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Joshua

Joshua 1:1

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:1–5

Moses led the Israelite people through the wilderness for forty years. At the end of the book of Deuteronomy the people were almost ready to enter the land of Canaan, and Moses died. Here at the beginning of the book of Joshua, Yahweh put Joshua in command of the Israelites, and told him to lead them into Canaan. Yahweh promised to be with Joshua and to help him.

1:1a

Now after the death of His servant Moses,

- ¶ After Moses the servant of Yahweh died,
- ¶ Moses had recently died. He was a person who served Yahweh.

after the death of His servant Moses: The death of... Moses is described in Deuteronomy 34. The book of Joshua follows that story. This sentence is the opening words of a new book. Think about the natural way to begin a new book in your language. In some languages it may be better to begin with a main clause, for example:

Moses had recently died

His servant Moses: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as servant can also be translated as “slave.” It refers to someone who must obey the commands of a master. It is recommended that you use a term that indicates the lowly position of a slave or a servant.

In some languages it may be more natural to place Moses’ title His servant after his name, for example:

Moses, Yahweh’s servant

In some languages it may be more natural to use the verb “serve” instead of the noun servant, for example:

Moses, a man who served Yahweh

General Comment on 1:1a

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After Moses, Yahweh’s servant, died

Moses had recently died. He was a man who served Yahweh.

1:1b

the LORD spoke to Joshua son of Nun, Moses’ assistant, saying,

- Yahweh spoke to Nun’s son, Joshua, who had assisted Moses.
- Then Yahweh spoke to Joshua. Joshua’s father was Nun, and he was the person who helped Moses.

the LORD spoke to Joshua son of Nun: This is the first event of the book. If you used a main clause to translate 1:1a you may want to use a temporal phrase here, such as “at that time.”

Here is another way to translate this clause:

At that time Yahweh said to Joshua the son of Nun

the LORD: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates LORD is “Yahweh,” the personal name of God. See the notes in the Introduction on how to translate this term.

Joshua son of Nun: In some languages it may be more natural to say:

Joshua whose father was called Nun

Moses’ assistant: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as assistant comes from a verb that means “to be an attendant on” or “to wait on.” It is different from the Hebrew word translated as “servant” in 1:1a. This word was used when Joshua accompanied Moses up Mount Sinai (Exodus 24:13) where the BSB translated it as “attendant.” Joshua’s task was not that of a servant but of an assistant.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the person who helped Moses

Moses' aide (NIV)

Moses' helper (GNT)

Here are some ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh said to Joshua, Nun's son, who had been Moses' assistant

Yahweh spoke to Joshua. Joshua was the son of Nun, and he was the person who had helped Moses

Joshua 1:2

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:1–5

Moses led the Israelite people through the wilderness for forty years. At the end of the book of Deuteronomy the people were almost ready to enter the land of Canaan, and Moses died. Here at the beginning of the book of Joshua, Yahweh put Joshua in command of the Israelites, and told him to lead them into Canaan. Yahweh promised to be with Joshua and to help him.

1:2a

“Moses My servant is dead.

- Yahweh said: “Moses my servant is dead.
- Yahweh said: “Moses served me, but he has died.

Moses My servant is dead: You should translate the word servant the same way you did in 1:1a.

My: The word My refers to Yahweh. It was Yahweh who was speaking.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

My servant Moses is dead

Moses served me, and now he has died

1:2b

Now therefore arise, you and all these people, and cross over the Jordan

- Now, prepare to cross the Jordan River, you^(sing) and all these people.
- So now, get ready. You must lead all these Israelites across the Jordan River.

Now therefore arise: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as arise is more literally “get up.” It is an idiom that indicates the beginning of an action. For example:

get ready to cross the Jordan River (NIV)

you and all these people: The phrase you and all these people refers to Joshua and all the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Get ready to cross the Jordan River, you and all the people of Israel

You and all the Israelites must prepare to cross the Jordan River

Now get ready to lead all the Israel people across the Jordan River

cross over the Jordan: The clause cross over the Jordan is a command to cross the Jordan River. The Israelites were on the east side of the Jordan River, and the land of Canaan was on the west side. The river is referred to as the Jordan because it was close to the place where Joshua was.

1:2c

into the land that I am giving to the children of Israel.

- Enter the land which I am giving to them, the people of Israel.
- Go into the land I am giving to all of you.

into the land that I am giving to the children of Israel: In some languages it may be clearer to start a new sentence here. For example:

Go into the land

to the children of Israel: The phrase to the children of Israel is used for emphasis. It emphasizes that Yahweh was giving the land of Canaan to the children of Israel to live in. Joshua was a part of the people of Israel. In some languages it may be clearer to include Joshua in this phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to you^(plur) the people of Israel

to you^(sing) and the people of Israel

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Enter the land that I am giving to you and to all the Israelites

Go into the land which I am giving to all of you

You must go into the land that I am giving to all the Israel people

Joshua 1:3

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:1–5

Moses led the Israelite people through the wilderness for forty years. At the end of the book of Deuteronomy the people were almost ready to enter the land of Canaan, and Moses died. Here at the beginning of the book of Joshua, Yahweh put Joshua in command of the Israelites, and told him to lead them into Canaan. Yahweh promised to be with Joshua and to help him.

1:3a

I have given you every place where the sole of your foot will tread,

- I have given you^(plur) everywhere that you place your feet,
- Everywhere that you walk/tread I have given to you.

I have given you: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as I have given you.

1. Some English versions translate with the past tense. For example:

I have given to you (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NASB, KJV, REB, GNT, NLT)

1. Some English versions translate with the future tense. For example:

I will give you (NIV) (NIV, NJB, NCV, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Israelites had not yet entered Canaan, but because Yahweh promised it, it was as certain as if they were already there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I have given you^(plur) everywhere that you^(plur) place your feet

Every place where you walk I have given to you

every place where the sole of your foot will tread:

The phrase every place where the sole of your foot will tread indicates that Yahweh will give the Israelites every part of the land that they walk on.

your: The Hebrew pronouns in this verse are plural: “your^(plur) feet,” and “given to you^(plur).” Yahweh spoke to all the people of Israel.

1:3b

just as I promised to Moses.

- as I promised Moses.
- This was the promise I made to Moses.

I promised to Moses: Yahweh promised Moses that he would give the land of Canaan to the Israelites in Exodus 3:8. He repeated this promise in Deuteronomy 11:24

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

just as I promised Moses

I promise you what I promised to Moses (NLT)

Joshua 1:4

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:1–5

Moses led the Israelite people through the wilderness for forty years. At the end of the book of Deuteronomy the people were almost ready to enter the land of Canaan, and Moses died. Here at the beginning of the book of Joshua, Yahweh put Joshua in command of the Israelites, and told him to lead them into Canaan. Yahweh promised to be with Joshua and to help him.

1:4a

Your territory shall extend from the wilderness and Lebanon

- Your land will extend from the desert in the south to the Lebanon mountains in the north.
- Your borders will reach from the wilderness in the south to the mountains of Lebanon in the north.

In verse 1:4 Yahweh described the four sides of the land that he was giving to the Israelite people: the south and the north, the east and the west.

from the wilderness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to the dry area in the south of the land of Canaan. Because it was dry, few people lived there, and it was difficult to grow crops there.

Here are some other ways to translate the word wilderness:

desert

deserted place

dry land

and Lebanon: The word Lebanon refers to a range of mountains at the north end of the land that Yahweh gave to the Israelites. These mountains had snow on them all year long, and the word Lebanon means “white” in Semitic languages. The country of Lebanon did not yet exist at this time.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

Lebanon Mountains (GNT)

Lebanon mountain range

Lebanon: The Hebrew is literally “the Lebanon,” which is difficult to understand. The mountains of Lebanon were a long way from where the Israelites were. Possibly it means “over there”, but no English version translates it that way. Many versions omit it, and you may do the same.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse.

Your land will extend from the wilderness in the south to the mountains of Lebanon in the north.

Your borders will reach from the desert in the south to the Lebanon Mountains in the north (GNT)

1:4b

to the great River Euphrates—all the land of the Hittites—

- It will extend from the great river Euphrates in the east, and across all the land that belongs to the Heth people.
- Your borders will extend to the great Euphrates River in the east and include all the land of the people of Heth.

to the great River Euphrates: The River Euphrates was on the east side of the land that God gave to the Israelites. The phrase the great River describes the Euphrates River. The Euphrates River was very wide.

all the land of the Hittites: The term Hittites refers to one of groups of people who lived in the land of Canaan. The phrase all the land of the Hittites is another way to refer to the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It will extend from the great Euphrates River in the east, across the land that belongs to the Hittites

Your borders will reach from the great river Euphrates in the east and include all the land of the Hitti people

1:4c

and west as far as the Great Sea.

- It will go to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.
- Your borders will extend to the Mediterranean Sea on the west where the sun sets.

and west: The phrase and west refers to the west. The Mediterranean Sea was the western boundary of the land that Israel received.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Your land will reach to the Mediterranean Sea in the west

to the Mediterranean Sea where the sun sets

as far as the Great Sea: The term the Great Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

General Comment on 1:4

In some languages it may be clearer to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

Your land will reach from the Negeb wilderness in the south to the Lebanon mountains in the north. It will reach from the great Euphrates River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west. It will include all the land of the Hittites.

Joshua 1:5

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:1–5

Moses led the Israelite people through the wilderness for forty years. At the end of the book of Deuteronomy the people were almost ready to enter the land of Canaan, and Moses died. Here at the beginning of the book of Joshua, Yahweh put Joshua in command of the Israelites, and told him to lead them into Canaan. Yahweh promised to be with Joshua and to help him.

1:5a

No one shall stand against you all the days of your life.

- No enemy will be able to defeat you^(sing) as long as you live.
- Nobody will be able to stand against you all your life.

No one shall stand against you: The expression stand against means “resist” or “oppose.” Yahweh told Joshua that no enemy would be able to defeat him.

you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as you is singular, and refers to Joshua.

all the days of your life: The phrase all the days of your life indicates for as long as Joshua lived.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

No one will succeed in fighting with you^(sing) all your life

No one will be able to defeat you as long as you live (GNT)

1:5b

As I was with Moses, so will I be with you;

- I will be with you^(sing) as I was with Moses.
- I helped Moses, and I will help you.

As I was with Moses, so will I be with you: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I will be with you in the same way that I was with Moses

I will help you as I helped Moses

1:5c

I will never leave you nor forsake you.

- I will not leave you or abandon you.
- I will always be with you. I will never leave you.

I will never leave you nor forsake you: The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as leave and forsake are close in meaning. The use of two verbs shows emphasis in Hebrew. In some languages the use of two synonymous verbs may not show emphasis. It might be unnatural or confusing to use two words that mean the same thing. If this is true in your language, you could use only one word but add an intensifier, for example:

I will never fail you

I will definitely not abandon you

You could also use two expressions with the same meaning, one positive and one negative. For example:

I will always be with you; I will never abandon you
(GNT)

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse.

I will not leave you or forget you (NCV)

Joshua 1:6

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:6–9

God encouraged Joshua to be brave and to be faithful to the law.

1:6a

Be strong and courageous,

- ¶ Be strong and do not be afraid.
- ¶ Be determined and confident.

Be strong and courageous: The phrases Be strong and [be] courageous have a similar meaning. The use of these two synonyms shows emphasis in Hebrew. In some languages it may be unnatural or confusing to use two words that mean the same thing. If this is true in your language, you could use one word and add an intensifier, for example:

be very brave

You could also use two words with the same meaning, one positive and one negative. For example:

be strong and do not be afraid

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Be determined and confident (GNT)

Be very courageous

1:6b

for you shall give these people the inheritance of the land

- You will lead these people so that they inherit the land
- You must lead these people so they can take the land.

for: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why Joshua must be brave. He must be brave because he was going to lead the Israelites into Canaan.

you shall give these people the inheritance of the land:

The clause you shall give these people the inheritance of the land means that Joshua will lead the Israelites to take the land that Yahweh will give them. Usually, a person does not inherit something until someone has died. In the book of Joshua, Yahweh gave the land of Canaan as an inheritance to the Israelites. The word inheritance means that the Israelites took possession of the land. Some languages may not use the word inheritance in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because you will lead them so that they inherit the land

You must lead these people so they can take the land (NCV)

because you will help these people take possession of the land (GW)

you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as you is emphatic. In English we might express this as:

it is you who will cause this people to inherit the land

If you have emphatic pronouns in your language, you may be able to use one here.

1:6c

that I swore to their fathers I would give them.

- that I promised their/your fathers that I will give them.
- This is the land which I vowed to give to their/your ancestors.

that I swore: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as swore can also be translated as:

vowed

promised

to their fathers I would give them: The word fathers refers to the ancestors of the Israelites, that is, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. Yahweh promised Abraham, Isaac and Jacob that he would give them the land of Canaan. See, for example, Genesis 13:14–15. These people were also the ancestors of Joshua. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the phrase to their fathers as “to your fathers.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

that I promised their/your fathers that I would give them

which I vowed to give to their/your ancestors

I promised their fathers that I would give them this land (ERV)

Joshua 1:7

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:6–9

God encouraged Joshua to be brave and to be faithful to the law.

1:7a

Above all, be strong and very courageous.

- Be strong and do not be afraid.
- Be determined and very confident.

Above all, be strong and very courageous: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as be strong and [be] very courageous are the same as those translated “be strong” and “[be] courageous” in 1:6a. You should translate them the same way in both places.

Above all: The phrase Above all makes the command stronger.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you must be strong and very courageous

very: There is a textual issue with this part of the verse.

1. The Hebrew text includes the word very (BSB, RSV, NIV, NET, REB, GW, NJPS, NASB, NLT, KJV)
2. The Septuagint, the early Greek translation, does not have the word very (GNT, NCV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow the Hebrew text and include a word that means very.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must be strong and very courageous

Be determined and very brave

1:7b

Be careful to observe all the law that My servant Moses commanded you.

- You must carefully keep all the commandments which my servant Moses commanded you.
- Be careful to obey all the instructions that Moses who served me gave you.

Be careful to observe all the law: The clause Be careful to observe indicates that Joshua must follow all the law.

all the law: The phrase all the law refers to the laws and commandments that Yahweh gave to Moses to pass on to the Israelites.

that My servant Moses commanded you: Yahweh referred to Moses as My servant in verse 1:2a, and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must carefully keep all the commandments that my servant Moses commanded you

Be sure to follow all the laws that Moses, my servant, told you to do

1:7c

Do not turn from it to the right or to the left,

- Do not stop obeying any of them,
- Follow them exactly.

Do not turn from it to the right or to the left: The phrase Do not turn from it means that Joshua must not disobey the law.

The phrase to the right or to the left is an idiom. It indicates that Joshua must not disobey the law in any way. He must carefully follow every part of the law.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Do not stop obeying any of the law

follow them exactly (NCV)

Do not walk away from any of these laws

1:7d

so that you may prosper wherever you go.

- in order that you will be successful wherever you go.

- Then it will go well with you in everything you do.

so that you may prosper wherever you go: This clause indicates that if Joshua obeyed all the laws, he would prosper wherever he went. However, this means more than “wherever he traveled.” It also means that he would be successful in everything he did.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so that you will succeed wherever you go

Then you will be successful in everything you do (NCV)

then everything will go well with you wherever you go

Joshua 1:8**Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua**

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:6–9

God encouraged Joshua to be brave and to be faithful to the law.

1:8a

This Book of the Law must not depart from your mouth;

- Never stop reading this book of the law.
- Always remember what is written in this law book.

This Book of the Law: The phrase This Book of the Law refers to “all the law” in 1:7b.

must not depart from your mouth: The clause must not depart from your mouth means that Joshua should always think about the law of Yahweh. He could do this by reading it and speaking it out loud.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Never stop reading this Book of the Law. (NIRV)

Always remember what is written in this law book

Do not stop reciting these laws

1:8b

meditate on it day and night,

- Think about what it says all day and all night.
- Say it over to yourself in the day and in the night.

meditate on it: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as meditate can also be translated as “mutter,” or “read in a low voice.” This was a way to keep thinking about something.

day and night: The phrase day and night means always or all the time.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Day and night you must think about what it says (NIRV)

Never stop reciting these teachings (GW)

Study it day and night (NCV)

1:8c

so that you may be careful to do everything written in it.

- Then you will be able to do everything written in it.
- Obey everything that it says.

so that you may be careful to do everything written in it: The clause be careful to do everything written in it indicates that Joshua must obey all the laws that Moses wrote down.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Make sure you do everything written in it (NIRV)

Carefully follow every law that Moses wrote

1:8d

For then you will prosper and succeed in all you do.

- Then you will be prosperous, and you will have great success.
- If you do that then it will go well with you and you will succeed.

For then you will prosper and succeed in all you do:

The Hebrew verbs that the BSB translates as will prosper and succeed are similar in meaning. In some languages there may not be two words with such similar meanings. In that case it may be more natural to translate this as “very successful”, or “very prosperous.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then things will go well with you. And you will have great success. (NIRV)

Only then will you prosper and succeed (GW)

If you do that, you will be successful in everything that you do (T4T)

Joshua 1:9

Section 1:1–9 Yahweh spoke to Joshua

In this section Yahweh commanded Joshua to lead the Israelites into the land that he had promised them. He told Joshua that no enemy would be able to oppose him, and that he must obey the law which Yahweh gave to Moses. Joshua told the Israelites to prepare to cross the Jordan River.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Yahweh told Joshua to be strong and courageous

Yahweh told Joshua to lead the people across the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:6–9

God encouraged Joshua to be brave and to be faithful to the law.

1:9a

Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous?

- I have commanded you to be strong and not to be afraid.
- Remember that I told you to be determined and confident.

Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a strong statement and emphasizes a fact that is true.

There are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a question, as the BSB does.
- Use a strong statement. For example:

I have commanded you, be strong and courageous (GW)

I repeat, be strong and brave (NET)

Remember that I have commanded you to be determined and confident (GNT)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to express a strong statement.

be strong and courageous: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as be strong and courageous are the same as in verse 1:6a. You should translate them the same way in both places. Yahweh commanded Joshua “be strong and courageous” in 1:6a and 1:7a, and he repeated the command here.

1:9b

Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged,

- Do not be afraid, but be brave.
- Do not be at all afraid.

Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged: These two negative commands have the same meaning as the positive commands in 1:9a. This is a way to emphasize those commands. The command Do not be afraid has the same meaning as the command do not be discouraged. In some languages it may not be natural to use two verbs that have the same meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Do not be at all frightened

Do not be frightened, but be brave

1:9c

for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.”

- Yahweh your^(sing) God, will be with you wherever you go.”
- I, Yahweh the God whom you worship, will go with you in everything you do.”

for the LORD your God is with you: The phrase the LORD your God is another way to refer to Yahweh. The word for God is added to the personal name of Yahweh. This title for Yahweh indicates that Yahweh is the God whom Joshua worships.

As it is Yahweh who is speaking, another way to translate this is:

I, Yahweh your God, am with you^(sing)

is with you: This refers to the time when Yahweh was talking to Joshua. It is also a promise for the future. You could translate this “will be with you” if that would be more natural in your language.

you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translate as you is singular. It refers to Joshua.

wherever you go: The phrase wherever you go is the same phrase as is used at the end of verse 7d.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I, Yahweh your God, am with you in all you do (NET)

I am Yahweh your God. I will be with you everywhere you go

Joshua 1:10

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:10–11

Joshua told the Israelites that they will soon cross the Jordan River. They must get food ready to take with them.

1:10

Then Joshua commanded the officers of the people:

- ¶ Then Joshua ordered the leaders of the people of Israel:

- ¶ So Joshua summoned the leaders of the Israelites and told them

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is used to show that the next action in the story will take place. Use a connection that is appropriate in your language for the beginning of a new section.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

And

So

Joshua commanded the officers of the people: In some languages it may be necessary to say that Joshua summoned the officers before he spoke to them.

officers of the people: The phrase officers of the people refers to the leaders of each Israelite tribe. Choose a word that indicates a position of responsibility and leadership but not of command over all the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the leaders of the tribes of Israel

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Then Joshua commanded the leaders of the people of Israel (T4T)

Joshua ordered the tribal leaders (CEV)

Then Joshua called the leaders of the Israelites together and told them

Joshua 1:11

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:10–11

Joshua told the Israelites that they will soon cross the Jordan River. They must get food ready to take with them.

1:11a

“Go through the camp and tell the people,

- “Walk through the camp and give this order to the people.
- to go through the place where the tents were set up. They should order the people

Go through the camp and tell the people: This verse gives the content of the command that Joshua gave to the officers. It is in direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech. For example:

¹⁰Joshua commanded the officers of the people
¹¹to pass through the camp and command the people

the camp: The Israelites lived in tents. The word camp refers to the area where they set up their tents.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

walk all through the camping place and tell the people

walk by all the tents and order the people

go through the tent area and command the people

1:11b

‘Prepare your provisions,

- Say, ‘Make food ready for a journey.
- to prepare food to take with them.

Prepare your provisions: This clause is a speech within a speech. It continues to the end of the verse. Consider whether direct or indirect speech is more appropriate in your language.

provisions: The term provisions refers to food that the Israelites took with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Get your food supplies ready

Prepare food to take with you

1:11c

for within three days you will cross the Jordan

- The day after tomorrow you will cross the Jordan River,
- In three days they were going to cross the Jordan River

for: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why the Israelites had to get food ready. They were going to cross the Jordan River and conquer the land of Canaan.

within three days: The Israelites counted days inclusively. They began with the day from which they were counting.

Here is another way to translate the phrase within three days:

the day after tomorrow

you will cross the Jordan: The clause that the BSB translates as you will cross the Jordan indicates that the Israelites will cross the Jordan River. Joshua will cross the river with the people. In some languages it may be more natural to use “we^(incl)” instead of you.

the Jordan: See the note on 1:2b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Three days from now you will cross the Jordan River (NCV)

the day after tomorrow we^(incl) are going to cross the Jordan River

1:11d

to go in and take possession of the land that the LORD your God is giving you to possess.”

- to enter and conquer the land which Yahweh your^(plur) God is giving you as your own.”
- to enter and take over the land which Yahweh their God was giving them.

to go in and take possession: The clause go in and take possession states the reason why the Israelites were about to cross the Jordan River. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as take possession indicates that they would take the land to be their own.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

to occupy the land

to conquer the land

the land that the LORD your God is giving you to possess: The clause the land that the LORD your God is giving you to possess indicates that Yahweh is giving them the land to be their own. It will belong to them.

your: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as your is plural. Joshua and the leaders were included in those who worshiped God. In some languages it may be more natural to say “our^(incl) God” instead of “your God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in order to occupy the land that Yahweh your God is giving to you as your own

and take the land that Yahweh our^(incl) God is giving us to live in

General Comment on 1:11b-d

In some languages it is more natural to put the reason for an action (1:11c-d) before the action itself (1:11b). For example:

^{11c}The day after tomorrow you will cross the Jordan River ^{11d}to conquer the land which Yahweh your God is giving you. ^{11b}So get ready food to take with you.

Joshua 1:12

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:12–15

The tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh already chose land on the east side of the Jordan River. In this paragraph Joshua reminded the men of these tribes about what they promised Moses. They promised to help the other Israelites conquer the land on the west of the Jordan River. When they had done this, they could return to their own territory.

1:12

But to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, Joshua said,

- ¶ Then Joshua spoke to the people of the clans of Reuben and Gad and half the clan of Manasseh and said:
- ¶ But Joshua said this to the clan of Reuben, the clan of Gad and the half-clan of Manasseh:

But to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh, Joshua said: In verses 1:10–11 Joshua spoke to the leaders of the people of Israel. In verses 1:12–15 he spoke to just two and a half of the tribes. The Hebrew text shows this contrast by putting to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh at the beginning of the sentence. Use the connection and sentence order that is most natural in your language.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: This refers to the people of the tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh. They already received their territory on the east side of the Jordan. See Numbers 32.

tribe: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as tribe can also be translated “branch” or “clan.” The Israelites were divided into twelve tribes. Each tribe was named after one of the sons of Jacob. The people in the tribe were descendants of that ancestor. Choose a word for a group of people who are descended from a common ancestor. See also the note at Joshua 7:14 where “tribe” and “clan” are used in the same verse.

Here are some other ways to translate the word tribe:

clan

branch

division

descendants

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Then Joshua spoke to the tribes of Reuben and Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh

Joshua said to the descendants of Reuben, the descendants of Gad, and half of the descendants of Manasseh

Joshua 1:13

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:12–15

The tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh already chose land on the east side of the Jordan River. In this paragraph Joshua reminded the men of these tribes about what they promised Moses. They promised to help the other Israelites conquer the land on the west of the Jordan River. When they had done this, they could return to their own territory.

1:13a

“Remember what Moses the servant of the LORD commanded you when he said,

- “Do not forget^(plur) what Moses, Yahweh’s servant, commanded you.
- “You know the command that Moses, the servant of Yahweh, gave you.

Remember: The verb Remember does not imply that the Israelites had forgotten Moses’ command. Joshua reminded them of something they already knew.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

You know

Do not forget

what Moses the servant of the LORD commanded you: The term what does not refer to a single word. It refers to all that Moses said to the Reubenites, the Gadites and half of the tribe of Manasseh when they asked for land to settle on the east side of the Jordan.

Moses the servant of the LORD: See the note on 1:1a for other ways to translate a similar phrase. Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Remember the command which Moses, Yahweh's servant, gave you

Do not forget what Moses, Yahweh's servant, told you

Remember how the Lord's servant Moses told you (GNT)

when he said: The phrase when he said introduces what Moses said. This is direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to report what Moses said using indirect speech.

1:13b

'The LORD your God will give you rest, and He will give you this land.'

- He said, 'Yahweh your^(plur) God will make you secure by giving you this land to settle in.'
- He told you that Yahweh your God will give you this land where you may live in safety.

The LORD your God will give you rest: The sentence The LORD your God will give you rest indicates that Yahweh will give them a permanent place to live. It will be a place where they can live safely.

and He will give you this land: The clause give you this land further explains the clause "give you rest." The "rest" that Yahweh will give them is the land they are about to enter. It may be more natural to combine the two expressions, for example:

Yahweh your God will provide this land for you, where you may live in safety

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Moses said, 'Yahweh your God is giving you this land. It will be a place where you can make your homes and find rest.'

Moses said, 'Yahweh your God will provide this land for you, a place where you may live in safety.'

Moses told you that the Lord your God would give you this land on the east side of the Jordan as your home. (GNT)

Joshua 1:14

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:12–15

The tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh already chose land on the east side of the Jordan River. In this paragraph Joshua reminded the men of these tribes about what they promised Moses. They promised to help the other Israelites conquer the land on the west of the Jordan River. When they had done this, they could return to their own territory.

1:14a

Your wives, your young children, and your livestock may remain in the land that Moses gave you on this side of the Jordan.

- Your^(plur) wives, children and livestock may stay here in the land which Moses gave you on this side of the Jordan River.
- Moses gave you this land east of the Jordan River. Your wives, children and animals may stay here.

and your livestock: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as livestock refers to cows and also to sheep and goats. Use a general word for domestic animals.

may remain in the land that Moses gave you: Joshua gave permission to the men of the two and a half tribes to let their families stay in the land east of the Jordan River. The men must cross the Jordan River to help the other Israelites.

on this side of the Jordan: The phrase on this side of the Jordan refers to the east side of the Jordan River. Joshua spoke as if he were already on the west side of the Jordan.

Here are some ways to translate this part of the verse:

Your wives, your children and your livestock may stay in the land that Moses gave you here on the east side of the Jordan River

Your wives and children and animals can stay here in the land Moses gave you (CEV)

Moses gave you this land east of the Jordan River. Your wives, children and animals may stay here

1:14b

But all your mighty men of valor must be armed for battle to cross over ahead of your brothers

- But all your^(plur) fighting men must lead your brothers across the Jordan, ready for fighting.
- But all the men who are able to fight should cross the Jordan River first, before the other Israelites. You should take your weapons with you.

But: This word marks a contrast between the men and their families. The fighting men went with the other tribes across the Jordan River to fight alongside them. Their families remained where they had settled on the east side of the Jordan.

all your mighty men of valor must be armed for battle to cross over ahead of your brothers: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as all your mighty men of valor must be armed for battle to cross over ahead of your brothers is more literally “but you shall cross over armed before your brothers, all the mighty men of strength.”

all your mighty men of valor: The phrase all your mighty men of valor refers to every Israelite man who was able to fight. The Israelites did not have a professional army. Every Israelite man who was over twenty years old and was fit to fight was considered a soldier. Avoid a term which will make your readers think that this refers to paid soldiers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the men who can fight

all the soldiers

all the fighting men

must be armed for battle to cross over: The phrase must be armed for battle to cross over indicates that the fighting men must cross the Jordan River carrying their weapons. They must be ready to fight.

ahead of your brothers: The phrase ahead of your brothers indicates that the fighting men of the tribes of Reuben and Gad and of half the tribe of Manasseh must cross the Jordan River in front of the other Israelites. All the Israelites were considered to be brothers, or relatives.

your fellow Israelites

your relatives

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But all your men who are able to fight must carry their weapons and cross the Jordan River in front of their fellow Israelites

but all your fighting men, ready for battle, must cross over ahead of your fellow Israelites (NIV)

But your strong warriors, fully armed, must lead the other tribes across the Jordan (NLT)

1:14c

and help them,

- You^(plur) will help them conquer the land.
- You will fight with them,

and help them: The clause help them indicates that the two and a half tribes must help the other Israelites to fight and conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must continue to help them fight

to help them conquer their territory. Stay with them (NLT)

Joshua 1:15

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:12–15

The tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh already chose land on the east side of the Jordan River. In this paragraph Joshua reminded the men of these tribes about what they promised Moses. They promised to help the other Israelites conquer the land on the west of the Jordan River. When they had done this, they could return to their own territory.

1:15a until the LORD gives them rest as He has done for you,

- Yahweh will make the peoples of Israel secure, as he made you^(plur) secure.
- until Yahweh gives your relatives a place to live as he has given one to you.

until the LORD gives them rest: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as gives them rest is the same verb as the BSB translated “give you rest” in 1:13b. You may be able to translate it the same way in both places.

as He has done for you: The phrase as He has done for you indicates that Yahweh will give a place of safety to the other Israelite tribes as he did for the two and a half tribes.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until Yahweh gives all the tribes of Israel a secure place to rest just as he did for you

until Yahweh gives your relatives a place to live as he gave one to you

1:15b and your brothers also possess the land that the LORD your God is giving them.

- When they have settled in the land which Yahweh your^(plur) God is giving them,
- After you have conquered the land that Yahweh your God is giving you,

and your brothers also possess the land: The clause and your brothers also possess the land indicates that the Israelite tribes will own the land. The phrase your brothers also is in an emphatic position in the Hebrew sentence. It emphasizes that the other Israelite tribes

will receive land just as surely as Gad, Reuben, and the half-tribe of Manasseh received it.

that the LORD your God is giving them: The phrase the LORD your God occurred in verse 1:9c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When they also have settled in the land that Yahweh your God is giving them

After they have conquered the land that Yahweh your God is giving them, just as you did

1:15c Then you may return to the land of your inheritance and take possession of

- then you^(plur) may come back to your land here and settle in it.
- you may come back to the land that you have settled in and live here.

Then you may return to the land of your inheritance: The phrase the land of your inheritance means their own land. It was the land that Moses gave them on the east side of the Jordan River.

and take possession of: The noun possession and the verb “possess” come from the same root in Hebrew. The Hebrew text uses both the noun and the verb to show emphasis. Some languages may not be able to show emphasis in this way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then you shall return to the land which you have settled and occupy it

then you can come back to your own land and live in it

1:15d that which Moses the servant of the LORD gave you on the east side of the Jordan.”

- This is the land which Moses, Yahweh’s servant, gave you^(plur) on the east side of the Jordan River.”
- Moses, the one who served Yahweh, gave you this land on the east bank of the Jordan River.”

that which Moses the servant of the LORD gave you: In Hebrew, the phrase used here for the servant of

the LORD is the same as the phrase used in 1:1a. You should translate it the same way in both places.

on the east side of the Jordan: The phrase on the east side of the Jordan indicates that the land which Moses gave them was on the east side of the Jordan River.

Some other ways to translate this part of the verse are:

It is the land here on the east side of the Jordan River, which Moses, Yahweh's servant, gave to you

Moses gave you this land on the east bank of the Jordan River

General Comment on 1:12–15

Verses 12–15 are similar to Deuteronomy 3:18–20. If you have already translated Deuteronomy, you should compare the similarities and differences so that similar words and phrases are translated in the same way.

Joshua 1:16

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:16–18

The tribes who lived on the east side of the Jordan River said that they will obey Joshua.

1:16a

So they answered Joshua,

- ¶ The people answered Joshua:
- ¶ Then the clans of Reuben and Gad and half the clan of Manasseh said to Joshua:

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB has translated as So introduces the next event in time. Another way to translate it is:

Then

Translate this connector in a way that is natural to introduce a consecutive event.

they answered Joshua: The word they refers to the people of Reuben and Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh. This list of names was last given in 1:12. It may be necessary in some languages to specify these names clearly. If you need to do this, you could either repeat the list or use an expression like “those people.” Use whatever is most natural in your language.

Joshua: In Hebrew, the name of a main character is repeated often. In some languages it will be more natural to use a pronoun after the first occurrence.

Here is another way to translate this name:

him

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people answered him

Then the men of the tribes of Reuben and Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh answered Joshua. They said

1:16b

“Everything you have commanded us we will do,

- “Whatever you^(sing) command us to do, we will do,
- “We will do everything that you have told us to do,

Everything you have commanded us we will do: The BSB translated this sentence following the Hebrew order. In Hebrew, the object is placed first for emphasis. Use whatever order is most natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Anything you command us to do, we will do (NCV)

We will do everything you have told us (GNT)

1:16c

and everywhere you send us we will go.

- and wherever you send us, we will go.
- and we will go anywhere you tell us to go.

and everywhere you send us we will go: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Any place you send us, we will go (NCV)

and will go anywhere you send us (GNT)

Joshua 1:17

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:16–18

The tribes who lived on the east side of the Jordan River said that they will obey Joshua.

1:17a

Just as we obeyed Moses in all things, so we will obey you.

- We^(excl) will obey you^(sing) in everything as we obeyed Moses.
- We obeyed everything Moses told us to do, and we will obey you too.

Just as we obeyed Moses in all things, so we will obey you: In some languages it may be more natural to reorder this part of the verse, for example:

We will obey you in everything, just as we used to obey Moses

Another way to translate this part of the verse is:

We did everything that Moses told us to do, and we will do everything you tell us to do

1:17b

And may the LORD your God be with you, as He was with Moses.

- May Yahweh your God be with you, as he was with Moses.
- We pray that Yahweh your God may help you, as he helped Moses.

And may the LORD your God be with you, as He was with Moses: These words have the form of a wish or a blessing.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

We pray/ask that Yahweh your God may help you, just as he helped Moses

Yahweh your God was always with Moses. May he always be with you too.

Joshua 1:18

Section 1:10–18 Joshua told the Israelites to get ready to cross the Jordan River

In this section Joshua told the Israelites to get ready and prepare food to cross the Jordan River. He reminded the men of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh that they would cross the Jordan River with the rest of the Israelites.

Here are some other possible sections headings:

Preparing to cross the Jordan River

Paragraph 1:16–18

The tribes who lived on the east side of the Jordan River said that they will obey Joshua.

1:18a

Anyone who rebels against your order and does not obey your words, all that you command him,

- If anyone opposes you^(sing) and does not obey your orders, no matter what you tell him to do,
- If anybody refuses to obey a single one of your commands,

Anyone who rebels against your order and does not obey your words: The clauses rebels against your order and does not obey your words use different words to express the same meaning. In some languages it will not be possible to find two expressions with similar meanings to use.

Anyone who rebels against your order: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as:

if anyone rebels against your commandment

rebels against: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rebels can also be translated as:

disobeys

opposes

all that you command him: The relative clause all that you command him gives extra emphasis. Find a way that is natural to give emphasis to the people's promise to obey Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

whoever refuses to obey your commands in any way

if anybody opposes your commands and disobeys what you tell them to do

1:18b

will be put to death.

- he must die.
- some of us^(excl) shall kill him.

will be put to death: This phrase is in the passive voice. Here are some other ways to translate it:

must die

some of us^(excl) will kill him

will be killed (ERV)

1:18c

Above all, be strong and courageous!”

- Be strong and do not be afraid.”
- Be determined and confident.”

Above all, be strong and courageous: The people encouraged Joshua to be strong. The words they used in Hebrew are identical to Yahweh’s word in 1:7a, except that the “very” in 1:7a (“very courageous”) is absent here. See the notes on 1:7a and 1:6a. You should use the same words for strong and courageous as you did in those verses.

Joshua 2:1

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:1a

Then Joshua son of Nun secretly sent two spies from Shittim, saying,

- ¶ Then Joshua son of Nun sent two men from Shittim where the Israelites were staying to go and explore the land secretly. He said to them:
- ¶ The Israelites were staying at Shittim Camp-ground. Joshua, the son of Nun, sent two men from there to go in secret and learn about the land. He told them:

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the narrative. This is the start of a new section, and some English versions start this section with the word “then.” Translate this in a way that is natural to introduce a new section in your language.

Joshua son of Nun: You should translate this the same way you did in 1:1b.

secretly sent two spies from Shittim, saying: In some languages, a literal translation would suggest that Joshua spoke to the two men after he sent them away. If this is true in your language, you need to make it clear that Joshua gave the orders to the men before they left.

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Joshua sent two men secretly from Shittim as spies. Before he sent them, he said

secretly: The term secretly means that the two men explored the land secretly. They did not want the Canaanites to know where they came from or what they were doing.

two spies: These two men were Israelites.

spies: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as spies comes from a verb that means “go as an explorer” or “go as a spy.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to explore secretly

to learn about the land of Canaan

to see where the land is weak

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua, the son of Nun, chose two men from the camp at Shittim to go in secret and explore the land. Before he sent them, he said,

The Israelites were staying at Shittim Campground. Joshua, the son of Nun, sent two men from there to go secretly and learn about the land. He told them,

from Shittim: Shittim was the place where the Israelites set up their tents on the east side of the Jordan River. This place is referred to in Numbers 25:1. It was northeast of the Dead Sea, opposite Jericho.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

while the Israelites were camping at Shittim

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Shittim means “acacia.” It is possible that there were several acacia trees in this area.^{2:1} Dallaire, p. 864. Some English versions use the name “Acacia” instead of the name Shittim. If you are familiar with acacia trees, you may choose to use that term instead of Shittim.

Shittim was the name of this area, but it was not a town or a village. If you must identify it you could call it “Shittim campground” or “Shittim region.”

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew word:

Acacia Grove (NLT)

Shittim campground/region

Acacia campground/region

2:1b

“Go, inspect the land, especially Jericho.”

- “Go^(dual) and look at the land and especially the city of Jericho.”

- “Go to the land of Canaan and learn about it. Look particularly at Jericho.”

Go, inspect the land: The clause Go, inspect the land indicates that the men must go to the land of Canaan and gather information about how to conquer it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Go through the land and find out about it

especially Jericho: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as especially Jericho is more literally “and Jericho.” Jericho was a town in Canaan that was across the river from the Israelite camp. It was the most important town in that region. There were many towns in Canaan. Joshua told the men to find out especially about this town because they would attack it first.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Go through the land and find out about it, especially the town of Jericho.

Go and look around the land, particularly Jericho.

2:1c

So they went and entered the house of a prostitute named Rahab and stayed there.

- Then they^(dual) left the camp at Shittim. When they arrived at the city of Jericho, they entered the house of a prostitute to stay there. Her name was Rahab.
- So, the men went to Jericho. They stayed for the night at the house of a prostitute named Rahab.

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in time.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

and

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural to introduce the next event in the narrative.

they went and entered the house of a prostitute named Rahab: Rahab’s house was in Jericho. It may be clearer to make explicit that they arrived in Jericho.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

They went to Jericho and entered the house of a prostitute whose name was Rahab

a prostitute named Rahab: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates literally as prostitute refers to someone who has sex with other people for money.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a prostitute. Her name was Rahab.

and stayed there: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as stayed there means “to lie down (to sleep).” The men intended to spend the night there, but they had to flee, and they left during the night.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they intended to stay there that night

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the men went to the town of Jericho. They entered the house of a prostitute whose name was Rahab. They planned to spend the night there.

So the men arrived at Jericho, and stayed at the house of a prostitute named Rahab

Joshua 2:2

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:2a

And it was reported to the king of Jericho:

- The king of Jericho received a report:
- While they were there, someone told the king of Jericho:

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the story.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

then

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural to introduce the next event in the narrative.

it was reported to the king of Jericho: We do not know who told the king of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

somebody told the king of Jericho

people told the king of Jericho

the king of Jericho: There were many towns in the land of Canaan at that time, and each town had its own king.

2:2b

“Behold, some men of Israel have come here tonight to spy out the land.”

- “Listen, some Israelite men came here tonight to spy on this land.”
- “Tonight, men from Israel have come into Jericho. They have come to find out things about our land.”

Behold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Behold introduces something that is surprising or unexpected. Some English versions do not translate this word. Some languages may have a grammatical marker which shows this information.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

look

listen

take note

some men of Israel have come here tonight: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as some men of Israel is more literally “men of the sons of Israel.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

some Israelite men have come to our town tonight

men from Israel are in our town tonight

to spy out the land: The clause to spy out the land means that the men planned to explore the land to find out information about it.

the land: As in 2:1b, the men were spying on the land of Canaan. It may be helpful to say “our land” or “this land” to make it clear that Jericho was part of the land they referred to.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to spy on our land

They want to find out things about this land.

Joshua 2:3

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:3a

So the king of Jericho sent to Rahab and said,

- Then the king of Jericho sent some of his soldiers to Rahab.
- The king of Jericho sent men to Rahab,

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the story line. Use a connection that is natural in your language.

the king of Jericho: In some languages it is not natural to repeat the phrase the king of Jericho as it has just been used in 2:2a. If this is true in your language, you could say “the king” or “he.”

sent to Rahab: In some languages it is clearer to make it explicit that the king sent some of his people. These are the same people who later searched for the spies along the road to the Jordan river. See 2:7a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the king of Jericho sent soldiers/messengers to Rahab.

Then the king sent some people to Rahab

and said: The words and said introduce the direct quotation that follows.

2:3b

“Bring out the men who came to you and entered your house,

- They said to her: “Bring out the men who entered your house,
- saying: “Make the people who went into your house come out.

Bring out the men who came to you and entered your house: The clause Bring out the men who came to you indicates that Rahab must make the men come out of her house.

Here are some other ways to translate this direct quotation:

Bring out the men who have come to you and gone into your house.

Make the men who went into your house come out.

In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation.

They told her to bring out the men who had entered her house.

2:3c for they have come to spy out the whole land.”

- because they have come to spy on all this land.”
- They have come here and intend to learn about all our land.”

for: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *for* introduces the reason why Rahab should bring out the two men. She should hand them over because they had come to spy out the country.

they have come to spy out the whole land: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as *spy out* was also used in 2:2b. You should translate it in the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because they have come to spy on our land

because they have come to find out things about the land

General Comment on verse 3b-c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder parts 3b and 3c so that the reason for the command comes before the command itself. For example:

The men in your house have come to spy out the whole country! Bring them out!” (GNT)

Joshua 2:4

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days.

When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:4a

But the woman had taken the two men and hidden them.

- But Rahab already took the two men and hid them.
- Before the soldiers got there, Rahab helped the two men to hide.

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* is usually used to indicate the next event in a narrative. However, Rahab hid the two men before the soldiers came to her. 2:4 Boling and Wright, p 145–146; Woudstra, p. 70. The BSB translates this conjunction as *But* to show that something unexpected happened. Choose a connecting word which sounds natural for this situation.

the woman had taken the two men and hidden them:

The context of the story shows that Rahab hid the men before she spoke to the soldiers. English versions indicate this by using the pluperfect tense *had taken them*. Languages have various ways to indicate events that are not reported in order. Translate this clause in a way that is natural for events that are not reported in order.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Before the soldiers arrived, the woman hid the two men

The woman had already hidden the two men before she spoke to the king’s messengers

2:4b

So she said,

- Then she said to the soldiers:

- So she answered them:

So she said: Rahab replied to the people that the king had sent.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

So she answered them,

2:4c

“Yes, the men did come to me, but I did not know where they had come from.”

- “It is true, some men came to me. I did not know where they came from.
- “You are right that some people came to my house. I don’t know where they were from.

Yes, the men did come to me: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

It is true that the men came to me

That’s right. The men did come to my house.

but I did not know where they had come from: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as where they had come from is more literally “but I did not know from where they were.”

Here is another way to translate this part of the phrase:

but I didn’t know where they were from (NLT)

Joshua 2:5

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:5a

At dusk, when the gate was about to close, the men went out,

- Before the city gate was closed this evening, the men went out of the city.
- At sunset, at the time when the gatekeeper was about to shut the gate, they left Jericho.

At dusk: The phrase At dusk refers to the time when the sun had just set and the sky was becoming dark.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

at sundown (GNT)

at dark (RSV)

when the gate was about to close: Jericho was a town surrounded by a wall. The word gate refers to the door in the wall through which people entered and left the town. It was closed at night to make the town more secure. The clause when the gate was about to close indicates that the gate was not yet closed.

the men went out: Rahab said that the men left through the town gate before it was closed for the night.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The men went out of the town just before it was time to close the town gate.

In the evening, when it was time to close the city gate, the men left (ERV)

2:5b

and I do not know which way they went.

- But I do not know where they went.
- They did not tell me where they were going.

and I do not know which way they went: Some English versions use an unusual English word order here in order to show the emphasis that is in the Hebrew word order. The BSB uses a natural English word order. Use a word order that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

where the men went I do not know (RSV)

I didn't find out where they were going (GNT)

They did not tell me where they were going

2:5c

Pursue them quickly, and you may catch them!"

- If you^(plur) chase after them quickly, you may catch them."
- Run after them quickly so that you can overtake them."

Pursue them quickly, and you may catch them: The command Pursue them quickly indicates that the soldiers should hurry to follow the two Israelite men.

and: the Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and shows a result. If the men chase the Israelite spies, the result will be that they may catch up with them. In some languages it may be more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. For example,

Go after them quickly. You may catch up with them. (NIV)

you may catch them: There is an interpretation issue with the form of the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as you may catch them.

1. It is a possible event. For example:

you can overtake them (NRSV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NKJV, NJPS, REB, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT)

1. It is a future event. For example:

you will catch up with them (GW) (GW, RSV, NJB, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with many English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Run after them quickly so that you can overtake them.

If you go quickly, maybe you can catch them.
(NCV)

go quickly and search for them! Perhaps you may catch them! (T4T)

Joshua 2:6

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:6a

(But Rahab had taken them up to the roof

- But she had already taken the two Israelites up to the roof.
- However, earlier she took the two men up to the flat roof of her house.

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But expresses a contrast between what Rahab said

and what she had done. Use whatever word is natural in your language to show this contrast.

Rahab had taken them up to the roof: The clause Rahab had taken them up to the roof indicates that Rahab had already led the men to the roof before she spoke to the soldiers.

up to the roof: The phrase up to the roof refers to the roof of Rahab's house. Houses in this area had flat roofs. It was possible for the men to be on the roof without falling off.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But she had already led them up to the flat roof of her house

Rahab said this, but really she had taken the men up to the roof (ERV)

2:6b

and hidden them among the stalks of flax that she had laid out there.)

- She hid them under the stalks of flax which she laid out there.
- She hid them under the flax plants that were drying on the roof.

and hidden them among the stalks of flax: The clause hidden them among the stalks of flax indicates that Rahab hid the men underneath the stalks of flax.

flax: The word flax refers to a plant that grows in tall stalks. People use the fibers from the stalks to make thread. They weave this thread into linen cloth.

The type of stalks that Rahab used is not the important thing in this verse. In areas where flax is not known, a general word like “stalk” or “plant” may be used in the translation.

that she had laid out there: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as laid out there can also be translated “arrange” or “lay out.” Rahab laid out the flax stalks on the roof to dry.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

she had hidden them underneath the stalks of flax which she had laid out on the roof

she had hidden them under the plants that were drying on the roof

General Comment on 2:4–6

Verse 2:6 gives a fuller version of the events of 2:4a. In some languages it may be clearer to put these events in chronological order.

Here is a way to translate these verses in chronological order:

^{4a} ^{6a} Before the soldiers arrived, Rahab took the two Israelites up to the roof of her house ^{6b}and hid them under the stalks of flax which she had laid out there. ^{4b}She said to the soldiers, ^{4c}“It is true, these men came to me, but I did not know where they came from. ^{5a}At sunset, when the town gate was about to be closed, they left. ^{5b}I do not know where they were going. ^{5c}If you chase them quickly, you may overtake them.”

Joshua 2:7

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph: 2:1–7

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho and they entered the house of Rahab. The king of Jericho sent soldiers to arrest them, but Rahab protected the two men. She hid the spies and told the soldiers that they had already left.

2:7a

So the king's men set out in pursuit of the spies along the road to the fords of the Jordan,

- So, the men went after the Israelites along the road to the ford across the Jordan River.

- The soldiers searched for the Israelite men to the place where people could cross the Jordan River, but they did not find them.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So is used to emphasize that the focus is on the soldiers and what they did. It can also be translated “as for the men.” Some English versions leave this conjunction untranslated, for example:

The king’s men pursued them (GW)

Choose a connection that is natural in your language.

the king’s men set out in pursuit of the spies: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as the king’s men set out in pursuit of the spies does not follow the normal Hebrew word order. In Hebrew the verb usually comes first. In this sentence the subject comes first. This emphasizes the change of subject, from Rahab to the king’s soldiers.^{2:7} Williams p. 96 paragraph 573.

the king’s men: The phrase the king’s men refers to the same men who came to Rahab’s house. These men were first mentioned in verse 2:3a. How you translate the phrase the king’s men will depend on the implied information that you supplied in that verse.

set out in pursuit of the spies: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as set out in pursuit can also be translated as “chased” or “looked for.”

the spies: The phrase the spies refers to the two Israelite men. The king’s men believed Rahab’s report that the Israelite men had already left Jericho.

along the road to the fords of the Jordan: The phrase along the road to the fords of the Jordan indicates the road that led to the Jordan River.

the fords of the Jordan: The fords are a place in a river where the water is shallow and people can walk across.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

crossing-place

the place where people can cross the river

It may be helpful to add the implicit information “but they did not find them.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As for the king’s men, they chased after the Israelites until they reached the fords of the Jordan River

The soldiers ran after the two Israelite men as far as the place where they could cross the Jordan River but they did not find them

2:7b

and as soon as they had gone out, the gate was shut.

- As soon as the men went out of Jericho, the city gate was shut.
- Immediately after the soldiers left the city, the gatekeeper shut the city gate.

and as soon as: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as soon as is more literally “after when.” Verse 5a said that the men left just at the time when the gate was closed at dusk. The two actions happened quickly one after the other.

they had gone out: The pronoun they refers to the king’s men who chased the Israelites. The phrase had gone out indicates that these soldiers left Jericho.

the gate was shut: See the note on 2:5a.

General Comment on 2:7

The events in this verse are not told in order. In some languages it may be more natural to reorder this verse. For example:

^{7b} The soldiers went out of Jericho, and immediately people closed the town gate. ^{7a} The soldiers pursued the two Israelites along the road as far as the fords over the Jordan River.

Joshua 2:8

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:8–11

Rahab told the spies that the news about the Israelites had made her people afraid. She believed that the God of Israel would help the Israelites to conquer the land.

2:8

In this verse the storyline changes back to what the two Israelite spies did. This action takes place at approximately the same time as the action in the previous verse. While the soldiers were searching for the Israelite spies along the road to the Jordan River, the spies were getting ready to sleep on the roof of Rahab's house.

2:8a

Before the spies lay down for the night,

- ¶ As for the Israelite men, before they lay down to sleep,
- ¶ Meanwhile, before the two men went to sleep that night

Before the spies lay down for the night: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Before the spies lay down is more literally “and they, before they lay down.” The Hebrew conjunction together with the emphatic pronoun indicates a change of subject, from the king's men back to the Israelite men. Some languages have a grammatical marker which indicates a change of subject.

lay down for the night: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as lay down indicates that the men were lying down to go to sleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As for the Israelite men, before they lay down to sleep

Meanwhile, before the two men went to sleep that night

2:8b

Rahab went up on the roof

- Rahab went to them on the roof.
- Rahab went up on the roof to see them.

Rahab went up on the roof: The name Rahab refers to Rahab. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Rahab went up to them again on the roof

Rahab went up on the roof to talk with them (NLT)

Joshua 2:9

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:8–11

Rahab told the spies that the news about the Israelites had made her people afraid. She believed that the God of Israel would help the Israelites to conquer the land.

2:9a

and said to them,

- She said to them:
- She told the men:

and said to them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

She said to them,

She told them,

2:9b**“I know that the LORD has given you this land**

- “I know that Yahweh has given our^(excl) land to you^(plur) Israelites.
- “I know that Yahweh is giving this land to you Israelite people.

I know that the LORD has given you this land: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as has given is in the perfect aspect. The perfect aspect expresses a completed action. Rahab said that the land already belonged to the Israelites, because Yahweh will give it to them. It is as if the action had already been done. Many English versions translate the Hebrew perfect aspect with a present perfect tense to show this. If this is not natural in your language, you can translate the verb using a future tense.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I know the Lord is handing this land over to you (NET)

I know that Yahweh is giving you^(plur) this land

I know that Yahweh will give our land to you Israelites

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the Israelites.

this land: The phrase this land refers to the land of Canaan.

2:9c**and that the fear of you has fallen on us,**

- You Israelites frighten us.
- We are very afraid of you.

and that the fear of you has fallen on us: The clause the fear of you has fallen on us is an idiom which means “we are afraid of you.”

you: The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as you is plural. It refers to all the Israelite people, not only to the two spies.

us: The pronoun us refers to Rahab and the people of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and that we^(excl) are very afraid of you^(plur)

Everyone in the country is terrified of you (GNT)

2:9d**so that all who dwell in the land are melting in fear of you.**

- In fact, all the inhabitants of this land tremble when they see you.
- All of us in the land are terrified of you.

so that all who dwell in the land are melting in

fear of you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as melting can also be translated “shake.” This is an idiom which means that the Canaanites were afraid of the Israelites. Many languages have idioms to express the idea of fear. These may be used here and in 2:9c.

in fear of you: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as in fear of you indicate that the people of the land were afraid of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Everyone who lives in this country is terrified of you

All the people of this land shake with fear because of you

General Comment on 2:9c-d

In some languages it is not natural to use two parallel expressions as the Hebrew text does. If that is true in your language, you could combine these two phrases into one phrase that expresses strong fear, as the GNT does:

Everyone in the country is terrified of you. (GNT)

Joshua 2:10**Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly**

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:8–11

Rahab told the spies that the news about the Israelites had made her people afraid. She believed that the God of Israel would help the Israelites to conquer the land.

2:10a

For we have heard how the LORD dried up the waters of the Red Sea before you when you came out of Egypt,

- We^(excl) have heard how Yahweh dried up the water of the Red Sea in front of you^(plur) and you crossed it to leave Egypt.
- We are frightened because we heard about how you left Egypt. We heard how Yahweh moved the water of the Red Sea to make a dry path for you.

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For introduces the reason why the Canaanites were afraid of the Israelites. Use the appropriate connecting word in your language. It may be clearer to supply some implicit information. For example:

We^(excl) are afraid because

we have heard how the LORD dried up the waters of the Red Sea before you: The sentence the LORD dried up the waters of the Red Sea before you refers to events described in Exodus 14. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit why Yahweh dried up the Red Sea, that is, so that the Israelites could cross it. If it is necessary to make this explicit you could say:

we have heard how Yahweh dried up the water of the Red Sea in front of you so that you could cross it

Red Sea: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as Red Sea are literally “sea of reeds.” The translation Red Sea comes from the Septuagint translation into Greek. This body of water is not the same as what is known as the Red Sea today. If you use the term Red Sea, you should consider adding a footnote. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The Hebrew phrase is literally “Sea of Reeds.” It refers to the lake that the Israelites had to cross when they left Egypt. See Exodus 14.

The term Red Sea occurs several times in Exodus. See, for example, Exodus 10:19.

you: The Hebrew inflection that the BSB translates as you is plural and refers to the people of Israel.

when you came out of Egypt: The whole story of what happened when the Israelites left Egypt is told in Exodus 12–14.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

For we have heard how the Lord made a dry path for you through the Red Sea when you left Egypt (NLT)

We are afraid because we heard that Yahweh made the Red Sea dry up in front of you so that you could cross it when you left Egypt

2:10b

and what you did to Sihon and Og, the two kings of the Amorites across the Jordan, whom you devoted to destruction.

- And we have heard what you did to King Sihon and King Og, the two kings of the Amorites who lived on the other side of the Jordan River. You completely destroyed them.
- We have heard how you killed King Sihon and King Og, the two Amorite kings. They ruled east of the Jordan River.

and what you did: This is the middle of a long sentence. In some languages it may be helpful to start a new sentence here. For example:

We have also heard what you did

to Sihon and Og, the two kings of the Amorites: The Amorites were nations on the east side of the Jordan River. The story of how the Israelites conquered their kings is told in Numbers 21:21–35.

to Sihon and Og: Sihon and Og are the two kings of the Amorites.

across the Jordan: The phrase across the Jordan refers to the east side of the Jordan River.

whom you devoted to destruction: This phrase describes what the Israelites did to King Sihon and King Og.

devoted to destruction: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as devoted to destruction means that something was dedicated to Yahweh and could not be used. It must be destroyed or given to Yahweh as an offering. In this context it indicates that they killed the two Amorite kings. This event is described in Numbers 21:21–35 and is retold in Deuteronomy 2:24–3:11.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

completely destroyed

killed

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We heard what you did when you killed King Sihon and King Og, the two Amorite kings who ruled east of the Jordan River

We know what you did to Sihon and Og, the two Amorite kings east of the Jordan River. You destroyed them.

Joshua 2:11

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:8–11

Rahab told the spies that the news about the Israelites had made her people afraid. She believed that the God of Israel would help the Israelites to conquer the land.

2:11a

When we heard this,

- When we^(excl) heard it
- We heard about that

When we heard this: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates When we heard this is more literally “and we heard.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When we heard that news

We heard about that

2:11b

our hearts melted

- our hearts shook with fear.
- and we were terribly afraid.

our hearts melted: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as melted is a different verb from the one used in verse 2:9d. It can also be translated “dissolve.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that they were very afraid.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Our hearts shook with fear

We were very afraid

2:11c

and everyone's courage failed because of you,

- Everyone lost courage because of you^(plur).
- None of us was brave at all, because we were frightened of you.

and everyone's courage failed: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as everyone's courage failed is more literally “there no longer arose breath in a man.” It is a Hebrew idiom. It means that they were very afraid of the Israelites.

In some languages it is not possible to use two phrases with such similar meanings. If this is true in your language, you could combine 2:11b-c and say, “we were very afraid.”

because of you: The phrase because of you indicates the reason for the fear. The people of Canaan were very afraid of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

There was no spirit left in us on account of what we had heard about you.

Everyone's courage disappeared because of what you had done.

2:11d

for the LORD your God is God in the heavens above and on the earth below.

- Because it is Yahweh your^(plur) God who is God in heaven above and on earth below.
- For Yahweh, your God, is the only God. He rules in heaven and on earth.

for: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why the Canaanites were frightened. They were frightened because of Yahweh.

the LORD your God: The Hebrew uses the name of God, Yahweh. The phrase your God indicates that he was the God of the Israelites.

is God in the heavens above and on the earth below:

The Hebrew sentence is more literally “for Yahweh your God, he is God in the heavens above and on the earth beneath.” The pronoun “he” emphasizes that it is Yahweh alone who is God over both heaven and earth. Use a natural way to show this emphasis.

in the heavens above: In some languages it will not be natural to say both in the heavens and above. If this is so in your language, you can say “in heaven.”

on the earth below: If it is not natural to translate both on the earth and below, you can translate this as “on earth.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because it is Yahweh your God who is God and rules over heaven and the earth

Yahweh your God is the only God. He rules over heaven above and over the earth below

Joshua 2:12

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:12–14

Rahab asked the spies to spare her and her family. The spies promised to do this if she helped them escape.

2:12a

Now therefore, please swear to me by the LORD

- ¶ So now swear^(dual) an oath to me in the name of Yahweh.
- ¶ Therefore promise me, and ask Yahweh to punish you if you do not keep this promise.

Now therefore: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now therefore can also be translated “so” or “then.” It shows that Rahab's request was urgent. It is not a time word.2:12 Bratcher p. 30. Choose an appropriate way to express this in your language.

please swear to me: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as swear can also be translated “promise.” It is used here in the sense of taking an oath. This verb is also used in 1:6c where God is the one who swore. In this verse the two Israelite men are the ones who swear.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

promise^(dual)

make an oath

pledge

by the LORD: The phrase by the LORD indicates that the person makes an oath or promise in the name of Yahweh. He says that he expects Yahweh to punish him if he does not keep his promise.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So now take an oath in the name of Yahweh

Therefore, promise me by the name of Yahweh

So, promise me, and may Yahweh punish you if you do not keep the promise.

2:12b

that you will indeed show kindness to my family,

- you will show kindness to the family of my father.
- Now you must be faithful to me and my whole family.

you will indeed show kindness: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as you will indeed show kindness is more literally “and you will do, also you, *hesed*.” The emphatic pronoun emphasizes that the Israelites should show loyalty to her as she has done to them. Use a term or grammatical marker that is natural to show this emphasis in your language.

The expression show kindness uses the same Hebrew word *hesed* as in 12c. You should translate it the same way in both places.

to my family: The phrase to my family refers to Rahab and her family.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

you in turn will show loyalty to my family (NJPS)

You yourselves will also treat my family kindly

You will act as faithfully to my family as I have acted faithfully to you

2:12c

because I showed kindness to you.

- Swear that because I have shown kindness to you.
- I have been faithful to you.

because I showed kindness to you: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I showed kindness to you is more literally “I have done *hesed* with you.” The Hebrew word *hesed* is a key biblical term. It means that one is loyal to a covenant relationship. It includes the meanings of faithfulness and loyalty. Consider what is the most appropriate word in your language in this context.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Since I have shown loyalty to you (NJPS)

Because I have treated you kindly

Because I have acted faithfully with you

2:12d

Give me a sure sign

- Give me a sign that I can trust.
- Do something so that I may be sure that you will do what you have promised.

Give me a sure sign: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as a sure sign is more literally “a sign of faithfulness.”

Here are some ways to translate this expression:

give me a sign that I can trust

do something so that I can be certain that you will do what you promised

Joshua 2:13

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:12–14

Rahab asked the spies to spare her and her family. The spies promised to do this if she helped them escape.

2:13a

that you will spare the lives of my father and mother, my brothers and sisters, and all who belong to them,

- I want to know that you^(dual) will allow me to live, with my father and mother, my brothers and sisters, and their families.
- Save the lives of my family and my parents, and the families of my brothers and sisters.

that you will spare the lives: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as spare the lives can also be translated “let live.” Rahab asked the two Israelites to promise that no one would kill her family when the Israelites conquered Jericho.

of my father and mother, my brothers and sisters, and all who belong to them: The phrase all who belong to them indicates the families of Rahab’s brothers and sisters as well as her own immediate family.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Let my father and mother, my brothers and sisters and all their families live

Save the lives of my whole family

2:13b

and that you will deliver us from death.”

- Do not let anyone kill us^(excl).”
- Do not kill us.”

and that you will deliver us from death: Rahab asked the Israelites not to kill her or her family. Rahab makes the same request two times, using different words, to emphasize the importance of her request.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

save us from death

do not let your people kill us

Joshua 2:14

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:12–14

Rahab asked the spies to spare her and her family. The spies promised to do this if she helped them escape.

2:14a

“Our lives for your lives!”

- “We^{(dual)(excl)} offer our own lives as a guarantee for your lives,”
- “We will give up our lives to protect your lives,”

The Hebrew conjunction that some English versions translate as “And” indicates the next event in the story. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language to indicate this. Some English versions, like the BSB, do not translate this connecting word.

Our lives for your lives: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Our lives for your lives is more literally “Our lives instead of you^(plur) to die.” The two spies promised to protect Rahab and her family even if it means that they must die themselves.2:14 Dallaire p. 869; Woudstra p. 74.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We offer our own lives as a guarantee for your safety (NLT)

We^{(dual)(excl)} will give our lives to protect your lives

2:14b

the men agreed.

- the men said:
- the two men answered her.

the men agreed: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the two men answered her

The men told her

2:14c

“If you do not report our mission,

- “But you^(plur) must not talk about our plans to anyone.
- “But you must not tell anyone what we have been doing.

If: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *if* introduces the condition on which the Israelites will keep Rahab’s family safe.

you do not report: The Hebrew inflection that the BSB translates as *you* is second person plural. It refers to Rahab and her family.

our mission: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *mission* can refer to any kind of matter or happening. In this context it refers to the men’s exploring the land so that the Israelites could attack it.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If you do not tell anyone what we have been doing
(GNT)

If you do not tell anyone about this matter of ours

2:14d

we will show you kindness and faithfulness when the LORD gives us the land.”

- If you do that, we will treat you^(sing) with kindness and faithfulness when Yahweh gives us this land.”
- Then we will be loyal and true to you when Yahweh helps us take this land.”

This verse part starts with a Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated. This conjunction introduces result. It explains what the men promised to do if Rahab did what they asked her to do. (They asked her

not to tell anybody about them). One way to translate this transition would be as the RSV does:

Then (RSV)

we will show you kindness and faithfulness: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as *we will show you kindness and faithfulness* is more literally, “we will do with you loyalty and faithfulness.” This phrase describes acts that are done because people have made a covenant, or agreement, between each other. For example, it is used in Genesis 24:27.2:14 Woudstra p. 74.

The term *kindness* translates the Hebrew word *hesed* that was used in verse 2:12 (12b and 12c). You should translate it the same way in each place. The term *faithfulness* indicates that the two men would be trustworthy in their relationship with Rahab.

you: The pronoun *you* is singular. The men referred only to Rahab.

when the LORD gives us the land: The clause *when the LORD gives us the land* refers to the time when Yahweh will help the Israelites to conquer the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then we^(excl) will act with kindness and faithfulness towards you^(sing) when Yahweh gives us this land.

We will be loyal and true to you when Yahweh helps us to take over the land.

Joshua 2:15

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:15a

Then Rahab let them down by a rope through the window,

- ¶ Then she lowered them from the window with a rope.
- ¶ Then she put a rope through the window and the two men climbed down the rope to the ground.

Then: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the story. Choose a connecting word that is appropriate in your language.

Rahab let them down by a rope through the window: The sentence Rahab let them down by a rope through the window indicates that Rahab tied a rope to the outer window of her house. The two men climbed down the rope to the ground.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

She lowered the two men by a rope through her window

Then she put a rope through the window and they climbed down the rope

2:15b

since the house where she lived was built into the wall of the city.

- This was possible because her house was built into the city wall, so that she lived within its walls.
- She could do this because she lived in a house that was built as part of the wall around the city.

since: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as since introduces an explanation of why Rahab was able to help the spies escape. She could help them because her house was built into the town wall. Her window opened onto the area outside the town.

the house where she lived was built into the wall of the city: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the house where she lived was built into the wall

of the city is more literally “her house was in the wall of the town wall.” It indicates that one of the walls of Rahab’s house formed a part of the wall that surrounded the town.

the house...was built into the wall of the city: Archaeological research shows that at one time Jericho had two town walls. There was a space between the walls and people could build their houses using the two walls.2:15 Boling and Wright, p. 148. The sentence the house ...was built into the wall of the city indicates that Rahab’s house was built between the inner and outer town wall.

A literal translation of the house where she lived was built into the wall of the city may not make any sense in many languages. It may be necessary to combine the two clauses in this part of the verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

she lived in a house that was a part of the town wall

the house where she lived was built using the town wall

General Comment on 2:15

In some languages it may be clearer to describe Rahab’s house first, and then say that she lowered the spies down. For example,

Her house was built as part of the town wall, so she let them down by a rope through the window.

Joshua 2:16

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:16a

“Go to the hill country,”

- “Go^(dual) up into the hills,”
- “Go hide in the mountains.”

2:16b

she said,

- she said to them before the men went down,
- she told them as they were leaving.

2:16a-b

The Hebrew conjunction commonly translated as “and” (which the BSB does not translate here) usually indicates the next consecutive action in the story. However, the events portrayed in verses 16–21 are not presented in chronological order. 2:16 Hess, p. 102; Coleson, p. 51; Bratcher, p. 33. It is likely that Rahab spoke to the men before they went through the window.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Rahab told them

Before they went down she said to the men

Go to the hill country: There were not very many people living in these hills, so it would be a good place for the spies to hide.

hill country: In English we distinguish between low hills, and high hills which we call “mountains.” Hebrew has only one word that refers to both hills and mountains. The high places west of Jericho that the BSB refers to as hill country were up to about 600 meters high. Choose a word in your language that is appropriate for hills of this height.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Go to the mountains

Go up to the hilly places

2:16c

“so that your pursuers will not find you.”

- “so that the people who chase you cannot find you.
- “Do not let them catch you.

your pursuers will not find you: See the note on “set out in pursuit” in 2:7a.

Here is another way to translate the word pursuers:

the men who are looking for you

will not find you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as find can also be translated “encounter,” or “happen upon.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so that the people looking for you will not find you

so that the king’s men who chase after you will not catch you

2:16d

Hide yourselves there for three days

- Hide there for three days,
- Hide in the mountains for three days.

Hide yourselves there for three days: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Hide there for three days

Hide in the hills for three days

2:16e

until they have returned;

- until the people who chase you have returned here.
- After three days, the men looking for you will give up the search and return here.

until they have returned: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until the people who are looking for you turn back

until the ones chasing you have come back here

2:16f

then go on your way.”

- After that you will be able to go home.”

- Then it will be safe for you to go where you want.”

then go on your way: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After that you can go back to your camp

Then you may go where you want

Joshua 2:17

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:17a

The men said to her,

- The men said to her:
- And the men told her:

The men said to her: The Hebrew has a word that the BSB does not translate. It indicates that this is the next event in the storyline.

2:17b

“We will not be bound by this oath you made us swear

- “We^{(dual)(excl)} will be free from keeping the promise that you^(sing) asked us to give if you don’t do these things.

- “If you do not do what we say we will be released from the oath you made us take.

We will not be bound by this oath: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as not...bound can also be translated “free,” “innocent,” or “exempt from.” The men told Rahab the conditions on which they would keep the promise they had made. If Rahab did not follow what they said in verses 18–20, they would not have to keep their promise to protect her.

this oath: The phrase this oath refers to the promise that the two spies made in 2:14 to protect Rahab and her family.

you made us swear: The clause you made us swear refers to Rahab’s action in verse 2:12. She asked the men to promise that they would keep her family safe.

There is some implied information. The condition on which the Israelites will be released from their promise is missing.

For example:

We will be bound by the oath we have taken only if you follow these instructions (NLT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

we^(excl) will be free from keeping the promise that you asked us to give if you do not do this

if you do not do what we say we will be released from the oath we have taken

Joshua 2:18

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:18a

unless, when we enter the land,

- When we^{(plur)(excl)} come back to this land,
- When our people come to invade your land,

The Hebrew word that begins this verse is usually translated as “Behold” and calls attention to the next statement. Languages have a variety of ways to direct the listener’s attention to the next statement. Some languages may have a word that has this function. In other languages it may be better to use a sentence. For example:

This is what you must do. (GNT)

In some English versions, including the BSB, this Hebrew word is omitted, but the implicit information from verse 17b is included here instead. For example:

unless you do what we say (NIRV)

when we enter the land: The spies spoke about the time when they will return with their army to invade the land. You may need to make this explicit, for example:

when our^(excl) people come to invade the land

the land: The phrase the land indicates the land of Canaan where Jericho was. If this is not clear you can say:

this land

your land

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

when we attack this land

when we Israelites invade your land

2:18b

you have tied this scarlet cord in the window through which you let us down,

- tie^(sing) this red rope to the window where you are letting us down.
- you must tie this red rope in the window. Tie it so that we can see it in the window you let us down from.

you have tied this scarlet cord: The clause you have tied this scarlet cord is a command. It indicates that Rahab must tie a length of red cord, or rope, to the window.

It is not clear whether the men gave Rahab the rope, or whether it was a rope that Rahab already had in her house. 2:18 Hess, p. 103–104; Bratcher, p. 34.

scarlet: The term scarlet is another word for red.

in the window through which you let us down: The clause in the window through which you let us down indicates that Rahab must tie the red rope so that it can be seen in the window that the men climb through.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

you must tie this red rope so that we can see it
in the window where you let us down

tie this red rope in the window that you let us
down from

2:18c

and unless you have brought your father and mother and brothers and all your family into your house.

- Then assemble your^(sing) father, your mother, your brothers, and all your father’s family into your house.
- You must bring your father, your mother, your brothers, and everyone in your father’s family into the house with you.

and unless you have brought your father and mother and brothers and all your family into your house: The BSB has reversed the order of the parts of the Hebrew sentence. The Hebrew is more literally, “and your father and your mother and your brothers and all the house of your father you shall gather to you, to the house.” This is a way of emphasizing the members of Rahab’s family.

In verse 13a, the phrase “my father and mother, my brothers and sisters, and all who belong to them” is used. In this verse Rahab’s sisters are not mentioned. However, this does not mean that they are no longer included. If this is likely to be misunderstood, you may wish to include the word “sisters” in this verse.

all your family: The phrase all your family refers to Rahab’s family, including her brothers and sisters and their families. In verse 13a this group of people was referred to as “all who belong to them.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must bring your father, your mother, your brothers and all who belong to your father’s household into the house with you

All your family members must come inside the house with you. Bring your father, your mother, your brothers, and all your relatives.

Joshua 2:19

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:19a

If anyone goes out the door of your house into the street,

- If anyone goes outside the doors of your^(sing) house,
- If anyone leaves your house and goes outside,

If anyone goes out the door of your house: The clause If anyone goes out the door of your house indicates that Rahab’s family must stay inside the house and not leave it. In some languages it may be more natural to omit the phrase the door.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

If any of them go outside your house (NIV)

into the street: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as into the street is more literally “outside.” If your translation of “out the door of your house” already contains the meaning “outside” you may not need to repeat it.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If any of them goes outside the house

Anyone who leaves your house (NET)

2:19b

his blood will be on his own head, and we will be innocent.

- his death will be his own responsibility. We will be innocent of his death.
- it will be his own fault if he gets killed. We will not be responsible for what happens.

his blood will be on his own head: This is an idiom. It means “his death will be his fault.” The spies said that if any of Rahab’s family does not obey their instructions, it will be that person’s fault when they die. It will not be the fault of the spies.

his blood: The term blood is a figure of speech. It refers to death. The pronoun his is masculine but in this context it refers to every member of Rahab’s family, the women as well as the men.

and we will be innocent: The term innocent is the same Hebrew word that was used in verse 17b (translated in the BSB as “not...bound”). If it is possible you should use the same term here as in verse 17b. If it is not natural to use the same term, here are some other ways to translate it:

we will be innocent of his death

we will not be responsible for his death

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

he will be responsible for his own death, and we will be innocent

If he dies it will be his own fault. We will not be guilty

2:19c

But if a hand is laid on anyone with you in the house,

- However, if our people harm anyone who is indoors with you,
- But, if anyone who remains with you in the house gets hurt,

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces a contrast. 2:19 Williams, p. 71 paragraph 433. Verse 19a-b explains what will happen to someone who leaves Rahab's house. Verse 19c-d explains what will happen to someone who stays in the house. Use a connecting word in your language that indicates this contrast.

if a hand is laid on anyone with you in the house:

The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as a hand is laid on indicates that someone gets hurt.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But if any one inside the house gets hurt

But if someone harms one of your family inside the house

2:19d

his blood will be on our heads.

- his death will be our responsibility.
- we will be responsible.

his blood will be on our heads: This indicates that the two spies will be responsible if Rahab's family dies. See the notes on verse 19b.

Joshua 2:20

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:20a

And if you report our mission,

- But if you^(sing) talk about our^{(dual)(excl)} matter to anybody,
- But if you tell anyone what we have been doing,

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces a contrast, so many English version translate it as "But." In verse 14c the Israelite spies gave the condition on which they will save the lives of Rahab and her family. In this verse they give the condition on which they will not save them. Use a word or a grammar marker which expresses this contrast in your language.

if you report our mission: The phrase if you report our mission uses the same Hebrew words that occurred in 2:14c except that the word "not" is not included. Translate this positive phrase the same way as you did in that verse, without using the negative.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

However, if you tell anyone what we have been doing (GNT)

but if you tell anyone about this matter of ours

2:20b

we will be released from the oath you made us swear.”

- we will be released from the oath you have made us take.”
- then we will be free from the promise which you asked us to make.”

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated introduces what will happen if Rahab tells people about them. In some languages it may be more natural to keep this word explicit by using a word like “then.”

we will be released from the oath you made us swear: This Hebrew phrase is the same as the phrase in verse 17b, except for one word. In verse 17b there is the emphatic pronoun “we.” In this verse the verb “we will be” occurs instead. The meaning is the same.

In both these verses the men give conditions on which they will not keep their promise. In the previous verse, they will not keep their promise if Rahab does not tie the red rope in the window. In this verse they will not keep their promise if Rahab tells anyone about what they were doing.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

we^{(dual)(excl)} will be free from keeping the promise that you^(sing) asked us to give

we will be released from the oath you made us take

Joshua 2:21

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:15–21

Rahab helped the spies escape. Before they left, they explained what she must do so that they can save her and her family.

2:21a

“Let it be as you say,”

- “I agree to do everything that you^(dual) have said,”
- “I will do what you say,”

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the story.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then

Let it be as you say: The clause Let it be as you say indicates that Rahab agreed to do what the men told her.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I agree to what you have said

I will do as you have said

2:21b

she replied,

- Rahab said.
- Rahab answered them.

2:21c

and she sent them away. And when they had gone,

- After that, she sent them^(dual) on their way, and they left her house.
- Then she said goodbye to them and they went down the rope and left.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates the next event in the story line.

she sent them away: The clause she sent them away indicates that Rahab told the men to go.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

she said goodbye to them

she took leave of them

And when they had gone: The clause they had gone indicates that the men left.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After that she told them to go on their way, and they left

Then she said goodbye to them and they went down the rope and left

2:21d

she tied the scarlet cord in the window.

- Then she tied the red rope in the window.
- After they left, Rahab tied the red rope to the window.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated indicates the next event in the story.

she tied the scarlet cord in the window: This states that Rahab tied the red rope in the window after the two men left.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then she tied the red rope in the window

When they had gone, she tied the red rope to the window

Joshua 2:22

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king's soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:22–24

The spies stayed in the hills for three days and then they returned to Joshua.

2:22a

So the spies went out into the hill country

- ¶ They left Jericho and they went up into the hills.
- ¶ When the spies left, they went to hide in the hills.

So the spies went out: The clause the spies went out repeats information from verse 21c. It refers to the same event.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When the two Israelites departed

After they left

into the hill country: The Israelite men followed the advice that Rahab gave them. They went to the hills that were west of the town of Jericho.

the hill country: See note on “hill country” at verse 2:16a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When they left, they went up into the hills

After they left the town they went up into the hills

2:22b

and stayed there three days,

- They stayed there for three days
- They hid there for three days

and stayed there three days: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They stayed there in the hilly country for three days.

They hid in the hills for three days.

2:22c

until their pursuers had returned without finding them,

- until the men who were looking for them went back to Jericho.
- until the soldiers gave up searching and returned home.

until their pursuers had returned: See the note on “set out in pursuit” in 2:7a. In some languages it is awkward to use a long phrase like “the men who were looking for them.” If this is the case in your language you can use some other phrase such as “the soldiers.” Be sure that your readers know that these are the people referred to in verse 16c.

had returned: The verb returned indicates that the pursuers went back to Jericho. In some languages it will be necessary to make that explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until the people who were looking for them had returned to Jericho

They waited until the soldiers had gone back to Jericho

without finding them: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as without finding them is more literally “but not they found.” It means that the king’s soldiers did not find them.

2:22d

having searched all along the road.

- Those people looked for them all along the road but did not find them.
- The soldiers looked for them on every road. But they did not find them.

having searched all along the road: The phrase searched all along the road means they searched for the two spies all along the roads that led back to the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Those people searched for them all along the road but did not find them

The king’s men looked for them on every road but did not find them

General Comment on 2:22b-d

The events in verse 22b-d are not told in the order that they occurred. In some languages it may be clearer to reorder these events.

Here is a way to reorder the events of this verse:

^{22b}The two Israelites stayed there three days.

^{22d}Meanwhile the men who were looking for them searched all along the road, but they did not find them. ^{22c}So they returned to Jericho.”

Joshua 2:23**Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly**

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:22–24

The spies stayed in the hills for three days and then they returned to Joshua.

2:23a

Then the two men started back, came down from the hill country,

- Then those two men came down from the hills.
- After three days, they came down from the hills where they hid

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the story.

the two men started back, came down from the hill country: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the two men started back, came down from the hill country is more literally “and the two men returned,

and they came down from the hills.” The phrase the two men refers to the Israelite spies.

from the hill country: It may be helpful to include the implicit information “where they were hiding.” For example:

they came down from the mountains where they hid

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the two Israelite men came back down from the hilly country

Then the two spies went down from the hills where they had been hiding

2:23b and crossed the river.

- They crossed the Jordan River,
- and crossed the river.

and crossed the river: That Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as crossed the river can also be translated “crossed.” On their way back to Joshua, the men had to cross the Jordan River. You may need to make the term Jordan River explicit in your translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they crossed the Jordan River

they crossed the river

2:23c So they came to Joshua son of Nun

- and went back to Joshua the son of Nun at the camp.
- They returned to the camp and went to see Joshua the son of Nun.

So they came to Joshua son of Nun: See the note about Joshua at verse 1:1b. It may be helpful to supply implicit information about the location.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They returned to the camp and went to see Joshua, the son of Nun

They came to Joshua the son of Nun at the Israelite camp

2:23d and reported all that had happened to them.

- Then they told Joshua about all that happened to them.
- They told him everything that they learned.

and reported all that had happened to them: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as all that had happened to them is more literally “all the things finding them.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It means “everything that had happened to them.” The word happened is an older way to say “happen.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They told him everything that had happened to them

They told him all the things that they had learned

Joshua 2:24

Section 2:1–24 Joshua sent men to explore Jericho secretly

Joshua sent two men to look at Jericho, a town in the land of Canaan. A woman of Jericho called Rahab hid the two men so that the king’s soldiers could not find them. She did this because she believed that Yahweh would help the Israelites conquer their land. The men promised Rahab that if she did not betray them, they would rescue her and her family when the Israelites conquered the town. Rahab helped the men escape from Jericho and they hid in the hills for three days. When the soldiers of Jericho stopped looking for them, they returned to Joshua.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The spies went to Jericho

The spies and Rahab

Rahab helped the spies

Paragraph 2:22–24

The spies stayed in the hills for three days and then they returned to Joshua.

2:24a

“The LORD has surely delivered the entire land into our hands,”

- “Certainly, Yahweh has given the whole land to us^(incl).”
- “It is true, Yahweh will give us the entire land.”

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event in the story.

In this part of the verse the two Israelite men use similar words to those that Rahab did in verse 2:9.

The LORD has surely delivered: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as has...delivered is in the perfect aspect. The perfect aspect expresses a completed action. They said that the land already belongs to the Israelites because Yahweh will give it to them. It is as if the action has already been done. The BSB translates the Hebrew perfect aspect with an English present perfect tense. If this is not natural in your language, you can translate the verb as a future tense. For example:

Yahweh will certainly hand over all this land to us

surely: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as surely indicates an emphatic assertion.

the entire land: The phrase the entire land refers to the entire land of Canaan.

into our hands: The phrase into our hands is a figure of speech. The words our hands indicates that the land will be under the control of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh has indeed given us power over all this land

Yahweh will certainly give us this land

2:24b

they said to Joshua.

- Then they said to him:
- They said to Joshua:

they said to Joshua: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then they said to him

They told Joshua

2:24c

“Indeed, all who dwell in the land are melting in fear of us.”

- “All the people of the land tremble when they see us.”
- “Indeed, everyone who lives in that land is terrified of us.”

Indeed: The Hebrew adverb that the BSB translates as Indeed is used for emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew adverb:

and also (ESV)

for (NLT)

Some English versions leave this adverb untranslated. For example:

all the people are melting in fear because of us (NIV)

all who dwell in the land: The phrase all who dwell in the land refers to the people who live in the land of Canaan.

are melting in fear: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as are melting in fear is the same Hebrew verb used in 2:9d. If possible, you should use the same expression here as you did there.

of us: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as of us is more literally “from before us.” It indicates that the people of Canaan were afraid of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Indeed, everyone who lives in this country is terrified of us.

All the people of this land even shake with fear because of us.

Joshua 3:1**Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River**

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the

river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:1–4

The Israelites left Shittim to go near the Jordan River, and set up camp there. Three days later they received instructions to set out and follow the ark, which was carried by the priests.

3:1a

Early the next morning Joshua got up and left Shittim with all the Israelites.

- ¶ The next day, early in the morning, Joshua and all the Israelites got up and left from Shittim where they had set up their tents.
- ¶ Early the next morning Joshua left Shittim. All the Israelites packed up their camp and went with him.

This is the beginning of a new story. It takes place the day after the spies returned from their trip to Jericho.3:1 Woudstra p. 79. In some languages it may be natural to start this new story with a phrase that sets the time, such as:

Early the next morning

The next day

Start this new episode in a way that is natural in your language.

Early the next morning Joshua got up: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Early the next morning...got up can also be translated as “make an early start” or “leave early in the morning.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The next morning Joshua got up early to leave

The next day Joshua left early in the morning

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates the next action in the story.

left Shittim with all the Israelites: The subject of the verb left is plural. It refers to all the Israelites. This is a characteristic of Hebrew narrative style. The first verb “rose” refers to Joshua and highlights his importance. The second verb “set out” indicates that all the Israelites participated in the action.

All the Israelites got up early and left along with Joshua. Some languages may need to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Joshua and all the people of Israel got up early in the morning and set out

Shittim: The term Shittim refers to the camping place that was mentioned in verse 2:1a. Translate it the same way you did there.

with all the Israelites: The BSB has moved the phrase with all the Israelites to this part of the verse because it makes more sense in English. In the Hebrew text this phrase is in verse 3:1b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua and all the people of Israel got up early in the morning to leave the camp. They set out from Shittim

The next day Joshua and all the Israelites got ready early and left Shittim Campground.

3:1b

They went as far as the Jordan,

- They came to the Jordan River,
- After leaving Shittim, they went to the Jordan River,

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event in the story.

went as far as the Jordan: The clause went as far as the Jordan indicates that Joshua and all the Israelites traveled to the Jordan River, which was approximately seven miles to the west.3:1 Dallaire p. 877.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and arrived at the Jordan River

They went west to the Jordan River

3:1c

where they camped

- and they stayed there
- and they set up their tents there for three days

where they camped: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as camped means that they set up their tents and stayed near the Jordan River. In v. 2 it says that they stayed there for three days. In some languages it may be more natural to repeat that as implied information in this verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they camped there

and they stayed near the Jordan River for three days

3:1d before crossing over.

- before they crossed the river.
- while they waited to cross the river.

before crossing over: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

before they crossed the Jordan River

Joshua 3:2

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:1–4

The Israelites left Shittim to go near the Jordan River, and set up camp there. Three days later they received instructions to set out and follow the ark, which was carried by the priests.

3:2

After three days the officers went through the camp

- After three days the leaders went through the camp
- After they stayed there two nights, the leaders of the clans of Israel went to everybody in the camp.

After three days: The Israelites counted days inclusively. The three days included the day that they arrived there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

After two nights

After three days had passed

the officers: The term officers refers to the leaders of each Israelite tribe. See how you translated this term in 1:10.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the leaders of the tribes of Israel

went through the camp: The clause went through the camp indicates that the leaders walked through the camp to communicate with all the people.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse

After three days, the officers walked around the camp

After two nights, the leaders of the Israel tribes went to everybody in the camp

Joshua 3:3

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:1–4

The Israelites left Shittim to go near the Jordan River, and set up camp there. Three days later they received instructions to set out and follow the ark, which was carried by the priests.

3:3a

and commanded the people:

- and told the people:
- They gave this order to the people:

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates the next event in the story.

commanded the people: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

they told the people

3:3b

“When you see the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God being carried by the Levitical priests,

- “When you^(plur) see the Levitical priests carrying the covenant box of Yahweh your God,
- “You will see the holy chest which shows that Yahweh our God is with us. The priests of the Levi clan will carry it ahead of us.

When you see the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as ark refers to a “box” or a “chest.”

The ark of the covenant was a box made of acacia wood and covered with gold (see Exodus 25:10–22). Inside the box were the stone tablets on which the Ten Commandments were written. It also contained a pot of manna and Aaron’s walking stick. On top of it were two gold winged creatures called “cherubim.” The box reminded the Israelites of the covenant that Yahweh made with them. It was a sign that Yahweh promised to be with them. When you translate this term, choose a short phrase that describes the box or explains its purpose.

If you have translated the New Testament, see how you translated ark of the covenant in Hebrews 9:4 or Revelation 11:19.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

covenant box

holy chest

box of God’s covenant

golden box

the ark of the covenant of the LORD your God: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the covenant box which shows that Yahweh your God is with you

covenant: A covenant is a formal agreement between two groups of people. God made a covenant with the people of Israel in which God and the people promised to be faithful to each other. See Genesis 17:1–21.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

agreement

promise

of the LORD your God: The phrase the LORD your God was used in Joshua 1:9c. See how you translated the phrase in that verse.

your God: Joshua was one of the Israelite people. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

Yahweh our God

being carried by the Levitical priests: Four priests worked together to carry the covenant box on poles that rested on their shoulders. If your language has several verbs for “carry” you should choose an appropriate one.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

which the Levitical priests carried on poles over their shoulders

Levitical priests: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Levitical priests is literally “the priests, the Levites.” The priests were descendants of Levi and belonged to the tribe of Levi. All the priests were Levites.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the priests, the Levites

the priests of the Levi tribe

If this implies that there are some priests who are not of the Levi tribe, it is possible to say “the priests” and put a literal translation in a footnote.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When you see the covenant box of Yahweh your God that the priests of the Levi tribe are carrying

You will see the Levites, the priests, carrying the golden box of Yahweh your God

priests: The priests were people who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. You should translate this term in the same way as in the New Testament. See, for example, Mark 1:44.

3:3c

you are to set out from your positions and follow it.

- set out from where you are and follow it.
- Then you should leave the place where you are camping and follow it.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “then” indicates the next thing that the Israelites must do.

you are to set out from your positions: The clause you are to set out from your positions is a command. The officers told the people to leave the place where they were camping, and to start walking.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

leave the place where you are camped

and follow it: The pronoun it refers to the covenant box.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and go behind the covenant box

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then you must start to walk from your camp and go behind it

Then you should leave your camping place and follow the covenant box

General Comment on 3:3b-c

The Hebrew sentence gives prominence to the covenant box, not to the priests. The people were told to follow the covenant box. If possible, translate this sentence in a way that gives prominence to the covenant box. For example:

When you see the covenant box and the priests who are carrying it, then you should follow the covenant box

Joshua 3:4

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:1–4

The Israelites left Shittim to go near the Jordan River, and set up camp there. Three days later they received instructions to set out and follow the ark, which was carried by the priests.

3:4a

But keep a distance of about two thousand cubits between yourselves and the ark.

- However, you must keep about half a mile between you and the covenant box.
- But make sure there is a space of about one kilometer between you and the holy chest.

But: The Hebrew adverb that the BSB translates as But indicates a restriction. It can also be translated as “however” or “but.”^{3:4 Williams p. 65 para 388.} The Israelites were told to follow behind the covenant box, but they must not get too close to it.

keep a distance of about two thousand cubits between yourselves and the ark: The clause keep a distance...between yourselves and the ark is a command. The officers told the people to walk a long way behind the covenant box.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you^(plur) must leave a distance between you and the covenant box

about two thousand cubits: A “cubit” is the length of the forearm, or about half a meter. Two thousand cubits is about one kilometer, or half a mile. Use the units of measurement most familiar in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

However, there must be about half a mile between you and the covenant box.

But you must stay about one kilometer away from the holy chest.

3:4b

Do not go near it,

- Do not go near it.
- Do not follow it too closely.

Do not go near it: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Do not follow it too closely

3:4c

so that you can see the way to go, since you have never traveled this way before.”

- Follow it so that you^(plur) will know where to go, because you have not walked on this path before.”
- You have never gone this way before, so the holy chest will show you which way to go.”

so that: The Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as so that indicates purpose. It can also be translated “in order that” or “that.”^{3:4 Williams p. 61 para 367.}

you can see the way to go: The clause you can see the way to go explains the purpose of following the covenant box. The box will lead the Israelites on the path they should take.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

so that you will know which path to go on

since: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as since indicates a reason. It can also be translated as “because.” The covenant box will show them the way because they have not gone on this path before.

you have never traveled this way before: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

you have never traveled along this path before

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of these clauses, as the GNT has done:

You have never been here before, so they will show you the way to go. (GNT)

General Comment on 3:4a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of these clauses. For example:

^{4b}But do not get near the Covenant Box; ^{4a}stay about half a mile behind it. (GNT)

Joshua 3:5

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:5

Joshua ordered the people to purify themselves.

3:5a

Then Joshua told the people,

- ¶ Then Joshua said to the people:
- ¶ Joshua told the Israelites:

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the story. This is the beginning of a new paragraph. Make sure your translation indicates that this is a new paragraph in the most natural way.

Joshua told the people: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua told the people

Then Joshua said to the Israelites

3:5b

“Consecrate yourselves,

- “Make yourselves holy,
- “Clean yourselves so that you may be pure in the eyes of Yahweh.

Consecrate yourselves: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Consecrate means that people should do a ritual that makes them pure and sets them apart to be holy for Yahweh. An example of what the people did is found in Exodus 19:10 where Yahweh told Moses that the people must wash their clothes. In Exodus 19:15 Moses told the people not to have sex.

We do not know what ritual the people did in this verse. It is best to translate this word in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

purify yourselves

make yourselves holy

prepare yourselves so that you will be pure

3:5c

for tomorrow the LORD will do wonders among you.”

- because Yahweh is going to do things that make you astonished tomorrow.”
- Tomorrow Yahweh will do some amazing things for us to see.”

for: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as for introduces the reason why the Israelites must purify themselves. It can also be translated as “because.” They should purify themselves because Yahweh will do something amazing among them tomorrow.

tomorrow the LORD will do wonders: The wonders are extraordinary things that amaze people. The wonders that Yahweh will do stop the water of the Jordan River from flowing.

among you: The phrase among you refers to Joshua as well as the Israelites. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

among us^(incl)

for us to see

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because tomorrow Yahweh will do an amazing thing among us

because tomorrow Yahweh will do something for you to see that makes you astonished

Joshua 3:6

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:6

Joshua told the priests to carry the covenant box and go ahead of the people. They did what Joshua told them to do.

3:6a

And he said to the priests,

- ¶ Then Joshua said to the priests:
- ¶ The next day, Joshua told the priests:

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the story.

he said to the priests: In verse 3:5 Joshua told the people that Yahweh will do wonders “tomorrow.” The events of verse 3:6 took place on the next day. It may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

The next day, Joshua said to the priests

3:6b

“Take the ark of the covenant

- “Lift up the covenant box,
- “Carry the holy chest on poles on your shoulders,

Take the ark of the covenant: The clause Take the ark of the covenant indicates that the priests were to put the covenant box on the carrying poles and carry it.

Some languages have a special verb to indicate this method of carrying.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Pick up the covenant box on poles on your shoulders

Lift the holy chest to carry it on poles on your shoulders

3:6c

and go on ahead of the people.”

- and carry it on poles on your shoulders ahead of the people.”
- and set out with the people following you.”

and: the Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates the next event in the story.

go on ahead of the people: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

go ahead of the people

walk in front of the people

3:6d

So they carried the ark of the covenant

- Then they lifted up the covenant box
- So the priests carried the holy chest on poles on their shoulders.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates the next event in the story.

they carried the ark of the covenant: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the priests carried the covenant box on poles on their shoulders

So the priests lifted the holy chest

3:6e

and went ahead of them.

- and went ahead of the people.
- They set out with the people following them.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates the next action in the story.

went ahead of them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the priests walked ahead of the people

the priests went leading the people

Joshua 3:7

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:7–8

Yahweh promised Joshua that the people will respect him. He also told Joshua what the priests should do.

3:7a

Now the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ Then Yahweh said to Joshua:
- ¶ Then Yahweh told Joshua:

This is the beginning of a new paragraph. Make sure your translation indicates this is a new paragraph in a natural way.

Now the LORD said to Joshua: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now indicates the next event in the story.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Yahweh said to Joshua,

Yahweh told Joshua,

3:7b

“Today I will begin to exalt you in the sight of all Israel,

- “Today I will begin to make you^(sing) great in the eyes of all the Israelites.
- “I will begin today to make all the people of Israel honor you.

Today: This can also be translated as Today.

I will begin to exalt you in the sight of all Israel:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as exalt is more literally “make great.” Yahweh said that he will make the Israelite people honor and respect Joshua. The clause I will begin to exalt you indicates that this

was the beginning of how Yahweh will make Joshua great. This will happen because Joshua will be the leader who takes them across the Jordan River.

in the sight of all Israel: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in the sight of all Israel is more literally “in the eyes of all Israel.” This indicates that all the Israelites will see that Joshua is great.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Today I will lift you up in the eyes of all the Israelites

Beginning from today, I will make all the Israel people think that you are great

What I do today will make all the people of Israel begin to honor you as a great man (GNT)

3:7c

so they may know that I am with you just as I was with Moses.

- They will know that I will be with you just as I was with Moses.
- Then they will know that I will be with you to help you in the same way that I was with Moses.

so: The Hebrew relative particle that the BSB translates as so indicates purpose. It can also be translated “so that.” Yahweh will make Joshua great so that the Israelites will know that Yahweh is with Joshua.

they may know that I am with you just as I was with Moses: The clause I am with you indicates that Yahweh is with Joshua to guide and help him. Yahweh gave this promise to Joshua in Joshua 1:5b. You should translate this clause the same way as you did in that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so that they will know that I will be with you in the same way that I was with Moses

then they will know that I will help you as I helped Moses

Joshua 3:8

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:7–8

Yahweh promised Joshua that the people will respect him. He also told Joshua what the priests should do.

3:8a

Command the priests carrying the ark of the covenant:

- You^(sing) must command the priests who are carrying the covenant box:
- Tell the priests who are carrying the holy chest

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “And” indicates the next action in the story.

Command: The Hebrew is literally “you shall command.” The pronoun “you” refers to Joshua. It is emphatic in Hebrew. Some English versions translate in such a way as to make this clear. For example:

You are the one who shall command the priests who bear the ark of the covenant (NRSV)

For your part, command the priests who carry the Ark of the Covenant as follows (NJPS)

the priests carrying the ark of the covenant: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests who carry the covenant box on poles on their shoulders

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It is you who will command the priests who are carrying the covenant box

You yourself must command the priests who carry the holy chest on poles on their shoulders

3:8b

‘When you reach the edge of the waters,

- ‘When you^(plur) come to the banks of the Jordan River,

- that when they reach the edge of the Jordan River,

When you reach the edge of the waters: The phrase the edge of the waters refers to the edge of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When you come to the edge of the Jordan River

When you arrive at the bank of the Jordan River

3:8c

stand in the Jordan.”

- stand still in the water.”
- they should enter the water and stand near the edge.”

stand in the Jordan: The clause stand in the Jordan is a command. Joshua told the priests to stand in the water.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

you must stand in the water by the edge of the river

The priests had to walk into the water before they stood still. In some languages it may be clearer to include this implicit information. For example:

When you reach the banks of the Jordan River, take a few steps into the river and stop there (NLT)

General Comment on 3:8a-c

This is a quotation contained within a quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation. For example:

You shall command the priests that when they get to the edge of the Jordan River, they should enter the water and stand still in it.

Joshua 3:9

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:9–13

Joshua told the people about the miracle that Yahweh will do.

3:9a**So Joshua told the Israelites,**

- ¶ Then Joshua said to the Israelites:
- ¶ Joshua told the Israelite people

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates the next action in the story. This is the beginning of a new paragraph. Make sure your translation indicates a new paragraph in a natural way.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Then

Joshua told the Israelites: In the previous paragraph Yahweh gave Joshua instructions about how to cross the Jordan River. In this paragraph Joshua passed these instructions on to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua said to the Israelites

Joshua told the Israelite people

3:9b**“Come here**

- “Come^(plur) here to me
- to come near

Come here: The clause Come here is a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Come^(plur) here to me

Come near me

3:9c**and listen to the words of the LORD your God.”**

- and listen to what Yahweh your God says.”
- and listen to the words of Yahweh their God.”

and listen to the words of the LORD your God: The clause listen to the words of the LORD your God is the second part of the command that Joshua gave to the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

and listen to what Yahweh your^(plur) God says

General Comment on 3:9a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation. For example:

Joshua told the people of Israel to come and hear the words of Yahweh their God.

Joshua 3:10**Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River**

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:9–13

Joshua told the people about the miracle that Yahweh will do.

3:10a**He continued, “This is how you will know that the living God is among you**

- Then Joshua said: “This is how you^(plur) will know that the living God is among you.
- When the people had come Joshua said: “This is what is going to happen. When it happens, you will know that the God who is alive is among you.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated and many English versions translate as “And” indicates the next action in the story.

He continued: There is some implied information here. In verse 9b Joshua told the people to “come here.” The people came, and then Joshua continued to speak.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

after the people had come Joshua said

the people came together and then Joshua said

This is how you will know: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as This is how is more literally “in this” or “by this.” It refers to what Joshua will say in 3:11–13.

that the living God: Joshua refers to Yahweh as the living God. This means that Yahweh is alive, and that he acts to help his people. The Israelites will know he is alive by the things he does.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the God who has life

the God who always lives

is among you: The phrase among you means that God was with the Israelites.

Joshua was also an Israelite. In some languages it may be better to say:

is among us^(incl)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After the people gathered, Joshua said to them, “By this you will know that the God who is alive is with you

When the people had come, Joshua told them, “This is how you will know that the God who has life is with us

3:10b

and that He will surely drive out before you the Canaanites, Hittites, Hivites, Perizzites, Girgashites, Amorites, and Jebusites.

- You will know that he will surely drive out the people of Canaan, Heth, Hiv, Periz, the Girgash, the Amor, and Jebus in front of you.
- You will know that, as you go forward, he will certainly force out the people of this land: the Canaan people, the Hitti people, the Hiw people, the Periz people, the Girgash people, the Amor people and the Yabus people.

and that He will surely drive out before you: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as He will surely drive out are more literally “drive out he will drive out.” This is a Hebrew idiom that indicates emphasis. Yahweh will certainly drive the Canaanites out of the land. He will take away the land from them and give it to the Israelites. Some languages have a grammatical marker or particle to indicate this emphasis.

before you: The phrase before you can also be translated “in front of you” or “ahead of you.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

as you go forward, he will certainly drive out...

Joshua was one of the Israelites. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

from before us^(incl)

the Canaanites, Hittites, Hivites, Perizzites, Girgashites, Amorites, and Jebusites: These seven groups of people lived in the land of Canaan. This list is the same as the list in Deuteronomy 7:1.

The suffix “ite” is an English suffix that means “people.” It does not come from Hebrew. The Hebrew name of these seven groups is similar to this:

Canaan people, Hitti people, Hiw people, Periz people, Girgash people, Amor people, Yabus people

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh will surely force these groups of people to leave from before you: the Canaan people, the Hitti people, the Hiw people, the Periz people, the Girgash people, the Amor people and the Jebus people

As you go forward, he will certainly drive out the Canaan group, the Hitti group, the Hiw group, the Periz group, the Girgash group, the Amor group and the Yabus group

Joshua 3:11

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:9–13

Joshua told the people about the miracle that Yahweh will do.

3:11

Behold, the ark of the covenant of the Lord of all the earth will go ahead of you into the Jordan.

- See, the covenant box of the Lord of the whole earth will go into the Jordan River before you^(plur).
- You will know this when you see the holy chest which shows that the ruler of all the earth is with us. This chest, the priests will carry it into the Jordan River ahead of you.

Behold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Behold calls attention to the next statement. In verse 10 Joshua told the Israelites that they will know that Yahweh is with them. In this verse Joshua tells them how they will know that.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Look

See

This is how you will know

the ark of the covenant of the Lord of all the earth will go ahead of you into the Jordan: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests will carry the covenant box, which shows that the Lord of all the earth is with you, ahead of you into the Jordan River

the ark of the covenant...will go ahead: In some languages it is not natural to speak of a box doing something. It may be more natural to make the priests be the subject of the sentence.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests will carry the covenant box

However, the Hebrew text puts emphasis on the ark, not on the priests. The ark was the symbol of God's presence with the Israelites. If possible, use the grammar of your language to make the covenant box be the topic or the focus of the sentence. For example:

as for the covenant box, the priests will carry it into the Jordan River

the ark of the covenant: Translate this the same way you did at 3:3b.

the Lord of all the earth: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Lord can also be translated "master" or "ruler." It is not the same as the name Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the ruler of the whole earth

the king of the whole world

will go ahead of you into the Jordan: The clause will go ahead of you into the Jordan indicates that the covenant box will go ahead of the Israelites into the Jordan River. In verses 12-17 the priests carry the covenant box into the Jordan River and stay there. Then the people walk past it to cross the river. Finally, the priests carry the covenant box, following the people out of the river.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

See, the covenant box that belongs to the Lord of all the earth will go into the Jordan River ahead of you

This is how you will know that God is among you. The priests will carry the holy chest of the ruler of all the earth into the Jordan River before you

Joshua 3:12

Section 3:1-17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:9-13

Joshua told the people about the miracle that Yahweh will do.

3:12

Now choose twelve men from the tribes of Israel, one from each tribe.

- Therefore, take^(plur) twelve men, one from each clan of Israel.
- So, choose one man from each of the twelve Israelite clans. I will tell you later what they should do.

Now: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Now is more literally "and now." Its function is to introduce a new thought.^{3:12 Holladay p. 287.} This thought is about the twelve men who have an important part in crossing the Jordan River. Their role is explained further in chapter 4.^{3:12 Hess p. 113.} This sentence interrupts the instructions about the priests and the covenant box.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

So

Therefore

choose twelve men: The reason why they chose these twelve men is not explained until Joshua 4:3.

from the tribes of Israel, one from each tribe: Joshua told each of the twelve tribes of Israel to choose one man from their tribe.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

So, choose twelve men, one man from each tribe of Israel

The instructions about these twelve men are not finished until Joshua 4:3. It may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

So, choose twelve men, one man from each tribe of Israel. Later I will tell you what they should do.

Joshua 3:13

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:9–13

Joshua told the people about the miracle that Yahweh will do.

3:13a

When the feet of the priests who carry the ark of the LORD—the Lord of all the earth—

- The feet of the priests carrying the covenant box of Yahweh, the king of the whole earth,
- As soon as the priests who carry the holy chest of Yahweh, the master of all the earth, put their feet

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated and many English versions translate as “And” is more literally “and it will be.” It indicates what will happen next.

When: The Hebrew construction that the BSB translates as When can also be translated “as soon as.” This indicates that when the priests stepped in the water, the water stopped flowing immediately. 3:13 Dallaire p. 879.

the feet of the priests: The feet refers to the bottom part of the foot. Many English translations leave this information implicit. For example:

the feet of the priests (NET)

who carry: Here is another way to translate this term:

who carry on poles on their shoulders

the ark of the LORD—the Lord of all the earth: This expression is like, but not quite the same as, the expression in 3:11.

the ark of the LORD: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as LORD is “Yahweh,” the name of God.

the Lord of all the earth: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Lord can also be translated as “master” or “ruler.” It is not the same as the name Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then, when the feet of the priests who carry the covenant box of Yahweh, the master of all the earth,

The priests will carry the holy chest of Yahweh, the ruler of all the earth. When their feet...

3:13b

touch down in the waters of the Jordan,

- will stand in the water of the Jordan River.
- into the water,

touch down in the waters of the Jordan: The clause touch down in the waters of the Jordan indicates that the priests’ feet will stand in the Jordan River.

the waters of the Jordan: the phrase the waters of the Jordan refers to the Jordan River. The Hebrew word for water always occurs in the plural. In English it usually occurs in the singular. Use the form that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the priests put their feet into the water of the Jordan River

the priests step into the Jordan River

3:13c

its flowing waters will be cut off

- Immediately, the water will stop flowing.
- God will stop it from flowing.

its flowing waters will be cut off: This clause is more literally “the waters of the Jordan will be cut off.” This is a passive sentence.

Here are two ways to translate this passive sentence:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

its waters flowing downstream will be cut off
(NIV)

- Use an active verb. Here are some ways to translate it with an active verb:

the waters coming downstream toward you will stop flowing (NET)

God will stop the water from flowing down toward you

Use the form that is most natural in your language.

its flowing waters: The phrase its flowing waters refers to the Jordan River that was flowing down from its source at a higher place to the place where the Israelites were.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the water that flows down toward you

3:13d

and will stand up in a heap.”

- The water coming from upstream will pile up in a heap.”
- He will cause the water coming down to collect in one place.”

will stand up in a heap: The clause will stand up in a heap indicates that the water of the Jordan River would stand up like a wall in one place. Instead of continuing to flow along the riverbed where the Israelites were about to cross, the water piled up at a distance up the river.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

will stand like a wall

will pile up in one place (GNT)

General Comment on 3:13c-d

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 3:13c and 3:13d. For example:

^{13d}the water will pile up in a heap upstream ^{13c}and will not flow down toward you

Joshua 3:14

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:14–17

The water of the Jordan River stopped flowing and the Israelites crossed on dry ground.

3:14a

So when the people broke camp

- ¶ When the people took down their tents to go
- ¶ Then the people took down their tents and left the place where they had been camping

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So is more literally “and it was.” It marks the return to the narrative after Joshua’s speech. The story continues after the Israelites listened to what Joshua said. Translate this return to the narrative in a way that is natural in your language.

when the people broke camp: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as broke camp is more literally “pull out.” It refers to pulling out the tent pegs and taking down their tents. 3:14 Holladay p 240.

The clause when the people broke camp indicates that the Israelite people took down their tents and left the place where they stayed. They took their tents with them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

when the people took down their tents and set out

when the people set out from the place where they had been camping

3:14b

to cross the Jordan,

- across the Jordan River,

- to cross the Jordan River.

to cross the Jordan: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

to cross the Jordan River

3:14c

the priests carried the ark of the covenant ahead of them.

- the priests who were carrying the ark of the covenant went ahead of them.
- The priests carried the holy chest ahead of the people,

the priests carried the ark of the covenant ahead of them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

with the priests carrying the ark of the covenant in front of the people

The priests carried the covenant box on poles on their shoulders ahead of the people

General Comment on 3:14a-c

Some English versions follow the Hebrew in making this a dependent clause. In some languages it may be more natural to start a new sentence here, and make this be an independent sentence, like the BSB does.

Joshua 3:15

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:14–17

The water of the Jordan River stopped flowing and the Israelites crossed on dry ground.

3:15a

Now the Jordan overflows its banks throughout the harvest season.

- (The Jordan River had risen over all its banks because it was harvest time.)
- (It was the time when they harvested barley, and the river was flooding.)

Now the Jordan overflows its banks throughout the harvest season: This is background information. It explains the miracle that God performed. At that time

of year, the river was full and overflowing. The people were able to cross the river even though the river was full of water.

the harvest season: The harvest refers to the barley harvest which happened in April. At that time snow melted in the mountains and made the river flood.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

it was the spring season when they harvested barley

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It was harvest time, and the river was in flood (GNT)

The water of the Jordan River had risen over its banks, as it did during harvest time.

3:15b

But as soon as the priests carrying the ark reached the Jordan

- The feet of the priests who were carrying the covenant box
- and arrived at the Jordan River.

But as soon as the priests carrying the ark reached the Jordan: The BSB follows the Hebrew in making this a dependent clause. In some languages it may be more natural to make this be an independent sentence. For example:

Then the priests carried the ark and reached the Jordan River.

Then the priests carried the ark and reached the Jordan River.

as soon as: The Hebrew construction that the BSB translates as as soon as is the same as in verse 3:13a. It can be translated “when.”

the priests carrying the ark: The phrase the priests carrying the ark refers to the priests who were carrying the covenant box. In Hebrew, the word priests is not made explicit until verse 15c. It may be more natural in some languages to make it explicit here and use a pronoun in the next part of the verse, as the BSB does.

the ark: The Hebrew sometimes refers to the ark of the covenant in a shortened form as the ark. You should follow natural discourse patterns when you translate this into your language. See how you translated it in verse 3b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When the priests who carried the covenant box reached the Jordan River

As soon as the priests carrying the holy chest came to the Jordan River

3:15c and their feet touched the water's edge,

- touched the water at the river's edge.
- The priests carrying the chest stepped into the river.

and their feet touched the water's edge: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they stepped into the water at the edge of the river

and their feet touched the water at the edge of the river

General Comment on 3:15a-c

Each language has a different way to express background information like that in verse 3:15a. One way to include background information would be to put the words in parentheses. In some languages it may be clearer to reorder the clauses and begin with the background information. For example:

^{15a}Now the Jordan is at flood stage all during harvest. ^{15b}Yet as soon as the priests who carried the ark reached the Jordan ^{15c}and their feet touched the water's edge, (NIV)

3:15a-c (reordered) It was the time of the barley harvest, and the river was flooding. The feet of the priests who were carrying the covenant box touched the water at the edge of the river.

Joshua 3:16

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River
The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:14–17

The water of the Jordan River stopped flowing and the Israelites crossed on dry ground.

3:16a the flowing water stood still. It backed up

- Then the water which came down from upstream stopped flowing and piled up in a heap a long distance away
- As soon as they stepped into the water, the water that was flowing down toward them stopped, and collected in one place, a long way upstream.

the flowing water: The phrase the flowing water was first used in verse 3:13d. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the water that was flowing down toward them

stood still: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as stood still can also be translated “stopped moving.” It indicates that the river water stopped flowing down from above. This corresponds to the event described in verse 3:13c.

Here is another way to translate this verb:

stopped flowing

It backed up: The clause It backed up is similar in meaning to the clause “will stand up in a heap” in verse 3:13d. In this verse the narrator used a different verb, but you may be able to use the same verb in both verses.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

It rose up like a dam (GW)

it piled up

3:16b as far upstream as Adam, a city in the area of Zarethan,

- at the town of Adam, which is near the town of Zarethan.
- This place was beside the city of Adam, near the city of Zarethan.

far upstream: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

a long distance away

far off (RSV)

Adam: The town of Adam was about 18 miles north of Jericho.3:16 Dallaire p 881.

a city in the area of Zarethan: The location of the town of Zarethan is uncertain.

city: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as city refers to a permanent settlement of houses with a wall around it for protection. These cities were not large places. The largest of the cities mentioned in Joshua may have had a population of two or three thousand people. Most of them were much smaller.

The Hebrew language does not distinguish between “city” and “town.” It does distinguish between a city/town and a village. Because they were small cities, some English versions translate the Hebrew word as “town” rather than city. In these Notes we follow those versions and use the word “town.”

Consider the word in your language that is appropriate for a small permanent settlement with a wall around it.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

at the town of Adam, which was near the town of Zarethan

3:16c

while the water flowing toward the Sea of the Arabah (the Salt Sea) was completely cut off.

- The water which flowed down to the sea of the Arabah, which was also called the Salt Sea, stopped completely.
- No more water flowed down to the Salt Sea (also called the sea of the Arabah).

while the water flowing: The phrase while the water flowing refers to the water that continued to flow downstream from where the people crossed.

toward the Sea of the Arabah (the Salt Sea): The names Sea of the Arabah and Salt Sea both refer to the same lake. This is the lake that the Jordan River flows into. This lake is very salty and no fish can live in it. In Hebrew it is usually called the Salt Sea. In English it is called the Dead Sea.

The name Sea of the Arabah refers to its location. The Hebrew term Arabah refers to the valley of the Jordan River.

In English this lake is called the Dead Sea. If your language has a name other than Salt Sea there are two ways you can translate it.

- Translate it literally as Salt Sea. For example:

Salt Sea (ESV)

- Translate it with its common name in your language. For example:

Dead Sea (NLT)

If you translate it literally you may want to have a footnote. For example:

FOOTNOTE: This refers to the lake that in our language we call the Dead Sea

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Dead Sea (the sea of the Jordan River valley)

the Salt Sea (the sea near the Arabah)

was completely cut off: The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as completely cut off is more literally “they were complete, they were cut off.” The water downstream from the Israelites was separated from the heap of water that was upstream. No more water flowed downstream to the Dead Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

no more water flowed down to the Salt Sea (also called the sea of the Arabah)

the water flowing down to the Dead Sea completely stopped

3:16d

So the people crossed over opposite Jericho.

- Then the people crossed the river opposite Jericho.
- The people of Israel crossed the river near the town of Jericho.

So the people crossed over: The clause the people crossed over indicates that the Israelites crossed the river.

opposite Jericho: Jericho was a town on the west side of the Jordan River. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

near the town of Jericho

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people crossed the river opposite Jericho

When the water was all gone , the Israelites crossed the Jordan River near Jericho

Joshua 3:17

Section 3:1–17 The Israelites crossed the Jordan River

The Israelites waited three days beside the Jordan and then crossed the river. The priests carried the ark and led the way. As soon as the priests stepped into the river, the water stopped flowing, and everyone was able to cross the river on dry ground.

Paragraph 3:14–17

The water of the Jordan River stopped flowing and the Israelites crossed on dry ground.

3:17a

The priests carrying the ark of the covenant of the LORD

- The priests carrying the covenant box of Yahweh
- The priests carrying the holy chest of Yahweh

The priests carrying the ark of the covenant of the LORD: In verse 3:13a the priests were called “the priests who carry the ark of the LORD.” In verse 3:14 it said “the priests carried the ark of the covenant.” In this verse the two expressions are combined. Translate this expression in a way that combines the words in those verses well.

3:17b

stood firm on dry ground in the middle of the Jordan,

- stood on dry ground in the middle of the river,
- stood firmly in the middle of the Jordan River on dry ground.

stood firm on dry ground in the middle of the Jordan: The priests moved from the edge of the river to the middle of the river and stood there while all the Israelites walked past them.

stood firm: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as stood firm are more literally “stood to be firm.” 3:17 Woudstra p. 88; Boling and Wright p. 171. This can

be translated in English as “stood firmly.” This emphasizes the miracle that Yahweh did when he stopped the water. Although some English versions do not translate the word “to be firm” it is recommended that you translate it. 3:17 Bratcher p. 45 says that it is not necessary to translate it because it may mean “right there.” Most commentaries (Woudstra, Boling and Wright, Butler) agree with the meaning of “firmly” from the Hiphil infinitive absolute of the Hebrew verb. The lexicons also agree with this definition for the form found in this verse.

Here are some other ways to translate these Hebrew words:

stood firmly (ESV, NET, GW)

stood on dry ground (GNT)

3:17c

while all Israel crossed over the dry ground,

- while all the Israelites crossed the river on dry ground.
- All the Israelite people walked across the river on dry ground,

while all Israel: The phrase all Israel indicates all the Israelite people.

crossed over the dry ground: The clause crossed over the dry ground indicates that the bed of the Jordan River was dry where the Israelites crossed the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

All the Israelites crossed the river on dry ground

3:17d

until the entire nation had crossed the Jordan.

- They stood there until all the people crossed the river.
- until all the people had crossed.

until the entire nation: The phrase the entire nation refers to all the Israelite people.

had crossed the Jordan: The clause had crossed the Jordan can also be translated “had crossed the Jordan River.”

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

until the whole Israelite nation finished crossing the Jordan River

General Comment on 3:17

The Hebrew text places the action of the priests at the beginning of the sentence to emphasize it. Throughout this story, the focus is on the covenant box of Yahweh and the priests who carried it. This concluding statement keeps this focus. It may be possible to translate in a way that keeps this emphasis. For example:

The priests carrying the ark of the covenant of the Lord stood firmly on dry ground in the middle of the Jordan. All Israel crossed over on dry ground until the entire nation was on the other side.
(NET)

Joshua 4:1

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:1a

When the whole nation had finished crossing the Jordan,

- ¶ When all the Israelite people crossed the Jordan,
- ¶ All the Israelites finished crossing over the Jordan River.

When the whole nation had finished crossing the Jordan: In some languages it may be more natural to make this into an independent clause. For example, you could say:

^{1a}All the Israelites finished crossing the Jordan River. ^{1b}Then Yahweh said to Joshua...

the whole nation: The phrase the whole nation refers to all the Israelite people.

had finished crossing the Jordan: The phrase had finished crossing the Jordan means that the Israelites crossed over to the west side of the Jordan River.

4:1b

the LORD said to Joshua,

- Yahweh said to Joshua:
- Then Yahweh commanded Joshua:

the LORD said to Joshua: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Yahweh commanded

Joshua 4:2

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:2

This verse is a repetition of the command that Yahweh gave to Joshua in 3:12. It is repeated because the emphasis of this story is on how the representatives of the twelve Israelite tribes set up memorial stones.

4:2a

“Choose twelve men from among the people,

- “Choose twelve men from among the Israelites
- “Now choose twelve men from the people of Israel

Choose twelve men: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Choose is imperative. It means that Yahweh commanded Joshua to choose twelve men.

from among the people: The phrase from among the people means that Joshua was to choose the men from among the Israelites.

4:2b

one from each tribe,

- one man per clan.

- one man from every clan of Israelite people.

one from each tribe: The phrase one from each tribe means that Joshua must choose one man from each of the twelve Israelite tribes.

tribe: See how you translated this term in 1:12|.

Joshua 4:3

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:3a-b

The BSB uses a direct quote. In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quote. For example, you could say:

Command them to take twelve stones

4:3a

and command them:

- Tell them,
- You must command them to do this:

and command them: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as command them is imperative. It means that God commanded Joshua to give a command (4:3b-e) to the group of men he chose.

4:3b

'Take up for yourselves twelve stones from the middle of the Jordan

- 'Each one of you must take a stone from the middle of the Jordan River
- 'You must each pick up a rock from the middle of the river.

Take up for yourselves twelve stones: The phrase Take up for yourselves twelve stones means that each of the twelve men must pick up one stone.

stones: These would have been large stones, about as large as a single person could carry.

from the middle of the Jordan: The phrase from the middle of the Jordan indicates that the men must take stones from the place where the priests were standing. The priests were standing in the middle of the Jordan river. The water had stopped flowing when the priests entered the water, which allowed the people to walk across the bottom of the (dry) river bed (see 3:17b-c). The men were supposed to take the twelve rocks from the bottom of the river from that same area. Here are some other ways to translate these verse part:

Take twelve stones out of the middle of the Jordan (GNT)

Tell them to get twelve rocks from the middle of the river (NCV)

4:3c

where the priests were standing,

- from the exact place where the priests' feet are standing.
- You must take the rocks from the same place where the priests are standing.

where the priests were standing: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as where the priests were standing is more literally "the firm standing place of the feet of the priests." The twelve men picked up the stones while the priests were still standing in the middle of the river. Another way to translate this is:

from right where the priests are standing (NIV)

where: The Hebrew word translated as where emphasizes that the men must pick up stones from the exact place where the priests are standing. Another way to show this emphasis would be:

from the very place where the priests' feet stood (RSV)

4:3d

carry them with you,

- Carry them over to the other side,
- Carry the stones to the west bank of the river.

carry them with you: The phrase carry them with you means that each man must carry the stone he picked up, and take it to the other side of the river.

4:3e

and set them down in the place where you spend the night.”

- and lay them down at the camping place where you will sleep tonight.”
- Then put them down in the same place that you will stay tonight.”

and set them down: The phrase set them down means that each man is to put his rock down on the ground.

in the place where you spend the night: The phrase in the place where you spend the night indicates the place where they were to put down the stones.

spend the night: The phrase spend the night means that the Israelites lived in that place for a short time (probably a few days or weeks).

Joshua 4:4**Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River**

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:4

There is implied information at the beginning of 4:4. It does not say explicitly that Joshua chose the men. You may wish to include this implied information.

Here is a way to translate the implied information:

Joshua chose one man from each tribe, and then he called the twelve men

4:4a

So Joshua summoned the twelve men he had appointed from the Israelites,

- ¶ Then Joshua called the twelve Israelite men,
- ¶ Then Joshua called together the twelve men

So Joshua summoned the twelve men: The phrase Joshua summoned the twelve men indicates that Joshua gathered the twelve men he had chosen in order to give them God’s command.

from the Israelites: The phrase from the Israelites emphasizes that these men were all Israelite men. It may be redundant to translate this phrase in some languages, because it is clear from previous verses that these were Israelite men. It may be more natural to leave this phrase implicit.

4:4b

one from each tribe,

- whom he had chosen, one from each clan of Israel.
- that he had chosen earlier, one man per clan.

he had appointed: The phrase he had appointed refers to the men that Joshua chose to carry the stones.

one from each tribe: A similar phrase is found in 4:2b. The purpose of one from each tribe was so that each tribe had a representative.

General Comment on 4:4

It might be helpful to reorder the phrases and to include the implied information. Some other ways to translate this verse are:

Joshua chose one man from each of the twelve Israelite tribes. Then he called them together

Joshua called together the twelve men he had appointed to represent the twelve Israelite tribes

Joshua 4:5**Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River**

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:5a and said to them,

- Joshua told them:
- Then he commanded them:

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and indicates the next action in the story. Use a word or particle in your language to show that the story line is progressing.

said to them: The phrase said to them indicates that Joshua told God's command to the twelve men. In other words, Joshua repeated to the men what God said to him in 4:3. It may be more natural in some languages to use a word such as:

Joshua ordered them

Joshua commanded them

4:5b "Cross over before the ark of the LORD your God into the middle of the Jordan.

- "Go to the middle of the Jordan River in front of the ark of Yahweh your God.
- "Go into the river where the covenant box of Yahweh your God is.

Cross over before the ark of the LORD your God into the middle of the Jordan: The phrase Cross over before the ark means that the twelve men must go into the middle of the riverbed, where the priests stood holding the ark of Yahweh.

ark: See 3:3 for ideas of how to translate the word ark.

4:5c Each of you is to take a stone upon his shoulder,

- Each one of you must pick up a stone and carry it on your shoulder.
- And every man must put a stone on his shoulder and carry it across the river.

Each of you is to take a stone upon his shoulder: The clause Each of you is to take a stone upon his shoulder means that each of the twelve men must pick up one stone and carry it across the river to the other side.

There is implied information here that is not made explicit until 4:8. The men were told to carry the stones to the camping place and put them down there. You may find it helpful to include this implied information here.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

each of you should take a stone on his shoulder, and carry them to the camp and put them down there

4:5d according to the number of the tribes of Israel,

- There will be one stone for each of the twelve clans of Israel.
- These twelve stones will represent the twelve clans of the people of Israel.

according to the number of the tribes of Israel: The phrase according to the number of the tribes means that the twelve stones which the men carried across the river each represented one of the Israelite tribes.

General Comment on 4:5

There is some uncertainty about how 4:5 (and 4:8) fits into the sequence of events of chapters 3–4.

1. The Israelites finished crossing the Jordan River. Then the twelve men went back into the river to get the stones from where the priests were still holding the ark of covenant.
2. The twelve men picked up the stones while they were crossing the river with the other Israelites. Chapter 4 is a flashback that focuses on one aspect of the crossing, namely, the memorial stones.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In 4:1–5 it seems that Joshua talked to the twelve men after the Israelites finished crossing the river. It was after everyone was across that the ceremony of gathering the memorial stones was done.

Joshua 4:6

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:6a**to serve as a sign among you.**

- These stones will be there for you to see.
- These stones will remind you what happened here today.

to serve as a sign among you: The clause to serve as a sign among you states the reason they gathered the twelve stones.

sign: The word sign indicates that these stones were a reminder to the Israelites of how God helped them to cross the Jordan River. When the Israelites saw the stones in the future, they would remember that Yahweh made the Jordan River stop flowing so that they could cross it.

among you: The phrase among you indicates that the stones remained where the men placed them, and were there for people to see whenever they passed by.

4:6b**In the future, when your children ask,**

- In the future your children will ask you,
- Whenever your children ask you in the future,

In the future, when your children ask: The clause In the future, when your children ask refers to the children of the Israelites as well as the future generations of Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

in the future, when your children and grandchildren ask

4:6c**‘What do these stones mean to you?’**

- ‘Why are these stones here?’
- ‘What do you remember when you see these stones?’

What do these stones mean to you?: The question What do these stones mean to you? asks why those stones are important to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways of translating this question:

Why are these stones important to you? (NET)

What event do these stones help you to remember?

Joshua 4:7**Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River**

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:7a**you are to tell them,**

- Then you must answer them,
- Answer them like this:

you are to tell them: In some languages it may be more natural to express the clause you are to tell them with a direct command. For example:

tell them

reply to them

4:7b**‘The waters of the Jordan were cut off**

- ‘The waters of the Jordan River stopped flowing
- ‘Yahweh made the Jordan River stop flowing

The waters of the Jordan: The phrase The waters of the Jordan refers to the Jordan River.

were cut off: The phrase were cut off means that Yahweh made the Jordan River stop flowing upstream from where the Israelites were waiting to cross it. It may be more natural for you to express this idea with an active verb, for example:

The Jordan River stopped flowing

It may be necessary to include the agent, who is God. For example, you could say:

God caused the Jordan River to stop flowing

4:7c**before the ark of the covenant of the LORD.**

- when the ark of the covenant of Yahweh
- when the priests carried his covenant box.

before the ark of the covenant of the LORD: It may be more natural in some languages to combine the phrase before the ark of the covenant of the LORD with the phrase in verse 4:7d. For example:

when the priests carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh over the Jordan River

while the ark of the covenant of Yahweh was crossing the Jordan River

ark of the covenant: See 3:3 for ideas about how to translate this phrase.

4:7d**When it crossed the Jordan,**

- was crossing the Jordan River.
- When the covenant box crossed the river

When it crossed the Jordan: The clause When it crossed the Jordan means that the priests carried the ark across the Jordan River. You may have already combined this clause with the phrase in verse 4:7c.

4:7e**the waters were cut off.'**

- At that time the Jordan River stopped flowing.'
- the river stopped flowing.'

the waters were cut off: The clause the waters were cut off is a repetition of 4:7b. It may be more natural in some languages not to repeat this information. If this repetition is natural in your language, you should translate this clause in the same way that you translated verse 4:7b.

4:7f**Therefore these stones will be a memorial to the Israelites forever."**

- These stones will always remind the Israelites of what happened here."
- Whenever the Israelites see these stones, they will remember what happened here."

Therefore these stones will be a memorial to the Israelites forever: The sentence these stones will be a memorial to the Israelites forever repeats the information given in verse 4:6a using different words. It is repeated to show how important these stones were. They reminded the Israelites of the great miracle that

Yahweh had done. If this repetition is not natural in your language, it is possible to combine this information with the beginning of verse 6a. You would then need to combine verses 4:6–7 in your numbering of them. For example:

^{6b}Someday your children will ask, ^{6c}"Why are these rocks here?" ^{7a}Then you can tell them ^{7e}how the water stopped flowing ^{7d}when the chest was being carried across the river. ^{6a}These rocks will always remind our people of what happened here today. (CEV)

memorial: A memorial is something that helps people to remember. This memorial refers to the stones that reminded the people of Israel of what Yahweh had done.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

memory-stone

something to help you remember

when you see the stones, you will remember

Joshua 4:8**Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River**

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:8a**Thus the Israelites did as Joshua had commanded them.**

- ¶ Then the twelve Israelite men followed Joshua's command.
- ¶ So the Israelite men did what he told them.

Thus: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Thus indicates that the next action in the story is about to take place. Use a word or particle in your language to show that the story line is progressing.

the Israelites: The phrase the Israelites refers to the twelve men that Joshua chose to carry the stones.

did as Joshua had commanded them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The men followed Joshua's orders (GNT)

So the Israelites obeyed Joshua (NCV)

4:8b

They took up twelve stones from the middle of the Jordan,

- They took twelve rocks out of the middle of the river,
- They picked up twelve stones from the middle of the Jordan River.

took up twelve stones from the middle of the Jordan: The phrase took up twelve stones means that they picked up twelve stones. The stones were lying in the riverbed. Because the water had stopped flowing, the men could pick up the stones easily.

the middle of the Jordan: The phrase the middle of the Jordan refers to the middle of the Jordan riverbed that was dry.

4:8c

one for each tribe of Israel,

- one stone for every clan of Israel,
- Each rock represented one of the twelve clans of Israel.

one for each tribe of Israel: The phrase one for each tribe of Israel is a repetition of 4:5d. There were twelve tribes, and there were also twelve stones.

4:8d

just as the LORD had told Joshua;

- as Yahweh commanded Joshua.
- They obeyed the command which Yahweh gave to Joshua.

just as the LORD had told Joshua: The phrase as the LORD had told Joshua emphasizes that the command to pick up the stones came from Yahweh, not from Joshua. It may be more natural in some languages to combine this phrase with 4:8a. For example:

The men followed the instructions that the Lord had given Joshua (CEV)

4:8e

and they carried them to the camp,

- They carried the stones over the river to their camping place,
- They carried the rocks across the river to the place where they stayed temporarily,

and: The word and indicates that the next action in the story is about to take place. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. Use a word or particle in your language to show that the story line is progressing.

they carried them: The phrase they carried them means that the twelve men carried the twelve stones across the river.

to the camp: The phrase to the camp refers to the place where the Israelites set up their camp or temporary dwelling place. If there is no word "camp" in your language, you may translate this phrase as "the place where they stayed for a short time."

4:8f

where they set them down.

- and put them down there.
- and put them on the ground there.

where they set them down: The phrase where they set them down means that the twelve men put down the stones on the ground at the place where they camped.

Joshua 4:9

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:9a

Joshua also set up twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan,

- Joshua also set up twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan River
- Then Joshua had men place another set of twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan River.

Joshua also set up twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan: There is an interpretation issue in this verse.

1. Joshua set up the twelve stones in the middle of the river at the place where the priests stood with the ark. This was a second monument. For example:

Joshua also set up twelve stones in the middle of the Jordan (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. Joshua set up the twelve stones at their campsite. These are the stones that the twelve men carried up out of the middle of the Jordan River. They do not refer to a separate monument. For example:

Joshua set up the twelve stones that had been in the middle of the Jordan (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Nearly all English versions and most commentaries understand it this way.

It is most likely that Joshua had some people build the monument for him. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

Joshua had some other men set up a monument (CEV)

Joshua also had twelve stones set up (NAB)

Joshua had the men place another set of twelve stones

also: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as also does not indicate that the next action in the story is about to take place. Verse 4:9 is a parenthetical comment. It may be more natural in some languages to use a word such as “and.” For example:

And Joshua set up twelve stones (RSV)

4:9b

in the place where the priests who carried the ark of the covenant stood.

- in the same place where the priests who carried the ark of the covenant stood.
- They marked the place where the priests stood with the covenant box.

in the place where the priests: The Hebrew is literally “in the place where the feet of the priests.” It may be more natural in some languages to make the words “the feet of” explicit.

who carried the ark of the covenant stood: The phrase who carried the ark of the covenant indicates that the priests were holding the ark of the covenant while they stood in the middle of river.

It may be more natural in some languages to re-arrange the phrases. For example:

where the priests had stood while carrying the Ark of the Agreement (NCV)

It is also possible to leave this phrase implicit if that is more natural in your language. For example:

the place where the priests were standing (CEV)

4:9c

And the stones are there to this day.

- They are still standing there today.
- Those stones are still there to this day.

And the stones are there to this day: The phrase the stones are there to this day means that the stones were still in the river at the time that the author wrote the book of Joshua.

Joshua 4:10

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

Paragraph 4:10–11

This paragraph is a summary about the crossing of the Jordan River. The priests obeyed God's command. They stood in the middle of the river while the rest of the Israelites crossed it. Finally, the priests with the ark of the covenant finished crossing the river.

4:10a

Now the priests who carried the ark remained standing in the middle of the Jordan

- ¶ The priests who carried the ark continued standing in the middle of the Jordan River
- ¶ The priests who carried the covenant box remained standing in the river on dry ground

Now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now is the Hebrew connector between sentences in a narrative. It may be more natural in some languages to leave it out. For example:

The priests who bore the ark remained standing (NRSV)

remained standing in the middle of the Jordan: The phrase remained standing in the middle of the Jordan indicates that the priests who were carrying the ark continued to stand in the middle of the Jordan River. The river stopped flowing, and they stood on the dry riverbed. It may be helpful to make this explicit in some languages. For example, you could say:

The priests who carried the ark stood on dry ground in the middle of the Jordan River

4:10b

until the people had completed everything the LORD had commanded Joshua to tell them,

- until the people finished doing everything that Yahweh commanded Joshua.
- until everyone crossed. This is what Yahweh commanded Joshua to tell them to do.

until the people had completed everything the LORD had commanded Joshua to tell them: The clause until the people had completed everything the LORD had commanded Joshua to tell them indicates that the people did everything that Yahweh commanded them to do. Yahweh gave his command to Joshua. Joshua repeated the command to the Israelites, and the Israelites obeyed the command.

4:10c

just as Moses had directed Joshua.

- The Israelites did everything as Moses commanded Joshua.
- The people obeyed all Joshua's commands, which he received from Moses.

just as Moses had directed Joshua: The phrase just as Moses had directed Joshua indicates that Yahweh first gave these commands to Moses before Moses died. Moses then told Joshua what Yahweh wanted the Israelites to do when they reached the Jordan.

4:10d

The people hurried across,

- The people crossed the river as quickly as they could.
- The people hurried across.

The people hurried across: The clause The people hurried across means that the Israelites crossed the Jordan River as quickly as they could. They hurried across it.

Joshua 4:11

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

Paragraph 4:10–11

This paragraph is a summary about the crossing of the Jordan River. The priests obeyed God's command. They stood in the middle of the river while the rest of the Israelites crossed it. Finally, the priests with the ark of the covenant finished crossing the river.

4:11a

and after everyone had finished crossing,

- When all the Israelites finished crossing,
- When everyone crossed the river,

and: The word and indicates that the next action in the story is about to take place.

after: Another time connector might be clearer such as “as soon as.” Use a time connector that is natural in your language.

everyone had finished crossing: The word everyone refers to all the Israelite people except for the priests carrying the ark.

4:11b

the priests with the ark of the LORD crossed in the sight of the people.

- the ark of Yahweh and the priests crossed while the people watched.
- the priests carried the covenant box of Yahweh across the river as the people watched.

the priests with the ark of the LORD: The Hebrew language places the ark of the LORD first to emphasize its importance. However, the priests were still carrying the ark. It may be more natural in some languages to translate this phrase as “the priests who were carrying the ark of Yahweh.”

ark: See 3:3 for ideas of how to translate the word ark.

crossed: The word crossed means that the priests crossed the Jordan River to the other side.

in the sight of the people: There are two ways to interpret the phrase in the sight of the people:

1. The priests crossed the river while the people watched. For example:

...crossed as the people looked on (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, KJV)

1. The priests crossed the river and went ahead of the people. For example:

...went on ahead of the people (GNT) (GNT, NAB, NJB, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The clause “crossed in the sight of the people” points to 4:15–18. The people came out of the river. Then they watched as the priests finished crossing the river.

Joshua 4:12

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:12a

The Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ The clans of Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh
- ¶ The men of the clan of Reuben, Gad, and the eastern half of the clan of Manasseh

The Reubenites: The word Reubenites refers to men of the tribe of Reuben.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

men from the tribe of Reuben

the Gadites: The word Gadites refers to men of the tribe of Gad.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

men from the tribe of Gad

and the half-tribe of Manasseh: The phrase the half-tribe of Manasseh refers to the families of the tribe of Manasseh who asked Moses for permission to settle on the east side of the Jordan River along with the tribes of Reuben and Gad. This request and Moses’ answer is found in Numbers 32:16–33.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

men from the east part of the tribe of Manasseh

There is implied information here. These men were also soldiers. This is made clear in 4:12b. For example:

The armed warriors from the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh (NLT)

4:12b

crossed over before the Israelites, armed for battle

- crossed over the river with their weapons ahead of the other Israelites,

- crossed the river first, carrying their weapons of war.

crossed over before the Israelites, armed for battle:

The phrase crossed over...armed for battle indicates that the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh took their weapons with them when they crossed over the Jordan River. They were ready to fight. They did this to show that they would keep the promise they made to Joshua in 1:16–18. They promised to help the other tribes of Israel conquer the land of Canaan.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they crossed the river carrying their weapons

before the Israelites: The phrase before the Israelites indicates that the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh crossed the river ahead of the other tribes.

4:12c

as Moses had instructed them.

- as Moses commanded them to do.
- because Moses commanded them to do this before he died.

as Moses had instructed them: The phrase as Moses had instructed them indicates that these tribes obeyed the command that Moses gave them before he died. This command is recorded in Numbers 32:16–32 and Deuteronomy 3:12–20.

had instructed: The phrase had instructed means “had commanded.”

Joshua 4:13

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:13a

About 40,000 troops armed for battle

- About forty thousand Israelite soldiers carried their weapons ready for war
- There were about forty thousand men prepared to enter battle.

About 40,000 troops armed for battle: There is an interpretation issue here. There are two ways to understand the number 40,000.

1. There were a total of 40,000 Israelite soldiers who crossed the Jordan River. This was the total number of soldiers for all twelve tribes combined. For example:

About forty thousand battle-ready troops (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, ESV, NIV, NABRE, NJPS, GNT, KJV)

1. There were 40,000 soldiers from the two and one half eastern tribes. This number does not include the soldiers from the western tribes. For example:

Forty thousand soldiers from the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and East Manasseh (CEV) (CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). A total of 40,000 Israelite soldiers corresponds with the numbers of soldiers referred to in Joshua chapters 7–8 and the two battles at Ai. See especially 8:3–12. This is the interpretation followed by many English versions, and by several commentaries.

armed: The word armed means that they carried their weapons with them.

for battle: The phrase for battle means that they were ready to fight in a war.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were about forty thousand soldiers who carried their weapons and were ready to fight

4:13b

crossed over before the LORD

- and marched past the ark of Yahweh,
- They marched past the ark of Yahweh ready to fight.

crossed over before the LORD: The phrase crossed over means that the forty thousand soldiers crossed over the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

crossed the Jordan River in the presence of Yahweh

4:13c **into the plains of Jericho.**

- heading toward the plains of Jericho.
- They went along the road to the plains in front of Jericho city.

into the plains of Jericho: The plains of Jericho refers to the plain between the Jordan River and the town of Jericho. This indicates that the forty thousand soldiers marched into this plain.

Joshua 4:14

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:14a **On that day the LORD exalted Joshua in the sight of all Israel,**

- ¶ All the people of Israel saw how Yahweh honored Joshua that day.
- ¶ That day Yahweh showed all the Israelites that Joshua was a great leader.

On that day: The phrase On that day refers to the day that the Israelites crossed the Jordan River.

the LORD exalted Joshua: The phrase the LORD exalted Joshua means that Yahweh honored Joshua when he made the Jordan River stop flowing. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Joshua was a leader whom they must respect because Yahweh had done this miracle by speaking through Joshua.

in the sight of all Israel: The phrase in the sight of all Israel indicates that all the people of Israel saw what Yahweh had done.

4:14b **and they revered him**

- They respected him greatly because of this
- So they honored him

and: The word and marks the result of what Yahweh did through Joshua's leadership. It might be more natural in some languages to translate this word with a word or phrase that expresses result, such as:

therefore

because of this

they revered him: The clause they revered him indicates that the Israelites honored and respected Joshua.

4:14c **all the days of his life,**

- for as long as he lived,
- for the rest of his life,

all the days of his life: The phrase all the days of his life refers to the rest of Joshua's life, or for as long as Joshua lived.

4:14d **just as they had revered Moses.**

- in the same way that they respected Moses.
- as much as they formerly honored Moses.

just as: The words just as mean "in the same way."

they had revered Moses: The clause they had revered Moses indicates that the Israelites had honored and respected Moses.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in the same way that they had honored Moses

Joshua 4:15

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:15

Then the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ Then Yahweh told Joshua:
- ¶ Yahweh commanded Joshua:

Then: The word Then indicates that the next action in the story is about to take place.

the LORD said to Joshua: It may be more natural in some languages to use a word such as:

Yahweh ordered Joshua

Yahweh commanded Joshua

Joshua 4:16

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:16a

“Command the priests who carry the ark of the Testimony

- “Tell the priests who are carrying the covenant box
- “Order the priests to bring the box with the Ten Commandments in it

Command the priests who carry the ark of the Testimony: The phrase the priests who carry the ark refers to the priests who carried the ark into the middle of the Jordan River.

the ark of the Testimony: The Testimony refers to the stone tablets on which Moses had written the Ten

Commandments. The ark of the Testimony and the “ark of the covenant” refer to the same box.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the ark of the covenantal laws (NET)

the box with the Ten Commandments in it

Some English versions translate this phrase in the same way that they translate “ark of the covenant.”

4:16b

to come up from the Jordan.”

- to come out of the Jordan River.”
- up out of the river bed.”

to come up from the Jordan: The phrase come up from the Jordan means that the priests should carry the ark from the middle of the riverbed where they were standing, across to the other side of the Jordan River.

In some languages, it might be more natural to change the indirect quote into a direct quote. For example, you could say:

Command the priests, “Come up out of the Jordan.”

Joshua 4:17

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:17a

So Joshua commanded the priests,

- So Joshua told the priests:
- Then Joshua gave this command to the priests:

So Joshua commanded the priests: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So indicates that the next action in the story is taking place. In this case, it also shows that Joshua's action is a response to God's command.

Here are some other way to translate this part of the verse:

and so Joshua commanded the priests

in obedience to God, Joshua commanded the priests

4:17b

“Come up from the Jordan.”

- “Bring the ark up from the riverbed.”
- “Carry the ark up out of the river.”

Come up from the Jordan: The clause Come up from the Jordan indicates that the priests should come up from the dry riverbed and cross to the west side of the Jordan River. It may be redundant in some languages to repeat this command, which uses almost the same words as in 4:16b. It may be more natural to summarize the action. For example:

Joshua did so (GNT)

So Joshua gave the command (NLT)

Joshua 4:18

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:18a

When the priests carrying the ark of the covenant of the LORD

- Then the priests who were carrying the ark of the covenant of Yahweh
- The priests who were carrying the covenant box of Yahweh

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” signals the next event in the storyline.

the ark of the covenant of the LORD: See how you translated this in 3:3.

4:18b

came up out of the Jordan

- came up out of the riverbed.
- brought the ark up from the middle of the river.

came up out of the Jordan: The clause came up out of the Jordan indicates that the priests came up from the middle of the dry riverbed to the west side of the Jordan River.

4:18c

and their feet touched the dry land,

- When their feet touched dry ground
- As soon as their feet stepped onto dry land,

touched the dry land: The phrase touched the dry land means that the priests stepped up out of the riverbed, and onto the dry ground. It may be more natural in some languages to leave the words touched implicit. For example:

And their feet were on high ground (NLT)

4:18d

the waters of the Jordan returned to their course

- the river water began to flow
- the Jordan River flowed again

the waters of the Jordan: Another way to translate this is:

the Jordan River

returned to their course: The phrase returned to their course means that the water began to flow again, as it had before the priests first stepped into the river.

4:18e

and overflowed all the banks as before.

- and flooded its banks again, as it was before.
- and the water was as high as it was before.

and overflowed all the banks as before: In 3:15 it says that the Jordan River was in flood. The clause overflowed all the banks as before indicates that the river now returned to being flooded again. The water was as high as it was before the priests stepped into it.

Joshua 4:19

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:19a

On the tenth day of the first month the people went up from the Jordan

- ¶ The Israelites crossed the Jordan River on the tenth day of the first month.
- ¶ On the tenth day of the first month of the year, Israel crossed the Jordan River.

On the tenth day of the first month: The first month refers to the month of the Hebrew calendar that was called Abib, and later called Nisan. This month began with the first new moon occurring after March 11. So, the people crossed the Jordan River between March 21 and April 18.4:19 Bratcher and Newman, p. 55.

the people went up from the Jordan: The Israelites walked out of the Jordan River and up onto the western bank.

4:19b

and camped at Gilgal on the eastern border of Jericho.

- They set up their camp in Gilgal, east of the city of Jericho.
- They set up their tents in a place called Gilgal, which was east of the land controlled by Jericho.

and camped: The word camped means that they set up a temporary camp or dwelling place. If there is no

appropriate word in your language for “camp” you can translate it:

they set up temporary homes

at Gilgal: Gilgal is the name of a place between Jericho and the Jordan River. At the time when the Israelites camped there, Gilgal was not yet a town. It was given the name Gilgal at the time of their encampment and probably later it became a town. The exact location of Gilgal is not known.

on the eastern border of Jericho: Jericho was a town with a large wall around it for protection against enemies.

Joshua 4:20

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:20a

And there at Gilgal Joshua set up

- Joshua set up at Gilgal as a monument
- Joshua commanded the men to set up as a memorial at Gilgal

Joshua set up: It is likely that Joshua commanded the men to set up the stones. He probably did not do this himself. However, this is not certain. You may wish to rearrange the parts of this verse, for example:

The men who had carried the twelve rocks from the Jordan brought them to Joshua, and they made them into a monument (CEV)

Joshua had the men set up a memorial with the twelve stones that they had taken from the Jordan River and carried to Gilgal

4:20b the twelve stones

- the twelve stones they carried with them
- those twelve stones

the twelve stones: The phrase the twelve stones refers to the twelve stones that Joshua told the men to take out of the Jordan River.

4:20c they had taken from the Jordan.

- that they took from the Jordan River.
- which they carried from the Jordan River.

they had taken from the Jordan: The word they refers to the twelve men whom Joshua chose to take the stones from the middle of the river.

General Comment on 4:20

In this verse the object (the stones) comes first and the subject (Joshua) comes after the verb. This is a device used in the Hebrew language to emphasize the stones. If possible, use the natural grammar of your language to give emphasis to the stones.

Joshua 4:21

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:21a Then Joshua said to the Israelites,

- Then Joshua told the Israelites:
- Then he said to the Israelites:

Then Joshua said to the Israelites: Joshua spoke to all the people of Israel. Earlier in 4:6 he spoke only to the twelve chosen men.

4:21b “In the future, when your children ask their fathers,

- “The children of future generations may ask their parents,
- “When your children ask you in the future

In the future, when your children ask their fathers: The word when creates a subordinate clause. In some languages, it may be more natural to use an independent clause. For example:

Years from now your children will ask you why these rocks are here. (CEV)

your children: The phrase your children refers to the present and future generations of Israelite children.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your descendants

your children and grandchildren

ask their fathers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fathers can refer to both mothers and fathers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When your children ask their fathers (ESV)

When your children ask their parents (NRSV)

In the future your children will ask (NLT)

4:21c ‘What is the meaning of these stones?’

- ‘Why are these rocks here?’
- what these stones represent.

What is the meaning of these stones?: The children will ask the question What is the meaning of these stones? because they want to know why the stones are there. The children of future generations will see the stones and wonder why they are arranged as a memorial in that place.

Joshua 4:22

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:22a

you are to tell them,

- Then you must explain to them,
- Then you must tell them this:

you are to tell them: The clause you are to tell them indicates that the parents of the children must explain to them the meaning of the stones.

In some languages, the quote formula between 4:22a-b may need to be made explicit. For example, you could say:

Then you should explain it to your children. Say to them...

4:22b

'Israel crossed the Jordan on dry ground.'

- 'The Israelites walked across the dry riverbed of the Jordan River.'
- 'The Jordan River dried up so that the nation of Israel could walk across it.'

Israel: The term Israel refers to all the Israelite people.

crossed: The word crossed means that the Israelite people walked across the Jordan River.

the Jordan: The phrase the Jordan refers to the Jordan River. This phrase is more literally "this Jordan." The word "this" probably adds emphasis: "this very Jordan River that you see before your eyes." In some languages it is not natural to include the word "this." Try to find a natural way to add emphasis. If you can't find a natural way to do this, then translate it as "the Jordan River."

on dry ground: The phrase on dry ground refers to the riverbed of the Jordan. This was dry because Yahweh made the river stop flowing.

Joshua 4:23

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:23a

For the LORD your God dried up the waters of the Jordan before you

- Yahweh your God made the Jordan River stop flowing so that
- Yahweh your God made a dry path across the Jordan River in front of you

For the LORD your God dried up the waters of the Jordan before you: It was Yahweh who made it possible for the people to cross the river. This theme of God's deliverance continues throughout the book of Joshua as the Israelites move in to conquer the land.

dried up: The words dried up mean that Yahweh made the water stop flowing.

the waters of the Jordan: It may be more natural in some languages to translate the phrase the waters of the Jordan as "the Jordan River."

4:23b

until you had crossed over,

- you could walk across the river bed.
- and kept it dry until you walked across on it.

until you had crossed over: The phrase crossed over means that they walked across the riverbed. God held back the water until they were all across on the west bank of the Jordan.

4:23c

just as He did to the Red Sea,

- He did this in the same way that he did when he parted the Red Sea.
- This was like when Yahweh made a path through the Red Sea.

just as: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as just as introduces a comparison.

He did to the Red Sea: This is a comparison. Yahweh rescued the Israelites many years ago at the Red Sea. In a similar way, he has rescued Israel once again at the Jordan River.

4:23d

which He dried up before us until we had crossed over.

- He made a dry path for us to walk on until we crossed to the other side.
- He dried up a path through the sea for us until we walked across.

which He dried up: God made a path for the Israelites to cross the Red Sea by making the waters stand like a wall on each side of the path. This story is told in Exodus 14:21–22.

before us: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as before us can also be translated as:

on our behalf

ahead of us (GW)

as we watched (NLT)

These three aspects of meaning all make sense in the context, and it is hard to know which meaning is more in focus. You should translate this phrase with the meaning that is most natural in your language.

until we had crossed over: The phrase until we had crossed over indicates that God held the water back until all the Israelites walked across to the other side of the Red Sea.

Joshua 4:24

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

4:24a

He did this so that all the peoples of the earth may know

- He did this so that every person in the whole world will know
- Because he has done this, every nation on the earth will understand

so that all the peoples of the earth may know: There is some implied information here. Yahweh did this so that all the people will know. For example:

He has done this so that all the nations of the earth might recognize the Lord's power (NET)

so that: The phrase so that indicates the reason why Yahweh dried up the Red Sea and the Jordan River.

all the peoples of the earth: The phrase all the peoples of the earth refers to all the nations that are in the world.

may know: The phrase may know indicates that everyone will know and understand that Yahweh is powerful.

4:24b

that the hand of the LORD is mighty,

- that Yahweh is powerful.
- that he has mighty power.

that: The word that introduces the content of what all the peoples of the earth should know.

the hand of the LORD is mighty: The phrase hand of the LORD is mighty is a Hebrew idiom that refers to Yahweh's power. Translate this idiom in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Yahweh is powerful

Yahweh has great power

4:24c

and so that you may always fear the LORD your God."

- And so that you will respect Yahweh your God and worship him forever.”
- He did this so that you will honor Yahweh your God forever.”

so that you may always fear the LORD your God:

There is implied information here. Yahweh did this so that you will fear him.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Yahweh did this so that you would fear him forever

so that: The phrase so that expresses purpose. It could also be translated “that” or “in order that.”

fear the LORD your God: The expression fear the LORD implies loyalty, respect, or honor of Yahweh. It means to be in awe of God’s greatness.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

honor the Lord your God (GNT)

worship him (CEV)

always obey the Lord your God (NET)

General Comment on 4:21–24

These verses repeat the theme that was introduced in 4:6–7]. This repetition emphasizes the importance of this commemoration event, and the great deliverance performed by God. It also emphasizes the unity of the Israelites as a nation specially chosen by God.

Joshua 5:1

Section 4:1–5:1 The Israelites commemorated the crossing of the Jordan River

Twelve men from among the Israelites each took a stone from the middle of the Jordan River. With these stones Joshua built a monument to remind the Israelite people, and their descendants, about how God helped them cross the river.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Setting up memorial stones

Twelve memorial stones

A reminder that God brought them to the promised land

Paragraph 5:1

This paragraph tells the reaction of the Israelites’ enemies when they heard about the things that God had done for the Israelites.

5:1a

Now when all the Amorite kings west of the Jordan

- ¶ All the Amorite kings who ruled the regions that were west of the Jordan River
- ¶ All the rulers of the Amor people who lived in the country west of the Jordan River

Now when all the Amorite kings west of the Jordan:

There is a contrast between the reaction of the Israelites and the reaction of their enemies, the Amorites and Canaanites. When the Israelites saw what God had done, they respected and honored him, but their enemies were terrified. There may be a word or particle in your language that will help to emphasize that contrast.

Amorite: The Amorite people were people who lived in the hills in the land of Canaan west of the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this name:

Amor people

kings: The word kings refers to the rulers of the small towns in the hills of Canaan. Each “king” ruled one town and the villages around it.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

rulers

leaders

west of the Jordan: The phrase west of the Jordan refers to the land on the west side of the Jordan River.

5:1b

and all the Canaanite kings along the coast

- and all the Canaanite kings who ruled the places on the seacoast
- and all the rulers of the Canaan people who lived near the sea heard about this.

and all the Canaanite kings: Here are some other ways to translate the word kings:

rulers

leaders

the Canaanite: The Canaanite people were people who lived in the land of Canaan west of the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Canaan people

along the coast: The phrase along the coast refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

who lived along the coast of the sea

who lived near the Mediterranean Sea

5:1c

heard how the LORD had dried up the waters of the Jordan before the Israelites

- heard that Yahweh made the Jordan River stop flowing for the Israelites.
- They heard that Yahweh made a dry path through the Jordan River.

heard: The Amorite and Canaanite kings heard that the Israelites had crossed the Jordan River.

how the LORD had dried up the waters of the Jordan: The main thing the kings heard was that the LORD had dried up the waters of the Jordan. They understood the significance of this. Now that the Israelites had crossed the river they were a threat to their safety, especially because a powerful God was helping them.

before the Israelites: There are two ways to understand the phrase before the Israelites:

1. God had acted on behalf of the people of Israel. For example:

the Lord had dried up the waters of the Jordan for the people of Israel (ESV) (ESV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NLT)

1. God had acted in the sight of the people of Israel. For example:

the Lord had dried up the Jordan before the Israelites (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and by many commentaries.

5:1d

until they had crossed over,

- They heard that they walked across to the other side.
- They heard that the Israelites walked over to the other side.

until they had crossed over: The phrase until they had crossed over indicates that God kept the Jordan River from flowing until the Israelites had walked across it.

they: There is a textual issue here.

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text reads: “until they had crossed over.” For example:

until they had crossed (NJB) (BSB, NJB, RSV, CEV, ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NCV, NJPS, NLT, GNT)

1. An alternate reading in the Hebrew Masoretic text reads: “until we had crossed over.” For example:

until we had crossed over (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The standard Hebrew text, nearly all the English versions, and most commentaries follow option (1).

5:1e

their hearts melted

- Then they became very afraid
- Then they no longer had any courage

their hearts melted: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as their hearts melted is an idiom. It means that the kings were afraid. There may be an idiom in your language that expresses this meaning in a vivid way.

5:1f

and their spirits failed

- and lost their courage to fight the people of Israel
- and they were terrified

and their spirits failed: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as and their spirits failed is an idiom. It means that the kings were afraid and lacked courage to fight against the Israelites.

The two idioms “their hearts melted” and their spirits failed mean the same thing. The Hebrew text uses two phrases to describe their fear to add emphasis to how fearful they were. In some languages, it may be helpful to combine the two idioms into one emphatic statement. For example, you could say:

The kings were very frightened

Use a way that is natural in your language to emphasize their fear.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The kings were very fearful and felt powerless to fight

5:1g for fear of the Israelites.

- because of what God did for the Israelites.
- and were afraid to fight the Israelites.

for fear of the Israelites: The phrase for fear of the Israelites indicates that they were fearful because of what God had done for the people of Israel. If this is not clear you might need to make this explicit. For example, you could say:

because of what God had done for the Israelites

Joshua 5:2

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:2a At that time the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ Then Yahweh commanded Joshua:
- ¶ While the Israelites were in their camp at Gilgal, Yahweh told Joshua:

At that time: The phrase At that time refers to the time while the Israelites lived in their tents at Gilgal. This is the same time to which verse 5:1 refers.

the LORD said: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Yahweh told them

Yahweh commanded them

5:2b “Make flint knives and circumcise the sons of Israel once again.”

- “Make knives from flint stones and do another ceremony to circumcise the men of Israel.”
- “Make stone knives and circumcise every man and boy who is not yet circumcised.”

Make flint knives and circumcise the sons of Israel: flint is a kind of stone that can be chipped until it forms a sharp edge. At this time humans were only just beginning to use iron, and flint knives were commonly used for cutting.

Here is another way to translate the term flint knives:

stone knives

circumcise: The verb circumcise means to cut off the foreskin of a man’s penis. This ceremony was first mentioned in Genesis 17:9–14 when Yahweh told Abraham to circumcise the men in his household. This was a sign, or a mark, of the covenant that God made with Abraham.

If you have translated the New Testament you should translate the word circumcise the same way you did there. For example, see Luke 1:59.

Consider whether you should use a euphemism or more general expression in your language to translate circumcise.

Here is another way to translate this word:

cutting ceremony

the sons of Israel: Only male people were circumcised. Normally, boys were circumcised when they were eight days old. It may be clearer to translate this as:

the men of Israel

the men and boys of Israel

once again: The phrase once again means that this is the second time that the nation of Israel had performed the ceremony of circumcision. The Israelite men who lived in Egypt were circumcised as children,

but that generation died while they walked through the wilderness. Now the men and boys who were born after the Israelites left Egypt must be circumcised. Normally, boys were circumcised when they were eight days old.

Joshua 5:3

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:3a

So Joshua made flint knives

- Then Joshua made stone knives,
- So, Joshua did as Yahweh commanded.

So Joshua made flint knives: It may be more natural in some languages not to repeat the information contained in the previous verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So Joshua did so

Then Joshua made the knives

5:3b

and circumcised the sons of Israel at Gibeath-haaraloth.

- and he circumcised the Israelite men and boys at Gibeath-haaraloth.
- He circumcised them at the Hill of the Foreskins.

and circumcised the sons of Israel: The phrase the sons of Israel refers to the Israelite men who were not yet circumcised. Women were not circumcised.

at Gibeath-haaraloth: The phrase Gibeath-haaraloth is a Hebrew phrase meaning “hill of the foreskins.” It may be better to translate the meaning of this phrase. For example:

Circumcision Hill (GNT)

the hill of the foreskins (KJV)

If you transliterate the phrase Gibeath-haaraloth, a footnote may be helpful. Here is a sample footnote:

FOOTNOTE: Gibeath-haaraloth means “hill of the foreskins”

Joshua 5:4

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:4a

Now this is why Joshua circumcised them:

- This is why Joshua circumcised the men:
- Joshua had to circumcise them because

Now this is why Joshua circumcised them: The phrase this is why refers ahead to verses 5:5–7 and adds emphasis. Choose a word or phrase that naturally indicates emphasis in your language. For example:

Joshua had to circumcise them because (NLT)

this is why it was necessary to circumcise them

5:4b

All those who came out of Egypt—all the men of war—

- All the men who were soldiers when they left Egypt
- after the Israelites left Egypt, all the men old enough to fight

All those who came out of Egypt—all the men of war: The two phrases All those who came out of Egypt and all the men of war refer to the same group

of people and can be translated by one phrase. For example:

all the men old enough to serve in the army (NCV)

all the soldiers (GW)

all the men of military age (NIV)

who came out of Egypt: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

After the Israelites left Egypt, all the men old enough to serve in the army (NCV)

All the men who were old enough to fight in battle when they left Egypt (NLT)

5:4c
had died on the journey in the wilderness after they had left Egypt.

- died in the wilderness after they left Egypt.
- died in the wilderness.

had died on the journey in the wilderness: The clause had died on the journey in the wilderness indicates that the men old enough to fight died while they walked through the wilderness.

after they had left Egypt: It may be redundant to translate this phrase in some languages because this information is already included in 5:4b.

Joshua 5:5

Section 5:2-12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:5a

Though all who had come out were circumcised,

- Even though the men who left Egypt were circumcised,
- The men who came out of Egypt were circumcised before they left Egypt,

Though all who had come out were circumcised: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Though is a connector to link verse 5a to 5b.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

although

even though

even though the men who left Egypt had been circumcised, the males born in the wilderness had not been circumcised

You should use the connector between these two clauses that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The men who left Egypt had been circumcised. However, the men born later...were not circumcised (GW)

Those who left Egypt had been circumcised. But none of those born after the Exodus...had been circumcised (NLT)

all: The word all refers to all the male people who had left Egypt. It does not refer to women.

5:5b

none of those born in the wilderness on the journey

- the men born later, on the way through the wilderness
- but all the boys born on the journey through the wilderness

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but the many English versions translate as “but” contrasts the men and boys who left Egypt with those who were born in the wilderness. Use a word that is natural in your language to show this contrast.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

yet

however

none of those: The phrase none of those refers to all the boys who were born in the wilderness. It does not refer to the women. The word none refers to the males born after the Israelite people left Egypt. If the reference is not clear, you may wish to make it explicit. For example:

The men who had come out of Egypt had been circumcised, but none of those who were born in the desert on the trip from Egypt had been circumcised. (NCV)

in the wilderness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a place where no people live. Some English versions translate this word as “desert.”

on the journey: The phrase on the journey refers to the time that the Israelites wandered in the wilderness. These boys were born during that time.

5:5c

from Egypt had been circumcised.

- after they left Egypt, never got circumcised.
- were not circumcised.

from Egypt had been circumcised: This phrase has been mentioned several times in previous verses, so it may be more natural to leave it implicit.

Joshua 5:6

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:6a

For the Israelites had wandered in the wilderness forty years,

- The Israelites walked through the wilderness for forty years
- The Israelites traveled in the wilderness for forty years.

For: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as For can also be translated as “because.” It connects verse 5 to verse 6, and it gives an explanation for what is stated in verse 5. Many English versions do not translate this word, and the function is implied. You should use a connecting word that is natural in your language to connect these two verses.

the Israelites had wandered in the wilderness forty years:

The Israelites walked from place to place in the wilderness. It took the Israelites forty years to reach Kadesh Barnea. Deuteronomy 1:2 states that they could have walked this distance in eleven days. The Israelites walked for forty years because they disobeyed Yahweh.

in the wilderness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wilderness refers to a place where no people live.

5:6b

until all the nation’s men of war who had come out of Egypt had died,

- until all the soldiers who left Egypt died
- During that time all the men old enough to fight when they left Egypt died.

until all the nation’s men of war: This phrase refers to men more than twenty years old and old enough to be soldiers.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

until all the nation, that is, the men of war (NASB)

In many languages it may be more natural to combine the two phrases or to delete all the nation’s. For example:

all their soldiers (GW)

all the men who were old enough to fight in battle (NLT)

the men in the army (CEV)

who had come out of Egypt: It was stated in the previous verse that they came out of Egypt, so it may be more natural in some languages to leave this information implicit.

5:6c**since they did not obey the LORD.**

- because they did not obey Yahweh.
- They died because they disobeyed Yahweh.

since: The word since introduces the reason why all these men died in the wilderness.

they did not obey the LORD: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as obey is literally “listen.” This is an idiom. It means “obey.”

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they did not obey what Yahweh had commanded

General Comment on 5:6a-c

It may be more natural in some languages to state the reason at the beginning of the sentence instead of at the end. You can reorder the verse so that 5:6c starts the verse. For example:

^{6c}The Israelites did not obey Yahweh. Because they disobeyed him, ^{6a}they had to walk in the wilderness for forty years ^{6b}until all of Israel’s soldiers died.

5:6d**So the LORD vowed**

- Because they disobeyed him, Yahweh made a solemn promise to them.
- So, Yahweh vowed to them

So the LORD vowed: The clause So the LORD vowed means that Yahweh made a promise to them. It may be more natural in some languages to put the indirect object in its normal order. For example:

the Lord had sworn to them (NIV)

Use whatever order is most natural in your language.

5:6e**never to let them see the land**

- He said he will not let them enter the land
- that they will not live long enough to see the land

never to let them see the land: The clause never to let them see the land indicates that Yahweh did not let them live long enough to enter the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he would not let them enter the land of Canaan

he would not let them live to see the land of Canaan

5:6f**He had sworn to their fathers to give us,**

- which he promised their ancestors to give us,
- he swore to give to them and to us.

He had sworn: The phrase He had sworn means that Yahweh made a vow or a promise.

to their fathers: The phrase to their fathers refers to their actual fathers and also their ancestors.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to their ancestors

to their fathers and grandfathers

to give us: There is implied information. The phrase to give us can also be translated as:

to give to us^(incl) Israelites

The writer of the book of Joshua wrote this many years later. When he said to give us he wrote about himself and the Israelites in his own time. He said that they also received what God had promised to their ancestors. 5:6 Bratcher and Newman, p. 62.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh did not let them see the land which he promised to their ancestors, and which he said that he would give to them and to us^(incl)

5:6g**a land flowing with milk and honey.**

- a rich and fertile land.
- That land is a fertile land, and produces lots of crops.

a land flowing with milk and honey: The phrase a land flowing with milk and honey is a Hebrew idiom. In this idiom the rivers flow with milk and honey instead of water. It means that the land was fertile and produced abundant crops. If possible, use vivid language or an idiom which conveys the same meaning in your own language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a very fertile land

a land which produces lots of crops

General Comment on 5:4–6

The structure of 5:4–6 is complex. Some English versions reorder these verses. If you find these verses difficult to translate, you might want to consider re-ordering them. For example:

^{4b}When the people of Israel left Egypt, ^{5a}all the males were already circumcised. ^{6a}However, during the forty years the people spent crossing the desert, ^{5c}none of the baby boys had been circumcised. ^{6b}Also, by the end of that time all the men who were of fighting age when they left Egypt had died ^{6c}because they had disobeyed the Lord. ^{6d}Just as he had sworn, ^{6e}they were not allowed to see ^{6g}the rich and fertile land ^{6f}that he had promised their ancestors. (GNT)

If you follow the GNT, you will need to look at how it translates 5:7. Verse 5:7 includes information that is implied at the beginning of the unit 5:4–6, specifically the statement about why these men had never been circumcised. Verse 5:7 in the GNT reads:

The sons of these men had never been circumcised, and it was this new generation that Joshua circumcised. (GNT)

You might also want to consider the CEV, which reorders 5:4–7.

Joshua 5:7

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:7a

And Joshua raised up their sons in their place,

- Their sons were the people whom God chose to replace them.
- So, Joshua circumcised their sons, those who grew up in place of their fathers.

And: Verse 7 is a summary of verses 5–6. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And is a connector word. It shows the relationship between this verse and the preceding verses.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

That is why

In light of that

So, for that reason

You should translate this word with a connecting word or phrase that is most natural in your language.

Joshua raised up their sons in their place: The phrase raised up their sons in their place could mean that either God or Joshua allowed the sons of the men who had died to take their place. Although the BSB translates this clause as if Joshua raised up these people, most English versions follow the Hebrew and use the pronoun “he,” which can refer to either interpretation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he raised up their sons in their place (NIV)

he replaced them with their sons (NET)

their sons—those who had grown up to take their fathers’ places (NLT)

raised up their sons: The phrase their sons is the object of the sentence, and it is emphasized in the Hebrew text. The construction raised up their sons is a way of emphasizing their sons in English. You should choose a way that is natural in your language to emphasize this phrase.

their sons: The phrase their sons refers to the male children of the people who died in the wilderness because they disobeyed God. And their sons make up the same group of men as those referred to in verse 5:4a.

5:7b

and these were the ones he circumcised.

- Joshua circumcised their sons
- Joshua circumcised these sons,

these were the ones he circumcised: The clause these were the ones refers to the words “their sons” in verse 5:7a. Joshua circumcised the sons of the men who died in the wilderness. It may be more natural to reorder the verse. You could put the relative clause next to the noun it modifies. For example, you could say:

So, it was their children whom Joshua circumcised, those whom God had raised up instead of them

5:7c

Until this time they were still uncircumcised,

- because they had not been circumcised before.
- for they had not yet been circumcised

Until this time they were still uncircumcised: It may be more natural in some languages to leave this clause implicit and untranslated, because the meaning is included in 5:7d. Consider whether such repetition is natural in your language.

5:7d

since they had not been circumcised along the way.

- No one was circumcised while Israel walked through the wilderness.
- in the wilderness.

since they had not been circumcised along the way: The phrase along the way refers to the time that the Israelites walked through the wilderness for forty years.

Joshua 5:8

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:8a

And after all the nation had been circumcised,

- ¶ When all the men were circumcised
- ¶ When they finished circumcising all the men,

And after all the nation had been circumcised: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When all the Israelite men had been circumcised

When they had finished circumcising all the men of Israel

all the nation: The phrase the nation refers to all the Israelite men. It does not refer to women.

5:8b

they stayed there in the camp

- they stayed in the camp
- everyone stayed in the camp

they stayed there in the camp: The clause they stayed there in the camp indicates that all the Israelite males stayed in the place where they had set up their camp and did not go anywhere.

5:8c

until they were healed.

- until they were healed.
- until the men were well again.

until they were healed: The clause until they were healed means until their wounds from the cutting of circumcision were healed and they were no longer sore.

Joshua 5:9

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

5:9a**Then the LORD said to Joshua,**

- Then Yahweh told Joshua:
- Then Yahweh said to Joshua:

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then signals the next event in the storyline. Use a connecting word in your language that shows that the next event in the story line is taking place.

the LORD said to Joshua: If it is necessary for this verb to have an explicit object, you can add “these words” or “this.” For example:

Yahweh said these words to Joshua

5:9b**“Today I have rolled away the reproach of Egypt from you.”**

- “Today I have taken the disgrace of being slaves in Egypt away from you.”
- “It was shameful for you to be slaves in Egypt. But now I have removed your shame.”

Today: The word Today means “this day” or “now.”

I have rolled away: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I have rolled away is a Hebrew idiom. It means “to remove” or “to take away.”

the reproach of Egypt from you: The phrase the reproach of Egypt refers to the shame the Israelites suffered while they were slaves in Egypt. Being circumcised was the final step in their freedom from this shame.

The reproach does not mean that the Israelites could not be circumcised in Egypt.^{5:9} See the footnote in NET at verse 5:9 about “disgrace of Egypt.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I have removed from you the disgrace of being slaves in Egypt (GNT)

It was shameful for you to be slaves in Egypt. Now I have taken away your shame

5:9c**So that place has been called Gilgal to this day.**

- That is why they named that place Gilgal, the name it still has today.
- Because of this, Joshua gave that place the name Gilgal, which it is still named today.

So: The word So can also be translated:

therefore

for this reason

that place has been called Gilgal: The Israelites called this place Gilgal when they made their camp there. It was not yet a town at that time. Later it became a center of worship.^{5:9} Rasmussen, p. 236. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

that place is called Gilgal

they named that place Gilgal

that place: The phrase that place refers to where the Israelites camped and were circumcised.

Gilgal: The name Gilgal sounds similar to the Hebrew word which means “to roll.” This is a pun on the idiom “I have rolled away the reproach of Egypt from you.” If you have used the idiom “roll” in verse 9b you could include this information in a footnote. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The name Gilgal sounds like the Hebrew word “roll”

to this day: The phrase to this day means “until now” or “until today” and refers to the time when the author was writing the book of Joshua.

Joshua 5:10**Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover**

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

Paragraph 5:10–12

The Israelites celebrated Passover in Canaan and they started to eat the food that grew there. The manna that God gave them in the wilderness for forty years stopped coming, because now God had brought them to the end of their journey.

5:10a**On the evening of the fourteenth day of the month,**

- On the evening of the fourteenth day of the first month,
- On the evening of the fourteenth day of the first month,

On the evening: The Israelites considered the evening to be the beginning of a new day. The evening was the beginning of the fourteenth day.

of the fourteenth day of the month: The phrase the fourteenth day of the month refers to the fourteenth day of the first month in the Jewish calendar. They crossed the Jordan River was on the tenth day of the first month (see 4:19a). They celebrated the Passover four days after they crossed the river.

5:10b**while the Israelites were camped at Gilgal**

- ¶ while the Israelites were still in the camp at Gilgal,
- ¶ the people of Israel continued to camp at Gilgal,

while the Israelites were camped at Gilgal: The clause while the Israelites were camped at Gilgal can also be translated:

during the time that the Israelites set up their tents at Gilgal

5:10c**on the plains of Jericho,**

- in the plain in front of Jericho City,
- in the fields not far from Jericho,

on the plains of Jericho: The town of Jericho was about ten kilometers west of the Jordan River on the plains, a level area of land. This land extended from Jericho to the Jordan River. Gilgal was also on this plain, probably a few miles northeast of Jericho.

5:10d**they kept the Passover.**

- they celebrated the Passover feast.
- they ate the Passover feast.

they kept the Passover: The clause they kept the Passover indicates that the Israelites celebrated the Passover feast.

Passover: The Passover feast and the regulations about it are described in Exodus 12:1–20 and in Leviticus 23:4–8. This feast reminded the Israelites of the time when God delivered them from being slaves in Egypt.

If you have translated the New Testament, you should translate the term the Passover the same way here. For example, see Matthew 26:2.

Joshua 5:11**Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover**

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

Paragraph 5:10–12

The Israelites celebrated Passover in Canaan and they started to eat the food that grew there. The manna that God gave them in the wilderness for forty years stopped coming, because now God had brought them to the end of their journey.

5:11a**The day after the Passover,**

- The next morning, after they had celebrated the Passover,
- The next day after they ate the Passover feast,

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but the many other English versions translate as “And” signals the next event in the storyline.

The day after: The phrase The day after refers to the morning after the Israelites had eaten the Passover feast.

the Passover: It may be more natural in some languages to translate this phrase as a clause. For example:

they ate the Passover feast

they celebrated the Passover

5:11b

on that very day, they ate unleavened bread and roasted grain from the produce of the land.

- they began to eat the crops that grew in that land. They made bread without yeast and roasted grain.
- on that same day, they ate food made from barley from the fields there, unleavened bread and grain roasted over a fire.

on that very day, they ate: The phrase on that very day emphasizes that now the Israelites could eat the crops that grew in the land of Canaan.

unleavened bread: The phrase unleavened bread refers to loaves of barley bread that they made without yeast.

and roasted grain: The phrase roasted grain refers to barley grain that they roasted over a fire.

from the produce of the land: The phrase the produce of the land refers to barley grain. Barley was ready to harvest at this time (see 3:15). The Israelites gathered barley from the fields belonging to the people of Jericho.

Joshua 5:12

Section 5:2–12 Joshua circumcised the men, and the Israelites observed Passover

Joshua circumcised the Israelite men, because they had not done this ceremony while they walked through the wilderness for forty years. Then the Israelites observed the Passover ceremony. They ate food from the land of Canaan, and God stopped sending them manna.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Circumcision of the next generation

Circumcision and the first Passover in the promised land

Paragraph 5:10–12

The Israelites celebrated Passover in Canaan and they started to eat the food that grew there. The manna that God gave them in the wilderness for forty years stopped coming, because now God had brought them to the end of their journey.

5:12a

And the day after they had eaten from the produce of the land,

- Because they could eat things that grew in the land there,
- That morning, since they had food to eat from the land,
- After they started eating food from the land of Canaan

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And signals the next event in the storyline.

the day after: The phrase the day after refers to the morning after the Israelites celebrated the Passover feast. This was the day that the Israelites began to eat food from the land of Canaan.

they had: The word had marks a transitional event. Yahweh stopped sending manna when they ate the produce from the land.

eaten from the produce of the land: The phrase produce of the land refers to the barley grain that the Israelites gathered to roast and to make into bread.

5:12b

the manna ceased.

- God stopped sending manna.
- God stopped sending them manna.
- they stopped getting manna to eat.

the manna: The manna is the food that Yahweh gave to the Israelites every morning while they walked through the wilderness. It is described in Exodus 16:13–16.

ceased: The word ceased means “stopped.” The manna appeared on the ground every morning for forty years. Now it no longer appeared. There is implied information: Yahweh is the one who sent the manna, and who stopped sending it.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Yahweh stopped sending the manna

5:12c

There was no more manna for the Israelites,

- So, the Israelites no longer gathered manna to eat.
- The manna that the Israelites ate for a long time came to an end.

There was no more manna for the Israelites: The clause There was no more manna for the Israelites indicates that God no longer sent them manna from the sky.

5:12d

so that year they began to eat the crops of the land of Canaan.

- That year they ate food gathered from what grew in the land of Canaan.
- From that time on, they ate food that grew in the land of Canaan.

that year they began to eat the crops of the land of Canaan: The clause the crops of the land of Canaan has the same meaning as the clause “the produce of the land” in 12a.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

that year they ate things that grew in the land of Canaan

The Israelites conquered Jericho, Ai, and many other towns in the southern part of the land of Canaan. God helped them, and through these events they learned to depend on him.

Joshua 5:13

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

5:13a

Now when Joshua was near Jericho,

- ¶ While Joshua was near Jericho,
- ¶ One day, Joshua was near Jericho,

Now when: This sentence introduces a new section of the story. In many languages it is natural to start a new section with a time word.

Here is another way to translate this word:

One day...

Joshua was near Jericho: The Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as near means that Joshua was near the town of Jericho. Perhaps he had come close to the town to spy on it and plan his strategy.

5:13b

he looked up and saw

- he suddenly saw
- and he was surprised to see

he looked up: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as he looked up is used to show that something unexpected is going to happen. It may not be natural in some languages to translate he looked up literally. Use an expression or grammatical device that shows that something surprising is going to happen. It is also possible to leave this phrase untranslated. For example:

While Joshua was near Jericho, he suddenly saw a man (GNT)

One day, Joshua was near Jericho when he saw a man (CEV)

and saw: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as and saw is another way that the Hebrew language focuses attention on what is going to happen next. You may have a similar expression in your language. It is also possible to leave this phrase untranslated.

5:13c

a man standing in front of him with a drawn sword in His hand.

- a man standing in front of him holding a sword.
- a man who stood in front of him with his sword in his hand.

a man standing in front of him: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as man refers to a male person. Some commentators believe that this man was an angel. Others believe that this was Yahweh.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

a man stood in front of him

with a drawn sword in His hand: The phrase with a drawn sword means that he had taken the sword out of its sheath. It was in his hand and was ready to use.

5:13d

Joshua approached Him and asked,

- So, Joshua walked up to him and asked him:
- Then Joshua went near him and asked him:

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and shows that this is the next event in the storyline.

Joshua approached Him and asked: The clause Joshua approached Him and asked can also be translated as:

Joshua approached the man and said

5:13e

“Are You for us or for our enemies?”

- “Are you on our side, or are you against us?”
- “Are you one of our friends, or are you an enemy?”

Are You for us or for our enemies?: Joshua asked this question to find out if the man would fight with the Israelites or against them. The word enemies means “adversaries.”

for us: With the phrase for us Joshua asked the man if he was a friend of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one of our friends

somebody one our side

for our enemies: With the phrase our enemies Joshua asked the man if he was an enemy of the Israelites.

one of our enemies

somebody who is against us

Joshua 5:14

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

5:14a

“Neither,” He replied.

- The man said: “I am not on your side and I am not against you.

- Then that man answered Joshua: “No, I am not either one.

Neither: The man answered Neither to indicate that he did not fit into either of the groups that Joshua named. He is not an Israelite soldier and he is not an enemy soldier. It may be helpful to repeat the information from Joshua’s question. For example, you could say:

No, I am not one of your friends, and I am not one of your enemies

He replied: The word He refers to the man who stood before Joshua.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Then the man replied to Joshua

5:14b

“I have now come as Commander of the LORD’s army.”

- I have come as the commander of Yahweh’s army.”
- I am here because I am the general of Yahweh’s army.”

I have now come as Commander of the LORD’s army: The man who appeared before Joshua identified himself as the Commander of the LORD’s army. Many commentators believe that this man was an angel. The phrase LORD’s army probably refers to the angels who help fight Yahweh’s battles. This commander came to take charge of the Israelite army. If Joshua and the Israelites obey the commander of Yahweh’s army, then they are also part Yahweh’s army, fighting on God’s side.

I have now come: The man told Joshua that he had come to Jericho to carry out his duty as the commander of Yahweh’s army. He came to accomplish God’s plan, not Israel’s.

Commander: A Commander of an army is the person in charge of the army.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

general

leader

5:14c

Then Joshua fell facedown in reverence

- Then Joshua bowed down and put his face to the ground,
- Joshua bowed down to the ground to show his respect.

Then Joshua fell facedown in reverence: The expression fell facedown means that Joshua bowed down and touched his forehead on the ground. He did this to show his respect for the leader of Yahweh's army.

fell facedown in reverence: The action of bowing was a form of respect given to people, as well as to God. For example, in Genesis 23:7 Abraham bowed down out of respect to the Hittites, the local inhabitants of Canaan.

It is not clear whether the man in 5:13–15 is an angel or is Yahweh himself. You should avoid implying that Joshua worshiped an angel. If necessary you could say that Joshua bowed “with respect” or use the BSB's in reverence. For example:

Joshua bowed down to the ground to show his respect

5:14d

and asked Him, “What does my Lord have to say to His servant?”

- and asked: “What command does my master have for me, his servant?”
- Then Joshua said: “I am your servant, sir. Tell me what to do.”

and asked Him: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Then he asked him

Joshua asked the man

What does my Lord have to say to His servant?:

Joshua spoke to the man in the third person. He did not use the second person pronoun “you.” In Hebrew, this choice of pronoun was a way to show respect. In some languages it may be clearer to use second person forms. For example:

I am your servant, sir. What do you want me to do? (GNT)

There may be another grammatical form or particle that shows respect in some languages. Use a form that is natural in your language.

my Lord: The term my Lord is a term of respect. It is not the word Yahweh. Use a term that shows respect when speaking to a superior.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

my master

my boss

have to say to His servant: The word say here means “command.” Joshua asked the man what he wanted him to do. It is also possible to translate this question as a statement as in the CEV:

“I am your servant,” he said. “Tell me what to do.” (CEV)

Joshua 5:15

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

5:15a

The Commander of the LORD's army replied,

- Then the commander of Yahweh's army answered Joshua:
- Then he told Joshua:

The Commander of the LORD's army replied: It may not be natural in some languages to repeat the whole phrase The Commander of the LORD's army again. It may be more natural to refer to the Commander as “the man” or by the pronoun “he.” For example:

he said to Joshua

the man said to Joshua

5:15b-c

Take off your sandals, for the place where you are standing is holy: This command is the same as the one that God gave Moses in Exodus 3:5 when Moses stood before the burning bush.

5:15b

“Take off your sandals,

- “Take your shoes off your feet,
- “Take off your sandals.

Take off your sandals: The command Take off your sandals means that Joshua must take off his shoes.

sandals: The people of that time wore sandals on their feet. If you have a word that means sandals in your language, it would be more accurate to use it. Otherwise the generic word “shoes” is appropriate.

5:15c

for the place where you are standing is holy.”

- because the place where you are standing is holy.”
- This is a holy place.”

for the place where you are standing is holy: The place where Joshua is standing is holy because of the presence of the man, or the angel, who represents God. The word holy means that something or someone is set apart for God.

5:15d

And Joshua did so.

- So, Joshua took off his sandals.
- And Joshua obeyed him.

And Joshua did so: Joshua obeyed the commander’s orders and took off his shoes.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

And Joshua obeyed him

Joshua 6:1

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:1a

Now Jericho was tightly shut up

- ¶ The gates of Jericho were closed securely
- ¶ The gates in the wall of Jericho City were locked up tight.

Now: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a parenthetical comment about Jericho.

Jericho was tightly shut up: The phrase Jericho was tightly shut up means that the gates in the wall around the town were closed so that they could not be opened from the outside.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they closed the gates in the town wall

Jericho: Jericho was a town with a wall built around it for protection against its enemies.

tightly shut up: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as tightly shut up is more literally “was shutting and shut up.” This is an idiom. It means that the gates were locked securely.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the gates were shut and locked securely

the gates were locked/barred tightly

6:1b

because of the Israelites.

- because the people were afraid of the Israelites.
- They locked them to keep out the Israelites.

because of the Israelites: The phrase because of the Israelites indicates that they closed the town gates because they were afraid of the Israelites. They were afraid that the Israelite army would conquer their town.

6:1c

No one went out and no one came in.

- Nobody could enter and nobody could leave.
- No one could go out or in.

No one went out and no one came in: The clause No one went out and no one came in indicates that the Jericho people didn’t allow anybody to enter or leave their town. It shows how fearful the people of Jericho were of the Israelites.

Joshua 6:2

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:2a

And the LORD said to Joshua,

- Then Yahweh told Joshua:
- And Yahweh said to Joshua:

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline.

the LORD said to Joshua: In 5:14–15 the commander of Yahweh’s army spoke to Joshua. In chapter 6 Yahweh himself spoke to Joshua. It is recommended that you distinguish between these two names.

6:2b

“Behold, I have delivered Jericho into your hand,

- “Look, I have given you^(sing) Jericho
- “Pay attention, Joshua. I will help you capture Jericho City.

Behold: The command Behold is a way to call attention to the importance of what Yahweh told Joshua. You may have an idiom that emphasizes the importance of what someone is saying. Some English versions leave this word untranslated, and it may be more natural to do so in your language.

I have delivered Jericho into your hand: The clause I have delivered Jericho into your hand is an idiom. It means that Yahweh will help Joshua and the Israelites to conquer Jericho. You may have a similar idiom that expresses this idea. If there is no appropriate idiom, you should translate the meaning. For example:

I will enable you^(sing) to capture Jericho

with my help you will conquer Jericho

6:2c

along with its king and its mighty men of valor.

- with its king, and its brave soldiers.
- You^(sing) will defeat the king and the strong fighting men.

along with its king: The phrase its king refers to the king of Jericho.

and its mighty men of valor: The phrase mighty men of valor refers to the soldiers of Jericho.

valor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as valor can also be translated as “strong” or “brave.”

General Comment on 6:2b–c

It may be more natural in some languages to reorder 2b and 2c. For example:

With my help, you will defeat the king of Jericho and his brave soldiers, and you will conquer Jericho

Joshua 6:3

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:3a

March around the city

- You must walk in procession around the city
- Walk around the walls of the city

March around the city: The clause March around the city is a command. It indicates that Joshua and the Israelite soldiers must walk in a procession around the town wall.

March around: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as March around is literally “go around.” The English word “march” indicates that soldiers are walking. Use an expression that is natural in your language for this action.

6:3b

with all the men of war, circling the city one time.

- with your soldiers once a day.

- with all the soldiers once a day.

with all the men of war, circling the city one time:

The phrase all the men of war refers to the Israelite soldiers. The number of Israelite soldiers is given in 4:13 is about 40,000. In verse 4 we learn that seven priests also walked around the town.

circling the city one time: There is implied information. They were to walk around the town once each day. For example:

You and your soldiers are to march around the city once a day (GNT)

6:3c

Do this for six days.

- You must do this for six days.
- Do this for six days in a row.

Do this for six days: The army and priests must walk around the town of Jericho once every day for six consecutive days.

Joshua 6:4

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:4a

Have seven priests carry seven rams' horns

- Seven priests must carry trumpets made from rams' horns,
- Seven priests will carry sheep horns and blow on them.

The Hebrew conjunction that BSB and many English versions leave untranslated can also be translated as "and." For example:

And seven priests shall bear seven trumpets of rams' horns (RSV)

Have seven priests carry seven rams' horns: The clause Have seven priests carry seven rams' horns is a command. The priests are to carry the seven horns.

There is some implied information. Verse 6:9 makes it clear that the priests blew the horns as they carried them. If it is clearer in your language you may include that information in this verse.

seven rams' horns: A "ram" is a male sheep. These horns were musical instruments made from the horns of male sheep. Female sheep also have horns, but the horns of male sheep are usually larger.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

trumpets made from horns of male sheep (NCV)

sheep horn trumpets

6:4b

in front of the ark.

- and walk in front of the ark.
- They should walk ahead of the covenant box.

in front of the ark: The phrase in front of the ark means that the priests were to walk in front of the ark.

the ark: The term the ark refers to the wooden box that was the symbol of Yahweh's presence. See how you translated this term in 3:3.

6:4c

Then on the seventh day, march around the city seven times,

- On the seventh day you must walk around the city seven times,
- And on the seventh day you are to walk around the city seven times.

Then on the seventh day, march around the city seven times: This is a command. On the first six days they were to walk around the town once a day. On the seventh day they must walk around the town seven times.

march around: The phrase march around is a plural command that refers to Joshua, the seven priests who carried the horns, the four priests who carried the ark, and the soldiers. These people walked around the town in a group together.

6:4d

while the priests blow the horns.

- while the priests blow the trumpets as they walk with you.
- And have the priests blow their horns.

while the priests blow the horns: On the seventh day, the priests blew the horns continuously as they walked around the town seven times.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests must blow their trumpets without stopping while you walk

General Comment on 6:4–20

In this and following verses, the “rams’ horns” are sometimes referred to as “trumpets” and sometimes as “horns.” It may be clearer to choose one term for these trumpets that is natural in your language and then continue to use the same term each time.

Joshua 6:5

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:5a

And when there is a long blast of the ram’s horn

- After the seventh day’s walk, they must sound one long note on the trumpet.
- Then they are to blow a long sound on their horns.

And: The word And introduces the next command that Yahweh gave to Joshua. Many English versions use a temporal connector such as “then.”

Here is another way to translate this word:

Then, when they make a long blast

Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

when there is a long blast: On the seventh day, they are to walk around the town seven times, with the priests blowing their trumpets. After the seventh time around, they are to blow a long loud sound on their trumpets.

of the ram’s horn: The term ram’s horn refers to the trumpets that the priests blew. It may be more natural in some languages to leave this reference to the ram’s horn implicit, as in GNT:

Then they are to sound one long note. (GNT)

6:5b

and you hear its sound,

- As soon as you hear that trumpet sound,
- When you hear it

and you hear: The pronoun you refers to Joshua and the soldiers in the Israelite army.

its sound: The phrase its sound refers to the long sound that the priests are to blow with horns after they walk around the town the seventh time.

6:5c

have all the people give a mighty shout.

- then all the soldiers must shout loudly.
- have the whole army give a big shout.

have all the people: The phrase all the people refers to the soldiers.

give a mighty shout: The clause give a mighty shout is a command. This is a Hebrew idiom that means that the soldiers must shout loudly.

6:5d

Then the wall of the city will collapse

- Then the walls around the city will collapse.
- Then the city walls will fall down.

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then expresses the result of their action. The wall of the town will fall when the soldiers shout. Use a word in your language that expresses result.

the wall of the city: Jericho had a wall made of stone and brick built around it. It may be necessary to make this clear by adding the implicit information:

the wall around the town

will collapse: The phrase will collapse means that the stones and bricks in the wall will fall apart and collapse onto the ground.

6:5e

and all your people will charge straight into the city.”

- Then every soldier must run straight ahead of him into the city.”

- Tell the soldiers to go straight into the city from where they are.”

and all your people: The term all your people refers to the Israelite soldiers.

will charge: The phrase will charge is a command. It indicates that the soldiers must climb over the rubble of the wall and enter the town.

straight into the city: The phrase straight into the city means that every soldier must run straight over the collapsed wall and into the town, starting from where he is standing when the walls collapse.

General Comment on 6:3–5

In verses 3–5 Yahweh gave commands to Joshua about what he and the Israelite army must do. In verses 6–20 the story is told of how the Israelites carried out Yahweh’s command.

Joshua 6:6

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:6a

So Joshua son of Nun summoned the priests and said,

- ¶ So Joshua son of Nun called the priests together and told them:
- ¶ So Joshua whose father was Nun summoned the priests and said to them:

So: The word So connects the preceding verses with what Joshua did next. It shows that Joshua obeyed the commands of Yahweh.

Joshua son of Nun: See how you translated this phrase in Joshua 1:1.

summoned the priests and said: The clause summoned the priests means that Joshua told the priests to come together so that he could give them his instructions.

6:6b

“Take up the ark of the covenant and

- “Take the ark of the covenant.
- “Carry the covenant box.

Take up: The phrase Take up means that some of the priests must pick up and carry the ark of the covenant.

the ark of the covenant: The term the ark of the covenant refers to the wooden box that was the symbol of Yahweh’s presence. See how you translated this term in 3:3.

6:6c

have seven priests carry seven rams’ horns in front of the ark of the LORD.”

- Tell seven priests to carry seven trumpets made of rams’ horns and walk in front of it.”
- Have seven priests who each hold a sheep horn walk ahead of the box.”

and have seven priests carry: Joshua ordered seven priests to each take a trumpet.

seven rams’ horns: The words seven rams’ horns indicates that each of the seven priests had one ram’s horn.

in front of the ark of the LORD: The phrase in front of the ark of the LORD means that the priests must walk ahead of the ark and blow their trumpets.

the ark of the LORD: The term the ark of the LORD is another way that the Hebrew language refers to the “ark of the covenant” that is mentioned in verse 6:6b. It may be clearer in some languages to use the same term as you used in 6:6b.

Joshua 6:7

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:7a

And he told the people,

- Then he ordered the soldiers and priests:
- Next, Joshua gave the army their orders. He said:

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. Use a connector that is natural in your language.

he told: The word he refers to Joshua.

the people: The word people refers to the Israelite priests and the soldiers.

6:7b

“Advance and march around the city,

- “Start walking. Walk around the city.
- “Go now. Go around the city.

Advance: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Advance is more literally “pass on.” This is a command and a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that the soldiers and the priests should begin to walk.

march around the city: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as march around the city is a command. It indicates that the soldiers should walk around the town.

6:7c

with the armed troops going ahead of the ark of the LORD.”

- Have one group of soldiers go ahead of the ark of Yahweh.”
- Some soldiers with their weapons should walk ahead of the covenant box of Yahweh.”

with the armed troops going ahead of the ark of the LORD: Joshua commanded that some of the soldiers must walk in front of the ark. There is implied information. Only some of the soldiers walked in front of the ark. There were also soldiers following the ark (see 6:9).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

have one group of soldiers walk in front of the ark of Yahweh

with an advance guard going on ahead of the Lord’s Covenant Box (GNT)

Joshua 6:8

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they

conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:8a

After Joshua had spoken to the people,

- ¶ And the people did as Joshua told them to.
- ¶ Then the soldiers and priests obeyed Joshua.

After: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as After indicates that the next event in the story is happening.

Joshua had spoken to the people: It may be more natural in your language to translate the clause Joshua had spoken to the people as an independent sentence. For example:

the soldiers and priests obeyed Joshua

the people: The phrase the people refers to the soldiers and the priests who blew the trumpets and carried the ark.

6:8b

seven priests carrying seven rams’ horns before the LORD

- The seven priests began walking in front of the ark with their trumpets.
- The seven priests who each held a trumpet walked in front of the presence of Yahweh.

seven priests carrying seven rams’ horns before the LORD:

The phrase seven priests refers to the priests who carried the trumpets and walked in front of the ark.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests with their trumpets started walking ahead of the presence of Yahweh

before the LORD: The phrase before the LORD is another way to refer to the ark. The ark represented the presence of Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

before the ark of Yahweh

before the presence of Yahweh

6:8c

advanced and blew the horns,

- As they walked, they blew the trumpets.
- They walked and blew their trumpets.

advanced and blew the horns: The priests walked in front of the ark. They blew their trumpets while they walked.

6:8d

and the ark of the covenant of the LORD followed them.

- The ark of the covenant of Yahweh followed them.
- The priests who carried the ark of the covenant of Yahweh followed behind them.

and the ark of the covenant of the LORD followed them: The Hebrew language uses the full term the ark of the covenant of the LORD in order to emphasize its importance. If it is not natural to repeat all this information, some of it may be left implicit. For example:

the ark of Yahweh

the ark of the covenant

If possible, use a way to add emphasis that is natural in your language.

followed them: Verse 6:8b has already mentioned that the priests went ahead of the ark. It may not be natural in your language to include the information that the ark followed them. If you include this information, it may be necessary to make explicit that some of the priests carried the ark. For example:

behind these came the priests who were carrying the covenant box (GNT)

Joshua 6:9

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:9a

While the horns continued to sound,

- The priests blew their trumpets without stopping.
- And the priests continually blew their trumpets.

While the horns continued to sound: This indicates that the priests blew the trumpets continually.

6:9b

the armed troops marched ahead of the priests who blew the horns,

- Soldiers with their weapons walked in front of the priests who were blowing their trumpets,
- Some of the armed men walked in front of the priests who blew the horns,

the armed troops: The phrase the armed troops refers to the group of soldiers mentioned in verse 6:7c.

marched ahead of the priests: These soldiers walked ahead of the priests. The priests walked behind the soldiers and blew the trumpets.

6:9c

and the rear guard followed the ark.

- and more soldiers walked behind the ark.
- and some of the armed men walked after the ark.

and the rear guard: There was also a group of soldiers who walked behind the ark of Yahweh. This is the first time the rear guard has been mentioned. This is a characteristic of Hebrew narrative style, which adds new information bit by bit as the story progresses. If this method of adding new information is not natural in your language, it may be better to combine verses 8 and 9 and add the information in logical order, as the GNT does. See the General Comment on 6:8–9.

followed the ark: The soldiers walked behind the priests who carried the ark. There is implied information here. The Hebrew text does not mention that there were priests who carried the ark. It may be helpful to make this information explicit in some languages. For example:

and the rear guard came after the priests who were carrying the ark

General Comment on 6:8–9

It may be more natural in some languages to rearrange the information in verses 8–9 and mention the groups of people who are walking in their order. In this case, verses 8–9 may be combined, as GNT as done:

^{8a}So, just as Joshua had ordered, ^{9b,8b,8c}an advance guard started out ahead of the priests who were blowing trumpets; ^{8d}behind these came the priests who were carrying the Covenant Box, ^{9c}followed by a rear guard. ^{9a}All this time the trumpets were sounding. (GNT)

Joshua 6:10

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:10a

But Joshua had commanded the people:

- But Joshua told the people:
- Joshua ordered the soldiers and the priests

But Joshua had commanded the people: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But marks a contrast. The priests blew on the trumpets, but the people were not allowed to speak until the seventh day. Use a natural way to express this contrast in your language.

the people: The words the people refers to the soldiers and the priests.

6:10b

“Do not give a battle cry or let your voice be heard;

- “Don't shout. Don't let anybody hear your voice.
- not to shout, or make any noise,

Do not give a battle cry or let your voice be heard:

The two clauses Do not give a battle cry and let your voice be heard have a similar meaning. This is a way to give an emphatic command to the soldiers that they must be silent until Joshua tells them to shout. You should translate this part of the verse with an emphatic expression in your language.

6:10c

do not let one word come out of your mouth until the day I tell you to shout.

- Don't say a single word.
- or let one word come out of their mouths

6:10d

Then you are to shout!”

- On the day I tell you, then you can shout.”
- until the day that he told them to.

6:10c-d

do not let one word come out of your mouth: The clause do not let one word come out of your mouth emphasizes that the soldiers must not say anything. It may be more natural in some languages to combine 10b and c and use an emphatic idiom or particle to convey the same meaning. For example:

^{10b}You must not shout. ^{10c}Don't speak even one word. ^{10b}Remain absolutely silent.

until the day I tell you to shout. Then you are to

shout!: The term the day refers to the seventh day that they walked around the town. Yahweh instructed Joshua in 6:5 that on the seventh day the army must shout. If you have a word in your language for a shout that soldiers make, you should use it here. For example:

give a war cry (NCV)

shout the battle cry (CEV)

Find a natural way to express this in your language.

General Comment on 6:10b-d

In the Hebrew text Joshua speaks with a direct quote. In some languages it may be more natural to use an indirect quote. For example:

Joshua told the people not to shout or let their voices be heard, or let even one word come out of their mouths, until the day that he told them to shout

Joshua 6:11

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:11a

So he had the ark of the LORD carried around the city,

- So Joshua told them to take the ark of Yahweh around the city
- So the soldiers and the priests who carried the covenant box of Yahweh walked around the city

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline.

In this context, the word So also marks the result. Joshua obeyed God's command and made the army walk around the town on the first day.

he had the ark of the LORD carried around the city:

This clause has some implied information. It was not only the ark of the LORD but also the priests and the soldiers that walked around the town. It may be more natural in some languages to include this implicit information. For example:

They obeyed Joshua's orders and carried the chest once around the town (CEV)

he: The pronoun he refers to Joshua.

carried around: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as carried around means "to go around."

6:11b

circling it once.

- and they walked around it once.
- one time.

circling it once: On this first day they walked once around the town.

6:11c

And the people returned to the camp and spent the night there.

- Then they returned to their camp and spent the night there.
- Then they went back to their camping place and slept there that night.

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline.

the people returned to the camp and spent the night there: After they walked once around the town, they returned to their camping place.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they returned to their camp and slept there that night

Joshua 6:12

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:12a

Joshua got up early the next morning,

- ¶ The next morning Joshua, the soldiers, and the priests woke up early.
- ¶ Joshua got up early the next morning and took the army and the priests back to Jericho.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as "Then" introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this event in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua got up early: There is some implied information. Not only Joshua, but also the priests and the soldiers woke up early.

got up early: The expression got up early means that Joshua (and the army) woke up early in the morning.

In order to make clear the connection between 6:12a and 6:12b-13, it may be helpful to include the implicit information that Joshua led his army back to Jericho for the second day. For example, you could add:

to lead the priests and army back to Jericho for a second day

and he took them back to Jericho

6:12b

and the priests took the ark of the LORD.

- The priests carried the ark of Yahweh.
- The priests again picked up the covenant box of Yahweh.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces the next event in the storyline.

the priests took the ark of the LORD: The clause the priests took the ark means that four of the priests picked up the ark to carry it around Jericho.

If you have included the implicit information mentioned in verse 6:12a, it may be necessary to begin a new sentence here.

Joshua 6:13

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:13a

And the seven priests carrying seven rams' horns

- The seven priests who carried the seven trumpets made of rams' horns
- The seven priests who each held a trumpet

the seven priests carrying seven rams' horns: The phrase the seven priests carrying seven rams' horns contains the same information as the similar phrase in 6:8b. You should translate this phrase in a similar way.

6:13b

kept marching ahead of the ark of the LORD

- walked ahead of the ark of Yahweh
- again walked in front of the covenant box of Yahweh,

kept marching: The phrase kept marching means that they walked forward.

ahead of the ark of the LORD: The priests carried the trumpets and walked in front of the ark of Yahweh.

6:13c

and blowing the horns.

- and blew their trumpets.
- blowing their trumpets all the time.

and blowing the horns: The priests blew the trumpets the entire time that they walked around the town.

6:13d

The armed troops went in front of them

- One group of soldiers walked ahead of the priests,
- Again, some of the armed men walked in front of the priests

The armed troops went in front of them: This repeats the information that is in 6:9a. You should translate this clause in a similar way.

6:13e

and the rear guard followed the ark of the LORD,

- and another group walked behind those who were carrying the ark of Yahweh.
- and other armed men walked behind the covenant box of Yahweh.

and the rear guard followed the ark of the LORD:

This repeats the information that was given in 6:9c. You should translate this in a similar way.

6:13f

while the horns kept sounding.

- They blew on their trumpets without stopping.
- The priests blew on the trumpets all the time as they walked.

while the horns kept sounding: The clause while the horns kept sounding indicates that the priests did not stop blowing their trumpets while they walked around the town.

Joshua 6:14

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:14a

So on the second day they marched around the city once

- They walked around the city once on the second day,
- On the second day they again walked around the city one time

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this event in a way that is natural in your language.

on the second day they marched around the city

once: The second day is like the first day. The priests with the ark and the soldiers walked around the town one time.

6:14b

and returned to the camp.

- and then they returned to the camp.
- and then returned to their camp.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and introduces the next event in the storyline.

returned to the camp: After the priests and soldiers had walked around the town one time, they returned again to their camp and slept there.

6:14c

They did this for six days.

- They did this every day for six days.
- They did the same thing for six days.

They did this for six days: The soldiers and priests walked around the town in the same way for six days, including the first day that was described in verse 6:11.

Joshua 6:15

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:15a

Then on the seventh day, they got up at dawn

- ¶ On the seventh day they woke up at dawn
- ¶ On the seventh day they got up at daybreak.

Then on the seventh day, they got up at dawn: This verse connects to the previous verse with a Hebrew phrase that the BSB indicates this with the word Then. The Hebrew phrase is literally “and it was.” It marks the next event in the storyline. If it is natural in your

language to indicate the next event in the storyline here, then you should do so.

they: The pronoun they includes Joshua, the priests, and the army who walked around the town.

6:15b

and marched around the city seven times in the same manner.

- and walked around the city as they did before, but this day they walked around it seven times.
- They walked seven times around the city in the same order as before.

and marched around the city seven times in the

same manner: They walked around the town in the same order as they did on the previous days. On this day they walked around the town seven times.

6:15c

That was the only day they circled the city seven times.

- Only on the seventh day did they walk around it seven times.
- This was the only day that they walked around the city seven times.

That was the only day they circled the city seven

times: The information that they walked seven times around the town on the seventh day is repeated for emphasis. This indicates that this day was different than the preceding days.

Joshua 6:16

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:16a

After the seventh time around, the priests blew the horns,

- The seventh time, while the priests were blowing a long sound on the trumpets,
- When they walked around the city the seventh time, the priests blew the trumpets for a long time.

After: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as After introduces the next event in the storyline.

the seventh time around: The phrase the seventh time refers to the seventh time that the priests and army walked around the town on the seventh day.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The seventh time around (NET)

On the seventh time they walked around the town

the priests blew the horns: There is an interpretation issue here. There are different views about the timing of blowing the trumpets and the shouting. This affects how we understand both 6:16 and 6:20.

1. While the priests were blowing the trumpets the people started shouting. The trumpets and the shouts were nearly simultaneous. For example:

as the priests blew the trumpets, Joshua said...
(REB) (REB, NLT, NASB, NIV, NJPS, GNT)

1. The priests blew the trumpets first and then the people started shouted. For example:

when the priests had blown the trumpets, Joshua said... (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is most likely that the blowing of the trumpets and the shouting were nearly simultaneous. The two sounds together made a loud noise that caused fear in their enemies.

6:16b
and Joshua commanded the people,

- Joshua said to the army:
- While they blew, Joshua told the army:

Joshua commanded the people: You may need to add a time connector to make it clear that Joshua spoke while the priests were blowing the trumpets. For example:

at the same time

the people: The phrase the people refers to the Israelite soldiers.

6:16c
“Shout! For the LORD has given you the city!”

- “Shout, for Yahweh will give the city to you!”
- “Shout out, because Yahweh has helped us to capture the city!”

Shout: It may be more natural in some languages to express the verb Shout as:

shout loudly

For the LORD has given you the city: The clause the LORD has given you the city indicates that Yahweh will help the Israelites to capture the town. It is because of Yahweh’s power that the Israelite army will conquer Jericho, not through their own cleverness or strength.

has given: The grammatical form of the verb has given seems to indicate that the event has already happened. But at this point the event hasn’t yet happened. The verb form is used to express certainty. It is as if God already made it happen. It may be more natural in some languages to express this certainty in a different way. For example:

The Lord will let you capture this town (CEV)

Yahweh will most certainly give you victory over the town

you: It may be more natural in some languages to translate the pronoun you as “us.” Joshua was among those who captured the town.

Joshua 6:17

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:17a Now the city and everything in it

- Everything in the city of Jericho
- The city and everything in it

Now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now introduces the next event in the storyline. You should use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

the city and everything in it: The phrase the city and everything in it includes living beings, both people and animals, and non-living things.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

absolutely everything in the town

6:17b

must be devoted to the LORD for destruction.

- must be totally destroyed, because it belongs to Yahweh.
- you must destroy, to show that it belongs to Yahweh.

must be devoted to the LORD for destruction: The Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as devoted... for destruction indicates that something is given to Yahweh. It cannot be used for ordinary purposes and so it must be destroyed.

must be devoted: The BSB uses a passive form must be devoted to translate this verb. The passive is a way that the English language uses to emphasize the object of an action. The emphasis is on the people, animals and other things in Jericho that will be destroyed. There are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The city and everything in it must be totally destroyed as an offering to the Lord (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

You must destroy the city and everything in it to show that it now belongs to the Lord (CEV)

Use the forms that are natural in your language.

6:17c

Only Rahab the prostitute and all those with her in her house will live,

- Only Rahab the prostitute and everybody who is in the house with her will live,
- But you must protect Rahab the prostitute and all her family who are in her house.

Only Rahab the prostitute and all those with her in her house will live: The word Only indicates that Yahweh made only one exception to his command.

Rahab the prostitute: The word prostitute means “harlot.”

and all those with her in her house: The phrase all those with her in her house refers to Rahab’s extended family. In 2:1–21 Rahab hid the Israelite spies so that they could escape. She asked them to spare the lives of her and all her family.

6:17d

because she hid the spies we sent.

- because she hid the spies that we^(incl) sent into Jericho.
- We^(incl) will let her live because she hid the men we sent to spy on the land.

because she hid the spies we sent: Rahab was rewarded because she helped the Israelites when she hid the spies.

the spies: The term the spies refers to the Israelite spies who learned about the town of Jericho in Joshua chapter 2.

we sent: In 2:1 Joshua sent men to explore the land and the town of Jericho. By using the inclusive pronoun we Joshua includes all the Israelites in his action. He acted as their representative.

Joshua 6:18

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:18a

But keep away from the things devoted to destruction,

- It is important that none of you take any of the things that belong to Yahweh.
- But remember: do not take any of the things that I told you to destroy as an offering to Yahweh.

But: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as But marks a contrast. In 6:17 Yahweh said that the Israelite

soldiers were not to kill Rahab and her family. But they are to destroy all the other things in the town.

keep away from the things devoted to destruction:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as keep away is an emphatic direct address to the Israelites. It stresses that it is important for the Israelite soldiers to obey Joshua's (and Yahweh's) command.

keep away: The phrase keep away means that the Israelite soldiers must be careful not to take for themselves the things that belong to Yahweh.

the things devoted to destruction: The phrase the things devoted to destruction includes the people, animals, and other things in the town that belong to Yahweh. The Israelites must offer these things to Yahweh by destroying them.

Translate 6:18a in a natural way in your language that emphasizes this command. For example:

It is important that none of you take any of the things that belong to Yahweh

But remember! You must be careful not to take for yourselves anything or any person that belongs to Yahweh

6:18b

lest you yourself be set apart for destruction. If you take any of these,

- You^(plur) must not be overcome by greed and take what belongs to Yahweh.
- Do not be tempted to take them for yourselves,

lest you yourself be set apart for destruction: There is a textual issue in the clause lest you yourself be set apart for destruction.

1. The Greek Septuagint reads "lest you should covet." For example:

for fear that, moved by greed, you take something lying under the curse (NJB) (NJB, NRSV, NIV, CEV, NAB, NASB, REB)

1. The Hebrew text reads "lest you should devote to destruction." For example:

lest when you have devoted them you take any of the devoted things (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NCV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). There is strong support for it among English versions, and in the Septuagint, and it makes better sense of the verse.

Some versions that are based on the Hebrew (option 2) leave out the parts of the verse that are difficult to understand.

It may help to reorder the parts of this verse so that the meaning is clearer. See the General Comment at the end of 6:18.

If you take any of these: The clause take any of these is the result of coveting.

these: The word these refers to things that were mentioned in 6:18a. It may be more natural to refer to them by a pronoun. For example, you could say:

so that you are not tempted to take them for yourselves

6:18c

you will set apart the camp of Israel for destruction and bring disaster upon it.

- If you do, you will bring disaster and destruction on Israel.
- or the Israelite people will be destroyed.

you will set apart the camp of Israel for destruction:

The result of taking the "devoted things" is that the whole Israelite camp would also become part of what must be destroyed.

and bring disaster upon it: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as bring disaster can also be translated as:

bring trouble

cause a calamity

it: The pronoun it refers to the "camp of Israel" and all the Israelite people.

General Comment on 6:18

In some languages it may help to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{18b}And you must beware of coveting anything that is forbidden under the ban; ^{18a}you must take none of it for yourselves, ^{18c}or else you will put the Israelite camp itself under the ban and bring disaster on it. (REB)

^{18a}Be careful not to take anything, ^{18b}because of your greed, ^{18a}that is devoted to Yahweh for destruction. ^{18c}If you do, you will also bring disaster and destruction on Israel.

Joshua 6:19

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:19a

For all the silver and gold and all the articles of bronze and iron are holy to the LORD;

- But all the silver and gold and the things made of bronze and iron belong to Yahweh.
- But you should not destroy the silver and the gold, or anything made of bronze or iron. Instead you should set them apart for Yahweh.

For: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as For introduces some exceptions to the things that the Israelites must destroy.

all the silver and gold and all the articles of bronze and iron are holy to the LORD: The silver and gold and all the articles of bronze and iron are exceptions to what they are to destroy. The implied information is that they are not to destroy these items, but they are to set them aside for Yahweh.

the articles of bronze and iron: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as articles refers to all hand-made items, including containers, tools, and decorative things.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

things made of bronze and iron

holy to the LORD: The phrase holy to the LORD means that these things were set apart for Yahweh. They belong to him alone.

6:19b

they must go into His treasury."

- You must put them into Yahweh's treasury."
- Put them in the storehouse where Yahweh's things are kept."

they must go into His treasury: The clause they must go means that the Israelites are to put these objects into the treasury. For example, you could say:

You must put these objects of metal into the treasury of Yahweh.

His treasury: The term His treasury refers to the storehouse where the things used for worship ceremonies were kept. They were probably kept in or near the Tent of Meeting. (See Numbers 31:54)6:19 See Woudstra, p. 114.

Here is another way to translate verse 19:

But all the silver and the gold, and the things made of bronze and iron, are sacred to Yahweh. Do not destroy these things but put them in the treasury of Yahweh.

Joshua 6:20

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:20a

So when the rams' horns sounded, the people shouted.

- So the people shouted, and the priests blew the trumpets.
- So they obeyed Joshua. They shouted loudly and the priests blew the trumpets.

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So indicates that the action in this verse is done in response to Joshua's instructions in 6:16–19.

when the ram's horn sounded, the people shouted: These two actions happened at the same time.

the rams' horns sounded: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the priests blew the trumpets

6:20b

When they heard the blast of the horn, the people gave a great shout,

- When they heard the trumpets, the people shouted loudly
- As soon as they heard the priests blow the trumpets, the people gave a loud shout

When they heard the blast of the horn, the people gave a great shout: These two actions happened at the same time. The words to describe them here and in 6:20a are in a different order.

General Comment on 6:20a-b

Although the BSB and the Hebrew text of 6:20a-b make it appear that the people shouted twice, this is unlikely. 6:20 See Bratcher and Newman, p. 79. It is recommended that you reorder this verse in a way that makes clear that the people only shouted once. The trumpet blast and the shout happened together.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

When the people heard the sound of the rams' horns, they shouted as loud as they could. (NLT)

So the troops shouted very loudly when they heard the blast of the rams' horns, (GW)

6:20c

and the wall collapsed.

- and the walls fell down.
- and the wall of Jericho collapsed.

and the wall collapsed: The clause the wall collapsed indicates that the wall collapsed and fell down to the ground.

6:20d

Then all the people charged straight into the city

- The soldiers ran straight up into the city
- The Israelite soldiers went straight uphill into the city

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then indicates that the Israelite soldiers could enter the town as a result of the wall falling down. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew word:

so that (RSV)

all the people charged straight into the city: The clause the people charged straight into the city indicates that the soldiers entered the town to conquer it.

straight into the city: Jericho was built at the top of a hill or a mound. The soldiers went straight into the city.

6:20e

and captured it.

- and so they captured the city.
- and they conquered it.

and captured it: The clause and captured it indicates that the Israelite soldiers defeated the soldiers of Jericho and captured the town.

General Comment on 6:16–20

In 6:16b-c, Joshua gave the command to shout, and in 6:20 the army shouted. In 6:17–19 Joshua gives instructions about the capture of Jericho. But 6:17–19 seems unusual and may be a parenthesis between 6:16 and 6:20. It may be that these instructions had already been given to the army, but the author repeats them in summary form here. This was the time for the army to carry out these commands.

Joshua 6:21

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:21a

At the edge of the sword they devoted to destruction everything in the city—

- They destroyed everything in the city with their swords.
- They killed everyone in the city.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as "Then" introduces the next event in the storyline.

At the edge of the sword: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as At the edge of the sword is more literally “with the mouth of the sword.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that they killed the people and animals.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

they killed everyone...they even killed every cow, sheep, and donkey (CEV)

they devoted to destruction everything in the city:

The phrase they devoted to destruction indicates that they destroyed everything in the town (including people, animals, and other things).

6:21b

man and woman, young and old, oxen, sheep, and donkeys.

- They killed men and women, young and old, and the oxen, sheep, and donkeys.
- They killed all the people. They killed the men and the women, the young and the old. And they killed all the domestic animals.

man and woman, young and old: They killed every human being in the town.

oxen, sheep, and donkeys: The word oxen refers to bulls and cows.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

all the domestic animals

Joshua 6:22

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God’s power

The Israelites followed God’s instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:22a

Meanwhile, Joshua told the two men who had spied out the land,

- ¶ Earlier, Joshua told the two men who were spies in Jericho:
- ¶ Joshua already told the two men who went to learn about Jericho:

Meanwhile, Joshua told: Joshua told the two men to go and rescue Rahab. This is something he had previously told them to do. There are several ways to make this clear:

- Use the past perfect tense or the equivalent in your language: For example:

Joshua had told the two men who had spied out the land

- Use a word or particle that indicates that this action happened previously.
- Supply the implied information that Rahab and her family were not killed in verse 6:21b. For example:

They killed everyone, men and women, young and old, everyone except Rahab and the others in her house. (CEV)

Choose a way that is most natural in your language.

the two men who had spied out the land: This phrase refers to the two men who went to find out things about the town of Jericho in Chapter 2.

the land: The phrase the land refers to Jericho and the country around it.

6:22b

“Go into the house of the prostitute and bring out the woman

- “Go^(dual) into the prostitute’s house. Bring her out
- “Go into Rahab’s house, and rescue her

Go into the house of the prostitute: The phrase the house of the prostitute refers to the house of Rahab the prostitute. If it is not appropriate in your language to use the term prostitute repeatedly, it is possible to translate this as:

go into Rahab’s house

bring out the woman: It may be more natural in some languages to use either the proper name Rahab, or else refer to her by a pronoun. For example:

bring Rahab out

bring her out

6:22c**and all who are with her,**

- along with all her family,
- and her family.

and all who are with her: The phrase all who are with her refers to Rahab's family members who were with her in the house.

6:22d**just as you promised her.”**

- because you^(dual) made a promise to her.”
- You promised her that you will do this.”

just as you promised her: The clause just as you promised her states the reason that the men must go into Rahab's house and rescue her. They had promised her that they would do this.

promised: The word promised can also be translated as “swore.” The men promised to Rahab in 2:12-14 that they would rescue her and her family when they conquered the town.

General Comment on 6:22

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{22a}Meanwhile, Joshua said to the two spies,
^{22d}“Keep your promise. ^{22b}Go to the prostitute's house and bring her out, ^{22c}along with all her family.” (NLT)

Joshua 6:23**Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power**

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:23a**So the young spies went in**

- So the two young men who were the spies went into the house
- So the two men went into Rahab's house.

So the young spies: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the young spies refers to young, unmarried men.

went in: It may be more natural in some languages to include the implied information:

went into Rahab's house

6:23b**and brought out Rahab,**

- and led Rahab out.
- They brought out Rahab

and brought out Rahab: They brought Rahab out of the house.

6:23c**her father and mother and brothers, and all who belonged to her.**

- They brought out her father and mother and brothers and all her relatives.
- and her father, mother, brothers, and all the other relatives who were with her.

her father and mother and brothers, and all who belonged to her: There are two ways to understand the phrase all who belonged to her.

1. It refers to Rahab's other relatives. For example:

all her kin (NAB) (NAB, NJPS, GW, NLT, CEV)

1. It refers to Rahab's slaves. For example:

family and slaves (GNT) (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Hebrew text does not mention Rahab's slaves. If the phrase belonged to her implies ownership (such as owning a slave) in your language, then it would be better to make the meaning clear. For example, you could say:

her father, her mother, her brothers and her other relatives

Many English versions translate it literally and leave its meaning unclear.

6:23d**They brought out her whole family**

- They brought out her entire family
- They took all her family

They brought out her whole family: The clause They brought out her whole family is a summary statement that emphasizes that they rescued her entire family. For example:

They moved her whole family to a safe place (NLT)

her whole family: The phrase her whole family refers to her extended family. This refers to the people listed in 6:23c, and not a different group of relatives.

6:23e

and settled them outside the camp of Israel.

- and led them outside the Israelite camp.
- to a place outside the camp of Israel where they could be safe.

and settled them outside the camp of Israel: The men found a safe place for Rahab and her family to stay outside the camp of Israel. Rahab and her family could not enter the Israelite camp because they were not ceremonially clean. The Israelite camp was a holy place and only Israelites could enter it.

Joshua 6:24

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:24a

Then the Israelites burned up the city and everything in it.

- The Israelite army burned down the city. They burned everything in it,
- Then they burned the whole city and everything in it.

Then the Israelites: The phrase the Israelites refers to the Israelite army, not to the two men who led Rahab's family to safety.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Then the army burned the town

burned up the city: For example:

But they burned the town and all that was in it (NET)

and everything in it: The Israelite soldiers killed every person and animal in the town. They then burned all the bodies and everything else that was still there.

6:24b

However, they put the silver and gold and articles of bronze and iron

- except the silver and gold and the things made of bronze and iron.
- They only saved the silver and the gold, and the things made of bronze and of iron.

However, they put the silver and gold and articles of bronze and iron: The only other exception to the ban besides Rahab's family are these items.

articles of bronze and iron: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as articles refers to all handmade items, including containers, tools, and decorative things.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

things made of bronze and iron

6:24c

into the treasury of the LORD's house.

- They put these things into Yahweh's treasury.
- They put them in the storehouse at the Tent of Meeting.

into the treasury of the LORD's house: The term treasury refers to the storehouse where the things used for worship ceremonies were kept. They were probably kept in or near the Tent of Meeting.

the LORD's house: The term the LORD's house is another name for the Tent of Meeting, the place where the Israelites worshiped Yahweh.

Joshua 6:25

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:25a

And Joshua spared Rahab the prostitute, with her father's household and all who belonged to her,

- But Joshua allowed Rahab the prostitute and her family to escape death.
- But Joshua spared the lives of Rahab and all her relatives.

And Joshua spared Rahab the prostitute, with her father's household and all who belonged to her:

The clause Rahab the prostitute, with her father's household and all who belonged to her is the object of the sentence. The Hebrew text puts this first for emphasis. Use the natural grammatical patterns of your language to give this emphasis.

And Joshua spared: The clause Joshua spared indicates that Joshua did not allow the soldiers to kill Rahab along with the other people of Jericho.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Joshua saved alive (RSV)

The two spies brought Rahab and her family to safety outside of Jericho. However, Joshua was the person who had authority and told them to do this.

her father's household and all who belonged to her: The phrase her father's household and all who belonged to her refers to Rahab's extended family. This is the same group of people referred to in 6:23.

6:25b

because she hid the men Joshua had sent to spy out Jericho.

- She was spared because she hid the spies whom Joshua sent to look around Jericho.
- She lived because she hid the two spies that Joshua sent into Jericho.

because she hid the men Joshua had sent to spy out Jericho: The word men refers to the two young spies.

to spy out Jericho: The phrase to spy out Jericho indicates that Joshua sent the two men to Jericho to learn about the town and the surrounding area.

6:25c

So she has lived among the Israelites to this day.

- And she has lived in Israel to this day.

- She and her family became a part of the people of Israel.

So she has lived among the Israelites: The family of Rahab and her descendants became part of the nation of Israel. There is an interpretation issue with the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as she has lived.

1. It refers to Rahab. For example:

she has lived in Israel to this day (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV, NASB, NET, NJPS, NLT, KJV)

1. It refers to Rahab's descendants. For example:

her descendants have lived in Israel to this day (GNT) (GNT, NABRE, NRSV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This agrees with the Hebrew text and is followed by many English versions and by Bible commentaries.6:25 See, for example, Woudstra, p. 115, and Dallaire, p. 899.

to this day: The phrase to this day refers to the time that the book of Joshua was written. The descendants of Rahab were still living among the Israelites at the time the author wrote the book.

General Comment on 6:25

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. The Hebrew text separates the reason clause (6:25c) from the result clause (6:25a) and these can be put together. For example:

^{25a}But Joshua spared Rahab the prostitute, with her family and all who belonged to her, ^{25c}because she hid the men Joshua had sent as spies to Jericho—^{25b}and she lives among the Israelites to this day. (NIV)

Joshua 6:26

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

Paragraph 6:26

This paragraph is a final statement about the destruction of Jericho. Even the land that Jericho is built upon is devoted to Yahweh for destruction. The town was to be left for Yahweh only. Anybody who disobeyed Yahweh would be punished.

6:26a

At that time Joshua invoked this solemn oath:

- ¶ After they destroyed Jericho, Joshua made this oath:
- ¶ At that time Joshua made this curse:

At that time: The phrase At that time refers to the time after the Israelites defeated Jericho. For example:

After Jericho was destroyed... (CEV)

Joshua invoked this solemn oath: The clause Joshua invoked this solemn oath means that Joshua warned the Israelites.6:26 The people probably answered “Amen,” or “Yes, I will do it.” Woudstra, p. 116.

invoked this solemn oath: The expression invoked this solemn oath can be expressed in many ways. For example:

Joshua made this solemn declaration (NET)

Joshua issued a solemn warning (GNT)

Joshua pronounced this curse (REB)

solemn oath: A solemn oath is a promise, declaration, or warning.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua laid an oath upon them at that time, saying, “Cursed before the Lord... (RSV)

After Jericho was destroyed, Joshua said this curse. He said to them, “Yahweh will punish...

6:26b

“Cursed before the LORD is the man who rises up and rebuilds this city, Jericho;

- “Whoever starts to rebuild Jericho city, Yahweh will curse them.

- “Yahweh will punish anyone who tries to rebuild this city of Jericho.

Cursed before the LORD is the man: The phrase Cursed before the LORD is the man indicates that Yahweh will curse anyone who rebuilds Jericho.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Yahweh will punish anybody who rebuilds Jericho

man: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as man is more literally “person.” (In other contexts the word can mean a “male person.”) You should use a word such as “person” or “anyone.”

who rises up and rebuilds: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rises up refers to the beginning of an action.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

anybody who starts to rebuild

the person who tries to rebuild

this city, Jericho: The words this city and Jericho refer to the same place.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Jericho town

6:26c

at the cost of his firstborn he will lay its foundations;

- Their oldest son will die when they lay the foundation of the city wall.
- The one who lays the foundation of the city will lose his oldest son.

at the cost of his firstborn: The phrase at the cost of his firstborn means that if anyone lays the foundation of the town of Jericho, their oldest son will die.

he will lay its foundations: The word foundations refers to the foundation of the town wall.

In some languages it may be clearer to reorder the parts of 6:26c. For example:

If anyone lays the foundation for the town wall, that person’s oldest son will die.

6:26d

at the cost of his youngest he will set up its gates.”

- Their youngest son will die when they set up the city gates.”
- The one who sets up the gates will lose his youngest son.”

at the cost of his youngest: The phrase at the cost of his youngest means if he sets up its gates, his youngest son will die.

he will set up its gates: The gates refer to the gates in the town wall.

In some languages it may be clearer to reorder the parts of 6:26d. For example:

If anyone sets up the gates to the town, that person's youngest son will die.

Joshua 6:27

Section 5:13–6:27 Israel conquered Jericho by God's power

The Israelites followed God's instructions and marched around the wall of Jericho town. On the seventh day the wall of the town collapsed and they conquered the town. They killed everybody in it except for Rahab and her family.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The wall of Jericho fell

The conquering of Jericho

6:27a

So the LORD was with Joshua,

- ¶ So Yahweh was always with Joshua,
- ¶ So Yahweh helped Joshua in everything he did,

6:27b

and his fame spread throughout the land.

- and Joshua was famous in all of Canaan.
- and everyone in that country knew about his great deeds.

6:27

So the LORD was with Joshua: The clause So the LORD was with Joshua indicates that Yahweh stayed with Joshua and helped him in everything that he did.

and his fame spread throughout the land: The clause his fame spread throughout the land indicates that everyone in the land of Canaan heard about Joshua and the things that he did.

Joshua 7:1

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:1

Yahweh was angry with Israel because Achan disobeyed Yahweh's command.

7:1a

The Israelites, however, acted unfaithfully

- ¶ But the Israel people did not keep their promise
- ¶ But the Israelites did not obey Yahweh.

The Israelites, however: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as however indicates a contrast with what precedes it in chapter 6. The contrast compares Yahweh's command not to take any devoted things and Achan's disobedience of that command.

The Israelites: Even though only one man took something, God considered all The Israelites to be guilty.

acted unfaithfully: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as acted unfaithfully means that the Israelites were not faithful to Yahweh. They disobeyed Yahweh by taking some of the devoted things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Israelites did not keep their promise to Yahweh

the Israelites did not obey the Lord (NCV)

7:1b

regarding the things devoted to destruction.

- about the things set apart for Yahweh.
- Yahweh told them to destroy everything in Jericho, but they did not destroy everything.

regarding the things devoted to destruction: The phrase regarding the things devoted to destruction can also be translated “about the devoted things.” In 6:17–18 Yahweh told the Israelites to destroy every-

thing in Jericho. In that way they would give these things to Yahweh. See how you translated the phrase things devoted to destruction in 6:18.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

about the things that must be destroyed

about the things that belong to Yahweh

7:1c

Achan son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah, took some of what was set apart.

- A man from the clan of Judah named Achan took some of the things that must be destroyed. Achan's father was Carmi. His grandfather was Zabdi, and his great-grandfather was Zerah.
- Achan took some of the things that belonged to Yahweh. Achan was the son of Carmi, the grandson of Zabdi, the great-grandson of Zerah, from the clan of Judah.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “for” introduces an explanation of the way that the Israelites disobeyed Yahweh. Many English versions do not include this conjunction. Do whatever is most natural in your language.

Achan son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah: This means that Carmi was the son of Zabdi, and that Zabdi was the son of Zerah.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Achan was the son of Carmi, the grandson of Zabdi, and the great-grandson of Zerah

Achan was the son of Carmi and grandson of Zabdi, and belonged to the clan of Zerah, a part of the tribe of Judah (GNT)

Zabdi: There is a textual issue with the word Zabdi.

1. The Hebrew text says “Zabdi.” (BSB, RSV, GNT, REB, NCV, NASB, NET, GW, NJPS, NJB, KJV)
2. The Septuagint translation into Greek says “Zimri.” (NIV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is best to follow the Hebrew text unless there are strong reasons to take a different reading.

took some of what was set apart: This means that Achan stole some of the things that belonged to Yahweh.

7:1d

So the anger of the LORD burned against the Israelites.

- So Yahweh was very angry at the Israelites.
- Because Achan did that, Yahweh was furious with the people of Israel.

So: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. Some versions do not translate this word. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

God's anger in 7:1d is the next event, and it is also the result of 7:1a-c. Some English versions express this as a result.

Here are some ways to express result:

therefore

and so (GNT)

You can express this connector as either introducing the next event, or as introducing a result.

the anger of the LORD burned against the Israelites:

The phrase the anger of the LORD burned is a Hebrew idiom. It means that:

Yahweh was very angry at the people of Israel

General Comment on 7:1

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

- ^{1a}But Israel violated the instructions ^{1b}about the things set apart for the Lord. A man named Achan had stolen some of these dedicated things, ^{1d}so the Lord was very angry with the Israelites. ^{1c}Achan was the son of Carmi, a descendant of Zimri son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah. (NLT)

Joshua 7:2

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:2–5

Joshua sent the Israelite army to fight against the men of Ai, but the Israelites were defeated.

7:2a

Meanwhile, Joshua sent men from Jericho to Ai,

- ¶ Joshua sent men from Jericho to the city of Ai,
- ¶ Joshua sent some Israelite men from where they were camped near Jericho City, to go to Ai City.

Meanwhile: The Hebrew text has a word that introduces the next event in the storyline. The BSB translates it as *Meanwhile*, but some English versions do not translate this word. Some English versions begin this verse with the connector “now.” Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua sent men from Jericho to Ai: The men that Joshua sent were Israelites. They were not people of Jericho. The Israelites were camped near Jericho following the battle. The NLT makes this clear:

Joshua sent some of his men (NLT)

Ai: Ai is the name of a town. It was smaller than Jericho.

7:2b

which is near Beth-aven to the east of Bethel,

- which is near Beth-aven City, east of Bethel City.
- Ai is near Beth-aven City and east of Bethel City.

which is near Beth-aven to the east of Bethel: These are the names of small towns. Ai was near the town of Beth-aven and was east of the town of Bethel. 7:2 “Beth-aven (“house of evil”) often appears as an insulting nickname for Bethel, which means “house of God.” Some scholars consider “near Beth-aven” to be an editorial gloss. Others, however, take it to be a variant spelling of “Bethon” (Bratcher and Newman, p. 319).

7:2c

and told them, “Go up and spy out the land.”

- He said to them: “Go up and find out about the land.”
- Joshua told the men to go and look at Ai and the area around it.

and told them: Joshua gave the men instructions before he sent them to Ai. The Hebrew text uses a direct quote for Joshua’s instructions. Some English versions put these brief instructions into an indirect quote.

The NET has a direct quote:

and instructed them, “Go up and spy on the land” (NET)

The GNT has an indirect quote:

Joshua sent some men...with orders to go and explore the land (GNT)

Use the kind of quotation that is most natural in your language.

Go up: Ai was at a higher elevation than the Israelite camp. Hebrew verbs keep track of elevation, and thus it says Go up. If your language does not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say “go.”

and spy out the land: The phrase spy out the land means “look at the land and learn about it.” Joshua wanted to know information that would help him to plan an attack on Ai.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

find out whatever you can (CEV)

land: The word land refers to both the town of Ai and to the land that surrounded it.

7:2d

So the men went up and spied out Ai.

- So the men went up and found out about Ai.
- So the men did so.

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as *So* indicates that 7:2d is the result of 7:2c. Use a natural way to indicate result in your language.

the men went up and spied out Ai: This clause indicates that the men obeyed Joshua’s instructions. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the information again. If that is true in your language, you may express the idea in a different way. For example:

so they did it

so the men obeyed Joshua

went up: See the note on “go up” in 7:2c.

Joshua 7:3

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:2–5

Joshua sent the Israelite army to fight against the men of Ai, but the Israelites were defeated.

7:3a

On returning to Joshua, they reported,

- When they returned they said to Joshua:
- Then they went back to Joshua and said to him:

The Hebrew word that the some English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this connection. Here is one way that you could translate this transition:

when (GNT)

On returning to Joshua, they reported: It may be helpful in some languages to include the implied information. For example:

After they spied out the land they returned to Joshua, and said to him

7:3b

“There is no need to send all the people;

- “Not all the people need to go up to fight Ai.
- “It is not necessary for our whole army to attack the city of Ai.

There is no need to send all the people: This clause expresses a suggestion from the men who looked at Ai. They suggested that it was not necessary for the whole army to fight against Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

There is no need for everyone to attack Ai. (GNT)

Do not send the whole army to attack Ai.

all the people: The phrase all the people refers to the soldiers of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the fighting men

the whole army

7:3c

two or three thousand men are enough to go up and attack Ai.

- Only two to three thousand men should go to attack Ai.
- Send only two or three thousand soldiers.

two or three thousand men are enough to go up and attack Ai: The spies suggested that two or three thousand men were enough to defeat the town of Ai. Translate this suggestion in a way that is natural in your language.

two or three thousand men: The whole army of Israel was about 40,000 men. The spies suggested that only a small number out of the whole army should go. It may be helpful to include a word that indicates this comparison. For example:

Send only two or three thousand men to fight (NCV)

go up: In some languages it may be necessary to indicate the location along with this verb of motion. For example:

Not all the people will have to go up against Ai (NIV)

The Hebrew uses the verb go up because the town of Ai was at a higher elevation than the Israelite camp. The soldiers went uphill to the town of Ai to attack it. In some languages it may be more natural to use a simple verb like “go.”

attack Ai: The BSB follows the Hebrew text and includes the phrase attack Ai at the end of 7:3c. In some languages, it may be more natural to put these words at the end of 7:3b, as the GNT does. For example:

There is no need for everyone to attack Ai. Send only about two or three thousand men (GNT)

7:3d**Since the people of Ai are so few,**

- Because the city of Ai is not large,
- Because not many people live there,

Since: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Since introduces the reason for the preceding clause.

the people of Ai are so few: This phrase refers to the people of Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

There are not many people in Ai

Ai is not a large town

There are not many men to defend Ai

7:3e**you need not wear out all our people there.”**

- do not make the entire army work their way up there and get tired.”
- you will not need to make the whole army work hard to defeat that small place

you need not wear out all our people there: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wear out.

1. It means “to work hard” or “become weary from working hard.” For example:

Don’t tire out the whole army (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, NIV, GW, REB, ESV, NASB, NLT)

1. It means “to cause trouble for.” For example:

Why bother the whole army (CEV) (CEV, NJPS)7:3
Some English versions (NCV, NLT96, GNT) leave this word unstated or implied.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Although the meaning is somewhat uncertain, this is the interpretation followed by the majority of English versions.

all our people: This refers to all the army, or all the fighting men.

General Comment on 7:3

In some languages it may be more natural to state the grounds before the result. English versions have done this in various ways. For example:

^{3e}There are only a few people in Ai, ^{3b}so we will not need all our people to defeat them. ^{3c}Send only two or three thousand men to fight. ^{3d}There is no need to send all of our people. (NCV)

Joshua 7:4**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:2–5

Joshua sent the Israelite army to fight against the men of Ai, but the Israelites were defeated.

7:4a**So about three thousand men went up,**

- So about three thousand Israelite men went to attack Ai.
- Then Joshua agreed and sent about three thousand soldiers to attack Ai City.

So: The BSB inserts the word So, which is not found in the Hebrew text. This introduces the result of the advice in 7:3d. Many English versions introduce this result with the word “so.”

Consider what is the most natural way in your language to indicate a result connection.

about three thousand men went up: This clause implies that Joshua sent the three thousand men to Ai, as the spies suggested. In some languages it may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

Joshua sent about three thousand soldiers to attack Ai (CEV)

Notice that the CEV included the reason why the men went to Ai, that is, to attack. It may be helpful to make that clear in your translation in some way.

men: The word men indicates “from among the Israelite army.” Only three thousand Israelite soldiers went to Ai. Some English versions omit this phrase because it is implied by the context.

went up: The town of Ai was at a higher elevation than the Israelite camp at Gilgal. The Hebrew language keeps track of elevation, and thus has the word up.

7:4b

but they fled before the men of Ai.

- But the Israelites had to retreat from the soldiers of Ai.
- But the soldiers of Ai defeated them and the Israelites ran away.

but: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as but introduces the next event in the storyline. Mark this next event in a way that is most natural in your language.

Many English versions use a contrastive connector such as but or “however” to show that what happened next is contrary-to-expectation. For example:

but they were routed by the men of Ai (NIV)

Translate this contrary-to-expectation relation in a way that is most natural in your language.

they fled before the men of Ai: The Hebrew text implies that the Israelites attacked Ai. The men of Ai defeated the Israelites so that the Israelites ran away from the battle. In some languages it may be helpful to make some of this information explicit. For example:

When the soldiers arrived at Ai, they attacked the town. The men of Ai defeated them and they ran from the battle

they: The word they refers to the three thousand Israelite men.

fled: The word fled indicates that the Israelite army had to run away from the people who were defending Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they turned back

they ran away

the men of Ai: This phrase refers to the men who lived in Ai and were defending it against the Israelites. Because they were fighting a battle they could be called:

the soldiers of Ai

Joshua 7:5

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:2–5

Joshua sent the Israelite army to fight against the men of Ai, but the Israelites were defeated.

7:5a

And the men of Ai struck down about thirty-six of them,

- The soldiers of Ai killed about thirty-six Israelite soldiers.
- The soldiers of Ai City killed thirty-six of the Israelites altogether.

And: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a way that is most natural in your language.

the men of Ai: The phrase the men of Ai refers to the soldiers who were fighting to defend the town.

struck down about thirty-six of them: The soldiers of Ai killed thirty-six Israelite soldiers.7:5 The Hebrew text has a word that the BSB translates as “about.” However, Boling and Wright note that this word is emphatic in verses 4 and 5. So the number of men killed was precisely thirty-six (Boling and Wright, p. 222).

7:5b

chasing them from the gate

- They chased the soldiers away from the gate in the city wall,
- They chased the Israelite army away from the entrance to the city,

The Hebrew prefix that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translates as “and” introduces some additional detail about the death of the Israelite soldiers. This adds emphasis to the defeat of the Israelites. The details specify where and when the Israelite soldiers were killed.

chasing them: The word them refers to the Israelite soldiers.

from the gate: The word from means “in front of.” The men of Ai chased the Israelite soldiers away from the area in front of the town gate all the way to the stone quarries.

the gate: Ai town (like Jericho town) was surrounded by a town wall. In the wall was a gate, and people could enter the town only through this gate.

7:5c

as far as the quarries

- and chased them as far as the stone quarries.
- and down the hill to the stone quarries

as far as the quarries: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as quarries.

1. It means rock quarries. For example:

They chased the Israelites from the city gate as far as the stone quarries (NIV) (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW, NCV, NET, NLT, REB, GNT)

1. It is a place named Shebarim. For example:

pursued them from the town gate as far as Shebarim (NJB) (NJB, RSV, ESV, NASB, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretation (2) is a transliteration of the Hebrew word and does not communicate the meaning as it was probably understood in Hebrew.

quarries: The word quarries refers to a place where people dig rock from the ground to use in construction.

7:5d

and striking them down on the slopes.

- They killed them while they fled down the hill.
- and killed the Israelites as they ran down the hill.

and: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as and introduces more details of where and when the Israelite soldiers were killed.

striking them down: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as striking them down means “killing.” The phrase striking them down refers to the thirty-six Israelite soldiers who were killed. It restates the information in 7:5a. It does not indicate that additional Israelites were killed.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the men of Ai killed them

on the slopes: The phrase on the slopes refers to the hillside going down to the stone quarries.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on the slope of the hill

while they were fleeing down the hill

General Comment on 7:5b-d

This story is told in a way that is common in Hebrew narrative style. It tells a summary of an event first, and then it adds the details. Use the natural grammar of your language to make this clear. Your readers should understand that only thirty-six Israelite people were killed. These are some ways that English versions have handled this style:

The men of Ai killed about thirty-six of them, chasing them from outside the gate as far as Shebarim and killing them on the slope. (GW)

The men of Ai chased them from the city gate as far as some quarries and killed about thirty-six of them on the way down the hill. (GNT)

7:5e

So the hearts of the people melted and became like water.

- The Israelite soldiers were very afraid and felt dread instead of courage.
- Then the Israelite army was very afraid.

So the hearts of the people melted and became like water:

This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that the people became very afraid. They no longer felt any courage. Many languages have their own idioms to express fear. Here are some English idioms that express this meaning:

And the heart of the troops sank in utter dismay. (NJPS)

they lost their courage (NCV)

The Israelites were paralyzed with fear at this turn of events, and their courage melted away. (NLT)

In some languages it may be more natural to express the meaning directly without using an idiom. For example, you could say:

The Israelite soldiers were very afraid

Express the meaning in the most natural way in your language.

the people: This phrase refers to the Israelite soldiers.

Joshua 7:6

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:6–9

Joshua asked Yahweh why he allowed the people of Ai to defeat the Israelites.

7:6a

Then Joshua tore his clothes

- ¶ Then Joshua tore his clothes to show his sorrow.
- ¶ When the soldiers returned to the camp and told Joshua, he tore his clothes to show his sorrow.

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. There is some implied information here. The Israelite soldiers returned to their camp and told Joshua what happened in the battle. In some languages it may be clearer to make this information explicit. For example:

When the soldiers returned to camp and reported to Joshua, he tore his clothes

Joshua: In the Hebrew text Joshua is mentioned alone as the subject of the sentence. Later in the verse, the elders of Israel also acted along with Joshua. This is a way to emphasize Joshua because he was the leader, and his reaction was the most important.

In some languages it may be more natural to include the elders of Israel as part of the subject. For example:

Joshua and the elders of Israel tore their clothes

tore his clothes: The phrase tore his clothes means that Joshua intentionally tore his clothes open. This dramatic action was a way to express grief or sorrow. Joshua ripped open his upper and under garment in front of his chest, as a symbol of the pain in his heart.7:6 This dramatic action was an expression of heartfelt grief. TWOT says that he tore both outer and inner garments (p. 816). Holladay's lexicon defines this word as "to tear, to tear in pieces." However, Bratcher and Newman says this was "probably only a tear along the edge of the outer garment" (p. 89). This seems unlikely because it is difficult to make a small tear along the edge of a garment with only the bare hands. It is recommended that you translate this as tearing his clothes completely open.

It may be helpful to make the reason for this action explicit. For example:

tore their clothes in grief (GNT)

7:6b

and fell facedown

- He lay face down on the ground
- He lay down with his face toward the ground

and fell facedown: Joshua lay down on the ground with his face downward. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fell means that Joshua deliberately lay down on the ground. This was one of the ways that he showed his humility and sorrow.

7:6c

before the ark of the LORD until evening,

- in front of the ark of Yahweh until evening came.
- in front of the covenant box of Yahweh until the sun set.

before: The word before indicates "in front of" the ark.

the ark of the LORD: the ark of the LORD was a wooden box that represented the presence of Yahweh among the people. You should use the same word for ark as you did in 3:3.

until evening: Joshua lay this way until the sun set.

7:6d

as did the elders of Israel;

- The elders of Israel were with him on their faces in front of the ark.
- Joshua did this with the leaders of Israel.

as did the elders of Israel: The Hebrew is an ellipsis. In many languages it may be necessary to express it in a different way. For example:

he and the elders of Israel all did this

The leaders of Israel did the same thing. (NCV)

The elders of Israel also did these things along with Joshua.

The Hebrew text puts this reference to the elders at an unusual place in the verse. In some languages it may not be natural to keep the order of the Hebrew text. Some English versions include the elders, along with Joshua, as the subject of the sentence in 7:6a. For example:

^{6a}Joshua and the leaders of Israel tore their clothes in grief (GNT)

Express this in a way that is natural in your language.

the elders of Israel: The elders of Israel were older men who were the leaders of Israel.

7:6e
and they all sprinkled dust on their heads.

- Joshua and the elders threw dirt onto their heads.
- They sprinkled dust on their heads.

and they all sprinkled dust on their heads: It was the custom for people to put dust on their heads to show sorrow. In some languages the reason for this action must be made explicit. For example:

with dust on their heads to show their sorrow (GNT)

sprinkled: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sprinkled is more literally “to cause to go up.” The precise action that the people used is not clear. Some English versions translate this word as “threw” (REB, NCV, NET). Choose a word that seems natural in your language.

dust: The word dust can also be translated as “dirt.”

General Comment on 7:6

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of some of the information in this verse. There is more than one way to do this. Here are two examples:

^{6a}Joshua ^{6d}and the leaders of Israel ^{6a}tore their clothing in dismay, ^{6e}threw dust on their heads, ^{6b}and bowed down ^{6c}facing the Ark of the Lord until evening. (NLT)

^{6a}Then Joshua ^{6d}and the leaders of Israel ^{6c}went to Yahweh’s Covenant Box. ^{6a}They tore their clothes ^{6e}and put dirt on their heads to show their grief. ^{6b}Then they threw themselves down ^{6c}in front of the Covenant Box and lay there with their faces to the ground until sunset.

Joshua 7:7

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:6–9

Joshua asked Yahweh why he allowed the people of Ai to defeat the Israelites.

7:7a

“O, Lord GOD,”

- “O, Lord Yahweh,
- “Yahweh who is the ruler of everything. This is terrible.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “And” introduces the next event in the storyline.

The Hebrew begins this clause with a word that some English versions translate as “Alas.” It is an expression of dismay.

Here is another way to translate this word:

This is terrible

Choose an exclamation or a way to show dismay or grief. In some languages it may be more natural to omit this word, as many English versions do (for example, BSB, GNT, NCV, NLT, GW).

O: The word O is an English “vocative” that marks the person who is being spoken to. This word was added by the BSB and is not the translation of a Hebrew word. Many English versions do not use this word. Use a natural form in your language to indicate that Joshua is speaking to God.

Lord GOD: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Lord here means “master” or “boss.” It is a title that shows respect. It is not the name Yahweh.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as GOD is “Yahweh.” It is God’s personal name. When it is used alone, it is often translated “LORD” or “Lord” by English versions.

There are several ways to translate the phrase Lord GOD. For example:

- Use God’s name, “Yahweh,” along with a title of respect. For example:

master Yahweh

sovereign Yahweh

almighty Yahweh

- Use God’s name, “Yahweh,” with a descriptive phrase. For example:

Yahweh who is the ruler of everything

Use an appropriate form in your language. See the section on “Translating the Names of God” in the Introduction.

7:7b

Joshua said,

- Joshua prayed,
- Joshua called out to Yahweh as he lay there.

Joshua said: In 7:7-9 Joshua expressed his grief in an emphatic complaint to Yahweh. He asked rhetorical questions that showed his confusion about what happened at Ai. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different verb instead of said.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua prayed (NET)

Joshua shouted out

7:7c

“why did You ever bring this people across the Jordan

- “why did you bring us^(excl) across the Jordan River?
- “Surely this was not your purpose when brought us, your people, across the Jordan River.

why did You ever bring this people across the Jordan: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a complaint or an expression of regret. Joshua regretted that Yahweh brought them across the Jordan River, because the people of Ai defeated them. He implies that it is God’s fault that they were defeated.

Here are two ways to translate this complaint:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Sovereign Lord, why did you bring us across the Jordan River if you are going to let the Amorites kill us? (NLT)

Our Lord, did you bring us across the Jordan River just so the Amorites could destroy us? (CEV)

- Use a statement or exclamation. For example:

Surely you did not bring us^(excl) across the Jordan River so that the Amorites could defeat us!

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for expressing a complaint.

You: The pronoun You means “you” and is singular. Joshua is speaking to God.

ever: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as ever is an idiom. It emphasizes Joshua’s complaint. Use a natural way in your language to emphasize a complaint like this.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

why did you bring this people across the Jordan just to hand us over to the Amorites to be destroyed? (REB)

this people: The phrase this people refers to the Israelites. Joshua is also one of the Israelites. In some languages this must be made explicit. For example:

bring us (NLT)

bring us^(excl) your people

7:7d**to deliver us into the hand of the Amorites**

- Did you want the Amorites to conquer us,
- Surely you did not want the Amor people to defeat us.

to deliver us into the hand of the Amorites: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as deliver us into the hand of the Amorites is an idiom. It means “let the Amorites gain control of us.” It indicates that the Amorites would conquer the Israelites.

us: The word us refers to the Israelites. It is exclusive.

us^(excl)

the Amorites: The name Amorites can be used in two senses. It can refer to a group of people who lived in the hills of Canaan where the town of Ai was. It can also be a synonym for the word “Canaanite,” to refer to all the people of Canaan. This is the way it is used here.

The English language uses the suffix “ites” to refer to a group of people.

Here is another way to translate this word:

the Amor people

7:7e**to be destroyed?**

- and destroy us?
- You did not want them to kill us all.

to be destroyed: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as to be destroyed often means “to be killed.” Joshua feared that the Amorites would kill the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to let the Amorites kill us? (NLT)

7:7f**If only we had been content to stay on the other side of the Jordan!**

- If only we had decided to stay east of the Jordan River and live there.
- We should have stayed on the other side of the Jordan River.

If only we had been content to stay on the other side of the Jordan: Joshua expressed regret about what happened. He wished that they had stayed on

the other side of the Jordan River. He thought that if they had stayed there, they would not have been defeated by the Amorites.

A regret is a wish that something in the past could have been different. Languages have different ways to express regret. Here are some examples in English:

I wish we had stayed

We should have stayed

Why didn't we just stay (GNT)

This wouldn't have happened if we had agreed to stay (CEV)

Express Joshua's regret in a natural and emphatic way in your language.

content to stay: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as content can be translated as:

willing to dwell

decided to dwell

the other side of the Jordan: This phrase refers to the east side of the Jordan River.

General Comment on 7:7

7:7c-e is a long rhetorical question in the BSB. In some languages it may be more natural to separate it into two or three different parts. For example:

Almighty Lord, why did you bring these people across the Jordan River? Was it to hand us over to the Amorites so that they could destroy us? (GW)

Why did you bring us^(excl) across the Jordan at all? Did you want to give us to the Amorites? Did you bring us across only to destroy us?

Use a natural option for your language.

Joshua 7:8**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of

Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:6–9

Joshua asked Yahweh why he allowed the people of Ai to defeat the Israelites.

7:8a

O Lord, what can I say,

- O Lord, what should I say to you
- My master, I do not know what to say about this.

O: The word O is an English “vocative” that marks the person who is being spoken to. This word was added by the BSB and is not the translation of a Hebrew word. Many English versions do not use this word. Use a natural form in your language to indicate that Joshua is speaking to God.

Lord: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or boss.” It is a title that shows respect. It was also used in 7:7b when Joshua addressed God as “Lord God.”

what can I say: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a part of Joshua's complaint to Yahweh. Joshua did not yet understand why God allowed the people of Ai to defeat Israel.

Here are two ways to translate this complaint:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What can I say, O Lord? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Lord, there is nothing I can say now (NCV)

I do not know what to say to you about this

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for expressing a complaint.

7:8b

now that Israel has turned its back and run from its enemies?

- now that the army of Israel has run away from their enemies?

- The army of Israel has fled from their enemies.

now that: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as now that introduces the topic that Joshua would say something about.

Here are some other ways to translate this connection:

What can I say about the fact that Israel has turned their backs?

What can I say, O Lord, now that Israel has retreated from the enemy? (GNT)

I don't even know what to say to you, since Israel's army has turned and run from the enemy (CEV)

Israel: The word Israel refers to the army of Israel.

Here is another way to translate this word:

since Israel's army has turned and run from the enemy (CEV)

has turned its back and run from its enemies: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as has turned its back is an idiom. It means that they turned and ran away. They had to run away, because they were defeated by their enemies.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

what can I say about this situation? The army of Israel ran away from our enemies

what can I say now that Israel has fled from its enemies? (NLT)

what can I say now that Israel has retreated before its enemies? (NET)

enemies: The word enemies refers to the people of Ai.

General Comment on 7:8

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of 7:8a and 7:8b. For example:

^{8b}Now that Israel has turned and run from its enemies in defeat, ^{8a}what can I say?

Joshua 7:9

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:6–9

Joshua asked Yahweh why he allowed the people of Ai to defeat the Israelites.

7:9a

When the Canaanites and all who live in the land hear about this,

- For the Canaanites and the other people of the country will hear about this
- The Canaanites and all the other people who live here will learn about it.

When: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as When introduces more of Joshua's thoughts about Israel's defeat. Some English versions translate this as "For" and others omit it. Use a natural option for your language in this context.

the Canaanites and all who live in the land: This phrase refers to all the people of the country. The Canaanites were one of the groups of people who lived in the land of Canaan.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The Canaanites and all the other people in this country (NCV)

Canaanites: The name Canaanites refers to the people who live in Canaan.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Canaan people

hear about this: The phrase hear about this indicates that the people who lived in the land will find out that Israel was defeated by Ai.

7:9b

they will surround us and wipe out our name from the earth.

- and they will surround us and attack us and kill us all.
- They will come and kill us all, and no one will remember us anymore.

they will surround us: The clause they will surround us states the result of their defeat. After the people hear about Israel's defeat at Ai, they will attack Israel. In some languages it may be clearer to make the result explicit. For example,

The Canaanites and other people in the land will hear about this. Then they will surround us and attack us^(excl)

and wipe out our name from the earth: The Hebrew expression that the BSB translates as wipe out our name from the earth is an idiom. It includes two ideas:

1. They will kill all the Israelites.
2. When the Israelites are dead, no one will speak their names or remember them anymore.

In some languages it may be clearer to express both these ideas. For example:

Then they will kill us^(excl) all, and no one will remember us anymore

7:9c

Then what will You do for Your great name?"

- Then what will you do to protect the honor of your name?"
- This will bring shame on you because they will think you could not protect your people."

Then: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as Then introduces another result of their defeat. Some English versions do not translate this connector. For example:

What will you do to protect your great reputation?
(NET)

what will You do for Your great name?: In modern English this reads: what will You do for Your great name? This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a strong statement that God's reputation will be damaged.

Here are two ways to translate this strong statement:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

And then what will happen to the honor of your great name? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

Then people will dishonor your great name. You will not be able to let them know how great you are.

Express this strong statement in a natural way in your language.

great name: The phrase great name refers to what people think about God. People thought that Yahweh was a great and powerful God. A god should be able to give his people success in battle.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

What will you do to protect your great reputation? (NET)

You will not be able to make people believe that you are a great God

Joshua 7:10

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:10–12

Yahweh explained to Joshua why the Israelites were defeated by the people of Ai.

7:10a

But the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ But Yahweh answered Joshua:
- ¶ Then Yahweh replied to Joshua:

But the LORD said to Joshua: The name LORD is Yahweh, the personal name of God.

7:10b

“Stand up! Why have you fallen on your face?”

- “Get up. You should not be lying on the ground like that.
- “Stand up. It is time to get up from the ground.

Stand up: Stand up is a command from Yahweh to Joshua and means that Joshua must arise to a standing position.

Why have you fallen on your face?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Yahweh rebuked Joshua for lying on the ground.

Here are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why are you lying on your face like this? (NLT)

- As a statement or a command. For example:

Stop lying there on the ground! (CEV)

Express this rebuke in a natural way in your language.

In Hebrew this clause has a word that means “like this,” or “in this way.” Include this phrase if it would be natural in your language.

fallen on your face: The word fallen refers to Joshua's action in 7:6b. He lay on the ground with his face down as a gesture of sorrow and humility. You should translate this in the same way as you did in 7:6b.

Joshua 7:11

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:10–12

Yahweh explained to Joshua why the Israelites were defeated by the people of Ai.

7:11

In 7:11 there are six verbs that describe Israel's sin. In Hebrew, there is a particle that precedes each verb.

This particle is sometimes translated “also.” There are two ways to interpret this Hebrew particle.

1. Some English versions do not translate this particle. They translate the verbs in 7:11 as a simple list. For example:

Israel has sinned; they have violated my covenant, which I commanded them to keep. They have taken some of the devoted things; they have stolen, they have lied, they have put them with their own possessions. (NIV) (NIV, RSV, ESV, NCV, NET, NJPS, REB, GNT)

1. Some English versions interpret this particle as marking emphasis. For example:

Israel has sinned; they have violated the covenant which I imposed on them. They have gone so far as to take what was under the curse of destruction, they have even stolen it; they have actually hidden it; they have put it in their baggage. (NJB) (BSB, NJB, GW, NASB, NLT)

It is not clear which interpretation is best. Option (1) is a good option to follow along with the majority of English versions. However, if you wish to give an emphatic sense to the verbs as in option (2) this is also acceptable.

7:11a **Israel has sinned;**

- The people of Israel have sinned.
- The Israelites have sinned.

Israel has sinned: A man named Achan took some of the things that were dedicated to Yahweh. Yahweh considered all the people of Israel to be guilty.

sinned: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sinned has the sense of “missing the right way” and “incurring guilt.” It is a general term for sin.

7:11b **they have transgressed My covenant that I commanded them,**

- They have not kept the covenant that I made with them.
- They have not done what they promised to do.

they have transgressed My covenant: This means that the Israelites did not obey God’s commands.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

broken my covenant (NLT)

they have broken the agreement with me that I ordered them to keep (GNT)

My covenant: Joshua told the Israelite people that everything in the town of Jericho must be destroyed. No Israelite must take anything from the town. Joshua’s commands followed the laws that God gave in Deuteronomy 20:10–20 about warfare. These laws were part of God’s covenant, or agreement, with the Israelites.

that I commanded them: God spoke through Joshua in verses 6:17–18 to remind the people of the laws about warfare which he gave them while Moses was still alive. Verse 7:11d explains which commands the people did not keep.

7:11c **and they have taken some of what was devoted to destruction.**

- They have taken some of the things that were set apart for me.
- They took some of the things from Jericho that I told them to destroy.

and they have taken some of what was devoted to destruction: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as devoted to destruction refers to the things which Yahweh commanded the Israelites to dedicate to him. You should translate it the same way you did in 7:1.

7:11d **Indeed, they have stolen and lied,**

- They stole those things and then lied about it.
- They have stolen the things which belong to me and they tried to deceive me

Indeed, they have stolen and lied: Although only the man named Achan has stolen anything, God regards all the people of Israel as guilty.

stolen: When Achan took some of the things which God told the people of Israel to destroy, he stole them from God.

7:11e **and they have put these things with their own possessions.**

- They hid the things which belong to me among their own belongings.
- by hiding them among their own things.

and they have put these things with their own possessions: Achan hid the things he stole from God with his own personal belongings.

possessions: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as possessions is a general word, used for equip-

ment, baggage, or belongings. You should choose a general, nonspecific word to translate possessions.

Joshua 7:12

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:10–12

Yahweh explained to Joshua why the Israelites were defeated by the people of Ai.

7:12a

This is why the Israelites cannot stand against their enemies.

- This is why the Israelite army cannot conquer their enemies,
- The Israelite soldiers will not win a battle against their enemies because of their sin.

This is why: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as *This is why* introduces the result of what the Israelites have done. Because they stole things dedicated to God, they cannot defeat the town of Ai. You should translate the words *This is why* with a word or phrase in your language that makes this connection clear.

the Israelites: The phrase the Israelites refers to the Israelite soldiers.

cannot stand against their enemies: The phrase cannot stand against their enemies means that the Israelite army is not able to defeat their enemies. They were not able to defeat the people of Ai, and they will not be able to defeat the people of any other town.

7:12b

They will turn their backs and run from their enemies,

- and why they run away from their enemies.
- Their enemies will defeat them in every battle,

They will turn their backs and run from their enemies: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as *They will turn their backs* is a Hebrew idiom. It means that the Israelite army turned back and ran away from

the soldiers of Ai. If you have a similar idiom in your language, consider using it here.

7:12c

because they themselves have been set apart for destruction.

- They have become a thing that is devoted to me, and they must die.
- because the Israelites themselves are now set apart for their enemies to destroy them.

because they themselves have been set apart for destruction:

The people of Israel became one of the things which was set apart for Yahweh. The Israelites were told to destroy the things in Jericho. Because they did not do so, now Yahweh will destroy them. If possible, use the same expression for the “thing devoted to destruction” that you used previously (see 6:17 and 7:1).

7:12d

I will no longer be with you

- I will not stay with you any longer
- I will no longer protect you

I will no longer be with you: The clause *I will no longer be with you* expresses a further result of their violating God's covenant. God will no longer help the Israelite army to defeat their enemies or protect them when they are attacked.

you: The pronoun *you* is plural. It refers to Joshua and all the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

I will not help you anymore (NCV)

I cannot help you anymore (CEV)

I will not remain with you any longer (NLT)

7:12e

unless you remove from among you whatever is devoted to destruction.

- unless you destroy the things set apart for me which some of you have.
- if you do not destroy the things that I commanded you to destroy.

unless you remove from among you whatever is devoted to destruction:

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *unless* introduces a condition. If the people of Israel do not destroy the devoted things,

then God will withdraw his presence and help from them.

remove from among you: This phrase means that the Israelites must not continue to keep the things which belong to Yahweh in their camp.

whatever is devoted to destruction: This phrase refers to the things which Achan stole from Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The things which belong to me

The things which I told you to destroy

The things which are set apart for me

General Comment on 7:12d-e

In some languages, it may be clearer to reverse the order of 7:12d and 7:12e. For example, you could say:

^{12e}If you do not destroy the devoted things from among you, ^{12d}then I will no longer be with you and help you.

Joshua 7:13

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:13

God told Joshua what to say to the Israelites.

7:13a

Get up and consecrate the people,

- ¶ Go and make the people holy.
- ¶ Tell the people to get ready to meet me.

Get up: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as Get up is literally “get up” or “stand up.” However, it can also be used to show the beginning of an action. It means “proceed” or “begin to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Proceed to sanctify the people (NRSV)

Go, consecrate the people (NIV)

Translate this idea of “proceed to action” in a way that is natural in your language.

consecrate the people: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates consecrate means that people are made holy for Yahweh by means of a ritual. They then belong to Yahweh. When the people of Israel do this, they will become pure again. In Exodus 19:10 the people were sanctified with the ritual of washing their clothes. In Exodus 19:15 they did not have sex. We do not know what ritual they followed in Joshua 7, so it is best to translate this word in a general way.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Purify the people

Make the people holy

Prepare the people to meet me

7:13b

saying, ‘Consecrate yourselves for tomorrow,

- Tell them to purify themselves for tomorrow.
- Tell them they must purify themselves in order to meet me tomorrow.

Consecrate yourselves for tomorrow: God told Joshua to have the people purify themselves so that they will be ready to meet with God the next day. Some English versions combine 13a and 13b because they repeat the same information.

Command the people to purify themselves in preparation for tomorrow (NLT)

Tell the people, ‘Get ready for tomorrow by performing the ceremonies to make yourselves holy.’ (GW)

7:13c

for this is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:

- Yahweh, the God of Israel, is saying to the Israelites:
- Tell them that I, Yahweh, the God of Israel

for: The connector that the BSB translates as for indicates the reason for God's judgment on Israel. Use a connector that is natural in your language.

this is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: This clause, what the LORD, the God of Israel, says, is an emphatic formula. It means that God will make an important declaration. God will make this declaration through the speech of Joshua. Use a natural way to show that the following speech is important and should be considered seriously.

These are embedded quotations. There is a quotation within a quotation within a quotation. God told Joshua to say to the people what God said. One way to translate 7:13a-c is:

God said, Get up Joshua, and sanctify the people. This is what you are to say to them, “Sanctify yourselves, because Yahweh, the God of Israel himself says this...

Translate these embedded quotes in a way that is natural in your language.

7:13d

Among you, O Israel, there are things devoted to destruction.

- ‘People of Israel, you have things in your camp that belong to me.
- know that they have hidden things in the camp that they should have set apart for me.

Among you: This phrase means that the devoted things were somewhere in the Israelite camp.

O Israel: The phrase O Israel shows that God is speaking to the people of Israel. It may not be possible in your language to put the addressee at the end of the sentence. You can put the addressee somewhere else in the sentence.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Israel, you have in your possession some things that I ordered you to destroy! (GNT)

Hidden among you, O Israel, are things set apart for the Lord. (NLT)

there are things devoted to destruction: The things devoted to destruction refer to the things that belong to God and that the Israelites must destroy. You should translate things devoted to destruction the same way you did in 7:1.

7:13e

You cannot stand against your enemies

- You will have to run away from your enemies,

- They will continue to flee from their enemies

You cannot stand against your enemies: The clause You cannot stand against your enemies means that the Israelites will not be able to defeat their enemies.

7:13f

until you remove them.

- until you destroy the things which I commanded you to destroy.’
- until they get rid of those things from their camp.

until you remove them: The Israelites must destroy the things that are dedicated for God’s use. God will not help them defeat their enemies until they obey him.

Joshua 7:14

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:14–15

God gave Joshua further instructions about what should happen the next day.

7:14

tribe by tribe...clan by clan...family by family: There are three Hebrew words in this verse that you should think about.

The Hebrew word שֵׁבֶט *shebet* that the BSB translates as tribe refers to the descendants of Jacob. Jacob had twelve sons. The twelve sons became the ancestors of twelve groups of people. All twelve groups in Israel spoke Hebrew. They did not speak twelve different languages. For this reason the word *shebet* is translated in the display as “clan.” Choose a word in your language that refers to a group of people descended from a common ancestor.

The Hebrew word מִשְׁפָּחָה *mishpahah* that the BSB translates as clan refers to a part of a clan. Each clan had several sub-clans. Each of Jacob’s sons had their own sons, and the sub-clans were named after these grandsons of Jacob. The word *mishpahah* is translated in the display as “sub-clan.”

The Hebrew word בֵּית bet that the BSB translates as family refers to a family or an extended family. The families do not have names. The word bet is translated in the display as “family.”

Here are some ways that these three terms are translated in English versions:

tribe...family...household (RSV, GW, NASB, KJV)

tribe...clan...family (BSB, NET, NIV, NABRE, NLT, GNT, CEV)

tribe...clan...household (ESV)

tribe...clan...ancestral house (NJPS)

clan...sub-clan...family (in the TN Display)

7:14a

In the morning you must present yourselves tribe by tribe.

- ¶ Tomorrow morning, you must come near to the Tent of Meeting one clan at a time.
- ¶ Tomorrow morning, the Israelite people must come before Yahweh clan by clan.

This verse begins with a Hebrew word that is often translated as “and.” This word makes a connection between the sin that the Israelites did and what Yahweh does next. There may be an appropriate word in some languages to show this connection, or no connecting word may be necessary. The BSB and many English versions leave the connection as implied information.

In the morning: The phrase In the morning can also be translated:

tomorrow morning

you must present yourselves: The people went near to Yahweh so that Yahweh could choose the guilty person. They stood in front of the Tent of Meeting, the place where Yahweh meets with his people. The Tent of Meeting is not mentioned in the Hebrew text or the BSB, but it may be clearer to make it explicit in some languages.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you must approach (NET)

you will come forward (CEV)

you must come near to Yahweh at the Tent of Meeting

tribe by tribe: The phrase tribe by tribe means that the Israelite people must come in twelve groups before Yahweh, with one tribe in each group.

tribe: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as tribe refers to the people who descended from one of the twelve sons of Jacob. Each of Jacob’s sons had children and grandchildren, and those descendants were part of his tribe. Choose a word that is appropriate for a group of people descended from a common ancestor.

7:14b

The tribe that the LORD selects shall come forward clan by clan,

- The clan that Yahweh chooses must come near one sub-clan at a time.
- The clan that Yahweh chooses by lot shall come sub-clan by sub-clan.

The tribe that the LORD selects: It is not certain how Yahweh told them which tribe he chose. Probably they cast lots, throwing small pebbles to determine the choice. 7:14 See TWOT, p. 171.

shall come forward clan by clan: When Yahweh chose one of the tribes, then each family in that tribe came before Yahweh.

clan: There were twelve tribes in the nation of Israel, named after the twelve sons of Jacob. Each tribe had several “clans.” A clan includes many families.

Here are some other ways to translate the word clan:

clan (BSB, NET, ESV, NIV, GNT, NLT)

sub-clan (used in the TN Display)

family group

branch (of a tribe)

7:14c

and the clan that the LORD selects shall come forward family by family,

- The sub-clan which Yahweh chooses must come near one family at a time.

- The sub-clan which Yahweh chooses by lot shall come family by family.

and the clan that the LORD selects shall come forward family by family: When Yahweh chose a clan, the people within that clan must come forward, one family at a time.

family: This refers to a group of relatives who live in the same house. Sometimes a family consisted of extended families who lived in several houses.

7:14d

and the family that the LORD selects shall come forward man by man.

- The family which Yahweh chooses must come near one man at a time.
- The family which Yahweh chooses by lot shall come man by man.

and the family that the LORD selects shall come forward man by man: After Yahweh chose one household, then the men of that household came forward one person at a time.

man by man: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as man refers to a male adult. Some English versions (NRSV, GNT, CEV, NLT) use a general word such as “person by person.” Translate this so that it is clear that the male adults came forward.

Joshua 7:15

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:14–15

God gave Joshua further instructions about what should happen the next day.

7:15a

The one who is caught with the things devoted to destruction

- The guilty person whom Yahweh selects because he has stolen Yahweh's things
- When the lot shows the guilty person who took what belongs to Yahweh

The one who is caught: Yahweh will choose one of the men. The people will know he is guilty because Yahweh will cause the lot to show this.

with the things devoted to destruction: The things devoted to destruction were things from Jericho that must be destroyed. The guilty person did not have the devoted things with him as he stood at the Tent of Meeting. Yahweh knew that this person had stolen them and hidden them. In some languages it might be helpful to make this explicit. For example, you could say:

he who has stolen the devoted things

7:15b

must be burned,

- must die and then be burned up.
- you must kill him and then destroy his corpse with fire.

must be burned: The fire must destroy him because he had become like one of the things in Jericho that belonged to Yahweh. In some languages it may be redundant to translate “burned with fire” because this is already implied by the word burned.

In 7:25 we learn that they killed the guilty person and then burned his body.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you shall kill that person and then burn his body in the fire

7:15c

along with all that belongs to him,

- All his family and everything he owns must burn up with him
- The fire must destroy him and his family and all his possessions,

along with all that belongs to him: The Hebrew is more literally “he and all that he has.” The word “he” is repeated in Hebrew for emphasis.

all that belongs to him: The phrase all that belongs to him refers to his family as well as his belongings. It may be necessary to make this explicit in some languages. For example:

along with his family and everything he owns (GNT)

7:15d**because he has transgressed the covenant of the LORD**

- because he has broken the agreement with Yahweh.
- because he has not kept the promise which the people of Israel made to Yahweh.

because: The connector that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason for the punishment of the guilty person.

he has transgressed the covenant of the LORD: The phrase he has transgressed the covenant of the LORD means that the person did not keep the promise which the Israelite people agreed to keep.

covenant: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as covenant refers to an agreement of loyalty made between two people. In the Old Testament it often refers to an agreement between God and his people.

7:15e**and committed an outrage in Israel.”**

- He has disgraced the people of Israel.”
- He has brought shame on the Israelites.”

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and introduces a second reason for the punishment of the guilty person.

committed an outrage in Israel: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as an outrage refers to something evil, such as a willful sin. Achan disgraced the Israelites by doing this deed.

Israel: The word Israel refers to the Israelite people. Achan did this sin among the people of Israel. For example:

has done a disgraceful thing among the people of Israel! (NCV)

Joshua 7:16**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:16–18

Yahweh chose Achan as the man who was guilty of the sin.

7:16a**So Joshua arose early the next morning**

- ¶ The next morning Joshua woke up early,
- ¶ Early the next morning Joshua got up

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as So introduces the result of God's instructions to Joshua and Israel. Use a natural way in your language to indicate a result.

Joshua arose early the next morning: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as arose early can also be translated as:

woke up early

got up early

7:16b**and had Israel come forward tribe by tribe,**

- and made each clan of Israel come near the Tent of Meeting one by one,
- and led the Israelites before Yahweh clan by clan.

and had Israel come forward tribe by tribe: Joshua told the people of Israel to come and stand in front of the entrance to the Tent of Meeting. Then each tribe came forward one tribe at a time.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua had Israel come forward by tribes (NIV)

he made Israel come forward tribe by tribe (NJB)

7:16c**and the tribe of Judah was selected.**

- and Yahweh chose the clan of Judah.
- Yahweh showed that the clan of Judah was guilty.

and the tribe of Judah was selected: The phrase was selected means that God chose the tribe of Judah. The method of choosing is unknown, but many scholars believe that they cast lots. To cast lots they threw small stones. The way the stones fell on the ground indicated the choice. The Israelites believed that God governed the way the stones fell.

The verb phrase was selected is passive. If you need to use an active verb in your language these are some ways you could translate this phrase:

the Lord chose the tribe of Judah (NCV)

the lot indicated the tribe was Judah (NJB)

Joshua 7:17

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:16–18

Yahweh chose Achan as the man who was guilty of the sin.

7:17a

He had the clans of Judah come forward,

- Then Joshua made the sub-clans of Judah come near the Tent of Meeting,
- When Joshua brought the sub-clans of the clan of Judah forward,

He had the clans of Judah come forward: The clause He had the clans of Judah come forward indicates that Joshua made each family stand in front of the Tent of Meeting one by one.

clans of Judah: Each “clan” in the tribe of Judah traced their ancestry back to one of the sons of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua brought the clans of Judah to the Lord (CEV)

He then had the clans of Judah come forward (NJPS)

7:17b

and the clan of the Zerahites was selected.

- and Yahweh chose the sub-clan of Zerah.
- Yahweh showed that the Zerah sub-clan was guilty.

and the clan of the Zerahites was selected: Zerah was one of the sons of Judah. The clan of Zerah included all the descendants of Zerah.

Zerahites: In Numbers 26:20 the man Zerah is shown as the head of one of the clans of the tribe of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate Zerahites:

the Zerah clan (CEV)

the descendants of Zerah

the Zerah branch of the Judah tribe

was selected: The phrase that the BSB translates as was selected indicates that Yahweh chose the clan of Zerah. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this with an active verb. For example:

Yahweh chose the clan of Zerah

7:17c

He had the clan of the Zerahites come forward,

- Then Joshua made the families in the sub-clan of Zerah come near the Tent of Meeting one by one,
- When Joshua brought the families of Zerah forward family by family

(NIV) he had the clan of the Zerahites come forward by families: The pronoun he refers to Joshua.

(NIV) had the clan of the Zerahites come forward: Joshua made the households in the clan of Zerah come and stand in front of the Tent of Meeting.

(NIV) by families: There is a textual issue in this verse that the BSB leaves untranslated.

1. Some Hebrew manuscripts, and the Syriac translation and Latin Vulgate translation say family by family. For example:

And he had the clan of the Zerahites come forward by families (NIV) (NIV, NRSV, NCV, NJPS, NLT, NJB, REB, GNT)

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text says man by man. For example:

And he brought near the clan of the Zerahites man by man (ESV) (ESV, RSV, GW, NASB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). “Family by family” fits the context better because it agrees with verse 7:14c.

7:17d**and the family of Zabdi was selected.**

- and Yahweh chose Zabdi's family.
- Yahweh showed that someone in the family of Zabdi was guilty.

and the family of Zabdi: Zabdi was the grandfather of Achan. He was mentioned in 7:1. Achan was a part of Zabdi's family.

was selected: Yahweh chose Zabdi. This showed that someone in Zabdi's family was guilty. The verb was selected is passive. It may be necessary in some languages to use an active verb. For example:

the Lord showed that Zabdi's family was guilty
(CEV)

Joshua 7:18**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:16–18

Yahweh chose Achan as the man who was guilty of the sin.

7:18a**And he had the family of Zabdi come forward man by man,**

- Then Joshua made each man of Zabdi's family come near the Tent of Meeting one by one.
- When Joshua brought the men of Zabdi's family forward man by man,

And: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. It may be clearer in some languages to begin a new sentence here.

he had the family of Zabdi come forward: The clause he had the family of Zabdi come forward means that Joshua told the family of Zabdi to stand near the entrance of the Tent of Meeting.

man by man: Each man of Zabdi's family stood one at a time before the Tent in order for the lot to show whether he was guilty or not.

7:18b**and Achan son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah, was selected.**

- Yahweh chose Achan, the son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah, of the clan of Judah.
- Yahweh showed that Achan was guilty. Achan was the son of Carmi, the grandson of Zabdi, the great-grandson of Zerah, of the clan of Judah.

and Achan son of Carmi, the son of Zabdi, the son of Zerah:

The author repeats the lineage of Achan as he did in 7:1. These are the names of his father, grandfather and great grandfather. You should translate this list in a way that is natural in your language. Some English versions leave this list of names implicit.

of the tribe of Judah: Achan's family traced their ancestry back to Judah, one of the sons of Jacob.

was selected: Yahweh selected Achan by means of the lot. In some languages, the passive verb was selected may need to be translated as an active verb. For example:

The Lord chose Achan son of Carmi (NCV)

Joshua 7:19**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:19

Joshua asked Achan to confess.

7:19a**So Joshua said to Achan,**

- ¶ Then Joshua told Achan:
- ¶ So Joshua said to him:

So Joshua said to Achan: After the lot showed that Achan was guilty, Joshua gave advice, or a warning, to Achan.

7:19b

“My son, give glory to the LORD, the God of Israel,

- “My son, honor Yahweh, the God of Israel.
- “Achan, bring glory to Yahweh, the God of Israel

My son: The direct address My son indicates that Joshua had higher status than Achan, and that he addressed him in a polite manner. It does not mean that Achan was really Joshua’s son. Use a form of address that is appropriate in this context. It may be more natural to not translate this phrase.

give glory to the LORD, the God of Israel: Joshua urged Achan to tell the truth. If Achan tells the truth, he will honor God and give glory to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Honor Yahweh, who is the God of Israel, by telling the truth

tell the truth here before the Lord, the God of Israel (GNT)

7:19c

and make a confession to Him.

- Confess your sin to him.
- and confess to him what you have done.

and make a confession to Him: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as make a confession:

1. It means confess. For example:

and confess (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NRSV, NJPS, NLT, REB, NCV, KJV)

1. It means give praise. For example:

and give him the praise (NIV) (NIV, RSV, NET, ESV, NABRE, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This fits well with the context.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

confess your sin to Yahweh

7:19d

I urge you to tell me what you have done;

- Tell me what you did.
- Tell me right now the wrong thing you have done.

7:19e

do not hide it from me.”

- Do not hide anything from me.”
- Do not keep it a secret.”

7:19d-e

I urge you to tell me what you have done; do not hide it from me: Joshua warned Achan that he must confess his sin and not attempt to keep it secret.

Joshua 7:20

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:20–21

Achan confessed his sin.

7:20a

“It is true,” Achan replied,

- ¶ So Achan told Joshua: “Truly
- ¶ Then Achan answered: “It is true

The Hebrew conjugation that the BSB leaves untranslated but the some English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this next event in a way that is most natural in your language.

It is true: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as It is true can also be translated:

truly (ESV)

Achan replied: Achan replied to Joshua’s warning.

7:20b

“I have sinned against the LORD, the God of Israel.

- I have sinned against Yahweh, the God of Israel.
- that I have sinned against Yahweh, who is Israel’s God.

I have sinned against the LORD, the God of Israel:
Achan acknowledged that he had sinned. This sin was against Yahweh, the God of Israel.

7:20c**This is what I did:**

- This is how I sinned:
- I will describe my sin to you.

This is what I did: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as This is what I did is literally “and like this, and like this.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that what follows is his confession. Some English versions do not translate this clause. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua 7:21**Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him**

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:20–21

Achan confessed his sin.

7:21a**When I saw among the spoils a beautiful cloak from Shinar,**

- I saw a beautiful robe from Babylon among the things from Jericho,
- I saw a beautiful Babylonian coat among the things the soldiers seized.

When I saw among the spoils: The phrase the spoils refers to the things that were taken by the Israelite soldiers when they conquered Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate the word spoils:

Among the plunder I saw (NLT)

among the booty I saw (REB)

Among the things we seized I saw (GNT)

a beautiful cloak: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as a cloak refers to the outer garment that an important person wears.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a beautiful robe

a beautiful cloak

from Shinar: Shinar is another name for the country of Babylon. You may want to use the more common name, Babylon, in your translation. For example:

a beautiful robe from Babylon (NLT)

In English the adjective form of Babylon is “Babylonian.” Thus, the GNT says:

a beautiful Babylonian cloak (GNT)

7:21b**two hundred shekels of silver, and a bar of gold weighing fifty shekels,**

- and more than five pounds of silver, and more than a pound of gold.
- I also saw about two kilograms of silver and a gold bar weighing about half a kilogram.

two hundred shekels of silver: A “shekel” is a measure of weight. It is not a coin. In the time of Joshua there was not yet any coined money. two hundred shekels of silver was about five pounds of silver, or more than two kilograms. The exact weight of a shekel was varied, so these weights are approximations. You can translate this using the standard measure of weight used in your country.

and a bar of gold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as bar is literally “tongue.” The gold was probably in a lump similar in shape to the tongue. Use an expression for a large piece of gold that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a gold bar (CEV)

a wedge of gold (NIV)

weighing fifty shekels: The weight, fifty shekels, was a little over one pound or about one-half kilogram. Translate this weight using the standard measure for precious metals in your country.

7:21c**I coveted them and took them.**

- I wanted them very much, so I took them.

- When I saw them, I wanted them so much that I stole them.

I coveted them: The phrase I coveted them means that Achan wanted to have these things very much. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as coveted is the same word used in the Ten Commandments in Exodus 20:17.

Here are some other ways to translate the word coveted:

I wanted these things very much for myself (NCV)

I wanted them so much (GNT)

I wanted them (NET)

and: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as and indicates the next event in the storyline.

took them: The things that Achan took belonged to Yahweh. It may be more appropriate in some languages to translate the word took as “stole.” This is how Yahweh describes Achan’s action in 7:11d.

7:21d

They are hidden in the ground inside my tent,

- I hid them in the ground underneath my tent,
- I dug a hole in the ground underneath my tent and hid them in it.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “behold” emphasizes the following word or clause. In this case, it adds emphasis to “They are hidden.” You may have a word or grammatical particle in your language that performs the same function. Many English versions leave this word untranslated.

They are hidden in the ground inside my tent: Achan took the things and buried them in a hole in the ground under his tent. In some languages an active verb may be necessary. For example:

I dug a hole under my tent and hid the silver, the gold, and the robe. (CEV)

I hid them in the earth inside my tent

7:21e

with the silver underneath.”

- and put the silver at the bottom of the hole with the other things on top of it.”

- The silver is underneath the gold and the robe.”

with the silver underneath: Achan buried the silver at the bottom of the hole, with the gold and the robe on top of it.

Joshua 7:22

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:22–26

Joshua and the Israelites stoned and burned Achan and his family.

7:22a

So Joshua sent messengers

- ¶ After Achan confessed Joshua sent men to search Achan’s tent.
- ¶ Then Joshua ordered some men to go and look for the things.

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So introduces the result after Achan confessed his sin. It may be clearer to make the connection explicit. For example, you could say:

So, after Achan had confessed his sin, Joshua sent messengers

Joshua sent messengers: The word messengers refers to people whom Joshua told to go and search Achan’s tent.

7:22b

who ran to the tent,

- These men ran to the tent,
- The men hurried to the tent.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event in the storyline. Some other English versions do not translate this word. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

ran to the tent: The phrase ran to the tent indicates that it was urgent to resolve this serious problem.

7:22c

and there it all was, hidden in his tent, with the silver underneath.

- and found the robe and the bar of gold with the silver underneath them.
- The robe and the bar of gold were buried in the ground on top of the silver as Achan said.

there: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as there emphasizes what happens next in the story. Some English versions do not translate this word, but many English versions translate it as “behold.” You may have a particle or another way in your language that has the same function. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

was, hidden in his tent: The men Joshua sent found the things buried under his tent, as he said they were. The verb phrase was, hidden in his tent is passive. In some languages it may be necessary to translate with an active verb. For example, you could say:

Achan had hidden it in his tent

with the silver underneath: The silver was buried at the bottom of the hole. The robe and the bar of gold were on top of the silver.

Joshua 7:23

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:22–26

Joshua and the Israelites stoned and burned Achan and his family.

7:23a

They took the things from inside the tent,

- So they took the stolen things from Achan’s tent
- Then the men took the things out of the ground under his tent

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event in the storyline. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

They: The word They here refers to the men whom Joshua sent to search for the stolen things.

the things: The phrase the things refers to the three stolen things.

7:23b

brought them to Joshua and all the Israelites,

- and brought them to Joshua. All the Israelites were standing and watching near him.
- and presented them to Joshua. All Israelite people were still gathered with him.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event in the storyline. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language.

brought them to Joshua and all the Israelites: The pronoun them here refers to the stolen things which the messengers found buried in the tent. The men who searched Achan’s tent brought the stolen things to Joshua and the people.

7:23c

and spread them out before the LORD.

- The men spread the things out in front of the Tent of Meeting.
- The men spread out the things on the ground in the presence of Yahweh.

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and indicates the next event in the storyline.

spread them out: The men spread out the stolen things on the ground before Joshua, so that everyone could see them.

before the LORD: The phrase before the LORD means “in the presence of Yahweh.” The presence of Yahweh is represented by the ark of the covenant, which was in the Tent of Meeting. The men spread out the stolen things in front of the Tent of Meeting.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

spread them out on the ground before the Lord
(NCV)

they laid them on the ground in the presence of
the Lord (NLT)

Joshua 7:24

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan's sin

Paragraph 7:22–26

Joshua and the Israelites stoned and burned Achan and his family.

7:24a

Then Joshua, together with all Israel, took Achan son of Zerah,

- Then Joshua, together with all the Israelites, led away Achan, whose father was Zerah.
- Then Joshua and the Israelite people took Achan, Zerah's son,

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the storyline.

Joshua, together with all Israel, took Achan son of Zerah: The Israelite people, with Joshua as their leader, took Achan away to the place where he will be punished.

Achan son of Zerah: The phrase son of Zerah recalls the genealogy of Achan in 7:1. It emphasizes that the correct person will be punished. Some English versions leave out this phrase. Consider whether this phrase is natural in your language or not.

7:24b

the silver, the cloak, the bar of gold,

- They brought along the silver and the robe and the bar of gold.
- with the things Achan stole from Yahweh.

the silver, the cloak, the bar of gold: These things were mentioned in 7:21. You should translate them the same way as you did there. If the repetition of the list is unnatural in your language, you can translate it as CEV has done:

the things he had stolen (CEV)

7:24c

his sons and daughters, his oxen and donkeys and sheep,

- They also took his sons and daughters, and his oxen and donkeys and sheep.
- They took him with his sons and daughters, and his oxen, donkeys, sheep, and goats,

his sons and daughters: The author specifies sons and daughters to indicate that Achan will have no descendants. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here.

his oxen and donkeys and sheep: oxen, donkeys and sheep were domestic animals. Listing the animals separately in Hebrew emphasizes that Achan did a serious thing. It may be more natural in some languages to use an inclusive term such as:

all his domestic animals

sheep: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sheep refers to both goats and sheep. These are animals that they herded in flocks.

7:24d

his tent, and everything else he owned,

- They took his tent and everything else that belonged to Achan,
- and his tent, and all his other possessions.

his tent, and everything else he owned: Everything else that Achan possessed was also brought with him to the Valley of Achor.

7:24e

and brought them to the Valley of Achor.

- and brought them to the Valley of Trouble.
- They brought them to Trouble Valley.

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and introduces the next event in the storyline.

brought them: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as brought indicates that the Valley of Achor was on higher ground than the place where the Israelites camped. The Israelites went uphill to reach it. In some languages it is natural to use the phrase “brought up” to indicate this. Many English versions translate this phrase as:

took them

them: The word them here refers to all Achan's family as possessions that were mentioned earlier in the

verse. In some languages it may be clearer to make this explicit.

to the Valley of Achor: We are not sure where the Valley of Achor was. Many scholars believe that it was a wilderness area eight miles north of Jericho. This means that Joshua took Achan far away from the Israelite camp.^{7:24} See, for example, Hess, p. 155.

Valley of Achor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Achor means “trouble.” There are two ways to translate the phrase Valley of Achor.

1. Translate it as “Valley of Trouble” or “Trouble Valley.” For example:

Valley of Disaster (NET) (NET, CEV, NCV, GNT)

1. Translate it as “Valley of Achor.” For example:

Valley of Achor (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NASB, NJB, NJPS, NLT, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and translate with a word meaning “trouble” or “disaster.” This will help readers to understand Joshua’s rhetorical question in 7:25.^{7:24} The term “Valley of Achor” also occurs in Isaiah 65:10 and Hosea 2:15.

If you choose option (2) it is recommended that you include a footnote explaining the meaning of Achor. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The name Achor means “trouble”

General Comment on 7:24

It is possible to break up this long Hebrew sentence into two or more shorter sentences. Some English versions also reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{24a}Then Joshua and all the people led Achan son of Zerah ^{24e}to the Valley of Trouble. ^{24b}They also took the silver, the coat, the gold, ^{24c}Achan’s sons, daughters, cattle, donkeys, sheep, ^{24d}tent, and everything he owned. (NCV)

Joshua 7:25

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him
Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:22–26

Joshua and the Israelites stoned and burned Achan and his family.

7:25a

“Why have you brought this trouble upon us?”

- “Why have you brought so much trouble on us?”
- “You have brought a lot of trouble for us,”

Why have you brought this trouble upon us?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Joshua rebuked Achan because he stole the devoted things and caused the Israelites to lose the battle of Ai.

Here are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Why did you bring this disaster on us? (GW)

- As a statement or exclamation. For example:

You have brought a lot of trouble on us^(excl)

I don’t know why you caused so much trouble for us! (NCV)

Express this rebuke in a natural way in your language.

brought this trouble: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as brought...trouble is the same word that Joshua used in 6:18. You should use the same word to translate it here as you did in that verse.

The Hebrew word for brought...trouble sounds like “Achor” the name of the valley.

7:25b

said Joshua.

- Joshua asked.
- Joshua said.

said Joshua: The Hebrew has this phrase at the beginning of 7:25a and begins with a word that many English versions translate as “and.” This word introduces the next event in the storyline. Indicate the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

In some languages it may be clearer to make the connection to the previous event explicit. For example:

When they arrived there, Joshua said

Joshua addressed Achan with a rhetorical question in 7:25a. If you translate it as a question, you need to think about how to introduce a question in your language. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

Joshua asked

7:25c

“Today the LORD will bring trouble upon you!”

- “Now Yahweh will bring the same trouble on you.”
- “Today Yahweh will bring trouble for you.”

Today the LORD will bring trouble upon you: Because Achan took the things that belonged to Yahweh, Yahweh punished Achan.

7:25d

And all Israel stoned him to death.

- Then all the people of Israel threw stones at him so that he died.
- Then all the Israelites threw stones at him until he died.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the storyline.

all Israel: The phrase all Israel means all the people of Israel.

stoned him to death: The phrase stoned him to death means that they threw stones at him until he died. 7:25 Hess suggests that Achan’s sons and daughters had to die with him so that Achan’s name will be forgotten. His sin was so grave that God did not allow him to have any descendants (Hess, p. 154). Butler suggests that “anyone who had come into contact with the goods was contaminated and had to be removed from the community to protect the community” (Butler, p. 86). Achan’s family came into contact with the stolen goods because he hid them inside his family tent.

7:25e

Then they stoned the others and burned their bodies.

- They also threw stones at his family so that they died. Then they burned the bodies and their things.
- They also killed his family by throwing stones at them. And they burned the bodies and the things that belonged to them.

Then they stoned the others: The stoning of Achan is mentioned first because he was the person who sinned. However, Achan’s family must die also.

The Hebrew clauses are not in chronological order. In some languages it may be clearer to rearrange them. First people stoned Achan, then they stoned his family, then they burned their bodies and their possessions.

and burned their bodies: There is disagreement among scholars as to whether their bodies refers to Achan’s possessions, or to the bodies of Achan and his family. Most English versions understand their bodies to refer to both the bodies and the possessions.

General Comment on 7:25d-e

These clauses can be reordered chronologically. It is also possible to include the implied information that Achan’s possessions were with him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

All the people then stoned Achan to death; they also stoned and burned his family and possessions (GNT)

And all the Israelites stoned Achan and his family and burned their bodies (NLT)

Joshua 7:26

Section 7:1–26 Achan sinned and God punished him

Achan disobeyed God. He took some of the things from Jericho that God told them to destroy. Because of his sin, the Israelites lost the battle against the town of Ai. Yahweh showed the Israelites that Achan was the one who had sinned, and they punished Achan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The defeat at Ai

Achan’s sin

Paragraph 7:22–26

Joshua and the Israelites stoned and burned Achan and his family.

7:26a

And they heaped over Achan a large pile of rocks

- Then they covered Achan’s body with a big pile of rocks.
- Then the Israelites piled up rocks to completely cover Achan’s body.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline.

they heaped over Achan a large pile of rocks: This phrase indicates that the people of Israel took stones and piled them over him until his body was hidden.

7:26b

that remains to this day.

- That pile of rocks is still here today.
- The heap of rocks has stood here until this time.

that remains to this day: This phrase indicates that the pile of stones was still there when the author wrote the book of Joshua.

7:26c

So the LORD turned from His burning anger.

- After that, Yahweh stopped being angry with the Israelites.
- Then Yahweh was no longer angry.

So: The Hebrew prefix that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

the LORD turned from His burning anger: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as turned from is more literally “turned back.” It indicates that Yahweh stopped being angry.

His burning anger: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as His burning anger is more literally “the burning of his anger.” This is an idiom. It means that Yahweh was angry at the Israelites. However, they obeyed him by destroying the devoted things, and so Yahweh was no longer angry.

7:26d

Therefore that place is called the Valley of Achor to this day.

- That is why the place where Achan was stoned is called the Valley of Trouble.
- Because of this, the name of that place is still called Trouble Valley.

Therefore: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces the reason why the place is called Achor.

that place is called the Valley of Achor: The word Achor in Hebrew means “trouble.” You should translate it as you did in 7:24e. It is recommended that you translate it as “Trouble Valley.”

to this day: This phrase this day refers to the time that the book of Joshua was written.

Joshua 8:1

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:1a

Then the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ Then Yahweh said to Joshua:
- ¶ Yahweh told Joshua:

Then the LORD said to Joshua: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Some English versions use a different word to mark the next event. Some do not use any word. For example:

And the Lord said to Joshua (RSV)

The Lord said to Joshua (GNT)

Use a natural way in your language to introduce the next event in the storyline.

8:1b

“Do not be afraid or discouraged.

- “Don’t^(sing) be afraid and don’t give up.
- “Do not be afraid at all.

Do not be afraid or discouraged: The two Hebrew words that the BSB translates as afraid and discouraged are imperative commands. The repetition of two synonyms makes this command emphatic. Joshua should not be afraid at all.

Translate this as an emphatic command. It is not necessary to use two verbs unless it is natural to do so. An adverb or an emphatic particle may be a more

natural way to express this idea. Some languages have an idiom with this meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged (NIV)

Don't be afraid or give up (NCV)

It may be helpful to add implicit information to make clear why Joshua might be afraid, as in the CEV:

Don't be afraid, and don't be discouraged by what happened at the town of Ai (CEV)

8:1c

Take the whole army with you,

- Take^(sing) all the soldiers with you^(sing)
- Take the whole army with you

Take the whole army with you: The phrase whole army refers to the Israelite soldiers.

8:1d

and go up and attack Ai.

- and go up to Ai.
- and attack Ai.

and go up and attack Ai: The Hebrew that the BSB translates as go up and attack is more literally “arise, go up.” The command “arise” is used to introduce a command. The command is “go up.” Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

go on up to Ai (GNT)

attack: As mentioned in the previous note, the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as attack is more literally “go up.” The town of Ai was at a higher elevation than Gilgal, where the Israelites camped. The Israelites went uphill to go from Gilgal to Ai. If your language does not keep track of elevation in this way, you can translate it as:

fight against Ai

Lead all your fighting men to Ai (NCV)

Ai: The town of Ai was mentioned in 7:2. You should translate it in the same way in both places.

8:1e

See, I have delivered into your hand the king of Ai,

- I will help you^(sing) to defeat the king of Ai.
- I will give the king of Ai,

See, I have delivered into your hand the king of Ai: It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

See: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as See is an emphatic word. It shows the importance of what Yahweh told Joshua. There may be another word or a grammatical particle in some languages to add emphasis. Some versions do not mark emphasis here. Use a word or a grammatical marker that is natural in your language.

I have delivered into your hand: The phrase I have delivered into your hand is a Hebrew idiom. It means that Yahweh will help Joshua and the Israelites to defeat the king of Ai.

your: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as your is singular. God is speaking to Joshua. It may be more natural in some languages to translate this as a plural. For example:

I will give the king of Ai into your hands

I will help you^(plur) to defeat the king of Ai

8:1f

his people, his city, and his land.

- You will defeat the people in Ai and conquer his land.
- and his people, and his city, and his land to you.

his people, his city, and his land: The word his refers to the king of Ai.

The phrase his people, his city, and his land emphasizes that Yahweh will give Joshua complete victory over every part of Ai. This includes its citizens and all the land that is under the power of the king.

Joshua 8:2

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers,

and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:2a

And you shall do to Ai and its king as you did to Jericho and its king,

- You will do the same thing to Ai and its king that you did to Jericho and its king.
- In the same way that you destroyed Jericho and its king, you must destroy Ai and its king.

And you shall do to Ai and its king: It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here. The command you shall do refers to what the Israelites did in Jericho. In some languages it may be more natural to make explicit what Joshua and the army must do. They must kill the people of Ai, as they killed the people of Jericho. For example:

Destroy Ai and kill its king as you did at Jericho (CEV)

as you did to Jericho and its king: Verse 6:21 said that the Israelites killed the men and women in Jericho with their swords. This is what they must also do to the king of Ai and the citizens.

8:2b

except that you may carry off their plunder and livestock for yourselves.

- However, you may take the things in the city and the domestic animals for yourselves.
- But you may take the things there for yourselves, including the cattle and the sheep.

except: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as except expresses contrast with what God commanded Israel previously regarding Jericho. Show contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

but

however

you may carry off for yourselves: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as carry off for yourselves is

more literally the simple verb “take.” In Jericho all the things belonged to God and the Israelites could not take them. But in Ai the Israelites can take these things for their own use.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

you may keep (these things) for yourselves (GNT)

you may carry off (these things) for yourselves (NIV)

their plunder and livestock: The Hebrew puts the phrase their plunder and livestock before “you may carry off for yourselves” in the sentence to show emphasis. You should emphasize this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

you may keep the livestock and everything else you want (CEV)

you may take its loot and livestock for yourselves (GW)

their plunder: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as plunder refers to things of value in the town that the Israelites could take.

livestock: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as livestock refers to domesticated animals. It can also include sheep and goats.

8:2c

Set up an ambush behind the city.”

- Get ready to attack the city by surprise from behind.”
- Tell some of your soldiers to go hide west of the city, so that they can attack it by surprise.”

It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

Set up an ambush behind the city: The phrase Set up an ambush indicates that some of the Israelite soldiers hid so that they could attack Ai by surprise.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

set an ambush behind the city (NET)

prepare to attack the city by surprise from the rear (GNT)

behind the city: The phrase behind the city indicates that the purpose of the “ambush” is to attack the town. In 8:9 it is clear that behind the city indicates the direction west of the town.

Joshua 8:3

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:3a

So Joshua and the whole army set out to attack Ai.

- ¶ So Joshua and all the soldiers started to go up to Ai.
- ¶ So Joshua and all his soldiers got ready to go to Ai.

So Joshua and the whole army set out: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as set out shows that a new action is beginning. This verb does not mean that Joshua was lying down. 8:3 Bratcher and Newman, p. 105.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua and all the fighting men set out to go up against Ai (NRSV)

Joshua and all the fighting men started to go up to Ai

and the whole army: The phrase the whole army refers to all the soldiers of Israel.

to attack Ai: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as to attack literally means “ascend.” Ai was at a higher elevation than the Israelite camp, and the Hebrew language keeps track of elevation. If your

language does not keep track of elevation in this way you can translate it as:

to go to Ai

to go and attack Ai

8:3b

Joshua chose 30,000 mighty men of valor

- Joshua picked out thirty thousand strong and brave soldiers
- And Joshua chose thirty thousand soldiers who were strong and brave

It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

Joshua chose 30,000 mighty men of valor: In 4:13 it says that there were forty thousand Israelite soldiers in total. Thirty thousand of them went to hide behind the town, and ten thousand of them stayed with Joshua.

mighty men of valor: The phrase mighty men of valor indicates that the soldiers Joshua chose were strong and brave.

8:3c

and sent them out at night

- and sent them out at night.
- and told them to march to Ai during the night.

and sent them out at night: The clause sent them out at night indicates that the soldiers whom Joshua chose went during the night. They went at night so that the people of Ai would not see them.

Joshua 8:4

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:4a with these orders:

- Joshua gave them these orders:
- Before they left, Joshua commanded them:

The Hebrew connector that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “And” introduces the next event in the storyline.

with these orders: Before they began to walk towards Ai, Joshua explained to them what they must do when they reached the town.

8:4b “Pay attention. You are to lie in ambush behind the city,

- “Listen carefully. You must hide yourselves behind the city.
- “Pay attention. Hide yourselves west of the city.

Pay attention: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Pay attention is literally “see.” It shows that what Joshua is about to say is important and that the soldiers should listen carefully. You may have a grammatical particle or another way to mark the importance of a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

listen carefully (NIV)

pay attention

lie in ambush behind the city: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lie in ambush indicates that the soldiers hid in order to attack the town by surprise.

behind the city: The soldiers are to hide on the far side of the town. From 8:12 it is clear that behind the city indicates the direction to the west of the town.

8:4c not too far from it. All of you must be ready.

- Do not hide far away from it. Be ready to attack it.
- Stay close to the city and be prepared to attack it.

not too far from it: This indicates that the soldiers must hide themselves close to the town.

All of you must be ready: The soldiers must be ready to attack at any time.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

be ready to attack (GNT)

Joshua 8:5

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:5a Then I and all the troops with me will advance on the city.

- I and all the people who are with me will march to the city.
- My men and I will all approach the city,

Then I and all the troops with me: The phrase all the troops with me refers to the ten thousand Israelite soldiers who stayed with Joshua and who did not hide behind Ai.

will advance on the city: The phrase will advance on the city indicates that Joshua and the soldiers with him will move toward the town as if they are going to attack it.

8:5b When they come out against us as they did the first time,

- When the Ai soldiers come out against us^(excl), as they did before,
- and they will come out to fight us as they did the first time.

When: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as When introduces the next event in the storyline.

they come out against us: The clause they come out against us indicates that the soldiers of Ai will come out of the town gate to attack the Israelite soldiers.

us: The word us is exclusive. Joshua spoke to the soldiers who were not with him.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

when they come out of the town to attack us^(excl)

as they did the first time: The phrase as they did the first time refers to the first time that the Israelites tried to capture Ai in 7:4–5. Some English versions place this phrase at the end of verse 5c. For example:

When the men of Ai come out against us, we will turn and run, just as we did the first time. (GNT)

8:5c

we will flee from them.

- we^(excl) will turn and run away.
- Then we will run away from them.

we will flee from them: The clause we will flee from them indicates that the soldiers who are with Joshua will run away from the soldiers of Ai.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

we^(excl) will run away from them

Joshua 8:6

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:6a

They will pursue us

- They will come out of the city and chase us^(excl)
- Then they will come out and run after us

It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

They will pursue us: The clause They will pursue us indicates that the soldiers of Ai will come out of their town and chase the Israelites when they run away.

8:6b

until we have drawn them away from the city,

- until we lead them far away from the city.
- and we will trick them into going away from the city.

until we have drawn them away from the city: The clause until we have drawn them away from the city indicates that the Israelite soldiers continued to run away until the soldiers of Ai were far from their town.

until: The English word until can also be spelled “till” as in most English versions.

have drawn them away: The expression drawn them away indicates that they lured them or enticed them to leave.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

we will trick them into going far from their town

8:6c

for they will say, ‘The Israelites are running away from us as they did before.’

- They will say: ‘They are running away from us as they did before.’
- They will think we are running away from them, as we did the first time.

for: The word for introduces the reason why the citizens of Ai left the town in 8:6a-b. Use a natural way in your language to indicate reason. It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

they will say, ‘The Israelites are running away from us as they did before.’: The clause they will say introduces what the soldiers of Ai would think and say to each other. In some languages it might be more natural to use an indirect quote. For example:

They will pursue us until we have led them away from the city. They will think that we are running from them, as we did before. (GNT)

as they did before: The citizens of Ai assumed that the Israelites would act the same way that they did the first time.

8:6d

So as we flee from them,

- When we run away from them
- While we are running

So as we flee from them: The clause So as we flee from them repeats information that Joshua stated in verse 8:5c. Even though this phrase is at the end of a verse, it is the beginning of a new sentence. For example:

^{6d}So when we flee from them, ^{7a}you are to rise up from ambush and take the town, (NIV)

Joshua 8:7

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:7a

you are to rise from the ambush and seize the city,

- then you^(plur) must come out from where you are hiding and take the city.
- you should come out from behind the city and capture it.

you are to rise from the ambush: This clause indicates the next step in Joshua's plan. First the Israelite soldiers with Joshua will lead the Ai soldiers away from the town. Then the soldiers who are hiding will attack the town.

and seize the city: The phrase seize the city indicates that the Israelites would defeat the people who remained in the town and capture it.

8:7b

for the LORD your God will deliver it into your hand.

- Yahweh your^(plur) God will give it to you.
- Yahweh your God will help you to take it.

for: The word for introduces the reason for Israel's success.

the LORD your God will deliver it into your hand: Yahweh will enable the Israelite soldiers to defeat the town. The Israelites captured the town because of the power of Yahweh, and not because of their own cleverness or strength.

deliver it into your hand: The expression deliver it into your hand is a Hebrew idiom. It means that Yahweh will help Joshua and the Israelites to defeat the king of Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

The Lord your God will give you the power to win.
(NCV)

The Lord our God will help you capture the town.
(CEV)

Joshua 8:8

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:8a

And when you have taken the city,

- After you^(plur) have taken the city,
- After you defeat the city and its people,

And: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as And is the normal way to indicate the next event of the story. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

when you have taken the city: The clause when you have taken the city refers to the time after the Israelite soldiers have captured the town. For example:

After you have taken the city (GNT)

8:8b

set it on fire. Do as the LORD has commanded!

- you^(plur) must set it on fire. This is what Yahweh says.
- burn the city, as Yahweh commanded.

set it on fire: Joshua commanded the Israelites to burn the buildings and other flammable objects in the town.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

light the town on fire

burn the town

Do as the LORD has commanded: Joshua told the Israelite soldiers that this was the command of Yahweh.

8:8c

See, I have given you orders.”

- I am telling you^(plur) his commands.”
- This is the command I am giving you.”

See: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as See emphasizes the importance of the command. You may have some other word or grammatical marker to emphasize that this command is important.

I have given you orders: The clause I have given you orders refers to the instructions that Joshua gave the soldiers. As Yahweh’s spokesperson, Joshua gave the soldiers Yahweh’s commands.

Joshua 8:9

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

Paragraph 8:9

In verses 8:4–8 Joshua gave instructions to the thirty thousand soldiers who will carry out the ambush. In 8:9 those soldiers started to go to their hiding place west of Ai.

8:9a

So Joshua sent them out,

- ¶ So Joshua sent them out
- ¶ Then Joshua sent the thirty thousand soldiers on their way

So Joshua sent them out: The clause Joshua sent them out indicates that Joshua ordered the soldiers who were to hide behind Ai to begin to move towards the town.

8:9b

and they went to the place of ambush

- and they went to their hiding place.
- and they went to a place where they could hide.

and they went to the place of ambush: The soldiers walked to the place where they hid until the time came to attack the town.

8:9c

and lay in wait between Bethel and Ai, to the west of Ai.

- And they stayed there on the west side of Ai, between Ai and Bethel.
- They hid on the west side of Ai, between Ai and Bethel, and waited to attack.

and lay in wait between Bethel and Ai: The soldiers found a place to hide between the towns of Bethel and Ai. They hid and waited there until the rest of the Israelite soldiers came to Ai the next day.

lay in wait: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lay is more literally “stayed” or “remained.” The soldiers stayed there overnight and probably many of them lay down to sleep.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they stayed between Bethel and Ai

they hid between Bethel and Ai

to the west of Ai: The place where the soldiers hid was west of Ai. The town of Bethel was further west of their hiding place.

8:9d

But Joshua spent that night among the people.

- But Joshua stayed that night in the camp with the rest of the army.
- But Joshua spent the night in the camp.

But Joshua spent that night among the people: The clause Joshua spent that night among the people indicates that Joshua stayed with the rest of the Israelite soldiers in the camp. For example:

Joshua spent the night with the rest of the troops (NJPS)

Joshua 8:10**Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.**

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:10a

Joshua got up early the next morning and mobilized his men,

- ¶ Joshua got up early the next morning and gathered the people together.
- ¶ Early the next morning Joshua assembled the soldiers.

The Hebrew connector that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event of the storyline.

Joshua got up early the next morning: This indicates that Joshua woke up early.

and mobilized his men: The clause mobilized his men indicates that Joshua assembled the rest of his army and got them ready to go to Ai.

mobilized: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as mobilized can also be translated as:

assembled

gathered together

8:10b

and he and the elders of Israel marched before them up to Ai.

- He and the leaders of Israel led the soldiers up to Ai.
- Then he and the other leaders of Israel marched in front of the army to Ai.

and he and the elders of Israel marched before them up to Ai: Joshua and the elders of Israel led the way as the army went up to Ai.

the elders of Israel: the elders of Israel were the leaders of the Israelite community. They were heads of tribes and families.

marched before them up: The Hebrew text says marched...up because Ai was higher than the Israelite camp. If your language does not keep track of elevation in the same way that Hebrew does, you can translate this as:

went

Joshua 8:11**Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.**

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:11a

Then all the troops who were with him marched up

- All the soldiers who were with him walked up
- The soldiers who were with him went

Then: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event of the storyline.

all the troops who were with him: The phrase all the troops refers to the Israelite soldiers who were with Joshua. The word him refers to Joshua, who was the commander of the army.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

all the soldiers who were with Joshua

marched up: The Hebrew text says marched up because Ai was higher than the Israelite camp. If your language does not keep track of elevation in the same way that Hebrew does, you can translate this as:

went

8:11b

and approached the city. They arrived in front of Ai

- until they got near Ai city.
- to Ai.

and approached the city: The clause approached the city indicates that the soldiers walked until they were close to the town of Ai.

8:11c

and camped to the north of it, with the valley between them and the city.

- They camped north of Ai with the valley between them and Ai.
- They set up camp on the north side of the city, with a valley between themselves and Ai.

and camped to the north of it: The clause camped to the north of it indicates that the soldiers set up their tents on the northern side of the town of Ai. It may be clearer in some languages if you begin a new sentence here. For example:

They set up camp north of Ai (NIV)

with the valley between them and the city: The Israelite soldiers made their camp north of the town, with a valley separating them from the town of Ai.

General Comment on 8:11

Because the information contained in 11a-b is already stated in 8:10, it may be more natural in some lan-

guages to leave this information implicit, as the CEV does:

They set up camp in full view of the town, across the valley to the north. (CEV)

Joshua 8:12

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:12a

Now Joshua had taken about five thousand men

- Then Joshua ordered about five thousand soldiers
- And Joshua chose about five thousand men

Now Joshua had taken about five thousand men: This clause indicates that Joshua gave orders to about five thousand soldiers.

In verse 8:3 it says that thirty thousand men were part of the ambush. In this verse it says there were five thousand men. The commentaries do not suggest any good way to reconcile these different numbers. It is recommended that you translate them literally.

had taken: There are two ways to interpret the meaning of the verb had taken.

1. The form of the verb indicates the next event in the story. For example:

He took five thousand men (NET) (NET, RSV, ESV, NJPS, GNT, NLT, KJV)

1. The form of the verb indicates an event that has already happened. For example:

Joshua had taken about five thousand men (NIV) (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation followed by many English versions and by many commentaries.

8:12b

and set up an ambush between Bethel and Ai, to the west of the city.

- to hide and be ready to attack on the west side of Ai, between Ai and the city of Bethel.
- and sent them west of the city between Bethel and Ai. He told them to hide there and be ready to attack.

and set up an ambush: The clause set up an ambush indicates that Joshua told them to hide and wait to attack Ai.

between Bethel and Ai, to the west of the city:

Bethel was three kilometers west of Ai. 8:12 Bratcher and Newman, p. 110. The soldiers hid themselves Bethel and Ai.

Joshua 8:13

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:13a

So the forces were stationed

- And Joshua and the leaders put the soldiers in their places.
- So the soldiers went to the right positions.

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. Often this word is translated as “and.”

the forces were stationed: The clause the forces were stationed indicates that Joshua and the leaders of Israel arranged the army in their places to attack the soldiers of Ai.

8:13b

with the main camp to the north of the city and the rear guard to the west of the city.

- The main camp was north of Ai and the rest of the soldiers went to the west.
- The main army was north of Ai, and the other soldiers hid west of the city.

with the main camp to the north of the city: It may be clearer to begin a new sentence here. The main group of soldiers was in their camp north of Ai.

and the rear guard to the west of the city: The rear guard refers to the soldiers who hid west of Ai so that they could attack by surprise.

8:13c

And that night Joshua went into the valley.

- But Joshua spent that night in the valley.
- But that night Joshua stayed in the valley that was between the army and Ai.

And that night Joshua went into the valley: The phrase into the valley refers to the valley mentioned in 8:11c that was between the Israelite camp and the town of Ai. Joshua may have gone down into the valley so that he would know the best way to conduct the battle the next morning. 8:13 Boling, p. 239.

Joshua 8:14

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:14a**When the king of Ai saw the Israelites,**

- ¶ When the King of Ai saw the Israelite army,
- ¶ But the king of Ai saw Joshua and the Israelites.

When the king of Ai saw the Israelites: The King of Ai saw Joshua's main army in its place north of the town, ready to attack the town.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

When the king of Ai saw the Israelite army

8:14b**he hurried out early in the morning with the men of the city**

- he and the people of his city got up early in the morning, and hurried out.
- So he and his army went out early

he hurried out early in the morning with the men of the city: The phrases he and the men of the city refer to the same group of fighting men in Ai. They can be translated as one phrase. For example:

he and all the men of the town hurried (NIV)

he hurried out: The phrase he hurried out indicates that they went quickly.

8:14c**to engage them in battle at an appointed place overlooking the Arabah.**

- They went to a place near the valley of the Jordan River, to attack the Israelites.
- to meet the Israelites at a place near the valley of the Jordan River and fight them there.

to engage them in battle: The phrase to engage them in battle indicates that the king of Ai intended to fight as he had done the day before.

at an appointed place overlooking the Arabah: The Hebrew text is more literally "at the meeting place near the Arabah."

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

to the meeting place near the Arabah (NET)

to meet...at a certain place overlooking the Arabah (NIV)

toward the Jordan Valley to fight...at the same place as before (GNT)

The army of Ai went toward the valley of the Jordan River. Some English versions include the implied information that the place was on the downhill slope toward the Jordan River. For example:

to the descent toward the Arabah (RSV)

on the slope facing the Arabah (NJB)

the Arabah: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the Arabah refers to the valley of the Jordan River. This was east of the town of Ai. For example:

at a place overlooking the Jordan Valley (NLT)

8:14d**But he did not know that an ambush had been set up against him behind the city.**

- But the king did not know that there were more soldiers hiding behind the city.
- But he didn't realize that there were Israelite soldiers behind the city.

But he did not know that an ambush had been set up against him behind the city: The clause an ambush had been set up against him refers to the Israelite soldiers who hid to attack the town by surprise. The king of Ai did not know about these soldiers.

behind the city: The phrase behind the city indicates the direction west of the town.

Joshua 8:15**Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.**

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:15a

Joshua and all Israel let themselves be beaten back before them,

- Joshua and his soldiers pretended to run away
- Joshua and the Israelite army ran away as if they were defeated.

The Hebrew connector that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “And” indicates the next event in the story.

Joshua and all Israel let themselves be beaten back before them: Joshua and the Israelite soldiers pretended that the soldiers of Ai were winning the battle by running away from them.

all Israel: The phrase all Israel refers to the Israelite soldiers.

8:15b

and they fled toward the wilderness.

- toward the wilderness.
- They ran toward the wilderness.

and they fled toward the wilderness: The word fled means “ran away.” The Israelite soldiers ran away towards the wilderness.

the wilderness: The wilderness refers to the uninhabited land east of Ai, between Ai and the Jordan River valley. Only a little vegetation grows in this area. Although some English versions use the word “desert,” this area is not sand. It is a rocky area that leads down to the Jordan River valley.

Joshua 8:16

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:16a

Then all the men of Ai were summoned to pursue them,

- So the king of Ai called all his soldiers together to chase the Israelites.
- So all the men of Ai gathered together to chase the Israelites.

Then all the men of Ai: The phrase all the men of Ai refers to the fighting men of Ai.

were summoned to pursue them: The phrase were summoned is a passive.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the king called them together

they all gathered together

8:16b

and they followed Joshua and were drawn away from the city.

- As they chased Joshua, they were lured away from the city.
- Joshua’s army kept running so that they could lead them further away from Ai.

and they followed Joshua: The phrase they followed Joshua implies that the soldiers of Ai chased the Israelite soldiers. It may be clearer to make this information explicit in some languages.

For example:

and as the army of Ai pursued Joshua and his army

were drawn away from the city: The Israelite army kept running away from the town so that the soldiers of Ai would go far away from it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they were lured away from the city (NIV)

they kept getting farther away from the city (GNT)

they were deceived into going far from the town

Joshua 8:17

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:17a

Not a man was left in Ai or Bethel who did not go out after Israel,

- Not even one man was left in Ai or Bethel; they all ran out after Israel.
- Every single fighting man in Ai and Bethel went to chase the Israelite army.

Not a man was left in Ai or Bethel who did not go out after Israel: The clause Not a man was left refers to the men who were able to fight. Every fighting man went out.

Not a man was left...who did not go out: This use of Not and not is an example of a double negative in English. These two negative words together have an emphatic positive sense. In other words, every man went after Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

every man in Ai went (GNT)

not a man stayed (NCV)

in Ai or Bethel: The word Bethel is in the Hebrew text and in most English versions. Some versions omit the word Bethel because this town was not mentioned in the preceding verses.

It is recommended that you include the word Bethel. The towns of Ai and Bethel were close together. The

people of Bethel went to help the men of their neighboring town.8:17 Hess, p. 166.

8:17b

leaving the city wide open while they pursued Israel.

- The city was wide open; and they chased after Israel.
- They left the city gates open when they left it to run after the Israelites.

leaving the city wide open while they pursued Israel: The soldiers of Ai ran out of the town gates and left them open, so that anyone could enter.

Joshua 8:18

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:18a

Then the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ Then Yahweh told Joshua:
- ¶ Then Yahweh commanded Joshua:

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces a new event in the storyline.

the LORD said to Joshua: The words that Yahweh told Joshua are a command.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Yahweh told Joshua

Yahweh commanded Joshua

8:18b

“Hold out your battle lance toward Ai,

- “Point your^(sing) sword toward Ai,
- “Stretch out your arm and point the spear that you are holding towards Ai.

Hold out your battle lance toward Ai: The clause Hold out your battle lance toward Ai indicates that Joshua must extend his arm to its full length with the javelin pointing towards Ai.

battle lance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as battle lance refers to either a short sword used for thrusting and hunting, or a curved, crescent-shaped sword. 8:18 Holladay, p. 156. These are some other ways that English versions have translated it:

sword (NRSV)

curved sword (NET)

spear (GNT)

You should choose a word that is similar in meaning to one of these terms and will be understood by your readers.

8:18c

for into your hand I will deliver the city.”

- because I am going to help you^(sing) defeat it.”
- I will give you power to conquer it.”

for into your hand I will deliver the city: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as into your hand I will deliver is an idiom. It indicates that Yahweh will enable Joshua and his army to defeat the town of Ai.

8:18d

So Joshua held out his battle lance toward Ai,

- So Joshua pointed his sword toward Ai.
- Joshua did what Yahweh commanded him to do.

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So introduces a new event in the storyline.

Joshua held out his battle lance toward Ai: Joshua obeyed the command that Yahweh gave him. If this repetition is not natural in your language, you can translate the meaning in another way. For example:

Joshua did as he was told (GNT)

So Joshua held out his spear (GW)

So Joshua did what Yahweh commanded him

Joshua 8:19

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:19a–b

Scholars disagree about whether Joshua pointed his javelin toward Ai as a signal to the men who were hiding, or as a symbol of God’s action in defeating the town. It seems likely that it served both functions. It signaled the troops to advance, and it symbolized God’s power and victory over Ai. In 8:19 the focus is on the signal to the soldiers, but 8:26 shows that the outstretched arm is also a symbol of God’s victory.

8:19a

and as soon as he did so,

- When Joshua stretched out his hand,
- As soon as Joshua raised his hand,

and as soon as he did so: When Joshua stretched out his hand with the lance, it was a signal to the troops to attack. Some English versions make this explicit. For example:

When the Israelites who were in ambush saw this (NCV)

As soon as he did this, the men in the ambush rose quickly (NIV)

as soon as he lifted his hand, the men who had been hiding got up quickly (GNT)

8:19b

the men in ambush rose quickly from their position.

- the soldiers who were hiding quickly got up.

- the soldiers behind the city quickly came out from where they were hiding.

the men in ambush rose quickly from their position:

This clause indicates that the soldiers who were hiding got up from their hiding places. They knew that the time had come to attack the town.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the men who had been hiding got up quickly (GNT)

General Comment on 8:19a-b

In some languages it is more natural to change the order of 19a and b to reflect the order in the original language. For example:

^{19b}The soldiers rose quickly from where they were hiding ^{19a}as soon as Joshua stretched out his hand

8:19c

They rushed forward, entered the city, captured it,

- They ran into the city and captured it.
- They entered the city through the open gates and captured it,

They rushed forward, entered the city, captured it:

The soldiers ran through the open gates and captured the town.

8:19d

and immediately set it on fire.

- Immediately they set the city on fire.
- and they quickly set it on fire.

and immediately set it on fire: The soldiers quickly set fire to the houses and other things in the town.

Joshua 8:20

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:20a

When the men of Ai turned and looked back,

- When the soldiers of Ai looked behind them
- Then the men of Ai turned around and looked back toward Ai

When the men of Ai turned and looked back: The soldiers of Ai were chasing the Israelite soldiers. At some point, they turned around and looked back towards their town. The story does not say why they looked back. Perhaps they heard noise coming from the direction of the town.

8:20b

the smoke of the city was rising into the sky.

- they saw that the sky was filled with smoke.
- and saw smoke rising to the sky because the city was burning.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “behold” is used to emphasize what happens next. You may have a word or particle in your language that is used for emphasis. Many English versions do not translate this word. It may be more natural to leave this word implicit.

the smoke of the city was rising into the sky: The clause the smoke of the city was rising into the sky indicates that the sky was filled with smoke because the town was burning.

8:20c

They could not escape in any direction,

- But there was nowhere that they could run and escape
- None of them had the courage to run away

They could not escape in any direction: The clause They could not escape in any direction indicates that the soldiers of Ai were surrounded, and so could not escape. They were caught between the two parts of the Israelite army.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

There was no way for them to escape (GNT)

they had no chance to escape in any direction (NIV)

they had nowhere to go (NLT)

They could not escape: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as They could not implies a loss of courage. Some English versions make this explicit. For example:

None of them had the courage to run (NJB)

were so shocked they were unable to flee (NET)

8:20d
and the troops who had fled to the wilderness now became the pursuers.

- because the Israelites who led them to the wilderness turned back on them.
- because the Israelites who ran away toward the wilderness now turned around to attack them.

and the troops who had fled to the wilderness now became the pursuers: The clause and the troops who had fled to the wilderness refers to Joshua and the Israelite soldiers who had pretended to run away. These are the same people referred to in 8:15.

now became the pursuers: The phrase that the BSB translates as became the pursuers is translated as “turned back against the pursuers” in most English versions. With either interpretation, the Israelite soldiers who had run away from the town now turned around and fought with the soldiers of Ai.

the pursuers: According to the BSB interpretation, the phrase the pursuers refers to Joshua and the Israelite soldiers who had pretended to run away. However, most English versions indicate that the pursuers refers to the soldiers of Ai.

Joshua 8:21

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:21a

When Joshua and all Israel saw that the men in ambush had captured the city

- Joshua and the Israelite army saw that the soldiers in hiding had taken the city
- Joshua and his men saw that the other soldiers had captured the city

When The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as When is used to give prominence to Joshua and his men and what they saw. You should translate the word with a connecting word that is most natural in your language. In some languages it may be most natural to omit them.

Joshua and all Israel saw that the men in ambush had captured the city: The phrase Joshua and all Israel refers to Joshua and the soldiers who were with him.

the men in ambush: The phrase the men in ambush refers to the men who were hiding behind Ai.

had captured the city: The clause had captured the city indicates that the soldiers who were in hiding had attacked the town and defeated Ai.

8:21b

and that smoke was rising from it,

- and that the sky was full of smoke because the city was burning.
- and that smoke was rising from the city.

and that smoke was rising from it: The clause that smoke was rising from it indicates that the town was burning. The smoke was the visible signal of this for them.

8:21c

they turned around and struck down the men of Ai.

- So they turned and attacked the soldiers of Ai.
- Then they turned back towards the city and attacked the people of Ai.

they turned around: The clause they turned around indicates that Joshua and the soldiers with him stopped running away. They turned around to face the soldiers of Ai.

and struck down the men of Ai: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as struck is more literally “hit.” This is an idiom. It means that the Israelite soldiers attacked them.

Joshua 8:22

Section 8:1-29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1-9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10-27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28-29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:22a

Meanwhile, those in the ambush came out of the city against them,

- The other Israelite soldiers came out of the city to help attack them.
- The Israelites soldiers from the city also came to attack the Ai soldiers.

Meanwhile: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Meanwhile is used to add emphasis to what happens next. Use a connecting word that is most natural in your language. It may be most natural to leave the word implicit.

those in the ambush came out of the city against them: This clause indicates that the Israelite soldiers who captured the town now came out of it to help Joshua and the rest of the army attack the soldiers of Ai.

8:22b

and the men of Ai were trapped between the Israelite forces on both sides.

- The men of Ai were caught between the armies of Israel.
- So the Israelite army surrounded the army of Ai on both sides.

and the men of Ai were trapped between the Israelite forces on both sides: The clause were trapped between the Israelite forces on both sides indicates that the soldiers of Ai were surrounded by the Israelite army. It may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

on both sides: This indicates that the Israelite army were on both sides of the men of Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the soldiers of Ai were caught between the two groups of Israelite soldiers

the Israelite soldiers were around them in front and behind

the Israelite soldiers surrounded the soldiers of Ai

8:22c

So Israel struck them down

- The Israelite army attacked them
- Then the Israelite soldiers killed them

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. It may be clearer in some languages to begin another sentence here.

Israel struck them down: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as struck...down is more literally "hit." This is an idiom. It means that the Israelites attacked them and killed them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Israel smote them (RSV)

Israel cut them down (NIV)

Israel attacked them (NLT)

8:22d

until no survivor or fugitive remained.

- and none of the men of Ai was left alive. None of them escaped.
- and all the Ai soldiers died. Not one of them escaped

until no survivor or fugitive remained: This clause indicates that the Israelite army killed all the soldiers of Ai. The Israelites did not let any of them escape and run away. They killed them all. For example:

until no one was left who survived or escaped (NRSV)

Joshua 8:23

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:23

But they took the king of Ai alive and brought him to Joshua.

- But they did not kill the king of Ai. They captured him and brought him to Joshua.
- except the king of Ai. They captured him and took him to Joshua.

But they took the king of Ai alive and brought him to Joshua: The Israelite soldiers killed all the soldiers of Ai, but they did not kill the king. Instead they captured him and brought him to Joshua.

In Hebrew the object of the sentence, the king of Ai, comes first for emphasis. It may be more natural in some languages to move it to its normal place in the clause. For example:

But they took alive the king of Ai (NASB)

Another way to translate the sentence is by using a passive construction. This may allow you to put the king of Ai at the front of the sentence. For example:

But the king of Ai was taken alive (NRSV)

Joshua 8:24

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua

to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:24a

When Israel had finished killing all the men of Ai

- ¶ The Israelite soldiers killed all the Ai soldiers
- ¶ The Israelite army finished killing all the fighting men of Ai

When Israel: The word Israel refers to the Israelite army.

had finished killing: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as killing means that the Israelite army killed all the soldiers of Ai.

all the men of Ai: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as men refers to the men of Ai who had come out to fight the Israelites.

8:24b

who had pursued them into the field and wilderness,

- in the wilderness where they chased them.
- in the wilderness to which the Israelites led them.

who had pursued them into the field and wilderness: In 8:15 Joshua and his army pretended to be afraid and ran away into the wilderness between Ai and the Jordan River Valley. In 8:20 the soldiers of Ai chased them there. In this verse the roles are reversed. Israel chased the soldiers of Ai and killed them. This change of roles adds dramatic impact to this turning point in the story.

who had pursued them: Scholars and English versions differ on who who and them refer to.

1. The word them refers to the Israelite soldiers and who refers to the soldiers of Ai. For example:

When the Israelite army finished chasing and killing all the men of Ai in the open fields (NLT)

(BSB, NLT, RSV, NIV, NASB, NCV, NJB, REB, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. The word them refers to the soldiers of Ai and who refers to the Israelite soldiers. For example:

When Israel had finished killing all the men of Ai who had chased them toward the desert (NET) (NET, GW, NJPS)

The Hebrew text is not clear on this issue. It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of English versions. As noted above, option (1) adds impact to this climactic turn of events where Israel is now the victor.

into the field and wilderness: The phrase the field and wilderness refers to the barren, uninhabited country that was mentioned in 8:15.

8:24c

and when every last one of them had fallen by the sword,

- They killed them all. Not one of them lived.
- They killed every single one of them.

and when every last one of them: The phrase every last one of them refers to the fighting men of Ai. This phrase indicates that not one of the soldiers of Ai was left. They were all dead.

had fallen by the sword: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as had fallen by the sword is more literally “had fallen by the mouth of the sword.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that the Israelite soldiers killed them.

This is a passive clause. The Israelites are the implied subject. The Israelite soldiers killed the men of Ai.

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew idiom:

they had been put to the sword (NIV)

they put them all to death (GW)

The Israelites killed every one of the enemy (GNT)

8:24d

all the Israelites returned to Ai and put it to the sword as well.

- Then the Israelites went back to Ai and killed everyone left there with their swords.

- Then the Israelite army returned to Ai and killed everyone who was still alive in the city.

all the Israelites returned to Ai and put it to the sword as well: This clause indicates that the Israelite army killed the people who were still left in the town of Ai, the women and children.

Joshua 8:25

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:25

A total of twelve thousand men and women fell that day—all the people of Ai.

- All the people of Ai died that day. There were twelve thousand men and women.
- Twelve thousand men and women from Ai died that day. All the people of Ai died.

A total of twelve thousand men and women fell that day—all the people of Ai: This verse is a summary of the outcome of the battle between the Israelites and the citizens of Ai. The summary statement as introduced in Hebrew with the words “and it was.” The NLT introduces this summary statement with the word:

So (NLT)

Translate the summary statement in a way that is natural in your language.

A total of twelve thousand...all the people of Ai: The total population of Ai, including men and women, numbered twelve thousand people. All of these people died.

men and women fell that day: The phrase men and women fell that day refers to the people who died that day.

men and women: The phrase men and women refers to the men who had gone out to battle and the women who had stayed in the town.

Joshua 8:26

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:26a

Joshua did not draw back the hand that held his battle lance

- Joshua kept holding out his sword
- Joshua kept his arm stretched out with the spear in his hand pointed toward Ai

The Hebrew conjunction that BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “For” introduces the reason why the Israelites could destroy Ai. You should indicate reason in a natural way in your language. In some languages it may be most natural to use no connecting word, as in many English versions.

Joshua did not draw back the hand: This clause indicates that Joshua continued to stretch out his arm.

that held his battle lance: Joshua stretched out his arm while he held the battle lance in his hand, and pointed the lance towards Ai.

battle lance: Translate the phrase battle lance the same way as you did in 8:18.

It was important that Joshua keep his arm stretched out and point the battle lance towards Ai until all the people of Ai were dead. This was what Yahweh

commanded him to do. This was a symbol that it was Yahweh who won the victory over Ai and not the Israelites themselves.

8:26b

until he had devoted to destruction all who lived in Ai.

- until they killed all the people of Ai.
- until the Israelite army killed every person in the city.

until he had devoted to destruction all who lived in Ai:

It may be necessary to make explicit the implied information that Joshua did not kill the people himself. The Israelite soldiers followed his orders and killed every Ai person. For example, you could say:

until the Israelite soldiers destroyed all the inhabitants of Ai

Many English versions use a passive verb. For example:

until all who lived in Ai had been destroyed (REB)

Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua 8:27

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:27a

Israel took for themselves only the cattle and plunder of that city,

- But the Israelites took for themselves the livestock and the goods in the city,

- But the Israelites kept the animals and other things from Ai,

Israel took for themselves only the cattle and plunder of that city: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as only marks a contrast. They killed the people of Ai, but they took the cattle. Another way to mark this contrast is with the word “but.” For example:

But the Israelites took the animals and other possessions of the people of Ai (CEV)

Israel: The word Israel refers to the soldiers of Israel.

took for themselves: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as took for themselves is more literally “take.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The Israelites kept for themselves the livestock and goods (GNT)

Israel did carry off for themselves the livestock and plunder (NIV)

the cattle: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as cattle is more literally “livestock.” It refers to cattle and to other domestic animals such as sheep and goats.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

animals

domestic animals

plunder: The word plunder refers to the things in the town that were not burned when the army set fire to the town.

8:27b

as the LORD had commanded Joshua.

- as Yahweh told Joshua.
- because this is what Yahweh told Joshua they could do.

as the LORD had commanded Joshua: This clause is a reminder about verse 8:2. At that time Yahweh told Joshua that the Israelites could take the goods and animals of Ai for themselves.

Joshua 8:28

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua’s preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:28a

So Joshua burned Ai

- So Joshua’s army burned the city of Ai.
- Then Joshua and his army burned Ai

So Joshua burned Ai: This indicates that Joshua gave orders to his soldiers to burn the town of Ai. He did not burn the town himself.

8:28b

and made it a permanent heap of ruins, a desolation to this day.

- It has remained a pile of ruins, up to today.
- and made it a heap of ruins. It is still like that now.

and made it a permanent heap of ruins: The Israelites burned the buildings and everything in Ai so that it was a pile of rubble. The name “Ai” in Hebrew means ruins. It is recommended that you add a footnote to explain that this is a word play. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The name Ai means “ruins”

a desolation to this day: The phrase this day refers to the time that the author wrote the book of Joshua. At that time it was still a heap of ruins

General Comment on 8:28

Verse 8:28 is a summary statement about the battle of Ai. The burning of Ai is mentioned three times in this chapter. The first mention, in 8:8, is part of God’s command to Israel. The next mention, in 8:19, reports that the soldiers burned the town. The final mention

in this verse is the summary of what Israel did to Ai. The Israelites burned Ai only once. Make sure that is clear in your translation.

Joshua 8:29

Section 8:1–29 Israel defeated Ai.

In chapter 7, Israel attacked Ai and the soldiers of Ai defeated them. They were discouraged but they repented of their sin. In chapter 8, God told Joshua to attack Ai again. This time, the Israelites were victorious and defeated Ai.

Verses 8:1–9 describe Joshua's preparations to attack Ai, with details about the ambush. The soldiers in the ambush left by night ahead of the other soldiers. Verses 8:10–27 describe the movement of the soldiers, and the defeat of Ai. Verses 8:28–29 is a summary of the story.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The fall and destruction of Ai

Israel conquered Ai

8:29a

He hung the king of Ai on a tree until evening,

- Joshua hung the king of Ai's dead body on a pole and left him there until evening.
- Joshua ordered his soldiers to kill the king of Ai and hang his dead body on a tree.

He hung the king of Ai on a tree until evening: It is most likely that Joshua ordered his soldiers to kill the king. Then his dead body was hung on a tree. This was a common practice in the Ancient Near East. 8:29 Hess, p. 170. The bodies of defeated enemies were hung up as an example to others of what might happen to them.

until evening: The phrase until evening means until the sun went down.

8:29b

and at sunset Joshua commanded that

- When the sun went down, Joshua gave the order
- At sunset, Joshua commanded his soldiers

and at sunset: It may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

When the sun was setting

Joshua commanded: It may be necessary to make explicit to whom Joshua gave the command. He commanded some of his soldiers. For example:

Joshua told his soldiers

8:29c

they take down the body from the tree

- to take the king's dead body down from the tree.
- to take his body down.

that they take down the body from the tree: The Israelite soldiers took the dead body of the king down from the tree on which it was hanging.

8:29d

and throw it down at the entrance of the city gate.

- They threw it in the entrance of the city
- He told them to throw it down near the city gate.

and throw it down: The phrase throw it indicates that the soldiers threw down the corpse of the king.

at the entrance of the city gate: The phrase at the entrance of the city gate indicates a place in front of the town gates. A wall enclosed the town and people entered and left the town through the town gate.

8:29e

And over it they raised a large pile of rocks, which remains to this day.

- and made a large pile of stones over it. That pile is still there today.
- Then they piled large stones in a mound over it. The pile of stones is still there now.

And over it they raised a large pile of rocks: The clause over it they raised a large pile of rocks indicates that the Israelite soldiers piled stones over the king's dead body so that it was covered up.

which remains to this day: The pile of stones was still there in front of Ai at the time that the author wrote the book of Joshua.

Joshua 8:30

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:30a

At that time Joshua built an altar on Mount Ebal

- ¶ Then Joshua built an altar on Mount Ebal
- ¶ Some time later, Joshua told the Israelites to build an altar on Mount Ebal

At that time Joshua built an altar on Mount Ebal:

There was probably a period of several days between the fight against Ai, and the time when Joshua built the altar to Yahweh.8:30 Bratcher and Newman, p. 119. If the phrase At that time suggests that this happened immediately after Ai, it may be better to add a phrase such as:

some time later

on another day

Joshua: The Hebrew text says that Joshua built the altar. It is most likely that he told some of the Israelites to build the altar for him. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

he told some of his men, “Build an altar for offering sacrifices to the Lord” (CEV)

built an altar: This altar was made by piling up stones. It is different from the altar of burnt offering that was inside the tent of meeting. That altar was made of acacia wood overlaid with bronze. See Exodus 38:1–7.

Verse 8:31 says that the altar was made of stones that were not cut with a tool. Do not use a word for built in your language which implies that tools were used.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

made an altar

piled stones up as an altar

on Mount Ebal: The altar was on the top of Mount Ebal. It was not buried inside it. The Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as on is translated that way by most English versions. Use a preposition that is appropriate in your language.

Mount Ebal: Mount Ebal is about 32 kilometers north of Ai.8:30 Boling, p. 247.

8:30b

to the LORD, the God of Israel,

- to Yahweh, the God of Israel.

to the LORD, the God of Israel: They built the altar so that they could make sacrifices to Yahweh on it. Yahweh is given this extended title for emphasis. You should translate this phrase consistently with the decisions you have made about translating the name of God throughout the Old Testament.

Joshua 8:31

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:31a

just as Moses the servant of the LORD had commanded the Israelites.

- This was what Moses, Yahweh’s servant, commanded the Israelites.
- He followed the instructions that Moses, the servant of Yahweh, gave the Israelites

just as Moses the servant of the LORD had commanded the Israelites: Moses gave the Israelites this command in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. It may be clearer to translate this dependent clause as an independent sentence. For example, you could say:

This is what Moses, the servant of Yahweh, commanded the Israelites to do

Moses the servant of the LORD: Translate the title servant of the LORD as you did in 1:1.

8:31b

He built it according to what is written in the Book of the Law of Moses:

- Joshua obeyed these instructions from the book of Moses' teachings which say:
- in the law of Moses. It says there:

He built it according to what is written in the Book of the Law of Moses: The phrase the Book of the Law of Moses refers to Deuteronomy, where these instructions were written down.

the Book of the Law of Moses: The phrase Law of Moses refers to the teachings, or instructions, of Moses.

8:31c

“an altar of uncut stones on which no iron tool has been used.”

- “The altar must be made from stones that have not been cut or shaped by an iron tool.”
- “Make an altar from stones that are uncut and that nobody has touched with iron tools.”

an altar of uncut stones on which no iron tool has been used: There is implied information. Joshua made an altar of unhewn stones. It may be more natural to state this information as an independent sentence. For example:

Joshua built an altar out of stones that had not been cut with an iron tool

uncut stones: The phrase uncut stones can also be translated as “unhewn stones.” It indicates that no one used any tool to chisel the stones or cut them up. An “altar of uncut stones” is mentioned in Exodus 20:25 and in Deuteronomy 27:5.

no iron tool has been used: The clause no iron tool has been used indicates that no person used a tool to cut or shape the stones.

8:31d

And on it they offered burnt offerings to the LORD,

- On the altar they offered to Yahweh burnt offerings
- Then the Israelites made sacrifices that are completely burnt on the altar to Yahweh,

And on it they offered burnt offerings to the LORD:

Probably the priests offered the sacrifices on behalf of the Israelites. It may be more natural in some languages to make this explicit. For example:

and the priests offered burnt offerings to Yahweh on the altar

burnt offerings: The phrase burnt offerings refers to animals that were totally burned up as an atonement for sins. See Leviticus 1:1–17 for more information about burnt offerings.

8:31e

and they sacrificed peace offerings.

- and fellowship offerings.
- and they made sacrifices of fellowship with Yahweh.

and they sacrificed peace offerings: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sacrificed describes the same action as “offered burnt offerings” in 8:31d. It may be clearer in some languages to use the same verb to refer to both sacrifices.

peace offerings: The phrase peace offerings refers to sacrifices in which only part of the animal was burned. The rest of the animal was eaten by the worshipers. 8:31 Bratcher and Newman, p. 119. Many English versions refer to these offerings as “fellowship offerings.” The person who ate the animal had fellowship with Yahweh. See Leviticus 3:1–17 for more information about peace offerings.

Joshua 8:32

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:32a

And there in the presence of the Israelites,

- There on Mount Ebal, while the Israelites watched,
- At that place, while the Israelites were there,

And there: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as there refers to the site of the altar on Mount Ebal. The ceremony at this place represents a climax for Israel because it fulfilled Moses' command in Deuteronomy 27.

in the presence of the Israelites: The phrase in the presence of the Israelites indicates that Joshua wrote a copy of the law while all the Israelites watched him.

8:32b

Joshua inscribed on the stones a copy of the law of Moses,

- he wrote a copy of the law on some flat stones.
- Joshua wrote on stones a copy of the teachings of Moses.

Joshua inscribed on the stones a copy of the law of Moses: The word that the BSB translates as Joshua is literally the pronoun "he." Use the word that would be most natural in your language.

the stones: In Deuteronomy 27:2–4 Moses told Joshua to write the law of Moses on large stones which they should first coat with plaster. The term the stones does not refer to the stones used to build the altar.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

he wrote on some flat stones

he chose some flat stones and wrote on them

a copy of the law of Moses: The stones were not large enough for the entire law of Moses, which is Genesis through Deuteronomy. Joshua copied some part of the law of Moses onto the stones, perhaps the Ten Commandments.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

he copied parts of the book of the Law of Moses onto the stones (CEV)

8:32c

which he had written.

- This was the law which Moses wrote for them.
- These are the teachings that Moses gave them.

which he had written: It is not clear in the Hebrew text whether the pronoun he refers to Joshua or to Moses. It is recommended that you translate the pronoun he as referring to Moses, as in the NET, NJB, NJPS, NLT, and GNT.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

which Moses had written (GNT)

the instructions Moses had given them (NLT)

Joshua 8:33

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:33a

All Israel, foreigners and citizens alike, with their elders, officers, and judges,

- All the Israelites, foreigners and native-born, together with their leaders and officers and judges,
- Then all the Israelites, those who had Israelite parents and those who were foreigners living among them, along with the elders, officers, and judges,

The Hebrew connector that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” indicates the next event of the story.

All Israel, foreigners and citizens alike: The phrase All Israel indicates that every Israelite was present at the ceremony.

foreigners and citizens alike: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as foreigners refers to foreigners who lived in the Israelite community.8:33 Howard, p. 216.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as citizens refers to Israelites who were descendants of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

Here are some other ways to translate these two words:

resident foreigners and native Israelites (NET)

aliens and citizens (NIV)

foreigners and native-born (NLT)

with their elders, officers, and judges: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as elders refers to the leaders of tribes and families who represented their tribe on special occasions.8:33 Woudstra, p. 139.

officers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as officers refers to people who had both military and administrative responsibilities.8:33 Woudstra, p. 64, footnote 1.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

leaders (NET)

officials (NIV)

judges: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as judges refers to people who judged disputes between Israelites. See Exodus 18:17-26 where Moses first appointed judges.

8:33b

stood on both sides of the ark of the covenant of the LORD facing the Levitical priests

- stood in two groups. One group stood on each side of the ark facing the priests, the Levites.
- were divided into two groups. Each group faced inward toward the ark. They were facing the priests,

stood on both sides of the ark of the covenant of the LORD: The clause stood on both sides of the ark indicates that the Israelites stood in two groups facing each other. The ark was in-between them.

the ark of the covenant of the LORD: The ark was a wooden box that was a sign of God’s presence. The term ark has different descriptive phrases attached to it in different contexts. In this verse it is called ark of the covenant of the LORD. This emphasizes that inside it were the stone tablets on which Moses wrote the Ten commandments, the symbol of Yahweh’s covenant with Israel.

facing the Levitical priests: Two Levitical priests stood at each end of the ark, carrying it on poles over their shoulders. The two groups of Israelites faced the ark and the priests who carried it.

Levitical priests: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Levitical priests is literally “the priests, the Levites.” The priests were descendants of Levi, and belonged to the tribe of Levi.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the priests, the Levites

the priests of the Levi tribe

It is also possible to say just “the priests,” and put the literal translation in a footnote. See how you translated this term in Joshua 3:3.

priests: The priests were people who offered sacrifices to God on behalf of the people. You should translate this the same way you do in the New Testament. See, for example, Mark 1:44.

8:33c

who carried it.

- The priests were carrying the ark of Yahweh’s covenant.
- the Levites who held the ark of the covenant of Yahweh.

who carried it: It was the responsibility of the priests to carry the ark of the covenant.

8:33d

Half of the people stood in front of Mount Gerizim and half of them in front of Mount Ebal,

- Half of the people stood on the slope of Mount Gerizim and the other half on the slope of Mount Ebal.
- Half of the people stood in front of Mount Gerizim and half stood in front of Mount Ebal.

Half of the people stood in front of Mount Gerizim and half of them in front of Mount Ebal: The phrase half of them indicates that the Israelites were divided into two large groups.

in front of Mount Gerizim and...in front of Mount Ebal: The Israelites stood in the Valley of Shechem, which was between the two mountains, Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal. One group stood facing Mount Gerizim and the other group stood facing Mount Ebal.

In Deuteronomy 27:12-13 Moses told the people to stand “on” Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal, whereas this verse uses the words in front of. Because the Israelites followed the commands that Moses gave them, it may be that they stood on the slopes of the two mountains, facing in the direction of the opposite mountain. For example:

on the upper slopes of Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal (NJB)

8:33e
as Moses the servant of the LORD had commanded earlier,

- This was what Moses, the servant of Yahweh originally commanded them.
- This was done according to the instructions that Moses, Yahweh’s servant, previously gave them.

as Moses the servant of the LORD had commanded earlier: This indicates that the Israelites obeyed the instructions that Moses gave them before he died.

earlier: The word earlier refers to the time when Moses gave the Israelites this command in Deuteronomy 27:12-13. For example:

the Lord’s servant Moses had earlier commanded the people (NCV)

General Comment on 8:33

This is a long and complicated verse, and you will have to think about it carefully. It is recommended that you begin a new sentence at 8:33d.

8:33f
to bless the people of Israel.

- Moses told Joshua and the priests to bless the Israelites.
- This was the way that they should bless the Israelites.

Joshua 8:34

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1-13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:34a
Afterward, Joshua read aloud all the words of the law—the blessings and the curses—

- Then Joshua read the whole Law of Moses, including the blessings and the curses
- Then Joshua read out loud the entire teachings of Moses, including the blessings and the curses

Afterward: The word Afterward refers to the time after the people arranged themselves in the two groups. Many English versions use the word “then” to signal this next event. Use the connecting word that is most natural in your language to indicate this.

Joshua read aloud all the words of the law: The clause Joshua read aloud all the words of the law indicates that Joshua read aloud the entire teachings of Moses.

the blessings and the curses: The phrase the blessings and the curses refers to the words of Moses in Deuteronomy 27:12-28:68. Moses said that they would receive blessings if they obeyed Yahweh, but they would experience curses if they did not obey him.

8:34b
according to all that is written in the Book of the Law.

- as Moses wrote them down.
- as they are written in the book of the law.

according to all that is written in the Book of the Law: The phrase according to all that is written in the Book of the Law repeats 8:34a in different words. The information that Joshua read the entire Book of the Law is repeated to emphasize its importance. Find a way to emphasize the reading of the law that is natural in your language.

Joshua 8:35

Section 8:30–35 Joshua read the law of Moses to the Israelites.

In this section the people of Israel built an altar to Yahweh and made sacrifices to him. Joshua had them write the law of Moses on stone tablets. Then all the people assembled at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim while Joshua read the law aloud to them. He read all of its blessings and its curses.

Before they crossed the Jordan River, Moses foretold this event. He gave them detailed instructions for how they should do this in Deuteronomy 27:1–13. Now that the Israelites were well established in the land of Canaan they followed the instructions of Moses.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Reading the law at Mount Ebal and Mount Gerazim

Joshua reads the blessings and the curses to the people

8:35a

There was not a word of all that Moses had commanded

- There was not one of the words of Moses
- Joshua read every one of Moses' commandments

There was not a word of all that Moses had commanded: The phrase not a word of all that Moses had commanded emphasizes again that Joshua read all Moses' teaching for the Israelites. This information is given again in this verse to emphasize how important the reading of the law was.

8:35b

that Joshua failed to read before the whole assembly of Israel,

- which Joshua did not read to all the people of Israel.
- while the entire population of the Israelites listened.

that Joshua failed to read before the whole assembly of Israel: In the previous verse, the information

that Joshua read the entire law is stated in a positive manner. Now it is restated using a double negative for extra emphasis. In some languages a double negative may convey a wrong meaning. Use a natural means to emphasize that Joshua read the entire law to the Israelites. For example, the GNT states 8:35a-b in a positive way:

Every one of the commandments of Moses was read by Joshua to the whole gathering (GNT)

before the whole assembly of Israel: The phrase before the whole assembly of Israel indicates that Joshua read Moses' teachings while all the Israelites stood and listened.

8:35c

including the women, the little ones, and the foreigners who lived among them.

- All the people listened, including the women and the children and the foreigners who lived with them.
- This included the women and children, as well as the foreigners living among them.

including the women, the little ones: The phrase including the women, the little ones indicates that women and children were present and listened while Joshua read the law. Women and children were not present at every gathering. The author includes this information to show that the entire population of Israel listened while Joshua read aloud the law.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

including the women and the children

and the foreigners who lived among them: The foreigners were foreigners who lived with the Israelites. They were not Israelites by birth. 8:35 Howard, p. 216–217.

General Comment on verse 8:35

It may be more natural in some languages to reorder the parts of this verse so that 8:35c is first, as in the NCV:

^{35b}All the Israelites were gathered together—^{35c}men, women and children, along with the non-Israelites who lived among them. ^{35a}Joshua read every command that Moses had given. (NCV)

Joshua 9:1

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

Paragraph 9:1–2

This paragraph forms an introduction to the story of this chapter. It tells how a group of kings from the nearby towns decided to fight together against the Israelites. Their action contrasts with how the Gibeonites deceived the Israelites.

9:1a

Now when news of this reached all the kings west of the Jordan—

- ¶ All the kings who ruled the cities west of the Jordan River heard about the Israelites.
- ¶ When all the kings west of the Jordan River heard that the Israelites lost a battle at Ai

Now when news of this reached: The words of this are not included in the Hebrew text. The Hebrew text says only, “When all the kings heard.” In some languages it may be clearer to add words about what the kings heard.

These kings heard something that made them decide to join forces and attack the Israelites. Probably they heard how Joshua and the Israelites were defeated in the first battle of Ai. Because they saw that it was possible for the Israelites to lose a battle, they decided to attack them. 9:1 Howard, p. 218; Hess, p. 175.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

When the kings heard about the Israelites they gathered together

When the kings heard that the Israelites lost a battle against Ai, they gathered together

all the kings west of the Jordan: The phrase the kings west of the Jordan refers to the kings who ruled towns on the west side of the Jordan River. It may be clearer to add the implied information in this clause. For example:

the kings of the towns beyond the Jordan River

the kings of the towns west of the Jordan River

west of the Jordan: The phrase west of the Jordan refers to the region west of the Jordan River.

9:1b

those in the hill country, the foothills, and all along the coast of the Great Sea toward Lebanon

- They are the kings in the mountains and the lower slopes and on the Mediterranean seacoast northwards toward Lebanon,
- (they are the kings in the mountain country, the foothills to the west, and on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea up north towards Lebanon,

those in the hill country: The term hill country refers to the central mountain range of Palestine.

the foothills: The term foothills refers to the western side of the central mountain range. It is a rocky plateau that is higher than the land near the Mediterranean Sea, but lower than the hill country.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

western foothills (NIV)

the lowland (RSV)

and all along the coast of the Great Sea: The phrase Great Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

toward Lebanon: Lebanon was a small but powerful kingdom to the north of Palestine. The phrase toward Lebanon indicates that some of these kings were from the north, near the kingdom of Lebanon.

9:1c

(the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites)—

- namely, the kings of the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites.

- the kings who ruled the Heth people, the Amor people, the Canaan people, the Periz people, the Hiw people, and the Yabus people),

the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites: These six groups of people were mentioned in 3:10. You should translate them the same way you did there. These people are inhabitants of the land of Canaan. In Deuteronomy 20:16–18 Yahweh told the Israelites to destroy these nations with his help.

General Comment on 9:1

This is a long sentence with a long and complicated subject. It may be clearer to break it into two sentences. For example:

^{1a}There were many people who lived on the west side of the Jordan River, ^{1b}in the hill country, and in the foothills, and along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea and up north toward Lebanon. ^{1c}The kings of the Hitti people, the Amor people, the Canaan people, the Periz people, the Hiw people, and the Yabus people ^{1a}heard about the Israelites.

Joshua 9:2

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

Paragraph 9:1–2

This paragraph forms an introduction to the story of this chapter. It tells how a group of kings from the nearby towns decided to fight together against the Israelites. Their action contrasts with how the Gibeonites deceived the Israelites.

9:2

they came together to wage war against Joshua and Israel.

- Then they agreed to join together in fighting Joshua and the Israelite army.
- they got together and agreed to fight against Joshua and the Israelites.

they came together: The clause they came together indicates that the kings and their armies joined as one group to fight the Israelites.

together: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as together is more literally “one mouth.” This means that all the kings agreed to do this.

to wage war against Joshua and Israel: The clause to wage war against Joshua and Israel indicates that the kings agreed that they and their armies would fight against Joshua and his army, the Israelites.

Joshua 9:3

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:3a

But the people of Gibeon, having heard

- ¶ But when the people in the city of Gibeon heard the news
- ¶ The people of Gibeon City heard

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But shows that there is a contrast between what the six kings did and what the Gibeonites did. Show this contrast in a natural way in your language.

the people of Gibeon, having heard: The phrase people of Gibeon refers to the people who lived in the town of Gibeon. They are also referred to as “Gibeonites.” Gibeon town was about twenty kilometers west of Ai town.9:3 Howard, p. 223.

9:3b

what Joshua had done to Jericho and Ai,

- that Joshua and the Israelites defeated the cities of Jericho and Ai,
- how Joshua defeated Jericho and Ai.

what Joshua had done to Jericho and Ai: The clause what Joshua had done to Jericho and Ai refers to Joshua’s victories over these two towns. The Israelite army, with Joshua as their leader, defeated the armies of both Jericho and Ai.

Joshua 9:4

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:4a-b

acted deceptively and set out as envoys: There is a Hebrew phrase near the beginning of this verse, which the BSB leaves implicit, that can be translated as “also they.” This phrase contrasts the Gibeonites with the kings mentioned in 9:1–2. Translate this phrase with whatever lexical or grammatical means is most natural to show this contrast.

9:4a

acted deceptively

- they decided to deceive the Israelites.
- So they used a deception.

acted deceptively: The phrase acted deceptively indicates that the Gibeonites deceived the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they deceived the Israelites

they did a trick/deception/scheme

9:4b

and set out as envoys,

- They packed up food for a journey
- They got together some food

set out as envoys: There is a textual issue with the phrase set out as envoys.

1. Some Hebrew manuscripts have a verb that means “made ready provisions.” For example:

they provided themselves with supplies (NJB)
(NJB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NAB, NCV, NET, GNT)

1. The Hebrew Masoretic Text uses a verb that occurs only here. Some scholars think this verb means “to act as an ambassador,” but the meaning is uncertain. The NIV is an example of an English version that follows this interpretation:

they went as a delegation (NIV) (BSB, NIV, CEV, GW, NASB, NLT, BSB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with a majority of English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they packed food to take on a journey

They went and got some food (GNT)

9:4c

carrying on their donkeys worn-out sacks

- and put it in old sacks for their donkeys to carry,
- and used old bags to put it in on their donkeys.

carrying on their donkeys: The phrase on their donkeys means that they carried the sacks on the backs of their donkeys.

donkeys: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as donkeys is translated “asses” in some English versions. The word “ass” is from old English.9:4 The word “ass” can have vulgar connotations in English.

worn-out sacks: The phrase worn-out sacks indicates that they used old sacks to carry things on their donkeys. The sacks were worn thin from much use.

**9:4d
and old wineskins, cracked and mended.**

- They put wine in old wineskins that were torn and mended.
- Their leather bags for wine were old and torn and mended.

and old wineskins, cracked and mended: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wineskins refers to leather bags that were used to carry wine. The wineskins, like the sacks, were old and in poor condition.

Joshua 9:5

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:5a

They put worn, patched sandals on their feet and threadbare clothing on their bodies,

- They put worn and patched sandals on their feet and wore worn-out clothes.
- They wore sandals that were old and patched, and clothes that were worn-out.

They put worn, patched sandals on their feet and threadbare clothing on their bodies: It may be more natural in some languages to translate this as an independent sentence. For example:

They put on ragged clothes and worn-out sandals that had been mended (GNT)

The men put worn and patched sandals on their feet and wore old clothes (NIV)

9:5b

and their whole supply of bread was dry and moldy.

- All their bread was dried out and hard.
- Their bread was dry and crumbly.

and their whole supply of bread was dry and moldy:

The phrase their whole supply of bread refers to the bread they took with them to eat.

moldy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as moldy is rarely used. Bible scholars and the English versions disagree about its meaning.

1. It means crumbly or hard rather than moldy. This seems likely because mold requires moisture for growth, and the climate in Palestine is very dry.9:5 Howard, p. 223. For example:

And all their provisions were dry and crumbly. (ESV) (ESV, GW, NAB, NASB, NET, NJB, NJPS, REB, CEV)

1. It means moldy. For example:

All the bread of their food supply was dry and moldy. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NCV, NLT, GNT)

It is difficult to know the meaning of this word because it is rare. It occurs only three times in the Old Testament (Joshua 9:5, 12, and 1 Kings 13:4). Both options are used by English versions. Even though Palestine generally had a dry climate, there was also a wet season and old bread could get moldy. Either option is acceptable.

Joshua 9:6

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:6a

They went to Joshua in the camp at Gilgal

- ¶ Then they went to meet Joshua in the Israelite camp at Gilgal,
- ¶ When the Gibeonites arrived at the Israelite camp at Gilgal,

They went to Joshua in the camp at Gilgal: After the Gibeonite men got their things together, they traveled to the Israelite camp at Gilgal to talk to Joshua.

Gilgal: Gilgal was first mentioned in 4:19. You should translate it the same way you did there.

9:6b

and said to him and the men of Israel,

- and said to Joshua and the Israelite leaders:
- they spoke to Joshua and the Israelite leaders and said:

and said to him and the men of Israel: The Gibeonite men met with Joshua and the Israelites. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as men of Israel is more literally “man of Israel.” This is a collective term that is frequently used for the Israelite army.^{9:6 Howard, p. 224.} The phrase men of Israel probably refers to the leaders of the Israelites, rather than to all the male Israelites.

9:6c

“We have come from a distant land; please make a treaty with us.”

- “We^(excl) have come from a country that is far from here. Please make^(plur) a peace treaty with us^(excl).”
- “We have come from a distant land. We want you to make a treaty with us.”

We have come from a distant land: The Gibeonites claimed that they had traveled a long distance and lived far away from the land of Canaan.

We: The word We is exclusive. It refers to the Gibeonites and not to the Israelites.

please make a treaty with us: The clause make a treaty with us is a request for the Israelites to make a treaty or agreement of friendship with them. A treaty is a formal agreement between two people or groups of people.

Joshua 9:7

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:7a

But the men of Israel said to the Hivites,

- The Israelites said to the Hivites:
- But the Israelites said to the Gibeonites, who were also called Hivites:

But the men of Israel: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as men of Israel is more literally “man of Israel.” This is a collective term that is frequently used for the Israelite army. The phrase men of Israel probably refers to the leaders of the Israelites.

said to the Hivites: The Gibeonites were one part of the “Hivite” nation. God ordered Israel to destroy this nation in 3:10. This group of people was also mentioned in 9:1. You should translate the word Hivites the same way you translated it earlier.

9:7b

“Perhaps you dwell near us. How can we make a treaty with you?”

- “Perhaps you really live near to us. If that is so, we cannot make a treaty with you.”
- “We want to know for sure that you really live far from us. We cannot make a treaty with anyone who lives in the land of Canaan.”

Perhaps you dwell near us. How can we make a treaty with you?: In Deuteronomy 7:1–7 Yahweh told the Israelites that they must not make any treaties with the people who lived in the land of Canaan. This question shows that the Israelites were suspicious of the Gibeonites’ statement that they came from a far

away country. The Israelites wanted to make sure it was true. It may be more natural in some languages to translate this question as a statement. For example:

But maybe you really live near us. We can't make a peace treaty with you if you live nearby. (CEV)

We^(excl) want to know for sure that you^(plur) do not live near us. We cannot make a treaty with any one who lives in the land of Canaan.

Joshua 9:8

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:8a

“We are your servants,” they said to Joshua.

- But they said to Joshua: “We are willing to be your servants.”
- The Gibeonites told Joshua: “We acknowledge your authority.”

We are your servants: The sentence We are your servants indicates that the Gibeonites wanted to accept Joshua as their leader and to become part of the Israelite nation.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we are willing to be your subjects (NET)

we acknowledge you as our masters

they said to Joshua: The word they refers to the Gibeonites. It may be helpful to make this explicit.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Gibeonites said to Joshua

9:8b

Then Joshua asked them, “Who are you and where have you come from?”

- Then Joshua asked them: “What nationality are you? Where exactly do you come from?”
- Joshua said to them: “I must know for sure what city and nation you come from.”

Then: The word Then indicates the next event in the storyline. Indicate this in a natural way in your language.

Who are you and where have you come from?:

The question Who are you...? indicates that Joshua wanted to know their nationality. The question where have you come from? indicates that Joshua wanted to know where the Gibeonites lived. These two questions together emphasize that Joshua wanted to be sure about who these men were. It may be more natural in some languages to combine these two questions in a way that shows this emphasis. For example:

Tell me from exactly from where you have come.

I must know for sure from what town and nation you have come.

Joshua 9:9

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:9a

“Your servants have come from a very distant land,” they replied,

- They told Joshua: “Your servants have come from a very far away land
- The Gibeonites answered: “We are your servants. We have come from a very far country

Your servants have come from a very distant land:

The Gibeonites lied to Joshua so that they could make a treaty with the Israelites. The phrase from a very distant land is placed at the beginning of the sentence in the Hebrew text to emphasize it. If a location phrase at the beginning of the sentence is not natural, you should use some other means in your language to show this emphasis.

they replied: In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word replied as “answered.”

9:9b

“because of the fame of the LORD your God.

- because we heard of the fame of Yahweh your God.
- because of the reputation of your God, Yahweh.

because of the fame of the LORD your God: The phrase the fame of the LORD your God refers to the reputation, or name, that Yahweh had because of the miracles he did for the Israelites. He made it possible for them to leave Egypt and then to defeat the kings of the Amorites.

9:9c

For we have heard the reports about Him: all that He did in Egypt,

- We have heard about what he has done and how he helped you to escape from Egypt.
- We heard about everything he did in Egypt.

For we have heard the reports about Him: The clause we have heard the reports about Him indicates that the news about Yahweh had spread among the people in the surrounding area.

all that He did in Egypt: The clause all that He did in Egypt indicates that the Gibeonites heard about the miracles Yahweh did when he helped the Israelites escape from Egypt. These events are described in Exodus chapters 5–14.

Joshua 9:10

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:10a

and all that He did to the two kings of the Amorites beyond the Jordan—

- We have heard how he defeated the two Amorite kings on the east of the Jordan River,
- And we heard that he defeated the two kings of the Amorites from the east side of the Jordan River.

and all that He did to the two kings of the Amorites beyond the Jordan: The phrase all that He did refers to the victories that the Israelites won over the two Amorite kings. These events are described in Numbers 21:21–35.

beyond the Jordan: The phrase beyond the Jordan indicates that these two Amorite kings ruled territories east of the Jordan River.

beyond the Jordan: The phrase beyond the Jordan indicates that these two Amorite kings ruled territories east of the Jordan River.

9:10b

Sihon king of Heshbon and Og king of Bashan, who reigned in Ashtaroath.

- King Sihon of Heshbon, and King Og of Bashan who lived in Ashtaroath.
- He defeated King Sihon the king of Heshbon Country, and King Og the king of Bashan Country, who ruled in Ashtaroath City.

Sihon king of Heshbon: Sihon was the name of one of the Amorite kings.

Heshbon: The town of Heshbon was the capital town of King Sihon’s kingdom.

and Og king of Bashan, who reigned in Ashtaroth: Og was the name of the other Amorite king.

Bashan: Bashan was an area east and northeast of the Sea of Galilee. The Jordan River Valley forms its western boundary. Mount Hermon is its northern boundary, and the area of Gilead is the southern boundary. In modern times this is the Golan Heights.

Here are some other ways to translate this name:

Bashan Country

Bashan Region

Ashtaroth: The town of Ashtaroth was the capital town of Bashan, and was the town where King Og lived. 9:10 Rasmussen, p. 227-228.

Joshua 9:11

Section 9:1-27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:11a

So the elders and inhabitants of our land told us,

- So our elders and all the people who live in our land told us,
- Our leaders and all our people told us

So the elders: The term elders refers to the leaders of the Gibeonites. Unlike the other towns in the region of Canaan, the Gibeonites were ruled by leaders but had no king. 9:11 Woudstra, p. 159.

and inhabitants of our land told us: The phrase inhabitants of our land refers to the people who lived

in the region of the Gibeonites. Gibeon was actually a town, but it had power over the other nearby towns.

Here are some other ways to translate the term land:

area

region

9:11b

'Take provisions for your journey;

- 'Take food for your journey
- to get some food ready for the journey

Take provisions for your journey: The clause Take provisions for your journey indicates that the people took food to eat. They put the food in sacks which their donkeys carried. They did not carry the food in their hands.

for your journey: The phrase for your journey refers to the trip that the Gibeonites took from their own town to the Israelite camp.

9:11c

go to meet them and say to them:

- Travel to the Israelite camp and tell their leaders:
- and to come and meet you Israelites. They wanted us to tell you:

go to meet them and say to them: The clause go to meet them indicates that the Gibeonites should travel to the Israelite camp and introduce themselves to Joshua and the Israelites leaders.

General Comment on 9:11a-c

The Gibeonites report this as a direct quote of what the elders told them to do. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as an indirect quote. For example:

Our leaders and all the people that live in our land told us to get some food ready for a trip and to go and meet you. (GNT)

9:11d

We are your servants. Please make a treaty with us.'

- "We are willing to be your servants. Make a treaty with us."
- "We acknowledge your authority. Please make a treaty with us."

We are your servants: The clause We are your servants indicates that the Gibeonites were willing to

become subject to the Israelites and submit to them. You should translate the phrase your servants in the same way as in 9:8a.

Please: The word Please is a way to make a polite request. You should use whatever word or grammatical means is appropriate to make a polite request in your language.

make a treaty with us: The clause make a treaty with us indicates that the Gibeonites wanted the Israelites to make a peace treaty with them.

Joshua 9:12

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:12a

This bread of ours

- Look at our bread.
- Do you see this bread?

This bread of ours: The Gibeonites said This bread of ours to call attention to the old bread they brought with them. In some languages it may be better to translate this as an imperative command, or as a rhetorical question. For example:

Look, see what our bread is like!

See this dry, crumbly bread of ours? (CEV)

9:12b

was warm when we packed it at home on the day we left to come to you.

- On the day we left our houses to come to you it was still warm out of the oven.
- It was still warm from being cooked when we packed our food for the journey and left home.

was warm when we packed it at home: The clause was warm indicates that they had just finished baking the bread. It was warm because they took it out of the oven. If people are not familiar with making bread, it may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

it was hot out of the oven on the day we packed the food when we left our homes (CEV)

we had just baked this bread and it was still warm when we took it from our houses

on the day we left to come to you: The phrase on the day we left to come to you refers to the day that the Gibeonites started their trip to the Israelite camp.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

on the day we left our houses

The phrase on the day we left to come to you may be incorporated into the first verse part, as in CEV above. It may also be left as implicit information and not translated, as in NCV:

Look at our bread. On the day we left home to come to you it was warm and fresh (NCV)

9:12c

But take a look, it is now dry and moldy.

- But now it is dried out and hard.
- But now, look and see how dry and crumbly it is.

But take a look: The phrase But take a look calls attention to something important. It emphasizes that the journey was long because the bread is all dried up. Show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

it is now dry and moldy: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as moldy is used only three times in the Old Testament. The meaning is uncertain. You should translate it the same way you did in 9:5b.

Joshua 9:13

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:13a

These wineskins were new when we filled them, but look, they are cracked.

- When we put wine in these wineskins they were new. Now they are torn.
- These leather wine bags were new when we filled them with wine. But look, now they are split open.

These wineskins were new when we filled them:

The term wineskins refers to the leather bags or pouches in which people carried their wine. Translate it the same way you did in 9:4.

but look: The word look calls attention to something important and emphasizes it. Use whatever means is appropriate in your language to show importance or emphasis.

they are cracked: The clause they are cracked means that the wineskins were so old that there were cracks in the leather.

9:13b

And these clothes and sandals are worn out from our very long journey.”

- Our clothes and our sandals are worn out from the very long trip.”
- Our clothes and our sandals are worn out because we came from so far away.”

And these clothes: The word clothes refers to the clothes the men were wearing.

and sandals are worn out from our very long journey: The phrase worn out from our very long journey emphasizes that the Gibeonites have come a long way and that they do not live near the Israelites.

sandals: The sandals that people wore in those times were open, with a sole under the foot and straps around the top. In some languages it may be more natural to call them:

shoes

General Comment on 9:11–13

When the Gibeonites said this they were telling lies to the Israelites. They were trying to deceive them. Translate this in a way that sounds like people who are telling convincing lies.

Joshua 9:14

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:14a

Then the men of Israel sampled their provisions,

- ¶ The Israelites examined their things.
- ¶ So the Israelites looked at the food that the Gibeonites showed them and believed what they said.

Then the men of Israel sampled their provisions:

The word men refers to the Israelite leaders. The term their provisions refers to the food that the Gibeonites brought with them.

sampled their provisions: There are three ways to interpret the meaning of the Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as sampled their provisions.

1. The Hebrew clause means that the Israelite leaders examined the food and accepted it as evidence that the Gibeonites had traveled from a distant place. For example:

the Israelites examined their food (NLT) (NLT, NET, GW, NJPS)

1. The Hebrew clause means that the Israelite leaders ate some of the food. For example:

the men of Israel sampled their provisions (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, GNT, CEV, NABRE, KJV)

1. The Hebrew clause means that the Israelite leaders ate some of the food as part of a covenant ceremony. Some commentaries follow this interpretation, including the UBS Handbook, but no English version follows this interpretation.

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This seems most likely in the context. The Gibeonites provided evidence, and the Israelites examined the evidence and believed it.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the men believed the evidence they were shown (GW)

sampled: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sampled is more literally “took.”

9:14b

but did not seek the counsel of the LORD.

- And they did not ask Yahweh what he wanted them to do.
- But they did not ask for help from Yahweh.

but did not seek the counsel of the LORD: The clause did not seek the counsel of the LORD means that the Israelite leaders did not ask Yahweh to show them what to do. They decided what to do without listening to Yahweh.

This is an important point in the story. In the Hebrew text it is emphasized by a change of word order. Look for a natural way to emphasize it in your language. It might be clearer in some languages to translate this as an independent sentence with the subject made explicit: For example:

But the Israelite leaders did not ask Yahweh what they should do.

Joshua 9:15

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:15a

And Joshua made a treaty of peace with them to let them live,

- And Joshua made a peace treaty with the Gibeonites. He made an agreement that they will not kill them.
- So Joshua made a treaty of friendship with the Gibeonites. He agreed to let them live.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And indicates the next action in the storyline. Indicate this in a natural way in your language.

Joshua made a treaty of peace with them: The Hebrew that the BSB and many English versions collapse into one clause, Joshua made a treaty of peace with them, is literally two clauses, “Joshua made peace with them, and he made a covenant for them.” Making a covenant, or a treaty, showed that there will be peace between the two groups of people. For example:

So Joshua made peace with them by making a treaty (GW)

to let them live: The terms of the peace treaty allowed the Gibeonites to live as subjects, under the rule of the Israelites. The Israelites promised not to kill the Gibeonites as they did the other inhabitants of Canaan.

9:15b
and the leaders of the congregation swore an oath to them.

- And Israel's leaders swore that Israel will do according to the treaty.
- And the leaders of the Israelites promised to keep this treaty.

and the leaders of the congregation swore an oath to them: The phrase the leaders of the congregation refers to the leaders of the whole Israelite community.

congregation: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as congregation refers to a meeting of free Israelite men who were eligible for military service. 9:15 Boling and Wright, p. 268.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the leaders of the assembly (NIV)

the leaders of the community (NET, NABRE)

Some English versions leave this word implicit. For example:

the Israelite leaders (NLT)

their leaders (GNT)

swore an oath to them: The clause swore an oath to them means that the Israelite leaders swore an oath, or made a solemn promise, that they will keep the agreement that they made with the Gibeonites.

Joshua 9:16

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:16a

Three days after they had made the treaty with the Gibeonites,

- ¶ Three days after they made a treaty with the Gibeonites,
- ¶ On the third day after they made the peace agreement,

Three days: In Hebrew, part of a day was counted as one day when reckoning time. For example, if the treaty was made on a Monday, these events were probably on the Wednesday evening. Translate this reference to Three days in a natural way in your language.

after they had made the treaty with the Gibeonites:

It may be necessary in some languages to make the subject and the object explicit. For example, you could say:

three days after the Israelites made a covenant with the Gibeonites

9:16b

the Israelites learned that they were neighbors, living among them.

- the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lived nearby; that they were neighbors.
- they found out that the Gibeonites lived near them, not far from them.

the Israelites learned that they were neighbors:

This indicates that the Israelites heard that the Gibeonites were their neighbors. In some languages it may be clearer to make either the subject or the object explicit. For example:

the Israelites learned that these people did indeed live nearby (GNT)

the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lived nearby (NCV)

living among them: The clause living among them is another way to say that the Gibeonites lived in a nearby town. It emphasizes that the Gibeonites lived close by, not far away, as they had claimed. Use whatever lexical or grammatical means is natural to show this emphasis.

Joshua 9:17

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:17a

So the Israelites set out and on the third day arrived at their cities—

- So the Israelites went to see them, and on the third day they got to their cities.
- Then the Israelites walked to where the Gibeonites lived, and reached their cities in three days.

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the narrative.

the Israelites set out: The clause the Israelites set out indicates that the Israelites left their camp to walk to where the Gibeonites lived and to confront them.

and on the third day: In Hebrew, part of a day was counted as one day when reckoning time. For example, if they started to walk on a Thursday, then they probably arrived on a Saturday. Translate this time reference in a natural way in your language.

arrived at their cities: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as arrived at means “reached.”

their cities: The Gibeonites lived in a group of at least four towns. These towns are named in the next part of this verse.

9:17b

Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim.

- The cities were Gibeon, Kephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath Jearim.
- The names of the cities were Gibeon, Kephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim.

Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim: In some languages it may be clearer to make it explicit that these are names of towns. For example:

the names of their towns were Gibeon, Chephirah, Beeroth, and Kiriath-jearim

Joshua 9:18

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:18a

But the Israelites did not attack them,

- But the Israelites did not attack them
- But the people of Israel did not attack them,

But: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as But indicates contrast. Contrary to what one would expect, the Israelites did not attack these enemies.

the Israelites did not attack them: The term the Israelites refers to the people of Israel who went to visit the Gibeonites.

attack: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as attack can be translated in two different ways.

1. It is translated “did not attack them.” For example:

the people of Israel did not attack them (ESV)
(BSB, ESV, NIV, NRSV, NASB, NCV, NET, NJB, NAB, NJPS, NLT, REB, CEV, KJV)

1. It is translated “did not kill them.” For example:

the Israelites could not kill them (GNT) (GNT, RSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the more accurate way to translate the Hebrew word. However, option (2) may be used if you consider this to be implied information. If the Israelites “attacked” the Gibeonites, then they would probably kill them.

9:18b

because the leaders of the congregation had sworn an oath to them by the LORD, the God of Israel.

- because the leaders of the community swore to a treaty of friendship with them in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel.
- because the leaders of their assembly made a solemn promise in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel to spare the Gibeonites.

because the leaders of the congregation: The word congregation refers to a meeting of free Israelite men who were eligible for military service. You should translate this the same way you did in 9:15.

had sworn an oath to them by the LORD, the God of Israel: The clause sworn an oath to them by the LORD, the God of Israel indicates that the leaders made a promise to the Gibeonites in the name of Yahweh. The full name of God is used to emphasize the solemnity of this vow.

9:18c

And the whole congregation grumbled against the leaders.

- Then all the community of Israelites criticized the leaders.
- Then all the assembly were not satisfied and grumbled about the leaders’ decision.

And the whole congregation: The phrase the whole congregation refers to all the members of the assembly of Israelite men. It is the same group of people as in 9:18b.

grumbled against the leaders: The clause grumbled against the leaders indicates that the Israelite men were not satisfied with the leaders’ decision and complained about it. They wanted to attack the Gibeonites, as is made clear in 9:26.9:18 Howard, p. 229.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the whole community criticized the leaders (NET)

the whole assembly grumbled against the leaders (NIV)

Joshua 9:19

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:19a

All the leaders answered,

- But all the leaders said to them:
- But they all said:

All the leaders answered: The subject and the object of this sentence are repeated in the Hebrew text for emphasis. In some languages it may be more natural to use pronouns. For example:

But they answered (GNT)

But the leaders said to them

9:19b

“We have sworn an oath to them by the LORD, the God of Israel,

- “We swore an oath to them in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel.
- “We made a solemn promise to them before Yahweh, the God of Israel,

We have sworn an oath to them by the LORD, the God of Israel: It may be more natural in some languages to introduce this clause with a word which shows it is the reason for the action. For example:

Since we have sworn an oath in the presence of the Lord, the God of Israel, we cannot touch them (NLT)

9:19c and now we cannot touch them.

- Now we cannot harm them.
- so now we can not attack them.

and now we cannot touch them: The clause we cannot touch them indicates that the Israelites could not attack the Gibeonites or harm them. This was because they made a vow to them in the name of Yahweh and this vow was binding.

General Comment on 9:19b-c

It may be more natural in some languages to switch the order of 19b and 19c, and put the reason for the action at the end of the sentence. For example:

^{19c}We must not harm them in any way, ^{19b}because we have made a promise to them in the name of Yahweh, the God of Israel.

Joshua 9:20

Section 9:1-27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:20a This is how we will treat them: We will let them live,

- This is what we will do. We will let them live.
- We must let them live

This is how we will treat them: We will let them live: The clause This is how we will treat them is a way to emphasize the second clause, We will let them live. The Israelites intend to let the Gibeonites live.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This is what we will do to them: we will let them live (NIV)

This we will do to them: let them live (ESV)

We must let them live (NET)

9:20b so that no wrath will fall on us because of the oath we swore to them.”

- If we don't let them live God will punish us, because we made an oath to them.”
- because we promised we will not hurt them. God will be angry with us if we break this promise.

so that no wrath will fall on us: The clause so that no wrath will fall on us indicates that Yahweh would be angry and punish the Israelites if they broke their vow and harmed the Gibeonites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that God's wrath will not fall on us (NIV11)

otherwise God will be angry at us

because of the oath we swore to them: The phrase the oath we swore to them states the reason that God would be angry with the Israelites. They made an oath to the Gibeonites in God's name. God will be angry if they break that oath.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

for breaking the oath we swore to them (NIV)

It may be clearer to combine these two clauses:

If we break our promise, God will punish us (CEV)

divine anger would come upon us if we broke our oath (NLT)

Joshua 9:21

Section 9:1-27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:21a

They continued, “Let them live,

- The leaders repeated: “We must let them live.”
- So we must let them live.”

They continued: Verse 21 continues the answer that the Israelite leaders gave to those who wanted to attack the Gibeonites. The clause They continued may not be necessary in some languages. It may not be natural to repeat a quote margin in the middle of continuous speech. For example, the NLT deletes the quote margin:

Let them live. (NLT)

The ESV follows the Hebrew with a long form of the quote margin:

And the leaders said to them, “Let them live” (ESV)

Let them live: The clause Let them live indicates that the Israelites will not kill the Gibeonites.

The words Let them live are a repetition of what the leaders said in 20a. In some languages it may be clearer to use the word “repeated” in the quote margin. For example:

They repeated, “Let them live”

9:21b

but let them be woodcutters and water carriers for the whole congregation.”

- So they became servants for the whole community and cut the firewood and drew water from the wells,
- And so the Gibeonites cut firewood and drew water from the wells for all the Israel people.

but let them be woodcutters and water carriers for the whole congregation: There are two ways to interpret the use of this phrase:

1. These words are not part of the quotation that started in 21a. Instead, this phrase shows the result of the Israelites’ decision. For example:

^{21a}“Let them live.” ^{21b}So they became woodcutters and water carriers for the whole community. (NET) (NET, RSV, ESV, NJPS, NLT, NASB)

1. These words are part of the quotation that started in 21a. For example:

^{21a}“Let them live, ^{21b}but let them be woodcutters and water carriers for the entire community.” (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NABRE, GNT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is followed by several English versions and several commentaries.

woodcutters: The word woodcutters indicates that the Gibeonites cut firewood for the Israelites.

water carriers: The phrase water carriers indicates that the Gibeonites drew water from the wells and carried it for the Israelites.

the whole congregation: The phrase the whole congregation indicates that the Gibeonites performed these tasks for the whole Israelite community, including the leaders and their families.

9:21c

So the leaders kept their promise.

- which was what the leaders decided.
- This is what the Israelite leaders said they should do.

So the leaders kept their promise: The clause So the leaders kept their promise emphasizes the decision of the leaders about the Gibeonites. It was the leaders who made the decisions.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So they became hewers of wood and drawers of water for all the congregation, as the leaders had decided concerning them (NRSV)

So they made them woodcutters and water carriers for the entire community, as the Israelite leaders directed (NLT)

Use a way that is natural in your language to emphasize this decision of the leaders.

Joshua 9:22

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:22a

Then Joshua summoned the Gibeonites and said,

- ¶ Joshua sent for the Gibeonite leaders and asked them:
- ¶ Joshua called together the Gibeonite leaders and said:

Then Joshua summoned the Gibeonites: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as summoned indicates that Joshua ordered the Gibeonites to come see him. He wanted to tell them how the Israelites would respond to their trickery.

the Gibeonites: The phrase the Gibeonites refers to the leaders or representatives of the Gibeonites, not to the whole group of Gibeonites.

and said: Some English versions translate the word said as “asked” because it introduces a rhetorical question. For example:

Joshua ordered the people of Gibeon to be brought to him, and he asked them (GNT)

9:22b

“Why did you deceive us by telling us

- “Why did you lie to us when you said,
- “You lied to us. You told us

Why did you deceive us by telling us: This is the beginning of a rhetorical question. It functions as a strong statement that the Gibeonites should not have tricked the Israelites.

Here are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why did you trick us? (NET)

- Use a strong statement. For example:

you should not have deceived us

you lied to us

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

9:22c

you live far away from us, when in fact you live among us?

- ‘We live far away,’ but actually you live very close by.
- that you live far away, but actually you live nearby.

you live far away from us: The clause you live far away from us is Joshua’s paraphrase of what the Gibeonites told the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

We live in a far country

when in fact you live among us: The clause when... you live among us indicates that the Gibeonites lived nearby.

General Comment on 22b–c

Some other ways to translate the statements in 22b–c are:

You actually live close to us. Why did you lie and tell us that you live far away?

You lied to us and said that you live far away. But actually you live nearby.

Why did you deceive us and tell us that you were from far away, when you live right here? (GNT)

Joshua 9:23

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:23a-b

Now therefore you are under a curse and will perpetually serve as woodcutters and water carriers for the house of my God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now therefore can be translated in two different ways:

1. It means therefore, or because of this, or for that reason. For example:

Because you did this, God has condemned you. (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, ESV, NAB, NASB, NJPS, KJV)

1. It is a temporal marker now. For example:

You are now under a curse (NIV) (NIV, NABRE, GW, NCV, NET, NJB, REB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and make the reason relation explicit. But option (2) is acceptable if the reason relation is implied by the context in your translation.

will perpetually serve as woodcutters and water carriers: The Hebrew words are more literally “not he will be cut off from you a slave.” There are two ways to interpret what this means.

1. This means that all the Gibeonites became slaves. For example:

every one of you shall always be a slave (NABRE) (BSB, NABRE, NASB, NIV, NET, GNT, GW, NAB, NCV, NJB, NJPS, NLT, KJV)

1. This means that some of the Gibeonites became slaves. For example:

some of you shall never be anything by servants (ESV) (ESV, RSV, REB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). God’s curse was on the whole Gibeonite nation. It is not clear from the Hebrew that we can translate this as only “some” of the Gibeonites.

9:23a

Now therefore you are under a curse and will perpetually serve

- Because you did this there is a curse on you. You will always be our slaves.
- Therefore, God has condemned you. For all time you will be slaves.

you are under a curse: The phrase you are under a curse means that God considered them to be guilty and condemned them.

will perpetually serve: The phrase will perpetually serve indicates the Gibeonites will live in submission to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

shall always be slaves (RSV)

shall never be anything but servants (ESV)

perpetual servitude (NET)

9:23b

as woodcutters and water carriers for the house of my God.”

- You will cut firewood and draw water for the house of my God.”
- You will have to cut wood and draw water from the wells for the tabernacle of my God.”

woodcutters: The word woodcutters indicates that they will cut firewood.

and water carriers: The phrase water carriers indicates that they will draw water from the wells and carry it.

for the house of my God: The phrase for the house of my God indicates that the Gibeonites will provide wood and water for the place of worship. During the time of Joshua, the house of my God in which the Israelites worshiped was a tent, not a permanent house. In 9:27 it is clear that the Gibeonites served both the place of worship and also the broader community in this way.

my God: The word my refers to Joshua. Joshua referred to Yahweh as his God.

Joshua 9:24

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:24a

The Gibeonites answered,

- ¶ The Gibeonites answered Joshua:
- ¶ The Gibeonites leaders replied to Joshua:

The Gibeonites answered: The phrase The Gibeonites refers to the Gibeonite leaders who met with Joshua. It may be necessary to make this clear in your translation.

9:24b

“Your servants were told clearly

- “We did it because people told us for sure
- “We lied to you because they told us how certain is it

Your servants were told clearly: The phrase were told is passive. In some languages it may be clearer to make this an active phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we learned (GNT)

We heard (NCV)

people told us

Your servants: The Gibeonites called themselves Your servants to show respect to Joshua. Many languages have pronouns or other vocabulary for showing respect. Use whatever means is natural to indicate this.

were told clearly: The phrase told clearly translates an emphatic form of the Hebrew verb “told.” The Gibeonites emphasized that they heard a sure and certain report that the God of the Israelites was powerful. Use whatever means is natural to show that there is no doubt that the Gibeonites heard these things.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

your servants were clearly told (NIV)

we learned that it was really true (GNT)

9:24c

that the LORD your God had commanded His servant Moses to give you all the land

- that Yahweh your God commanded his servant Moses to give you all of this land.
- that Yahweh your God told his servant Moses to help you conquer this land.

that the LORD your God had commanded His servant Moses to give you all the land: It may be more natural to divided this long clause into two or more clauses. For example:

we heard that Yahweh your God had made a promise to his servant Moses. Yahweh promised Moses that he would help the Israelites conquer this land

we heard about the promise that Yahweh your God gave to Moses, who served him. Yahweh told Moses that the Israelites would take this land

9:24d

and wipe out all its inhabitants before you.

- Yahweh promised Moses that he will help the Israelites kill all the people as you move into the land.
- We heard that you will kill all the people in the land.

and wipe out all its inhabitants: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence. For example:

We heard that they will kill all the people who live in the land

before you: The phrase before you indicates that the Israelites will advance into the land, and kill the people living there wherever they find them.

9:24e

So we greatly feared for our lives because of you, and that is why we have done this.

- We were afraid that you will kill us, and so we lied to you.
- This is why we tricked you into making a peace treaty. We were afraid you will kill us.

So we greatly feared for our lives because of you:

The clause we greatly feared for our lives indicates that the Gibeonites were afraid the Israelites would kill them.

and that is why we have done this: The word this refers to the lie that the Gibeonites told the Israelites.

General Comment on 9:24

It may be more natural in some languages to rearrange the parts of this verse of the Gibeonites' answer to Joshua.9:24 Bratcher and Newman, p. 134. For example:

^{24a}They answered, ^{24e}“We did it, sir, ^{24b}because we learned that it was really true ^{24c}that the Lord your God had commanded his servant Moses to give you the whole land ^{24d}and to kill the people living in it as you advanced. ^{24e}We did it because we were terrified of you; we were in fear of our lives. (GNT)

Joshua 9:25

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they

made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:25a

Now we are in your hands.

- We know that you are more powerful than we are.
- Now look, you have the strength to do anything you want.

Now: The word Now calls attention to what the Gibeonites said next. It is a way to emphasize it. Use whatever means is natural to show this emphasis.

we are in your hands: The clause we are in your hands is an idiom. It indicates that the Gibeonites know the Israelites are stronger than them and can do whatever they want to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we are in your power (NET)

you are strong enough to do anything to us that you want (CEV)

9:25b

Do to us whatever seems good and right to you.”

- So treat us in whatever way seems just to you.”
- Do to us whatever you think is right.”

Do to us whatever seems good and right to you:

The phrase Do to us whatever seems good and right to you indicates that the Gibeonites asked the Israelites to treat them in whatever way seemed just to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do to us what you think is good and appropriate (NET)

do to us whatever you think is right (NLT)

Joshua 9:26

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:26a

So Joshua did this and delivered them from the hands of the Israelites,

- ¶ So Joshua saved them from the Israelites,
- ¶ So Joshua rescued the Gibeonites from them

So Joshua did this and delivered them: The two clauses Joshua did this and delivered them indicate that Joshua decided to save the lives of the Gibeonites. These clauses can be combined as one clause, for example,

So Joshua saved them from the Israelites. (NIV)

So Joshua rescued them (GW)

from the hands of the Israelites: The phrase from the hands of the Israelites indicates that Joshua did not allow the Israelites to kill the Gibeonites.

9:26b

and they did not kill the Gibeonites.

- and they did not kill them.
- and the Israelites did not kill them.

and they did not kill the Gibeonites: The clause they did not kill the Gibeonites states the same meaning as 26a in different words. Joshua kept the Israelites from killing the Gibeonites, and the Israelites did not kill them.

Joshua 9:27

Section 9:1–27 The Gibeonites deceived the Israelites

The Gibeonite people lived near Ai. When they heard that Joshua had defeated Ai, they were afraid that he would conquer and kill them too. So, they sent messengers who pretended they had come from a long distance away. They deceived the Israelites and made a treaty of friendship with them.

Later, the Israelites learned that the Gibeonites lied to them, and that they lived quite close to them. They could not kill them because of the treaty, so they made them be water carriers and woodcutters for the Israelites.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The people of Gibeon

The Gibeon people tricked the Israelites and made a treaty with them

9:27a

On that day he made them woodcutters and water carriers,

- But from that day on he made the Gibeonites cut firewood and draw water.
- But starting from that day, Joshua made the Gibeonites be woodcutters and water carriers,

On that day he made them woodcutters and water carriers: This indicates that Joshua carried out the decision of the leaders that was mentioned in 9:21. The Gibeonites will live among the Israelites and will cut firewood and draw water from the wells for them.

On that day: Here is another way to translate the words that day:

starting from that day

from that day on

9:27b

as they are to this day

- They are still doing it today
- and they continue to this day.

as they are to this day: The phrase as they are to this day indicates that when the book of Joshua was written, the Gibeonites were still slaves who cut wood and drew water.

9:27c**for the congregation of the LORD and for the altar**

- for the community and for the altar of Yahweh,
- They provided for the Israelites, and for the altar of Yahweh,

for the congregation of the LORD and for the altar:

The phrase for the congregation of the LORD and for the altar indicates that the Gibeonites will supply wood and water for the Israelite community and for the special needs of the altar.

altar: The word altar is used in place of the phrase “house of my God” in 9:23b. Both the word altar and the phrase “house of my God” refer to the same place. This was the tent of worship where the priests burned sacrifices to Yahweh.

9:27d**at the place He would choose.**

- in whatever place Yahweh decides the altar should be.
- They serve the altar wherever Yahweh decides the altar should be.

at the place He would choose: This indicates that in the future Yahweh may choose a different place for the altar. The Gibeonites will continue to provide wood and water wherever it might be.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

wherever the Lord would choose to build it (NLT)

wherever he chose it to be (NCV)

General Comment on 9:27c-d

It may be more natural in some languages to reorder 27b-d so that the phrase “at the place He would choose” is next to the phrase “for the altar.” For example:

^{27a}But that day he made the Gibeonites the wood-cutters and water carriers ^{27c}for the community of Israel and for the altar of the Lord—^{27d}wherever the Lord would choose to build it. ^{27b}And that is what they do to this day. (NLT)

Joshua 10:1**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their

fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:1a**Now Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem heard that Joshua had captured Ai**

- ¶ Adoni-Zedek, the king of Jerusalem, heard that Joshua captured Ai
- ¶ At this time King Adoni-Zedek of Jerusalem City heard that Joshua defeated

Now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now introduces a series of dependent clauses in 1a-e.

Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem heard: In 9:1–2 the kings who ruled on the west side of the Jordan River heard about Joshua and the amazing things that Yahweh had done for the Israelites. In 10:1 the kings who ruled in Southern Canaan heard similar news. The word heard at the beginning of chapters 9, 10, and 11 gives a thematic unity to these chapters. It is recommended that you translate the word heard at the beginning of each of these chapters in a way that keeps this thematic unity but is also natural in your language.

Adoni-zedek: The name Adoni-zedek means “My master is righteous” in Hebrew. Some English versions hyphenate this name and other versions write it as one word. For example:

Adonizedek (GNT)

Jerusalem: At this time Jerusalem was a Canaanite town. The people of Israel did not yet live there.

that Joshua had captured Ai: The clause Joshua had captured Ai indicates that Joshua and his army captured the town of Ai, and defeated it.

10:1b**and devoted it to destruction—**

- and destroyed it completely,
- and completely destroyed Ai City.

and devoted it to destruction: The phrase devoted it to destruction indicates that Joshua and his army completely destroyed the town and everything in it. There was nothing left but rubble.

10:1c

doing to Ai and its king as he had done to Jericho and its king—

- and killed its king, as he destroyed Jericho and killed its king.
- He destroyed it and killed its king, as he destroyed Jericho City and killed its king.

doing to Ai and its king: The clause doing to Ai and its king means that Joshua and his army killed the people who lived in the town of Ai and also killed the king of Ai.

as he had done to Jericho and its king: The clause as he had done to Jericho means that Joshua treated these two towns in the same way. He killed the people of Jericho along with their king, and he also killed the people who lived in Ai and their king.

10:1d

and that the people of Gibeon had made peace with Israel

- He heard that the Gibeonites made peace with Israel
- He also heard that the people of Gibeon City made a treaty with Israel

and that the people of Gibeon: The phrase the people of Gibeon refers to the people who lived in the towns of Gibeon.

had made peace with Israel: The clause made peace with Israel refers to the peace treaty that the Gibeonite leaders made with the Israelite leaders.

10:1e

and were living near them.

- and lived with them.
- and that they lived among them.

and were living near them: The clause were living near them indicates that the Gibeonites lived in the same area as the Israelites.

General Comment on 10:1a-e

This sentence in the BSB is long and complex. The main verb of the sentence does not come until verse 2. Verse 1 consists of background information. The first action in the story is in verse 2. It may be clearer in some languages to translate verse 1 as two or three independent sentences. For example:

^{1a}Adoni-zedek, king of Jerusalem, heard that Joshua had captured ^{1b}and completely destroyed Ai ^{1c}and killed its king just as he had destroyed the town of Jericho and killed its king. ^{1d}He also learned that the Gibeonites had made peace with Israel ^{1e}and were now their allies. (NLT)

Joshua 10:2

Section 10:1-27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:2a

So Adoni-zedek and his people were greatly alarmed,

- King Adoni-Zedek and his people were very afraid when they heard this,
- When he and his people heard this they were frightened.

So Adoni-zedek and his people were greatly alarmed: The words greatly alarmed refer to King Adoni-zedek. They indicate that the king was very afraid.

There is a textual issue here.

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text and the Septuagint translation into Greek both read “they feared greatly.” For example:

he and his people were very much alarmed (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, NABRE, GW, NCV, NLT, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. Some ancient translations such as the Syriac read “he feared greatly.” For example:

he feared greatly (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NASB, NJPS, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Usually we translate the Hebrew text unless it is very difficult. Your translation could say “they” or it could say “the king and his people.” Here is another way to translate this:

the people of Jerusalem were greatly alarmed
(GNT)

If you have translated 10:1 as an independent sentence, you may need to supply some implicit information here. For example, the NLT supplies this information:

He and his people became very afraid when they heard all this (NLT)

10:2b

because Gibeon was a great city, like one of the royal cities;

- because Gibeon was an important city, like the cities that had a king,
- They knew that Gibeon was a big city, as big as the cities that had kings.

because: The word because introduces the reason why the king and his people were afraid.

Gibeon was a great city: In 9:17 it said that Gibeon was actually a group of four towns. The phrase a great city indicates that Gibeon was a large and important place.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a large city (NET)

an important city (NIV)

like one of the royal cities: The phrase like one of the royal cities indicates that Gibeon was equal in size and importance to the towns that had a king to rule them. Gibeon was ruled by an assembly of leaders and did not have a king.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

as large as any of the cities that had a king (GNT)

10:2c

it was larger than Ai, and all its men were mighty.

- and because it was larger than Ai, and the men of Gibeon were good fighters.

- It was larger than Ai, and all its men were soldiers.

it was: The words it was introduce a second reason why the king and his people were afraid.

and all its men were mighty: The clause all its men were mighty indicates that all the men of Ai were good at fighting.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all its men were warriors (NET)

all its men were good fighters (NIV)

Joshua 10:3

Section 10:1-27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:3a

Therefore Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem sent word

- So Adoni-Zedek, king of Jerusalem, sent this message
- So King Adoni-Zedek of Jerusalem sent messengers with this message

Therefore Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem sent word: The phrase sent word indicates that the king sent messengers to take his message to the other kings.

King Adoni-zedek of Jerusalem sent this message to... (NET)

Adoni-zedek king of Jerusalem appealed to... (NIV)

King Adoni-zedek of Jerusalem sent messengers to... (NLT)

It may be more natural in some languages to put the title “King” before the names of each of the kings in this list.

10:3b

to Hoham king of Hebron, Piram king of Jarmuth,

- to King Hoham of Hebron, to King Piram of Jarmuth,
- to Hoham, king of Hebron City, to Piram, king of Jarmuth City

to Hoham king of Hebron: Hoham is the name of the king of Hebron. Hebron was a town in the hill country southwest of Jerusalem.

Piram king of Jarmuth: Piram is the name of the king of Jarmuth. Jarmuth was a town about 24 kilometers west of Bethlehem in the Elah Valley. It was southwest of Jerusalem. 10:3 Boling and Wright, p. 279.

10:3c

Japhia king of Lachish, and Debir king of Eglon, saying,

- to King Japhia of Lachish, and to King Debir of Eglon.
- to Japhia, king of Lachish City, and to Debir, king of Eglon City.

Japhia king of Lachish: Japhia is the name of the king of Lachish. Lachish was about 40 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. 10:3 Boling and Wright, p. 280.

and Debir king of Eglon, saying: Debir is the name of the king of Eglon. Eglon was about 56 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. 10:3 Bratcher and Newman, p. 138.

Joshua 10:4

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:4a

“Come up and help me. We will attack Gibeon,

- “Come to me and help me attack Gibeon,
- “Come with me. Let’s attack Gibeon,

Come up and help me: The two clauses Come up and help me indicate that the king of Jerusalem asked these four kings to join with him in battle against the Gibeonites. The word Come up is used because Jerusalem was at a higher elevation than the other four towns. In languages that do not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say “come to me.”

We will attack Gibeon: The clause We will attack Gibeon indicates that the king of Jerusalem asked the other four kings to gather their armies together with his and attack the people of Gibeon.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Come and help me attack Gibeon (GNT)

10:4b

because they have made peace with Joshua and the Israelites.”

- for they have made a peace treaty with Joshua and the Israelites.”
- because the people of Gibeon have made peace with Joshua and the people of Israel.”

because they have made peace with Joshua and the Israelites: The clause they have made peace states the reason the king of Jerusalem wanted to attack the town of Gibeon. The Gibeonites had a treaty with the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

because its people have made peace with Joshua and the Israelites (GNT)

General Comment on 10:4a-b

It may be more natural in some languages to change the order of 4a and 4b, and state the reason first, as in CEV:

^{4b}The Gibeonites have made a peace treaty with Joshua and the Israelites. ^{4a}Come and help me attack Gibeon! (CEV)

Joshua 10:5

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their

fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:5a

So the five kings of the Amorites—

- Then these five Amorite kings,
- So these five kings of the Amorites,

So the five kings of the Amorites: The phrase the five kings of the Amorites refers to the kings who were mentioned in verse 3. These kings were all “Amorite” kings. The term “Amorite” referred to people who lived in the hill country. These five kings lived in the southwestern hill country. The towns of the Gibeonites were north of Jerusalem. These kings wanted to attack Gibeon because they had trade connections with it. 10:5 Hess, p. 190. The peace treaty that the Gibeonites made with the Israelites made it difficult to trade with them.

10:5b

the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon—

- the king of Jerusalem City, the king of Hebron City, the king of Jarmuth City, the king of Lachish City, and the king of Eglon City,
- the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon

the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon: This list of kings is repeated from verse 3. In some languages it may be more natural to avoid some of the repetition.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Then the five kings of the Amorites—the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish and Eglon (NIV)

When these five Amorite kings (CEV)

10:5c

joined forces and advanced with all their armies.

- gathered their armies, and they all went up

- got their soldiers together. All five armies went up

joined forces: The clause joined forces indicates that the five kings assembled their armies together.

and advanced with all their armies: The clause advanced with all their armies indicates that the five kings led their armies and went to the towns of Gibeon.

advanced: The Hebrew text says they advanced. Although the towns of Gibeon were at about the same elevation as Jerusalem, they were higher than the other four towns. In languages that do not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say:

they went with all their armies

10:5d

They camped before Gibeon and made war against it.

- and surrounded Gibeon, and attacked it.
- to Gibeon, and surrounded it, and fought against it.

They camped before Gibeon: The clause camped before Gibeon indicates that the armies surrounded the town so that the Gibeonites could not leave it. They could not find food and would soon become weak. Then the five Amorite armies could conquer it.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

(they) surrounded Gibeon (GNT)

(they) moved all their troops into place (NLT)

In 9:17 it says that the Gibeonites lived in four towns: Gibeon, Kephirah, Beeroth and Kiriath Jearim. Probably this attack was only against the town of Gibeon.

and made war against it: The clause made war against it indicates that the five armies attacked the towns of Gibeon.

Joshua 10:6

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:6a

Then the men of Gibeon sent word to Joshua in the camp at Gilgal:

- ¶ The Gibeonites sent messengers to Joshua in the camp at Gilgal.
- ¶ The leaders of the Gibeonites sent a message to Joshua in his camp at Gilgal.

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this next event in a natural way in your language.

the men of Gibeon: The phrase the men of Gibeon refers to an indefinite number of people. Probably these men were some of the Gibeonite leaders.

sent word to Joshua: The clause sent word to Joshua indicates that the Gibeonites sent messengers to Joshua to ask him for his help.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

sent this message to Joshua (NET)

sent messengers to Joshua (NLT)

in the camp at Gilgal: The phrase the camp at Gilgal refers to the same camping place where the Israelites were staying. Gilgal was where the Gibeonites first met with the Israelites (9:6).

10:6b

“Do not abandon your servants.

- They said: “Don’t abandon your servants.
- They pleaded with them: “We are your servants. Don’t throw us away.

In Hebrew this clause begins with the word translated literally as “saying.” It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. In this case, the word “saying” may be translated as:

They said

They begged

They pleaded

Use words that show the urgency of their request.

Do not abandon your servants: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Do not abandon is a Hebrew idiom. It could be more literally translated “do not let your hand drop.” This idiom indicates that the Gibeonites asked Joshua to protect them from the Amorite kings and their armies. They expected the Israelites to help them because of the peace treaty that they had made with them.

your servants: The phrase your servants is used by the Gibeonites to show their respect for Joshua and the Israelites. Many languages have pronouns or nouns that are used when speaking to superiors. Use whatever is most natural in your language to express this relationship.

10:6c

Come quickly and save us! Help us,

- Come quickly. Save us. Help us.
- Come now. We desperately need your help.

Come: In Hebrew, the word Come is more literally “come up”. The town of Gibeon was higher than the Israelites’ camp at Gilgal. If your language keeps track of elevation, this would be a place to imply going up a steep hill/mountain.

quickly: The word quickly indicates the urgency of the Gibeonites’ request. They are in danger and want Joshua and the Israelite army to come at once to fight with them against the Amorite armies.

and save us! Help us: The two verbs save and Help are very similar in meaning. The Hebrew text uses two verbs with similar meanings to emphasize the urgency of the request. It may be more natural in some languages to express this meaning using one verb and some other means of showing emphasis.

10:6d

because all the kings of the Amorites from the hill country have joined forces against us.”

- For all the Amorite kings who live in the hill country are attacking us.”
- The kings of all the Amorite cities in the mountains have gotten together to attack us.”

because: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason for the Gibeonites’ request.

all the kings of the Amorites from the hill country:

The Gibeonites referred to the five kings that are mentioned in 10:3. There may also have been other kings of smaller towns in the hill country, as 10:28–39 suggests. In addition, the Gibeonites may have exaggerated the facts because they were afraid. 10:6 Hess, p. 192.

have joined forces against us: The clause joined forces against us indicates that the Amorite kings with their armies were preparing to attack the Gibeonites.

Joshua 10:7**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:7a**So Joshua and his whole army,**

- So Joshua with all his soldiers,
- So Joshua and his entire army,

Joshua and his whole army: The phrase his whole army refers the Israelite soldiers. These soldiers went with Joshua to fight against the Amorites.

10:7b**including all the mighty men of valor,**

- including those who were strongest and bravest,
- including his best warriors,

all the mighty men of valor: The phrase mighty men of valor refers to the strongest and bravest soldiers in the Israelite army.

Here are some other way to translate this phrase:

including the bravest warriors (NET)

including all the best fighting men (NIV)

10:7c**came from Gilgal.**

- went from Gilgal.
- left Gilgal to go to Gibeon.

came from Gilgal: The clause came from Gilgal indicates that when Joshua received the message from the Gibeonites, he left the Israelite camp at Gilgal to help the Gibeonites fight against the Amorites. Here, as in 10:6c, the Hebrew word indicates elevation, that the army went up a steep hill/mountain since Gibeon was a higher elevation than Gilgal.

General Comment on 10:7

It may be more natural in some languages to include the whole subject (Joshua and his army) at the beginning of the verse followed by the verb, like the BSB does.

The Hebrew text mentions Joshua first as a way to show the importance of Joshua as the leader. Use a way that is natural in your language to emphasize Joshua's importance. For an example of the Hebrew word order, the RSV says:

Joshua went up from Gilgal, he and all the people of war with him, and all the mighty men of valor (RSV)

Joshua 10:8**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:8a**The LORD said to Joshua,**

- Yahweh said to Joshua:
- Yahweh told Joshua:

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translate as “and” indicates that the next action in the story is taking place. Use whatever connecting word is natural in your language to express this.

10:8b**“Do not be afraid of them, for I have delivered them into your hand.”**

- “Don’t be afraid of them. I will give you power to defeat them.
- “Don’t be afraid of the Amorites. They will lose when you attack them.

Do not be afraid of them: The pronoun *them* refers to the Amorite kings and their armies. It may be necessary to make this explicit in some languages. For example:

don’t be afraid of the Amorites (CEV)

for I have delivered them into your hand: The clause *I have delivered them into your hand* states the reason that the Israelites did not need to be afraid of the Amorite armies. The clause *delivered them into your hand* is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that Yahweh will enable the Israelites to defeat the Amorites. The words Yahweh spoke to Joshua are similar to the encouraging words he said to Joshua in 1:2,5,9.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

I have given you victory over them (NLT)

they will run away when you attack (CEV)

10:8c**Not one of them shall stand against you.”**

- Not one of them will be able to defeat you.”
- None of them will be able to fight against you.”

Not one of them shall stand against you: The clause *Not one of them shall stand against you* is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that the Amorites will not be able to defeat the Israelites. All the Amorites will die or will run away. This happened in 10:10–11.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

not one of them can resist you (NET)

none of them will be able to fight and defeat you

Joshua 10:9**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:9a**After marching all night from Gilgal,**

- After they walked uphill from Gilgal to Gibeon during the night,
- They did this by walking all night from their camp at Gilgal.

After marching all night from Gilgal: The clause *marching all night from Gilgal* indicates that it took all night for Joshua and the Israelite army to walk uphill from Gilgal to Gibeon. The distance from Gilgal to Gibeon was about twenty to twenty-five miles up a fairly steep hill. 10:9 Howard, p. 236, note 186.

marching: The English verb *marching* is used for soldiers who are walking.

10:9b**Joshua caught them by surprise.**

- Joshua and the Israelite army made a surprise attack on the Amorites,
- And Joshua attacked the Amorites when they were not expecting it.

Joshua caught them by surprise: Joshua was the leader of the Israelites, and he attacked the Amorites along with his army. The word *them* refers to the Amorites.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Joshua and the Israelite army made a surprise attack upon the Amorite armies.

caught them by surprise: The phrase caught them by surprise is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that the Amorites did not know that the Israelites were going to attack them. It was a surprise.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

attacked them by surprise (NET)

attacked them when they were not expecting it

General Comment on 10:9a-b

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 9a and 9b so that the events are in the Hebrew sentence order. For example:

So Joshua came upon them suddenly, having marched up all night from Gilgal (RSV)

Joshua 10:10

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:10a

And the LORD threw them into confusion before Israel,

- Yahweh confused the Amorite armies when Israel attacked.

- Yahweh made the Amorites be afraid when they saw the Israelites.

And the LORD threw them into confusion before Israel: The clause threw them into confusion indicates that Yahweh caused the Amorite armies to be confused and afraid, so that they could not fight the Israelites.

10:10b

who defeated them in a great slaughter at Gibeon,

- The Israelite army defeated them in a great victory at Gibeon.
- The Israelites killed many of them at Gibeon City.

who defeated them in a great slaughter: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as defeated them in a great slaughter is more literally “hit them with a great hit.” This Hebrew idiom means that the Israelite army killed many Amorite soldiers.

There is an interpretation issue in this clause. The verb defeated (or “hit”) is marked as masculine singular and there is no nominal subject. English versions interpret the subject of the verb in three ways:

1. The subject of the verb is the Israelite army. For example:

and the Israelites slaughtered great numbers of them at Gibeon (NLT) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NLT, NAB, GNT, NCV, CEV)

1. The subject of the verb is Joshua. For example:

Joshua utterly defeated them at Gibeon (REB) (REB, NEB, NJPS)

1. The subject of the verb is Yahweh. For example:

and He struck them down with a great defeat at Gibeon (NASB) (NASB, NJB, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Verses 8 and 11 make it clear that the Israelites defeated the Amorites only with Yahweh’s help, but verse 11 also makes it clear that the Israelites had a part in the defeat.

at Gibeon: The phrase at Gibeon refers to the town of Gibeon, where the battle took place.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

(Israel) defeated them with a great victory at Gibeon (NIV)

Israel thoroughly defeated them at Gibeon (NET)

10:10c

pursued them along the ascent to Beth-horon,

- The Israelite army chased them along the road going up to Beth-horon,
- They chased them up to the mountain pass at Upper Beth-horon City,

pursued them along the ascent to Beth-horon: The phrase along the ascent to Beth-horon indicates that the Israelite army pursued the Amorite armies uphill to Beth-horon.

Beth-horon: There were two towns named Beth-horon. Upper Beth-horon was 66 meters higher in altitude than Gibeon. Lower Beth-horon is referred to in verse 11. The road from Gibeon goes first uphill to Upper Beth-horon, and then down to Lower Beth-horon.10:10 Woudstra, p. 172, footnote 19. Upper Beth-horon was the highest town in that area. It dominated an important mountain pass that led to the lower hills and the plain to the west.10:10 Hess, p. 195.

The English versions spell the name Beth-horon in various ways:

Beth-horon (BSB, RSV, ESV, NLT, NABRE, NJPS, NASB, KJV)

Beth Horon (NET, NIV, GNT, GW)

Beth-Horon (CEV)

10:10d

and struck them down as far as Azekah and Makkedah.

- and killed more of them all the way to Azekah and Makkedah.
- kept on killing them going down to Azekah City and Makkedah City.

and struck them down: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as struck them down is more literally “hit them.” This idiom indicates that the Israelite army killed many of the Amorite fighters.

as far as Azekah and Makkedah: The phrase as far as Azekah and Makkedah indicates that the Israelite army continued to pursue the Amorite armies all the way to the towns of Azekah and Makkedah. Azekah

was about 30 kilometers south of Beth-horon and is considerably lower downhill. Makkedah was in the southern part of Canaan, about 14 kilometers west of Hebron.10:10 Rasmussen, p. 244.

Joshua 10:11

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

Paragraph 10:6–11

The Israelites defended the Gibeonites against their enemies.

10:11a

As they fled before Israel

- While the Amorite armies ran away from the Israelites,
- The Amorites fled from the Israelites.

As they fled before Israel: This verse is a flashback. It provides additional information about what happened in 10:10. The word they refers to the Amorite armies.

fled before Israel: The clause fled before Israel indicates that the Amorite armies turned and ran away from the Israelite army.

10:11b

along the descent from Beth-horon

- and while they were running down the mountain slope from Beth-horon,
- They fled down the hill from Beth-horon City.

along the descent from Beth-horon: The phrase the descent from Beth-horon indicates that the Amorite armies ran down from the mountain pass. Starting from Upper Beth-horon, they ran southwest and down out of the hill country.

the descent from Beth-horon: There is an interpretation issue with this phrase.

1. This means the descent of Beth-horon, or the way down from Beth-horon. For example:

on the road down from Beth Horon (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, GNT, CEV, GW, NASB, NCV, NLT, NRSV, NJPS, REB)

1. This mean the ascent of Beth-horon. For example:

while they were going down the ascent of Beth-horon (ESV) (ESV, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Hebrew text is clear and it is best to follow it. In verse 10 the Amorite army fled from the Israelites at Gibeon town and followed the road up the mountain slope to Beth-horon town. This was at the peak of the pass through the mountains. In verse 11 the Amorite army then fled through the mountain pass and down-hill to the foothills and plains below.

10:11c

to Azekah, the LORD cast down on them large hailstones from the sky,

- Yahweh made large hailstones fall on them from the sky, all the way to Azekah, and so many of them died.
- Then Yahweh threw large hailstones on them from the sky on the road to Azekah. This killed many of them.

to Azekah: The phrase to Azekah indicates that the hail continued to fall on the Amorite armies all the way to Azekah. The distance that the Amorite armies ran away from the Israelites was about twenty miles.10:11 Howard, p. 237.

the LORD cast down on them large hailstones from the sky: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as large hailstones refers to lumps of hail. Hail is ice that comes down from the sky. Hail storms occur about five to eight times per year in Palestine.10:11 Boling and Wright p. 282.

the sky: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sky can also be translated “heaven.” For example:

the Lord threw down great stones from heaven upon them (RSV)

10:11d

and more of them were killed by the hailstones than by the swords of the Israelites.

- The hailstones killed more of the Amorites than the Israelites killed with their swords.

- More of the Amorites were killed by hailstones than were killed by the Israelites.

more of them were killed by the hailstones than by the swords of the Israelites: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the hailstones killed more of the enemy soldiers than the Israelites killed with their swords

more of them were killed: The clause more of them were killed shows the result of the hailstorm. It may be clearer in some languages to make the connection between the hail and their death explicit. For example:

because of that, they died

and the hail killed them

by the swords of the Israelites: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as by the swords is an idiom. This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that they killed the people.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

more were killed by the hailstones than by the Israelites (GNT)

Joshua 10:12

Section 10:1-27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:12a

On the day that the LORD gave the Amorites over to the Israelites,

- On the same day that Yahweh helped the Israelites to defeat the Amorites,

- On the day that they defeated the Amorites with the help of Yahweh,

On the day that the LORD gave the Amorites over to the Israelites: This is the same day as the events referred to in 10:10–11. In 10:12–15, the author told the story of the battle of Gibeon again from another perspective and added new information to what he had already said. It may be clearer in some languages to translate the clause the day that the LORD gave the Amorites over to the Israelites as an independent sentence. For example, you could say:

Yahweh gave the Israelites victory over the Amorites on that day. On that same day Joshua spoke to Yahweh...

the LORD gave the Amorites over to the Israelites:

The clause the LORD gave the Amorites over to the Israelites is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that Yahweh helped the Israelites to defeat the Amorites. For example:

the Lord gave the men of Israel victory over the Amorites (GNT)

10:12b

Joshua spoke to the LORD

- ׀ Joshua spoke to Yahweh.
- ׀ Joshua prayed to Yahweh.

Joshua spoke to the LORD: Some English versions follow the Hebrew word order, “spoke Joshua to the LORD.” It puts the verb before the subject. The natural English word order is Joshua spoke as in the BSB. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua spoke: In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word spoke as “prayed.” For example:

on that same day Joshua prayed to Yahweh while the Israelites watched him

10:12c

in the presence of Israel:

- Joshua prayed in front of the Israelites:
- Joshua prayed while Israel was watching, and he said:

in the presence of Israel: The phrase in the presence of Israel indicates that the Israelites who fought the battle watched while Joshua prayed to Yahweh.

10:12d

“O sun, stand still over Gibeon, O moon, over the Valley of Aijalon.”

- “Sun, stop moving above Gibeon, and moon, stop moving above the valley of Aijalon.”
- “Let the sun stay in one place over Gibeon, and the moon stay in one place over the valley of Aijalon.”

O sun, stand still over Gibeon: The expression, O sun, stand still over Gibeon is a kind of figurative language called personification. Personification gives human characteristics to non-human things for poetic effect. In 12b Joshua spoke to Yahweh. In 12d Joshua spoke to the sun. If the reader does not understand that this is figurative language, it is good to make this clear. One way to clarify this is to include some implicit information:

Joshua asked Yahweh to make the sun and the moon stand still. He said, “Sun, stay still at Gibeon. And moon, stay still in the valley of Aijalon.”

O sun, stand still: The command sun, stand still may not be natural in some languages. The sun does not have legs and it may not be possible to say that the sun can stand.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Sun, stop moving in the sky

Sun, stay in one place

over Gibeon: It may be more natural to translate the phrase over Gibeon as “at Gibeon,” or “above Gibeon.” The sun shone in the sky over the town of Gibeon. Use a preposition that is natural in your language.

O moon, over the Valley of Aijalon: The expression O moon, over the Valley of Aijalon is an example of personification. Personification gives human characteristics to non-human things for poetic effect.

the Valley of Aijalon: The phrase Valley of Aijalon refers to the valley where the town of Aijalon was, seven to ten miles west of Gibeon. 10:12 Bratcher and Newman, p. 143. The Amorites fled from Gibeon as far as Azekah (10:10d). Aijalon was between Gibeon and Azekah.

Here are some ways to translate 10:12c-d:

Joshua prayed to the Lord in front of all the people of Israel. He said, “Let the sun stand still over Gibeon, and the moon over the valley of Aijalon.” (NLT)

In the presence of the people of Israel, Joshua said, “Yahweh, cause the sun to stop moving over Gibeon and cause the moon to stop moving over the valley of Aijalon.”

General Comment on 10:12d

In the ancient Near East many people believed that natural objects such as the sun and the moon had a soul or a spirit. The Bible does not teach this. Joshua did not actually speak to the sun or the moon, and he did not expect them to respond to his command. The language Joshua used is a figure of speech called “personification.” Personification gives human characteristics to non-human things. It is used to add emotional impact to the story. As you translate this verse, keep in mind that this response by the sun and moon to Joshua’s command is poetic language. It should not be understood literally.

A miracle of God’s power took place when he lengthened the day. It was God, responding to the prayer of Joshua, who caused the miracle. The sun and moon did not actually do anything. God made them stand still.

Joshua spoke to both the sun and the moon. Biblical scholars do not agree on why he addressed both the sun and the moon. One possibility is that Joshua prayed this prayer in the early morning when the sun was rising in the east and the moon was setting in the west.

Joshua 10:13

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:13a

So the sun stood still and the moon stopped

- Then the sun stood still and the moon did not move
- So the sun and the moon both stopped and remained in one place.

So the sun stood still: The clause So the sun stood still is a result clause. This was what happened as a result of Joshua’s prayer. Use whatever connecting word indicates a result in your language. The clause the sun stood still indicates that the sun remained in the same place in the sky. God answered Joshua’s prayer and caused the sun to stay still.

and the moon stopped: The clause and the moon stopped indicates that the moon remained in one place in the sky, because Joshua prayed for this to happen. God answered Joshua’s prayer and caused the moon to stay still.

10:13b

until the nation took vengeance upon its enemies.

- until the Israelites completely defeated their enemies.
- They stayed there until Israel finished fighting its enemies.

until the nation took vengeance upon its enemies:

The sun and moon did not move through the sky for a long period of time. This allowed Israel to finish the battle against their enemies.

the nation: The phrase the nation refers to the Israelites.

took vengeance upon its enemies: The clause took vengeance upon its enemies indicates that the Israelites defeated the Amorites.

10:13c

Is this not written in the Book of Jashar?

- This event is written in the Book of Jashar.
- This is written down in the Book of Jashar.

Is this not written in the Book of Jashar?: This is a rhetorical question that functions as a statement. The expected response is “yes, it is.” It may be more natural in some languages to translate this as a statement. For example:

This is what is written down in the Book of Jashar

the Book of Jashar: The term Book of Jashar probably refers to a collection of stories about wars. It is also mentioned one other place in the Old Testament, 2 Samuel 1:18.10:13 Bratcher and Newman, p. 143.

10:13d**“So the sun stopped in the middle of the sky**

- The sun remained in the middle of the sky,
- The sun stopped in the middle of the sky,

So the sun stopped in the middle of the sky: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The sun stayed in the midst of heaven (RSV)

10:13e**and delayed going down about a full day.”**

- and did not set for a whole day.
- and Yahweh delayed it's going down for almost a whole day.

and delayed going down about a full day: This clause adds information about the length of time the sun did not move in the sky. Yahweh made the sun stay in one place for about one day. The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as delayed going down is a Hebrew idiom.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and did not go down for a whole day (GNT)

Joshua 10:14**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:14a**There has been no day like it before or since,**

- There has never been a day like this before or since,
- Never before or after this day was there anything like this.

There has been no day like it before or since: The clause There has been no day like it before or since

indicates that the day when the Israelites fought the Amorites was an extraordinary day. In the history of the world, there was never a day when God answered such a bold request from a human being.

10:14b**when the LORD listened to the voice of a man,**

- a day when Yahweh listened to a man pray such a prayer.
- There was never a day on which Yahweh did something like that for somebody who prayed.

when the LORD listened to the voice of a man: There are two ways to interpret the clause when the LORD listened to the voice of a man.

1. It means that Yahweh listened to Joshua and granted his request. For example:

there has never been a day like this one before or since, when the Lord answered such a prayer (NLT) (BSB, NLT, NIV, RSV, ESV, NASB, NCV, NJPS, REB, CEV, KJV)

1. It means that Yahweh obeyed Joshua. For example:

never before, and never since, has there been a day like it, when the Lord obeyed a human being (GNT) (GNT, GW, NAB, NET, NJB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is followed by a majority of English versions. Sometimes the Hebrew word “to listen” can be translated as “obey.” But it is only used for humans or angels obeying God, not the other way around. A suggestion that God obeyed a human being seems unlikely.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

there has never been a day like it before or since, a day when the Lord listened to a man (NIV)

never before and never since has the Lord done anything like that for someone who prayed (CEV)

10:14c**because the LORD fought for Israel.**

- Yahweh really did fight for Israel.
- Surely the Israelites won the battle because of what Yahweh did for them.

because: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as because can also mean “surely” or “certainly.” It is

used to emphasize a statement. Some examples of its use in English translations are:

surely the Lord was fighting for Israel! (NIV)

the Lord really was fighting for Israel (CEV)

the LORD fought for Israel: The clause the LORD fought for Israel indicates that the Israelites were able to win the battle because of the miracles that Yahweh did for them.

Joshua 10:15

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:15

Then Joshua returned with all Israel to the camp at Gilgal.

- Then Joshua and the Israelite soldiers went back to their camp at Gilgal.
- After the battle, Joshua and all the Israelites went back to their camp at Gilgal.

Then Joshua returned with all Israel to the camp at Gilgal: The phrase all Israel refers to the Israelite army. It may be more natural in some languages to translate the two subjects, Joshua and all Israel, as one compound phrase. For example:

then Joshua and the entire Israelite army returned to their camp at Gilgal

General Comment on 10:6–15

These verses tell the story of the battle against the Amorites, which is completed in verse 15. Verses 16–21 tell the story of the five Amorite kings who fled and hid

in a cave. The CEV supplies some implicit information with verse 15:

After the battle, Joshua and the Israelites went back to their camp at Gilgal. (CEV)

This implicit information may help to clarify the transition between verse 15 and 16.

Joshua 10:16

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:16

Now the five kings had fled and hidden in the cave at Makkedah.

- ¶ However, the five kings ran away and hid in a cave near Makkedah.
- ¶ During the battle, the five Amorite kings escaped and hid in a cave at Makkedah City.

Now the five kings: The phrase the five kings refers to the five Amorite kings who joined together to fight the Israelites. There is a list of these kings in 10:3.

had fled: The verb fled indicates that the kings ran away from the battle. There is implicit information: The five kings ran away before the battle finished. They probably ran away when they realized that the Israelites would win the battle. It may be more natural in some languages to include the implicit information in this part of the verse. For example:

During the battle the five kings escaped (NLT)

While the enemy soldiers were running from the Israelites, the five enemy kings ran away (CEV)

and hidden in the cave at Makkedah: The phrase in the cave at Makkedah refers to a cave near the town of Makkedah. 10:10 stated that the Israelite army chased the Amorite armies as far as the towns of Azekah and Makkedah. The five enemy kings found a cave near Makkedah where they could hide from the Israelites.

Joshua 10:17

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:17a

And Joshua was informed:

- Someone told Joshua:
- And Joshua heard the news that

And Joshua was informed: The phrase Joshua was informed indicates that somebody spoke to Joshua. This passive form makes it possible to leave the speaker unnamed. Use a form in your language to indicate that the speaker is not known.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Someone told Joshua

Joshua heard the news that

Joshua's soldiers told him (CEV)

10:17b

“The five kings have been found; they are hiding in the cave at Makkedah.”

- “We have found the five Amorite kings. They are hiding in a cave near Makkedah.”
- they found the five enemy kings hidden in a cave at Makkedah City.

The five kings have been found: The clause The five kings have been found is a passive construction. If a passive construction is not natural, it is possible to translate this clause in the active voice.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

We have found the five kings

They have found the five enemy kings.

they are hiding in the cave at Makkedah: The town of Makkedah was mentioned in 10:10. It may be more natural in some languages to translate the clause hiding in the cave at Makkedah as an independent sentence. For example:

They are hiding in a cave near the town of Makkedah

Joshua 10:18

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:18a

So Joshua said, “Roll large stones against the mouth of the cave,”

- So Joshua said: “Roll large rocks over the cave opening,
- Joshua told them: “Close the mouth of the cave by rolling big stones against it.

So Joshua said: The clause So Joshua said is a result clause. Joshua gave a command as a result of what the soldiers told him. For example:

Therefore

Use an appropriate means to indicate result in your language.

Joshua said: It may be more natural in some languages to translate the word said as “commanded” or “answered.” It may also be more natural to include the addressee in the clause. For example:

So Joshua commanded them

Roll large stones against the mouth of the cave:

Joshua told his soldiers to Roll large stones against the mouth of the cave so that the entrance to the cave was closed. The five kings could not leave the cave until the Israelites finished fighting the battle. It may be more natural in some languages to make this information explicit. For example:

Cover the opening of the cave with large rocks
(NLT)

10:18b

and post men there to guard them.

- and choose some men to guard the kings.
- Then leave some men there to guard it so that the kings cannot come out.

and post men there to guard them: The clause post men there to guard them indicates that Joshua had some soldiers guard the entrance to the cave, so that the five kings would not push away the rocks and get out. The pronoun them refers to the five kings.

Joshua 10:19

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:19a

But you, do not stop there.

- But as for you, don’t stay there.
- However, don’t stay there yourselves.

But you, do not stop there: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as you, do not stop there is more literally “you, do not stand.” The pronoun “you” is in an emphatic position. Use whatever way is natural in your language to give this emphasis.

The clause do not stop there indicates that Joshua made a distinction between the people who gave the order to guard the cave and the people who guarded it.

10:19b

Pursue your enemies and attack them from behind.

- Chase after your enemies and kill those who are at the back.
- Continue chasing the enemy, attack them from behind.

Pursue your enemies: The clause Pursue your enemies indicates that Joshua commanded these soldiers to continue fighting and to chase the enemy soldiers.

and attack them from behind: The Amorite soldiers were running away from the battlefield. Joshua told the Israelite soldiers to attack those who were running from behind.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

attack them from behind

10:19c

Do not let them reach their cities,

- Don’t let them get into their cities.
- Don’t let them escape behind their city walls.

Do not let them reach their cities: The clause Do not let them reach their cities indicates that Joshua commanded the Israelite army to kill the enemy soldiers before they could return to their walled towns. If they reached their towns they would be protected by the town walls and could continue to fight.

10:19d

for the LORD your God has delivered them into your hand.”

- Yahweh your God has already made sure that you will defeat them.”
- For Yahweh your God has defeated them for you.”

for the LORD your God has delivered them into your hand: The clause the LORD your God has delivered them into your hand indicates that Yahweh has decided that the Israelites will defeat the Amorites. The Israelite army should not hesitate to chase and attack

the enemy soldiers because they can have confidence that Yahweh will enable them to defeat them.

Joshua 10:20

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:20a

So Joshua and the Israelites continued to inflict a terrible slaughter

- Joshua and the Israelites killed many of the Amorites,
- Joshua and the Israelite army killed many Amorite soldiers,

So Joshua and the Israelites: The phrase Joshua and the Israelites refers to Joshua and the Israelite army.

continued to inflict a terrible slaughter: The clause continued to inflict a terrible slaughter is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that the Israelite army killed many of the Amorite soldiers.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua and the Israelites destroyed them completely (NIV)

Joshua and the men of Israel slaughtered them (GNT)

10:20b

until they had finished them off,

- and destroying almost all of them.
- until there were hardly any left alive.

until they had finished them off: The clause until they had finished them off indicates that the Israelite army killed almost all the Amorite soldiers. This clause

restates the information in 10:20a. It emphasizes how completely the Israelites defeated the Amorites. If repetition is not a natural way to show emphasis, it may be more natural to combine 20a and b. For example,

So Joshua and the Israelites killed the enemy (NCV)

Joshua and the Israelites defeated them decisively, almost destroying them (GW)

In some languages there may be grammatical particles or other means that you can use to emphasize this important information in the story.

10:20c

and the remaining survivors retreated to the fortified cities.

- A few were able to get back to their walled cities.
- But a few who were still alive escaped back into their strong cities.

and: It may be more natural in many languages to begin a new sentence and to leave the word and untranslated.

the remaining survivors: The phrase the remaining survivors indicates that a few Amorite soldiers were still alive.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and when the survivors (NRSV)

but the few who were left (NIV)

retreated to the fortified cities: The clause retreated to the fortified cities indicates that a few Amorite soldiers who remained alive escaped into their own towns. These towns had walls to protect them.

Joshua 10:21

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:21a

The whole army returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah,

- Then the whole army returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah.
- Then the Israelites went back safely to Joshua at Makkedah.

The whole army returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah: The clause returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah indicates that Joshua had made a temporary camp at Makkedah and waited there for the army to return from battle.

Makkedah: The town of Makkedah was mentioned in 10:10. Makkedah was in the southern part of Canaan, about 14 kilometers west of Hebron. 10:21 Rasmussen, p. 244. Joshua made his camp there temporarily while the Israelite army attacked the towns in the south of Canaan.

General Comment on 10:20a-21a

It may be clearer in some languages to split this long sentence into several shorter sentences. For example:

^{20a}Joshua and the Israelite soldiers killed almost all of the Amorite soldiers. ^{20b}There were hardly any left alive. ^{20c}Those who were still alive ran into their fortified towns. ^{21a}Then all the Israelite soldiers returned safely to Joshua in the camp at Makkedah.

10:21b

and no one dared to utter a word against the Israelites.

- None of the Canaanite people dared to say anything bad about the Israelites.
- No one was brave enough to threaten the Israelites.

no one dared to utter a word against the Israelites: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as no one dared to utter a word is more literally “not a man sharpened his tongue.” This Hebrew idiom indicates that none of the Canaanites criticized the Israelites or spoke anything bad about them, because they saw how powerful the Israelites were.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

no one dared to speak against any of the Israelites (NRSV)

no one uttered a word against the Israelites (NIV)

no one around there dared say anything bad about the Israelites (CEV)

Joshua 10:22

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:22a

Then Joshua said, “Open the mouth of the cave

- ¶ Joshua told his soldiers: “Now, move the rocks from the entrance to the cave
- ¶ Then Joshua commanded his soldiers: “Take away the rocks from the cave entrance,

Then Joshua said: The clause Joshua said indicates that Joshua gave a command to his soldiers. It may be more natural in some languages to make that information explicit. For example:

Then Joshua commanded his soldiers

Open the mouth of the cave: The clause Open the mouth of the cave indicates that Joshua commanded some of his soldiers to roll away the rocks that covered the entrance to the cave.

10:22b

and bring those five kings out to me.”

- and bring the five kings out to me.”
- and then bring out the five kings who are hiding there.”

and bring those five kings out to me: The five kings refers to the kings of the Amorites who ran away from the battle and hid in the cave.

Joshua 10:23

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:23a

So they brought the five kings out of the cave—

- So they obeyed him, and brought the five kings out from the cave.
- So the soldiers brought the five kings out of the cave,

So they brought: The clause So they brought indicates that the soldiers obeyed Joshua's command.

the five kings out of the cave: The phrase the five kings refers to the five Amorite kings who fought against the Israelites.

It is possible to combine these two clauses into one.

Here are some other ways to translate these clauses:

So Joshua's men brought the five kings out of the cave (NCV)

The soldiers opened the entrance to the cave and brought out the kings (CEV)

10:23b

the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon.

- They were the king of Jerusalem, the king of Hebron, the king of Jarmuth, the king of Lachish and the king of Eglon.

- namely the kings of Jerusalem City, Hebron City, Jarmuth City, Lachish City, and Eglon City.

the kings of Jerusalem, Hebron, Jarmuth, Lachish, and Eglon: These five kings were first named in 10:3. The Hebrew text states this information in detail to emphasize the importance of what is happening. Some languages may have particles or grammatical means other than repetition to give importance to some information.

Joshua 10:24

Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:24a

When they had brought the kings to Joshua,

- When they brought the kings out to Joshua,
- When the soldiers brought them out,

When they had brought the kings to Joshua: The clause When they had brought the kings to Joshua repeats information already stated in 10:23. It links 10:23 with 10:24 and emphasizes that the soldiers obeyed Joshua's commands. This head-tail linkage is natural in some languages but not in others. It may be more natural to leave some of this information implicit. For example,

When they brought them to Joshua (GW)

When they brought them out (NLT)

After this

10:24b

he summoned all the men of Israel and said to the army commanders who had accompanied him,

- he called all the soldiers together and told the officers who fought with him:
- Joshua called the soldiers to come and he told the commanders of his army

he summoned all the men of Israel: The clause he summoned indicates that he called all the soldiers together.

all the men of Israel: The phrase all the men of Israel refers to all the soldiers in the Israelite army.

and said to the army commanders who had accompanied him: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence. For example:

He said to all the commanders of his army (NCV)

He told the army officers

the army commanders: The phrase the army commanders indicates the officers of the Israelite army.

who had accompanied him: The relative clause who had accompanied him refers to the officers of Joshua's army. If translating this clause implies that there were some officers who did not go with Joshua, it may be better to leave it untranslated. 10:24 Bratcher and Newman, p. 149. Some English versions leave this information implicit. For example:

He said to the commanders of his army (NCV)

Joshua told the commanders of his army (NLT)

10:24c

“Come here and put your feet on the necks of these kings.”

- “Come here. Put your feet on the necks of these five kings.”
- to put their feet on the necks of the five kings as a sign of victory.

Come here: The clause Come here indicates that Joshua commanded his officers to come close to where he was.

and put your feet on the necks of these kings: Joshua ordered his officers to put your feet on the necks of these kings because this symbolized victory in the Ancient Near East. There is implied information. Before the army officers could put their feet on the necks of the defeated kings, they must force the kings to lie down. It may be helpful to make this implied information explicit. For example:

Make the five kings lie down and put your feet on their necks

10:24d

So the commanders came forward and put their feet on their necks.

- So the officers did exactly as Joshua told them to do.
- So the commanders obeyed Joshua and put their feet on their necks.

So the commanders came forward: The clause commanders came forward indicates that the army officers came close to Joshua as he had told them to.

and put their feet on their necks: Joshua's command to the soldiers in the first part of the verse is repeated using the same words to emphasize that the army officers obeyed Joshua exactly. It may not be natural in some languages to repeat this information in the same words. In other languages it may be more natural to make a summary statement. For example:

So the army commanders did exactly as Joshua had commanded them

The officers obeyed Joshua and did so.

Joshua 10:25

Section 10:1-27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:25a

“Do not be afraid or discouraged,” Joshua said.

- Then Joshua said to them: “Do not ever be afraid at all.
- And Joshua said to the officers: “Do not be afraid or discouraged.

“Do not be afraid or discouraged,” Joshua said:

Use whatever connecting word is natural to indicate continuing narrative action.

Do not be afraid or discouraged: The two words afraid and discouraged have a similar meaning. This command is similar to the command that Yahweh gave to Joshua in 1:9 and uses the same words that Yahweh spoke to Joshua in 8:1. These two words together indicate that the Israelites should not be afraid at all.

10:25b**“Be strong and courageous,**

- Be strong and brave.
- Be determined and have courage,

Be strong and courageous: The command Be strong and courageous repeats the words that Yahweh spoke to Joshua in 1:9. It is recommended that you translate them in the same way as 1:9 if possible.

10:25c**for the LORD will do this to all the enemies you fight.”**

- Yahweh will defeat all your enemies as he defeated these kings.”
- because this is what Yahweh is going to do to all the people you fight against.”

for the LORD will do this to all the enemies you fight: The clause for the LORD will do this to all the enemies you fight indicates the reason that the Israelites did not have to be afraid. Yahweh will defeat all the Israelites’ enemies as he defeated the Amorite kings and their armies.

you: The pronoun you refers to the army commanders.

Joshua 10:26**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:26a**After this, Joshua struck down and killed the kings,**

- Then Joshua killed the kings
- After this, Joshua put the five kings to death,

After this: The phrase After this indicates that the next event took place after the officers put their feet on the necks of the kings.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

After the officers had done this

Joshua struck down and killed the kings: The two clauses struck down and killed the kings are parallel and have the same meaning. They indicate that Joshua killed the five kings. In some languages it may be more natural to use one verb rather than two to indicate this. For example:

Then Joshua killed each of the five kings (NLT)

10:26b**and he hung their bodies on five trees**

- and hung their bodies on five poles,
- and hung their dead bodies on five trees,

and he hung their bodies on five trees: The clause he hung their bodies on five trees indicates that after Joshua killed the five kings, he hung them each on a tree as a public sign that God had cursed them. This was the same as Joshua did to the king of Ai in 8:29, and you should translate it in a similar way. See also Deuteronomy 21:22–23 where Moses gave rules for how such executions should be done.

10:26c**and left them there until evening.**

- where they hung until evening.
- and left them there until the evening.

and left them there until evening: The clause and left them there until evening indicates that Joshua left the five kings on the trees all day. In the evening, when the sun was setting, he took them down. This was commanded by Moses in Deuteronomy 21:23.

Joshua 10:27**Section 10:1–27 Five Canaanite Kings attacked the Israelites**

The kings of five Canaanite towns joined together to fight against Gibeon. Because the Israelites had a peace treaty with Gibeon, they helped them in their fight. Yahweh helped the Israelites by sending down

hailstones on the Canaanites, and by causing the sun to stop moving so that the Israelites could continue their victory. The five Canaanite kings were captured and put to death.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Israel defeated the Canaan group

The sun stood still

10:27a At sunset

- But when the sun went down,
- When the sun was going down,

At sunset: The phrase At sunset refers to the time when the sun goes down. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence at this point. For example:

when the sun was setting

10:27b Joshua ordered that they be taken down from the trees

- Joshua commanded his soldiers to take the bodies of the kings down from the trees.
- Joshua told the soldiers: “Take the bodies down,

Joshua ordered: It may be more natural in some languages to supply the direct object:

Joshua commanded his soldiers.

that they be taken down from the trees: The clause that they be taken down from the trees indicates that Joshua’s soldiers took the bodies of the kings down from the trees where they were hanging.

10:27c and thrown into the cave in which they had hidden.

- The soldiers threw the bodies into the same cave where the kings hid.
- and throw them into the same cave where they hid themselves.”

and thrown into the cave in which they had hidden: The clause and thrown into the cave in which they had hidden indicates that Joshua’s soldiers threw the bodies of the dead kings into the same cave in which they first hid. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. It may also be helpful to make the subject and object explicit. For example:

Then the soldiers threw the bodies into the same cave where they had been hiding

10:27d Then large stones were placed against the mouth of the cave,

- They covered the opening of the cave with large rocks,
- Then the soldiers covered the cave entrance with large stones.

Then large stones were placed against the mouth of the cave: The clause Then large stones were placed against the mouth of the cave indicates that after the soldiers threw the dead bodies into the cave, they covered up the cave entrance again with large rocks. The place where the kings hid themselves to escape Joshua’s army became their tomb.

10:27e and the stones are there to this day.

- which are there to this day.
- Those stones are still there to this day.

and the stones are there to this day: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence at this point. For example:

The stones remain there until this day

to this day: The phrase to this day indicates that, at the time the author wrote the book of Joshua, the stones were still there.

Joshua 10:28

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:28a On that day Joshua captured Makkedah

- ¶ That day Joshua defeated the city of Makkedah.
- ¶ On that same day, Joshua and the Israelites attacked and defeated Makkedah City.

On that day: The phrase On that day indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army attacked and captured Makkedah on the same day that they killed the five kings.

Joshua captured Makkedah: The clause Joshua captured Makkedah indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army captured the town of Makkedah. It may be necessary in some languages to make explicit that the Israelite army also fought, and that Joshua did not capture Makkedah by himself. For example:

Joshua and the Israelites captured the town of Makkedah on that day

Makkedah: The town of Makkedah was about 40 kilometers southwest of Gibeon. 10:28 Bratcher and Newman, p. 151. The cave where the five Amorite kings hid was near Makkedah. After Joshua killed the five kings, he and his army proceeded to capture this nearby town.

10:28b
and put it to the sword, along with its king.

- He killed the king and the people of the city with his sword.
- They killed the king and the people of this city.

and put it to the sword, along with its king: This indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army killed the king of Makkedah and the people who lived there.

put it to the sword: The phrase put it to the sword is a Hebrew idiom. The word “smote” is the past tense of “smite.” It means “hit.” This idiom means that they killed the king and the people of Makkedah.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

Joshua killed its king and everyone else in the town (CEV)

10:28c
He devoted to destruction everyone in the city, leaving no survivors.

- He devoted them to Yahweh for destruction. He killed them all.
- They killed every single person because Yahweh claimed them.

He devoted to destruction everyone in the city: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as devoted to destruction everyone comes from the same root word as the term “devoted for destruction” used in 6:17b. It refers to people or things that are claimed by Yahweh and cannot be bought back by any means. They must be destroyed. If possible, translate this word in the same way as you did in 6:17b. For example:

he devoted to destruction every person in it (ESV)

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors indicates that not a single person was left alive in the town.

10:28d
So he did to the king of Makkedah as he had done to the king of Jericho.

- He did the same thing to the king of Makkedah that he did to the king of Jericho.
- He killed the king of Makkedah City in the same way that he killed the king of Jericho City.

So he did to the king of Makkedah as he had done to the king of Jericho: The pronoun he refers to Joshua. The clause he did to the king of Makkedah as he had done to the king of Jericho indicates that Joshua killed the king of Makkedah. It may be clearer to make this information explicit. For example:

and he killed the king of Makkedah as he had killed the king of Jericho (NLT)

A similar phrase was used in 8:2 referring to the king of Ai.

Joshua 10:29

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:29a
Then Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Makkedah to Libnah

- Then Joshua and the Israelites went from Makkedah to Libnah
- Joshua and the soldiers left Makkedah City and went to Libnah City

Then Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Makkedah: The clause Then Joshua...moved on from Makkedah indicates that Joshua left the town of Makkedah.

and all Israel with him: The phrase and all Israel with him indicates that the whole Israelite army went with him. The terms “Joshua” and all Israel are both the

subjects of this sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to put them together. For example:

Then Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Makkedah to Libnah (NIV)

Then Joshua, along with his whole army, left Makkedah and went to fight against Libnah.

to Libnah: The town of Libnah was about 11 kilometers southwest of Makkedah.

10:29b and fought against Libnah.

- and fought against it.
- and attacked it.

and fought against Libnah: The clause fought against Libnah indicates that Joshua and his army attacked the town of Libnah.

Joshua 10:30

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:30a And the LORD also delivered that city and its king into the hand of Israel,

- Yahweh gave the Israelites the power to defeat the king of Libnah and his people.
- Yahweh gave the Israelites victory over Libnah and its king,

And the LORD also delivered that city and its king into the hand of Israel: The clause the LORD also delivered that city and its king into the hand of Israel indicates that Yahweh gave Joshua and the Israelite army the power to defeat the king and the town of Libnah. They captured the town of Libnah as they had captured the town of Makkedah.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The Lord also gave that city and its king into Israel's hand (NIV)

The Lord also gave the Israelites victory over this city and its king (GNT)

10:30b and Joshua put all the people to the sword,

- The Israelites killed every single person in the city with their swords.
- and they killed the king and all the people.

and Joshua: There are two ways to understand the pronoun “he,” which the BSB translates as Joshua.

1. The pronoun “he” refers to Joshua and the Israelite army. For example:

the city and everyone in it Joshua put to the sword (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, NJPS, GNT, NLT, NCV, CEV)

1. The pronoun “he” refers to Yahweh. For example:

and he struck it with the edge of the sword, and every person in it (ESV) (ESV, RSV, GW, NABRE, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The pronoun “he” probably refers to Joshua as the representative of the Israelite army, or to the Israelite army itself.

put all the people to the sword: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as put all the people to the sword is an idiom. It indicates that Joshua and his army killed every person in the town of Libnah.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

he killed all the people (GW)

killed every person in it (GNT)

10:30c leaving no survivors.

- Not a single person was left alive.
- They didn't let any of them live.

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors indicates that there were no people still alive in Libnah after the Israelite army attacked it. This information was stated in a positive manner in the previous part of the verse. It is restated here negatively. This is a way to emphasize that every single person died.

Here is another way to translate 30b-c:

Joshua and his army killed everyone in Libnah with their swords, leaving no survivors

10:30d

And he did to the king of Libnah as he had done to the king of Jericho.

- And they did the same thing to the king that they did to the king of Jericho.
- Joshua killed the king of Libnah in the same way that he killed the king of Jericho.

And he did to the king of Libnah as he had done to the king of Jericho: The clause he did to the king of Libnah as he had done to the king of Jericho is similar to the clause in 10:28d. It indicates that Joshua killed the king of Libnah. You should translate this in a similar way to 10:28d.

It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Then Joshua killed the king of Libnah as he had killed the king of Jericho (NLT)

Joshua 10:31

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:31a

And Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Libnah to Lachish.

- ¶ Then Joshua and his soldiers went from Libnah to Lachish.
- ¶ Joshua then went with his army from Libnah City to Lachish City.

And Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Libnah to Lachish: The clause Joshua and all Israel with him moved on from Libnah to Lachish has similar wording to 10:29a. It indicates that Joshua and his army went from Libnah to Lachish. It is recommended that you translate this clause in the same way that you translated the clause in 10:29a.

Lachish: The town of Lachish was about 17 kilometers south of Libnah. 10:31 Bratcher and Newman, p. 152.

10:31b

They laid siege to it and fought against it.

- They surrounded it, and attacked it.
- They set up their camp around the city and attacked it.

They laid siege to it: The verb laid siege indicates that Joshua and the Israelites set up their camp around the town so that no one could leave the town.

and fought against it: The clause fought against it indicates that the Israelite army attacked the town of Lachish.

Joshua 10:32

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:32a

And the LORD delivered Lachish into the hand of Israel,

- Yahweh gave the Israelites victory over Lachish.
- Yahweh helped the Israelites capture Lachish City.

And the LORD delivered Lachish into the hand of Israel: The clause the LORD delivered Lachish into the hand of Israel is similar to verse 10:30a.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Yahweh enabled the Israelite army to defeat the people of the town of Lachish.

10:32b

and Joshua captured it on the second day. He put all the people to the sword,

- Joshua captured it on the second day of the battle, and killed the people in it with the sword.
- On the second day they defeated the city, and killed the people in it.

and Joshua captured it on the second day: The clause Joshua captured it on the second day indicates that it took two days for Joshua and his army to defeat the town of Lachish, unlike the first two towns, which they defeated in only one day.

He put all the people to the sword: The clause put all the people to the sword is a Hebrew idiom. This is the same wording as the clauses in 10:28b and 10:30b. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way.

The king of Lachish is not mentioned because he was one of the five kings who led the battle against the Gibeonites. Joshua killed him by the cave at Makkedah (10:23, 26).

10:32c
just as he had done to Libnah.

- He spared no one, as he did at Libnah.
- They killed everybody there, as they did at Libnah City.

just as he had done to Libnah: The clause as he had done to Libnah refers to what Joshua did to the people of Libnah. It may be more natural in some languages to make this information explicit. For example:

Joshua killed all the people of Lachish, as he had killed all the people in Libnah

Joshua 10:33

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:33a

At that time Horam king of Gezer went to help Lachish,

- ¶ At this time Horam king of Gezer came to help Lachish,
- ¶ At that time King Horam of Gezer City came to help the people of Lachish City.

At that time Horam king of Gezer: Horam is the only king in this list of kings and towns who is mentioned by name. The grammar of this sentence is also different from the usual narrative storyline pattern in Hebrew.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as At that time indicates that the action that follows has special prominence. This verse stands at the center of the narrative about these seven towns.10:33 Boling and Wright, p. 294. It emphasizes the military leadership of Joshua because Horam king of Gezer came to the help of Lachish. However, Joshua and the Israelites defeated both Horam's army and the army of Lachish. Some English versions give prominence to this verse in the following ways:

During this same time King Horam of Gezer came to help Lachish (NCV)

During the attack on Lachish, King Horam of Gezer arrived with his army to help defend the town (NLT)

At that time King Horam of Gezer had come to help Lachish (GW)

Gezer: The town of Gezer is probably about 35 kilometers north of Lachish.10:33 Bratcher and Newman, p. 152.

went to help Lachish: The phrase went to help is used in a military sense. It indicates that the king and his army came prepared to fight a battle.10:33 Boling and Wright, p. 292.

10:33b

but Joshua struck him down along with his people, leaving no survivors.

- But Joshua defeated him and his army, and no one was left alive.
- But Joshua killed him and his soldiers, and they all died.

but: The BSB used the word but here to indicate that what happens is surprising and not what was expected.

Joshua struck him down along with his people: The clause Joshua struck him down along with his people indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army killed the king of Gezer and his army.

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors indicates that the Israelite army continued to attack the army of the king of Gezer until every soldier had died.

Joshua 10:34

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:34a

So Joshua moved on from Lachish to Eglon, and all Israel with him.

- ¶ Then Joshua and all the Israelites went from Lachish to Eglon.
- ¶ Next, Joshua and his soldiers went from Lachish City to Eglon City,

So Joshua moved on from Lachish to Eglon, and all Israel with him: The clause Joshua moved on from Lachish to Eglon, and all Israel with him has similar wording as 10:31a. The town of Eglon was about 16 kilometers west of Lachish. 10:34 Bratcher and Newman, p. 152. It is possible to translate this clause in the same way as 10:31a. In languages where a repetitious style is not natural, it may be possible to vary the wording a little bit.

10:34b

They laid siege to it and fought against it.

- They surrounded it, and attacked it.
- They set up their camp around the city and attacked it.

They laid siege to it and fought against it: The clause They laid siege to it and fought against it is the same as the clause in 10:31b. It is recommended that you translate it the same way.

Joshua 10:35

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:35a

That day they captured Eglon and put it to the sword,

- They captured it that day and killed the people in it with their swords.
- They captured it that same day, then killed everyone in it.

That day they captured Eglon: The clause That day they captured Eglon indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army captured the town and its inhabitants on the same day that they attacked it. In some languages, it is more natural to reverse the order of the words in this phrase. For example:

They captured Eglon City that same day

That day: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as That day is stated twice in this verse for emphasis. It contrasts the fact that the Israelites captured and destroyed the town of Eglon in one day, whereas it took them two days to capture the town of Lachish.

and put it to the sword: The clause put it to the sword indicates that the Israelite army killed the people of the town. This is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:28, and it is recommended that you translate it the same way in both places.

10:35b

and Joshua devoted to destruction everyone in the city,

- Joshua devoted them to Yahweh for destruction on that day
- On that day they killed every single person because Yahweh claimed them.

and Joshua devoted to destruction everyone in the city: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as and Joshua devoted to destruction everyone in the city has the object stated first because this is a way that the Hebrew language indicates prominence or emphasis. Other languages may have a different way to show emphasis. Indicate emphasis that is natural in your language.

Joshua: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Joshua refers to Joshua as the representative of the Israelite army. In some languages it may be more natural to include this implied information. For example:

Joshua and the Israelite soldiers utterly destroyed the town of Eglon that day

devoted to destruction: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as devoted to destruction is the same verb used in 10:28c. It refers to people or things that are claimed by Yahweh and cannot be bought back by any means. They must be destroyed.

10:35c

just as he had done to Lachish.

- as he did to Lachish.
- This was same as they did to Lachish City.

just as he had done to Lachish: The phrase just as he had done to Lachish may be translated as an independent sentence. For example:

He treated Eglon the same way as he had treated Lachish.

Joshua 10:36

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:36a

Then Joshua and all Israel with him went up from Eglon to Hebron

- ¶ Then Joshua and his soldiers went from Eglon uphill to Hebron,
- ¶ Then Joshua and all the Israelite army marched from Eglon City to Hebron City.

Then Joshua and all Israel with him went up: The Hebrew text says Joshua...went up to Hebron, because Hebron was in the high hill country. Joshua walked from Eglon to a higher elevation. In languages that do not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say:

Then Joshua went

and all Israel with him: The phrase all Israel with him indicates that Joshua led the whole Israelite army to Hebron.

from Eglon to Hebron: The town of Hebron was in the hill country, about 36 kilometers from Eglon. 10:36 Bratcher and Newman, p. 154.

10:36b

and fought against it.

- and they attacked it.
- They attacked it

and fought against it: The clause fought against it indicates that the Israelite army attacked the town of Hebron.

Joshua 10:37

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:37a

They captured it and put to the sword

- They captured it and killed the people with their swords.
- and captured it, and killed its people.

They captured it: The clause captured it indicates that the Israelites captured the town.

put to the sword: The clause put to the sword indicates that the Israelite army killed the people in Hebron. This is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:28, and it is recommended that you translate it the same way in both places.

10:37b

its king, all its villages, and all the people.

- They killed its king and every person in it and in the villages around it.
- They killed the king and all the people, and the people in the small towns near it.

its king, all its villages, and all the people: The phrase its king, all its villages refers to the king of Hebron and the surrounding villages that were under the control of Hebron. All the people in Hebron and its villages were killed.

10:37c

Joshua left no survivors, just as he had done at Eglon; he devoted to destruction Hebron and everyone in it.

- As he did to Eglon, he killed everybody. He devoted them to Yahweh for destruction.
- Nobody was left alive, as nobody was left alive at Eglon City. Joshua claimed the city and all its people for Yahweh by destroying them.

Joshua left no survivors: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Joshua left no survivors is more literally “not a survivor remained.” This indicates that the Israelite army killed every person in Hebron and its surrounding towns.

just as he had done at Eglon: The clause just as he had done at Eglon is similar to the clause in verse 10:35c. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way.

he devoted to destruction Hebron and everyone in it: The clause he devoted to destruction Hebron and everyone in it is similar to verse 10:35b. The verb devoted to destruction refers to the action of destroying people and things that Yahweh had claimed and could not be bought back by any means.

General Comment on verse 10:37

It may be more natural in some languages to reorder the parts of 10:37.

Here is another way to translate this verse:

and captured it. They killed the king and everyone else in the city as well as in the nearby towns. Joshua condemned the city to total destruction, just as he had done to Eglon. No one in it was left alive. (GNT)

Joshua 10:38**Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan**

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:38**Finally Joshua and all Israel with him turned toward Debir and fought against it.**

- ¶ Then Joshua and the Israelite army turned southward to Debir and attacked it.
- ¶ Then Joshua and the Israelite soldiers turned back to Debir City and attacked it.

Joshua and all Israel with him: The phrase Joshua and all Israel with him refers to Joshua and the entire Israelite army.

turned toward Debir: The clause turned toward Debir indicates that the Israelites changed the direction that they were walking. Earlier they walked from Eglon north to Hebron in the higher hills. Now they turned and walked south to Debir. The town of Debir was 20 kilometers southwest of Hebron. 10:38 Bratcher and Newman, p. 155.

and fought against it: The clause fought against it indicates that the Israelite army attacked Debir.

Joshua 10:39**Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan**

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

10:39a**And they captured Debir, its king, and all its villages.**

- They captured it with its king and all the towns near it
- They captured Debir City and its king, and the villages under its control

And they captured Debir, its king, and all its villages:

In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence, as in the BSB. The clause they captured Debir, its king, and all its villages is similar to verse 10:37a-b. It indicates that the Israelite army captured the king and all the people of Debir and he also captured the small towns that were close by.

10:39b**They put them to the sword**

- and they killed the people with their swords.
- and they killed the people there.

They put them to the sword: The clause They put them to the sword indicates that the Israelite army killed the people of Debir and the nearby towns. This is a Hebrew idiom that is similar to the clauses in verses 28b, 30b, 32b, 35a, and 37a. It is recommended that you translate it the same way in all these places.

10:39c**and devoted to destruction everyone in the city,**

- They devoted every person to Yahweh for destruction.
- They claimed them all for Yahweh by destroying them.

10:39d**leaving no survivors.**

- There were nobody who lived.
- No one was left alive.

10:39c-d

and devoted to destruction everyone in the city, leaving no survivors: These two clauses are similar to verse 10:37.

devoted to destruction: The phrase devoted to destruction indicates that Yahweh had claimed these people for himself and they could not be bought back by any means. They must be destroyed.

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors indicates that not a single person was left alive in the town of Debir and the surrounding towns.

10:39e**Joshua did to Debir and its king as he had done to Hebron and as he had done to Libnah and its king.**

- Joshua did the same thing to Debir and its king that he did to Hebron and to Libnah and its king.
- Israel did to Debir City and its king as they did to Hebron City, and to Libnah City and its king.

Joshua did to Debir and its king as he had done to Hebron and as he had done to Libnah and its king: Here is another example of how to translate this verse part:

Joshua did the same thing to Debir and its king
as he had done to Hebron and as he had done to
Libnah and its king

Joshua 10:40

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

Paragraph 10:40–43

This paragraph is a conclusion to the account of the battles that Israelites fought in southern Canaan. These verses summarize what the Israelite army accomplished. These events were told in detail in 10:28–39.

10:40a

So Joshua conquered the whole region—

- ¶ So Joshua defeated the kings of all the cities in this region.
- ¶ In this way Joshua conquered the whole land of Southern Canaan.

So Joshua conquered the whole region: Joshua is named as the leader of the Israelite army. He defeated the whole region by leading the army as they fought. In some languages it may be more natural to include the Israelite army with Joshua as a compound subject. For example:

Joshua and the Israelite soldiers defeated the
whole land

the whole region: The phrase the whole region refers to the region of southern Canaan. The towns that the Israelite army captured in chapter 10 were all in southern Canaan.

10:40b

the hill country, the Negev, the foothills, and the slopes, together with all their kings—

- He defeated all the people in the mountains, the Negev Desert south of Canaan, the hills to the west, and the slopes to the east.
- He conquered the central hill country, the southern desert, the foothills to the west, and the slopes that go down to the Dead Sea.

the hill country: The phrase the hill country refers to the central mountain range that extended from Ai and Gibeon in the north to Hebron and Debir in the south. See how you translated this term in 9:1.

the Negev: The phrase the Negev refers to the wilderness area south of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the dry country in the south (GNT)

the Southern Desert (CEV)

the foothills: The phrase the foothills refers to the western foothills that were between the mountains and the coastal plain. This term was used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and the slopes: The phrase the slopes refers to the steep slopes that lead down from the hill country eastward to the Dead Sea.

together with all their kings: The phrase all their kings refers to the kings of the towns in these areas. It may be more natural in some languages to include the term about the kings in the first part of the verse, as in GNT:

Joshua conquered the whole land. He defeated the kings of the hill country, the eastern slopes, and the western foothills, as well as those of the dry country in the south. (GNT)

10:40c

leaving no survivors. He devoted to destruction everything that breathed,

- He did not let anybody live. He killed all the people.
- He killed all the people, and none of them were left alive,

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors has occurred five times in verses 10:28–39. It is repeated to emphasize that Joshua obeyed Yahweh's command in Deuteronomy 20:16–18 to destroy every-

one in the land of Canaan. It is recommended that you translate it the same way each time.

He devoted to destruction everything that breathed: The clause devoted to destruction everything that breathed is similar to the clauses in verses 28, 35, 37, and 39.

devoted to destruction: The phrase devoted to destruction translates the Hebrew verb that means a person or thing is claimed by Yahweh and cannot be bought back by any means, but must be destroyed.

everything that breathed: The phrase everything that breathed means “every person.” It does not refer to animals. This expression is also used in Deuteronomy 20:16.

10:40d
just as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded.

- This was what Yahweh the God of Israel commanded.
- as Yahweh the God of Israel said.

just as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded: The clause as the LORD, the God of Israel, had commanded refers to the command that Yahweh gave to Joshua and the Israelites through Moses in Deuteronomy 20:16–18. It may be more natural in some languages to state this as an independent sentence. For example:

This was what the Lord God of Israel had commanded. (GNT)

It is recommended that you include a footnote or a reference to Deuteronomy 20:16–18.

Joshua 10:41

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

Paragraph 10:40–43

This paragraph is a conclusion to the account of the battles that Israelites fought in southern Canaan. These verses summarize what the Israelite army accomplished. These events were told in detail in 10:28–39.

10:41a

Joshua conquered the area from Kadesh-barnea to Gaza,

- Joshua defeated the cities from Kadesh Barnea in the south to Gaza in the west,
- Joshua conquered them from Kadesh Barnea town in the south to Gaza City by the Mediterranean Sea.

Joshua conquered the area: The clause Joshua conquered the area continues the summary of what Joshua did.

from Kadesh-barnea: Kadesh-barnea was a town on the southeast boundary of Canaan, more than 80 kilometers south of Debir. It was the southernmost town that Joshua conquered.

Here is another way to spell Kadesh-barnea:

Kadesh Barnea (NIV, NET)

to Gaza: Gaza was a town on the southwestern coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

10:41b
and the whole region of Goshen as far as Gibeon.

- and from Goshen to Gibeon in the north.
- He conquered the people in the region of Goshen City, and as far north as Gibeon City.

and the whole region of Goshen: The phrase the whole region of Goshen refers to a town in the southern hill country of Canaan and the region around it. The exact location of the town of Goshen is unknown. 10:41 Howard, p. 262.

as far as Gibeon: The town of Gibeon was the northernmost point of Joshua’s conquest.

Joshua 10:42

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

Paragraph 10:40–43

This paragraph is a conclusion to the account of the battles that Israelites fought in southern Canaan. These verses summarize what the Israelite army accomplished. These events were told in detail in 10:28–39.

10:42a

And because the LORD, the God of Israel, fought for Israel,

- Because Yahweh, the God of Israel, helped Israel to fight,
- Because Yahweh the God of Israel fought for the Israelites,

Joshua captured all these kings and their land in one campaign: The clause Joshua captured all these kings and their land in one campaign indicates that Joshua defeated all the kings mentioned in the previous verse and conquered their lands.

in one campaign: The phrase in one campaign indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army were able to conquer all the kings and lands in one continuous military campaign. It does not indicate how many days this campaign lasted. The army began their battle against the five Amorite kings at Gibeon and then continued on from town to town until they had defeated them all.

10:42b

Joshua captured all these kings and their land in one campaign.

- Joshua conquered these kings and their cities all at one time.
- Joshua conquered all these kings and their territory in one continuous battle.

because the LORD, the God of Israel, fought for Israel: In some languages it may help to emphasize the important point made here by supplying implicit information:

They were able to do this because Yahweh the God of Israel fought for Israel

Joshua 10:43

Section 10:28–43 The Israelites conquered the towns of southern Canaan

Joshua defeated seven other important towns in Southern Canaan.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the southern towns

Paragraph 10:40–43

This paragraph is a conclusion to the account of the battles that Israelites fought in southern Canaan. These verses summarize what the Israelite army ac-

complished. These events were told in detail in 10:28–39.

10:43

Then Joshua returned with all Israel to the camp at Gilgal.

- Then Joshua and the Israelite soldiers went back to their camp at Gilgal.
- After the battle, Joshua and all the Israelites went back to their camp at Gilgal.

Then Joshua returned with all Israel to the camp at Gilgal: This verse is identical to verse 10:15. It is recommended that you translate this verse the same as you translated 10:15.

Joshua 11:1

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:1a

Now when Jabin king of Hazor heard about these things,

- ¶ When King Jabin of Hazor heard about the battles that the Israelites won,
- ¶ King Jabin, the king of Hazor, heard what happened.

Now when Jabin king of Hazor heard about these things: The clause when Jabin king of Hazor heard about these things has the same structure as the clause that began 10:1. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way.

Hazor: The town of Hazor was a large town about 14 kilometers north of the Sea of Galilee. 11:1 Howard, p. 265.

about these things: The phrase about these things refers to Joshua's victories over the kings in Southern Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

King Jabin of Hazor heard about Joshua's victories (CEV)

King Jabin of Hazor heard what had happened
(GW)

11:1b

he sent word to Jobab king of Madon; to the kings of Shimron and Achshaph;

- he sent a message to King Jobab of Madon, and to the kings of Shimron and Achshaph,
- So, he sent messengers to many cities and asked them to join him in fighting against Israel. He sent them to King Jobab of Madon City and to the king of Shimron City and the king of Achshaph City.

he sent word to Jobab king of Madon: In the list of kings that follows, King Jobab is the only king listed by name. This indicates that he was Jabin's most powerful neighbor.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he sent messengers to King Jobab of Madon to ask for his help to fight against the Israelites

Madon: The town of Madon was 30 kilometers south-east of Hazor.11:1 Bratcher and Newman, p. 158.

to the kings of Shimron: The exact location of the town of Shimron is unknown. In Joshua 19:15, it is listed as part of the territory of Zebulun.11:1 Howard, p. 266.

and Achshaph: The exact location of the town of Achshaph is uncertain. It is listed as part of the territory of Asher in Joshua 19:25.

Joshua 11:2

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:2a

to the kings of the north in the mountains,

- and to the kings in the northern hills,
- He sent them to the northern kings in the hills.

to the kings of the north in the mountains: The phrase the kings of the north in the mountains refers

to other towns ruled by kings which were further north in the mountains of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the northern kings who were in the mountains
(NIV)

the kings in the hill country in the north (GNT)

11:2b

in the Arabah south of Chinnereth, in the foothills, and in Naphoth-dor to the west;

- and in the Jordan River Valley south of Lake Galilee, and the kings in the lower slopes, and in Naphoth-dor to the west,
- He sent them to the kings in the valley of the Jordan River south of Lake Galilee, and to those in the foothills to the west. He sent a message to the king of Naphoth-dor City in the west.

in the Arabah south of Chinnereth: The Arabah refers to the valley of the Jordan River, north of the Dead Sea and south of Lake Galilee.

Chinnereth: Chinnereth refers to Lake Galilee.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Jordan valley south of Lake Galilee (GNT)

in the foothills: The phrase the foothills refers to the western foothills that were between the mountains and the coastal plain. This word was used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and in Naphoth-dor to the west: The town of Dor was a seaport on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea south of Mount Carmel. It is not certain to what the term Naphoth refers.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

the heights of Dor (NET, NASB)

on the coast near Dor (GNT)

the district of Dor (NJPS)

the borders of Dor (KJV)

Naphoth Dor (NIV, GW)

Joshua 11:3

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:3a

to the Canaanites in the east and west;

- and to the Canaanite kings east and west of the Jordan River,
- He sent them to the Canaanites on both sides of the Jordan River.

to the Canaanites: The Canaanites were one of the groups of people who lived in the land of Canaan. It may be more natural to include some implicit information at the beginning of verse 3. For example, you could say:

King Jabin also sent messengers to the kings of the Canaan people

in the east and west: The phrase in the east and west indicates the east and west sides of the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to the Canaanite people on the east and west sides of the Jordan River

11:3b

to the Amorites, Hittites, Perizzites, and Jebusites in the hill country;

- and to the kings of Amor, Heth, Periz, and Jebus in the hill country,
- He sent them to the kings of the Amorites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, and the Jebusites in the mountains.

to the Amorites, Hittites, Perizzites, and Jebusites: These are groups of people who lived in the land of Canaan along with the Canaanites. Yahweh told the Israelites to destroy all these nations with his help (see Deuteronomy 20:16–18). These groups of people were mentioned in Joshua 3:10. You should translate the names the same way you did there.

in the hill country: The phrase hill country indicates the mountainous region that is between the coastal plain and the Jordan River valley. This is the same phrase used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

11:3c

and to the Hivites at the foot of Hermon in the land of Mizpah.

- and to the king of the Hiv people in the region of Mizpah, near the foot of Mount Hermon.
- And he sent them to the Hivites, who lived at the foot of Hermon Mountain in the Mizpah Valley.

and to the Hivites at the foot of Hermon: The Hivites were a group of people who lived in the Mizpah Valley south of Mount Hermon. Hermon Mountain is a tall mountain in northeastern Israel. It is 43 kilometers southwest of Damascus and 2,814 meters high. It is the tallest mountain in Israel. 11:3 Rasmussen, p. 238.

at the foot of Hermon: The Hivites lived near the foot of Hermon Mountain. Hermon Mountain is covered with snow most of the year. It was the dominant feature of the landscape above the Hivite people.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Hivite kings in the region of Mizpah, near the foot of Mount Hermon (CEV)

in the land of Mizpah: The term Mizpah refers to a valley at the foot of Hermon Mountain. There are several towns mentioned in the Bible that are named Mizpah, but they are in other places. The Mizpah mentioned here is only mentioned again in Joshua 11:8. 11:3 Rasmussen, p. 245.

General Comment on verses 11:1–3

These verses contain a list of the names of towns and their kings to whom King Jabin of Hazor sent messengers. He asked them to help him fight the Israelites. In some languages it may be helpful to state this information at the beginning of 11:1. For example:

When King Jabin of Hazor heard the news of the Israelites' victories, he sent messengers to the towns of Northern Canaan and their kings asking for their help to fight the Israelites. He sent to King Jobab of Madon... 11:3 Bratcher and Newman, p. 158.

Joshua 11:4

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:4a

So these kings came out with all their armies, a multitude

- They came out with all their soldiers, a lot of them.
- The kings of these cities gathered together, and there were many soldiers.

So: The Hebrew connector that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the story. Here it also indicates result. The kings and their armies marched out in response to the message they had received from King Jabin of Hazor.

these kings: The pronoun these kings indicates the kings of the towns referred to in verse 3.

came out with all their armies: The verb came out indicates that the kings gathered their troops together and came out of their towns to fight against the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the kings of these towns came out with all their soldiers

a multitude: The phrase a multitude indicates that there were many soldiers.

11:4b

as numerous as the sand on the seashore,

- There were as many soldiers as the grains of sand on the seashore,
- There were so many soldiers they could not be counted. There were as many as the grains of sand beside the sea.

as numerous as the sand on the seashore: The phrase as numerous as the sand on the seashore indicates a comparison. The number of Canaanite soldiers gathered to fight against the Israelites is compared to the grains of sand on the beach by the sea. There were

so many that it was impossible to count them. In some languages it may be helpful to make this comparison clearer. For example:

there were so many soldiers that they could not be counted. It was like counting the sand that is on the seashore

11:4c

along with a great number of horses and chariots.

- and they had many horses and chariots.
- They had many horses which pulled war carts.

along with a great number of horses and chariots:

The horses were used to pull the chariots. At that time, the Israelite army did not have any horses or chariots. The Canaanite army had more soldiers and had better weapons than the Israelites. This made the Israelite victory even more remarkable and showed that it was only possible because God fought for them.

chariots: The chariots were light carts that were each pulled by one or two horses. There was room in the chariot for two soldiers. One drove the horses and the other was free to fight with a sword or with bow and arrows.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

war cart

horse-drawn war cart

Joshua 11:5

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:5a

All these kings joined forces

- All these kings brought their soldiers together
- All these kings came with their armies

All these kings: The phrase All these kings indicates the kings of each of the towns mentioned in the above verses.

joined forces: The clause joined forces indicates that the kings told their armies to fight together as one army against the Israelites.

11:5b

and encamped at the waters of Merom

- at the waters of Merom, and camped there
- to the Merom River and set up their camp together there.

and encamped: The clause and encamped indicates that all the armies set up their camps as if they were one army.

at the waters of Merom: The exact location of the waters of Merom is uncertain. It was probably a riverbed where waters flowed during rainstorms. It was probably somewhere between the Sea of Galilee and the Mediterranean coast. 11:5 Howard p. 267 and footnote 264.

Here is another way to translate this term:

Merom Brook (GNT)

11:5c

to fight against Israel.

- ready to fight Israel.
- Then they got ready to fight with the Israelites.

to fight against Israel: The clause to fight against Israel indicates the intention of the armies. They gathered and set up camp in order to fight against the Israelites. This can also be translated as an independent sentence. For example:

Then they got ready to fight with Israel.

Joshua 11:6

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:6a

Then the LORD said to Joshua, “Do not be afraid of them,

- Then Yahweh said to Joshua: “Do not be afraid of them.
- Then Yahweh told Joshua: “Do not be afraid of the Canaanite armies

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then indicates the continuing action of the narrative. Yahweh gave instructions to Joshua after the armies gathered to fight against the Israelites.

Do not be afraid of them: Yahweh told Joshua not to be afraid of the enemies. Yahweh gave him this same encouragement before the battle of Ai (Joshua 8:1) and the battle at Gibeon (Joshua 10:8).

11:6b

for by this time tomorrow I will deliver all of them slain before Israel.

- By this time tomorrow I will kill all of them and hand them over to Israel.
- because I am going to give them to you Israelites. At this time tomorrow they will all be dead.

for by this time tomorrow: The phrase by this time tomorrow indicates the time that Yahweh will help the Israelites to defeat the armies of the northern kings.

I will deliver all of them slain before Israel: The clause I will deliver all of them slain before Israel indicates that Yahweh will kill the enemies of the Israelites. It is evident from verses 6–7 that the Israelites had a part in pursuing their enemies and killing them. However, this happened only because Yahweh enabled them to do it.

slain: The word slain is from the verb “to slay” which means “to kill.” Yahweh said that he would kill the enemies.

before Israel: Yahweh said he would give the Canaanite soldiers before Israel. Since Yahweh was talking to Joshua, it may be clearer in some languages to translate this:

to you

to you Israelites

11:6c

You are to hamstring their horses

- Then you must cut the hamstrings of their horses

- You must cut the legs of their horses so that they cannot be used in battle

You are to hamstring their horses: The word to hamstring means to cut the large tendon, the “hamstring,” that runs down the back of the horse’s hind leg. The Israelites were to cut the hamstrings of the Canaanite horses so that they would not be able to walk. They did this so that the enemy armies could not use the horses that survived.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

cut the hamstrings of their horses

cut the legs of their horses so that they cannot be used to fight

11:6d and burn up their chariots.”

- and burn their chariots.”
- and burn up their chariots with fire.”

and burn up their chariots: The Hebrew text includes the words “with fire”, which may be helpful to specific in some languages. For example:

and burn their chariots with fire

In other languages, adding this might make it redundant, because it is already implied in the verb burn.

Joshua 11:7

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:7a So by the waters of Merom,

- At waters of Merom.
- At Merom River.

So by the waters of Merom: The waters of Merom were mentioned in 11:5b. The battle between the

Israelites and the enemy armies took place near this riverbed.

11:7b Joshua and his whole army came upon them suddenly and attacked them,

- Joshua and all his soldiers caught them by surprise.
- Joshua and his army made a surprise attack against the Canaanites.

Joshua and his whole army came upon them suddenly: The clause Joshua and his whole army came upon them suddenly indicates that Joshua and his army attacked the Canaanite armies by surprise. These words are similar to the words in 10:9, and you may be able to translate them in a similar way.

and his whole army: The phrase and his whole army indicates that Joshua’s entire army was with him. In Hebrew, this is more literally “all the people of war with him”.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Joshua and his whole army caught them by surprise (NET)

So Joshua and his whole army came against them suddenly (NIV)

and attacked them: The clause and attacked them indicates that Joshua and his army attacked the enemy armies. It may be more natural in some languages to combine this clause with the clause in 11:7a, for example:

So Joshua and all his men attacked them by surprise at Merom Brook (GNT)

Joshua and his army made a surprise attack against the enemy camp at Merom Pond (CEV)

Joshua 11:8

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:8a

and the LORD delivered them into the hand of Israel,

- Yahweh gave the Canaanites to Israel, and the Israelites defeated them.
- Yahweh helped the Israelites to have victory over them.

and the LORD delivered them into the hand of Israel: The clause the LORD delivered them into the hand of Israel indicates that Yahweh helped the Israelite army defeat the Canaanites.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The Lord gave the Israelites victory over them (GNT)

The Lord helped Israel defeat the enemy (CEV)

11:8b

who struck them down and pursued them all the way to Greater Sidon and Misrephoth-maim,

- The Israelites fought them and chased them as far as Great Sidon, and Misrephoth-maim,
- The Israelites attacked them and chased them as far north as Great Sidon City and Misrephoth-maim City,

who struck them down: The word struck comes from the verb “to strike” which means “to hit.” This is an idiom for killing. The clause struck them indicates that the Israelite army killed many soldiers in the enemy army. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. For example:

The Israelites killed them

and pursued them: The clause pursued them indicates that the Israelite army chased the Canaanites as they ran away and killed the people whom they overtook.

all the way to Greater Sidon: The town of Greater Sidon was to the northwest on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. 11:8 Hess, p. 112, Map B.

and Misrephoth-maim: The location of the town of Misrephoth-maim is uncertain. It was probably north of Galilee, near Sidon, possibly near the Litani River. 11:8 Rasmussen, p. 245. Some scholars think it was on the coast near the modern border between Lebanon and Israel. 11:8 Boling and Wright, p. 308.

11:8c

and eastward as far as the Valley of Mizpeh.

- and eastward to the valley of Mizpeh.
- and then as far east as the valley of Mizpeh.

and eastward as far as the Valley of Mizpeh: The Israelite army chased them in a circular path around the borders of Galilee. They went northwest towards Greater Sidon and then south towards the town of Misrephoth-maim. Then they turned eastward to the Valley of Mizpeh.

This Valley of Mizpeh is probably the same place as the “land of Mizpah” mentioned in verse 11:3c. It is recommended that you spell this name the same way in both places.

11:8d

They struck them down, leaving no survivors.

- They kept on killing them until none of them were still alive.
- They attacked them until they were all dead.

They struck them down: The clause They struck them down indicates that the Israelite army killed the enemy soldiers. This clause is like the clause in 11:8b. It is repeated here for emphasis.

leaving no survivors: The clause leaving no survivors indicates that the Israelite army killed all the soldiers who had gathered to attack them.

It may be more natural in some languages to translate this clause as an independent sentence. For example:

None of the enemy soldiers escaped alive (CEV)

They killed them until all of them were dead

Joshua 11:9

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:9a

Joshua treated them as the LORD had told him;

- Joshua did what Yahweh told them to do.
- Then Joshua ordered his soldiers to obey Yahweh's command.

Joshua treated them: The word them refers to the Canaanite armies.

as the LORD had told him: The clause as the LORD had told him indicates that Joshua obeyed Yahweh's commands.

11:9b

he hamstrung their horses and burned up their chariots.

- They cut the hamstrings of the Canaanite horses and burned their chariots.
- He told them to cut the legs of their horses so that they couldn't walk and to burn their chariots.

he hamstrung their horses: The clause he hamstrung their horses indicates that Joshua had the tendons in the back legs of the enemy horses cut so that they could not walk. Probably Joshua ordered his soldiers to do this. He did not do it himself. It may be clearer in some languages to make this information explicit. Translate this using similar words to 11:6c.

and burned up their chariots: The clause burned up their chariots indicates that Joshua had his soldiers burn the enemy chariots. Translate this using similar words to 11:6d.

Here is another way to translate these phrases:

Joshua told his soldiers to cut the hamstrings of their horses and burn their chariots as Yahweh had commanded them

Joshua 11:10

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:10a

At that time Joshua turned back

- ¶ Then Joshua went back
- ¶ After that, Joshua went back southwards

At that time Joshua turned back: The verb phrase turned back indicates that Joshua changed directions. He and his soldiers turned south to walk to town of Hazor.

At that time: The phrase At that time indicates that Joshua and the Israelites turned back as part of the same battle as verse 9.

11:10b

and captured Hazor and put its king to the sword,

- and captured Hazor, and killed its king with the sword,
- and captured Hazor City and killed its king.

and captured Hazor: The clause and captured Hazor indicates that Joshua and his army captured the town of Hazor City. Hazor City was mentioned in 11:1.

and put its king to the sword: The clause put its king to the sword indicates that they killed the king of Hazor City. "Put to the sword" is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:32, and it is recommended that you translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

captured Hazor and killed its king (GNT)

11:10c

because Hazor was formerly the head of all these kingdoms.

- because at that time the king of Hazor City was the leader of all the Canaanite kingdoms.
- They did this because he was the leader of all the kings who fought against the Israelites.

because: The word because introduces the reason why they attacked the town of Hazor.

Hazor was formerly the head of all these kingdoms:

The word formerly indicates the viewpoint of the author of this book, who wrote at a time later than Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

at that time (GNT, NET)

up to this time (CEV)

the head of all these kingdoms: The phrase the head of all these kingdoms indicates that the king of Hazor was the leader of the kingdoms who fought against the Israelites.

Joshua 11:11

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:11a

The Israelites put everyone in Hazor to the sword, devoting them to destruction.

- The Israelites killed everybody that lived in the city with the sword, completely destroying them.
- Israel killed everyone in Hazor City and destroyed them completely.

The Israelites put everyone in Hazor to the sword:

The clause The Israelites put everyone in Hazor to the sword indicates that Joshua and his army killed every person in the town of Hazor. This is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:32. It is recommended that you translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

they put everyone there to death (GNT)

devoting them to destruction: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as devoting them to destruction indicates destroying people or things that were devoted to Yahweh and cannot be saved by any means. This is the same kind of destruction that Yahweh commanded Joshua to carry out at Jericho and Ai (6:24 and 8:8). You should translate this phrase in the same way that you translated it there.

11:11b

Nothing that breathed remained,

- Not one person still lived.
- Nobody was left alive.

Nothing that breathed remained: The clause Nothing that breathed remained indicates that every person in the town was killed. This information is repeated to emphasize it. Joshua obeyed Yahweh's command to kill all the Canaanites so that the Israelites could live in the land God had promised them.

11:11c

and Joshua burned down Hazor itself.

- Then Joshua burned Hazor.
- And he told his soldiers to burn the town of Hazor.

and Joshua burned down Hazor itself: The clause Joshua burned down Hazor itself indicates that Joshua had his soldiers burn the town of Hazor completely.

Joshua 11:12

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:12a

Joshua captured all these kings and their cities

- ¶ Joshua captured all these cities and their kings.
- ¶ Joshua took all these cities and killed their kings.

Joshua captured all these kings and their cities:

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua captured all the cities where the enemy kings had ruled (CEV)

Joshua captured: The clause Joshua captured indicates that Joshua and his soldiers defeated the kings and captured their towns. You should follow the word order that is natural in your language.

11:12b

and put them to the sword. He devoted them to destruction,

- He killed them with the sword, and completely destroyed them,
- He killed everybody in them.

and put them to the sword: The clause put them to the sword indicates that Joshua and his army killed the people in the towns and their kings. This is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:32. You should translate it in the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

putting everyone to death (GNT)

He devoted them to destruction: This is the same word as in 11:11a, and you should translate it in the same way.

11:12c
as Moses the LORD's servant had commanded.

- as Yahweh's servant Moses commanded him to do.
- He did this as Moses, the servant of Yahweh, told him.

as Moses the LORD's servant had commanded: The title that is given to Moses the LORD's servant is the same as in Joshua 1:1, and you should translate it in the same way.

had commanded: Moses commanded the Israelites to defeat and destroy all their enemies in Numbers 33:51–52 and in Deuteronomy 7:2. He did this because Yahweh commanded him to do so.

Joshua 11:13

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:13a
Yet Israel did not burn any of the cities built on their mounds,

- But the Israelites did not burn any of the cities built on mounds,
- But Joshua and the Israelites did not burn any of the cities built on small hills

Yet Israel did not burn any of the cities built on their mounds: Here is another way to translate this sentence:

But Israel burned none of the towns that stood on mounds (NRSV)

Israel: The noun Israel indicates Joshua and the Israelite army.

their mounds: Some towns were built on top of the ruins of other older towns. When this happened many times at these sites, the mounds, or small hills, were formed. Joshua did not destroy these towns.

Here is another way to translate this word:

small hills (CEV)

11:13b
except Hazor, which Joshua burned.

- except the city of Hazor, which they burned.
- except for Hazor City. Joshua ordered his army to burn that city.

except Hazor, which Joshua burned: The clause except Hazor indicates that Hazor was the only town on a mound that the Israelites captured and burned during the battle in the north.

Joshua 11:14

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:14a
The Israelites took for themselves all the plunder and livestock of these cities,

- The Israelite soldiers took all the valuable things and the animals in these cities.
- The Israelite army kept for themselves all the goods of these cities and the domestic animals,

The Israelites: The phrase The Israelites indicates the Israelite army.

took for themselves: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as took for themselves is more literally “took” or “seized.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Israelites kept the animals and everything of value from these towns (CEV)

The Israelites took for themselves all the animals and the other things from those towns

all the plunder and livestock of these cities: The phrase all the plunder and livestock of these cities refers to the things such as clothing or jewelry that a soldier might want to take. Yahweh allowed the Israelites to take these things for their own use. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as plunder is the same word as was used in 8:27.

and livestock of these cities: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as livestock can refer to other kinds of animals as well as cattle. It is recommended that you use a more general term, such as “domestic animals.” The same Hebrew word was also used in 8:27.

11:14b

but they put all the people to the sword

- But they killed all the people there with their swords.
- but they killed every single person.

they put all the people to the sword: The phrase put all the people to the sword indicates that the Israelite army killed the people. This is a Hebrew idiom that was used in 10:32, and it is recommended that you translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

they put every person to death (GNT)

all the people: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as all the people refers to both men and women.

11:14c

until they had completely destroyed them, not sparing anyone who breathed.

- They destroyed them all. They left no one alive.
- They completely destroyed all of them. No one was left alive.

until they had completely destroyed them: The clause until they had completely destroyed them indicates that the Israelite army completed the task that Yahweh had given them through Moses.

not sparing anyone who breathed: The clause not sparing anyone who breathed indicates that the army killed every single person. The Hebrew text states this information three times using different words to emphasize that the Israelites obeyed Yahweh’s command to completely destroy their enemies.

General Comment on verses 11:12–14

In each of these verses, the object comes before the subject and the verb. The Hebrew text uses this word order to emphasize the object. In some languages this order may be difficult to understand. Use the natural

grammatical or lexical means in your language to indicate this emphasis.

Joshua 11:15

Section 11:1–15 The Israelites conquered the towns of northern Canaan

King Jabin, the king of Hazor, brought together the kings of the towns in Northern Canaan to fight against Israel. With the help of Yahweh, Joshua and the Israelites fought and defeated all these towns and killed their kings and their people.

Here is another possible section heading:

Israel defeated the northern towns

11:15a

As the LORD had commanded His servant Moses,

- Yahweh commanded Moses his servant to do this,
- Yahweh told his servant Moses to kill all the people in Canaan,

As the LORD had commanded His servant Moses:

The clause As the LORD had commanded His servant Moses refers to Yahweh’s command to Moses to destroy the inhabitants of the land. Yahweh gave Moses this command in Numbers 33:51–52. Verse 11:15 emphasizes that Joshua followed these commands completely.

In some languages it may help to include some implicit information. For example:

As Yahweh had commanded his servant Moses to destroy all the inhabitants of the land

11:15b

so Moses commanded Joshua. That is what Joshua did,

- and Moses commanded Joshua to do it, and so Joshua did it.
- and Moses gave this command to Joshua, and Joshua obeyed.

so Moses commanded Joshua. That is what Joshua did:

The clause so Moses commanded Joshua. That is what Joshua did indicates that Moses told Joshua what Yahweh had commanded, and Joshua obeyed the command to destroy the people living in the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate 15a-b:

The command that Yahweh gave to Moses his servant, Moses told to Joshua, and Joshua obeyed.

Yahweh had commanded Moses his servant to kill all the people in the land. Moses gave this command to Joshua, and Joshua obeyed it.

11:15c

leaving nothing undone of all that the LORD had commanded Moses.

- Joshua did everything that Yahweh told Moses to do.
- Joshua did not fail to do anything that Yahweh commanded Moses.

leaving nothing undone of all that the LORD had commanded Moses: The phrase leaving nothing undone is a double negative. Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

he did everything that Yahweh had commanded Moses

he did not fail to do anything that Yahweh had commanded Moses

This clause repeats the information that Joshua completely obeyed Yahweh's command. It is repeated for emphasis. Use a way that is most natural to show how completely Joshua followed Yahweh's commands.

Joshua 11:16

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:16a

So Joshua took this entire region:

- ¶ Joshua conquered all that land.
- ¶ Joshua and his army captured the whole land.

So Joshua took this entire region: The clause Joshua took this entire region indicates that Joshua conquered all the towns in the regions listed in 11:16–17. The places mentioned in 11:16 are similar to the places listed in 10:40. These places were mostly in the southern part of Canaan.

The BSB translates verse 16 and part of verse 17 as one continuous sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to translate 11:16a as one sentence and to begin a new sentence with verse 11:16b. For example:

So Joshua took all that land. He took the hill country...

11:16b

the hill country, all the Negev, all the land of Goshen, the western foothills,

- Joshua conquered the hill country and the Negev and all the area around Goshen and the lower slopes of the hills,
- They captured the mountains, the Negev in southern Canaan, all the area near Goshen City, the foothills to the west,

the hill country: The hill country indicates the central mountain range that extended from Ai and Gibeon in the north to Hebron and Debir in the south. This is the same phrase as in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

all the Negev: The Negev indicates the southern wilderness area of Canaan. This term was used in 10:40 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

all the land of Goshen: Goshen refers to a town in the southern hill country of Canaan and the region around it. The exact location of Goshen is unknown. 11:16 Howard, p. 262.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the land around the town of Goshen

the western foothills: The phrase the western foothills refers to the western foothills that were between the mountains and the coastal plain. This word was used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

11:16c

the Arabah, and the mountains of Israel and their foothills,

- and the valley of the Jordan River. And so, he conquered the mountains and the hills near them.
- and the Jordan River Valley. In this way they captured the high areas and the low areas.

the Arabah: The term Arabah indicates the Jordan River Valley, which is south of the Sea of Galilee and north of the Dead Sea. 11:16 Rasmussen p. 226. This word was used in 8:14 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and the mountains of Israel and their foothills: The phrase the mountains of Israel and their foothills is a summary of the places that were mentioned previ-

ously in this verse. Translate this phrase so that the readers will understand that it does not refer to new places. It emphasizes that Joshua captured all the mountains and foothills of Israel. For example:

He Joshua controlled the mountains of Israel and all the hills near them. (NCV)

And so, Joshua conquered the highlands and lowlands of Israel.

Joshua 11:17

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:17a

from Mount Halak, which rises toward Seir,

- Joshua conquered the land from Mount Halak near Edom,
- They conquered the land from Mount Halak near the country of Edom in the south,

from Mount Halak: Mount Halak was the southernmost place that the Israelites captured. The location of Mount Halak is uncertain. It may be the modern Jebel Halaq, which is 45 kilometers southeast of Beer-sheba.11:17 Rasmussen, p. 237.

which rises toward Seir: The clause which rises toward Seir indicates that Mount Halak was near the territory of Edom, which was also called Seir. Edom was south of the Dead Sea.11:17 Bratcher and Newman, p. 166.

11:17b

as far as Baal-gad in the Valley of Lebanon at the foot of Mount Hermon.

- to Baal-gad in the valley of Lebanon, below Mount Hermon.
- and north to Baal-gad City in the Lebanon Valley at the foot Hermon Mountain.

as far as Baal-gad: Baal-gad was a town in the valley of Lebanon at the western foot of Mount Hermon.11:17 Rasmussen, p. 228. The exact location of Baal-gad is unknown. This was the northernmost place that the Israelites captured.11:17 Howard, p. 272. Some English versions spell this “Baal Gad.”

in the Valley of Lebanon at the foot of Mount Hermon: Mount Hermon was a high mountain in the northeast of Israel. The Valley of Lebanon was near Mount Hermon. It may be the modern Beqa Valley. It

may also include the valley of the Litani River further south.11:17 Hess, p. 216.

11:17c

He captured all their kings and struck them down, putting them to death.

- Joshua captured all the kings in the land and killed them.
- They caught all the kings of this territory and killed them.

He captured all their kings: The clause He captured all their kings indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army captured all the kings who ruled the towns in the regions mentioned.

and struck them down, putting them to death: The two clauses struck them down and putting them to death have the same meaning. In some languages it may be more natural to combine these two clauses into one clause.

Here is another way to translate these clauses:

Joshua ordered his soldiers to kill these kings

Joshua 11:18

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:18

Joshua waged war against all these kings for a long period of time.

- Joshua fought against them for a long time.
- The battles against these kings lasted a long time.

Joshua waged war against all these kings for a long period of time: The clause Joshua waged war against all these kings for a long period of time indicates that it took a long time for Joshua and his army to defeat the enemy kings and kill them. Some commentators believe this was about seven years.11:18 Woudstra, p. 196.

This verse adds more information to the summary statements of verses 16–17. In some languages it may be clearer to combine verses 17 and 18. For example:

Joshua was at war with the kings of this territory for a long time, but he captured them all and put them to death. (GNT)

Joshua 11:19

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:19a

No city made peace with the Israelites except the Hivites living in Gibeon;

- Not one city made a peace treaty with the Israelites except for the Hivites in Gibeon City.
- The only city that made peace with Israel was Gibeon City where the Hivites lived.

No city made peace with the Israelites: Every town in this area fought against Israel. No town (except Gibeon) tried to make peace.

the Israelites: Another term for the Israelites is “the people of Israel.”

except the Hivites living in Gibeon: In 9:7 the people who lived in the town of Gibeon were identified as Hivites. The Hivites were one of the nations who lived on the west side of the Jordan River in the land of Canaan (see 9:3).

It may be more natural in some languages to translate the clause “No city made peace with the Israelites” in positive rather than negative terms. For example:

The people of only one city in all the land had made peace with Israel (NCV)

The only city that made peace with the people of Israel was Gibeon (GNT)

11:19b

all others were taken in battle.

- The Israelites defeated all the other cities.
- The Israelites fought and defeated everyone else.

all others were taken in battle: The clause all others were taken in battle indicates that the Israelite army fought against all the other enemy nations and captured them.

Joshua 11:20

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:20a

For it was of the LORD to harden their hearts

- These things happened because Yahweh made their hearts stubborn and rebellious,
- The Israelites defeated their enemies because Yahweh caused them to be unwilling to make peace.

For: The word For indicates that the following clause contains the reason why the Israelites defeated all the towns that were named in the previous verses. Another way to translate this word is:

These things happened because

it was of the LORD: The clause it was of the LORD indicates that Yahweh caused these things to happen.

to harden their hearts: The clause harden their hearts indicates that Yahweh caused the enemy people to be stubborn and rebellious, so that they were not willing to make peace treaties with the Israelites. Like Pharaoh in Exodus 5:2, the kings of the towns decided to oppose God and his plans instead of submitting to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

These things happened because Yahweh made their hearts stubborn and rebellious

The Israelites defeated these enemies because Yahweh caused them to be unwilling to make peace

11:20b

to engage Israel in battle,

- so that they wanted to fight against the Israelites.
- Instead, they fought against Israel.

to engage Israel in battle: The clause that to engage Israel in battle indicates that the enemy nations were determined to fight against the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

so that they wanted to fight against the Israelites

Instead they fought against the Israelites

11:20c

so that they would be set apart for destruction

- The Israelites had to destroy them completely.
- God wanted the Israelites to kill them all.

so that they would be set apart for destruction: The clause so that they would be set apart for destruction

indicates that the Israelites had to kill all their enemies. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

This happened so that they would all die

11:20d

and would receive no mercy, being annihilated

- They could not be merciful. They had to kill every single person,
- They should show them no mercy but kill them all,

and would receive no mercy: The clause receive no mercy indicates that the Israelites were not to show mercy to their enemies or allow any of them to live.

being annihilated: The clause being annihilated indicates that the Israelites must destroy the Canaanites. This clause repeats the information of verse 20c using different words to emphasize how important this was. In some languages repetition may not be a natural way to show emphasis. There may be other lexical or grammatical means to indicate emphasis. Use whatever means is natural to indicate emphasis in your language.

11:20e

as the LORD had commanded Moses.

- as Yahweh commanded Moses.
- because this was what Yahweh commanded Moses to tell them to do.

as the LORD had commanded Moses: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. The clause as the LORD had commanded Moses refers to the command that Yahweh gave Moses in Deuteronomy 7:2. Yahweh commanded the Israelites to destroy the Canaanite people so that the Israelites would not be tempted to worship their gods.

Joshua 11:21

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:21a

At that time Joshua proceeded to eliminate the Anakim from the hill country

- ¶ During this time Joshua killed all the Anakites who lived in the mountains
- ¶ At this time Joshua destroyed all the Anak people who lived in the hill country.

At that time Joshua proceeded: The Hebrew verb proceeded indicates continuation of action, rather than movement. 11:21 Bratcher and Newman, p. 167. Some English versions leave this verb untranslated, for example:

Now Joshua fought... (NCV)

At that time: The phrase At that time indicates an indefinite time. It is close to the same time that Joshua and his army finished fighting the other enemy soldiers.

Some other ways to translate this phrase are:

During this period (NLT)

At this time (GNT)

to eliminate: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as to eliminate indicates that Joshua and his army killed all the Anakim.

the Anakim: The Anakim were a group of people who were descendants of Anak. The descendants of Anak were first referred to in Numbers 13:22–33. At that time the Israelites were afraid of the Anakim and refused to enter the promised land. They did not trust Yahweh, and so they had to walk through the wilderness for forty years. Now the Israelites killed the Anakim.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

descendants of Anak (NLT)

people of Anak (GW)

Anakites (NIV, NET)

from the hill country: The term hill country indicates the central mountain range of the land of Israel. This is the same phrase used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way that you did there.

11:21b

of Hebron, Debir, and Anab,

- in the area of Hebron, Debir, and Anab,
- They lived in Hebron City, Debir City, and Anab Village,

of Hebron: Joshua destroyed the town of Hebron in 10:36–37. Hebron was in the hill country of Judah, 32 kilometers southwest of Jerusalem. 11:21 Rasmussen, p. 238.

Debir: Joshua destroyed the town of Debir in 10:38–39. Debir was 14 kilometers southwest of Hebron, in the hill country of Judah.11:21 Rasmussen, p. 232.

and Anab: Anab was a village in the hill country of Judah. Anab was 19 kilometers southwest of Hebron.11:21 Rasmussen, p. 226.

11:21c

and from all the hill country of Judah and of Israel.

- and in the mountains of Judah and the mountains of Israel.
- and in the hill country of Judah and Israel.

and from all the hill country of Judah: The hill country of Judah indicates the central mountain range in the southern part of the land of Israel.

and of Israel: The and of Israel indicates the mountains in the northern part of the country.

It may be clearer to combine these two phrases into one. For example:

from all the hill country of Judah and Israel

11:21d

Joshua devoted them to destruction, along with their cities.

- Joshua completely destroyed them and their cities.
- Joshua killed them all and destroyed their cities.

Joshua devoted them to destruction, along with their cities: The phrase with their cities indicates that Joshua destroyed the Anakim people, and also the towns in which they lived.

Joshua 11:22

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:22a

No Anakim were left in the land of the Israelites;

- There were no Anakites left living in the land of the Israelites,
- None of the Anak people were left in the land of Israel.

No Anakim were left in the land of the Israelites: The clause No Anakim were left in the land of the Israelites repeats the information of verse 21 in different words, to emphasize its importance.

the land of the Israelites: The phrase the land of the Israelites indicates the entire country of the Israelites.

It includes both the southern part, which was called Judah in verse 21, and the northern part, which was called Israel.

11:22b

only in Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod did any survive.

- but there were a few left in Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod.
- However, some still remained in the towns of Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod which Israel did not capture.

only in Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod: The towns of Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod were in the territory of the Philistines. They were in southwestern Canaan, on the Mediterranean Sea.11:22 Howard, p. 275.

did any survive: The clause did any survive indicates that some Anakim still lived in the towns of Gaza, Gath and Ashdod. The Israelites did not capture these towns.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

However, there were still some Anakim who lived in Gaza, Gath, and Ashdod.

Joshua 11:23

Section 11:16–23 The towns that the Israelites conquered

In this section there is a summary of the towns that the Israelites conquered in the land of Canaan.

11:23a

So Joshua took the entire land,

- ¶ So Joshua conquered of all the land
- ¶ In this way, Joshua and the Israelite people took control of the entire land of Israel.

So Joshua took the entire land: The clause Joshua took the entire land indicates that Joshua and the Israelite army conquered the whole land of Canaan. This verse is the conclusion to the first section of the book of Joshua. Chapter 12 contains a list of conquered kings and territories and forms a kind of appendix to chapter 11.11:23 Howard, p. 275.

11:23b

in keeping with all that the LORD had spoken to Moses.

- as Yahweh told Moses to do long ago.
- This was what Yahweh instructed Moses long ago.

in keeping with all that the LORD had spoken to Moses: The phrase in keeping with all that the LORD had spoken to Moses indicates that Joshua followed every command that Yahweh gave to Moses. Yahweh

told Moses to drive out all the other nations from the land of Canaan.

11:23c

And Joshua gave it as an inheritance to Israel according to the allotments to their tribes.

- Then Joshua divided up the land and gave a part to each of the clans of Israel.
- And Joshua gave it to the people of Israel, giving a part to each clan.

And Joshua gave it as an inheritance to Israel: The clause Joshua gave it as an inheritance to Israel indicates that Joshua divided up the land for each tribe of Israel to live in. Each of the twelve tribes of Israel got a certain part of the land.

inheritance: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as inheritance is more literally “property.” Yahweh gave land to each tribe for that tribe to own. Each family could pass this land on to their children and grandchildren.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

a possession (GW)

a gift (NLV)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this term as a clause. For example:

The Lord gave that land to Israel as he promised (ERV)

Joshua gave it to the Israelites as their own (GNT)

according to the allotments to their tribes: The phrase according to the allotments to their tribes indicates that Joshua divided the land into sections and each tribe received one section of the land for their people to live in.

11:23d

Then the land had rest from war.

- And there was peace in the land.
- So, there was no more fighting in the land.

Then the land had rest from war: The clause the land had rest from war indicates that the Israelite army no longer fought. The soldiers could rest. The countryside was peaceful and no longer destroyed by battles.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then there was peace in the land

Then there was no war in the land

Joshua 12:1

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:1a

Now these are the kings of the land

- ¶ These are the kings of the land
- ¶ These are the names of the two kings

Now: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Now introduces a list of two kings that the Israelites defeated. Many English versions do not translate this word. Use a word that is appropriate to introduce a list in your language.

these are the kings: In some languages it may be more natural to say that these are the names of the kings.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

These are the names of the kings (REB)

of the land: The phrase the land indicates the land east of the Jordan River. This is not stated until 12:1c. It may be more natural in some languages to reorder this verse. A way to reorder the verse is found at the end of the notes for this verse.

12:1b

whom the Israelites struck down

- whom the Israelite soldiers defeated
- whom the Israelites defeated before they crossed the Jordan River.

whom the Israelites struck down: The Israelites defeated these kings at an earlier time, before they crossed the Jordan River. This story is found in Num-

bers 21:21–35. It may be helpful to express this implicit information.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The people of Israel had defeated these kings
before they crossed the Jordan River

Israelites: The word Israelites indicates the Israelite army.

12:1c

and whose lands they took beyond the Jordan to the east,

- and whose territory the Israelites took east of the Jordan River.
- The Israelites captured their land east of the Jordan River.

and whose lands they took: The clause whose lands they took indicates that after the Israelites defeated the kings and their armies, they occupied their land and controlled it.

beyond the Jordan to the east: The phrase beyond the Jordan to the east indicates that the land was on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:1d

from the Arnon Valley to Mount Hermon, including all the Arabah eastward:

- Their land went from the valley of the Arnon River to Mount Hermon, including all the eastern side of the Jordan River.
- These kings ruled the land from the Arnon River gorge in the south, to Mount Hermon in the north. They ruled all the land on the east side of the Jordan River.

from the Arnon Valley to Mount Hermon: The Arnon Valley and Mount Hermon were at the south and the north of the area that the Israelites conquered east of the Jordan River.

the Arnon Valley: The Arnon River flows through a deep Valley that is dry during part of the year. It runs into the Dead Sea. Its valley is halfway between the southern and northern ends of the Dead Sea. This was the southern limit of the land that the Israelites conquered on the east side of the Jordan River. 12:1 Bratcher and Newman, p. 170.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the valley of the Arnon River

Valley: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Valley refers to a riverbed that has water in it only during the rainy season. This kind of riverbed is sometimes referred to by its Arabic term, wadi.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

gorge (NLT, NIV)

ravine (NCV)

wadi (NRSV, REB, NJPS)

Use the word in your language that best fits this context.

Mount Hermon: Mount Hermon is west of Damascus. It was the northern limit of the land that the Israelites conquered on the east side of the Jordan River.

including all the Arabah eastward: The Arabah is the valley of the Jordan River. The land that the Israelites conquered included all the Jordan River valley and the land to the east of it.

General Comment on 12:1

Here are some other ways to translate verse 1. These examples have partially reordered the parts of the verse. They have also broken the verse into two sentences.

These are the kings of the land east of the Jordan River that the people of Israel defeated. Israel also took possession of their land from the Arnon Valley to Mount Hermon, and all the eastern plains. (GW)

Before Moses died, he and the Israelites had defeated two kings east of the Jordan River. These kings had ruled the region from the Arnon River Gorge in the south to Mount Hermon in the north, including the eastern side of the Jordan River Valley. (CEV)

General Comment on 12:1–5

In the Hebrew text these verses are one long sentence, and the BSB translates them this way. It is recommended that you translate these verses as several sentences. Use the sentence breaks that are most natural in your language. There are some examples of how to do this the end of each verse.

Joshua 12:2

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:2a

Sihon king of the Amorites, who lived in Heshbon.

- Sihon was the Amorite king who lived in Heshbon.
- The first king that the Israelites defeated was King Sihon of the Amor people. He lived in Heshbon City.

Verses 12:2–3 give a detailed description of the territory that King Sihon ruled. Verse 2 describes the eastern part of his territory starting from its south end. Verse 3 describes the western part of his territory that was in the Jordan River valley.

Sihon king of the Amorites: The story of how Moses and the Israelites conquered Sihon king of the Amorites is in Numbers 21:21–35.

the Amorites: The word Amorites refers to a group of people who lived on the east side of the Jordan River. This word was used in 3:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

who lived in Heshbon: King Sihon lived in Heshbon, which was the capital town of the Amorites. Heshbon was about 25 kilometers northeast of the Dead Sea. 12:2 Bratcher and Newman, p. 171.

12:2b

He ruled from Aroer on the rim of the Arnon Valley,

- His kingdom went from Aroer, on the edge of the Arnon River valley,
- His territory started at Aroer City in the south. Aroer City was on the edge of the Arnon River gorge.

He ruled from Aroer: The town of Aroer was beside the Arnon River. King Sihon's territory started at Aroer in the south and went north from there.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

King Sihon's territory started at the town of Aroer

on the rim of the Arnon Valley: The clause on the rim of the Arnon Valley indicates that the town of Aroer was on the bank of the Arnon River. The Arnon River runs into the Dead Sea.

12:2c

along the middle of the valley, up to the Jabbok River (the border of the Ammonites),

- from the middle of this valley to the Jabbok River, which is the border of Ammonites.
- It went north from the middle of the Arnon River gorge to the Jabbok River. The Jabbok River starts the territory of the Ammon people.

along the middle of the valley: The words the valley refers to the Arnon River valley. There is an interpretation issue here.

1. The Hebrew text reads “and the middle of the valley.” For example:

from the middle of the gorge (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, GW, CEV, NLT, NABRE, KJV)

1. Some English versions say “from the town in the middle of the valley.” They add the word “town” because of Joshua 13:9 and 16 which describe the same place. For example:

including the city in the middle of the valley (NET) (NET, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and translate the middle of the valley as in the BSB. This follows the Hebrew text.

up to the Jabbok River: The phrase up to the Jabbok River indicates that the Jabbok River was the northern boundary of King Sihon's territory. It was also that beginning of Ammonite territory.

the border of the Ammonites: The phrase the border of the Ammonites indicates that the Jabbok River formed the boundary between the territory of King Sihon and the territory of the Ammonites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

all the way to the Jabbok Valley bordering Ammonite territory (NET)

to the Jabbok River, which is the border of the Ammonites (NIV)

the Ammonites: The term Ammonites indicates a group of people who lived in the country of Ammon. Ammon was a region or an area, not a town.

12:2d
that is, half of Gilead,

- This was half of the region of Gilead.
- This territory of King Sihon was the southern half of the Gilead area.

that is, half of Gilead: The clause half of Gilead indicates that the territory which King Sihon ruled was half of the region of Gilead.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This included half of Gilead (NIV)

This territory included the southern half of the territory of Gilead (NLT)

Gilead: The term Gilead indicates the mountainous region north of the Dead Sea. The Gilead Region stretched from the east of the Jordan River to the desert. 12:2 Rasmussen, p. 236.

General Comment on 12:2

Here is another way to translate 12:2. This example has divided the verse into three sentences.

King Sihon of the Amorites, who lived in Heshbon, was defeated. His kingdom included Aroer, on the edge of the Arnon Gorge, and extended from the middle of the Arnon Gorge to the Jabbok River, which serves as a border for the Ammonites. This territory included the southern half of the territory of Gilead. (NLT)

Joshua 12:3

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:3a as well as the Arabah east of the Sea of Chinnereth

- It included the land east of the Jordan River valley, from Lake Galilee,
- King Sihon's territory included the valley of the Jordan River and the land east of it, from Lake Galilee in the north

Verse 12:3 continues the description of King Sihon's territory. It describes the territory that he ruled in the valley of the Jordan River, starting from its north end. It may be clearer to start a new sentence here.

as well as the Arabah: The Arabah is the valley of the Jordan River.

east of the Sea of Chinnereth: The Sea of Chinnereth is another name for the Sea of Galilee. In the Jordan River valley, the territory of King Sihon extended north beyond the Jabbok River to the Sea of Galilee.

east of: The phrase east of indicates that King Sihon's territory was east of the Jordan River. It extended eastward from the Jordan River to the desert.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

King Sihon's territory included the east side of the Jordan River valley to the Sea of Galilee in the north

12:3b to the Sea of the Arabah (the Salt Sea),

- and the Dead Sea,
- to the Dead Sea,

to the Sea of the Arabah: The Sea of the Arabah is another name for the Dead Sea.

the Salt Sea: The Salt Sea is another name for the Dead Sea. The Dead Sea is referred to by two different names in this verse. See how you translated this phrase in Joshua 3:16.

12:3c eastward through Beth-jeshimoth,

- to Beth-jeshimoth,
- and went south to Beth-jeshimoth City,

through Beth-jeshimoth: Beth-jeshimoth is a town referred to in Numbers 33:49. It was the last place that the Israelites camped before crossing the Jordan River into Canaan. It is beside the Jordan River, at the northeast tip of the Dead Sea. 12:3 Rasmussen, p. 229.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and his territory went south to the town of Beth-jeshimoth

Some English versions spell this name as two separate words:

Beth Jeshimoth (NIV, NET, GNT)

12:3d

and southward below the slopes of Pisgah.

- and on to the slopes of Mount Pisgah in the south.
- and on south to the foot of Pisgah Mountain.

southward below the slopes of Pisgah: Mount Pisgah was the southern boundary of King Sihon's territory. The exact location of Mount Pisgah is uncertain, but it is probably at the north end of the Dead Sea.12:3 Rasmussen, p. 248.

General Comment on 12:3

Here is another way to translate 12:3. This example includes some connecting words to make the meaning clear.

Sihon also controlled the Jordan Valley and regions to the east—from as far north as the Sea of Galilee to as far south as the Dead Sea, including the road to Beth-jeshimoth and southward to the slopes of Pisgah. (NLT)

Joshua 12:4

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:4a

And Og king of Bashan,

- Og king of Bashan
- The second king that the Israelites defeated was King Og, king of Bashan Country,

And Og king of Bashan: King Og was the second king that the Israelites defeated. The story of how Moses

and the Israelites defeated Og king of Bashan is found in Numbers 21:33–35.

Bashan is a country northeast of the Sea of Galilee. This country appeared in Joshua 9:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Verse 4 is part of the long Hebrew sentence that begins at 12:1. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They also defeated King Og of Bashan (GNT)

Next, Moses and the Israelites defeated King Og of Bashan (CEV)

12:4b

one of the remnant of the Rephaim,

- was among the last group of the Rephaim.
- He was one of the last of the Repha people.

one of the remnant of the Rephaim: The word one introduces a relative clause. Use the relative clause marker that is most natural in your language. It is also possible to translate this relative clause as an independent sentence.

Here are some other ways to translate this relative clause:

who was one of the remnant of the Rephaim

King Og was one of the last of the Repha people

remnant: The word remnant indicates that only a few of the Rephaim were still alive.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

one of the few remaining Rephaites (NET)

one of the last of the Rephaites (NIV)

among the last group of the Repha people

the Rephaim: The term Rephaim indicates a group of people who lived in the land of Canaan before the Israelites. They are mentioned in Deuteronomy 2:10–11, where it is said that they are strong and tall.

Here are some other ways to translate this name:

Rephaites (NIV, NCV, NLT, NET)

Repha people

12:4c who lived in Ashtaroth and Edrei.

- He lived in Ashtaroth and Edre-i.
- He lived at Ashtaroth City and Edre-i City.

who lived in Ashtaroth: The town of Ashtaroth was the capital town of King Og. Ashtaroth was twenty-two miles east of the Sea of Galilee.

and Edrei: King Og also had a residence in the town of Edrei. Edrei was sixty miles south of Damascus.12:4 Rasmussen, p. 233. The king was living there when the Israelites defeated him.

Here is another way to spell the name of Edrei:

Edre-i (RSV)

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

Og king of Bashan was one of the last of the Rephaites. He ruled the land in Ashtaroth and Edrei (NCV)

They also defeated King Og of Bashan, who was one of the last of the Rephaim; he ruled at Ashtaroth and Edrei. (GNT)

Joshua 12:5

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:5a He ruled over Mount Hermon, Salecah,

- He ruled the territory that went from Mount Hermon and Salecah City in the north

- His kingdom went north to Mount Hermon, and east to Salecah City,

He ruled over Mount Hermon, Salecah: Mount Hermon is a high mountain that was the northern limit of Joshua's conquests. It formed the northwest end of King Og's kingdom.

Salecah: The town of Salecah was on the eastern boundary of the territory of Bashan. It was southeast of the Sea of Galilee.12:5 Rasmussen, p. 250.

Here are some ways to translate this part of the verse:

He ruled a territory stretching from Mount Hermon and Salecah in the north (NLT)

His kingdom stretched north to Mount Hermon, east to the town of Salecah, (CEV)

12:5b all of Bashan up to the border of the Geshurites and Maacathites,

- and all of Bashan to where the Geshurites and the Maacathites lived.
- and included the land of Bashan as far west as the land of the Geshur people and the Maacah people.

all of Bashan up to the border of the Geshurites: The term Geshurites can also be translated "Geshur people." They were a small group who lived northeast of the Sea of Galilee. Joshua and the Israelites were not able to conquer them.12:5 Rasmussen, p. 236.

and Maacathites: The term Maacathites can also be translated "Maacah people." This was a small kingdom in modern Syria whose people continued to live in their land. Joshua and the Israelites failed to drive them out.12:5 Rasmussen, p. 243.

12:5c and half of Gilead to the border of Sihon king of Heshbon.

- He ruled half the land of Gilead up to the border of Sihon king of Heshbon.
- His territory included the northern half of Gilead, as far as the boundary of King Sihon of Heshbon.

and half of Gilead: King Og ruled over the northern half of Gilead. King Sihon ruled over the southern half of Gilead. You should translate the word Gilead the same way you did in 12:2d.

to the border of Sihon king of Heshbon: King Og's territory extended south to the area that King Sihon ruled.

Joshua 12:6

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:1–6

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side of the Jordan River.

12:6a

Moses, the servant of the LORD, and the Israelites had struck them down

- Moses the servant of Yahweh and the Israelites destroyed the people of King Sihon and King Og
- These were the people that Moses, Yahweh's servant, and the people of Israel defeated.

Verse 6 is a summary of how Moses and the Israelite army conquered the land east of the Jordan River and divided it among Reuben, Gad and half of Manasseh.

Moses, the servant of the LORD: You should translate the phrase the servant of the LORD the same way you did in Joshua 1:1.

and the Israelites: The word Israelites indicates the Israelite army.

had struck them down: The pronoun them refers to King Sihon and King Og. It may be helpful to make this reference explicit. For example:

Moses, the servant of the Lord, had destroyed the people of King Sihon and King Og. (NLT)

12:6b

and given their land as an inheritance

- and gave away all their land
- He gave their land

In the Hebrew text, the phrase “Moses, the servant of the LORD” is repeated here to emphasize the status of Moses as the one who led the Israelites out of Egypt. In some languages, it may be natural to repeat this phrase, as the Hebrew text does.

and given their land as an inheritance: The clause given their land as an inheritance indicates that Moses divided the land on the east side of the Jordan

River between the two and a half tribes, who became the owners of it.

12:6c

to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.

- to the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh for them to own.
- to the clans of Reuben and Gad and East Manasseh as their own.

to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh:

The phrase the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh indicates the descendants of Reuben, the descendants of Gad, and the descendants of Makir, who was a son of Manasseh. The people of Reuben and Gad asked to settle east of the Jordan River because it was good land for shepherding herds and flocks. This story is told in Numbers 32:1–5. The descendants of Makir, from the tribe of Manasseh, conquered the land of Gilead and settled there in Numbers 32:39–40).

the half-tribe of Manasseh: Some English versions translate this as East Manasseh, because these people lived on the east side of the Jordan River.

Joshua 12:7

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:7a

And these are the kings of the land that Joshua and the Israelites conquered beyond the Jordan to the west,

- ¶ This is a list of the kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated west of the Jordan River,
- ¶ Joshua and the Israelite army also defeated the kings on the west side of the Jordan River.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the narrative. Some English versions do not translate this word.

these are the kings of the land: The clause these are the kings of the land introduces the list of kings whom Joshua and the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River. However, the actual list does not start until verse 9.

that Joshua and the Israelites conquered beyond the Jordan to the west: Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Joshua and the people of Israel defeated all the kings in the territory west of the Jordan (GNT)

Joshua and the Israelites also defeated kings in the land west of the Jordan River. (NCV)

The following is a list of the kings that Joshua and the Israelite armies defeated on the west side of the Jordan (NLT)

12:7b

from Baal-gad in the Valley of Lebanon to Mount Halak, which rises toward Seir

- from Baal-gad in the valley of Lebanon to Mount Halak which is near Seir.
- This land went from Baal-gad in the Lebanon Valley in the north, to Halak Mountain near Edom in the south.

from Baal-gad in the Valley of Lebanon: The term Baal-gad indicates a town in the valley of Lebanon at the western foot of Mount Hermon.12:7 Rasmussen, p. 228. The exact location of Baal-gad is unknown, but it was the northern point of Joshua's conquests.12:7 Howard, p. 272.

Some English versions spell this name as two words:

Baal Gad (NIV, NET, GW)

the Valley of Lebanon: The Valley of Lebanon was near Mount Hermon. It may be the modern Beqa Valley. It may also include the valley of the Litani River further south.12:7 Hess, p. 216. This term occurred in 11:17 and you should translate it the same way as you did there.

to Mount Halak, which rises toward Seir: The term Mount Halak indicates a mountain that marked the southern point of the Israelites' conquests. Its location is uncertain, but it may be Jebel Halaq, 28 miles southeast of Beersheba.12:7 Rasmussen, p. 237.

rises toward Seir: Seir is another word for the territory of Edom, which was south of the Dead Sea. The clause rises toward Seir indicates that Mount Halak was near the territory of Edom.12:7 Bratcher and Newman, p. 166.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Mount Halak near the country of Edom (CEV)

General Comment on 12:7b

Verse 12:7b describes the land by naming its northern and southern points. In 12:8a-b the same land is described by naming its geographical regions. 12:8c describes this land again by naming the Canaanite peoples who lived there.

12:7c

(according to the allotments to the tribes of Israel, Joshua gave them as an inheritance

- Joshua gave this land to the clans of Israel for them to own, giving some to each clan,
- Joshua divided this land among the clans and gave it to them as their own.

according to the allotments to the tribes of Israel, Joshua gave them as an inheritance: The BSB puts verse 12:7d-12:8c in parentheses. Most English versions do not use parentheses here.

according to the allotments to the tribes of Israel: Here is another way to translate this phrase:

according to their tribal divisions (NIV)

Joshua gave them as an inheritance: These words are like the words in 12:6 and you should translate them in the same way. Joshua gave land to each of the ten- and one-half tribes of Israel who settled on the west side of the Jordan River. These tribes became owners of that land.

Joshua 12:8

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:8a**the hill country, the foothills, the Arabah,**

- including the mountains, the lowlands to the west, the Jordan Valley,
- This land included the central mountains, the western foothills of the central mountains, the valley of the Jordan River,

Verse 12:8a-b lists all the geographical areas of Israel on the west side of the Jordan River.

the hill country: The phrase the hill country indicates the central mountain range on the west side of the Jordan River. This word was used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

the foothills: The phrase the foothills refers to the western side of the central mountain range, between the mountains and the coastal plain. This word was used in 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

the Arabah: The term Arabah refers to the valley of the Jordan River. This word was used in 8:14 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

12:8b**the slopes, the wilderness, and the Negev—**

- the mountain slopes, the Judean wilderness, and the Negev.
- the eastern slopes of the central mountains, the desert of Judea, and the desert in southern Canaan.

the slopes: The phrase the slopes refers to the steep slopes that go down from the hill country eastward to the Dead Sea. This word was used in 10:40 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

the wilderness: The term wilderness indicates the wilderness of Judah. This is a deserted area that lies between the Judean hill country and the Dead Sea. 12:8 Aharoni, p. 41.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Judean wilderness (NLT)

and the Negev: The word Negev indicates the southern wilderness area. This word was used in 10:40 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

General Comment on 12:7b–8c

Verse 12:7b described the land of Israel by naming its northern and southern points. In 12:8a-b the same land

is described again by naming its geographical regions. 12:8c describes this land a third time by naming the Canaanite peoples who lived there.

12:8c**the lands of the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites):**

- This is the land that belonged to the Heth people, the Amor people, the Canaan people, the Periz people, the Hiv people, and the Jebus people.
- This was the land where the Hitti people, the Amor people, the Canaan people, the Periz people, the Hiv people, and the Yabus people used to live.

the lands of the Hittites, Amorites, Canaanites, Perizzites, Hivites, and Jebusites: These are names of peoples who lived in the land of Israel before the Israelites conquered the land. These names occurred in 3:10, but in a different order.

Here is another way to translate this list of peoples:

The people who lived in this region were the Hittites, the Amorites, the Canaanites, the Perizzites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites. These are the kings Israel defeated: (NLT)

General Comment on 12:9–24

Verses 12:9–24 is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated. The BSB translates the words literally according to the Hebrew text. In some languages this may not be natural.

You should translate this list in a way that your language naturally arranges a list. It may be clearer to begin the list with an introduction stating that these are the kings the Israelites defeated. This information was in verse 12:7a and the readers may not make the connection. You can include this introduction at the end of verse 8, as NLT and NCV have done, or at the beginning of verse 9, as GNT has done.

These notes on verses 9–24 include only issues which need explanation.

Joshua 12:9**Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated**

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:9

the king of Jericho, one; the king of Ai, which is near Bethel, one;

- These are the kings they defeated: the king of Jericho, the king of Ai near Bethel,
- The people of Israel defeated the kings of the following cities: Jericho City, Ai City (near Bethel City),

the king of Jericho, one: The word one indicates that there was one king of Jericho. This is a literal translation of the Hebrew word. Most English versions do not include the word one. You should translate this list in a way that your language naturally arranges a list.

the king of Ai, which is near Bethel, one: The phrase near Bethel indicates that the town of Ai was near the town of Bethel.

Here are two different ways to translate verses 9–24:

9 The people of Israel defeated the kings of the following cities: Jericho, Ai (near Bethel), **10** Jerusalem, Hebron, **11** Jarmuth, Lachish, **12** Eglon, Gezer, **13** Debir, Geder, **14** Hormah, Arad, **15** Libnah, Adullam, **16** Makkedah, Bethel, **17** Tappuah, Hephher, **18** Aphek, Lasharon, **19** Madon, Hazor, **20** Shimron Meron, Achshaph, **21** Taanach, Megiddo, **22** Kedesh, Jokneam (in Carmel), **23** Dor (on the coast), Goiim (in Galilee), **24** and Tirzah—thirty-one kings in all. (GNT)

9 The king of Jericho

The king of Ai, near Bethel

10 The king of Jerusalem

The king of Hebron

11 The king of Jarmuth

The king of Lachish

12 The king of Eglon

The king of Gezer

13 The king of Debir

The king of Geder

14 The king of Hormah

The king of Arad

15 The king of Libnah

The king of Adullam

16 The king of Makkedah

The king of Bethel

17 The king of Tappuah

The king of Hephher

18 The king of Aphek

The king of Lasharon

19 The king of Madon

The king of Hazor

20 The king of Shimron-meron

The king of Achshaph

21 The king of Taanach

The king of Megiddo

22 The king of Kedesh

The king of Jokneam in Carmel

23 The king of Dor in the town of Naphoth-dor

The king of Goyim in Gilgal

24 The king of Tirzah.

In all, thirty-one kings were defeated. (NLT)

Joshua 12:22

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:22

the king of Kedesh, one; the king of Jokneam in Carmel, one;

- the king of Kedesh, the king of Jokneam in Carmel,
- Kedesh City, Jokneam City near Carmel Mountain,

Jokneam in Carmel: The phrase in Carmel indicates that the town of Jokneam mentioned here was at the northern border of the territory of the tribe of Manasseh, near Mount Carmel. There was another town named Jokneam that was in the territory of the tribe of Ephraim. 12:22 Boling and Wright, p. 329.

Here is another way to translate this name:

Jokneam on Mount Carmel (CEV)

Joshua 12:23

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:23

the king of Dor in Naphath-dor, one; the king of Goim in Gilgal, one;

- the king of Dor City in Naphath-dor, the king of Goim in Galilee,
- Dor City in Naphath-dor, Goim City (in the Galilee Region),

Dor in Naphath-dor: The town of Dor was a seaport on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea south of Carmel. It is not clear what the Hebrew word “Naphath” refers to. This word appeared in 11:2 in a similar context. It is recommended that you translate this place name in agreement with the major language version in your area.

English versions differ in how they translate the word Naphath-dor. Here are some other ways to translate the name of this town:

Dor – near Naphath Dor (NET)

Dor (in Naphath Dor) (NIV)

Dor in the heights of Dor (NASB)

Dor in the district of Dor (NJPS)

Dor (on the coast) (GNT)

Dor in the coast of Dor (KJV)

the king of Goim: The Hebrew word that the BSB transliterates as Goim means “nations.” For example:

the king of the nations in Galilee (NJB)

Most English versions transliterate this word, as the BSB does. It is recommended that you transliterate it as the BSB does.

in Gilgal: There is a textual issue with the term Gilgal.

1. The ancient Greek translation, the Septuagint, has the name Galilee. (RSV, ESV, NJB, REB, GNT, CEV)
2. The Hebrew text has the name Gilgal. (BSB, NIV, NET, NCV, NJPS, NLT, GW, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and translate this word as “Galilee” or “Galilee Region.”

There is no evidence that there was a place called Gilgal in this area.12:23 Hess, p. 228; Woudstra, p. 206.

Joshua 12:24

Section 12:1–24 The kings that Joshua and the Israelites defeated

In this section there is a list of the kings that the Israelites defeated on the east side and the west side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The kings that the Israelites defeated on both sides of the Jordan River

Paragraph 12:7–24

The kings that the Israelites defeated on the west side of the Jordan River.

12:24a

and the king of Tirzah, one.

- and the king of Tirzah.
- and Tirzah City.

12:24b

So there were thirty-one kings in all.

- In total they defeated thirty-one kings.
- They defeated the kings of thirty-one (31) cities.

12:24

So there were thirty-one kings in all: The kings listed in verses 9–24a come to a total of thirty-one kings.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

In total they defeated thirty-one kings

They defeated the kings of thirty-one (31) towns

Joshua 13:1

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:1a

Now Joshua was old and well along in years,

- ¶ Joshua was very old,
- ¶ Joshua was old and had lived for many years.

Now: The word Now indicates that a new section of the narrative is beginning in this verse. It does not refer to a specific time.

Here are some other ways to translate this connection:

When Joshua was very old (NCV)

Many years later (CEV)

There may be a particle or grammatical marker in your language to indicate that a significant time had passed between the events of the previous chapter and chapter 13.

Joshua was old and well along in years: The Hebrew idiom that the BSB translates as well along in years is more literally “he had come in days.” This idiom means that Joshua was very old. If there is an idiom for great age in your language, you can use it. Or you can say:

Joshua was very old

13:1b

and the LORD said to him,

- and Yahweh said to him:
- Then Yahweh told him:

and the LORD said to him: The clause the LORD said to him may be restructured according to how you have translated the first part of verse one. For example:

When Joshua was very old, the Lord said to him (NCV)

Joshua was old, near the end of his life. So the Lord said to him (GW)

13:1c

“You are old and well along in years,

- “You are very old,
- “You are old and have lived for many years.

You are old and well along in years: The clause You are old and well along in years contains the same words as 13:1a. It indicates that Joshua was very old. If it is not natural to restate this information, it maybe left implicit in the first part of the verse, for example,

Many years later, the Lord told Joshua, “Now you are very old,” (CEV)

13:1d
but very much of the land remains to be possessed.

- and there is still much land left to be conquered.
- There is a lot of land left for you to take.

but: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence rather than use the conjunction but.

very much of the land remains to be possessed: The clause very much of the land remains to be possessed indicates that there was still a lot of land that the Israelites had not conquered. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause in an active voice, for example:

There is still much land for you to take (NCV)

There is still a lot of land that the Israelites must conquer

Joshua 13:2

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:2–6

These verses are a list of all the towns and regions that the Israelites had not yet conquered. Use a format that is appropriate to list place names in your language. Verse 2a introduces the list.

13:2a

This is the land that remains:

- These are the places that you still must conquer:
- This is the territory that remains for you to take:

This is the land that remains: The phrase the land that remains indicates the places in Canaan that Israel has not yet conquered. It may be helpful to include some implicit information. For example:

This is the land that has not yet been conquered

13:2b

All the territory of the Philistines and the Geshurites,

- all the land where the Philistines and the Geshurites live.
- all the districts that belong to the Filisti people and the Geshur people.

All the territory of the Philistines: The territory of the Philistines were on the coastal plain of the Mediterranean Sea in the southwestern part of Canaan.

Philistines: The Philistines indicates a group of people who lived in several large towns near the Mediterranean Sea.

Here is another way to translate this word:

Filisti people

The Philistines are mentioned several times in Genesis. If you have already translated Genesis, you should translate this name the same way you did there. See, for example, Genesis 10:14.

and the Geshurites: The phrase the Geshurites indicates the land where the Geshur people lived. The Geshur people were mentioned in Joshua 12:5 and you should translate the term the same way in both places.

Joshua 13:3

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:3a-d

The BSB adds parentheses around part of this section to make it clear that this is a description of the “territory of the Philistines and the Geshurites.” These parentheses are not in the Hebrew text. You may find that parentheses are helpful, or there may be some other way to connect verses 3a-d to verse 2.

13:3a**from the Shihor east of Egypt to the territory of Ekron on the north**

- Their land extends from the Shihor Canal which is east of Egypt, and north as far as the border of Ekron,
- That area goes south to the Shihor Canal at the east border of Egypt, and it goes north to Ekron City.

from the Shihor east of Egypt: The term Shihor indicates a canal of the Nile River in the eastern delta of Egypt, near the present-day Suez Canal. The Shihor Canal was on the east side of Egypt, and it was the south boundary of the Philistine and Geshurite region.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The Philistine and Geshurite region goes south to the Shihor Canal which is east of Egypt

to the territory of Ekron on the north: The phrase to the territory of Ekron on the north indicates that Ekron was the north boundary of the Philistine and Geshurite region. Ekron was a town of the Philistine people and is mentioned in 13:3d.

13:3b**(considered to be Canaanite territory)—**

- which is considered to be Canaanite territory.
- All that area formerly belonged to the Canaan people.

considered to be Canaanite territory: The clause considered to be Canaanite territory indicates that Ekron was considered to be part of Canaan because the Philistines took it from the original Canaanite settlers. 13:3 Woudstra, p. 210.

13:3c**that of the five Philistine rulers**

- There are five Philistine rulers,
- There are five kings of Filisti people who rule in these five cities:

that of the five Philistine rulers: The clause that of the five Philistine rulers indicates that each Philistine town had its own ruler. The towns are listed in the next part of the verse.

13:3d**of Gaza, Ashdod, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron,**

- of Gaza, Ashdod, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron.
- Gaza City, Ashdod City, Ashkelon City, Gath City, and Ekron City.

of Gaza: The name Gaza refers to a Philistine town in southwest Canaan, near the Mediterranean Sea.

Ashdod: The name Ashdod indicates a Philistine town 22 miles south of Joppa on the Mediterranean Sea.

Ashkelon: The name Ashkelon indicates a Philistine town on the Mediterranean Sea 32 miles south of Joppa.

Gath: The name Gath indicates a Philistine town 25 miles southeast of the town of Joppa. In later times King David fought against Goliath, who came from Gath.

and Ekron: The name Ekron indicates a Philistine town 20 miles southeast of Joppa.

13:3e**as well as that of the Avvites;**

- There is also the land where the Avvim people live
- The district of the Avvim people

as well as that of the Avvites: The phrase that of the Avvites indicates that the Israelites must also conquer the region where the Avvim people lived. This is a third region that is mentioned, and it is parallel to the “territory of the Philistines” and the “territory of the Geshurites” (13:2b). In some languages it may be clearer to start a new sentence here.

Avvites: The Avvites are mentioned in Deuteronomy 2:23. They lived in villages near Gaza. 13:3 Boling and Wright, p. 338.

Here are some other ways to translate the word Avvites:

Avvim (NRSV)

Avvim people

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

There is also the region of the Avvim people in the south that has not been conquered

Joshua 13:4**Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River**

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:4a to the south,

- in the south.
- in the south has not been conquered.

to the south: The Avvim lived in the south of the Philistine territory. This prepositional phrase describes the Avvim people and is a continuation of verse 3e. You should translate it as a single phrase.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The region of the Avvim people in the south has also not been conquered

13:4b all the land of the Canaanites,

- There is also all the land of the Canaanites,
- There are also the districts of all the Canaan people,

all the land of the Canaanites: The phrase the land of the Canaanites introduces a second group of towns. These are places in the north that are named in verses 4–6.13:4 Woudstra, p. 211.

For example:

In the north, the following area has not yet been conquered: all the land of the Canaanites, including Mearah (which belongs to the Sidonians) stretching northward to Aphek on the border of the Amorites. (NLT)

The term “Canaanite” is used here as a term for the inhabitants of Canaan. This is different from how it is used in verse 13:3b, where it refers to a specific group of Canaan people.

13:4c from Mearah of the Sidonians

- from Mearah City which belongs to the Sidonians,
- including Mearah City which belongs to the Sidonian people

from Mearah: There is a textual issue in this verse.

1. The Hebrew text says Mearah. We do not know where the town of Mearah was. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NJB, NABRE, NJPS, GW, NLT, GNT, KJV)
2. Some scholars suggest that we should divide the word Mearah and modify the vowels so that it

becomes two Hebrew words “from Arah.” The town of Arah is also unknown. (NIV, NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the Hebrew text.

of the Sidonians: The clause of the Sidonians indicates that town of Mearah was ruled by the people of Sidon. Sidon was on the Mediterranean coast in the north.

13:4d to Aphek, as far as the border of the Amorites;

- and on to Aphek, on the Amorite border.
- and going north to Aphek City on the border of the Amor people.

to Aphek: The term Aphek indicates a town that was probably southeast of Byblos in Lebanon.13:4 Rasmussen p. 226.

as far as the border of the Amorites: The phrase as far as the border of the Amorites indicates that “Aphek” was on the northern border of the land that was ruled by the Amorite people. The next people further north from there were the Amorite people.

Joshua 13:5

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:5a the land of the Gebalites;

- There is also the land of the Gebalites,
- There are also the districts of the Gebal people,

the land of the Gebalites: It may be more natural to begin a new sentence at the beginning of verse 5, for example:

It also includes the land of the Gebal people

the Gebalites: The term Gebalites indicates the people who lived in Gebal, a town on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea, eighteen miles northeast of mod-

ern Beirut.13:5 Rasmussen, p. 235. The ancient Greek name of this town was Byblos, and some English versions (NIV11, NET) refer to it by this name. The modern Arabic name for this town is Jubayl.

13:5b
and all Lebanon to the east,

- and all of Lebanon eastward
- all of Lebanon to the east,

and all Lebanon to the east: The phrase all Lebanon to the east indicates that the rest of Lebanon east of Gebal must still be conquered.

The places named in 13:5c describe the southern and northern limits of all Lebanon.

13:5c
from Baal-gad below Mount Hermon to Lebo-hamath.

- from Baal-gad at the foot of Mount Hermon to the entrance into Hamath City,
- from Baal-gad at the base of Mount Hermon in the south, to Hamath Mountain Pass in the north.

from Baal-gad below Mount Hermon: The town of Baal-gad was mentioned in Joshua 11:17. It was in the Lebanon Valley at the western foot of Hermon Mountain. Baal-gad was at the southern point Lebanon Valley.

Here is another way to spell the word Baal-gad:

Baal Gad (NIV, NET)

below Mount Hermon: The phrase below Mount Hermon indicates that the town of Baal-gad was at the base of Hermon Mountain.

to Lebo-hamath: There are two ways to interpret the phrase Lebo-hamath.

1. The Hebrew text reads lebo hamath. The Hebrew word lebo means “entrance.” Some English versions translate this as the entrance of Hamath or the Hamath Mountain Pass. For example:

the border of Hamath (GW) (GW, RSV, NJB, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. Some English versions translate this as a proper name, Lebo Hamath. For example:

Lebo Hamath (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NCV, NLT, NET, NJPS, REB)

It is difficult to know which is the proper interpretation. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) unless the national version used in your area uses interpretation (2).

Lebo-hamath: The town of Lebo-hamath and its mountain pass occurs several times in the Bible in boundary lists. See, for example, Numbers 13:21 and Judges 3:3. Hamath town was the northern point of the Lebanon Valley.

Joshua 13:6

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:6a All the inhabitants of the hill country from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim—

- and all the inhabitants of the mountain region from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim,
- There are also all the people who live in the mountain range that runs from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim,

All the inhabitants of the hill country: The phrase the inhabitants of the hill country indicates the people who lived in the mountain range that runs from north to south in Lebanon, away from the coastal plain.

from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim: The phrase from Lebanon to Misrephoth-maim indicates that the mountain range extended from the north part of the country of Lebanon south to the town of Misrephoth-maim.

Misrephoth-maim: The location of the town of Misrephoth-maim is uncertain. It was probably north of Galilee and not far from Sidon, near the Litani River.13:6 Rasmussen, p. 245.

Here is another way to spell Misrephoth-maim:

Misrephoth Maim (NIV, NET)

13:6b all the Sidonians—

- that is, all the Sidonians.
- who are under the rule of Sidon City.

all the Sidonians: The phrase the Sidonians indicates that the people who lived in the mountain range of Lebanon were Sidonians. This region was governed by Sidon. The town of Sidon was twenty-four miles southwest of Beirut on the Lebanese coast.

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder verses 6a and 6b. For example:

This includes all the territory of the Sidonians, who live in the hill country between the Lebanon Mountains and Misrephoth Maim (GNT)

13:6c I Myself will drive out before the Israelites.

- I am the one who will drive them out before the Israelites.
- It is I who will drive the people mentioned above out of the land ahead of the Israelites.

I Myself will drive out: The Hebrew pronoun that the BSB translates as Myself emphasizes that Yahweh is the one who will give the Israelites victory. Use the most natural way in your language to show this emphasis.

before the Israelites: The phrase before the Israelites indicates that God will give the Israelites victory as they move forward to conquer the land.

13:6d Be sure to divide it by lot as an inheritance to Israel,

- Be sure to give this land to Israel as an inheritance,
- However, Joshua, you must distribute the land to Israel for them to own,

Be sure to: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Be sure to introduces a command. It contrasts what is Joshua's responsibility with what Yahweh would do for the Israelites.

Here are some other ways that English versions emphasize this command:

So be sure to give this land to Israel as a special possession (NLT)

All you have to do is to distribute the territory as a heritage for the Israelites as I have commanded you (NJB)

divide it by lot as an inheritance to Israel: The clause divide it by lot as an inheritance to Israel indicates that Joshua must divide the land among the tribes of Israel who would live on the west side of the Jordan River.

as an inheritance: The phrase as an inheritance indicates that the Israelites received the land of Canaan as a gift from Yahweh to them. It would then belong to them and their descendants forever if they obeyed Yahweh. The word "inheritance" was used in 11:23, and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:6e as I have commanded you.

- as I have told you.
- as I commanded you.

as I have commanded you: Yahweh gave this command to Moses in Numbers 33:54. Moses told Joshua to carry out this command in Deuteronomy 31:7.

Joshua 13:7

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:7a Now therefore divide this land as an inheritance

- Now, divide up this land as an inheritance
- So, divide this land

Now therefore: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as Now therefore are literally "and now." The word Now indicates that the time has arrived for Joshua to divide the land between the Israelite tribes. Use a joining word that is natural to connect this clause with the preceding clause.

divide this land as an inheritance: The clause divide this land as an inheritance has the same meaning as the command in 13:6d. It is repeated for emphasis, using different words.

13:7b to the nine tribes and the half-tribe of Manasseh."

- for the nine clans and the half-clan of Manasseh."

- for the nine clans and half the clan of Manasseh to own.”

to the nine tribes: The phrase to the nine tribes indicates the nine tribes of Israel that had not yet received land. These nine tribes are Judah, Ephraim, Benjamin, Simeon, Zebulun, Issachar, Asher, Naphtali, and Dan.

and the half-tribe of Manasseh: The phrase the half-tribe of Manasseh indicates those people of the tribe of the Manasseh who chose to live west of the Jordan River.

There is a textual issue in this verse. The Septuagint, the ancient Greek translation, includes another clause at the end of verse 13:7 which is not in the Hebrew text. Most English versions do not include this clause, but it is found in the NJB:

from the Jordan as far as the Great Sea in the west, you must give it them; the Great Sea will be their limit (NJB)

It is recommended that you do not include this clause unless it is included in the majority language version in your area.

Joshua 13:8

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:8a

The other half of Manasseh,

- ¶ Half the clan of Manasseh
- ¶ The other half of the clan of Manasseh

The other half of Manasseh: The phrase The other half of Manasseh indicates those people from the tribe of Manasseh who chose to live on the east side of the Jordan River. This story is first told in Numbers 32.

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 8a and 8b, for example:

The tribes of Reuben and Gad and the other half of the tribe of Manasseh had already received their land on the east side of the Jordan River

13:8b

along with the Reubenites and Gadites, had received the inheritance

- and the clans of Reuben and Gad received their inheritance
- and the clans of Reuben and Gad had already received their land

along with the Reubenites and Gadites, had received the inheritance: The terms the Reubenites and Gadites indicate the tribe of Reuben and the tribe of Gad.

Here is another way to translate these names:

the tribe of Reuben and the tribe of Gad

13:8c

Moses had given them beyond the Jordan to the east,

- which Moses gave them on the east side of the Jordan.
- on the east side of the Jordan River.

Moses had given them beyond the Jordan to the east: The phrase beyond the Jordan to the east indicates that the land Moses gave these tribes was on the east side of the Jordan River.

13:8d

just as Moses the servant of the LORD had assigned to them:

- Moses, the servant of Yahweh, gave this land to them.
- Moses, Yahweh’s servant, gave them this land.

just as Moses the servant of the LORD had assigned to them: The phrase Moses the servant of the LORD was used in Joshua 1:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Verse 8d repeats information from 8c, and some English versions combine these two phrases together. Here is another way to translate this verse:

The tribes of Reuben and Gad and the other half of the tribe of Manasseh had already received the land that Moses, the Lord’s servant, had given them; it was on the east side of the Jordan River. (GNT)

Joshua 13:9

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:9a

The area from Aroer on the rim of the Arnon Valley,

- Their territory extended from Aroer on the edge of the valley of the Arnon River,
- Their land started at Aroer City at the Arnon River gorge.

The area from Aroer: In some languages it may be more natural to add implicit information, for example:

Their land started at Aroer (NCV)

Aroer: The term Aroer indicates a town that was along the Arnon River.

on the rim of the Arnon Valley: The clause on the rim of the Arnon Valley indicates that the town of Aroer was on the bank of the Arnon River, in the Arnon River Valley.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Aroer was on the bank of the Arnon River, in the valley.

Arnon Valley: The term Arnon Valley appeared in 12:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:9b

along with the city in the middle of the valley,

- including the town that is halfway along the valley,
- It included the city that is halfway along the Arnon River gorge,

along with the city in the middle of the valley: The phrase in the middle of the valley indicates that the town was halfway along the valley. The town is not named.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

including the town that is halfway along the Arnon River Valley

13:9c

the whole plateau of Medeba as far as Dibon,

- to the plain beyond Medeba, as far as Dibon City.
- and the whole of the Medeba Plateau to Dibon City.

the whole plateau of Medeba: The word plateau indicates a plain. The plateau of Medeba was a high, flat area between the Arnon River in the south and Heshbon in the north. It was 600–700 meters high.13:9 Woudstra, p. 216.

Medeba: The town of Medeba was a Moabite town that the Israelites captured from King Sihon (see Numbers 21:21–32). Today it is the town of Madaba in Jordan, twenty miles south of Amman.13:9 Rasmussen, p. 244.

as far as Dibon: The phrase as far as Dibon indicates that the tableland of Medeba stretched from Medeba in the north to Dibon in the south. Dibon was one of the Moabite towns that the Israelites captured. Its name today is Dhiban and it is thirteen miles east of the Dead Sea and three miles north of the Arnon Gorge.13:9 Rasmussen, p. 244.

Joshua 13:10

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:10a

and all the cities of Sihon king of the Amorites who reigned in Heshbon,

- It extended to all the cities of Sihon king of the Amorites, who reigned in Heshbon,
- It included all the cities ruled by King Sihon of the Amorites, who ruled from Heshbon City,

and all the cities of Sihon king of the Amorites: The phrase all the cities refers to all the towns in the territory that King Sihon ruled.

the Amorites: The word Amorites can be used in two senses. It can refer to a group of people who lived in the mountainous region of Canaan. This is the way it is used here. It can also be a synonym for “Canaanite,” and refer to the whole population of Canaan.

The word Amorites occurred in Joshua 2:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

who reigned in Heshbon: The clause who reigned in Heshbon indicates that Heshbon was the capital town of King Sihon. Heshbon was about 25 kilometers northeast of the Dead Sea, and southwest of present-day Amman, the capital city of Jordan.^{13:10 Bratcher and Newman, p. 171.}

It may be helpful to start a new sentence here. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Their territory extended as far as the towns of King Sihon of the Amorites, who reigned in Heshbon

13:10b as far as the border of the Ammonites;

- and extended to the border of the Ammonites.
- and as far as the area where the Ammon people lived.

as far as the border of the Ammonites: The phrase as far as the border of the Ammonites indicates that the territory Moses assigned to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and half the tribe of Manasseh extended to the border of the Ammon people.

Ammonites: The term Ammonites indicates a group of people who lived in the country of Ammon and whose capital city was Rabbah-ammon. This term was used in Joshua 12:2 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Joshua 13:11

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:11a also Gilead and the territory of the Geshurites and Maacathites,

- It extended to Gilead, and the territory of the Geshurites and the Maacathites,
- It included Gilead Region, and the place where the Geshur people and the Maacath people lived.

also Gilead: The term Gilead indicates the mountainous region north of the Dead Sea. The Gilead Region stretched from the east side of the Jordan River to the desert.

The term Gilead occurred in 12:2 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and the territory of the Geshurites: The term Geshurites indicates the people of the kingdom of Geshur. They were a small group who lived northeast of the Sea of Galilee.

The term Geshurites occurred in 12:5 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and Maacathites: The term Maacathites indicates the people of Maacah. This was a small kingdom in modern Syria whose people continued to live in their land.

The term Maacathites occurred in 12:5 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

It may be more natural to begin a new sentence at the beginning of verse 11. Here is another way to translate it:

It also included Gilead Region, and the region where the Geshur people lived and the Maacath people lived

13:11b all of Mount Hermon, and all Bashan as far as Salecah—

- and all of Mount Hermon and all of Bashan as far as Salecah.
- It included all of Mount Hermon and Bashan Region as far as Salecah City.

all of Mount Hermon: The phrase all of Mount Hermon indicates Mount Hermon and its surrounding foothills. Mount Hermon was a high mountain that was the northern limit of Joshua’s conquests. It was in the northeast part of Israel. It formed the northwest limit of King Og’s kingdom.

The term Mount Hermon occurred in Joshua 11:3 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

and all Bashan: The territory of Bashan stretched south to the hills of northern Gilead, where Sihon's territory began, and west to the Sea of Galilee. The east boundary of the Bashan territory was the desert.

The term Bashan occurred in Joshua 9:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

as far as Salecah: The name Salecah indicates a town on the east boundary of the territory of Bashan. Salecah was southeast of the Sea of Galilee.

The term Salecah occurred in 12:5 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Joshua 13:12

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:12a the whole kingdom of Og in Bashan,

- Those places were all the kingdom of Og in Bashan,
- All these places named above were the kingdom of King Og in Bashan Territory,

the whole kingdom of Og in Bashan: The phrase the whole kingdom of Og in Bashan indicates all the places that were named in the previous verse. It may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

that is, the whole kingdom of Og in Bashan (NIV)

These previously mentioned places were all included in the land of King Og, who ruled in Bashan Territory

The story of how Moses and the Israelites defeated the kingdom of Og in Bashan is found in Numbers 21:33–35.

13:12b

who had reigned in Ashtaroth and Edrei

- who reigned in Ashtaroth and Edrei,
- who ruled in Ashtaroth City and Edrei City.

who had reigned in Ashtaroth: The town of Ashtaroth was the capital city of King Og. It was twenty-two miles east of the Sea of Galilee. 13:12 Rasmussen. p. 227.

and Edrei: King Og also had a residence in the town of Edrei. Edrei was mentioned in Joshua 12:4, and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:12c

and had remained as a remnant of the Rephaim.

- and who was the last of the Rephaite people.
- King Og was the last of the Repha people,

and had remained as a remnant of the Rephaim: The clause and had remained as a remnant of the Rephaim is placed in parentheses in some English versions to indicate that the translators consider this to be background information. There are no parentheses in the Hebrew text or the BSB.

remnant: The word remnant indicates that only a few of the Rephaim were still alive.

Rephaim: The word Rephaim occurred in Joshua 12:4 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:12d

Moses had struck them down and dispossessed them,

- Moses defeated them and drove them out of their land.
- but Moses defeated him and took their land.

Moses had struck them down and dispossessed them: The pronoun them indicates the two kings, King Sihon and King Og. It may be more natural to make this information explicit, for example:

Moses had conquered and dispossessed these two kings (NJB)

Moses had defeated Sihon and Og and their people and had forced them to leave their land (CEV)

Joshua 13:13

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:13a

but the Israelites did not drive out the Geshurites or the Maacathites.

- But the Israelites did not drive out the Geshurites and the Ma-acathites,
- However, the Israelites did not make the Geshur people and the Maacah people leave,

but: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as but contrasts what follows with the information in 13:11a. Yahweh told the Israelites to conquer the land of the Geshurites and Maacathites, but they did not.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

but (NIV, NET)

however (GNT, NJB)

the Israelites did not drive out the Geshurites or the Maacathites: The clause did not drive out indicates that the Israelite army did not defeat the Geshur people and the Maacah people and did not drive them out of their land.

13:13b

So Geshur and Maacath dwell among the Israelites to this day.

- and so they still live among the Israelites to this day.
- and today they still live among the Israel people.

Geshur and Maacath: The terms Geshur and Maacath are another way to refer to the Geshurites and Maacathites.

dwell among the Israelites to this day: The clause dwell among the Israelites to this day indicates that the Geshur people and the Maacah people still lived among the Israelites.

to this day: The phrase this day indicates the time that the author was writing the book of Joshua.

Joshua 13:14

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing

of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:14a

To the tribe of Levi, however, Moses had given no inheritance.

- The clan of Levi was the only one to whom Moses did not give any land as their inheritance.
- But Moses did not give any land to the clan of Levi.

To the tribe of Levi: In the Hebrew text the phrase that the BSB translates as To the tribe of Levi is at the beginning of the sentence to show emphasis. The tribe of Levi was the only tribe that did not receive land as their gift from Yahweh.

In some languages it may not be natural to begin a sentence with this phrase. Use a natural way in your language to emphasize that the tribe of Levi was different from the other tribes.

Moses had given no inheritance: The clause Moses had given no inheritance indicates that Moses did not assign any land to the tribe of Levi.

13:14b

The offerings made by fire to the LORD, the God of Israel, are their inheritance,

- The sacrifices burned on the altar to Yahweh God of Israel are what the Levites inherited,
- Instead, he gave them the burned sacrifices that were offered to Yahweh, the God of Israel,

The offerings made by fire to the LORD, the God of Israel, are their inheritance: The phrase offerings made by fire refers to sacrifices that were partially burned. In Numbers 18:21–32| Yahweh told Aaron that the Levites could eat some of these offerings.

There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. The Hebrew text includes the words offerings made by fire. For example:

To the tribe of Levi alone Moses gave no inheritance. The offerings by fire to the Lord God of Israel are their inheritance (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NIV84, NET, GW, NJPS, NLT, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. The Septuagint, the ancient Greek translation, does not include the words offerings made by fire. For example:

To the tribe of Levi alone no heritage was given; Yahweh, God of Israel, was his heritage (NJB) (NJB, NEB, REB, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and the Hebrew text.

offerings made by fire: There are two ways to interpret the phrase offerings made by fire:

1. It means offerings that are burned. For example:

the sacrifices burned on the altar to the Lord God of Israel (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, NET, ESV, NIV84, GW, NJPS, NLT, KJV)

1. It means food offerings. For example:

the food offerings presented to the Lord, the God of Israel (NIV11) (NIV11)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with most English versions and the Hebrew lexicons.

Here is another way to translate the phrase offerings made by fire:

offerings burned on the altar (NLT)

are their inheritance: The phrase their inheritance indicates that God gave the tribe of Levi the offerings of the Israelites instead of land.

13:14c

just as He had promised them.

- as Yahweh said to Moses.
- as Yahweh told Moses and the Israelites.

just as He had promised them: The clause just as He had promised them indicates that Yahweh told this to Moses. This is recorded in Deuteronomy 18:1-2.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

as the Lord had told Moses (GNT)

them: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as them is singular. Some English versions, such as the BSB, NIV, and KJV, observe that God spoke to all the Israelites as well as to Moses, and so they translate this word as them.

Joshua 13:15

Section 13:1-33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:15

This is what Moses had given to the clans of the tribe of Reuben:

- ¶ Moses gave land to the clan of Reuben for each sub-clan.
- ¶ Moses assigned the following land to the sub-clans of the clan of Reuben.

This verse begins with a Hebrew word that is often translated as “and.” This word introduces the next event in the story. Many English versions do not translate this word.

This is what Moses had given to the clans of the tribe of Reuben: The Hebrew text is more literally “Moses gave to the tribe of the sons of Reuben.” The phrase This is what is not in the Hebrew text. The BSB has supplied this phrase to make clear what Moses gave to the tribe of Reuben. Moses assigned land to the tribe of Reuben in Numbers 32.

to the clans: The phrase to the clans indicates that each clan or group of families within the tribe of Reuben received their own portion of land. See how you translated the words “clan” and “family” in Joshua 7:14.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Moses had given each family group from the tribe of Reuben some land. (NCV)

Moses had assigned the following area to the clans of the tribe of Reuben. (NLT)

the tribe of Reuben: The phrase the tribe of Reuben indicates the people who were descended from Reuben, one of the sons of Jacob.

Joshua 13:16

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:16a

The territory from Aroer on the rim of the Arnon Valley,

- Their territory extended from Aroer on the edge of the valley of the Arnon River,
- Their land started at Aroer City at the Arnon River gorge.

The Hebrew word that the BSB that other versions translate as “and” or “so” leaves untranslated introduces the details about the land that was given to Reuben. Use whatever connecting word or particle is appropriate in your language.

The territory from Aroer on the rim of the Arnon Valley: The Hebrew words of this clause are almost identical to the words in 13:9a, and you should translate it in the same way.

13:16b

along with the city in the middle of the valley, to the whole plateau beyond Medeba,

- including the town that is halfway along the valley, to the plain beyond Medeba.
- It included the city that is halfway along the Arnon River gorge, and the whole of the Medeba Plateau.

along with the city in the middle of the valley, to the whole plateau beyond Medeba: The Hebrew words of this clause are almost identical to the words in 13:9b-c, and you should translate it in the same way.

Joshua 13:17

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing

of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:17a

to Heshbon

- It included Heshbon
- It included Heshbon City

to Heshbon: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence. For example:

It included Heshbon

Heshbon: Heshbon was the capital city of King Sihon. You should translate the name of this town the same way you did in 13:10a.

13:17b

and all its cities on the plateau,

- and all the cities on the plain near Heshbon:
- and the other cities in the Medeba Plateau.

and all its cities on the plateau: The phrase and all its cities on the plateau indicates all the towns that Sihon king of the Amorites ruled. They were in the plateau or tableland that was near Medeba. These towns are listed in the following verses.

13:17c

including Dibon, Bamoth-baal, Beth-baal-meon,

- Dibon, and Bamoth-baal, and Beth-baal-meon,
- These are Dibon City, Bamoth-baal Region, Beth-baal-meon City,

including Dibon: Dibon was a large town that was captured by Israel (Numbers 21:30). Its name today is Dhiban and it is thirteen miles east of the Dead Sea and three and a half miles north of the Arnon Gorge.13:17 Bratcher and Newman, p. 232.

Bamoth-baal: The term Bamoth-baal indicates the area northeast of the Dead Sea to which Balak took Balaam to curse Israel (Numbers 22:41). Bamoth-baal is not a town, but an area or a region.13:17 Rasmussen p. 228.

Here is another way to spell this name:

Bamoth Baal (NIV, NET)

Beth-baal-meon: The term Beth-baal-meon indicates a town that was twenty-three miles southwest of

Amman, Jordan, and ten miles east of the Dead Sea. Its name today is Ma'in.13:17 Rasmussen, p. 228, 229.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Beth Baal Meon (NIV, NET)

Joshua 13:18

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:18

Jahaz, Kedemoth, Mephaath,

- and Jahaz, and Kedemoth, and Mepha-ath,
- Jahaz City, Kedemoth City, Mepha-ath City,

Jahaz: The term Jahaz indicates a town that was part of the kingdom of Sihon. The story of how Moses defeated King Sihon at Jahaz is told in Numbers 21:23–24. The location of Jahaz is uncertain.

Kedemoth: The term Kedemoth indicates another town that was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. Its location is uncertain.

Mephaath: The term Mephaath indicates another town east of the Jordan River. It was a part of the kingdom of King Sihon. Its location is uncertain.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Mepha-ath (RSV)

Joshua 13:19

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:19a

Kiriathaim, Sibmah,

- and Kiriathaim, and Sibmah,
- Kiriathaim City, Sibmah City,

Kiriathaim: The term Kiriathaim indicates a town that was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. Its location is uncertain.

Sibmah: The term Sibmah indicates a town that was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. It was famous for its vineyards and is mentioned in Isaiah 16:8–9 and Jeremiah 48:32. Its location is unknown.

13:19b

Zereth-shahar on the hill in the valley,

- and Zereth-shahar on the hill in the valley,
- Zereth-shahar City on the hill in the middle of the valley,

Zereth-shahar on the hill in the valley: The term Zereth-shahar indicates a town that was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. The location of this town is uncertain.

the hill in the valley: The word valley probably refers to the Jordan River Valley. It is not known what hill this refers to.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Zereth Shahar (NIV, NET)

Joshua 13:20

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:20

Beth-peor, the slopes of Pisgah, and Beth-jeshimoth—

- and Beth-peor, and the slopes of Mount Pisgah, and Beth-jeshimoth.

- Beth-peor City, the area around Pisgah Mountain, and Beth-jeshimoth City.

Beth-peor: The term Beth-peor indicates a town east of the Jordan River, where the Israelites stayed while Moses gave them the law (Deuteronomy 4:46). It was also the place where Balaam gave one of his prophecies about the Israelites (Numbers 23:28). Its location is uncertain.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Beth Peor (NIV, NET)

the slopes of Pisgah: The slopes of Pisgah indicates the area around Mount Pisgah. It formed the south boundary of King Sihon's territory. The location of Mount Pisgah is uncertain.

and Beth-jeshimoth: The town of Beth-jeshimoth is referred to in Joshua 12:3 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Beth Jeshimoth (NIV, NET)

Joshua 13:21

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:21a

all the cities of the plateau

- Reuben inherited all these cities on the plain
- The clan of Reuben inherited all these cities on the Medeba Plateau

all the cities of the plateau: The clause all the cities of the plateau summarizes the list of towns that appear in verses 17–21. This clause is almost identical to the clause in verse 13:17b and you should translate it the same way. In verse 17 this phrase was at the beginning of the list, and here it comes at the end of the list.

13:21b

and all the kingdom of Sihon king of the Amorites,

- and the whole kingdom of King Sihon of the Amorites,
- and all the area that King Sihon of the Amorites ruled

and all the kingdom of Sihon king of the Amorites:

The phrase the kingdom of Sihon king of the Amorites indicates that Moses gave the land that King Sihon ruled on the plateau to the tribe of Reuben.

13:21c

who reigned in Heshbon until Moses killed him and the chiefs of Midian

- who ruled in Heshbon. Moses defeated him and Midian's leaders
- from Heshbon City. Moses defeated him along with the leaders of the Midianites,

who reigned in Heshbon: The clause who reigned in Heshbon indicates that Heshbon was the capital city of King Sihon. Heshbon was mentioned in 13:10 and 13:17, and you should translate it the same way every time.

until Moses killed him and the chiefs of Midian:

Moses defeated King Sihon along with all the other leaders of Midian. It may be helpful to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Moses had defeated him along with the Midianites including Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur and Reba (NCV)

chiefs of Midian: Midian was one of the sons of Abraham and Keturah (Genesis 25:1–2). Midian's descendants became a group called Midian. They were a nomadic people who lived in northwest Arabia, east of the Gulf of Aqaba. 13:21 Rasmussen p. 245.

13:21d

(Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba), the princes of Sihon who lived in the land.

- Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba. They were rulers under King Sihon who lived in that country.
- including Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba. These leaders lived in that land and ruled with King Sihon.

(Evi, Rekem, Zur, Hur, and Reba), the princes of Sihon: These five names are the leaders of the Midian people. The story of how Moses and the Israelites fought and killed these leaders is found in Numbers 31:7–8.

princes of Sihon: The phrase princes of Sihon indicates that these leaders of Midian were under the authority of King Sihon.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

all of them had ruled the land for King Sihon (GNT)

who lived in the land: The clause who lived in the land indicates that these five Midianite leaders and their people lived in the land that King Sihon ruled.

Joshua 13:22

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:22a

The Israelites also killed the diviner Balaam son of Beor

- The Israelites killed Balaam, son of Beor, who cast lots to predict the future,
- The Israelite soldiers also killed Balaam, the son of Beor, who used magic to tell the future,

The Israelites also killed: In some languages it is more natural to restructure verse 22 so that it begins with the subject, The Israelites. The term The Israelites indicates the Israelite soldiers. The Israelites soldiers killed Balaam.

also: The word also is not in the Hebrew text. It is added in the BSB to show that Balaam is a new topic. Choose the word order or lexical means that is most natural in your language to do this.

the diviner Balaam son of Beor: In this verse the diviner Balaam son of Beor is the object of the verb. In Hebrew the object is sometimes put at the beginning of the sentence to show emphasis.

the diviner: The word diviner indicates a person who predicted the future by casting lots. The lots were probably small stones. The word diviner refers to Balaam, not to Beor his father.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the one who practiced divination (ESV)

who used black magic (GW)

fortune teller (GNT)

who used magic to tell the future (NLT)

13:22b

along with the others they put to the sword.

- along with other people.
- and some other people.

along with the others: The phrase along with the others indicates that the Israelites killed other people at the same time that they killed Balaam.

Here is another way to translate this verse:

The Israelites killed many people during the fighting, including Balaam, son of Beor, who tried to use magic to tell the future (NCV)

they put to the sword: The phrase that the BSB translates as they put to the sword is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that they killed these people.

Here is another way to translate this Hebrew idiom:

they killed

Joshua 13:23

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:23a

And the border of the Reubenites was the bank of the Jordan.

- The west boundary of the clan of Reuben was the Jordan River.
- The Jordan River marked the west side of the land that the clan of Reuben inherited.

And the border of the Reubenites was the bank of the Jordan: This clause indicates that the Jordan River was the western boundary of the land that belonged to the tribe of Reuben.

13:23b

This was the inheritance of the clans of the Reubenites,

- These were the places that the clan of Reuben inherited,
- The places listed above were given to the clan of Reuben,

This was the inheritance of the clans of the Reubenites: The clause This was the inheritance indicates that God gave this land to belong to the tribe of Reuben. This summarizes the explanation of the area that the tribe of Reuben inherited, which began in 13:15.

of the clans of the Reubenites: The phrase of the clans of the Reubenites indicates that each clan of families within the tribe of Reuben received their own portion of the land. See how you translated the words “clan” and “family” in Joshua 7:14.

13:23c

including the cities and villages.

- for each of their sub-clans, including cities and villages.
- with some cities and villages for each sub-clan.

including the cities and villages: Each family in the tribe of Reuben received certain cities and villages as their own. The term cities indicates settled areas with a wall around them to protect them. The term villages indicates small settled areas without walls.

Joshua 13:24

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:24

This is what Moses had given to the clans of the tribe of Gad:

- ¶ Moses gave land to the clan of Gad for their people to inherit.
- ¶ Moses assigned the following land to the clan of Gad.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated is often translated as “and.” It indicates a transition to the next topic. Many English versions do not translate this connecting word.

Moses had given to the clans of the tribe of Gad:

This indicates that Moses assigned land to the tribe of Gad for them to live on and pass on to their descendants.

to the clans of the tribe of Gad: The phrase the clans of the tribe of Gad indicates the people who had Gad as their ancestor.

to the clans: The phrase to the clans indicates that each clan or group of families in the tribe of Gad received their own portion of the land. See how you translated the words “clan” and “family” in Joshua 7:14.

Joshua 13:25

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:25a

The territory of Jazer, all the cities of Gilead,

- Their territory included Jazer City, all the cities of Gilead Region,
- Their land included Jazer City, all the cities in the southern part of Gilead Region,

The territory of Jazer: The term Jazer indicates a town east of the Jordan River. Jazer was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. Its location is uncertain.

all the cities of Gilead: The phrase cities of Gilead indicates the towns in the region of Gilead that were near to Jazer. This was the southern part of Gilead. In verse 13:31 it says that the northern part of Gilead was assigned to the half-tribe of Manasseh.

The name Gilead appeared in Joshua 12:2 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:25b and half the land of the Ammonites

- and half the region of the Ammonite people
- and half the land of the Ammon people

and half the land of the Ammonites: The phrase half the land of the Ammonites indicates the western half of the land controlled by the Ammon people. This area was between the Arnon River and Jabbok River.13:25 Woudstra, p. 221.

the Ammonites: The term Ammonites refers to the Ammon people. It was used in Joshua 12:2 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:25c as far as Aroer, near Rabbah;

- to Aroer City, which is near Rabbah City.
- as far as Aroer City close to Rabbah City.

as far as Aroer, near Rabbah: The term Aroer indicates a town that was part of the kingdom of King Sihon. The town named Aroer in this verse is not the same as the Aroer mentioned in verse 16 which was assigned to Reuben. The location of the Aroer in this verse is not known.

near: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as near is more literally “on the face of.” There are three ways to interpret this word.

1. It means near. For example:

near Rabbah (BSB) (BSB, NIV, NCV, NET, NJPS, GW, NJB)

1. It means east. For example:

east of Rabbah (GNT) (GNT, RSV, ESV, REB)

1. It means west. For example:

west of Rabbah (CEV) (CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). We do not know for certain which direction Aroer town was in relation to Rabbah town. It is best to translate it using a word that means “near” or “close to.”

Here are some other ways that English versions translate this word:

by (GW)

facing (NJB)

Rabbah: The term Rabbah indicates the capital city of the Ammon people. Today it is the city of Amman, Jordan and it is 22 miles east of the Jordan River.

General Comment on 13:25

It may be more natural in some languages to translate this list of cites using more than one sentence. For example:

Their territory included the town of Jazer and all the towns of the southern Gilead Region. It also included half the land of the Ammonites. It extended as far as Aroer, which was close to Rabbah.

Joshua 13:26

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:26a the territory from Heshbon to Ramath-mizpeh and Betonim,

- Their territory went from Heshbon to Ramath-mizpeh and Betonim,
- The land given to the clan of Gad went from Heshbon City in the south to Ramath-mizpeh City and Betonim City

the territory from Heshbon to Ramath-mizpeh and Betonim: It is recommended that you begin a new sentence here.

Heshbon: The town of Heshbon was about 25 kilometers northeast of the Dead Sea, and southwest of Amman, Jordan.13:26 Bratcher and Newman, p. 238. It formed the south boundary of the land of the tribe of Gad.

Ramath-mizpeh: The town of Ramath-mizpeh was one of the towns that the tribe of Gad inherited. The location of Ramath-mizpeh is uncertain.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Ramath Mizpah (NIV, NET)

Betonim: The town of Betonim was sixteen miles northeast of Jericho. Its name today is Khirbet Bat-neh.13:26 Rasmussen, p. 230.

13:26b

and from Mahanaim to the border of Debir;

- and from Mahanaim to Debir.
- and further north to Mahanaim City and Debir City.

and from Mahanaim: The phrase from Mahanaim indicates that the land of the tribe of Gad included the town of Mahanaim. Mahanaim was to the north, at the border between the tribes of Gad and Manasseh. Its location is uncertain.

to the border of Debir: There is a textual issue with the word Debir.

1. In the Hebrew text this word is spelled lidber. In 2 Samuel 9:4 there is a town called Lo-debar. Some scholars think that the town mentioned here in Joshua is Lo-debar. However, they have to amend the Hebrew spelling slightly to make it fit.

The town of Lo-debar in 2 Samuel 9:4 was in the Jordan River Valley, ten miles south of the Sea of Galilee.13:26 Rasmussen, p. 232.

Here are some ways that English versions spell this name:

Lo-debar (NLT, NABRE)

Lodebar (GNT)

Lidbir (GW, NJPS)

Lidebor (CEV)

1. Some ancient versions of Joshua omit the letter “l” when they spell this name. They spell it idber. From this we get the English name Debir as in the BSB. However, there is no town known by the name of Debir east of the Jordan River.13:26 Woudstra, p. 222. For example:

Debir (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, ESV, NET, NASB, KJV)

The commentaries do not agree on this issue. It is recommended that you follow the majority language version of your area in translating this word.

Joshua 13:27

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:27a

and in the valley, Beth-haram, Beth-nimrah, Succoth, and Zaphon,

- In the valley were Beth-haram, Beth-nimrah, Succoth, and Zaphon,
- In the Jordan River Valley it included Beth-haram City, Beth-nimrah City, Succoth City, and Zaphon City,

and in the valley: The word valley indicates the Jordan River Valley.

Beth-haram: The term Beth-haram indicates a town in the Jordan River Valley that was eighteen miles southwest of present-day Amman. Today it is identified with Tel Iktanu.13:27 Rasmussen, p. 229.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Beth Haram (NIV, NET)

Beth-nimrah: The term Beth-nimrah indicates a town that was eighteen miles east of present-day Amman. Today it is identified with Tel el-Bleibil.13:27 Rasmussen, p. 229.

Here is another way to spell the name of this town:

Beth Nimrah (NIV, NET)

Succoth: The term Succoth indicates a town in the Jordan River Valley that was north of the Jabbok River.

and Zaphon: The term Zaphon indicates a town in the Jordan River Valley that was north of the Jabbok River.

13:27b

with the rest of the kingdom of Sihon king of Heshbon

- the rest of the kingdom of King Sihon of Heshbon.

- which were the rest of the kingdom of King Sihon, king of Heshbon City.

with the rest of the kingdom of Sihon king of Heshbon: The phrase the rest of the kingdom of Sihon king of Heshbon describes the towns in verse 13:27a. These towns and the area surrounding them were the second half of King Sihon's kingdom. The tribe of Reuben had received the first half.

Here is another way to translate 27a-b:

Joshua gave Gad the towns of Beth-haram, Beth-nimrah, Succoth, and Zaphon which were in the Jordan River Valley. These towns were the other half of the kingdom of King Sihon of Heshbon.

13:27c (the territory on the east side of the Jordan)

- The Jordan River was the western boundary,
- The west border of Gad's territory was the Jordan River

the territory on the east side of the Jordan: The clause the territory on the east side of the Jordan indicates that the Jordan River was the western boundary of the land that the tribe of Gad received.

13:27d up to the edge of the Sea of Chinnereth).

- and it went north to the edge of the Sea of Galilee.
- and the north border was the bottom of the Sea of Galilee.

up to the edge of the Sea of Chinnereth: The phrase up to the edge of the Sea of Chinnereth indicates that the territory of the tribe of Gad extended north to the southern end of the Sea of Chinnereth.

Sea of Chinnereth: The term Sea of Chinnereth is another name for the Sea of Galilee. It is recommended that you use the term "Lake Galilee" if it is more familiar to your readers. Translate this name the same way as in Joshua 11:2.

Here is another way to translate Sea of Chinnereth:

Sea of Galilee (NCV, CEV, NLT, GNT, GW)

The RSV spells this name "Chinneroth". As with many of these names, you may wish to use a spelling/pronunciation that is used in a nearby or well-known translation from your region.

Joshua 13:28

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:28a This was the inheritance of the clans of the Gadites,

- These were the places that the clan of Gad inherited,
- The places listed above were given to the clan of Gad,

This was the inheritance of the clans of the Gadites:

The clause This was the inheritance of the clans of the Gadites indicates that God gave the land described in the previous verses to the tribe of Gad.

of the clans: The phrase of the clans indicates that each clan or group of families in the tribe of Gad received their own portion of the land. See how you translated the words "clan" and "family" in Joshua 7:14.

13:28b including the cities and villages.

- for each of their sub-clans, including cities and villages.
- with some cities and villages for each sub-clan.

including the cities and villages: Each family or clan in the tribe of Gad received certain cities and villages as their own. This is the same wording as used in 13:23c and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Joshua 13:29

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:29a

This is what Moses had given to the clans of the half-tribe of Manasseh,

- ¶ Moses gave land to half the clan of Manasseh for their people to inherit.
- ¶ Moses assigned the following land to half the clan of Manasseh.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” indicates a transition to the next topic. Many English versions do not translate this connecting word.

Moses had given to the clans of the half-tribe of Manasseh: The clause Moses had given to the clans of the half-tribe of Manasseh indicates that Moses assigned land to half of the tribe of Manasseh for them to live on and pass on to their descendants. Moses mentioned this in Deuteronomy 3:13.

the half-tribe of Manasseh: The half-tribe of Manasseh indicates the people who had Manasseh as their ancestor. Manasseh was the oldest son of Joseph, son of Jacob. The tribe of Manasseh received land on both the east and the west sides of the Jordan River, and so there were two “half-tribes.” Some English versions refer to these two groups as East Manasseh and West Manasseh.

13:29b

that is, to half the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh:

- It was given to them with some for each sub-clan.
- He gave some to each of their sub-clans.

to half the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh: The clause to half the tribe of the descendants of Manasseh repeats the information in 29a using different words. In some languages it may be more natural to leave this part of the clause as implicit information.

the descendants of Manasseh: The phrase the descendants indicates that each family or clan within half of the tribe of Manasseh received their own portion of the land on the east side of the Jordan River. See how you translated the word “family” in Joshua 7:14.

Joshua 13:30

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they

still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:30a

The territory from Mahanaim

- Their territory started at Mahanaim,
- Their land went north from Mahanaim City

The territory from Mahanaim: The town of Mahanaim was on the south border of the tribes of Gad and Manasseh. Its exact location is uncertain. The town of Mahanaim was mentioned in 13:26 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

their land extended north from the town of Mahanaim

13:30b

through all Bashan—all the kingdom of Og king of Bashan,

- and included all of Bashan, the country of King Og,
- through all of the country of Bashan, which was ruled by King Og.

through all Bashan—all the kingdom of Og king of Bashan: The phrase through all Bashan contains the same information as the next phrase, all the kingdom of Og king of Bashan.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

it included the country of Bashan, which was ruled by King Og

Bashan: The term Bashan indicates a country or a region that was on a high and fertile plateau north of Gilead. The country of Bashan was mentioned in Joshua 9:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:30c

including all the towns of Jair that are in Bashan, sixty cities;

- and all sixty of the cities which Jair of the clan of Manasseh captured in Bashan.
- It included all sixty cities in the country of Bashan which Jair, a descendant of Manasseh, captured.

including all the towns of Jair that are in Bashan:

The phrase all the towns of Jair that are in Bashan indicates that the towns that Jair captured were included in the territory of Manasseh. Jair was a descendant of Manasseh. The story of how he captured these towns is found in Numbers 32:41.

sixty cities: In some languages it may be more natural to include the words sixty cities as part of the preceding phrase. For example:

It included all the sixty cities which Jair, a descendant of Manasseh, captured in Bashan

Joshua 13:31**Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River**

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:31a**half of Gilead; and Ashtaroth and Edrei, the royal cities of Og in Bashan.**

- It included half of Gilead, and Ashtaroth and Edrei in Bashan, the country of King Og.
- It included the northern half of the region of Gilead, as well as Ashtaroth City and Edrei City, the capital cities of King Og who ruled the country of Bashan.

half of Gilead: The phrase half of Gilead indicates half of the region of Gilead. The other half of the Gilead region was captured from King Sihon and was mentioned in 12:2. You should translate the term Gilead the same way in both places.

and Ashtaroth and Edrei, the royal cities of Og in Bashan: Ashtaroth and Edrei were two important towns in the kingdom of King Og.

In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. Here is another way to translate this verse:

It included half of Gilead, as well as Ashtaroth and Edrei (GNT)

Ashtaroth: The town of Ashtaroth was the capital town of King Og of Bashan. Ashtaroth was mentioned in Joshua 9:10 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Edrei: King Og also had a residence where he sometimes lived in the town of Edrei. Edrei was mentioned in Joshua 12:4, and you should translate it the same way in both places.

13:31b**All this was for the clans of the descendants of Machir son of Manasseh,**

- These cities were given to the descendants of Machir, who was Manasseh's son,
- Moses gave this land to the people descended from Machir the son of Manasseh.

All this was for the clans of the descendants of Machir son of Manasseh: The word All this indicates the towns that were listed in verses 13:30–31.

was for: The verb phrase was for is not in the Hebrew text. The Hebrew text has no verb, but in English a verb must be supplied.

the clans of the descendants: The phrase the clans of the descendants indicates that each clan or group of families within half of the tribe of Manasseh that was descended from Machir received their own portion of the land on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Moses gave these towns to the people of Machir the son of Manasseh

Machir son of Manasseh: Machir was the first-born son of Manasseh.

Here is another way to spell Machir:

Makir (NET, NIV)

13:31c**that is, half of the descendants of Machir.**

- for the Machir side of the clan of Manasseh, with some land for each family.
- He gave it to each family descended from Machir. These families made up this half-clan of Manasseh.

that is, half of the descendants of Machir: The phrase half of the descendants of Machir contains similar information to the phrase in verse 13:31b “the people of Machir the son of Manasseh.” In some lan-

guages it is more natural to leave one of these phrases as implicit information.

Here is another way to translate verse 13:31b-c:

Moses gave these towns to the families in this half-tribe of Manasseh. These families were the descendants of Machir the son of Manasseh.

Joshua 13:32

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:32a

These were the portions Moses had given them

- ¶ These are the land assignments that Moses made
- ¶ The lands described above are the places that Moses gave to the people

These were the portions Moses had given them:

The word *These* refers back to 13:15–31. It indicates the regions and towns that Moses gave to the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and half the tribe of Manasseh.

13:32b

on the plains of Moab beyond the Jordan, east of Jericho.

- when the Israelites were in the plains of Moab, east of the Jordan River, opposite Jericho.
- while they were camped on the plains of Moab, across the Jordan River, east of Jericho.

on the plains of Moab: The phrase the plains of Moab indicates a flat land on the east side of the Jordan River. Moab was one of the kingdoms on the east side of the Jordan. Moses made the distribution of land while the Israelites were camped on this plain.

beyond the Jordan, east of Jericho: The phrase beyond the Jordan, east of Jericho is written from the perspective of the author, who wrote this book in the land west of the Jordan River. It indicates that the plains of Moab were on the east side of the Jordan River. They were to the east of the town of Jericho, which was on the west side of the Jordan River.

Joshua 13:33

Section 13:1–33 Moses had distributed the land east of the Jordan River

Before Moses died he had given land to the tribes of Reuben, Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh. In this section Yahweh reminded Joshua of the land that they still had not conquered. Then there is a detailed listing of the boundaries of the lands on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here is another possible section heading:

The land east of the Jordan River

13:33a

To the tribe of Levi, however, Moses had given no inheritance.

- But Moses did not give an allotment to the clan of Levi,
- But Moses did not give any land to the clan of Levi.

To the tribe of Levi, however, Moses had given no inheritance: The tribe of Levi was the only tribe that did not receive land of their own.

The Hebrew text places the phrase *To the tribe of Levi* at the beginning of the sentence. In Hebrew this shows emphasis. In some languages it may not be natural to begin a sentence with this phrase. Use a way that is natural to emphasize that the tribe of Levi was different from the other tribes.

This verse is similar to verse 13:14.

13:33b

The LORD, the God of Israel, is their inheritance, just as He had promised them.

- because Yahweh, the God of Israel, promised that he himself will be their allotment.
- Instead, the Levi clan received Yahweh, the God of Israel himself, as he promised to them.

The LORD, the God of Israel, is their inheritance:

The phrase *their inheritance* indicates that the tribe of Levi had a special relationship with Yahweh, the God of Israel. They were the only tribe that served Yahweh at his altar in the Tent of Meeting. The words here are similar to Numbers 18:20.

just as He had promised them: The clause *just as He had promised them* indicates that Yahweh had previously promised this privilege to the tribe of Levi. See, for example, Deuteronomy 18:1–2.

Joshua 14:1

Section 14:1–5 The Israelites divided the land west of the Jordan River

In this section the nine and a half tribes who were to live on the west side of the Jordan River received their allotment of land. The tribe of Levi received only towns to live in.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land west of the Jordan River

Dividing up the land

14:1a

Now these are the portions that the Israelites inherited in the land of Canaan,

- ¶ This is the land that the Israelites received in the land of Canaan.
- ¶ This description that follows is about how the land of Canaan west of the Jordan was divided among the people of Israel.

Now these are the portions that the Israelites inherited in the land of Canaan: This sentence introduces a new topic. The topic is the areas of land which each tribe received on the west side of the Jordan River. Begin this sentence in a way that is natural in your language.

these are the portions: This phrase refers to the detailed description of land areas in chapters 14–19.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forWhat follows is an account of how the land... was divided (GNT)

Here are the pieces of land that the people of Israel received

portions: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as portions is more literally “gave them as a possession.” God gave some land to each tribe of Israel. He intended that their children and grandchildren would inherit those lands forever.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the land that God gave them

the lands they received as a possession

the land of Canaan: The phrase the land of Canaan refers to the land on the west side of the Jordan River, and also to some of the other nearby lands. God first promised this land to Abraham in Genesis 15:17–21.

14:1b

as distributed by Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun,

- Eleazar the priest, and Joshua the son of Nun,
- Eleazar the priest, and Joshua whose father was Nun,

as distributed by Eleazar the priest: Eleazar was the son of Aaron and he became the high priest after Aaron died. The word priest was used in 3:3 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

as distributed: The phrase that the BSB translates as as distributed can also be translated “divided” or “gave.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they divided it among the people

they decided what land to give to each group

Joshua son of Nun: This phrase was used in Joshua 1:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

14:1c

and the heads of the families of the tribes of Israel.

- and the leaders of the clans gave a piece of land to each Israelite family.
- and the leaders of the families of the Israelite clans divided it among the people.

and the heads of the families of the tribes of Israel: This phrase refers to the leaders of the Israelite tribes. In Numbers 34:16–29 Yahweh commanded Moses to appoint one leader from each of the tribes of Israel to help assign the land along with Joshua and Eleazar the priest. Moses decided who each of these leaders would be.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the leaders of the families of the Israelite tribes (GNT)

the leaders of all the tribes of Israel (NCV)

General Comment on 14:1a-c

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

^{1b}Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun, ^{1c}and the leaders of all the tribes of Israel ^{1a}decided what land to give to the people in the land of Canaan. (NCV)

Joshua 14:2**Section 14:1–5 The Israelites divided the land west of the Jordan River**

In this section the nine and a half tribes who were to live on the west side of the Jordan River received their allotment of land. The tribe of Levi received only towns to live in.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land west of the Jordan River

Dividing up the land

14:2a**Their inheritance was assigned by lot**

- These leaders used lots to decide which land the people would receive
- The priests rolled stones to decide which piece of land each family will receive

Their inheritance was assigned by lot: It was the role of the priest to throw the lots. God used the lots to show which piece of land he would give to each family.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Eleazar threw stones to decide which piece of land each family would receive.

inheritance: This word was used in 11:23 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

lot: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as lot refers to small objects that the Israelite people threw to determine God's will. It is possible that the lots were stones with a different color on each side. 14:2 Bean, Albert: Lots, Holman Bible Dictionary p. 896. Holman Bible Publishers, Nashville, TN 1991. If you have a tradition of choosing or throwing small objects to make a decision, you can use that term here. Or you can use some other term that is familiar in your language for choosing by chance.

Here are some ways to translate this term:

throw dice

draw straws

14:2b**for the nine and a half tribes,**

- for the remaining nine and one-half clans.
- for the nine and a half clans that hadn't yet received any land.

for the nine and a half tribes: The nine and a half tribes included all the tribes except for Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh. They received land on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

for the remaining nine and one-half tribes

for the nine and a half tribes that hadn't yet received their inheritance

14:2c**as the LORD had commanded through Moses.**

- Yahweh told Moses to do this.
- This is what Yahweh told Moses to do.

as the LORD had commanded through Moses: Numbers 33:50–54 tells the story of how Yahweh commanded Moses to distribute the land on the west side of the Jordan River.

Joshua 14:3**Section 14:1–5 The Israelites divided the land west of the Jordan River**

In this section the nine and a half tribes who were to live on the west side of the Jordan River received their allotment of land. The tribe of Levi received only towns to live in.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land west of the Jordan River

Dividing up the land

14:3a**For Moses had given the inheritance**

- Moses already gave an inheritance
- Moses already assigned land

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB has translated as For can also mean “because.” It states the reason for something. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. For example:

Moses had already given a grant of land to the two and a half tribes on the east side of the Jordan River. (NLT)

Moses had given the inheritance: This verse explains the reason why the land on the west side of the Jordan River was divided between nine and a half tribes, rather than all twelve tribes.

14:3b
east of the Jordan to the other two and a half tribes.

- to the two and one-half clans on the other side of the Jordan River.
- to the other two and a half clans on the east side of the Jordan River.

east of the Jordan to the other two and a half tribes: The other two and a half tribes refers to the tribes of Gad, Reuben and one half of the tribe of Manasseh.

east of the Jordan: The phrase east of the Jordan indicates the east side of the Jordan River. It may be helpful to make this clear. For example

Moses had given the two-and-a-half tribes their inheritance east of the Jordan River. (GW)

Moses had given the other two and a half tribes their own land on the east side of the Jordan River.

14:3c
But he granted no inheritance among them to the Levites.

- But he did not give any inheritance of land to the clan of Levi.
- Moses did not assign any land to the Levi clan.

But he granted no inheritance among them to the Levites: Although the BSB puts the phrase to the Levites at the end of the clause, it comes first in the Hebrew clause to emphasize that the Levites were different from the other tribes. Many languages will have another way to show this emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He did not give any land as an inheritance to Levi's tribe. (GW)

The tribe of Levi did not receive any land like the other tribes. (ERV)

he granted no inheritance among them: This indicates that the Levites did not receive any land. If you have translated the word inheritance as “land” in previous verses then you should translate it the same way here.

Joshua 14:4

Section 14:1–5 The Israelites divided the land west of the Jordan River

In this section the nine and a half tribes who were to live on the west side of the Jordan River received their allotment of land. The tribe of Levi received only towns to live in.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land west of the Jordan River

Dividing up the land

14:4a
The descendants of Joseph became two tribes, Manasseh and Ephraim.

- This happened because the clan of Joseph divided into two clans, Manasseh and Ephraim.
- There were still twelve clans even if Levi is not counted because the descendants of Joseph divided into two clans, Manasseh and Ephraim.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but many English versions translates as “For” is the same as the word in verse 3. It means “because.” It introduces the reason why the tribe of Levi did not receive land of their own.

The descendants of Joseph became two tribes, Manasseh and Ephraim: This verse explains why there were twelve tribes who inherited land, even though the Levite tribe did not receive any land. The descendants of Joseph had split into two tribes.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The descendants of Joseph had divided into two tribes—Manasseh and Ephraim. (ERV)

Manasseh and Ephraim were the sons of Joseph. They had become two tribes. (NIRV)

14:4b**And no portion of the land was given to the Levites,**

- The clan of Levi did not receive a share of the land,
- The Levi clan did not receive any land.

And no portion of the land was given to the Levites:

The clause no portion of the land was given to the Levites indicates that the Levites did not receive any land area of their own.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The Levites received no share of the land (NIV)

The Levite tribe did not receive any land.

General Comment on 14:3–4b

The information about the Levites is repeated in 4b for emphasis. If it is not natural to repeat this information, verses three and four may be combined, as in the GNT:

Moses had already assigned the land east of the Jordan to the other two and one-half tribes. (The descendants of Joseph were divided into two tribes: Manasseh and Ephraim.) However, Moses gave the Levites no portion of the territory. (GNT)

14:4c**except for cities in which to live,**

- but only towns to live in,
- They only received cities to live in,

except for cities in which to live: The phrase except for cities in which to live, indicates that the Levite tribe did not receive a region of land as the other tribes did. Instead, they received towns to live in.

14:4d**along with pasturelands for their flocks and herds.**

- along with the surrounding lands for their cattle and sheep and goats to graze in.
- and the nearby land for their animals to live on.

along with pasturelands for their flocks and herds:

The word pasturelands indicates fields in which cattle or other domestic animals could eat the grass.

their flocks and herds: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates their flocks and herds is more literally “their acquired possessions.” It can also refer to animals. In this context it refers to other domesticated animals that the Levites owned, such as sheep and goats.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

nearby pastures for their sheep, goats, and cattle (CEV)

fields for all their animals to live on

Joshua 14:5**Section 14:1–5 The Israelites divided the land west of the Jordan River**

In this section the nine and a half tribes who were to live on the west side of the Jordan River received their allotment of land. The tribe of Levi received only towns to live in.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land west of the Jordan River

Dividing up the land

14:5a**So the Israelites did as the LORD had commanded Moses,**

- The Israelites did what Yahweh commanded Moses.
- The Israelites followed Yahweh’s commands to Moses

So the Israelites did as the LORD had commanded Moses:

This is a summary of verses 1–5. Yahweh told Moses how to divide up the land when they were on the plains of Moab, before they entered the land of Canaan (Numbers 33:50–54).

Here is another way to translate this clause:

The Israelites followed the Lord’s instructions to Moses. (NET)

14:5b**and they divided the land.**

- They divided the land in the way he told them to do.
- and divided up the land among the twelve clans.

and they divided the land: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

they allotted the land (RSV)

they assigned the land to the people

Joshua 14:6

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:6a

Then the sons of Judah approached Joshua at Gilgal,

- ¶ Then people from the clan of Judah approached Joshua at Gilgal.
- ¶ One day the Judah clan came to Joshua while they were camped at Gilgal camp.

Then the sons of Judah approached Joshua at Gilgal: While the Israelites were camped at Gilgal, the people of the tribe of Judah went to talk to Joshua.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

While the Israelites were camped at Gilgal, the people of Judah came to Joshua

Gilgal: Gilgal is the name of a place east of Jericho and west of the Jordan River. It is the place where the Israelites set up their camp after they crossed the Jordan River. It is first mentioned in Joshua 4:19] and you should translate it the same way in both places.

14:6b

and Caleb son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite said to him,

- Caleb, who was the son of Jephunneh and grandson of Kenaz, said to Joshua:
- Caleb was the son of Jephunneh, and the grandson of Kenaz. He said to Joshua:

and Caleb son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite said to him: The story of Caleb is told in 13. He was one of the twelve spies who explored the land of Canaan. Caleb and Joshua were the only two of the twelve spies who trusted God.

the Kenizzite: There are two ways to interpret the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Kenizzite.

1. It indicates that Caleb is a grandson of Kenaz. For example:

Caleb...the grandson of Kenaz (GW) (GW)

1. It indicates that Caleb belongs to the family or clan of Kenaz. For example:

Caleb belonged to the Kenaz clan (CEV) (BSB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is based on Judges 3:9 and I Chronicles 4:13–15.

14:6c

“You know what the LORD said to Moses the man of God

- “You know what Yahweh told Moses the man of God
- “You remember what Yahweh said to Moses the prophet of God

You know what the LORD said to Moses the man of God: The phrase Moses the man of God is a title for Moses. He is called this several times, for example in Deuteronomy 33:1. This is a term that is often used for a prophet who speaks for God, for example 1 Samuel 2:27.

Here are some other ways to translate the phrase Moses the man of God:

Moses the man who belongs to God

the prophet Moses (NCV, CEV)

14:6d

at Kadesh-barnea about you and me.

- about you and me in Kadesh-barnea.
- about us two while we were in Kadesh-barnea.

at Kadesh-barnea: The term Kadesh-barnea refers to a town on the south boundary of Canaan. The twelve spies returned here to make their report about Canaan (Numbers 13:26). This town was mentioned in Joshua 10:41 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

about you and me: Caleb said this to Joshua. Yahweh promised that Caleb and Joshua would receive land which their descendants would inherit (Numbers 14:24–30).

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

concerning you and me (RSV)

about the two of us

Joshua 14:7

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:7a

I was forty years old

- At that time I was forty years old.
- When I was forty years of age,

I was forty years old: In some languages it may be more natural to put this phrase at the end of the verse rather than at the beginning.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

When Moses the servant of Yahweh sent me from Kadesh-barnea, I was forty years old.

14:7b

when Moses the servant of the LORD sent me from Kadesh-barnea

- Moses the servant of Yahweh sent me from Kadesh-barnea
- Moses, Yahweh's servant, told me to go from Kadesh-barnea

when Moses the servant of the LORD: This phrase was used in Joshua 1:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

sent me from Kadesh-barnea: The account of what happened when Moses sent the twelve spies to explore the land of Canaan occurs in Numbers 13.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

when Moses, Yahweh's servant, commanded me to go from Kadesh-barnea

Both Caleb and Joshua were among the twelve spies. It is also possible to translate this clause as:

when Moses, Yahweh's servant, commanded us to go from Kadesh-barnea

14:7c

to spy out the land,

- to explore the land of Canaan.
- to look around the land of Canaan.

to spy out the land: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as spy out is more literally "explore."

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

to explore the land

to look all around the land

14:7d

and I brought back to him an honest report.

- I brought him back an honest report.
- I came back and told him what I thought.

and I brought back to him: This means that Caleb returned to Moses and gave him a report about what had happened while he explored the land. In some languages it may be clearer to start a new sentence here.

an honest report: The clause an honest report indicates that Caleb spoke honestly about what he had seen in Canaan. (The only other person who was not afraid of the Canaan people was Joshua, but he is not directly mentioned in this narrative.) The other ten spies said that they were afraid of the Canaan people, but Caleb said that God would help the Israelites to fight them.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I returned and gave him an honest report (NLT)

I brought him back a report according to my convictions (NIV)

I came back and gave him a faithful account about the land.

Joshua 14:8

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he

would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:8a

Although my brothers who went with me

- But the people who went up with me
- However, my companions who went with me

Although my brothers who went with me: The phrase my brothers refers to ten of the twelve spies. They were also Israelites and Caleb thought of them as brothers.

who went with me: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as went indicates that the men were going up to a higher place. They started in the wilderness of Kadesh-barnea, which was on the edge of the coastal plain. From there they went up into the hill country. In languages that do not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say went, as the BSB does.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But the other Israelites who went with me

But my companions who went with me

14:8b

made the hearts of the people melt with fear,

- made the other Israelites afraid.
- said things that terrified the rest of the people.

made the hearts of the people melt with fear: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as made the hearts of the people melt with fear is an idiom. It indicates that the people were very afraid. The words the people refer to the Israelite people. A similar expression was used in verse 2:9d. If possible, you should translate this clause in the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

my companions made the Israelites afraid

the brothers who went with me said things that terrified the rest of the people

14:8c

I remained loyal to the LORD my God.

- But I followed Yahweh my God with all my heart.
- However, I was completely loyal to Yahweh my God.

I remained loyal to the LORD my God: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as I remained loyal to the LORD my God is more literally "I fulfilled after Yahweh my God." This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that Caleb was completely loyal to Yahweh. 14:8 This idiom also occurs in Numbers 14:24, Numbers 32:12 and Deuteronomy 1:36. If you have already translated those books, it is recommended that you translate it the same way here.

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew idiom:

I was completely loyal to Yahweh my God.

I followed Yahweh my God with all my heart.

I completely trusted the Lord God (CEV)

Joshua 14:9

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:9a

On that day Moses swore to me, saying,

- That day Moses made a promise to me, saying:
- The day that I came back from Canaan, Moses promised me:

On that day Moses swore to me, saying: The clause Moses swore means that Moses made a promise to Caleb.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

On the day I returned, Moses promised me

The same day I came back, Moses told me (CEV)

14:9b

'Surely the land on which you have set foot

- 'The land on which your feet have walked
- 'The land you have walked on

Surely the land on which you have set foot: The phrase the land on which you have set foot indicates the land on which Caleb walked. This was a part of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The land which your feet walked on

The land in Canaan where you walked

14:9c

will be an inheritance to you and your children forever,

- will become your land and that of your children and grandchildren forever,
- will certainly belong to you and to your descendants always,

will be an inheritance to you and your children forever: This clause indicates that Caleb would receive the land he walked on as a gift from God. He could pass it on to his children and his grandchildren.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

it will be your land and that of your descendants always

it will belong to you and to your children and grandchildren for ever

14:9d

because you have wholly followed the LORD my God.'

- because you followed Yahweh my God with all your heart.'
- because you were completely loyal to Yahweh my God.'

because you have wholly followed the LORD my God: The clause you have wholly followed the LORD my God is the same Hebrew idiom that was used in verse 14:8c and you should consider translating it the same way.

Joshua 14:10

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:10a

Now behold, as the LORD promised, He has kept me alive

- ¶ Now, look. Yahweh has let me live, as he said he would.
- ¶ Now see. Yahweh has caused me to live, as he promised.

Now behold: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Now behold, is a literary device to call attention to what comes next. Use a natural expression in your language to call attention to what comes next. In some languages this expression may best be left implicit.

as the LORD promised, He has kept me alive: In Numbers 14:24–30 Yahweh promised that Caleb would live to inherit land in Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Yahweh has let me live as he promised

Yahweh has caused me to live, as he said he would

14:10b

these forty-five years since He spoke this word to Moses,

- It has been forty-five years since Yahweh said this to Moses.
- Yahweh gave Moses this promise about me forty-five years ago,

these forty-five years since He spoke this word to Moses: Caleb said that it had been forty-five years since Yahweh promised to give him the land that he had walked on in Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

It has been forty-five years since Yahweh said this to Moses

Yahweh said this to Moses forty-five years ago

14:10c
while Israel wandered in the wilderness.

- At that time the Israelites were walking through the wilderness.
- while the people of Israel were wandering through the wilderness.

while Israel wandered in the wilderness: The name Israel refers to the descendants of Israel (who was also called Jacob). This is another way to say “Israelites.”

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

at that time the Israelites were walking through the wilderness

while the people of Israel were going through the wilderness

14:10d
So here I am today, eighty-five years old,

- Now look at me. I am eighty-five years old today.
- Here I am, eighty-five years old now.

So here I am: In the BSB, the phrase So here I am translates the same Hebrew words as occurred in verse 14:10a. This is a literary device to call attention to what comes next. You should translate this phrase in whatever way is natural to call attention to what comes next.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Look at me! (GNT)

Now here I am (NCV)

today, eighty-five years old: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Today I am eighty-five years old.

Now here I am, eighty-five years old today

General Comment on 14:10a-d

Some English versions translate this verse as one long sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to divide the verse into several sentences. For example:

But now, look. It has been forty-five years since the Lord said that to Moses. That was when Israel was going through the desert, and the Lord, as he promised, has kept me alive ever since. Look at me! I am eighty-five years old. (GNT)

Joshua 14:11

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:11a
still as strong today as I was the day Moses sent me out.

- I am as strong today as I was when Moses told me to go explore the land.
- I am still as strong now as I was on the day Moses sent me out.

still as strong today as I was the day Moses sent me out: Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

I am as strong today as I was when Moses told me to go to spy on the land

I am as strong today as I was then

14:11b
As my strength was then, so it is now

- I am as strong now as I was then.
- I am strong enough

As my strength was then, so it is now: The clause As my strength was then, so it is now has the same meaning as the previous clause. It is repeated in

slightly different words in Hebrew to emphasize the statement.

14:11c

for war, for going out, and for coming in.

- I can go fight battles and I can do anything else.
- to go fight in battle, and do my daily work.

for war: The phrase for war indicates the ability to be a soldier and fight in a battle.

for going out, and for coming in: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as for going out, and for coming in is more literally “to go out and to come in.” This is a Hebrew idiom that refers to the ability to do one’s daily activities.

Here are some other ways to translate these phrases:

to fight battles and to do all my daily work

to go out to war as well as do any other thing

I am still strong enough to fight in war, and to do anything else.

Joshua 14:12

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb’s inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:12a

Now therefore give me this hill country that the LORD promised me on that day,

- So please give me the hill country that Yahweh promised me then.
- Now please give me the mountain region that Yahweh told me I will receive.

Now therefore give me this hill country: The phrase hill country refers to a region that had mountains in it. In verses 13–15 Joshua gives the town of Hebron to Caleb. Hebron was in this mountainous area.

that the LORD promised me on that day: Numbers 14:24 tells how Yahweh promised to give Caleb the land that he had explored.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

So I’m asking you for the hill country that the Lord promised me that day (CEV)

Now give me the mountain region which Yahweh told me then I will receive

14:12b

for you yourself heard then that the Anakim were there,

- You heard then that the descendants of Anak lived there,
- At that time you heard that the Anak people lived there.

for you yourself heard then that the Anakim were there: When the twelve spies came back, they told Moses about people called Anakim who lived in that land. Joshua was there and heard the report.

Anakim: The term Anakim refers to people who were descended from Anak. They are mentioned in Joshua 11:21, and you should translate this word the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You heard then that the descendants of Anak lived there

At that time you heard that the Anak people lived there

14:12c

with great and fortified cities.

- in large cities surrounded by walls.
- They lived in large walled cities.

with great and fortified cities: The phrase with great and fortified cities indicates that the Anak people lived in towns with strong walls and gates.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

they lived in large towns surrounded by walls

they have large walled towns

14:12d**Perhaps with the LORD's help I will drive them out,**

- If Yahweh is with me, I will take their land from them,
- With Yahweh helping me, I will force them to leave their land,

Perhaps with the LORD's help: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB has translated as Perhaps is more literally “perhaps, maybe.” This word in Hebrew expresses hope, not doubt.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

if Yahweh is with me

I know that Yahweh will help me

I will drive them out: The clause I will drive them out means that Caleb will force the Anak people to leave the land and he will be able to live there himself.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I will force them to leave their land

I will take their land from them

14:12e**as the LORD has spoken.”**

- as Yahweh said I will.”
- as Yahweh promised.”

as the LORD has spoken: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

as Yahweh promised

as Yahweh promised that I would do.

Joshua 14:13**Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron**

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:13a**Then Joshua blessed Caleb son of Jephunneh**

- ¶ Then Joshua blessed Caleb.
- ¶ Then Joshua prayed that Yahweh would be with Caleb,

Then Joshua blessed Caleb son of Jephunneh: The phrase Joshua blessed Caleb indicates that Joshua prayed that God would help Caleb and give him success. In 8:33 it said that Moses blessed the people. You should translate this verb the same way you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then Joshua gave a blessing to Caleb

Then Joshua prayed that God would help Caleb (CEV)

Caleb son of Jephunneh: This phrase was used in 14:6 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

14:13b**and gave him Hebron as his inheritance.**

- Joshua gave the city of Hebron to Caleb the son of Jephunneh as his own possession.
- and he gave Hebron City to Caleb and to his descendants.

and gave him Hebron as his inheritance: The town of Hebron was in the mountainous area that Joshua gave to Caleb. Hebron was mentioned in 10:3, and you should translate it the same way in both places.

as his inheritance: The phrase as his inheritance indicates that Caleb will receive the town of Hebron for his own.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Joshua gave the town of Hebron to Caleb the son of Jephunneh and to his descendants

Joshua gave Caleb the son of Jephunneh the town of Hebron as his own possession

Joshua 14:14**Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron**

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to

spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:14a

Therefore Hebron belongs to Caleb son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite as an inheritance to this day,

- So the city of Hebron became the possession of Caleb the son of Jephunneh, the grandson of Kenaz, up to this day,
- So Caleb the son of Jephunneh the son of Kenaz conquered the city of Hebron, and it still belongs to his descendants to this day.

Therefore Hebron belongs to Caleb son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite as an inheritance to this day:

There is some implied information here. Caleb conquered the town of Hebron.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The town of Hebron became the possession of Caleb the son of Jephunneh the son of Kenaz up to today

So Caleb conquered the town of Hebron, and it still belongs to his descendants

14:14b

because he wholly followed the LORD, the God of Israel.

- because he was completely loyal to Yahweh the God of Israel.
- This happened because he followed Yahweh the God of Israel with all his heart.

because he wholly followed the LORD, the God of Israel:

The expression wholly followed translates the same Hebrew words as were found in verses 14:8c ("remained loyal" in the BSB) and 14:9d ("wholly followed" in the BSB). Translate this expression the same way as you did in those verses.

the LORD, the God of Israel: The phrase the LORD, the God of Israel is slightly different from the way that God was referred to in verses 8c and 9d. There the phrase "the LORD, my God" was used.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because he was completely loyal to Yahweh the God of Israel

because Caleb followed Yahweh the God of Israel with all his heart

Joshua 14:15

Section 14:6–15 Joshua gave Caleb the town of Hebron

In this section Caleb reminded Joshua of a promise that Moses had made to him. After Caleb helped to spy out the land of Canaan, Moses promised that he would inherit the land he had walked on. So Joshua granted the town of Hebron to Caleb.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Caleb's inheritance

Caleb claimed his inheritance

14:15a-b

(Hebron used to be called Kiriath-arba, after Arba, the greatest man among the Anakim.): The Hebrew word that begins this verse is often translated as "Now" and introduces an explanation about the name of Hebron. The BSB indicates this by putting it in parentheses. Introduce this explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

14:15a

(Hebron used to be called Kiriath-arba,

- The city of Hebron used to be called Kiriath-arba,
- Before that time, the city of Hebron was called the City of Arba.

Hebron used to be called Kiriath-arba: The town of Kiriath-arba is mentioned in Genesis 23:2. The word "Kiriath" means "town" in Hebrew. Arba is the name of one of the Anak people.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The town of Hebron used to be called Kiriath-arba

In the past times, the name of Hebron was Kiriath-arba

Before that time, the town of Hebron was called Arba

14:15b after Arba, the greatest man among the Anakim.)

- because Arba was the most important man of the Anak people.
- It was named after Arba, the greatest man among the people of Anak.

after Arba, the greatest man among the Anakim:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

because Arba was the most important man of the Anak people

It was named after Arba, the greatest man among the people of Anak

14:15c Then the land had rest from war.

- Then there was no war in the land.
- Then there was peace in the land.

Then the land had rest from war: The clause the land had rest from war translates the same Hebrew words as are found in verse 11:23. You should translate this sentence in the same way that you translated verse 11:23.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Then there was peace in the land.

Then there was no war in the land

Joshua 15:1

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:1–4

The next four paragraphs describe the boundaries of the land that Joshua assigned to the tribe of Judah. The south boundary is described in verses 1–4. The east boundary is in verse 5a. The north boundary is in verses 5b through verse 11. The west boundary is in verse 12.

The south boundary starts at the south end of the Dead Sea. From there it swings south and then west to encompass a large area of the Negev Desert. Finally it ends at the Mediterranean Sea.

15:1a Now the allotment for the clans of the tribe of Judah

- ¶ The land that the people of Judah received by lot according to their sub-clans
- ¶ When Joshua threw lots for the clan of Judah, this was the land that they received. Each sub-clan received their own piece of land.

Now the allotment for the clans of the tribe of Judah: The phrase the allotment refers to the land that the tribe of Judah received when Eleazar and Joshua cast lots for them. This was first mentioned in Joshua 14:2 where it was translated as “inheritance... assigned by lot.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The land that was assigned by lot to the tribe of Judah

When Joshua threw the lots, this was the land that the people of Judah received

Joshua assigned this land to the tribe of Judah

for the clans: The nation of Israel was divided into tribes, named after the twelve sons of Jacob. Each tribe was divided into clans or groups of families named after the sons of the leader of the tribe. See how you translated “tribe,” “clan,” and “family” in Joshua 7:14.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Each family/clan received their own portion of land.

15:1b extended to the border of Edom,

- extended south to the border of Edom in the south-east.
- Their land went south to the border of the land of Edom.

extended to the border of Edom: The clause extended to the border of Edom indicates that the

southern border of the land that Judah received was next to the land of Edom.

Edom: Edom was a kingdom that was south of the Dead Sea and southeast of the territory of Judah. The kingdom of Edom is mentioned throughout the Old Testament. See for example, Genesis 32:3. You should translate it the same way every time.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

their land extended south to the land of Edom

their land went south to the border of the Edom Kingdom in the southeast

15:1c
to the Wilderness of Zin at the extreme southern boundary:

- It went south to the wilderness of Zin in the south-west.
- The southernmost point was the Wilderness of Zin.

to the Wilderness of Zin at the extreme southern boundary: The Wilderness of Zin was south of the land that Judah received, and west of the land of Edom.

at the extreme southern boundary: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as at the extreme southern boundary is more literally “from the end of the south.” It indicates the southernmost point of the southern border of Judah’s land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

as far south as the wilderness of Zin (NLT)

The southernmost point was the wilderness of Zin in the southwest

Joshua 15:2

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land
This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:1–4

The next four paragraphs describe the boundaries of the land that Joshua assigned to the tribe of Judah. The south boundary is described in verses 1–4. The east boundary is in verse 5a. The north boundary is in verses 5b through verse 11. The west boundary is in verse 12.

The south boundary starts at the south end of the Dead Sea. From there it swings south and then west to encompass a large area of the Negev Desert. Finally it ends at the Mediterranean Sea.

15:2a

Their southern border started at the bay on the southern tip of the Salt Sea,

- ¶ The southern border started at the south end of the Salt Sea where the end of the sea points to the south.
- ¶ That boundary began at the southern tip of the Dead Sea

Their southern border started at the bay on the southern tip of the Salt Sea: Verses 2–4 describe the southern boundary of Judah’s land in more detail. The clause Their southern border started at the bay on the southern tip of the Salt Sea indicates that the Salt Sea was the eastern point of the south boundary of Judah. the Salt Sea is also known as the Dead Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Judah’s southern border started at the south end of the Dead Sea (CEV)

That boundary began at the south tip of the Salt Sea

at the bay on the southern tip of the Salt Sea: The phrase at the bay on the southern tip of the Salt Sea further describes the beginning point of the southern border of Judah.

Some English versions combine verse 15:2a–b. For example:

Their southern boundary started from the bay at the southern end of the Dead Sea (NIV)

Joshua 15:3

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:1–4

The next four paragraphs describe the boundaries of the land that Joshua assigned to the tribe of Judah. The south boundary is described in verses 1–4. The east boundary is in verse 5a. The north boundary is in verses 5b through verse 11. The west boundary is in verse 12.

The south boundary starts at the south end of the Dead Sea. From there it swings south and then west to encompass a large area of the Negev Desert. Finally it ends at the Mediterranean Sea.

15:3a proceeded south of the Ascent of Akrabbim,

- The border goes south of Akrabbim Pass,
- The boundary line continued to the south of Scorpion Pass,

proceeded south of the Ascent of Akrabbim: This indicates that the border passed to the south of the Ascent of Akrabbim as it continued going on toward the west.

proceeded: The Hebrew verbs in verses 3–12 are not in the same tense as the verbs in verses 1 and 2. The RSV uses a present tense to reflect this change in the Hebrew tense, but some English versions like the BSB do not.

It is recommended that you translate these verses using the same tense or aspect throughout. Choose a tense or aspect that is natural for a description of land boundaries.

Ascent of Akrabbim: The phrase Ascent of Akrabbim refers to a mountain pass or a road through the mountains. The Hebrew word Akrabbim means scorpion. Some English versions translate this phrase as “Scorpion Pass.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As it went west from there, it ran south of Scorpion Pass (CEV)

The boundary line continued south of Scorpion Pass

The border went south of Akrabbim Pass as it continued westward

15:3b continued on to Zin, went over to the south of Kadesh-barnea,

- continues to the Wilderness of Zin, and ascends south of Kadesh-barnea.
- went to the Wilderness of Zin and went uphill as it passed south of Kadesh-barnea Town.

continued on to Zin, went over to the south of Kadesh-barnea: The town of Kadesh-barnea was mentioned in Joshua 10:41. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Zin: This refers to the “Wilderness of Zin” that was mentioned in verse 15:1.

went over: The phrase went over indicates that the boundary went uphill as it went past the town of Kadesh-barnea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then continued to the Wilderness of Zin, and up south of the town of Kadesh-barnea

the boundary line went to the Wilderness of Zin and went uphill as it passed south of Kadesh-barnea

15:3c ran past Hezron up to Addar, and curved toward Karka.

- It continues past Hezron, up to Addar, and turns toward Karka.
- The boundary line went to the town of Hezron, then ascended to the town of Addar, and turned toward the town of Karka.

ran past Hezron up to Addar, and curved toward Karka: The phrase up to Addar indicates that the boundary ascended in elevation as it went from Hezron to Addar.

Hezron...Addar...Karka: These are the names of small towns. It may be helpful in some languages to include the term “town” in the translation.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It continued past Hezron up to Addar, turned toward Karka (CEV)

Then it ran past Hezron up to Addar and curved around to Karka (NIV)

The boundary line went on to the town of Hezron, then went uphill to the town of Addar, and turned toward the town of Karka

Joshua 15:4

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:1–4

The next four paragraphs describe the boundaries of the land that Joshua assigned to the tribe of Judah. The south boundary is described in verses 1–4. The east boundary is in verse 5a. The north boundary is in verses 5b through verse 11. The west boundary is in verse 12.

The south boundary starts at the south end of the Dead Sea. From there it swings south and then west to encompass a large area of the Negev Desert. Finally it ends at the Mediterranean Sea.

15:4a

It proceeded to Azmon,

- The border then continues to Azmon,
- The boundary line went past the town of Azmon,

It proceeded to Azmon: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border then continued to Azmon

The boundary line went past the town of Azmon

15:4b

joined the Brook of Egypt,

- follows the river on the border with Egypt,
- and continued along the Egypt River

joined the Brook of Egypt: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Brook refers to a river. This river had water only in the rainy season. See Joshua 12:1 where this Hebrew word was translated “Valley.”

Brook of Egypt: The phrase Brook of Egypt refers to a river that drains rainwater from the Sinai Peninsula into the Mediterranean Sea. This river is usually dry but becomes a large river when it rains. It formed the boundary between Israel and Egypt. Today this river is called the Wadi el Arish.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

Stream of Egypt (NET)

River of Egypt (GW, KJV)

Wadi of Egypt (NIV, NJPS)

the stream on the border of Egypt (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary line followed the river valley on the border of Egypt

and continued along the Brook of Egypt

15:4c

and ended at the Sea.

- and ends at the Mediterranean Sea.
- until it reached the Mediterranean Sea.

and ended at the Sea: The term the Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and ended at the Mediterranean Sea

until it reached the Mediterranean Sea

15:4d**This was their southern border.**

- That is your southern border.
- This is the southern boundary line of the clan of Judah.

This was their southern border: Here the author speaks directly to the people of Judah. The BSB translates this as their southern border, while some English versions chose to translate this with a second person plural reference. For example:

All this describes your boundary on the south

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

their south boundary (NIV, NET)

That was the south border of the tribe of Judah

Joshua 15:5**Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5a

The east boundary of Judah is marked by the Dead Sea.

15:5a**The eastern border was the Salt Sea as far as the mouth of the Jordan.**

- ¶ Judah's eastern border is along the Salt Sea, to where the Jordan River flowed into it.
- ¶ The eastern boundary is the Dead Sea, going north to the mouth of the Jordan River.

The eastern border was the Salt Sea as far as the mouth of the Jordan: The Salt Sea is another name for the Dead Sea. The phrase as the mouth of the Jordan indicates that the east border of Judah's land extended the length of the Dead Sea, from its southern point to where the Dead Sea reached the Jordan River in the north.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Judah's east boundary was along the Dead Sea, from its south end to where the Jordan River flows into it

The border on the east was the Dead Sea, going north to the mouth of the Jordan River

Paragraph 15:5b-11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:5b**The northern border started**

- ¶ The northern border starts
- ¶ The boundary on the north begins at

The northern border started: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The north border ran

The boundary on the north began at

15:5c**from the bay of the sea at the mouth of the Jordan,**

- at the end of the Dead Sea, where it meets the Jordan River.
- the north end of the Dead Sea, where the Jordan River flows into it.

from the bay of the sea at the mouth of the Jordan:

The phrase the bay of the sea indicates the north end of the Dead Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

from the end of the Dead Sea where it meets the Jordan River

the north end of the Dead Sea where the Jordan River flows into it

Joshua 15:6

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b-11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:6a

went up to Beth-hoglah,

- From there the boundary ascends to the town of Beth-hoglah
- Then the border goes uphill to Beth-hoglah Town

went up to Beth-hoglah: The location of the town of Beth-hoglah is uncertain.

went up: The Dead Sea is at a low point, so the path from the Dead Sea to Beth-hoglah went uphill.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border went uphill to the town of Beth-hoglah

From there the border ascended to Beth-hoglah

15:6b

proceeded north of Beth-arabah,

- and continues north of the town of Beth-arabah.
- and goes north of Beth-arabah Town.

proceeded north of Beth-arabah: The location of the town of Beth-arabah is uncertain. 15:6 Rasmussen, p. 229.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and continued north of the town of Beth-arabah

and went on north of Beth-arabah

15:6c

and went up to the Stone of Bohan son of Reuben.

- Then the boundary ascends to the large stone of Bohan, the son of Reuben.
- The border continues westward, uphill to the stone of Bohan who was Reuben's son.

and went up to the Stone of Bohan son of Reuben:

The location of the Stone of Bohan is not known. Probably it was a large rock set up to remember an important event. In some languages it may be helpful to add a qualifier such as "big stone" or "large stone."

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border ascended to the large stone of Bohan the son of Reuben

The boundary continued west, uphill to the stone of Bohan who was the son of Reuben

Joshua 15:7

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b-11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:7a

Then the border went up to Debir from the Valley of Achor,

- The border ascends to Debir from the Valley of Achor.
- Then it continues along Trouble Valley, going up to Debir Town.

Then the border went up to Debir from the Valley of Achor: The location of the town of Debir is uncertain.

the Valley of Achor: the Valley of Achor was mentioned in Joshua 7:24. You should translate it the same

way in both places. If you translated it as “Valley of Trouble” in chapter 7 you should also do so here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary ascended from the Valley of Achor to the town of Debir

The border went up to the town of Debir from Trouble Valley

15:7b

turning north to Gilgal, which faces the Ascent of Adummim

- It turns north to Gilgal, which is across from the Pass of Adummim
- It goes north toward Gilgal Town, which faces the road going through the Adummim Pass

turning north: The phrase turning north indicates that the border turned north after reaching the town of Debir.

to Gilgal: The phrase to Gilgal indicates that when the border turned north it went toward the town of Gilgal.

Gilgal: This town of Gilgal is not the same as the Gilgal mentioned in Joshua 5:9.

which faces the Ascent of Adummim: The phrase the Ascent of Adummim refers to a pass that goes from east to west through the mountains. The road along this pass was the major road from the Dead Sea up to Jerusalem. The road was on the south side of this pass. The town of “Gilgal” was on the north side of the pass.15:7 Rasmussen, p. 225.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

it turned north to Gilgal, which faced the Pass of Adummim

it turned north toward Gilgal, which was on the north side of Adummim Pass, opposite the road that goes through the pass

15:7c

south of the ravine.

- on the south side of the valley.
- which is across the valley, on its southern side.

south of the ravine: The clause south of the ravine indicates that the road through mountains was on the south side of the pass.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

south of the valley

which was across the valley on its southern side

15:7d

It continued along the waters of En-shemesh

- The boundary continues west to the spring of En-shemesh,
- Then the border goes to En-shemesh Spring

Verses 7d through verse 8 describe the boundary as it swings south around Jerusalem, going from east to west.

It continued along the waters of En-shemesh: The phrase waters of En-shemesh refers to a spring called En-shemesh. En-shemesh Spring was near Jerusalem. This spring still exists today and is called Ain el-Hod.15:7 Rasmussen, p. 234.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary continued west to the spring of En-shemesh

Then the border went to En-shemesh Spring

15:7e

and came out at En-rogel.

- and southwest to En-rogel.
- and goes southwest to En-rogel Spring, which ends its southward direction.

and came out at En-rogel: The clause and came out at En-rogel means that this was the southernmost point of the border as it went south around Jerusalem.15:7 Boling and Wright, p 368. It does not mean that the border ended here.

En-rogel: The name En-rogel refers to a spring in the Kidron Valley south of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and went on to En-rogel Spring

and it went southwest to the spring of En-rogel, which ends its southward direction

Joshua 15:8

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b–11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:8a

From there the border went up the Valley of Hinnom

- The boundary then ascends through the valley of the son of Hinnom
- The border goes up the valley of the son of Hinnom

From there the border went up the Valley of Hinnom:

The clause the border went up indicates that the boundary line climbed in elevation from the spring of En-rogel through the Valley of Hinnom.

the Valley of Hinnom: The phrase Valley of Hinnom refers to a valley that is southwest of Jerusalem.

Hinnom: Hinnom is the name of a person. The Hebrew word ben hinnom means “son of Hinnom.” Some English versions keep the Hebrew word and say “valley of Ben Hinnom.” It is recommended that you follow the tradition of the major language version in your area when you translate this name.

Here are some ways that English versions translate this name:

valley of the son of Hinnom (RSV, ESV, KJV)

valley of Ben Hinnom (NET, NIV, NABRE, NASB, NJPS, GW, NLT)

Hinnom Valley (GNT, CEV)

15:8b

along the southern slope of the Jebusites (that is, Jerusalem)

- and along the southern slope of Jerusalem, where the Jebus people live.
- beside the hill to the south of the town of Jerusalem, which was then called Jebus.

along the southern slope of the Jebusites (that is, Jerusalem):

The phrase southern slope refers to the slope of the hill that is south of Jerusalem. 15:8 Aharoni, p. 255.

of the Jebusites: The term Jebusites refers to the Jebus people. Jebus was also the name of their town at the time of Joshua. Later King David conquered this town and renamed it Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

along the south slope of Jerusalem, where the Jebus people live

beside the hill to the south of Jerusalem, which was then called Jebus

15:8c

and ascended to the top of the hill

- The border then climbs up to the top of the mountain
- From there the border goes up to the peak of the mountain

and ascended to the top of the hill: The clause ascended to the top of the hill indicates that the border continued to climb up until it reached the top of a mountain.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

the border climbed up to the top of the mountain

15:8d

that faces the Valley of Hinnom on the west,

- which is on the west side of the valley of Hinnom.
- on the west edge of Hinnom Valley

that faces the Valley of Hinnom on the west: The clause faces the Valley of Hinnom on the west indicates that the mountain is on the west side of the Valley of Hinnom.

the Valley of Hinnom: The Valley of Hinnom is the same place as the “Valley of Hinnom” in verse 15:8a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

which is on the west side of the valley of Hinnom

on the west side of the Hinnom Valley

15:8e
at the northern end of the Valley of Rephaim.

- It is on the northern side of the valley of Rephaim.
- and on the north edge of Rephaim Valley.

at the northern end of the Valley of Rephaim: The Rephaim people were mentioned in Joshua 12:4 and you should translate the term the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

That mountain is on the northern side of the valley of Rephaim

It is on the northern edge of the Rephaim Valley

Joshua 15:9

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land
This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b-11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:9a
From the hilltop the border curved

- From the peak of that mountain the border goes downhill northwest
- Then the border turns from the mountain top to go down

From the hilltop the border curved: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the peak of that mountain the border went downward northwest

Then the border turned from the mountain top to go down

15:9b
to the spring of the Waters of Nephtoah,

- to the spring of Nephtoah.
- to Nephtoah Spring.

to the spring of the Waters of Nephtoah: The phrase the spring of the Waters of Nephtoah refers to a spring northwest of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

to the spring of Nephtoah

to the Nephtoah Spring

15:9c
proceeded to the cities of Mount Ephron,

- The border continues up to the towns around Mount Ephron.
- The border goes from there to the towns near Ephron Mountain.

proceeded to the cities of Mount Ephron: Mount Ephron was west of Jerusalem, but its exact location is uncertain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued to the towns around Mount Ephron

The border went from there to the towns near Ephron Mountain

15:9d
and then bent around toward Baalah (that is, Kiriath-jearim).

- Then it turns west toward the town of Baalah. That town is called Kiriath-jearim today.
- Then the border continues down to Baalah Town, which is now called Kiriath-jearim Town.

and then bent around toward Baalah (that is, Kiriath-jearim): The town of Kiriath-jearim is men-

tioned in Joshua 9:17. It is at a lower elevation than the towns around Mount Ephron.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then it turned west toward the town of Baalah.
That town is called Kiriath-jearim today

Then the border continued down to Baalah, which is now called Kiriath-jearim

Joshua 15:10

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b–11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:10a

The border curled westward from Baalah to Mount Seir,

- The border then curves to the west of Baalah on to Mount Seir.
- The border goes in a curve west from Baalah Town and arrives at Mount Seir.

The border curled westward from Baalah to Mount Seir: The clause curled westward from Baalah to Mount Seir indicates that the border line was not straight. It went on a curve as it went westward to Mount Seir.

Mount Seir: The location of this mountain is uncertain. It may be a mountain ridge west of Kiriath-jearim and north of Chesalon, about eleven miles west of Jerusalem. 15:10 Rasmussen, p. 250.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border then curved to the west of the town of Baalah to Mount Seir

The border went in a curve west from Baalah to Seir Mountain

15:10b

ran along the northern slope of Mount Jearim (that is, Chesalon),

- It descends on to the northern side of Mount Jearim (also called Chesalon).
- Then the border goes down along the northern ridge of Mount Jearim (which is also called Mount Chesalon).

ran along the northern slope of Mount Jearim (that is, Chesalon): The phrase the northern slope of Mount Jearim refers to the northern ridge of Mount Jearim.

Mount Jearim (that is, Chesalon): Mount Jearim was one of the low hills west of Jerusalem.

There is an interpretation issue here. There are two ways to understand the relationship between Chesalon and Mount Jearim.

1. Chesalon is another name for Mount Jearim. For example, the ESV says:

Mount Jearim (that is Chesalon) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NET, NIV, GW, NJPS, GNT, KJV)

1. Chesalon is the name of a town. For example:

the town of Kesalon on the northern slope of Mount Jearim (NLT) (NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions. 15:10 In modern times there is a town in this area called Kesla. Thus, it is possible that there was an ancient town called Chesalon. See Woudstra, p. 255–256.

Chesalon: Here are some ways that the English versions spell this word:

Chesalon (BSB, ESV, RSV, GW, GNT, CEV, NABRE, NJPS, KJV)

Kesalon (NIV, NET, NLT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued to the northern side of Mount Jearim (also called Mount Chesalon)

Then the border went down along the northern ridge of Mount Jearim (which is also called Mount Chesalon)

15:10c

went down to Beth-shemesh, and crossed to Timnah.

- It continues going down southwest to Beth-shemesh and then northwest to Timnah.
- The border descends to Beth-shemesh Town and goes to Timnah Town.

went down to Beth-shemesh, and crossed to Timnah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border descended to the town of Beth-shemesh and went on to the town of Timnah

It continued going down southwest to Beth-shemesh and then northwest to Timnah

crossed to Timnah: There is an interpretation issue here:

1. The border goes to the town of Timnah. For example:

and on to Timnah (GW) (BSB, GW, NIV, NET, NABRE, NJPS, CEV, NLT, KJV)

1. The border passes by the town of Timnah. For example:

passes along by Timnah (ESV) (ESV, RSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the option taken by most English versions. However, the Hebrew grammar can be understood either way, and probably both are true.

Joshua 15:11

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land
This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:5b-11

The north boundary of Judah started from the north end of the Dead Sea and went west from there to the Mediterranean Sea. This boundary did not go in a straight line. It swung south to avoid Jerusalem, which was part of the territory of Benjamin.

15:11a

Then it went out to the northern slope of Ekron,

- The border then goes along the slope of the hill to the north of Ekron.
- It continues along the hillside north of Ekron Town.

Then it went out to the northern slope of Ekron: The phrase the northern slope indicates a mountain slope.

Ekron: The town of Ekron was one of the five most important towns of the Philistines. It was southwest of Timnah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It continued along the hillside north of the town of Ekron

The border then went on along the slope of the hill to the north of Ekron

15:11b

curved toward Shikkeron,

- Then it curves westward toward Shikkeron.
- There the border turns to go west to Shikkeron Town.

curved toward Shikkeron: The town of Shikkeron lies between the town of Ekron and the town of Jabneel.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then it curved westward toward the town of Shikkeron

Then the border turned to go west to Shikkeron

15:11c

proceeded to Mount Baalah, went on to Jabneel,

- It goes on west to Mount Baalah and down to Jabneel.
- It goes along to Baalah Mountain and down to Jabneel Town.

proceeded to Mount Baalah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It went on west to Mount Baalah

The border went along to Baalah Mountain

went on to Jabneel: The town of Jabneel is northwest of the town of Shikkeron. In later times Jabneel was referred to as Jamnia. The GNT uses the name Jamnia.

15:11d and ended at the Sea.

- There it ends at the Mediterranean Sea.
- Then it goes on to its end at the Mediterranean Sea.

and ended at the Sea: The term the Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued down to the town of Jabneel and then went on to end at the Mediterranean Sea

The border went to Jabneel and ended at the Mediterranean Sea

Joshua 15:12

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:12

The west boundary of Judah is the coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

15:12a And the western border was the coastline of the Great Sea.

- ¶ The western border runs along the shore of the Mediterranean Sea.
- ¶ The coast of the Mediterranean Sea forms the western border.

And the western border was the coastline of the Great Sea: The phrase the coastline of the Great Sea indicates that the western border of Judah's land was the coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The western border ran along the shore of the Mediterranean Sea

The Mediterranean Sea was the western border

15:12b These are the boundaries around the clans of the descendants of Judah.

- The sub-clans of the clan of Judah lived within these boundaries.
- The boundary described above was the boundary of the land that belonged to the sub-clans of the clan of Judah.

Verse 15:12b is a conclusion to verses 1–12.

These are the boundaries around the clans of the descendants of Judah: The phrase the clans of the descendants of Judah refers to all the families or clans within the tribe of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clans of the tribe of Judah lived within these borders

The boundary described above was the boundary of the land that belonged to the families of the tribe of Judah

Joshua 15:13

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:13a

According to the LORD's command to him,

- ¶ As Yahweh commanded Joshua to do,
- ¶ Yahweh had commanded Joshua

According to the LORD's command to him: In this paragraph more information is given about Caleb.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh had commanded Joshua

As Yahweh had instructed Joshua

15:13b

Joshua gave Caleb son of Jephunneh a portion among the sons of Judah—

- he gave a part of the land that belonged to Judah to Caleb the son of Jephunneh.
- to give Caleb some land within the borders of Judah, and Joshua did so.

Joshua gave Caleb son of Jephunneh a portion among the sons of Judah: The phrase a portion among the sons of Judah indicates that Joshua gave Caleb some land within the boundaries of the tribe of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate verse 13a-b:

Yahweh had commanded Joshua to give Caleb the son of Jephunneh some land within the borders of Judah. So he gave it to him

As Yahweh instructed Joshua to do, he gave some land in Judah to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 13a and 13b. For example:

Joshua gave Caleb the son of Jephunneh a piece of land within the boundaries of the tribe of Judah, as Yahweh had told him to do

15:13c

Kiriath-arba, that is, Hebron.

- He gave him the town of Kiriath-arba, which is now called Hebron.
- He received the town of Hebron which was formerly called Kiriath-arba

Kiriath-arba, that is, Hebron: The term Kiriath-arba refers to the town that Joshua gave to Caleb. In Hebrew the word Kiriath-arba means “town of Arba.” Some English versions translate it this way. For example:

Caleb's share was Hebron, which at that time was known as Arba's Town (CEV)

Hebron: Hebron was the name of the town of Kiriath-arba at the time the book of Joshua was written.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The town Joshua gave him was Kiriath-arba, but it is now called Hebron

He gave Caleb the town of Hebron, which in former times was called Kiriath-arba

15:13d

(Arba was the forefather of Anak.)

- Arba was the ancestor of the Anak people.
- because Arba was the ancestor of the people of Anak.

Arba was the forefather of Anak: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the forefather of Anak is more literally “the father of the Anak.” The word “father” in Hebrew is often used to mean ancestor. For example:

Arba was the ancestor of the Anak people-group (T4T)

Anak: There is an interpretation issue concerning the word Anak.

1. The word Anak refers to a group of people, the descendants of a man called Anak. For example:

because Arba was the famous ancestor of the Anakim (CEV, NIV)

1. The word Anak refers to a person, the son of a man named Arba. For example:

Arba was the father of Anak (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NET, ESV, GW, GNT, NJPS, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) which is supported by Hebrew grammars and is implied by the information in verse 14:15.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Arba was the ancestor of the Anak people

Arba was the ancestor of the people of Anak

15:13b-c (reordered) Joshua gave Caleb the son of Jephunneh a piece of land within the boundaries of the clan of Judah, as Yahweh had told him to.

Joshua 15:14

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:14a

And Caleb drove out from there the three sons of Anak—

- Caleb forced the three clans of Anak people to leave there.
- Caleb attacked the three clans of Anak who lived in Hebron and made them leave.

And Caleb drove out from there the three sons of Anak: The clause Caleb drove out from there indicates

that Caleb attacked the three sons of Anak and made them leave Hebron.

the three sons of Anak: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sons can refer to a group of descendants. In this verse it is likely that the three sons of Anak refers to three tribes of the descendants of Anak.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Caleb forced three tribes of Anak people to leave there

Caleb attacked the three tribes of Anak people who lived in Hebron and made them leave

15:14b

the descendants of Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai, the children of Anak.

- Those were the clans of Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai, descended from Anak.
- They were the descendants of Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai. Anak was their ancestor.

the descendants of Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai, the children of Anak: The names Sheshai, Ahiman, and Talmai refer to three tribes. Anak was their forefather. These tribes are also mentioned in Numbers 13:22 and Judges 1:10.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Those were the tribes of Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmai, all descended from Anak

Those were the tribes of Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmai, all descended from Anak

These were the descendants of Sheshai, Ahiman and Talmai, who were descended from Anak

Joshua 15:15

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:15a

From there he marched against the inhabitants of Debir

- Then he went on from Hebron to fight the people of Debir.
- After that Caleb attacked the town of Debir

From there he marched against the inhabitants of Debir: The town called Debir in this verse is not the same as the place mentioned in 15:7. The location of this town is not clear.

he marched: Caleb marched uphill to fight against the people of Debir. Hebrew verbs keep track of elevation, and thus it says “went up.” If your language does not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to say “went.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then he went from Hebron to fight the people of Debir

Caleb next went to attack the town of Debir

15:15b

(formerly known as Kiriath-sepher).

- In past times Debir was called Kiriath-sepher.
- which used to be called Kiriath-sepher.

Debir (formerly known as Kiriath-sepher): Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in past times the name of Debir was Kiriath-sepher

the town of Debir used to be called Kiriath-sepher

Joshua 15:16

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:16a

And Caleb said, “To the man who strikes down Kiriath-sepher and captures it,

- Caleb said, “Whoever attacks Kiriath-sepher and captures it,
- Then Caleb said, “The man who fights and defeats the town of Kiriath-sepher

And Caleb said, “To the man who strikes down Kiriath-sepher and captures it: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as strikes means “to hit.” This is a Hebrew idiom which means that somebody would attack Kiriath-sepher and capture it.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

whoever defeats the town of Kiriath-sepher

the man who attacks the town of Kiriath-sepher and captures it

15:16b

I will give my daughter Acsah in marriage.”

- I will give my daughter Achsah to him to be his wife.”
- can marry my daughter Achsah.”

I will give my daughter Acsah in marriage: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I will give my daughter Acsah to him to be his wife

I will let him marry my daughter Acsah

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the order of 16a and 16b. For example:

I will let my daughter Acsah marry the man who defeats the town of Kiriath-sepher

Joshua 15:17

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land
This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:17a

So Othniel son of Caleb's brother Kenaz captured the city,

- Then Othni-el defeated that town. Othni-el was the son of Kenaz, who was Caleb's younger brother.
- Othni-el, who was the son of Caleb's younger brother Kenaz, captured Kiriath-sepher town.

So Othniel son of Caleb's brother Kenaz captured the city: Kenaz was the father of Othniel and the younger brother of Caleb.

Othniel: Here are some ways that English versions spell the name of this person.

Othni-el (RSV, KJV)

Othniel (NET, ESV, NIV, GW, NJPS, GNT, NLT, CEV)

captured the city: The clause captured the city indicates that Othniel attacked and defeated the town of Kiriath-sepher.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Othni-el defeated that town. Othni-el was the son of Kenaz, who was Caleb's younger brother

Othni-el, who was the son of Caleb's younger brother Kenaz, captured the town of Kiriath-sepher

15:17b

and Caleb gave his daughter Acsah to him in marriage.

- Then Caleb gave his daughter Achsah to Othni-el to be his wife.
- So Caleb let him marry his daughter Achsah.

and Caleb gave his daughter Acsah to him in marriage: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So Caleb gave Othniel his daughter Acsah to be his wife

So Caleb let Othniel marry his daughter Acsah

Joshua 15:18

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land
This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:18a

One day Acsah came to Othniel and urged him to ask her father for a field.

- When she arrived to marry him, she urged Othni-el to ask her father for a field.
- When she became his wife, Achsah told Othni-el to ask her father to give her a field.

One day Acsah came to Othniel and urged him to ask her father for a field: There is an interpretation issue with the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as One day Acsah came to Othniel.

1. It refers to the time of Acsah's marriage to Othniel. For example:

On the wedding day (GNT) (GNT, NLT, CEV)

1. It refers to an unspecified day. For example:

One day when she came to Othniel (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which is supported by commentaries^{15:18} See for example, Woudstra, p. 241. and by several English versions.

urged him: There is a textual issue with this Hebrew word.

1. The Hebrew text and most Greek translations read “she urged him.” For example:

she urged him (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, RSV, NABRE, NJPS, NLT, CEV, GW, NCV, KJV)

1. One Greek translation reads “he urged her.” For example:

Othniel urged her (GNT) (GNT, NET, NEB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). These are the words of the Hebrew text and of most Greek manuscripts and the reading followed by most English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When Acsah came to marry Othni-el, she urged Othni-el to ask her father for a field

When she became his wife, Acsah told Othni-el to ask her father to give her a field

15:18b

When she got off her donkey,

- So Achsah got down from her donkey
- Then Achsah went to see her father, Caleb. As she got off her donkey

When she got off her donkey: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Achsah got down from her donkey

as she got off her donkey

To make a smoother transition between 18a and 18b, some English versions add implied information. The implied information is underlined below. For example:

Right after the wedding, Achsah started telling Othniel that he ought to ask her father for a field. She went to see her father, and while she was getting down from her donkey (CEV)

When Caleb’s daughter married Othniel, she told him to ask her father to give her a field. Then Acsah went to talk with her father Caleb. As she got down from her donkey (T4T)

It is recommended that you add implied information if it will help readers to understand the meaning clearly.

15:18c

Caleb asked her, “What do you desire?”

- And Caleb asked her, “What do you want?”
- Caleb asked her, “What shall I do for you?”

Caleb asked her, “What do you desire?”: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and Caleb asked her “What do you want?”

Caleb asked her, “What can I do for you?”

Joshua 15:19

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:13–19

This paragraph tells about Caleb and his daughter Acsah (also spelled Aksah or Achsah in other English versions). The story of Caleb starts in Numbers 13. In Joshua 14:6–15 Caleb received land from Joshua. In this paragraph Caleb gave Acsah a gift of land when she married Othni-el.

15:19a

“Give me a blessing,” she answered.

- She said, “Give me a gift as a sign of your blessing.”

- Achsah answered, “Do something to show that you have blessed me.”

“Give me a blessing,” she answered: In this context, the blessing that Achsah asks for is a gift. She asks her father to give her a source of water for her land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Give me a gift as a sign of your blessing

Do something to show that you have blessed me

15:19b

“Since you have given me land in the Negev,

- You have given me land in the dry southern region,
- You gave me dry land in the south,

Since you have given me land in the Negev: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as you have given me is more literally “You gave me.” The word Negev often refers to the dry desert land in the south of Judah. In this context it probably refers to dry land south of the town of Debir. Caleb gave Debir to Othni-el. The town had no natural water source, so Achsah asked to be given a source of water that was nearby. 15:19 Coleson, p. 132–134.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because you have given me land in the dry south region

since you have given me dry land in the south

15:19c

give me springs of water as well.”

- please give me pools of water as well.”
- so give me some springs of water also.”

give me springs of water as well:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

please give me springs of water as well

give me water holes also

15:19d

So Caleb gave her both the upper and lower springs.

- So Caleb gave her both the higher and the lower springs.
- Then Caleb gave Achsah the upper and the lower pools of water near Hebron.

So Caleb gave her both the upper and lower springs:

It is most likely that these water sources were near Hebron.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Caleb gave Achsah the upper and lower pools of water

Joshua 15:20

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:20a

This is the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Judah.

- ¶ This is the land that God gave to the people of the clan of Judah. Each sub-clan received their own share of the land.
- ¶ The following list shows the towns that the Judah clan received. Every sub-clan received its own land.

This is the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Judah: The word inheritance refers to the land which God gave to the people of the tribe of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This is the land that God promised to the people who belonged to the tribe of Judah

The following list shows the towns that the Judah tribe received

the clans: The phrase that the BSB translates as clans means that each clan or group of families received their own share of the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Each clan received their own share of the land

Every family got their own land

Joshua 15:21

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:21a

These were the southernmost cities of the tribe of Judah in the Negev

- These are the southernmost towns which the people belonging to the clan of Judah received.
- These are the towns in the farthest south which belonged to the Judah people

These were the southernmost cities of the tribe of Judah in the Negev: The phrase the southernmost cities indicates the southern part of the land that the tribe of Judah received.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These are the southernmost towns which the people of the tribe of Judah received

The towns in the farthest south which belonged to the people of Judah

15:21b

toward the border of Edom: Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur,

- These towns were close to the border of the land of Edom: Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur,
- near the border of the land of Edom. They are as follows: Kabzeel Town and Eder Town and Jagur Town,

toward the border of Edom: Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur:

The phrase toward the border of Edom indicates that the towns listed in this paragraph were close to the border of the land of Edom.

Edom: The term Edom refers to a kingdom that was southeast of Judah. It was mentioned in Joshua 15:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These towns were close to the border of the land of Edom: Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur...

they were near the border of the Edom Kingdom. They are as follows: Kabzeel, Eder, Jagur...

Joshua 15:22

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:22

Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah,

- Kinah, Dimonah, and Adadah.
- Kinah Town and Dimonah Town and Adadah Town.

Kinah, Dimonah, Adadah:

Joshua 15:23

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:23

Kedesh, Hazor, Ithnan,

- Kedesh, Hazor, Ithnan,
- Kedesh Town and Hazor Town and Ithnan Town,

Kedesh, Hazor, Ithnan:

Joshua 15:24

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:24

Ziph, Telem, Bealoth,

- Ziph, Telem, Be-aloth,
- Ziph Town and Telem Town and Be-aloth Town,

Ziph, Telem, Bealoth:

Joshua 15:25

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:25

Hazor-hadattah, Keriath-hezron (that is, Hazor),

- Hazor-hadattah, and Keri-oth-hezron which is also called Hazor.
- Hazor-hadattah Town and Keri-oth-hezron Town which is also known as Hazor Town.

Hazor-hadattah, Keriath-hezron (that is, Hazor):

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Hazor-hadattah, Keri-oth-hezron which is also called Hazor

Hazor-hadattah, Keri-oth-hezron which is now known as Hazor

Joshua 15:26

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:26

Amam, Shema, Moladah,

- Amam, Shema, Moladah,
- Amam Town and Shema Town and Moladah Town,

Amam, Shema, Moladah:

Joshua 15:27

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:27

Hazar-gaddah, Heshmon, Beth-pelet,

- Hazar-gaddah, Heshmon, and Beth-pelet.
- Hazar-gaddah Town and Heshmon Town and Beth-pelet Town.

Hazar-gaddah, Heshmon, Beth-pelet:

Joshua 15:28

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:28

Hazar-shual, Beersheba, Biziothiah,

- Hazar-shual, Beer-sheba, Biziothiah,
- Hazar-shual Town and Beer-sheba Town and Biziothiah Town,

Hazar-shual, Beersheba, Biziothiah:

Joshua 15:29

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:29

Baalalah, Iim, Ezem,

- Baalalah, Iim, and Ezem.
- Baalalah Town and Iim Town and Ezem Town.

Baalalah, Iim, Ezem:

Joshua 15:30

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:30

Eltolad, Chesil, Hormah,

- Eltolad, Chesil, Hormah,
- Eltolad Town and Chesil Town and Hormah Town,

Eltolad, Chesil, Hormah:

Joshua 15:31

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:31

Ziklag, Madmannah, Sansannah,

- Ziklag, Madmannah, Sansannah,
- Ziklag Town and Madmannah Town and Sansannah Town,

Ziklag, Madmannah, Sansannah:

Joshua 15:32

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:20–32

This paragraph is a list of the towns that the tribe of Judah received in the southern part of their land. After the paragraph there are several other paragraphs that list towns throughout the territory of Judah.

15:32a

Lebaoth, Shilhim, Ain, and Rimmon—

- Lebaoth, Shilhim, Ain, and Rimmon.
- Lebaoth Town and Shilhim Town and Ain Town and Rimmon Town.

Lebaoth, Shilhim, Ain, and Rimmon:

15:32b

twenty-nine cities in all, along with their villages.

- The total was twenty-nine towns and the villages that surrounded them.
- In all there were twenty-nine (29) towns, with villages around them.

twenty-nine cities in all, along with their villages:

Most towns in the time of Joshua were very small. They had a wall for protection and a ruler of their own. Outside the walls of the town, there were villages that depended on that town for protection.

The list of town names in verses 15:21–32 adds up to thirty-six towns. It is not clear why the author says twenty-nine. It is possible that seven of the towns were small settlements that did not have villages attached to them. It is recommended that you translate this as twenty-nine.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The total was twenty-nine towns and the villages that surrounded them

In all there were 29 towns, with the villages around them

Joshua 15:33

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:33–36

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the western foothills that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:33

These were in the foothills: Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah,

- ¶ The towns belonging to the clan of Judah that were in the foothills were: Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah,
- ¶ These are the towns that the people of Judah received in the low hills to the west: Eshtaol Town and Zorah Town and Ashnah Town,

These were in the foothills: Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah:

The word foothills refers to the western foothills that were between the mountains and the coastal plain.

This word was used in Joshua 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The towns belonging to the tribe of Judah that were in the foothills were: Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah,

These are the towns that the people of Judah received in the hilly land to the west: Eshtaol, Zorah, Ashnah,

Joshua 15:34

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:33–36

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the western foothills that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:34

Zanoah, En-gannim, Tappuah, Enam,

- Zanoah, En-gannim, Tappuah, and Enam.
- Zanoah Town and En-gannim Town and Tappuah Town and Enam Town.

Zanoah, En-gannim, Tappuah, Enam:

Joshua 15:35

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:33–36

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the western foothills that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:35

Jarmuth, Adullam, Socoh, Azekah,

- Jarmuth, Adullam, Socoh, Azekah,
- Jarmuth Town and Adullam Town and Socoh Town and Azekah Town,

Jarmuth, Adullam, Socoh, Azekah:

Joshua 15:36

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph 15:33–36

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the western foothills that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:36a

Shaaraim, Adithaim, and Gederah (or Gederothaim)

- Shaaraim, Adithaim. Gederah, and Gederothaim.
- Shaaraim Town and Adithaim Town and Gederah Town and Gederothaim Town.

Shaaraim, Adithaim, and Gederah (or Gederothaim): There are two ways to interpret the names Gederah and Gederothaim.

1. These names refer to two different places. For example:

Gederah and Gederothaim (GW) (GW, ESV, NASB, RSV, NABRE, NJPS, GNT, NLT, CEV, KJV)

1. These names refer to one place that has two different names. For example, the NIV says:

Gederah (or Gederothaim) (BSB, NIV, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with the Hebrew text and is followed by most English versions.^{15:36} If Gederah and Gederothaim are two names for the same place, then the list in this paragraph comes to a total of fourteen towns.

15:36b**fourteen cities, along with their villages.**

- In all there were fourteen towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was fourteen (14), with the villages that were near them.

fourteen cities, along with their villages: The list of town names in verses 15:33–36 adds up to fifteen towns. It is not clear why the author says fourteen. It is possible that one of the towns was a small settlement that did not have villages attached to it. It is recommended that you translate this as fourteen.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were fourteen towns together with the villages that surrounded them

The number of towns was fourteen, and there were villages that were near them

Joshua 15:37**Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:37–41

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:37**Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal-gad,**

- ¶ They also received Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal-gad,
- ¶ There was also Zenan Town and Hadashah Town and Migdal-gad Town,

Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal-gad: This is the beginning of a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Zenan, Hadashah, Migdal-gad...

Joshua 15:38**Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:37–41

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:38**Dilan, Mizpeh, Joktheel,**

- Dilean, Mizpeh, and Joktheel.
- Dilean Town and Mizpeh Town and Joktheel Town.

Dilan, Mizpeh, Joktheel:**Joshua 15:39****Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:37–41

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:39**Lachish, Bozkath, Eglon,**

- Lachish, Bozkath, Eglon,
- Lachish Town and Bozkath Town and Eglon Town,

Lachish, Bozkath, Eglon:**Joshua 15:40****Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:37–41

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:40

Cabbon, Lahmas, Chitlish,

- Cabbon, Lahmam, and Chitlish.
- Cabbon Town and Lahmam Town and Chitlish Town.

Cabbon, Lahmas, Chitlish:

Joshua 15:41

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:37–41

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:41a

Gederoth, Beth-dagon, Naamah, and Makkedah—

- Gederoth, Beth-dagon, Naamah, and Makkedah.
- Gederoth Town and Beth-dagon Town and Naamah Town and Makkedah Town.

Gederoth, Beth-dagon, Naamah, and Makkedah:

15:41b

sixteen cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were sixteen towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was sixteen (16), with the villages that were near them.

sixteen cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in all there were sixteen towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

the number of these towns was sixteen, and there were villages that were near them

Joshua 15:42

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:42–44

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:42

Libnah, Ether, Ashan,

- ¶ They also received Libnah, Ether, Ashan,
- ¶ There was also Libnah Town and Ether Town and Ashan Town,

Libnah, Ether, Ashan: This is the beginning of a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Libnah, Ether, Ashan...

Joshua 15:43

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:42–44

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:43

Iphtah, Ashnah, Nezib,

- Iphtah, Ashnah, Nezib,
- Iphtah Town and Ashnah Town and Nezib Town,

Iphtah, Ashnah, Nezib:

Joshua 15:44

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:42–44

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:44a

Keilah, Achzib, and Mareshah—

- Keilah, Achzib, and Mareshah.
- Keilah Town and Achzib Town and Mareshah Town.

Keilah, Achzib, and Mareshah:

15:44b

nine cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were nine towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was nine (9), with the villages that were near them.

nine cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in all there were nine towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

the number of these towns was nine, and there were villages that were near them

Joshua 15:45

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:45–47

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:45

Ekron, with its towns and villages;

- ¶ There was also Ekron, together with the towns and villages that surrounded it.
- ¶ The people of Judah also received Ekron Town with its nearby towns and villages.

Ekron, with its towns and villages: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as towns is literally “daughters.” It refers to small settlements that were dependent on a larger town.^{15:45 Boling and Wright p. 387.}

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

There was also the town of Ekron, together with the towns and villages that surrounded it

The people of Judah also received Ekron, with its nearby towns and villages

Joshua 15:46

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:45–47

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:46

from Ekron to the sea, all the cities near Ashdod, along with their villages;

- From Ekron westward to the Mediterranean Sea, all the towns that were near Ashdod and their villages belonged to Judah.
- They received the villages near Ashdod Town, which was between Ekron Town and the Mediterranean Sea.

from Ekron to the sea, all the cities near Ashdod: The phrase from Ekron to the sea refers to the area

between the town of Ekron and the coast of the Mediterranean Sea.

Ashdod: The town of Ashdod was one of the five most important towns of the Philistines. Ashdod was on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea. It was the largest town between Ekron and the Mediterranean Sea.

along with their villages: The phrase their villages refers to the villages that were near these towns.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

This included all the cities with their villages between Ekron and the Mediterranean Sea and alongside Ashdod (GW)

Joshua 15:47

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:45–47

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:47a

Ashdod, with its towns and villages; Gaza, with its towns and villages,

- The town of Ashdod together with its towns and villages also belonged to them.
- They also received the town of Ashdod and the towns and villages that were near it.

Ashdod, with its towns and villages; Gaza, with its towns and villages: The town of Gaza was another one of the five most important towns of the Philistines.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The town of Ashdod together with its towns and villages, and the town of Gaza together with its towns and villages also belonged to the people of Judah

They also received Ashdod and Gaza, and the towns and villages that were near them

15:47b

as far as the Brook of Egypt and the coastline of the Great Sea.

- They also had the places south along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea, up to the Brook of Egypt.
- This area reached south along the Mediterranean Sea to the river at the border of Egypt.

as far as the Brook of Egypt and the coastline of the Great Sea: The phrase Brook of Egypt occurred in Joshua 15:4, and you translate it the same way in both places.

the Great Sea: The phrase Great Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea. This indicates that all the towns and villages near Ashdod and Gaza, and along the shore of the Mediterranean south to the Brook of Egypt, belonged to the people of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and all the places southward along the coast of the Mediterranean Sea to the Brook of Egypt

This area reached all the way south along the shore of the Mediterranean Sea, to the stream at the border of Egypt

Joshua 15:48

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:48–51

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the hill country that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:48

These were in the hill country: Shamir, Jattir, Socoh,

- ¶ The towns that the people of Judah received in the hill country were Shamir, Jattir, Socoh,

- ¶ The clan of Judah received the following towns in the mountainous region: Shamir Town and Jattir Town and Socoh Town,

These were in the hill country: Shamir, Jattir, Socoh: The phrase hill country refers to the mountainous region in the land that Judah received. This phrase occurred in Joshua 9:1 and you should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The towns that the people of Judah received in the hill country were Shamir, Jattir, Socoh...

The tribe of Judah received the following towns in the mountainous region: Shamir, Jattir, Socoh...

Joshua 15:49

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:48–51

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the hill country that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:49

Dannah, Kiriath-sannah (that is, Debir),

- Dannah, and Kiriath-sannah which is also known as Debir.
- Dannah Town and Kiriath-sannah Town which is also called Debir Town.

Dannah, Kiriath-sannah (that is, Debir):

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Dannah, Kiriath-sannah which is also known as Debir

Dannah, Kiriath-sannah which is also called Debir

Joshua 15:50

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:48–51

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the hill country that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:50

Anab, Eshtemoh, Anim,

- Anab, Eshtemoh, Anim,
- Anab Town and Eshtemoh Town and Anim Town,

Anab, Eshtemoh, Anim:

Joshua 15:51

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:48–51

This paragraph is a list of the towns in the hill country that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:51a

Goshen, Holon, and Giloh—

- Goshen, Holon, and Giloh.
- Goshen Town and Holon Town and Giloh Town.

Goshen, Holon, and Giloh:

15:51b

eleven cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were eleven towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was eleven (11), with the villages that were near them.

eleven cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were eleven towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

The number of these towns was eleven, with the villages that were near them

Joshua 15:52

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:52–54

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:52

Arab, Dumah, Eshan,

- ¶ They also received Arab, Dumah, Eshan,
- ¶ There was also Arab Town and Dumah Town and Eshan Town,

Arab, Dumah, Eshan: This is the beginning of a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Arab, Dumah, Eshan...

Joshua 15:53

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:52–54

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:53

Janim, Beth-tappuah, Aphekah,

- Janim, Beth-tappuah, Aphekah,
- Janim Town and Beth-tappuah Town and Aphekah Town.

Janim, Beth-tappuah, Aphekah:

Joshua 15:54

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:52–54

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:54a

Humtah, Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron), and Zior—

- Humtah, Kiriath-arba, which is also called Hebron, and Zior.
- Humtah Town and Kiriath-arba Town which also has the name Hebron Town, and Zior Town.

Humtah, Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron), and Zior:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Humtah, Kiriath-arba which is also called Hebron, and Zior

Humtah, Kiriath-arba which now has the name Hebron, and Zior

15:54b

nine cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were nine towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was nine (9), with the villages that were near them.

nine cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were nine towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

The number of these towns was nine, with the villages that were near them

Joshua 15:55

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:55–57

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:55

Maon, Carmel, Ziph, Juttah,

- ¶ They also received Maon, Carmel, Ziph, Juttah,
- ¶ There was also Maon Town and Carmel Town and Ziph Town and Juttah Town,

Maon, Carmel, Ziph, Juttah: This is the beginning of a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Maon, Carmel, Ziph, Juttah...

Joshua 15:56

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:55–57

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:56

Jezreel, Jokdeam, Zanoah,

- Jezreel, Jokde-am, and Zanoah.
- Jezreel Town and Jokde-am Town and Zanoah Town.

Jezreel, Jokdeam, Zanoah:

Joshua 15:57

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:55–57

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:57a

Kain, Gibeah, and Timnah—

- Kain, Gibeah, and Timnah.
- Kain Town and Gibeah Town and Timnah Town.

Kain, Gibeah, and Timnah:

15:57b

ten cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were ten towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was ten (10), with the villages that were near them.

ten cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were ten towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

The number of these towns was ten, with the villages that were near them

Joshua 15:58

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:58–59

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:58

Halhul, Beth-zur, Gedor,

- ¶ There were also Halhul, Beth-zur, Gedor,
- ¶ There was also Halhul Town and Beth-zur Town and Gedor Town,

Halhul, Beth-zur, Gedor: This is the beginning of a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Halhul, Beth-zur, Gedor...

Joshua 15:59

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:58–59

This paragraph is a list of more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:59a

Maarath, Beth-anoth, and Eltekon—

- Maarath, Beth-anoth, and Eltekon.
- Maarath Town and Beth-anoth Town and Eltekon Town.

Maarath, Beth-anoth, and Eltekon:

15:59b

six cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were six towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was six (6), with the villages that were near them.

six cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were six towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

The number of these towns was six, with the villages that were near them

Joshua 15:60

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:60

This paragraph names two more towns that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:60a

Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim), and Rabbah—

- ¶ There were also Kiriath-baal which is also called Kiriath-jearim, and Rabbah.
- ¶ They also received Kiriath-baal Town which also has the name Kiriath-jearim Town, and Rabbah Town.

Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim), and Rabbah:

This is a new list of towns. It may be helpful to make this clear.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

There were also the towns of Kiriath-baal which is also known as Kiriath-jearim, and Rabbah

Also there were Kiriath-baal whose other name is Kiriath-jearim, and Rabbah

15:60b

two cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were two towns and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was two (2), with the villages that were near them.

two cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The total of these was two towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.

The number of these towns was two, with the villages that were near them.

Joshua 15:61

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:61–62

This paragraph is a list of towns in the wilderness that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:61

These were in the wilderness: Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah,

- ¶ The towns that were in the wilderness were Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah,
- ¶ The people of Judah also received towns in the wilderness near the Dead Sea. These were Beth-arabah Town and Middin Town and Secacah Town,

These were in the wilderness: Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah: The phrase the wilderness refers to the area near the Dead Sea, on its west side. This was a desert area.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The towns in the wilderness were Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah,

The people of Judah also received towns in the wilderness near the Dead Sea. These were Beth-arabah, Middin, Secacah,

Joshua 15:62

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:61–62

This paragraph is a list of towns in the wilderness that were given to the tribe of Judah.

15:62a

Nibshan, the City of Salt, and En-gedi—

- Nibshan and the Town of Salt and En-gedi.
- Nibshan Town and Ir Hamelah Town and En-gedi Town.

Nibshan, the City of Salt, and En-gedi: The phrase City of Salt is a translation of the Hebrew words Ir Hamelah. Some English versions transliterate this phrase instead of translating it.

Here are some ways that English versions translate this name:

City of Salt (BSB, RSV, NET, ESV, NIV, NLT, KJV)

Salt City (GNT)

Salt Town (CEV)

Ir Hamelah (GW, NABRE)

15:62b

six cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were six towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these towns was six (6), with the villages that surrounded them.

six cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there were six towns, and there were villages that surrounded them

The number of these towns was six, with the villages that were near them.

Joshua 15:63

Section 15:1–63 The tribe of Judah received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the tribe of Judah and lists the towns that are within those boundaries.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The boundaries of Judah

The land of the tribe of Judah

Paragraph: 15:63

This paragraph talks about the Jebus people, whom the people of Judah could not drive out.

15:63a

But the descendants of Judah could not drive out

- The people of Judah were not able to rid themselves of
- But the clan of Judah could not force out.

But the descendants of Judah could not drive out:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of Judah were not able to make them leave

The tribe of Judah could not force them to leave Jerusalem.

15:63b

the Jebusites living in Jerusalem.

- the Jebus people who lived in the town of Jerusalem,
- the people of Jebus who lived in Jerusalem.

the Jebusites living in Jerusalem: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But as for the Jebus people who lived in the town of Jerusalem

The people of Jebus lived in Jerusalem

15:63c

So to this day the Jebusites live there among the descendants of Judah.

- Therefore, the Jebus people live with the Judah people in Jerusalem up to today.
- Because of this, the people of Jebus still live with the people of Judah in Jerusalem till this present day.

So to this day the Jebusites live there among the descendants of Judah: The phrase this day refers to the time when the book of Joshua was written.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Because of this, the Jebus people still live with the Judah people in the town of Jerusalem up to today

Therefore, the people of Jebus live with the people of Judah in Jerusalem till this present day

Joshua 16:1

Section 16:1-17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:1a

The allotment for the descendants of Joseph extended from the Jordan at Jericho

- ¶ The land that the descendants of Joseph received began at the Jordan River near Jericho,
- ¶ The southern border of the land given to the descendants of Joseph started at the Jordan River near the town of Jericho.

The allotment for the descendants of Joseph: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as The allotment is more literally “the lot went out.” There is a similar phrase in Joshua 15:1. It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a similar way in both places.

the descendants of Joseph: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the descendants of Joseph is more literally “the sons of Joseph.” Joseph had two sons: Ephraim and Manasseh. Their descendants became the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh.

Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

the descendants of Joseph (BSB, RSV, GNT, NLT, NET)

the people of Joseph (ESV)

Joseph (NIV, GW)

the children of Joseph (KJV)

extended from the Jordan at Jericho: The clause extended from the Jordan at Jericho describes the

starting point of the southern border of the land given to Ephraim and Manasseh. The eastern point of the border was at the Jordan River near the town of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

The land that the descendants of Joseph received began at the Jordan River, near Jericho

The south border of the land given to the descendants of Joseph started at the Jordan River, near the town of Jericho

16:1b

to the waters of Jericho on the east, through the wilderness

- to the east of the springs of Jericho. It went west into the wilderness.
- It began to the east of the springs at the town of Jericho and then went west into the wilderness.

to the waters of Jericho on the east: The phrase waters of Jericho refers to springs that were north of the town of Jericho.

through the wilderness: The phrase through the wilderness indicates that the border then continued west into the wilderness.

wilderness: A wilderness is an uncultivated and uninhabited area. In this verse it refers to the Judean wilderness. The Judean wilderness is between the Judean mountains and the valley of the Dead Sea. This wilderness is a rocky place that descends steeply from the mountains into the valley. It consists of flat plateaus, rounded hills, deep canyons, and cliffs. Rasmussen p. 42. It receives little rainfall and no crops can grow there. It is not a typical desert with large areas of sand. Many languages may have a term for an uncultivated area or an uninhabited place.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

It then went to the east of the springs of Jericho and continued west into the wilderness

The border began to the east of the springs at the town of Jericho and went west into the wilderness

16:1c

that goes up from Jericho into the hill country of Bethel.

- It ascended from Jericho up into the hill country to Bethel.
- From Jericho it went up into the mountain country as far as the town of Bethel.

that goes up from Jericho into the hill country of Bethel: The clause goes up from Jericho indicates that the border ascended in elevation as it went through the wilderness, into the hill country to the town of Bethel.

hill country: The term hill country refers to the central mountain range which runs from the north to the south of Israel. This area receives a lot of rain and farmers plant crops in terraces along the hillsides. See how you translated this phrase in Joshua 9:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border went from Jericho up into the hill country to the town of Bethel

From Jericho it went up into the mountains as far as Bethel

Joshua 16:2

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:2a

It went on from Bethel (that is, Luz)

- It then continued west from Bethel, which used to be called Luz.
- The border went to the west from the town of Bethel. In the past Bethel was called Luz.

It went on from Bethel (that is, Luz): There is a textual issue in this verse.

1. The Septuagint reads from Bethel (that is Luz). (BSB, NIV, NLT, NCV)
2. The Masoretic Text reads from Bethel to Luz. (RSV, ESV, NJPS, NABRE, GNT, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) since this agrees with four other biblical references. In Genesis 28:19, 35:6, Joshua 18:13 and Judges 1:23 Bethel is identified with Luz.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

it then continued westward from Bethel, which used to be called Luz

The border went on from the town of Bethel. In the past Bethel was called Luz

16:2b
and proceeded to the border of the Archites in Ataroth.

- It continued to Ataroth in the area of the Archites.
- It went to the town of Ataroth in the land of the Arch people.

and proceeded to the border of the Archites in Ataroth: The Archites were a group of people who are mentioned in only one other place in the Bible. In 2 Samuel 15:32 Hushai the Archite is named as a counselor of David. This is not the same as the group mentioned in Genesis 10:17, where the Hebrew name is spelled differently.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued to the town of Ataroth in the territory of the Archites

It continued to the town of Ataroth in the land of the Arch people

in Ataroth: There is an interpretation issue with the term Ataroth.

1. It refers to a town called Ataroth whose location is unknown. This town is also mentioned in verse 16:7. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NIV, NJPS, NLT, NCV, NET, GW)
2. It refers to the town of Ataroth Addar, which is mentioned in Joshua 16:5 and 18:13. The GNT adds the word Addar in verse 2 to show that these both refer to the same place. (GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and translate this term Ataroth. Biblical scholars do not agree on whether the town referred to in this verse is Ataroth Addar or is a different town called Ataroth.

Joshua 16:3

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:3a Then it descended westward to the border of the Japhletites

- It then went westward downhill to the area of the Japhlet people,
- Then the border descended west to the land of the Japhlet people,

Then it descended westward to the border of the Japhletites: Japhlet was the son of Heber from the clan of Asher. He is mentioned in 1 Chronicles 7:32–33. The Japhletites are descendants of Japhlet.

In verse 2 the border ascended into the hill country. Now it has passed over the hills and is going downhill on its way toward the Mediterranean Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It then went downhill in a westward direction to the area where the Japhlet people lived

Then the border descended west to the land of the descendants of Japhlet

16:3b as far as the border of Lower Beth-horon

- continuing west as far as Lower Beth-horon.
- and went on to the area of Lower Beth-horon town.

as far as the border of Lower Beth-horon: The border continued to the west until it reached the town of Lower Beth-horon. Lower Beth-horon is first mentioned in Joshua 10:10.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued west as far as the town of Lower Beth-horon

and went on as far as the area of Lower Beth-horon

16:3c and on to Gezer, and it ended at the Sea.

- Then it went to Gezer and ended at the Mediterranean Sea.
- It continued west to the town of Gezer and ended at the Mediterranean Sea.

and on to Gezer, and it ended at the Sea: Gezer is a town that was seventeen miles southeast of the town

of Joppa. Joshua and the Israelites had defeated this town. The account of the battle is in Joshua 10:33.

the Sea: The term the Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and went to the town of Gezer and ended at the Mediterranean Sea

It then continued west to Gezer and on to the Mediterranean Sea

Joshua 16:4

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:4

So Ephraim and Manasseh, the sons of Joseph, received their inheritance.

- So the descendants of Joseph, that is the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh, received this land as their inheritance.
- The sons of Joseph, which were the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh, received their land according to the boundary lines given above.

So Ephraim and Manasseh, the sons of Joseph, received their inheritance: This verse is the conclusion to the paragraph. It may be helpful to add a conjunction or a phrase which shows that this is a conclusion, like the BSB does with So. For another example:

The people of Joseph, namely Manasseh and Ephraim, received their land according to the boundary lines given above

Ephraim and Manasseh: It may be helpful to state that the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh are the descendants of Joseph. For example:

the descendants of Joseph, that is, the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh

Manasseh: Manasseh was the first son of Joseph so he is listed first in the Hebrew. In the paragraph that follows, the land that Ephraim received is described before that of Manasseh. This reflects the story in

Genesis 48, in which Joseph blessed Ephraim before he blessed Manasseh. Woudstra p.256.

Joshua 16:5

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:5a

This was the territory of the descendants of Ephraim by their clans:

- ¶ The land that the clan of Ephraim received, according to their sub-clans, was like this:
- ¶ Each sub-clan in the clan of Ephraim received their own portion of land. That land had the following boundary.

This was the territory of the descendants of Ephraim by their clans: The phrase the territory of the descendants of Ephraim refers to the land that the clan of Ephraim received.

clans: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as clans actually refers to families or groups of people within a clan. This word is translated in the display as “sub-clans.” See the note at Joshua 7:14.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

according to their sub-clans

each sub-clan in the clan of Ephraim received their own portion of land

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the land that the clan of Ephraim received, according to their sub-clans, was like this

each family in the clan of Ephraim received their own portion of land. That land had the following boundaries.

16:5b

The border of their inheritance went from Ataroth-addar in the east

- The border of their land began at Ataroth-addar in the east
- On the east their southern boundary started at the town of Ataroth-addar,

The border of their inheritance went from Ataroth-addar in the east: The boundary points in this verse define the southern boundary of the clan of Ephraim.

Ataroth-addar: This town may be the same town as the town of “Ataroth” in Joshua 16:2, but this is not certain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border of their land began at Ataroth-addar in the east

Their southern boundary started at the town of Ataroth-addar in the east

16:5c to Upper Beth-horon

- and continued west to Upper Beth-horon.
- and went to the town of Upper Beth-horon.

to Upper Beth-horon: The town of Upper Beth-horon was to the west of Ataroth-addar.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and continued west to Upper Beth-horon

and went on to the town of Upper Beth-horon

Joshua 16:6

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:6a and out toward the Sea.

- The border then continued to the Mediterranean Sea.
- It then went down to the Mediterranean Sea.

and out toward the Sea: There is an interpretation issue in this verse.

1. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as toward the Sea refers to the Mediterranean Sea. (BSB, RSV, NRSV, NET, ESV, NIV, NJPS, NABRE, GNT, KJV)
2. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as toward the Sea means to the west.

Then the border went westward (NASB) (NASB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) which is followed by most English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary then continued to the Mediterranean Sea

From there it went downhill to the Mediterranean Sea

16:6b From Michmethath on the north

- The town of Mich-methath was on their northern border.
- The town of Mich-methath was the northern boundary of Ephraim’s territory.

From Michmethath on the north: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as From Michmethath on the north is more literally “Michmethath from north.” Most commentaries agree that this part of the verse describes the northern border of Ephraim.

Michmethath: The town of Michmethath was on the north border of Ephraim, near the town of Shechem. The exact location of Michmethath is unknown.

The English versions spell Michmethath in several ways:

Mich-methath (RSV)

Michmethath (BSB, ESV, GW, NABRE, GNT, CEV)

Michmethah (KJV)

Micmethath (NET, NIV84, NLT)

Mikmethath (NIV11)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The town of Michmethath was on their northern border

The town of Michmethath was in the north of Ephraim's territory

16:6c

it turned eastward toward Taanath-shiloh

- The border turned east toward Taanath-shiloh.
- The northern boundary line curved around to the east to the town of Taanath-shiloh

it turned eastward toward Taanath-shiloh: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as eastward toward Taanath-shiloh is more literally “the boundary turns east, Taanath-shiloh.”

Taanath-shiloh: Taanath-shiloh refers to a town to the east of Michmethath.

The English versions spell Taanath-shiloh in several ways:

Taanath-shiloh (BSB, RSV, ESV, NLT, NABRE, KJV)

Taanath Shiloh (NIV, NET, GW, GNT)

Taanath-Shiloh (CEV)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border then turned east toward the town of Taanath-shiloh

The boundary then curved around to the east to the town of Taanath-shiloh

16:6d

and passed by it to Janoah on the east.

- It went past that town and continued east to Jan-oah.
- and continued past it, and east to the town of Jan-oah.

and passed by it to Janoah on the east: The clause passed by it to Janoah on the east indicates that the border went past the town of Taanath-shiloh and continued east to the town of Janoah.

The English versions spell Janoah in several ways:

Jan-oah (RSV)

Janoah (BSB, NIV, NET, ESV, GW, NABRE, GNT, CEV, NLT)

Janoah (KJV)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border then went past that town and continued east to the town of Janoah

The border continued east from the town of Taanath-shiloh to the town of Janoah

Joshua 16:7

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:7a

From Janoah it went down to Ataroth and Naarah,

- Then the border went down from Jan-oah to Ataroth, and on to Naarah.
- From Jan-oah it went southeast and down to the town of Ataroth, and on to the town of Naarah.

From Janoah it went down to Ataroth and Naarah:

The phrase From Janoah it went down to indicates that the town of Janoah is at a higher elevation than the other two towns.

Ataroth and Naarah: These towns are southeast of the town of Janoah. The town of Ataroth listed here is not the same town as that mentioned in verses 2 or 5.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border went down from Janoah to Ataroth, and on to Naarah

Then the border went southeast to the town of Ataroth and on to the town of Naarah

16:7b

and then reached Jericho and came out at the Jordan.

- It then went on to Jericho and ended at the Jordan River.
- The border reached the town of Jericho and then ended at the Jordan River.

and then reached Jericho and came out at the Jordan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It then went on to Jericho, and ended at the Jordan River

The border reached the town of Jericho and then went on to end at the Jordan River

Joshua 16:8

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:8a

From Tappuah the border went westward to the Brook of Kanah and ended at the Sea.

- From the town of Tappuah the border went west to the Kanah River, and ended at the Mediterranean Sea.
- The border went west from the town of Tappuah as far as the Kanah streambed and ended at the Mediterranean Sea.

From Tappuah the border went westward to the Brook of Kanah: The town of Tappuah was about ten miles southwest of Shechem.

the Brook of Kanah: The Brook of Kanah is a deep ravine with a river that runs only when it rains. Today it is called Wadi Qana in Arabic, and Nahal Ha Yarkon in Hebrew. It flows west to join the Yarkon River, which then flows into the Mediterranean Sea. Coleson p.137–138.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the town of Tappuah the border went west to the Kanah River

The border went west from Tappuah to the Kanah streambed

From Tappuah the boundary line went west to the Kanah ravine

and ended at the Sea: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

and ended at the Mediterranean Sea

the end of the border was the Mediterranean Sea

16:8b

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Ephraim,

- This was the land that the families of the Ephraim clan received.
- The land described above was the land that the clan of Ephraim received. Each family received a part of that land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This is the land that the sub-clans of the clan of Ephraim received

This is the land that the Ephraim clan received. Each family in Ephraim received a part of the land

Joshua 16:9

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:9

along with all the cities and villages set apart for the descendants of Ephraim within the inheritance of Manasseh.

- The clan of Ephraim also received other towns within the land of the clan of Manasseh. The villages surrounding these towns also belonged to the clan of Ephraim.
- Their land also included some towns in areas belonging to the clan of Manasseh. They also received the villages that were near those towns.
- (reordered) The clan of Ephraim also received other towns and the villages which surrounded them. These towns and villages were in the land that belonged to the clan of Manasseh.

along with all the cities and villages set apart for the descendants of Ephraim: The clause the cities and villages set apart for the descendants of Ephraim indicates that there were other towns that the clan of Ephraim received. These towns were in the land belonging to the clan of Manasseh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Ephraim also received other towns

Their land also included towns

all the cities and villages: The phrase and villages indicates that there were villages that surrounded the cities. These villages also belonged to the clan of Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The villages surrounding these cities also belonged to the clan of Ephraim

The Ephraim clan also received the villages that were near these cities

within the inheritance of Manasseh: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

which were within the land that the clan of Manasseh received

which were in the land that belonged to the clan of Manasseh

General Comment on 16:9

It may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse so that the last clause follows the first. For example:

The clan of Ephraim also received other cities and the villages that surrounded them. These towns and villages were in the land that belonged to the clan of Manasseh.

Joshua 16:10

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

16:10a

But they did not drive out the Canaanites who lived in Gezer.

- But the people of Ephraim could not force the Canaanite people to leave Gezer.
- But the Ephraim clan could not make the Canaan people leave the town of Gezer.

But they did not drive out the Canaanites who lived in Gezer: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

but they did not conquer the Canaanite people who lived in the town of Gezer

but the Ephraim people did not force the Canaan people to leave Gezer

16:10b

So the Canaanites dwell among the Ephraimites to this day,

- So the Canaanite people still live among the Ephraim people up to this time.
- That is why the Canaan people still live there along with the Ephraim people.

So the Canaanites dwell among the Ephraimites to this day: This clause indicates that the people of Canaan still lived alongside the people of the clan of Ephraim.

to this day: The phrase to this day indicates that they still lived there when the book of Joshua was written.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so the Canaan people still live among the Ephraim people up to this time

that is why the people of Canaan still live along with the clan of Ephraim

16:10c

but they are forced laborers.

- However, they work as slaves to the Ephraim people.
- But they are slaves to the clan of Ephraim and have to work hard for them.

but they are forced laborers: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

but they work as slaves to the Ephraim people

but they are slaves to the clan of Ephraim and have to work hard for them

Joshua 17:1

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:1a

Now this was the allotment for the tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ Then the clan of Manasseh received land according to the lot.
- ¶ This is the land that Joshua gave to the clan of Manasseh

Now this was the allotment for the tribe of Manasseh:

The clause allotment for the tribe of Manasseh translates the same Hebrew words as in Joshua 15:1, except that here it refers to the clans of the tribe of Manasseh rather than the clans of the tribe of Judah. It refers to the land that the clan of Manasseh received when Joshua and Eleazar cast lots for them. It is recommended that you translate this the same way as you did in 15:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the clan of Manasseh received land according to the lot

Then the descendants of Manasseh were assigned land by lot

Joshua gave land to the descendants of Manasseh according to the lot

17:1b

as Joseph's firstborn son,

- Manasseh was the first-born son of Joseph.
- who was the elder son of Joseph.

as Joseph's firstborn son: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He was Joseph's first son

Manasseh was the oldest son of Joseph

as: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as as shows that the phrase "Joseph's firstborn son" is additional information.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The tribe of Manasseh, Joseph's firstborn son, was also allotted land (NET)

This was the allotment for the tribe of Manasseh as Joseph's firstborn (NIV)

A part of the land west of the Jordan was assigned to some of the families descended from Joseph's older son Manasseh (GNT)

17:1c

namely for Machir the firstborn of Manasseh and father of the Gileadites,

- Machir, the firstborn son of Manasseh and the father of Gilead,
- Machir was Manasseh's oldest son. The name of Machir's son was Gilead.

for Machir the firstborn of Manasseh and father of the Gileadites: There is an interpretation issue concerning the name Gileadites.

1. Gileadites is the name of a person, Gilead. For example:

To Machir...the father of Gilead (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NET, NLT, NABRE, NJPS, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. Gileadites is the name of a group of people who descended from a person name Gilead. For example:

Makir was the ancestor of the Gileadites (NIV) (BSB, NIV)

1. Gileadites is the name of a region. For example:

Machir...the ancestor of the people living in Gilead (GW) (GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In this phrase the word "Gilead" refers to a person, not to the region of Gilead. This is the interpretation taken by the majority of English versions and by some commentaries. Woudstra, p. 263. The person named Gilead is also mentioned in Numbers 26:29–30 and 1 Chronicles 7:14]. The region of Gilead is mentioned in Joshua 17:1d.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Machir was the firstborn son of Manasseh and the father of Gilead

Machir was Manasseh's oldest son. The name of his son was Gilead

17:1d

who had received Gilead and Bashan

- received the territories of Gilead and Bashan,
- Machir was assigned the lands of Gilead and Bashan east of the Jordan River,

who had received Gilead and Bashan: Gilead and Bashan were regions. They were areas of land that were east of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

he received the regions of Gilead and Bashan east of the Jordan River

Machir received the lands of Gilead and Bashan which were east of the Jordan River

they gave Machir land in the regions of Gilead and Bashan which were east of the Jordan River

17:1e

because Machir was a man of war.

- because he was a skilled fighter.
- because he fought well in battle.

because Machir was a man of war: The phrase man of war indicates that Machir was a skilled fighter. Numbers 32:39 tells how Machir and his descendants went to Gilead and defeated the people who were living there. Because of this he received Gilead as his inheritance.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because he was a skilled fighter

because he fought well in battle. He had fought the people of Gilead and Bashan and captured their land.

General Comment on 17:1d-e

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 1e before 1d. For example:

Machir was a skilled fighter, so he received the territories of Gilead and Bashan on the east side of the Jordan River.

Joshua 17:2

Section 16:1-17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:2a

So this allotment was for the rest of the descendants of Manasseh—

- The rest of the clan of Manasseh also received land by lot
- The other descendants of Manasseh were also assigned land.

So this allotment was for the rest of the descendants of Manasseh: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as allotment was for is more literally “was to.” Both the subject and the object of this clause are missing. In some languages it will be necessary to make them clear. For example:

Joshua gave land to the other descendants of Manasseh according to the lot

the rest of the descendants of Manasseh: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the rest of the descendants of Manasseh is more literally “the remaining sons of Manasseh.” This phrase refers to the descendants of Manasseh who did not receive land east of the Jordan River. These people were descendants of Machir and his son Gilead.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the rest of the clan of Manasseh also received land by lot

the other descendants of Manasseh were also assigned land

they gave land also to other descendants of Manasseh

17:2b

the clans of Abiezer, Helek, Asriel, Shechem, Hepher, and Shemida.

- according to their sub-clans. These are the names of the sub-clans: Abi-ezer, Helek, Asri-el, Hepher, and Shemida.
- The names of the families were Abi-ezer and Helek and Asri-el and Shechem and Hepher and Shemida.

the clans: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the clans was used in Joshua 16:5a. It is recommended that you translate it in the same way as you did in that verse. The Hebrew word is translated in the display as “sub-clans.” See the note at Joshua 7:14.

Abiezer, Helek, Asriel, Shechem, Hepher, and Shemida: These are the names of the sub-clans that received land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

according to their sub-clans. These are the names of the sub-clans: Abiezer, Helek, Asriel, Shechem, Hepher, and Shemida

The names of the sub-clans that received land were Abiezer and Helek and Asriel and Shechem and Hepher and Shemida

17:2c

These are the other male descendants of the clans of Manasseh son of Joseph.

- They were the male descendants of Manasseh, who was the son of Joseph.
- They were the males who inherited land in the family of Manasseh, who was one of the sons of Joseph.

These are the other male descendants of the clans of Manasseh son of Joseph: The writer wanted to make clear that these were male descendants of Manasseh, because in the next verse he talked about the female descendants of Manasseh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people named above were the male descendants of Manasseh

Those people were the other sons of Manasseh, and the heads of their sub-clans

Joshua 17:3

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:3a

But Zelophehad son of Hepher (the son of Gilead, the son of Machir, the son of Manasseh)

- ¶ Zelophehad was the son of Hepher, and the grandson of Gilead, whose father was Machir and whose grandfather was Manasseh.
- ¶ But Zelophehad, son of Hepher, son of Gilead, son of Machir, son of Manasseh,

But: The Hebrew particle that the BSB translates as But shows a contrast. Unlike the fathers of the sub-clans listed in the previous verse, Zelophehad had only daughters. He did not have any sons. Use a word or particle that is natural in your language to mark a contrast.

Zelophehad son of Hepher (the son of Gilead, the son of Machir, the son of Manasseh) had no sons but only daughters: Many languages have their own way of stating this kind of genealogy. Use whatever is the most natural way in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Zelophehad, the son of Hepher, the grandson of Gilead, and the great-grandson of Machir, whose father was Manasseh had no sons. He only had daughters

Zelophehad was the son of Hepher and the grandson of Gilead, whose father was Machir. Gilead's grandfather was Manasseh. Zelophehad had only daughters and no sons

17:3b

had no sons but only daughters. These are the names of his daughters:

- He had no sons, but he had daughters. His daughters were
- had only daughters. He did not have any sons. The names of his daughters were

17:3c

Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah.

- Mahlah and Noah and Hoglah and Milcah and Tirzah.

17:3b-c

These are the names of his daughters: Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The daughters were named as follows: Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah, and Tirzah

The names of his daughters were Mahlah and Noah and Hoglah and Milcah and Tirzah

Joshua 17:4**Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:4a

They approached Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun, and the leaders, and said,

- These daughters went to Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun and the tribal leaders, and said:
- These women went to Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun and the heads of the clans. They said to them,

They approached Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun, and the leaders, and said: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates leaders is more literally “one who is lifted up.” It refers to the heads of the clans. This Hebrew word was used in Joshua 14:1 (see “heads of the families”). It is recommended that you translate it the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

All the daughters went to Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun and the clan leaders, and said to them

Those women went to Eleazar the priest and Joshua and the heads of the clans and said

17:4b

“The LORD commanded Moses to give us an inheritance among our brothers.”

- “Yahweh told Moses to give us^(excl) some land for our own, just as he did for our male relatives.”
- “Yahweh commanded Moses to give us land to possess like he also gave to our male relatives.”

The LORD commanded Moses to give us an inheritance among our brothers: The phrase among our brothers indicates that the daughters would receive land as their male relatives did. The word brothers cannot refer to literal brothers, because Zelophehad had no sons.

The story of how Yahweh commanded Moses to give land to Zelophehad’s daughters is told in Numbers 27:1–11.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh told Moses to give us(excl) some land for our own, as he did for our male relatives

Yahweh commanded Moses to give land to us as well as our male relatives

17:4c

So Joshua gave them an inheritance among their father’s brothers,

- He gave them land along with the male relatives of their father.
- He assigned them some land among the land of their father’s male relatives.

So Joshua gave them an inheritance among their father’s brothers: The Hebrew does not specify who gave them an inheritance and some versions use “he” here since it is not certain whether this refers to Joshua or to Eleazar the priest. If it is necessary to make this explicit then it is recommended that you choose Joshua, as in the BSB.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

he gave them land along with the male relatives of their father

Joshua assigned them some land just as he had assigned some land to the male relatives of their father

So Joshua assigned them land among their uncles (NET)

17:4d

in keeping with the command of the LORD.

- Then Joshua did what Yahweh had commanded.
- So Joshua obeyed Yahweh’s command.

in keeping with the command of the LORD: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So Joshua did what Yahweh commanded

So he obeyed Yahweh's command

Joshua 17:5

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:5a

Thus ten shares fell to Manasseh,

- So the clan of Manasseh received ten portions of land west of the Jordan River
- That is why the clan of Manasseh had ten sections of land west of the Jordan River.

Thus ten shares fell to Manasseh: The clause ten shares fell to Manasseh indicates that the clan of Manasseh received ten pieces of land on the west side of the Jordan River. The sub-clans of Abiezer, Helek, Asriel, Shechem and Shemida each received one piece of land. The sub-clan of Hephher received five pieces of land. It received one piece for each of Zelophehad's daughters.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the clan of Manasseh received ten portions of land on the west side of the Jordan River

That is why the descendants of Manasseh had ten sections of land west of the Jordan River

17:5b

in addition to the land of Gilead and Bashan

- in addition to the regions of Gilead and Bashan
- They also had the lands of Gilead and Bashan

in addition to the land of Gilead and Bashan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

as well as the regions of Gilead and Bashan

They also had the lands of Gilead and Bashan

17:5c

beyond the Jordan,

- east of the Jordan River.
- on the east side of the Jordan River.

beyond the Jordan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

which were east of the Jordan River

These regions were on the east side of the Jordan River

Joshua 17:6

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:6a

because the daughters of Manasseh received an inheritance among his sons.

- This was because the female descendants of Manasseh received land just like the male descendants.
- The daughters of Zelophehad, Manasseh's descendant, were assigned land along with their male relatives.

because the daughters of Manasseh received an inheritance among his sons: The clause the daughters of Manasseh received an inheritance among his sons states the reason that the clan of Manasseh received ten areas of land. In some languages it may be helpful to reorder the information in verses 5 and 6 to make this clear. See the General Comment on 17:5–6a.

the daughters of Manasseh: The phrase the daughters of Manasseh refers to the five daughters of Zelophehad. These women were fifth-generation descendants of Manasseh. They were not literally his daughters. The Hebrew language uses "daughters" to refer to female descendants.

his sons: The phrase his sons refers to five of the sons of Gilead. These men were third-generation descendants of Manasseh. They were not literally his sons. The Hebrew language uses "sons" to refer to male descendants.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This happened because the female descendants of Manasseh received portions of land like the male descendants

This was because the daughters of Zelophehad, who were descended from Manasseh, were assigned land along with their male relatives

General Comment on 17:5–6a

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder these verses and put the reason first. For example:

^{6a}Because the female descendants of Manasseh received portions of land like their male relatives, ^{5a}the clan of Manasseh received ten portions of land on the west side of the Jordan River. ^{5b}The other descendants of Manasseh received the lands of Gilead and Bashan ^{5c}on the east side of the Jordan River.

17:6b

And the land of Gilead belonged to the rest of the sons of Manasseh.

- The land of Gilead had been assigned to the other descendants of Manasseh.
- Other descendants of Manasseh had received the land of Gilead.

And the land of Gilead belonged to the rest of the sons of Manasseh: The phrase the rest of the sons of Manasseh refers to the other descendants of Manasseh who were mentioned in Joshua 17:1. They received the land of Gilead on the east side of the Jordan River.

It is not clear from scripture exactly how these descendants of Manasseh were related to the six sons of Gilead. Possibly Machir had other sons who were brothers of Gilead.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The land of Gilead was assigned to the other descendants of Manasseh

Other descendants of Manasseh had received the land of Gilead

Joshua 17:7

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:7a

Now the border of Manasseh went from Asher to Michmethath near Shechem,

- ¶ The territory of Manasseh went from the border of Asher's land to the town of Michmethah east of Shechem town.
- ¶ Manasseh's land bordered on the clan of Asher's land in the northwest and reached to the town of Michmethath in the south to the east of Shechem town.

Now the border of Manasseh went from Asher to Michmethath near Shechem: The term Asher refers to the clan of Asher. Their land was northwest of the land belonging to the clan of Manasseh.

Michmethath: The town of Michmethath was on the northern border of Ephraim, near the town of Shechem. The exact location is unknown. This town was mentioned in Joshua 16:6b.

Shechem: The town of Shechem was in the territory assigned to Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Manasseh's land bordered on the clan of Asher's land in the northwest, and reached to the town of Michmethath in the south. Michmethath was east of Shechem town

The territory of the clan of Manasseh went from the border of Asher's land in the northwest to the town of Michmethath which was east of Shechem

17:7b

then southward to include the inhabitants of En-tappuah.

- Then the border went south to the people who lived near En-tappuah.
- The border then continued southward. The people who lived near the spring of Tappuah were within the border.

then southward to include the inhabitants of En-tappuah: The town of Tappuah was mentioned in Joshua 16:8. The Hebrew phrase that the BSB trans-

lates as En-tappuah can also be translated as “the spring of Tappuah.” The inhabitants of En-tappuah lived in the area near Tappuah spring, which was outside the town of Tappuah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border went south to the people who lived near the spring of Tappuah

The border then continued south. It went past the people who lived near the spring of Tappuah

Joshua 17:8

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:8a

The region of Tappuah belonged to Manasseh,

- The land near the town of Tappuah belonged to the clan of Manasseh,
- The land that surrounded Tappuah Town belonged to the clan of Manasseh.

The region of Tappuah belonged to Manasseh: The phrase The region of Tappuah refers to the land near the town of Tappuah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The land around the town of Tappuah belonged to the clan of Manasseh

The land near Tappuah belonged to the descendants of Manasseh

17:8b

but Tappuah itself, on the border of Manasseh, belonged to Ephraim.

- but the town of Tappuah itself did not. It was on the border and belonged to the clan of Ephraim.
- The town of Tappuah was on the border between the clans of Manasseh and Ephraim and it belonged to Ephraim.

but Tappuah itself, on the border of Manasseh, belonged to Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

but the town of Tappuah itself did not belong to Manasseh. It was on the border of Manasseh and belonged to the clan of Ephraim

the town of Tappuah was on the border between the clans of Manasseh and Ephraim, and it belonged to Ephraim

Joshua 17:9

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:9b

There were cities belonging to Ephraim among the cities of Manasseh,

- Some towns that belonged to the clan of Ephraim were south of the river among the towns that belonged to the clan of Manasseh.
- Some towns of the clan of Ephraim were south of the streambed in land that belonged to the clan of Manasseh.

17:9a-b

From there the border continued southward to the Brook of Kanah. There were cities belonging to Ephraim among the cities of Manasseh: There is an interpretation issue in this verse. Scholars do not agree on how the word southward relates to the parts of this verse.

1. It relates to the phrase the cities in verse 9b. For example:

These cities, to the south of the brook... (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NABRE, NJPS, NLT, GNT, CEV, KJV)

1. It relates to the term border in verse 9a. For example:

Then the boundary continued south to the Kanah Ravine (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with the majority of English versions and some commentaries. Woudstra, p. 266. The border of Manasseh went south of the Kanah River for some distance. However, there were some towns belonging to the clan of Ephraim that were within the borders of the land assigned to Manasseh.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Some towns that belonged to the clan of Ephraim were south of the river, among the towns that belonged to the clan of Manasseh

17:9a

From there the border continued southward to the Brook of Kanah.

- Then the border descended to the southwest to the Kanah River.
- The border then continued downhill to the Kanah streambed.

From there the border continued southward to the Brook of Kanah: You should translate the phrase the Brook of Kanah the same way as you translated it in Joshua 16:8.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border descended to the southwest to the Kanah River

The border then continued south downhill to the Kanah streambed

17:9c

but the border of Manasseh was on the north side of the brook and ended at the Sea.

- The border of the clan of Manasseh's land continued west on the north side of the river as far as the Mediterranean Sea.
- The boundary line of Manasseh's land was on the north side of the streambed, and it ended at the Mediterranean Sea.

but the border of Manasseh was on the north side of the brook and ended at the Sea: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border of Manasseh's land continued westward on the north side of the river and ended at the Mediterranean Sea

Then the boundary line of Manasseh's land went along the northern side of the river, and it ended at the Mediterranean Sea

Joshua 17:10

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:10a

Ephraim's territory was to the south,

- The land on the south side of the river belonged to the clan of Ephraim.
- The land south of the streambed belonged to the descendants of Ephraim.

Ephraim's territory was to the south: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The land on the south side of the river belonged to the clan of Ephraim

The land that was south of the riverbed belonged to the descendants of Ephraim

17:10b

and Manasseh's was to the north,

- The land on the north side of the river belonged to the clan of Manasseh.
- The land north of the streambed belonged to the descendants of Manasseh

and Manasseh's was to the north: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and the land on the north side of the river belonged to the clan of Manasseh

and the land that was north of the riverbed belonged to the descendants of Manasseh

17:10c

having the Sea as its border

- The Mediterranean Sea formed the western boundary of Manasseh's land.
- and the western border was the Mediterranean Sea.

having the Sea as its border: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Mediterranean Sea formed the west boundary of Manasseh's land

The clan of Manasseh had the Mediterranean Sea as the western border of its land

**17:10d
and adjoining Asher on the north and Issachar on the east.**

- Their border reached to the clan of Asher in the north, and to the clan of Issachar in the east.
- To the north- west was land that belonged to the descendants of Asher. To the north- east was land that belonged to the descendants of Issachar.

and adjoining Asher on the north: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as adjoining Asher on the north is more literally “they touched Asher on the north.” The clan of Manasseh shared a border with the clan of Asher in the north and northwest.

and Issachar on the east: The phrase that the BSB translates as Issachar on the east indicates that the clan of Manasseh shared a border with the clan of Issachar in the east and northeast.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the clan of Manasseh had a border with the clan of Asher on the north, and with the clan of Issachar on the east

to the north-west was land that belonged to the people of Asher. To the north-east was land that belonged to the people of Issachar

Joshua 17:11

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

**17:11a
Within Issachar and Asher, Manasseh was assigned Beth-shean,**

- The clan of Manasseh also had towns in the land of the clans of Issachar and Asher. These were Beth-shean town and its surrounding villages,
- Some towns that belonged to the Manasseh clan were in land that belonged to the Asher clan and the Issachar clan. These towns were Beth-shean and the villages that surrounded it,

Within Issachar and Asher, Manasseh was assigned Beth-shean: The town of Beth-shean was fifteen

miles southwest of the Sea of Galilee. Rasmussen p. 230.

Here are some ways that English versions have spelled the name of this town:

Beth Shean (NET, GW)

Beth-shean (BSB, RSV, ESV, NABRE, KJV)

Beth Shan (NIV, GNT)

Beth-shan (NLT, CEV)

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Manasseh also had towns in the lands of the clan of Issachar and the clan of Asher. These were Beth-shean town and its surrounding villages

**17:11b
Ibleam, Dor (that is, Naphath),**

- and Ibleam and its surrounding villages, and the people of Dor and its surrounding villages,
- Ibleam town and the villages that surrounded it, and the people who lived in Dor town and the villages that surrounded it,

Ibleam, Dor (that is, Naphath): Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Ibleam and its surrounding villages, and the people of the town of Dor and its surrounding villages

Ibleam and the villages that surrounded it, and the people who lived in Dor and the villages that surrounded it

Dor (that is, Naphath): The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as that is, Naphath is more literally, “three is Naphath.” Most scholars understand the term Naphath to refer to the town of Dor. Dor is the third town in this list. The town of Naphath Dor is also mentioned in Joshua 11:2 and 12:23.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The third town in the list was also called Naphath

The town of Dor also had the name Naphath

17:11c

Endor,

- and the people of En-dor and its surrounding villages,
- the people who lived in En-dor town and the villages that surrounded it,

Endor:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of the town of En-dor and its surrounding villages

the people who lived in En-dor and the villages that were around it

17:11d

Taanach,

- and the people of Taanach and its surrounding villages,
- the people who lived in Taanach town and the villages that surrounded it,

Taanach: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of the town of Taanach and its surrounding villages

the people who lived in Taanach and the villages that surrounded it

17:11e

and Megiddo, each with their surrounding settlements.

- and the people of Megiddo and its surrounding villages. The third town in the list was also called Naphath.
- and the people who lived in Megiddo town and the villages that surrounded it. The town of Dor also had the name Naphath.

and Megiddo, each with their surrounding settlements: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of the town of Megiddo and its surrounding villages

the people who lived in Megiddo and the villages that surrounded it

General Comment on verse 17:11

It may be more natural in your language to reorder and combine the parts of verse 11. For example:

The clan of Manasseh also had towns in the lands of the Issachar and Asher clans. These towns were Beth-shean, Ibleam, Dor which is also called Naphath Dor, Endor, Taanach, and Megiddo. The villages that surrounded these towns also belonged to the clan of Manasseh

17:11a-e

(reordered) The clan of Manasseh also had towns in the land of the Issachar and Asher clans. These towns were Beth-shean, Ibleam, Dor which is also called Naphath, En-dor, Taanach, and Megiddo. The villages that surrounded these towns also belonged to the clan of Manasseh.

Joshua 17:12

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:12a

But the descendants of Manasseh were unable to occupy these cities,

- But the clan of Manasseh was not able to conquer those towns.
- But the descendants of Manasseh could not make the Canaan people leave those towns.

But the descendants of Manasseh were unable to occupy these cities: The phrase the descendants of Manasseh refers to the clan of Manasseh.

But the clan of Manasseh was not able to conquer those towns

But the descendants of Manasseh clan could not make the Canaanite people leave those towns

17:12b

because the Canaanites were determined to stay in this land.

- The people of Canaan were determined to live in that territory.

- The Canaan people continued to live there.

because the Canaanites were determined to stay in this land: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Canaan were determined to live in the land

The Canaan people continued to live there

Joshua 17:13

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:13a

However, when the Israelites grew stronger,

- But when the people of Israel became stronger
- But later, when the Israel people became strong enough,

However, when the Israelites grew stronger: The clause when the Israelites grew stronger indicates that the Israel people became strong enough to force the Canaanite people to do what they wanted.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But when the people of Israel became stronger

But later when the Israel men became strong enough

17:13b

they put the Canaanites to forced labor;

- they made the Canaan people work as slaves.
- the Canaan people became their slaves and had to work hard for them.

they put the Canaanites to forced labor: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they made the Canaan people work as their slaves

the people of Canaan became their slaves and had to work hard for them

17:13c

but they failed to drive them out completely.

- But still the Israel people did not completely force the Canaan people to leave.
- However, the Israel people did not succeed in making the Canaan people leave the land.

but they failed to drive them out completely: The clause that the BSB translates as failed to drive them out has a form in Hebrew to show that it is emphasized. The BSB translates this emphasis with the word completely. Use a word or grammatical form in your language that shows emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But still the Israel people did not completely force the Canaan people to leave

However, the people of Israel failed to make all of the people of Canaan leave the land

Joshua 17:14

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:14a

Then the sons of Joseph said to Joshua,

- ¶ The people of the clan of Joseph went to Joshua and asked him:
- ¶ One day the descendants of Joseph said to Joshua:

Then the sons of Joseph said to Joshua: The clan of Joseph includes both the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh. Ephraim and Manasseh were the two sons of Joseph.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of the clan of Joseph went to Joshua and asked him

One day the descendants of Joseph said to Joshua

17:14b

“Why have you given us only one portion as an inheritance?”

- “Why did you give us only one share of land to be our own?”

- “Why have you given just one area of land to our clan?”

Why have you given us only one portion as an inheritance: The Hebrew text considers the clan of Joseph as a single entity. Because the clan of Joseph included many people, it is more natural to translate the Hebrew pronoun “me” with a plural pronoun us.

only one portion: In the phrase one portion refers to the area of land that Joshua had assigned to the clan of Joseph. In some languages it may be clearer to translate this phrase as:

one piece of land

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Why did you^(sing) give us^(excl) only one share of land to be our own?

Why have you given just one area of land for our clan to own?

17:14c

We have many people, because the LORD has blessed us abundantly.”

- We have many people in our clan, because Yahweh has blessed us.”
- Yahweh has blessed our clan with many descendants, and now we are a large group of people.”

We have many people: The clause We have many people indicates that the clan of Joseph had many people in it.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

even though there are many of us

because the LORD has blessed us abundantly: The clause the LORD has blessed us indicates that Yahweh gave the clan of Joseph many descendants.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We^(excl) have many people in our clan because Yahweh has blessed us

Yahweh has blessed our clan with many descendants. So now we are a large group of people

Joshua 17:15

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:15a

Joshua answered them,

- Then Joshua said to them,
- Joshua answered,

Joshua answered them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua said to them

Joshua answered

17:15b

“If you have so many people that the hill country of Ephraim is too small for you, go to the forest

- “If you have so many people, go up into the forests.
- “You have many people, so go up into the wooded country.

If you have so many people that the hill country of Ephraim is too small for you, go to the forest: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If you^(plur) have so many people, go up into the forest

You have many people, so go up into the wooded country

that the hill country of Ephraim is too small for you:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because you think that the hill country of Ephraim is not wide enough for you

because the mountain country of Ephraim is too small for all of you to live in

17:15c

and clear for yourself an area in the land of the Perizzites and the Rephaim.”

- Clear land for yourselves there, in the country of the Periz people and the Repha people. The mountain country of Ephraim is too small for you to live in.”
- Cut down the trees to make room where the Periz and the Repha peoples live, because you think the hill country of Ephraim is not big enough for you.”

and clear for yourself an area in the land of the Perizzites and the Rephaim: The Hebrew that the BSB translates as clear refers specifically to the act of cutting down trees and removing shrubs in a forest to create a place to live.

the Perizzites: The term Perizzites refers to the Periz people. The Periz people had lived in the land of Canaan for a long time. The Perizzites were mentioned in Joshua 3:10 and 12:8. It is recommended that you translate the name of these people in the same way here.

the Rephaim: The term Rephaim refers to the Repha people. The Repha people had lived in the land of Canaan for a long time. The Rephaim were mentioned in Joshua 12:4 and 13:12. It is recommended that you translate the name of these people in the same way here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and clear land for yourselves there, in the country of the Periz people and the Repha people

Cut down the trees to make room for yourselves where the Periz people and the Repha people live

General Comment on verse 17:15

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{15a}Joshua answered them, ^{15b-c}“Go up to the forests, take the land that belongs to the Periz people and the Repha people, and make a place to live there ^{15b}if you have so many people that the mountain country of Ephraim is not wide enough for you.

Joshua 17:16

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:16a

“The hill country is not enough for us,” they replied,

- The people of the Joseph clan said, “The hill country is not large enough for us.
- The descendants of Joseph said, “The mountain area is still not wide enough for all of us.

“The hill country is not enough for us,” they replied: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of the Joseph clan answered him, “The hill country is not large enough for us.”^(excl)

The mountain area is still not wide enough for all of us

17:16b

“and all the Canaanites who live in the valley have iron chariots,

- But all the Canaan people who live in the valleys have chariots made with iron.
- But the Canaan people who live in the lowlands have iron war carts. We cannot defeat them.

and all the Canaanites who live in the valley have iron chariots: The clan of Joseph considered the mountain country to be too small for them, but they could not expand into the valley because the Canaanite people already lived there.

iron chariots: A “chariot” is a war cart with two wheels which was pulled by horses. The wheels were reinforced with iron. The Israelites did not have war vehicles. The chariots gave the Canaanites an advantage over the Israelites when they fought each other.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But all the Canaan people who live in the valleys have war carts made of iron to use when we fight

But the Canaanite people who live in the flat area have iron war vehicles. We^(excl) cannot defeat them

17:16c

both in Beth-shean with its towns and in the Valley of Jezreel.”

- Those in Beth-shean town and the villages around it, and also those in the Valley of Jezreel have iron chariots.

- This includes those who live in the town of Beth-shean and its surrounding villages, and those who live in Jezreel Valley.

both in Beth-shean with its towns and in the Valley of Jezreel: The town of Beth-shean was mentioned in Joshua 17:11. You should translate it the same way here.

Valley of Jezreel: The Valley of Jezreel was a large valley shaped like a triangle. It separated the hill country of the clan of Manasseh from the Galilee region. Rasmussen p. 240.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

not only the people who live in Beth-shean and the villages around it, but also those who live in the Valley of Jezreel

This includes those who live in the town of Beth-shean and its surrounding villages, and those who live in Jezreel Valley

General Comment on verse 17:16

It may be clearer to reorder the parts of this verse. For example,

^{16a}The people of the Joseph clan said, “It is true that there is not enough space for us in the hill country. ^{16b}But all the Canaan people who live in the plain ^{16c}including those who live in town of Beth-shean and the villages around it, and those who live in the Valley of Jezreel ^{16b}have chariots made of iron.

Joshua 17:17

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:17a

So Joshua said to the house of Joseph—to Ephraim and Manasseh—

- Then Joshua answered the descendants of Joseph, that is, the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh:
- Joshua said to the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh, who were descendants of Joseph:

So Joshua said to the house of Joseph: The term the house of Joseph refers to the descendants of Joseph.

to Ephraim and Manasseh: The phrase Ephraim and Manasseh refers to the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh. It is another way of referring to the descendants of Joseph.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua said to the clans of Ephraim and Manasseh, who were the descendants of Joseph

Joshua answered the descendants of Joseph, that is, the clan of Ephraim and the clan of Manasseh

17:17b

“You have many people and great strength.

- “You have many people and are very strong.
- “You have a lot of people in your clans. You are very powerful.

You have many people and great strength: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Your clans have many people and are strong

You have a lot of people in your clans. You are very powerful

17:17c

You shall not have just one allotment,

- So you will not have only one share of land.
- You will not have just one area of land.

You shall not have just one allotment: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So you will not have only one piece of land

You will not have just one area of land

Joshua 17:18

Section 16:1–17:18 The clans of Ephraim and Manasseh received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land given to Ephraim and to Manasseh, and the towns within each of their lands.

17:18a

because the hill country will be yours as well.

- The hill country will be yours.
- The mountain country will belong to you as well.

because the hill country will be yours as well: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You will be able to conquer the whole hill country

The mountain country will belong to you as well

17:18b

It is a forest; clear it, and its farthest limits will be yours.

- It is a forest, but you will cut down the trees and live in all of it.
- Even though it is a forest area, you can clear it out and make all of it your own.

It is a forest; clear it, and its farthest limits will be yours: The Hebrew that the BSB translates as clear refers specifically to the act of cutting down trees and removing shrubs in a forest to create a place to live. Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It is a forest, but you will cut down the trees and conquer all of it

Even though it is a forest area, you can clear it out and make all of it your own

17:18c

Although the Canaanites have iron chariots and although they are strong, you can drive them out.”

- You will make the Canaan people leave, though they are strong and have chariots made of iron.”
- You will defeat the Canaan people, even though they are powerful and have iron war carts.”

Although the Canaanites have iron chariots and although they are strong: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

though they are strong and have chariots made of iron

even though they are powerful and have iron war carts

you can drive them out: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You will make the Canaanites leave

You will defeat the Canaan people

Joshua 18:1

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:1a

Then the whole congregation of Israel assembled at Shiloh

- ¶ Then all the community of Israel gathered at the town of Shiloh
- ¶ All the Israel people met together at Shiloh town.

Then the whole congregation of Israel assembled at Shiloh: The phrase the whole congregation refers to all the Israelite people.

Shiloh: Shiloh is a town in the territory of the Ephraim clan. It was in the center of Israel, west of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then all the community of Israel gathered at Shiloh

All the Israelite people met together at the town of Shiloh

18:1b

and set up the Tent of Meeting there.

- and put up the meeting tent there.
- They set up the holy tent there.

and set up the Tent of Meeting there: The tent of meeting was the tent that God told the Israelites to make. God gave detailed instructions to Moses on how to set up this tent and the things that were inside it. These instructions are found in Exodus 25–27. The fabric of the tent had outer layers made of goat hair. The inner layers were made of linen which were skillfully embroidered to make the inside beautiful.

The term Tent of Meeting emphasizes that this tent is where God met with his people.

A tent is a portable shelter made of cloth. The Israelites took the tent down and carried it when they moved through the wilderness. Some languages may not have a word for “tent.” In some languages, the closest equivalent may be “hut.”

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

holy tent

meeting tent

tent of the Lord’s presence (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and put up the meeting tent there

they set up the holy tent there

18:1c

And though the land was subdued before them,

- The Israelites had conquered the land.
- They had defeated the people of the land.

And though the land was subdued before them: The clause the land was subdued before them indicates that the Israelites had conquered the people who lived in the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Israelites had conquered the land

They had defeated the people of the land

General Comment on verse 18:1

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse so that they occur in chronological sequence. For example:

After the Israelites had defeated the people of the land they set up the tent of meeting at Shiloh

Joshua 18:2

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:2

there were still seven tribes of Israel who had not yet received their inheritance.

- There were still seven clans in Israel to whom Joshua had not assigned a share of land as their inheritance.
- Seven of the Israel clans were left that had not yet received their part of the land.

there were still seven tribes of Israel who had not yet received their inheritance: The clause who had not yet received their inheritance indicates that Joshua and Eleazar the priest had not yet divided land for the seven clans who remained.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

There were still seven clans of Israelite people to whom Joshua had not assigned a share of land as their inheritance

Seven of the Israelite clans had not yet received their part of the land

Joshua 18:3

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:3a**So Joshua said to the Israelites,**

- Joshua asked the Israel people,
- So Joshua said to the people of Israel,

So Joshua said to the Israelites: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua asked the people of Israel

So Joshua spoke to the Israelites. He said, (NIRV)

18:3b**“How long will you put off entering and possessing the land that the LORD, the God of your fathers, has given you?”**

- “Why are you waiting so long to claim the land that Yahweh the God of your ancestors has given you?”
- “Do not delay any longer. Go and settle in the land that Yahweh has given you. He is the God whom your ancestors worshiped.

How long will you put off entering and possessing the land that the LORD, the God of your fathers, has given you?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. Joshua rebuked the Israelites because they had not taken the land that God gave them.

Here are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How long will you wait before you begin to take possession of the land that the Lord, the God of your ancestors, has given you? (NIV)

- As a rebuke. For example:

You should not have waited so long to take possession of the land that Yahweh the God of your ancestors has given you

Do not delay any longer. Go and settle in the land that Yahweh has given you. He is the God whom your ancestors worshiped.

Translate this as a natural rebuke in your language.

How long will you put off: The Hebrew participle that the BSB translates as put off indicates that the Israelite people were lazy, or slow to act.

you: This is a plural you. Joshua spoke to the people of Israel.

entering and possessing the land: The clause entering and possessing the land indicates that the Israelites should enter the land to live in it. They had conquered the land but they had not yet settled down in it. Expositor’s Bible Commentary volume 2.

the God of your fathers: The term the God of your fathers indicates that Yahweh was the God whom their ancestors had worshiped.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Why are you^(plur) waiting so long to claim the land that Yahweh, the God of your ancestors, has given to you?

Do not delay any longer to go in and settle in the land that Yahweh has given you. He is the God whom your ancestors worshiped.

Joshua 18:4**Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans**

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:4a**Appoint three men from each tribe, and I will send them out**

- Choose three men from each clan, and I will send them out.
- Appoint three men from each of the seven remaining clans. I will send them

Appoint three men from each tribe: The phrase each tribe probably refers to the seven clans that had not yet received their share of land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Choose three men from each of the seven clans

Appoint three men per clan

18:4b
to survey the land and map it out,

- They will go and walk around the land.
- to go throughout the land.

There is a Hebrew verb at the beginning of this clause that the BSB leaves untranslated. This verb means “and they will arise.” This is a Hebrew idiom which is used to indicate the beginning of an action. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to indicate the beginning of an action.

to survey the land and map it out: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as survey the land and map it out is more literally “they will walk back and forth in the land.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they will walk all around the land

they will go through the land

18:4c
according to the inheritance of each.

- They can make a map of the area that they would like to receive as their inheritance.
- They will write a report. It will show the boundaries of the land that each clan wants to receive.

according to the inheritance of each: This indicates that the men wrote a description of the land that they wanted to receive for their own clan. The description may have been in the form of a map.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so that they can make a map of the area they want to receive as their inheritance

They will write a report. The report will show the boundaries of the land that their clan wishes to receive

18:4d
Then they will return to me

- Then they will come back to me.
- Then they will return to me with their report.

Then they will return to me: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then they must come back to me

Then they must return to me with the report

Joshua 18:5

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:5a
and divide the land into seven portions.

- They must divide the land into seven parts among themselves.
- They will divide the remaining land into seven areas.

and divide the land into seven portions: This indicates that the men should divide the remaining land into seven parts, one for each of the clans that had still not received a share of land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They must divide the remaining land into seven parts among themselves

They will divide it into seven areas of land

18:5b
Judah shall remain in their territory in the south,

- The clan of Judah will remain in the land they received in the south.
- The clan of Judah will stay in their land to the south.

Judah shall remain in their territory in the south: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Judah will remain in the land they have received in the south

The clan of Judah will stay in their land to the south

18:5c
and the house of Joseph shall remain in their territory in the north.

- The descendants of Joseph will remain in the land they received in the north.
- The family of Joseph will stay in their land to the north.

and the house of Joseph shall remain in their territory in the north: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The descendants of Joseph will remain in the land they have received in the north

The family of Joseph will stay in their land to the north

Joshua 18:6

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:6a
When you have mapped out the seven portions of land

- You^(plur) must describe the land and divide it into seven parts
- These men will divide the land into seven areas and write down what each area is like.

When you have mapped out the seven portions of land: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as you have mapped out the seven portions of land is more literally “you will write the land seven portions.”

you: In verse 4 Joshua told the people of Israel that they must choose three men from each clan. He referred to them in the third person. In this verse Joshua addresses the chosen men in the second person. It may be more natural in some languages to keep referring to the men in the third person. For example:

In their report, the men from the seven tribes should describe the seven parts of the remaining land that they wish to receive (T4T)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But you should describe the land and divide it into seven parts (ERV)

They will divide the land into seven areas and write down what each area is like

The first two parts of this verse are similar to Joshua 18:4c–d.

18:6b
and brought it to me,

- and bring the description back to me.
- Then they will bring the report back to me.

and brought it to me: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Bring the map to me (ERV)

Then they will bring the report back to me

18:6c
I will cast lots for you here in the presence of the LORD our God.

- I will throw lots for you^(plur) here in the presence of Yahweh our God.
- I will throw marked stones to let Yahweh our God decide how to divide the land among the clans.

I will cast lots for you: The word lots refers to small objects of unknown shape and material that the Israelite people threw to determine God’s will. Holman Bible Dictionary p. 896. Use a term that is familiar in your language for choosing by chance.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

throw dice/stones

draw straws

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua threw stones to decide which share of land each clan would receive

here in the presence of the LORD our God: In 18:1 the people of Israel set up the tent of meeting in Shiloh. Inside the tent of meeting was the ark of the covenant that was a symbol of God's presence. The phrase here in the presence of the LORD our God indicates that Joshua threw the lots in front of the tent of meeting, the place where God met with his people. The Israelites believed that Yahweh had control over the way the lot would fall.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I will throw lots for you^(plur) here in the presence of Yahweh our^(incl) God

I will throw lots here before the tent of Yahweh our God. He will decide how to divide the land among the clans.

While Yahweh is watching, I will throw marked stones to decide which land should be allotted to each tribe (T4T)

Joshua 18:7

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:7a

The Levites, however, have no portion among you,

- The clan of Levi will not receive any part of the land as their own
- But the Levi clan will not have a share of land

The Levites, however, have no portion among you:

The clause The Levites...have no portion among you indicates that the clan of Levi did not receive any land of their own.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Levi will not receive any land as their own

But the Levi clan will not have any share of the land

18:7b

because their inheritance is the priesthood of the LORD.

- because their inheritance is to serve Yahweh as his priests.
- because their share is to be priests of Yahweh.

because their inheritance is the priesthood of the LORD: The phrase priesthood of the LORD indicates that the clan of Levi were to serve Yahweh as priests.

inheritance: Instead of receiving land from Yahweh, the clan of Levi received the privilege of serving Yahweh as his priests.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

their inheritance is to serve Yahweh as his priests

their gift/reward is the duty to be priests of Yahweh

their role as priests of the Lord is their allotment (NLT)

instead, they will serve the Lord as priests (CEV)

18:7c

And Gad, Reuben, and half the tribe of Manasseh

- The clan of Gad and the clan of Reuben and half of the clan of Manasseh
- The Gad clan, the Reuben clan and half of the Manasseh clan

And Gad, Reuben, and half the tribe of Manasseh:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Gad and the clan of Reuben and half the clan of Manasseh

The clans of Gad and Reuben and half of the Manasseh clan

18:7d

have already received the inheritance that Moses the servant of the LORD gave them beyond the Jordan to the east.”

- have land on the east side of the Jordan River as their inheritance. Moses the servant of Yahweh gave that land to them.”
- have already received their share of land on the east bank of the Jordan River, as Moses the man who served Yahweh decided.”

have already received the inheritance that Moses the servant of the LORD gave them beyond the Jordan to the east: This indicates that the clans of Gad, Reuben and half the clan of Manasseh had already received their land on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they have land on the east side of the Jordan River as their inheritance

they already have their share of land on the east side of the Jordan River

that Moses the servant of the LORD gave them: The phrase Moses the servant of the LORD occurs in Joshua 1:1. You should translate it the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

Moses the man who served God well (T4T)

Moses the man who served Yahweh

General Comment on verse 7:c-e

The words in verse 7c–d are similar to Joshua 13:8. You should translate it in a similar way.

Joshua 18:8

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:8a

As the men got up to go out,

- So the men got ready and went.
- The men went on their journey.

As the men got up to go out: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as got up to go out is more literally “the men arose and they went.” This is a Hebrew idiom that is used to indicate the beginning of an action. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language to indicate the beginning of an action.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the men started to go

The men went on their journey

18:8b

Joshua commanded them to map out the land, saying,

- Joshua had commanded the ones who were going to survey the land. He said,
- Joshua had told them,

Joshua commanded them to map out the land, saying: The English word commanded can also be translated as “charged” or “told.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua instructed them (NIV)

Joshua repeated their orders (CEV)

18:8c

“Go and survey the land, map it out,

- “Walk^(plur) around the land and write a description of it.
- “Go through the land and write a report. It will show the boundaries of the land.

Go and survey the land, map it out: The words in 18:8c are similar to 18:4b–c. You should translate these verses in a similar way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Walk all around the land and write a report about it

Go through the land and draw a map of it. The map will show the boundaries of the land.

18:8d
and return to me.

- Then bring the description to me.
- When you return to me,

and return to me: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then come back to me

Then return to me

18:8e
Then I will cast lots for you here in Shiloh in the presence of the LORD.”

- Here in Shiloh town I will throw lots for you^(plur) in the presence of Yahweh.”
- I will throw marked stones here in Shiloh to let Yahweh decide how to divide the land among you.”

Then I will cast lots for you here in Shiloh in the presence of the LORD: This verse is like verse 18:6c except that the words in Shiloh are added.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Here in Shiloh town I will throw lots for you in the presence of Yahweh

I will throw marked stones here in Shiloh town to let Yahweh decide how to divide the land among you

Joshua 18:9

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:9a
So the men departed and went throughout the land,

- So the men left and went all through the land.
- So the men set out and went all over the land.

So the men departed and went throughout the land: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as throughout the land is more literally “they passed through in the land.” The Hebrew verb is different from the verb used in verse 18:4b but the meaning is the same.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the men left and went through the land (NIV)

So the men went all over the land. (GNT)

18:9b
mapping it city by city into seven portions.

- They wrote a description of the land in seven parts on a scroll. They listed the towns that were in each part.
- They wrote a report about it. The report showed how to divide the land into seven shares, and listed the towns in each share.

mapping it city by city into seven portions: The clause which the BSB translates as mapping it is more literally “they wrote it on a book.” This indicates that the men wrote down a description on writing material, perhaps on a scroll. They did not have books in the modern sense of the word.

city by city into seven portions: This indicates that the men described the land according to the towns that were in seven parts of the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and wrote down a description of the land in seven parts, according to the towns that were in each part

they described in a scroll each town that was in the seven parts into which they had divided the land (T4T)

they wrote a report about it on a scroll. The report showed how they divided up the land into seven parts and listed the towns in each part

18:9c

Then they returned with the document to Joshua at the camp in Shiloh.

- Then they returned to Joshua, to the camp in Shiloh town.
- Then they went back to Joshua. He was at the tenting place in Shiloh.

Then they returned with the document to Joshua at the camp in Shiloh: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then they returned to Joshua, to the camp in the town of Shiloh

Then they went back to Joshua. He was at the tenting place in Shiloh

Joshua 18:10

Section 18:1–10 Joshua divided land among the remaining seven clans

In this section Joshua instructed the remaining seven clans to make a plan for dividing up the rest of the land of Canaan.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Dividing the rest of the land

The rest of the land is distributed

18:10a

And Joshua cast lots for them in the presence of the LORD at Shiloh,

- There in Shiloh town Joshua threw lots for them in the presence of Yahweh.
- Joshua threw marked stones in the town of Shiloh to let Yahweh decide how to divide the land among the clans.

And Joshua cast lots for them in the presence of the LORD at Shiloh: The words here are similar to Joshua 18:6c and 18:8e.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So there in the town of Shiloh Joshua threw lots for them in the presence of Yahweh

Joshua threw marked stones in Shiloh town to let Yahweh decide how to divide the land among the clans

18:10b

where he distributed the land to the Israelites according to their divisions.

- Joshua divided the land among the remaining clans of Israel. Each clan received its own piece of land.
- He gave a share of land to each of the remaining clans of Israel.

where he distributed the land to the Israelites according to their divisions: The clause he distributed the land indicates that Joshua divided up the remaining land.

The word Israelites refers to the seven clans who had not yet received any land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and Joshua divided out the land to the remaining clans of Israel. Each clan received its own piece of land.

There he gave out a share of land to each of the remaining tribes in Israel (NIRV)

Joshua 18:11

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:11a

The first lot came up for the clans of the tribe of Benjamin.

- ¶ The first lot went to the clan of Benjamin by its families.
- ¶ The first clan to be given land was the Benjamin clan and its families.

The first lot came up for the clans of the tribe of Benjamin: This sentence indicates that the first clan chosen by lot was the clan of Benjamin. Each family of Benjamin received some land. This verse is similar to Joshua 15:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The first lot belonged to the tribe of Benjamin by its clans (NET)

The first clan to receive land was the Benjamin clan and its families

18:11b

Their allotted territory lay between the tribes of Judah and Joseph:

- The land they received was between the lands of the Judah clan and the Joseph clan.
- The land given to them was between the land that the clans of Judah and Joseph had received.

Their allotted territory lay between the tribes of Judah and Joseph: This indicates that the land that the clan of Benjamin received was between the lands of the clans of Judah and Joseph. Judah's land was to the south of Benjamin's land. Joseph's land was to the north of Benjamin's land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The land they received by lot was between the land of the Judah clan and the Joseph clan

The land assigned to them was between the land that the clans of Judah and Joseph had received

Joshua 18:12

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:12a

On the north side their border began at the Jordan,

- Their northern border began at the Jordan River in the east.
- These are the boundaries of Benjamin's land. On the north the boundary began at the Jordan River.

On the north side their border began at the Jordan:

The description of Benjamin's boundary began at the Jordan River in the east and continued to the west.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their northern border began at the Jordan River

Benjamin's boundary on the north began at the Jordan River

18:12b

went up past the northern slope of Jericho,

- Then it ascended the mountain ridge north of the town of Jericho.
- It went up from there to the mountain slope north of Jericho town

went up past the northern slope of Jericho: The phrase went up indicates that the boundary ascends in elevation.

the northern slope of Jericho: The northern slope of Jericho refers to a mountain ridge that is north of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then it ascended the mountain ridge north of Jericho

It went up from there to the mountain slope to the north of Jericho

18:12c

headed west through the hill country,

- It continued west up through the mountain country
- and westward into the mountains.

headed west through the hill country: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and continued west up through the mountain country

and westward into the mountains

18:12d

and came out at the wilderness of Beth-aven.

- until it reached the wilderness near Beth-aven.
- It ended in the wilderness near Beth-aven town.

and came out at the wilderness of Beth-aven: Beth-aven was a town in the mountains. It was mentioned in Joshua 7:2.

wilderness: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as wilderness indicates an uninhabited place. The area around “Beth-aven” was a wilderness, but it was not a desert with large areas of sand.

Beth-aven: Here are some ways that the English versions spell the name of Beth-aven town.

Beth-aven (BSB, RSV, ESV, NLT, NABRE, NASB, KJV)

Beth Aven (NET, NIV, GW)

Beth-Aven (CEV)

Bethaven (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until it reached the wilderness near Beth-aven

as far as the wasteland near Beth-aven town

Joshua 18:13

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin’s land

18:13a

From there the border crossed over to the southern slope of Luz

- From there the border passed along the mountain slope south of Luz,

- Then the boundary went along the mountain ridge south of the town of Luz.

From there the border crossed over to the southern slope of Luz: The Hebrew clause behind this verse is more literally “the boundary passed to Luz, to the shoulder of Luz, to the south.”

There is an interpretation issue in this verse. It concerns the placement of the Hebrew word translated as to the southern slope.

1. The Hebrew word translated as to the southern slope modifies the mountain ridge. It means that the mountain ridge is south of Luz. For example:

From there it crossed to the south slope of Luz (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NABRE, NET, GW, NLT, GNT, CEV)

1. The Hebrew word that means “to the south” modifies the boundary line. It means that the boundary line went south to Luz town. For example:

From there the boundary passes along southward in the direction of Luz, to the shoulder of Luz (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NJPS)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with many English versions and commentaries. Woudstra p 276.

the southern slope of Luz: The southern slope of Luz refers to a mountain ridge that was south of the town of Luz. Compare this with “the northern slope of Jericho” in 18:12b.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then border then went along the mountain ridge that was south of Luz town

From there it went to Luz...The border ran along the ridge south of Luz (CEV)

Luz: The town of Luz was mentioned in Joshua 16:2.

18:13b (that is, Bethel)

- which is now called Bethel.
- Luz is also named Bethel.

that is, Bethel: The phrase that is, Bethel indicates that the town of Luz was named Bethel at the time that the book of Joshua was written.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It is now called Bethel

Luz is also called Bethel

18:13c and went down to Ataroth-addar

- Then the border went down to the town of Ataroth-addar
- The boundary continued down to Ataroth-addar town.

and went down to Ataroth-addar: The town of Ataroth-addar was lower in elevation than the town of Bethel. It was mentioned in Joshua 16:5.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border went down to the town of Ataroth-addar

Then the border continued down to Ataroth-addar

18:13d on the hill south of Lower Beth-horon.

- which is on the mountain to the south of Lower Beth-horon town.
- It is on the hill south of the town of Lower Beth-horon.

on the hill south of Lower Beth-horon: The town of Lower Beth-horon is mentioned in verse 16:3b in connection with the border of Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

which is on the hill to the south of Lower Beth-horon

Ataroth-addar is on the hill south of the town of Lower Beth-horon

General Comment on 18:12–13

Verses 12–13 describe the northern border of the clan of Benjamin. This border is the same as the southern border of the clan of Ephraim which was described in chapter 16:1–2. It is recommended that you compare these two passages as you translate them.

Joshua 18:14

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:14a On the west side the border curved southward

- The border then changed direction. The western border went south,
- Then the boundary turned to the south on its western side.

On the west side the border curved southward: Verses 12–13 described the north side of Benjamin's land. Verse 14 describes the west side of their land. On the west side the boundary turns toward the south.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary then changed direction. On the west side the boundary went southward

At that point it turned south and became the western border (CEV)

18:14b from the hill facing Beth-horon on the south

- starting at the mountain that was south and across from the town of Beth-horon.
- It began by the mountain which was opposite the town of Beth-horon to its south.

from the hill facing Beth-horon on the south: The hill facing Beth-horon on the south marks the beginning of the western border. The town of Beth-horon was on a mountain. Across the valley to the south was another mountain that marked the border. It is the same mountain as was mentioned in verse 13 (that the BSB translates as "hill").

Note that Joshua 16:5 mentioned the town of Upper Beth-horon. Joshua 18:13 mentioned Lower Beth-horon. In this verse Upper Beth-horon and Lower Beth-horon are spoken of as one place.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The western boundary started at the mountain that was across from the town of Beth-horon

It began at the mountain which was opposite the town of Beth-horon, to the south

18:14c

and came out at Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim),

- The western border ended at the town of Kiriath-baal. That town was also called Kiriath-jearim.
- That side of the boundary ended by the town of Kiriath-baal, which was also named Kiriath-jearim.

and came out at Kiriath-baal (that is, Kiriath-jearim): The names Kiriath-baal and Kiriath-jearim are two names for the same town.

Here are some ways that English versions spell these names:

Kiriath-baal, Kiriath-jearim (BSB, RSV, ESV, NABRE, NASB, NLT, KJV)

Kiriath Baal, Kiriath Jearim (NET, NIV, GW, GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The western border ended at the town of Kiriath-baal. That town is also called Kiriath-jearim

That side of the border ended by the town of Kiriath-baal, which was also named Kiriath-jearim

18:14d

a city of the sons of Judah.

- It was in land that belonged to the Judah clan.
- People of the clan of Judah lived in the town of Kiriath-baal.

a city of the sons of Judah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

That town was in land that belonged to the Judah clan

People of the clan of Judah lived in the town of Kiriath-baal

18:14e

This was the western side.

- This was the western border of the land of Benjamin.
- That described the western boundary of Benjamin's land.

This was the western side: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This was the western boundary of the clan of Benjamin

That described the western border

Joshua 18:15

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:15a

On the south side the border began at the outskirts of Kiriath-jearim

- The southern border began at the edge of the town of Kiriath-jearim,
- The boundary on the south started at the limits of Kiriath-jearim.

On the south side the border began at the outskirts of Kiriath-jearim: Joshua 18:15–19 describes the south border of Benjamin's land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The south border began at the edge of Kiriath-jearim

The boundary of Benjamin's land on the south started at the limits of the town of Kiriath-jearim

18:15b
and extended westward to the spring at the Waters of Nephtoah.

- and went to the spring of Nephtoah.
- Then the boundary continued to the spring of water called Nephtoah.

and extended westward: The Hebrew text is difficult. The Hebrew text reads “and the boundary goes westward.” However, that contradicts verse 14. In verse 14 the western boundary came to an end. The description of the southern boundary begins here and is described from west to east. The English versions have handled this difficulty in several ways:

1. Some versions omit the word westward. For example:

and projected... (NABRE) (NABRE, GNT)

1. Some versions follow the Hebrew text. For example:

and extended westward (NET) (BSB, NET, GW, NASB, NJPS)

1. Some versions change the text to follow Joshua 15:9, which describes the same border, going from east to west. For example:

and the boundary goes from there to Ephron (RSV) (RSV, ESV)

1. Some versions move the word “west” to a different place in the sentence. For example:

The southern side began at the outskirts of Kiriath Jearim on the west (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This makes the least change to the text, while still making sense. If you do this, it is recommended that you add a footnote to explain the Hebrew text. For example:

FOOTNOTE: The Hebrew text says: “and the boundary goes westward.”

to the spring at the Waters of Nephtoah: This is the spring mentioned in Joshua 15:9b. You should translate this phrase as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border went on to the spring of Nephtoah

Then the border continued to the spring of water called Nephtoah

Joshua 18:16

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin’s land

18:16a

Then it went down to the foot of the hill

- Then it descended to the base of the mountain
- The boundary went down to the foot of the mountain

Then it went down to the foot of the hill: This indicates that the border descended to the foot of the mountain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border descends to the foot of the mountain (GW)

The boundary went down to the foot of the hill (NIV)

18:16b

that faces the Valley of Hinnom

- that faced the valley of the son of Hinnom.
- that was opposite the valley of the son of Hinnom.

that faces the Valley of Hinnom: This valley was mentioned in Joshua 15:8. You should translate it the same way that you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

facing the Valley of Ben Hinnom (NIV)

that overlooks the Valley of the Son of Hinnom (ESV)

18:16c
at the northern end of the Valley of Rephaim

- That mountain is on the north side of the valley of Rephaim.
- It is on the northern edge of Rephaim Valley.

at the northern end of the Valley of Rephaim: This valley was mentioned in Joshua 15:8e. It is recommended that you translate this part of the verse in the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

That mountain is on the northern side of the Valley of Rephaim

It is on the northern edge of Rephaim Valley

18:16d
and ran down the Valley of Hinnom

- Then the border went along the valley of Hinnom.
- The boundary line passed through the Hinnom Valley,

and ran down the Valley of Hinnom: This indicates that the boundary line of Benjamin's land continued through the Valley of Hinnom.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border went along the Valley of Hinnom

The boundary line passed through the Hinnom Valley

18:16e
toward the southern slope of the Jebusites and downward to En-rogel.

- It continued to the mountain ridge that was south of Jerusalem and then descended to the spring of En-rogel.
- and went past the hill that was south of Jerusalem and down to En-rogel Spring.

toward the southern slope of the Jebusites: The phrase the southern slope of the Jebusites refers to a mountain ridge that was south of Jerusalem.

Jebusites: The Jebusites were people who lived in Jerusalem. Jebus was the name of the town of Jerusalem before David conquered it.

and downward to En-rogel: The name En-rogel refers to a spring in the Kidron valley east of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It continued to the mountain ridge that was south of Jerusalem and then descended to the spring of En-rogel

and went on past the hill that was south of the town of Jerusalem and down to En-rogel Spring

Joshua 18:17

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:17a
From there it curved northward and proceeded to En-shemesh

- Then the border turned to the north and continued to the spring of En-shemesh.
- The boundary line then curved northward to En-shemesh Spring.

From there it curved northward: This indicates that the southern border made a turn to the north at this point.

and proceeded to En-shemesh: En-shemesh is the name of a spring of water that was near Jerusalem. This spring was mentioned in Joshua 15:7. It is recommended that you translate it the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border turned to the north and continued to the spring of En-shemesh

The boundary line then curved northward to En-shemesh Spring

18:17b**and on to Geliloth facing the Ascent of Adummim,**

- From there it went to Geliloth, which faced the Pass of Adummim.
- Then it continued to the circle of stones which was across from the road going up Adummim Mountain.

and on to Geliloth: The term Geliloth means “circle of stones” in Hebrew. It is not known where Geliloth was. It is uncertain whether or not Geliloth was a town.

Here are some other ways to translate this term:

Geliloth

the circle of stones

facing the Ascent of Adummim: The Ascent of Adummim is a road that went up Adummim Mountain. This clause is the same as the one found in Joshua 15:7b. It is recommended that you translate it in the same way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From there it went on to the circle of stones
across from the Pass of Adummim

Then it continued to Geliloth, which was across
from the road that went up Adummim Mountain

18:17c**and continued down to the Stone of Bohan son of Reuben.**

- Then the border descended to the stone of Bohan, the son of Reuben.
- The boundary continued to go down eastward to the large stone of Bohan, who was the son of Reuben.

and continued down to the Stone of Bohan son of Reuben: The Stone of Bohan was mentioned in Joshua 15:6c. It is recommended that you translate it the same way as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border descended to the large stone of
Bohan, the son of Reuben

The boundary continued to go east downhill to the
stone of Bohan. Bohan was the son of Reuben.

Joshua 18:18**Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land**

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:18a**Then it went on to the northern slope of Beth-arabah**

- It went along the north side of the slope overlooking the Jordan River valley.
- From there it passed north of the ridge that faced the valley of the Jordan River

Then it went on to the northern slope of Beth-arabah:

There is a textual issue about the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Beth-arabah.

1. The Hebrew text reads “in front of the Arabah.” For example:

It crossed to the slope in front of the Arabah to the north (NET) (NET, NASB, NABRE, NJPS, GW, GNT, NLT, KJV)

1. The Septuagint reads “Beth-arabah.” For example:

It continued to the northern slope of Beth Arabah (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the reading of the Hebrew text, and is followed by many English versions and Bible commentaries. Woudstra p. 277.

Some versions follow the Septuagint because they compare this verse with Joshua 15:6. The Hebrew text of Joshua 15:5 reads “It passed along to Beth-arabah to the north.” Joshua 15:6 and 18:18 describe the same boundary, although they trace it in different directions.

Beth-arabah: The word “arabah” is a Hebrew word that refers to the valley of the Jordan River.

Based on option (1) of the previous note, here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From there it passed along the north side of the slope overlooking the Jordan Valley (NLT)

and passed north of the ridge overlooking the Jordan Valley (GNT)

18:18b and went down into the valley.

- Then the border descended into the Jordan River valley.
- and went down into the valley of the Jordan River.

and went down into the valley: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then the border descended into the Jordan River Valley

then it went down into the valley of the Jordan River

Joshua 18:19

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:19a The border continued to the northern slope of Beth-hoglah

- From there the border continued east and passed the northern slope of Beth-hoglah.
- Then the boundary went north of the mountain ridge of Beth-hoglah town.

The border continued to the northern slope of Beth-hoglah: The town of Beth-hoglah was mentioned in verse 15:6a. It was to the southeast of the town of Jericho. Rasmussen p. 229.

northern slope of Beth-hoglah: The northern slope of Beth-hoglah refers to a mountain ridge that was near the town of Beth-hoglah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

passing north of the ridge of Beth Hoglah (GNT)

Then the border went along north of the ridge of Beth-hoglah town

18:19b and came out at the northern bay of the Salt Sea,

- And the border ended at the bay at the north end of the Salt Sea,
- It ended at the northern point of the Dead Sea

and came out at the northern bay of the Salt Sea: The northern bay of the Salt Sea is the northernmost part of the Salt Sea.

Salt Sea: In English the Salt Sea is usually referred to as the Dead Sea. You should use the same term as you did in Joshua 15:5a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary ended at the north end of the Dead Sea

Benjamin's border ended at the northern end of the Salt Sea

18:19c at the mouth of the Jordan.

- which is at the south end of the Jordan River.
- where the Jordan River flowed into it.

at the mouth of the Jordan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

which was at the south end of the Jordan River

where the Jordan River flowed into it

18:19d This was the southern border.

- That was the south border of Benjamin's land.
- This describes the southern boundary of the clan of Benjamin.

This was the southern border: This clause is a conclusion to Joshua 18:15–19, which described the southern border.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This described the southern boundary line for the clan of Benjamin

That was the south border of Benjamin's land

Joshua 18:20

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:20a

On the east side the border was the Jordan.

- The Jordan River formed the eastern border.
- The boundary on the east side of their land was the Jordan River.

On the east side the border was the Jordan: The eastern border is easy to describe. The full description is in this one phrase.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Jordan River formed the eastern boundary line

The border on the east side of Benjamin's land was the Jordan River

18:20b

These were the borders around the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin.

- This was the land that the clan of Benjamin received as their inheritance. These borders marked the four sides of the land that they received according to their families.
- That describes the land that the Benjamin clan received. Each family received land within these boundaries.

These were the borders around the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin: The clause These were the borders around the inheritance is a conclusion to Joshua 18:12–20. We have now made a circle

around all four of the boundary lines of the land that Benjamin received.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This was the land that the clan of Benjamin received as their inheritance

That described the land that the Benjamin clan received as its permanent possession

These were the borders around the inheritance: The phrase the borders around refers to the boundary lines on all sides: north, south, east and west.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These boundaries marked out the land that they received according to their family groups

Each clan received land within these boundaries

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the phrase the borders around with the information in 18:20b. For example:

These were the borders of the land which the clan of Benjamin received as their inheritance

Those boundaries described the land that the Benjamin clan received

the clans: The phrase the clans actually refers to the families within the clan of Benjamin.

Joshua 18:21

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:21a

These were the cities of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin:

- ¶ The following towns belonged to the families of the clan of Benjamin:
- ¶ The families of the Benjamin clan received these towns:

These were the cities of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin: This introduces a list of the towns that were within Benjamin's land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The following towns belonged to the families of the clan of Benjamin

The families of the Benjamin clan received these towns. In the eastern part of their territory there were:

18:21b

Jericho, Beth-hoglah, Emek-keziz,

- Jericho and Beth-hoglah and Emek-keziz,

Jericho, Beth-hoglah, Emek-keziz: The towns listed in verses 21–24 were in the eastern part of Benjamin's territory. The town of Beth-hoglah was mentioned in Joshua 18:19a. The town of Emek-keziz is mentioned only here in the Bible, and its location is unknown.

Joshua 18:22

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:22

Beth-arabah, Zemaraim, Bethel,

- and Beth-arabah and Zemaraim and Bethel

Beth-arabah, Zemaraim, Bethel:

Joshua 18:23

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:23

Avvim, Parah, Ophrah,

- and Avvim and Parah and Ophrah

Avvim, Parah, Ophrah:

Joshua 18:24

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:24a

Chephar-ammoni, Ophni, and Geba—

- and Chepharammoni and Ophni and Geba.

Chephar-ammoni, Ophni, and Geba:

18:24b

twelve cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were twelve towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- The number of these was twelve towns, and there were villages that were near them.

twelve cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

there were twelve towns in this area and there were villages that surrounded them

a total of twelve towns, with the villages that were near them

Joshua 18:25

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:25

Gibeon, Ramah, Beeroth,

- They also received Gibeon and Ramah and Be-eroth

Gibeon, Ramah, Beeroth: The towns listed in verses 25–28 were in the western part of Benjamin's territory. Here is another way to translate these words:

In the western part of their territory there were the towns of Gibeon, Ramah, Be-eroth,

Joshua 18:26

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:26

Mizpeh, Chephirah, Mozah,

- and Mizpeh and Chephirah and Mozah

Mizpeh, Chephirah, Mozah:

Joshua 18:27

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:27

Rekem, Irpeel, Taralah,

- and Rekem and Irpeel and Taralah

Rekem, Irpeel, Taralah:

Joshua 18:28

Section 18:11–28 The clan of Benjamin received their land

This section describes the boundaries of the land of Benjamin and the towns within it.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The land of the clan of Benjamin

Benjamin's land

18:28a

Zelah, Haeleph, Jebus (that is, Jerusalem),

- and Zela and Ha-eleph and Jebus which is now called Jerusalem,
- and Zela and Ha-eleph and the town of the Jebus people. That town is now named Jerusalem.

Zelah, Haeleph, Jebus (that is, Jerusalem): The term Jebus is an older name for the town of Jerusalem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Jebus, which is now called Jerusalem

The town of the Jebus people. That town is now named Jerusalem.

18:28b

Gibeah, and Kiriath-jearim—fourteen cities, along with their villages.

- and Gibe-ah and Kiriath-jearim. In all there were fourteen towns, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- There were also Gibe-ah and Kiriath-jearim. The number of these was fourteen towns, and there were villages near them.

Gibeah, and Kiriath-jearim—fourteen cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

there were fourteen towns in this area, and there were villages that surrounded them

a total of fourteen towns, with the villages that were near them

18:28c

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin.

- This was the land that the families of the clan of Benjamin received as their inheritance.
- That describes the land that the families of the Benjamin clan received.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Benjamin: This verse repeats information from verse 18:20. You should translate it in the same way as you did there.

Joshua 19:1

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:1a

The second lot came out

- ¶ The second lot belonged to (NET)
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a second time

The second lot came out: The clause The second lot refers to the second time that Joshua threw the lot. This time the lot showed that the clan of Simeon should receive their land. This verse is similar to verse 15:1 and 18:11. In each case the Hebrew verb is slightly different, but the meaning is the same.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The second lot belonged (NET)

Joshua threw the lot a second time

19:1b

for the clans of the tribe of Simeon:

- the clan of Simeon. They received land according to their families.
- and each family of the clan of Simeon received some land.

for the clans of the tribe of Simeon: The phrase the clans refers to the families among Simeon's descendants. Simeon was one of the twelve sons of Jacob who had many descendants.

the tribe of Simeon: The phrase the tribe of Simeon refers to all the clans of Simeon.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Each of the families of the Simeon clan received some land

Joshua threw the lot again. This second lot showed that the clans of Simeon was the next to receive land. There was some land for each family in the Simeon clans.

19:1c

Their inheritance lay within the territory of Judah

- Their land was within the land that belonged to the clan of Judah.
- Their land was inside the land that the clan of Judah had received.

Their inheritance lay within the territory of Judah: The sentence Their inheritance lay within the territory of Judah indicates that the land that the clans of Simeon received was inside the boundaries of the land that the clans of Judah had received.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

their land was within the boundaries of the land that belonged to the clans of Judah

their land was inside the land that the clans of Judah had received

Joshua 19:2

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:2

and included Beersheba (or Sheba), Moladah,

- They received these towns as their permanent possession: Beer-sheba, which is also called Sheba, and Moladah.
- The land that was assigned to them included the following towns: Beer-sheba or Sheba town, and Moladah town,

and included Beersheba (or Sheba), Moladah: The towns listed in verses 2–6 were in the south part of the land that belonged to the clan of Judah.

Beersheba: There is also an interpretation issue with the word Beersheba.

1. Sheba is another name for the town of Beersheba. For example:

Beersheba (or Sheba), Moladah (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, NJPS, NASB, GW, REB, KJV)

1. Sheba is a different town. It is not the same town as Beersheba. For example:

Beersheba, Sheba, Moladah (ESV) (ESV, RSV, NRSV, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with many English versions. There is a similar list of the towns that belonged to the clan of Simeon in 1 Chronicles 4:28. That list does not include the town of Sheba. Moreover, if Sheba is counted as an independent town in this list, the total number of towns would come to fourteen, rather than thirteen, as stated in verse 6. Because of this, many Bible scholars consider the term Sheba to be an alternative name for the town of Beersheba.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They received the following towns as its permanent possession: Beersheba, which is also called Sheba, and Moladah

The land that was assigned to them included the following towns: Beersheba, or Sheba, and Moladah

Sheba: There is a textual issue with the word Sheba.

1. The text should say Sheba. This follows the Masoretic Text. (BSB, NIV, NET, RSV, ESV, NJPS, NASB, GW, GNT, KJV)
2. The text should say Shema. This follows the Septuagint, and it also agrees with Joshua 15:26. (NABRE, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is the reading of most English versions, and is supported by many commentaries.

Joshua 19:3

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:3

Hazar-shual, Balah, Ezem,

- They also received the towns of Hazar-shual, Balah and Ezem,
- and Hazar-shual town and Balah town and Ezem town,

Hazar-shual, Balah, Ezem: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

They also received the towns of Hazar-shual and Balah and Ezem

Hazar-shual and Balah and Ezem

Joshua 19:4

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:4

Eltolad, Bethul, Hormah,

- the towns of Eltolad, Bethul and Hormah,
- and Eltolad town and Bethul town and Hormah town,

Eltolad, Bethul, Hormah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Eltolad, the town of Bethul, the town of Hormah

Eltolad town and Bethul town and Hormah town

Joshua 19:5

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:5

Ziklag, Beth-marcaboth, Hazar-susah,

- the towns of Ziklag, Beth-marcaboth and Hazar-susah,
- and Ziklag town and Beth-marcaboth town and Hazar-susah town

Ziklag, Beth-marcaboth, Hazar-susah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Ziklag, the town of Beth-marcaboth, the town of Hazar-susah

Ziklag town and Beth-marcaboth town and Hazar-susah town

Joshua 19:6

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:6

Beth-lebaoth, and Sharuhén—thirteen cities, along with their villages.

- and the towns of Beth-lebaoth and Sharuhén. In all there were thirteen towns and the villages that surrounded them.
- and Beth-lebaoth town and Sharuhén town. The number of these towns was thirteen (13), and there were villages that were near them.

Beth-lebaoth, and Sharuhén—thirteen cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Beth-lebaoth and the town of Sharuhén. In all there were thirteen towns and the villages that surrounded them.

and Beth-lebaoth and Sharuhén. The number of all these towns was thirteen, and there were villages that were near them.

Joshua 19:7

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:7

Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan—four cities, along with their villages,

- They also received the towns of Ain, Rimmon, Ether and Ashan. There were four towns with the villages that surrounded them.
- Their land also included the towns of Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan. The number of these towns was four towns with the villages that were near them.

Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan—four cities, along with their villages: There is a textual issue in the first part of the word Rimmon (some versions have “En-rimmon”):

1. En-rimmon is two towns: Ain and Rimmon. This is the way the vowels are written in the Masoretic

text. (BSB, NRSV, NIV, ESV, NJB, NABRE, NJPS, NET, NASB, REB, GNT, KJV)

2. En-rimmon is one town. This is the reading of the Septuagint. (RSV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with the majority of English versions. This also agrees with the list of the same towns in Joshua 15:32.

The towns of Ain and Rimmon were in the southern part of Judah’s land. The towns of Ether and Ashan were farther north, in the Shephelah district. Woudstra p. 281.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received the towns of Ain, Rimmon, Ether, and Ashan. There were four towns with the villages that surrounded them.

Their land also included the towns of Ain, Rimmon, Ether and Ashan. The number of these towns was four towns with the villages that were near them.

Joshua 19:8

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:8a

and all the villages surrounding these cities as far as Baalath-beer

- They received all the villages that were near these towns, as far to the south as the town of Baalath-beer.
- Simeon’s land also included all the other towns and villages as far south as Baalath-beer, (CEV)

and all the villages surrounding these cities as far as Baalath-beer: Baalath-beer was a town in the southern part of Judah’s territory.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received all the villages that were near these towns, as far to the south as the town of Baalath-beer

Simeon’s land also included all the other towns and villages as far south as Baalath-Beer (CEV)

19:8b (Ramah of the Negev).

- This town also had the name Ramah of the Negeb.
- which is also called Ramah of the South. (CEV)

Ramah of the Negev: The phrase Ramah of the Negev is another name for the town of Baalath-beer. The term Negev means “south” in Hebrew.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This town also had the name Ramah of the South

which is also called Ramah of the South (CEV)

19:8c This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Simeon.

- This was the land that the families of the clan of Simeon received as their inheritance.
- That describes the land that the Simeon clan received as its permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Simeon: This is similar to verse 18:20b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This was the land which the family groups of the clan of Simeon received as their inheritance

That described the land that the Simeon clan received as its permanent possession. Each family received some land.

Joshua 19:9

Section 19:1–9: The clan of Simeon received their land

19:9a The inheritance of the Simeonites was taken from the territory of Judah,

- Their clan received land within the boundaries of the clan of Judah,
- That land was inside the land of the Judah clan.

The inheritance of the Simeonites was taken from the territory of Judah: The information in verse 9a was already stated in verse 1c.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of the Simeon clan received land within the boundaries of the clan of Judah

The land that the clan of Simeon received as their permanent possession was inside the land of the clan of Judah

19:9b because the share for Judah’s descendants was too large for them.

- because the clan of Judah did not need all the land that it had received.
- The clan of Judah had received too much land for the number of people in its clan,

because the share for Judah’s descendants was too large for them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because the clan of Judah did not need all the land that it had received

Judah had received too much land for the number of people in its tribe (CEV)

19:9c So the Simeonites received an inheritance within Judah’s portion.

- Therefore, the inheritance of the clan of Simeon was within the boundaries of the inheritance of the clan of Judah.
- so part of Judah’s land was given to Simeon. (CEV)

So the Simeonites received an inheritance within Judah’s portion: This restates information from verse 9a. The repetition emphasizes that the clan of Simeon did not receive their own separate land. This repetition may not be natural in some languages. A way to avoid this repetition is suggested below.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the inheritance of the clan of Simeon was within the boundaries of the inheritance of the clan of Judah

Therefore the clan of Simeon received their share of land inside the land that belonged to the clan of Judah

General Comment on verse 19:9

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the information in this verse so that there is less repetition. For example:

Simeon's tribal land was actually inside Judah's territory. Judah had received too much land for the number of people in its tribe, so part of Judah's land was given to Simeon. (CEV)

Joshua 19:10

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:10a

The third lot came up for the clans of the tribe of Zebulun:

- ¶ The third lot belonged to the tribe of Zebulun, by its clans. (NET)
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a third time and the clan of Zebulun received land, according to its family groups.

The third lot came up for the clans of the tribe of Zebulun: This is similar to 19:1a–b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The third lot belonged to the tribe of Zebulun, by its clans (NET)

Joshua threw the lot a third time and the clans of Zebulun received land, according to its family groups

19:10b

The border of their inheritance stretched as far as Sarid.

- Their land reached as far as the town of Sarid in the southeast.
- Their southern border began at the town of Sarid in the east.

The border of their inheritance stretched as far as Sarid: The land that the clan of Zebulun received was in northern Palestine.

Sarid: Sarid is a town that was southeast of the town of Nazareth in northern Palestine. This town was in the

southeastern most part of Zebulun's land. Woudstra p. 283.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their land reached as far as the town of Sarid in the southeast

Their southern border began at the town of Sarid in the east

Joshua 19:11

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:11a

It went up westward to Maralah,

- The border went west to the town of Maralah.
- From there the boundary went west to the town of Maralah,

It went up westward to Maralah: The clause went up westward to Maralah indicates that the boundary line continued westward from Sarid town. The southern boundary line of Zebulun's land followed the course of the Kishon River. Aharoni p. 257. The Kishon River flows from east to northwest through the Valley of Jezreel and enters the Mediterranean Sea at the port of Haifa.

Maralah: It is not certain where this town was located.

There is an interpretation issue with the term Maralah. Bible scholars divide the Hebrew words in two different ways.

1. The name of the town is Maralah. (BSB, NRSV, NIV, NASB, NJPS, NET, NLT, GW, REB, NJB, CEV, KJV)
2. The name of the town is Mareal. The Hebrew word "Maralah" should be separated into "Mareal" and "-ah." The last syllable -ah is a Hebrew directional. (RSV, ESV, NABRE, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Most English versions and most Bible atlases Rasmussen p. 244; Aharoni p. 257. refer to the name of this town as Maralah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border went west to the town of Maralah

From there the boundary ran on to the town of Maralah

19:11b reached Dabbesheth,

- Then it went on to the town of Dabbesheth.
- and continued to the town of Dabbesheth.

reached Dabbesheth: The clause reached Dabbesheth indicates that the southern border continued to the town of Dabbesheth.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then it went on to the town of Dabbesheth

and continued to the town of Dabbesheth

19:11c and met the brook east of Jokneam.

- The border then went on to the stream near the town of Jokne-am.
- Then it went on to the river valley near the town of Jokne-am.

met the brook east of Jokneam: The phrase the brook east of Jokneam refers to a streambed that flowed with water in certain seasons. It was near the town of Jokneam.

east: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as east is more literally “on the face of.” There are two ways to interpret this word.

1. It means “near” or “opposite.” For example:

the ravine near Jokneam (NIV) (NIV, NET, NASB, GW, NJPS, NJB, NABRE, CEV, KJV)

1. It means “east.” For example:

the stream east of Jokneam (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, ESV, REB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). We do not know for certain where the brook was in relation to Jokneam town. It is best to translate it using a word that means “near” or “close to.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border then went on to the streambed near the town of Jokne-am

It reached the wadi near the town of Jokne-am

Joshua 19:12

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:12a From Sarid it turned eastward

- From the other side of the town of Sarid the border went east toward the sunrise
- Beginning again at Sarid town the border went east

From Sarid it turned eastward: The description of the border returns to the starting point at the town of Sarid. The southern border is described as it went northeast along the foothills near Nazareth. Aharoni p. 257.

it turned eastward: Although the Hebrew phrase is literally “eastward toward the sunrise,” in some languages it may be redundant to include both the term eastward and the phrase “toward the sunrise.” One of these terms may be left as implicit information. For example:

From Sarid it turned eastward to the territory of Kisloth Tabor (NET)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the other side of the town of Sarid it turned east toward the sunrise

Beginning again at Sarid town the border went toward the sunrise

19:12b along the border of Chisloth-tabor

- up to the border of Chisloth-tabor town.
- to the boundary of the town of Chisloth-tabor.

along the border of Chisloth-tabor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as border also has the meaning of “territory.” Some English versions translate this term as “territory.” It is recommended that you translate this term as “boundary” or border.

Chisloth-tabor: The term Chisloth-tabor refers to a town. It was southeast of the town of Nazareth.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

up to the border of Chisloth-tabor

and reached the boundary of the town of Chisloth-tabor

19:12c

and went on to Daberath and up to Japhia.

- From there it went to Daberath town and then uphill to Japhia town.
- The boundary line continued to the town of Daberath and up to the town of Japhia.

and went on to Daberath and up to Japhia: The town of Daberath is northeast of Chisloth-tabor. The town of Japhia is southeast of the town of Nazareth.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From there the border went on to Daberath town and then on to Japhia town

Then the boundary line continued to the town of Daberath and up to the town of Japhia

Joshua 19:13

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:13a

From there it crossed eastward to Gath-hepher

- From there the border went east toward the sunrise to the town of Gath-hepher,
- It then continued east to the town of Gath-hepher.

From there it crossed eastward to Gath-hepher: This verse describes the eastern border. The town of Gath-hepher was north of the towns of Daberath and Japhia.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From there the eastern border went toward the sunrise to the town of Gath-hepher

It then continued on the east side to the town of Gath-hepher

19:13b

and to Eth-kazin; it extended to Rimmon and curved around toward Neah.

- and on to the towns of Eth-kazin and Rimmon, turning toward Neah.

- It continued on to Eth-kazin town and Rimmon town, and curved toward Neah town.

and to Eth-kazin: The location of the town of Eth-kazin is unknown.

it extended to Rimmon: Rimmon was a town six miles northeast of Nazareth.

and curved around toward Neah: The exact location of the town of Neah is unknown. It was on the northern border of Zebulun's land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It went on to the towns of Eth-kazin and Rimmon, turning towards Neah

Then the border continued to Eth-kazin town and Rimmon, and curved towards Neah

Joshua 19:14

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:14a

Then the border circled around the north side of Neah to Hannathon

- Then the border turned north of the town of Hannathon.
- On the north the border turned toward Hannathon. (GNT)

Then the border circled around the north side of Neah to Hannathon: This verse describes the northern boundary. The border ran to the north of the town of Hannathon. Hannathon was on the northwestern boundary of Zebulun's land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

On the north the border turned toward Hannathon (GNT)

The border turned north of the town of Hannathon

19:14b

and ended at the Valley of Iphtah-el.

- Zebulun's boundary line ended at the valley of Iphtah-el.
- The border ended at Iphtah-el Valley on the west.

and ended at the Valley of Iphtah-el: The Valley of Iphtah-el was on the western boundary of Zebulun. This boundary touched Asher's land. This valley is also mentioned in verse 19:27.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Zebulun's boundary line ended at the valley of Iphtah-el

The border ended at Iphtah-el valley on the west

Joshua 19:15

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:15a

It also included Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah, and Bethlehem.

- The clan of Zebulun received the towns of Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah and Bethlehem.
- Zebulun's land included the towns of Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah and Bethlehem.

It also included Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah, and Bethlehem: It is not certain where the towns of Kattath, Nahalal, and Idalah were. The town of Shimron was west of Nazareth. The town of Bethlehem which is mentioned here was northwest of Nazareth. It is not the same town as the town of Bethlehem which was in the land of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clans of Zebulun received the towns of Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah and Bethlehem

Zebulun's land included the towns of Kattath, Nahalal, Shimron, Idalah and Bethlehem

19:15b

There were twelve cities, along with their villages.

- In all they had twelve towns with their surrounding villages.
- Altogether there were twelve towns with the villages that were near them.

There were twelve cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Altogether there were twelve towns with the villages that surrounded them

These were included in their twelve towns and the villages that were near them

General Comment on verse 19:15

It may be more natural in some languages to reverse the order of the parts of this verse. For example:

Zebulun had twelve towns with their surrounding villages. Some of these were Katta, Nahalal, Shimron, Jiralah, and Bethlehem (CEV)

Joshua 19:16

Section 19:10–16: The clan of Zebulun received their land

19:16a

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Zebulun,

- This was the land that the clan of Zebulun received as their inheritance, according to their families.
- The clan of Zebulun received that land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Zebulun: This is similar to verse 19:8c.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This was the land that the clan of Zebulun received as their inheritance, according to its families

The clan of Zebulun received this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land

19:16b

including these cities and their villages.

- They received these towns with the villages that were around them.
- They received those towns with the villages that were near them.

including these cities and their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they received those towns with the villages that were around them

They received these towns with the villages nearby them

Joshua 19:17

Section 19:17–23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:17

The fourth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Issachar:

- ¶ The fourth lot belonged to the tribe of Issachar, by its clans. (NET)
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a fourth time and the clan of Issachar received land. Each family of the clan of Issachar received land.

The fourth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Issachar: The first part of the verse is similar to verse 19:1a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The fourth lot belonged to the tribe of Issachar (NET)

Joshua threw the lot the fourth time and the clan of Issachar received land

the clans of the tribe of Issachar: This part is similar to verse 19:1b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

by its clans (NET)

The clan of Issachar received land according to their families

Each family of the clan of Issachar received some land

Joshua 19:18

Section 19:17–23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:18

Their territory included Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem,

- Their land included the cities of Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem, (T4T)

- They received the towns of Jezreel and Chesulloth and Shunem

Their territory included Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem: The terms Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem refer to towns. These towns were in the plain of Jezreel. Woudstra p, 285.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their land included the cities of Jezreel, Chesulloth, Shunem (T4T)

They received Jezreel and Chesulloth and Shunem

Joshua 19:19

Section 19:17–23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:19

Hapharaim, Shion, Anaharath,

- and Haphara-im town and Shion town and Anaharath town

Hapharaim, Shion, Anaharath: The location of these three towns is not certain.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

and Hapharaim town and Shion town and Anaharath town

Joshua 19:20

Section 19:17–23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:20

Rabbith, Kishion, Ebez,

- and Rabbith town and Kishion town and Ebez town

Rabbith, Kishion, Ebez: The exact location of these towns is not certain.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Rabbith town and Kishion town and Ebez town

Joshua 19:21

Section 19:17–23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:21

Remeth, En-gannim, En-haddah, and Beth-pazzez.

- and Remeth town and En-gannim town and En-haddah town and Beth-pazzez town.

Remeth, En-gannim, En-haddah, and Beth-pazzez:

The town of En-gannim was west of Beth-shean in the southern part of the plain of Jezreel. Woudstra p. 287. The location of the other towns in this verse is not known.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

and Remeth town and En-gannim town and En-haddah town and Beth-pazzez town

Joshua 19:22

Section 19:17-23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:22a

The border reached Tabor, Shahazumah, and Beth-shemesh,

- Their boundary line went up to the towns of Tabor and Shahazumah and Beth-shemesh.
- The border was close to Tabor town, Shahazumah town and Beth-shemesh town.

The border reached Tabor: 1 Chronicles 6:77 mentions a town of Tabor. It is listed as a town that belonged to the clan of Zebulun. It was probably near Mount Tabor, which is in the northeastern part of the plain of Jezreel. Boling and Wright p. 450. The verb reached indicates that the town of Tabor was beyond the northern boundary of Issachar's land. The clan of Issachar's land was southeast of Zebulun's land.

Shahazumah: the location of the town of Shahazumah is not known.

and Beth-shemesh: This is not the same town as was mentioned in verse 15:10. The location of the town of Beth-shemesh in Issachar's land is uncertain. Boling and Wright p. 450.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their boundary line went up northward to the towns of Tabor and the towns of Shahazumah and Beth-shemesh

The border of Issachar's land was close to Tabor, Shahazumah and Beth-shemesh

19:22b

and ended at the Jordan. There were sixteen cities, along with their villages.

- The boundary line ended at the Jordan River. In all, Issachar received sixteen towns and the villages that surrounded them.
- The border went on to the east as far as the Jordan River. Issachar's land included sixteen towns and the villages that were near them.

and ended at the Jordan. There were sixteen cities, along with their villages: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The boundary line of Issachar's land ended at the Jordan River. In all Issachar received sixteen towns and the villages that surrounded them

The border went on to the east as far as the Jordan River. Issachar's land included sixteen towns and the villages that were near them

Joshua 19:23

Section 19:17-23: The clan of Issachar received their land

19:23a

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Issachar,

- This was the land that the clan of Issachar received as their inheritance, according to its families.
- The clan of Issachar got this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Issachar: This part of the verse is similar to verse 19:16a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This was the land that the clan of Issachar received as their inheritance, according to its families

The clan of Issachar received this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land

19:23b

including these cities and their villages.

- They received these towns with the villages that were around them.
- They received those towns with the villages that were near them.

including these cities and their villages: This part of the verse is the same as verse 19:16b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they received these towns with the villages that were around them

They received these towns with the villages nearby them

Joshua 19:24

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:24

The fifth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Asher:

- ¶ The fifth lot belonged to the tribe of Asher, by its clans. (NET)
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a fifth time. Each family of the clan of Asher received land.

The fifth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Asher: This verse is similar to 19:1. It is recommended that you translate it in the same way as you did that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The fifth lot belonged to the tribe of Asher, by its clans (NET)

Joshua threw the lot the fifth time. Each of family of the clan of Asher received land

Joshua 19:25

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:25

Their territory included Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph,

- Their land included the towns of Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph,
- Their area had Helkath town and Hali town and Beten town and Achshaph town

Their territory included Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph: The clan of Asher received land in the northwest area of Israel. These towns were in the southwest part of Asher's land. Rasmussen p. 99. The town of Achshaph was mentioned in chapter 11:1. It was at the south edge of the plain of Acco, near the foot of Mount Carmel. Coleson p. 149.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their land included the towns of Helkath, Hali, Beten, Achshaph

Their area included Helkath and Hali and Beten and Achshaph

Joshua 19:26

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:26a

Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal.

- and the towns of Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal.
- and Allammelech town and Amad town and Mishal town.

Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal: The location of these towns is not certain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Allammelech town and Amad town and Mishal town

and the towns of Allammelech, Amad, and Mishal

19:26b

On the west the border touched Carmel and Shihor-libnath,

- The border began in the southwest at Mount Carmel and Shihor-libnath.
- Their western border started from the south at Carmel Mountain and Shihor-libnath.

On the west the border touched Carmel: The clause On the west the border touched Carmel indicates that the clan of Asher's land extended to the Mount Carmel Range in the southwest. The Mount Carmel range extends to the Mediterranean Sea south of the land that the clan of Asher received. The western border of Asher's land ran along the Mediterranean Sea. How-

ever, the text does not describe all the western border. Here it mentions the southern point of the western border. In the next verse it describes the border as it ran southeast to the land that belonged to the clan of Zebulun.

and Shihor-libnath: The location of Shihor-libnath is unknown. It is not certain whether this name refers to a wadi or a town. Rasmussen p. 251. If the grammar of your language demands a label then it is recommended that you call it a town.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In the south west the border extended to Mount Carmel and Shihor-libnath town

The western border started in the south at Carmel Mountain and Shihor-libnath (T4T)

Joshua 19:27

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:27a

then turned eastward toward Beth-dagon,

- From there it extended southeast to Beth-dagon town. (T4T)
- Then the border went eastward to Beth-dagon town.

then turned eastward: This part of the verse describes the southeastern border of Asher's land.

toward Beth-dagon: The location of the town of Beth-dagon is unknown.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From there it extended southeast to Beth-dagon town (T4T)

From there the border turned eastward to Beth-dagon town

19:27b

touched Zebulun and the Valley of Iphtah-el,

- It touched the land that belonged to the clan of Zebulun, in the Valley of Iphtah-el.
- The border went on up to Zebulun's land and the Valley of Iphtah-el.

touched Zebulun: The clause touched Zebulun indicates that Asher's land reached to the clan of Zebulun's land in the southeast.

and the Valley of Iphtah-el: The Valley of Iphtah-el was mentioned in 19:14b. Its exact location is not known but it formed part of the boundary between the land of Asher's clan and Zebulun's clan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and extended to the land of the clan of Zebulun and the Valley of Iphtah-el

It went up to the border of Zebulun's land and the Valley of Iphtah-el

19:27c

and went north to Beth-emek and Neiel,

- The eastern border went northward to the towns of Beth-emek and Neiel
- Then it went north to the towns of Beth-emek and Neiel.

and went north to Beth-emek and Neiel: This verse describes the eastern border. These towns were in the north of Asher's land, along the eastern border.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued northward to the towns of Beth-emek and Neiel

Then it went north to the towns of Beth-emek and Neiel

19:27d

passing Cabul on the left.

- and on northward to the town of Cabul.
- It continued on to Cabul in the north.

passing Cabul on the left: The town of Cabul was in the plain of Acco. Rasmussen p. 230.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and went on northward to the town of Cabul

It continued to Cabul in the north

Joshua 19:28

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:28

It went on to Ebron, Rehob, Hammon, and Kanah, as far as Greater Sidon.

- Their land included the towns of Ebron, Rehob, Hammon and Kanah. The border reached as far north as the great town of Sidon.
- The clan of Asher also received the towns of Ebron and Rehob and Hammon and Kanah. Their land extended in the north to the important town of Sidon.

It went on to Ebron, Rehob, Hammon, and Kanah, as far as Greater Sidon: The term Ebron is spelled “Abdon” in some Hebrew manuscripts and also in Joshua 21:30 and 1 Chronicles 6:59. For this reason some English versions translate this term as “Abdon” here. It is recommended that you follow the major language version in your area when deciding which spelling to follow here.

Greater Sidon: The towns listed here were further north than those listed in the previous verse. Woudstra p. 289. The town of Greater Sidon was an important Phoenician town which was on the Mediterranean Sea. The town of Sidon marked the northern limit of the land assigned to the clan of Asher.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their land included the towns of Ebron, Rehob, Hammon and Kanah. The border reached as far north as the great town of Sidon.

The clan of Asher also received the towns of Ebron and Rehob and Hammon and Kanah. Their land extended in the north to the important town of Sidon.

Joshua 19:29

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:29a

The border then turned back toward Ramah as far as the fortified city of Tyre,

- Then the border turned southward toward Ramah town and continued to the walled town of Tyre.
- The boundary turned south to Ramah town and went as far as Tyre, a town with high walls.

The border then turned back toward Ramah: The clause The border then turned back toward Ramah indicates that the border turned in another direction, south toward the town of Ramah. The location of this town is not certain. It was somewhere between Sidon and Tyre.

as far as the fortified city of Tyre: The phrase the fortified city of Tyre indicates a town with strong walls to protect it from enemies. The town of Tyre was on the coast of the Mediterranean Sea, south of Sidon.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border turned southward towards Ramah town and continued to the walled town of Tyre

The boundary turned back south to Ramah town and went as far as Tyre, a town with high walls

19:29b

turned toward Hosah, and came out at the Sea in the region of Achzib,

- Then the border turned to Hosah town and ended at the Mediterranean Sea. It included the towns of Mahalab and Achzib.
- The boundary turned west to the town of Hosah and went on to the Mediterranean Sea, to Mahalab town and Achzib town,

turned toward Hosah: The location of the town of Hosah is not known.

and came out at the Sea: After reaching the town of Hosah, the border went west and ended at the Mediterranean Sea.

in the region of Achzib: There is an interpretation issue with these two Hebrew words as they are not easy to understand. There are four ways to understand them.

1. It is two towns called “Mahalab” and Achzib. This is based on the Septuagint and also the parallel passage in Judges 1:31. (RSV, ESV, GW, REB, NJPS, NJB, NABRE, NLT, GNT)
2. It is two towns called “Hebel” and Achzib. (NET)
3. The words mean “near Achzib.” For example:

in the region of Achzib (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB)

1. The words mean “from the coast to Achzib.” For example:

from the coast to Achzib (KJV) (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) and translate it as “Mahalab, Achzib” the names of two towns. This is supported by many English versions, and by Bible commentaries. Woudstra p. 290.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the border turned west to Hosah town and ended at the Mediterranean Sea. Their land included the towns of Mahalab and Achzib.

The boundary turned to the town of Hosah and went on to the Mediterranean Sea, to Mahalab and Achzib.

Joshua 19:30

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:30

Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob. There were twenty-two cities, along with their villages.

- They also received Ummah town, Aphek town and Rehob town. Their total number of towns was twenty-two, and there were villages that surrounded them.
- to Ummah town, to Aphek town and to Rehob town. The total number of towns and nearby villages was twenty-two.

Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob. There were twenty-two cities, along with their villages: The towns of Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob were in the plain of Acco.

There were twenty-two cities, along with their villages: The list of towns given for the clan of Asher totals twenty-four towns. Some Bible scholars suggest that Mahalab and Achzib is a parenthesis and should not be counted in the total. Others scholars suggest that Tyre and Sidon should not be included in the list.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob. Their total number of towns was twenty-two, including the villages that were near them

to Ummah, Aphek, and Rehob. The total number of towns and nearby villages was twenty-two

Joshua 19:31

Section 19:24–31: The clan of Asher received their land

19:31a

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Asher,

- This was the land that the clan of Asher received as their inheritance, according to its families.
- The clan of Asher got this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Asher: This is like verse 23a, except that it refers to the clan of Asher instead of Issachar. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way.

19:31b

including these cities and their villages.

- They received these towns with the villages that were around them.
- They received those towns with the villages that were near them.

including these cities and their villages: This part of the verse is like verse 23b. It is recommended that you translate this part of the verse in the same way as you did verse 23b.

Joshua 19:32

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:32

The sixth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Naphtali:

- ¶ The sixth lot belonged to the tribe of Naphtali. (NET) The clan of Naphtali received land according to their families.
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a sixth time and the clan of Naphtali received land. Each family of the clan of Naphtali received some land.

The sixth lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Naphtali: This verse is similar to verse 19:17. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The sixth lot belonged to the tribe of Naphtali (NET)

Joshua threw the lot a sixth time and the clan of Naphtali received land

the clans of the tribe of Naphtali: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The clan of Naphtali received land according to their family groups

Each of the clans of Naphtali received some land

Joshua 19:33

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:33a

Their border started at Heleph and the great tree of Zaanannim,

- Their border began in the southwest at Heleph town, near the oak tree at Za-anannim town.
- The southern border of Naphtali's land began at the town of Heleph near the large tree in Za-anannim town.

Their border started at Heleph: The town of Heleph was at the southwest corner of the land that belonged to the clan of Naphtali. Rasmussen p. 238.

and the great tree of Zaanannim: The phrase the great tree of Zaanannim is mentioned in Judges 4:11.

Zaanannim: Judges 4:11 says that Zaanannim was near Kedesh. Its exact location is not certain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their border began in the south at Heleph town, near the tall tree at Zaanannim

The southern border of Naphtali's land began at the town of Heleph near the large tree in Zaanannim

19:33b

passing Adami-nekeb and Jabneel as far as Lakkum and ending at the Jordan.

- The border continued east to Adami-nekeb town and Jabneel town and on to Lakkum town. The border ended at the Jordan River.
- The border passed Adami-nekeb town and Jabneel town and went on eastward to Lakkum town. The Jordan River was the east end of the southern border.

passing Adami-nekeb and Jabneel as far as Lakkum and ending at the Jordan: The towns of Adami-nekeb and Jabneel were southwest of the Sea of Galilee.

Lakkum: The town of Lakkum was near the southern end of the Sea of Galilee.

and ending at the Jordan: The south border is described from west to east. The eastern end of the south border was the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The border continued eastward to Adaminekeb, and Jabneel and on to Lakkum. The border ended at the Jordan River

The border passed Adaminekeb and Jabneel and went on eastward to Lakkum. The Jordan River was the east end of their southern border

Joshua 19:34

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:34a

Then the border turned westward to Aznoth-tabor

- The western boundary extended through Aznoth-tabor town,
- To the west the border turned to Aznoth-tabor town,

Then the border turned westward to Aznoth-tabor:

This verse describes the west border of Naphtali's land. The town of Aznoth-tabor was at the foot of Mount Tabor. Aharoni p.259.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The western boundary extended through Aznoth-Tabor (T4T)

To the west the border turned to Aznoth-tabor

19:34b

and ran from there to Hukkok, touching Zebulun on the south side,

- as far as Hukkok city. It extended to the borders of the tribe of Zebulun at the south, (T4T)
- and went northward to Hukkok town. The border touched the clan of Zebulun's land in the south.

and ran from there to Hukkok: The town of Hukkok was somewhere on the western border of Naphtali's land.

touching Zebulun on the south side: The phrase touching Zebulun on the south side indicates that the southwestern border of Naphtali's land was next to the clan of Zebulun's land. The southeast border of Naphtali's land was next to the land of the clan of Issachar.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

as far as Hukkok. It extended to the borders of the tribe of Zebulun at the south (T4T)

and went on northward to the town of Hukkok. The border touched the clan of Zebulun's land in the south

19:34c

Asher on the west, and Judah at the Jordan on the east.

- to the border of the tribe of Asher on the west, and the Jordan River at the east. (T4T)
- The border touched the clan of Asher's land on the west side and the Jordan River on the east side.

Asher on the west: The phrase Asher on the west indicates that the west border touched the border of the clan of Asher's land.

and Judah at the Jordan on the east: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse. The word Judah is in the Hebrew text but is not in the Septuagint.

1. The text is Jordan on the east. (NIV, NET, NJB, NABRE, REB, NLT, GNT)
2. The text includes the word Judah. For example:

and Asher on the west, and Judah on the east at the Jordan (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NASB, ESV, GW, NJPS, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with many English versions. The border of the clan of Judah did not touch the border of the clan of Naphtali.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

to the border of the tribe of Asher on the west, and the Jordan River at the east (T4T)

The border touched the clan of Asher's land on the west and the Jordan River on the east

Joshua 19:35

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:35

The fortified cities were Ziddim, Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Chinnereth,

- Within their land were several cities with strong walls around them. They were Ziddim, Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Kinnereth. (T4T)
- The towns with strong walls that belonged to the clan of Naphtali were Ziddim and Zer and Hammath and Rakkath and Kinnereth

The fortified cities: The term fortified cities indicates towns that have strong walls around them. This term occurred in verse 19:29.

were Ziddim, Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Chinnereth:

The location of the towns of Ziddim and Zer is not known. The towns of Hammath and Rakkath were on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee. The town of Chinnereth was northwest of the Sea of Galilee. It is called Gennesaret in the New Testament. Rasmussen p. 242.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Within their land were several cities with strong walls around them. They were Ziddim, Zer, Hammath, Rakkath, Kinnereth (T4T)

The towns with strong walls that belonged to the clan of Naphtali were Ziddim, and Zer and Hammath and Rakkath and Kinnereth

Joshua 19:36

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:36

Adamah, Ramah, Hazor,

- There were also the towns of Adamah, Ramah, Hazor,
- and Adamah town and Ramah town and Hazor town

Adamah, Ramah, Hazor: The town of Adamah was probably to the west of the sea of Galilee. The towns of Ramah and Hazor were in upper Galilee. The town of Hazor was mentioned in 11:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

There were also Adamah town, Ramah town, Hazor town

Adamah town and Ramah town and Hazor town

Joshua 19:37

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:37

Kedesh, Edrei, En-hazor,

- Kedesh town, Edre-i town, En-hazor town,
- and Kedesh town and Edre-i town and En-hazor town.

Kedesh, Edrei, En-hazor: The town of Kedesh was northwest of the Sea of Galilee, in the hill country of Galilee. The locations of the towns of Edrei and En-hazor are not known.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Kedesh town, Edrei town, En-hazor town

and Kedesh town and Edrei town and En-hazor town

Joshua 19:38

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:38a

Iron, Migdal-el, Horem, Beth-anath, and Beth-shemesh.

- and Yiron and Migdal-el and Horem and Beth-anath and Beth-shemesh.
- They also had Yiron town, Migdal-el town, Horem town, Beth-anath town, and Beth-shemesh town.

Iron: This town was in upper Galilee. It was on the modern border between Lebanon and Israel. Woudstra p. 292.

Migdal-el, Horem, Beth-anath: The location of these three towns is not known.

and Beth-shemesh: This town is not the same as the town mentioned on Judah's northern border in 15:10. This town and the others listed above were most likely in Upper Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also had Iron town, Migdal-el town, Horem town, Beth-anath town, and Beth-shemesh town

and Iron and Migdal-el and Horem and Beth-anath and Beth-shemesh

19:38b

There were nineteen cities, along with their villages.

- In all there were nineteen towns with the villages that surrounded them.
- There were nineteen towns with their nearby villages.

There were nineteen cities, along with their villages: The total number of towns listed in verses 35–38 is sixteen towns. The names of the three other towns that are counted here are not known.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In all there was a total of nineteen towns with the villages that surrounded them

There were nineteen towns with their nearby villages

Joshua 19:39

Section 19:32–39: The clan of Naphtali received their land

19:39a

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Naphtali,

- This was the land that the clan of Naphtali received as their inheritance, according to its families.
- The clan of Naphtali got this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Naphtali: This verse is like verse 19:23a, except that here it refers to the clan of Naphtali. It is recommended that you translate this verse in a similar way to that verse.

19:39b

including these cities and their villages.

- They received these towns with the villages that were around them.

- They received those towns with the villages that were near them.

including these cities and their villages: This part of the verse is the same as verse 19:23b. It recommended that you translate this part of the verse as you did that verse.

Joshua 19:40

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:40

The seventh lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Dan:

- ¶ The seventh lot belonged to the tribe of Dan, by its clans. (NET)
- ¶ Joshua threw the lot a seventh time. Each family of the clan of Dan received land.

The seventh lot came out for the clans of the tribe of Dan: This verse is similar to verse 19:24. It is recommended that you translate it in a similar way to that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The seventh lot belonged to the tribe of Dan, by its clans (NET)

Joshua threw the lot a seventh time. Each of the families of the clan of Dan received land

Joshua 19:41

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:41

The territory of their inheritance included Zorah, Eshtaol, Ir-shemesh,

- Their land included the towns of Zorah, Eshta-ol, Ir-shemesh,
- The land that they received had the following towns: Zorah town and Eshta-ol town and Ir-shemesh town,

The territory of their inheritance included Zorah, Eshtaol, Ir-shemesh: The clan of Dan received the towns of Zorah and Eshtaol from the clan of Judah. These towns are mentioned in chapter 15:33. The town of Ir-shemesh was also called Beth-shemesh and was listed as a border town of the clan of Judah in chapter 15:10.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Their land included the towns of Zorah, Eshtaol, Ir-shemesh

The land that they received had the following towns: Zorah and Eshtaol and Ir-shemesh

Joshua 19:42

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:42

Shaalabbin, Aijalon, Ithlah,

- Sha-alabbin, Aijalon, Ithlah,
- and Sha-alabbin town and Aijalon town and Ithlah town,

Shaalabbin: The town of Shaalabbin was on the north side of the valley of Aijalon, north of Beth-shemesh. Boling and Wright p. 464.

Aijalon: The town of Aijalon was northwest of Jerusalem in the valley of Aijalon.

Ithlah: The location of the town of Ithlah is uncertain.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Shaalabbin town and Aijalon town and Ithlah town

Joshua 19:43

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:43

Elon, Timnah, Ekron,

- Elon, Timnah, Ekron,
- and Elon town and Timnah town and Ekron town,

Elon: The town of Elon was probably on the south side of the Aijalon valley. Boling and Wright p. 465.

Timnah, Ekron: The towns of Timnah and Ekron were on the boundary between the lands of the clan of Dan and the clan of Judah.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Elon town and Timnah town and Ekron town

Joshua 19:44

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:44

Eltekeh, Gibbethon, Baalath,

- Eltekeh, Gibbethon, Baalath,

- and Eltekeh town and Gibbethon town and Baalath city

Eltekeh, Gibbethon: These two towns were southeast of the town of Joppa.

Baalath: The location of this town is uncertain.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Eltekeh town and Gibbethon town and Baalath town

Joshua 19:45

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:45

Jehud, Bene-berak, Gath-rimmon,

- Jehud, Bene-berak, Gath-rimmon,
- and Jehud town and Bene-berak town and Gath-rimmon town,

Jehud, Bene-berak, Gath-rimmon: The town of Jehud was east of the town of Joppa in the coastal plain. The town of Bene-berak was southeast of Joppa. The town of Gath-rimmon was northeast of Joppa. 19:45 Dallaire, p. 1011.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Jehud town and Bene-berak town and Gath-rimmon town

Joshua 19:46

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:46

Me-jarkon, and Rakkon, including the territory across from Joppa.

- Me-jarkon and Rakkon, with the area facing Joppa town.
- Me-jarkon town and Rakkon town. Their territory also included land that was near Joppa town.

Me-jarkon: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as Me-jarkon can also be translated as “the waters of Yarkon.” The Yarkon River flows into the Mediterranean Sea north of Joppa town. Some scholars consider Me-jarkon to refer to the river, not to a town. However, it is recommended that you translate it as a town name as in the majority of English versions.

and Rakkon: The location of this place is uncertain.

including the territory across from Joppa: The phrase territory across from Joppa indicates that the

clan of Dan received land that was near the town of Joppa as part of their tribal inheritance.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Me-jarkon and Rakkon, with the area facing Joppa (NIV)

Me-jarkon and Rakkon. Their territory also included land that was near Joppa town

Joshua 19:47

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land 19:47a

(Later, when the territory of the Danites was lost to them,

- But the people of the Dan clan failed to conquer the land that was assigned to them.
- But the clan of Dan did not succeed in taking all their land.

Later, when the territory of the Danites was lost to them: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the territory of the Danites was lost to them is more literally “the territory of the people of Dan went out from them.” The clan of Dan was not able to take over all the land that was given to them by lot. Judges 1:34 says that the Amorites fought against the people of Dan and so they could not take over the land that was on the plain near the sea.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But the people of the Dan clan failed to conquer all the land they had received

But the tribe of Dan had trouble taking possession of their land (NLT)

19:47b

they went up and fought against Leshem,

- So they went northeast to Leshem town and attacked it.
- Because of that, they went up to Leshem town and fought against it.

they went up and fought against Leshem: The town of Leshem was an ancient town that was at the source of the Jordan River. It was northeast of the other towns given to the people of Dan. In Judges 18:7 this town

is called Laish. The clause they went up and fought against Leshem indicates that the members of the Dan clan attacked the town of Leshem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So the clan of Dan went northeast to the town of Leshem and attacked it

Because of that, the people of the Dan clan went up to Leshem and fought against it

19:47c

captured it, and put it to the sword.

- They conquered the town and killed the people with the sword.
- They defeated and killed the people in the town.

captured it, and put it to the sword: The clause that the BSB translates as captured it, and put it to the sword indicates that the Dan people defeated and killed the people of Leshem town.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They conquered the town and killed the people with the sword

They defeated and killed the people in the town

19:47d

So they took possession of Leshem, settled there,

- Then they moved into the town and lived in it.
- Then they began to live in Leshem,

So they took possession of Leshem, settled there:

The clause they took possession of Leshem, settled there indicates that the people of the Dan clan moved into the town and began to live there.

19:47e

and renamed it after their father Dan.)

- They gave the town a new name, Dan, according to the name of their ancestor.
- and changed the name of the city to Dan, the man from whom their tribe descended. (T4T)

and renamed it: The phrase renamed it indicates that the Dan clan renamed the town of Leshem. They named it “Dan.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then they moved into that town and lived in it. They gave the town a new name, Dan.

Then they began to live in Leshem, and changed the name of the town to Dan (T4T)

after their father Dan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

according to the name of their ancestor Dan

the man from whom their tribe descended (T4T)

Joshua 19:48

Section 19:40–48: The clan of Dan received their land

19:48a

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of Dan,

- This was the land that the clan of Dan received as their inheritance, according to its families.
- The clan of Dan received this land as their permanent possession. Each family received some land.

This was the inheritance of the clans of the tribe of

Dan: This part of the verse is similar to 19:16a. It is recommended that you translate in a similar way here.

19:48b

including these cities and their villages.

- They received those towns with the villages that were around them.
- They received these towns with the villages nearby them.

including these cities and their villages: This part of the verse is the same as in 19:16b. It is recommended that you translate it the same way as you did there.

Joshua 19:49

Section 19:49–51: Joshua received land

19:49a

When they had finished distributing the land into its territories,

- ¶ When they had finished distributing the land
- ¶ After the people of Israel had finished dividing the land among the clans,

When they had finished distributing the land into its territories: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When they had finished distributing the land

After the people of Israel had finished dividing the land among all the clans

19:49b

the Israelites gave Joshua son of Nun an inheritance among them,

- they also gave some land to Joshua son of Nun as his inheritance.
- they also gave a portion of land to Joshua the son of Nun.

the Israelites gave Joshua son of Nun an inheritance among them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of Israel also gave some land to Joshua son of Nun as his inheritance

they also gave a portion of land to Joshua son of Nun

Joshua 19:50

Section 19:49–51: Joshua received land

19:50a

as the LORD had commanded. They gave him the city of Timnath-serah in the hill country of Ephraim, as he requested.

- Yahweh had said that Joshua could have whatever town he wanted. So they gave him the town that he chose, which was Timnath-serah in the mountain country that belonged to the clan of Ephraim.
- Yahweh had commanded them to give Joshua whatever town he chose. He chose the town of Timnath-serah, in the hill country that belonged to the Ephraim tribe.

as the LORD had commanded. They gave him the city of Timnath-serah in the hill country of Ephraim, as he requested: The command that is referred to here is not recorded anywhere in the book of Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh had said that Joshua could have whatever town he wanted. So, they gave him the town that he chose

Yahweh had commanded them to give Joshua whatever town he chose

the city of Timnath-serah in the hill country of Ephraim: The town of Timnath-serah was southwest of the town of Shechem.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

which was Timnath-serah in the mountain country that belonged to the clan of Ephraim

He chose the town of Timnath-serah which was in the hill country that belonged to the clan of Ephraim

19:50b

He rebuilt the city and settled in it.

- Joshua rebuilt that town and lived in it.
- After Joshua conquered it he rebuilt the town and lived there.

He rebuilt the city and settled in it: Archaeology shows that the town of Timnath-serah was abandoned at the time that Joshua settled there. That is why he rebuilt the town. 19:50 Coleson, p. 152.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua rebuilt that town and lived in it

He built up the town and lived there

Joshua 19:51

Section 19:49–51: Joshua received land

19:51a

These are the inheritances that Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun,

- This is the land that Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun assigned as an inheritance
- Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun divided this land

These are the inheritances that Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun: This verse is similar to chapter 14:1. You should compare how you translated similar words and phrases in that verse and translate in a similar way here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These are the pieces of land that Eleazar the priest and Joshua the son of Nun assigned as an inheritance

Eleazar the priest and Joshua son of Nun divided out all of this land

19:51b
and the heads of the families distributed by lot to the tribes of Israel

- together with the leaders of the families of the clans of Israel.
- along with the leaders of the clans of Israel.

and the heads of the families: This phrase refers to the leaders of the Israelite clans. In Numbers 34:16–29 Yahweh told Moses to appoint one leader from each of the clans of Israel to help assign the land along with Joshua and Eleazar the priest. Moses decided who each of these leaders would be.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and the leaders of the families of the Israelite tribes (GNT)

along with the leaders of all the tribes of Israel (NCV)

distributed by lot: The phrase distributed by lot indicates that Eleazar and the tribal leaders cast a lot to decide which pieces of land each clan should receive.

19:51c
at Shiloh before the LORD

- They used lots to divide the land in the presence of Yahweh at Shiloh,
- They threw the lot to assign this land in the presence of Yahweh at Shiloh.

at Shiloh: The term Shiloh was first used in chapter 18:1a. Shiloh was twelve miles south of Shechem and was in the tribal territory of Ephraim. It was in the center of the Israelite land west of the Jordan River.

before the LORD: The phrase that the BSB translates as before the LORD indicates the presence of Yahweh. Yahweh was present in the tent of meeting, which is mentioned in the next part of the verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They used the lot to divide the land in the presence of Yahweh at Shiloh

They threw the lot to assign these inheritance lands in the presence of Yahweh at Shiloh

19:51d
at the entrance to the Tent of Meeting.

- at the entrance of the Meeting Tent.
- They stood at the door of the Holy Tent.

at the entrance to the Tent of Meeting: The term Tent of Meeting is first used in chapter 18:1b. You should translate the term here in the same way as you did in Chapter 18.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

at the entrance of the Meeting Tent

They stood at the door of the Holy Tent

19:51e
So they finished dividing up the land.

- And so they finished giving out the land.
- In that way they completed dividing up the land. (T4T)

So they finished dividing up the land: This sentence is the conclusion to chapters 14–19.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They finished giving out all the land to the clans

In that way they completed dividing up the land (T4T)

Joshua 20:1

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:1
Then the LORD said to Joshua,

- ¶ After this, Yahweh said to Joshua:
- ¶ Yahweh told Joshua

Then the LORD said to Joshua: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as Then the LORD said to Joshua is more literally “and Yahweh spoke to Joshua,

saying...” This sentence begins a new topic. Use a word or a phrase that marks a new topic in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

After this, Yahweh said to Joshua

Then Yahweh spoke to Joshua. He said

Yahweh told Joshua

Joshua 20:2

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:2a

“Tell the Israelites

- “Tell the Israelites,
- to say to the people of Israel

Tell the Israelites: The phrase Tell the Israelites is a command from Yahweh to Joshua. This command is in direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to report this command in indirect speech. For example,

Then Yahweh told Joshua to say to the people of Israel

20:2b

to designate the cities of refuge,

- ‘Choose the towns to which people can run and be safe
- “Designate towns where people can escape and be safe.

to designate the cities of refuge: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as designate is more literally “give to yourselves” or “set for yourselves.” In this context it indicates that the Israelites must choose some towns.

cities of refuge: A refuge is a place where someone can be safe. The cities of refuge were towns to which people who were in trouble could run and be safe.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

safe towns

towns to be safe

towns of safety

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Choose for yourselves towns where people can run and be safe

that they should select safe towns

20:2c

as I instructed you through Moses,

- that I had Moses speak to you about.
- In the past I told Moses to speak to you about these towns.

as I instructed you through Moses: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as as I instructed you through Moses is more literally “which I spoke to you by the hand of Moses.” Yahweh had spoken to Moses and told him to tell the Israelites to select these towns after they had crossed the Jordan River. This is reported in Numbers 35:9–29 and in Deuteronomy 19:1–13.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I commanded Moses to speak to you about them.

long ago I told Moses to speak to you about these towns

Joshua 20:3

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:3a

so that anyone who kills another unintentionally or accidentally may flee there.

- Any person who kills someone by mistake, who did not intend to do that, can escape there.
- These will be towns of safety. Perhaps somebody will kill a person by accident. He did not plan to kill them. He can go to one of these towns and be safe there.

so that: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as so that indicates purpose. This verse explains the purpose of the towns of refuge.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

that

in order that

anyone who kills another unintentionally or accidentally: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as unintentionally can also be translated “by mistake” or “in error.” It means that the killer did not plan to kill the person.

accidentally: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as accidentally is more literally “without knowledge.” This is a synonym of the word “unintentionally.” It means that the killer did not plan to kill the person. Some languages may not have two words for this concept. In that case you may need to use only one word. For example:

If any of you accidentally kills someone (GNT)

may flee there: The verb flee can also be translated “escape” or “run away.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These will be towns of safety. Anybody who kills a person by accident, without planning to kill him, may go there.

Any person who kills someone by accident and did not intend to kill him may run away to that place so that he can be safe.

Anyone who kills a person by mistake, who did not intend to kill, can escape there.

20:3b

These will be your refuge from the avenger of blood.

- These cities will be a safe place for any of you from the relative of the dead person who wants to kill you.
- They will be a place of safety from any relative who wants to get revenge for the death.

These will be your refuge from the avenger of blood: A refuge is a place where somebody can be safe.

avenger of blood: An avenger of blood is a person who wants to get revenge. Usually this was a relative of the person who died. He would seek to get revenge for his relative by finding the killer and killing him. Woudstra, p, 299.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These towns will be a safe place to protect you from the relative of the dead man who wants to kill you

They will be a place of refuge from any relative who can avenge the death. (GW)

they will be places of refuge from relatives seeking revenge for the person who was killed (NLT)

Joshua 20:4

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:4a

When someone flees to one of these cities,

- Any person who has killed someone should run to one of these towns.
- Anyone who kills someone accidentally can escape to one of these towns.

When someone flees to one of these cities: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The person who has killed someone should run to one of these towns.

Anyone who kills someone accidentally can escape to one of these towns.

20:4b

stands at the entrance of the city gate,

- He should stand at the entrance to the town gate where the elders judge cases.
- He will stand at the entrance to the town where the leaders make decisions.

stands at the entrance of the city gate: The entrance of the city gate was an open area near the town entrance. The town leaders gathered there to decide about cases between people that needed to be settled. It may be helpful to include this implicit information when translating this part of the verse. For example,

He should stand at the entrance to the town gate where the elders judge cases.

There he will stand at the entrance to the town where the leaders hold court.

20:4c

and states his case before its elders,

- He should state his case to the elders of that town.
- He must tell the town leaders what he did.

and states his case before its elders: The clause that the BSB translates as states his case before its elders is more literally in Hebrew “he will speak his words in the ears of the elders of that town.” The term elders refers to the leaders of the town.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He should state his case to the elders of that town.

He must tell the town leaders what he did.

20:4d

they are to bring him into the city and give him a place

- Then the elders will allow him to come into the town and give him a place to live,
- The town leaders will bring him into the town and give him a place to stay,

they are to bring him into the city: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as they are to bring him into the city is more literally “and they will gather him to the town, to themselves.” It means that the elders will allow him to enter the town.

and give him a place: The clause give him a place indicates that the elders would find a place where he could live.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the elders will allow him to come into the town, and they will give him a place to live there.

The town leaders will bring him into the town and give him a place to stay.

20:4e

to live among them.

- and he will stay there with them.
- and he will live among them.

to live among them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and he will stay in that town with them

and he will live among them

Joshua 20:5

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:5a

Now if the avenger of blood pursues him,

- If the relative who wants to kill him chases after him
- And if the relative who wants to get revenge follows after the killer,

Now: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now can also be translated “but” to indicate contrast. It is not a time word. Choose the word that is most natural in this context. Some English versions do not translate this word.

if: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as if can also be translated as “when.” Choose the conjunction that is most natural in your language.

the avenger of blood: The term avenger of blood was first mentioned in 20:3b. You should translate it the same way here.

pursues him: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as pursues can also be translated as “chases” or “follows.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But if the relative of the person who died chases after the person who killed him

But if the relative of the dead person follows after the killer

20:5b

they must not surrender the manslayer into his hand,

- the elders must not hand him over to that relative.
- the town leaders must not give him up.

they: The pronoun they refers to the elders of the town.

must not surrender the manslayer into his hand: The clause must not surrender the manslayer into

his hand means that the elders must protect the manslayer (the person who killed someone) from the person who is trying to get revenge. They must not hand him over to that person.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the elders must not hand over the killer to the person trying to avenge the dead man

the town leaders must not give up the person who killed to the relative

20:5c

because that man killed his neighbor accidentally

- They must protect him because he has killed his neighbor without intending it.
- They must do this because he killed the other person without planning to do it,

because that man killed his neighbor accidentally:

The clause that man killed his neighbor accidentally indicates the reason why the person who killed should be protected from his pursuer.

his neighbor: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as neighbor can also be translated “friend,” “companion” or “other one.” In this context it refers to a fellow human being.

accidentally: The word accidentally means that the killer did not plan to kill. This is the same Hebrew word as in verse 20:3.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They must protect him because he has killed his fellow man without intending it.

They must do this because he killed the other person without planning to do it.

20:5d

without prior malice.

- He had not hated him in the past.
- and not because he was angry with him in past times.

without prior malice: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as without prior malice is more literally “and not hating him from yesterday three days

ago.” The phrase “from yesterday three days ago” is a Hebrew idiom that means “in the past.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He had not hated him in the past.

and not because he was angry with him in the past

General Comment on verse 20:5

In the Hebrew and in the BSB verse 5 is a long sentence. It may be more natural in some languages to divide it into more than one sentence. For example:

But if the one who is chasing him follows him to that town, the leaders of the city must not hand over the killer. It was an accident. He did not hate him beforehand or kill him on purpose. (NCV)

Joshua 20:6

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:6a

He is to stay in that city until he stands trial before the assembly

- But he must live in that town until his trial before the assembly.
- He should stay in that town until the congregation has judged his case.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” can also be translated as “but.” Choose the connecting words that are most natural in your language. Some English versions do not translation this conjunction.

He is to stay in that city: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as He is to stay in that city can also be translated “he must live in that town.”

until he stands trial before the assembly: The clause until he stands trial before the assembly indicates that there will be a trial for the person who was accused of killing someone. The trial will be conducted by the assembly which was composed of all the adult males of the town. Boling and Wright p. 474.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But he must live in that town until his trial before the assembly.

He should stay in that town until the people gather and judge his case.

20:6b
and until the death of the high priest serving at that time.

- If he is innocent he must continue to stay there until the high priest of that time has died.
- If they decide that he is not guilty, he should live there until the chief priest in those days has died.

until the death of the high priest serving at that time: There is implicit information in this part of the verse. First the congregation must decide that the person who killed someone was innocent of murder. If they decided he was innocent he could stay in the town of refuge until the high priest died. It may be clearer in some languages to include this implicit information.

high priest: The high priest was the leader of all the priests. The priests offered sacrifices on behalf of the people, but the high priest offered certain sacrifices that no other priest could offer. He represented the Israelite people to God.

If you have translated the gospels you should translate high priest the same way you did there. See for example John 18:19.

Here are some other ways to translate the term high priest:

the chief/leader of all the priests

the main/principal priest

the highest/leading priest

at that time: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as at that time is more literally “in those days.” The high priest continued his duties until he died or could not carry them out. Then a new person was chosen.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If he is innocent he must continue to stay there until the high priest of that time has died.

After he is judged to be not guilty he should live there until the chief priest in those days has died.

20:6c
Then the manslayer may return to his own home in the city from which he fled.”

- Then he may return to his own house in the town that he escaped from.”
- After that, the person may go back to his home in the town that he ran away from.”

Then the manslayer may return to his own home: This clause indicates that the person who killed unintentionally could then return to his home.

in the city from which he fled: the city from which he fled is the same town as is indicated in the phrase “to his own home.” In some languages it may be clearer to combine these two phrases. For example:

to his own home in the town from which he fled

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the person who killed unintentionally may return to his own house in his town.

After that the person may go back to his home in the town that he ran away from.

Joshua 20:7

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:7a
So they set apart Kedesh in Galilee in the hill country of Naphtali,

- ¶ So the people of Israel chose Kedesh town. It was in the region of Galilee in the mountain country that belonged to the Naphtali people.
- ¶ Then the Israelites designated Kedesh town in Galilee in the hill country where the Naphtali clan lived.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates the next event in the storyline. Choose a connecting word that is natural in your language.

they set apart: The pronoun they refers to the people of Israel. The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as set apart means to choose something for a special use.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

the people chose

they designated

Kedesh in Galilee in the hill country of Naphtali: The town of Kedesh was northwest of the Sea of Galilee. It is mentioned in 19:37.

Galilee: Galilee is the name of a region in northern Israel. It was a part of the land assigned to the clan of Naphtali.

the hill country of Naphtali: The term hill country of Naphtali refers to the mountainous region that belonged to the clan of Naphtali.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Israel chose the town of Kedesh. It was in the region of Galilee in the hill country that belonged to Naphtali.

Then they designated the town of Kedesh in Galilee in the mountainous region that belonged to the clan of Naphtali.

20:7b

Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim,

- They also chose the town of Shechem. It was in the mountain country that belonged to the Ephraim people.
- They also designated the town of Shechem. It was in the hill country where the Ephraim clan lived.

Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim: The town of Shechem was on the boundary of the clan of Ephraim and Manasseh. This town was in the middle region of the country of Israel. It is mentioned in 17:7.

hill country of Ephraim: The term hill country of Ephraim refers to the mountainous region that belonged to the clan of Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also chose the town of Shechem. It was in the mountain country of the clan of Ephraim.

They also designated the town of Shechem. It was in the hill country of the clan of Ephraim.

20:7c

and Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron) in the hill country of Judah.

- They also chose the town of Kiriath-arba in the mountain country that belonged to the Judah people. The name of that town is now Hebron.
- They also designated the town of Kiriath-arba which was in the hill country where the Judah clan lived. That town is now called Hebron.

and Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron): The town of Kiriath-arba was mentioned in 15:13 and 14:15. Its name was later changed to Hebron. It was in the southern area of Israel, fifteen miles southwest of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p. 238.

in the hill country of Judah: The term hill country of Judah refers to the mountainous region which belonged to the clan of Judah.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also chose the town of Kiriath-arba in the mountain country of the clan of Judah. The name of that town is now Hebron.

They also appointed the town of Kiriath-arba which was in the hill country of the clan of Judah. That town is now called Hebron.

Joshua 20:8

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:8a

And beyond the Jordan, east of Jericho,

- On the east side of the Jordan River, across from Jericho town,
- Across the Jordan River, to the east of the town of Jericho,

And: The Hebrew conjunction And makes this sentence a continuous sentence with the previous verse. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

beyond the Jordan: The phrase beyond the Jordan indicates that the next towns were on the east side of the Jordan River.

east of Jericho: The phrase east of Jericho indicates that the next towns in the list were east of the town of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

On the east side of the Jordan River, across from Jericho town

Across the Jordan River, to the east of the town of Jericho

20:8b

they designated Bezer on the wilderness plateau from the tribe of Reuben,

- they chose the town of Bezer. It was in the wilderness on the plain that belonged to the Reuben people.
- the Israelites designated Bezer town. It was on the wilderness plateau where the Reuben clan lived.

they designated Bezer: The town of Bezer was in the south part of Israel and east of the Jordan River.

on the wilderness plateau: The phrase the wilderness plateau indicates that Bezer was in a flat, uncultivated area. The term plateau refers to a flat plain.

from the tribe of Reuben: The phrase from the tribe of Reuben indicates that the town of Bezer was in the area that belonged to the clan of Reuben. The land that Moses assigned to the clan of Reuben is described in 13:15–23.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the people of Israel chose the town of Bezer. It was in the wilderness on the plain that belonged to the clan of Reuben.

They also designated Bezer town, on the wilderness plateau that belonged to the Reuben clan.

20:8c

Ramoth in Gilead from the tribe of Gad,

- They also chose Ramoth town in the region of Gilead that belonged to the Gad people,
- They also designated Ramoth town in Gilead region where the Gad clan lived,

Ramoth in Gilead: The town of Ramoth was north of the modern town of Amman in Jordan. Rasmussen p. 249. It was in the middle region of Israel's land on the east side of the Jordan River. Gilead was a mountainous area north of the Dead Sea and east of the Jordan River. This area is now in the country of Jordan.

from the tribe of Gad: The phrase the tribe of Gad indicates that Moses had assigned the town of Ramoth in the region of Gilead to the clans of Gad.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also chose Ramoth town in the region of Gilead, which belonged to the people of Gad.

They also designated the town of Ramoth in Gilead region, where the Gad clans lived.

20:8d

and Golan in Bashan from the tribe of Manasseh.

- and Golan town in the Bashan region that belonged to the Manasseh people.
- and Golan town in the Bashan region, where the Manasseh clan lived.

and Golan in Bashan: The town of Golan was in the region of Bashan, which is a high plateau in the north-east part of the land of Israel.

from the tribe of Manasseh: The phrase the tribe of Manasseh indicates that the town of Golan was in land that belonged to the clans of Manasseh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and Golan town in the Bashan region, which belonged to the people of Manasseh

They also designated the town of Golan in the Bashan region, where the Manasseh people lived.

Joshua 20:9

Section: 20:1–9 Joshua set apart towns of refuge so that people could run to them and be safe

20:9a

These are the cities appointed for all the Israelites

- These towns of refuge were chosen for all the people of Israel
- These were the towns that they designated to benefit all the Israel people

These are the cities appointed for all the Israelites:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as appointed can also be translated “designated” or “agreed upon.” It may be clearer to add the implicit information “towns of refuge.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These towns of refuge were appointed for all the people of Israel.

These were the safe towns that were selected for all the Israel people.

20:9b and foreigners among them,

- and also for the foreigners who lived among them.
- and anyone who lived with them.

and foreigners among them: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as foreigners among them is more literally “the sojourner who sojourns among them.” This refers to foreigners who were living among the people of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

a foreigner who lived among them

anyone who lived among them

20:9c so that anyone who kills a person unintentionally may flee there

- Anyone who killed a person accidentally could run to them.
- Anyone who killed a person by mistake could escape there.

so that: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as so that indicates purpose. It can also be translated as “that.”

anyone who kills a person unintentionally may flee there: This clause is like the clause in verse 20:3a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so that anyone who killed a person accidentally could run there

anybody who killed a person by mistake could escape there

20:9d and not die by the hand of the avenger of blood

- Then the relative who wanted to kill him would not be able to kill him
- He would not die from the relative who wanted to get revenge

and not die: The phrase and not die indicates the purpose of running away to the town of safety. The person who had killed by accident could escape to a safe town and be safe from the person who wanted to kill him.

by the hand of the avenger of blood: The phrase by the hand of the avenger of blood indicates how the one who had killed might die. The avenger of blood would find him and kill him. You should translate the term avenger of blood the same way as you did in verse 20:3b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the relative of the person who died would not kill him

so that he will be safe from the relative who wanted to kill him

20:9e prior to standing trial before the assembly.

- until his trial before the assembly of the people.
- before the congregation had judged his case.

prior to standing trial before the assembly: This part of the verse is like verse 20:6a. It may be clearer to include here the information “for judgment” which is found in that verse in Hebrew.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until he comes before the assembly and they judge him

until the congregation has judged his case

Joshua 21:1

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

**21:1a
Now the family heads of the Levites approached Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun,**

- ¶ Then the family heads of the clan of Levi came to Eleazar the priest, and Joshua the son of Nun,

- ¶ After that, the leaders of the families of the Levi people had a request. They went to Eleazar the priest, and to Joshua whose father was Nun,

Now: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now indicates the next event in the story. This begins a new section. Use a connecting word that is appropriate in your language to begin a new section.

the family heads of the Levites: The phrase the family heads of the Levites refers to the leaders of the Levite clan. This same phrase was used in 14:1. Translate it in a similar way to how you did in that verse.

approached Eleazar the priest, Joshua son of Nun: Yahweh had told Moses in Numbers 34:16–17 that Eleazar and Joshua would assign land to all the clans of Israel. Yahweh had also told Moses in Numbers 35:1–8 to give the Levites towns to live in and pasturelands around the towns.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the heads of the families in the clan of Levi came to Eleazar the priest and to Joshua the son of Nun

After that, the leaders of the families of the Levi clan went to Eleazar the priest and to Joshua son of Nun

21:1b and the heads of the other tribes of Israel

- and to the heads of the clans of Israel
- and to the leaders of the other clans of Israel.

and the heads of the other tribes of Israel: In verse 21:1a the leaders were those of the Levi clan. They approached the leaders from all the other clans of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and to the heads of the other Israel clans

and to the leaders of all the other clans of Israel

Joshua 21:2

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

**21:2a
at Shiloh in the land of Canaan and said to them,**

- at Shiloh in the land of Canaan. They said to them,
- They were still at Shiloh town in the land of Canaan. They said to them,

There is a Hebrew conjunction at the beginning of this verse that is often translated as “and.” It introduces the next event in the story. The BSB leaves this conjunction untranslated.

at Shiloh in the land of Canaan and said to them: in 18:1 the Israelites had set up the tent of meeting at Shiloh. Shiloh was a town twelve miles south of Shechem and was in the tribal territory of Ephraim. It was in the center of the Israelite land west of the Jordan River.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

While they were still at Shiloh town in the land of Canaan, they said

21:2b “The LORD commanded through Moses that we be given cities in which to live,

- “Yahweh told Moses that you must give us towns to live in,
- “Yahweh said to Moses: ‘Command the Israelites to give the descendants of Levi towns to live in,

The LORD commanded through Moses: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as The LORD commanded through Moses is more literally “Yahweh commanded by the hand of Moses.” Yahweh had told Moses to give the following command to the Israelites.

that we be given cities in which to live: In Numbers 35:1 Yahweh had told Moses to command the Israelites to give the Levites towns to live in. These towns belonged to the various clans but the Levites lived in them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh told Moses to command you^(plur) to give us towns to live in.

Yahweh said to Moses, “Command the Israelites to give the Levi people towns to live in.”

21:2c together with pasturelands for our livestock.”

- and the pasture lands around them for our cattle to graze on.”

- and the grasslands near them for their livestock to eat.”

together with pasturelands for our livestock: The phrase together with pasturelands for our livestock indicates that the Levites should receive the lands around the towns where their livestock could eat grass.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and the pasturelands around them for our cattle to graze there

and the grasslands near them to provide grass for our livestock

General Comment on verses 1–2

In some languages it may be more natural to combine verses 1 and 2 and reorder them. For example:

^{2a}While the Israelites were still at Shiloh in the land of Canaan, ^{1a}the heads of the Levi clan went to Eleazar the priest, to Joshua the son of Nun, ^{1b}and to the other heads of the clans of Israel. They said to them, ^{2b}“Yahweh told Moses to command you to give us towns to live in ^{2c}and grasslands for our cattle.”

Joshua 21:3

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:3a

So by the command of the LORD,

- So the Israel people obeyed Yahweh’s command.
- So as Yahweh had told them to do,

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates the next event in the narrative. Translate this connecting word in a way that is natural in your language.

by the command of the LORD: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as by the command of the LORD is more literally, “by the mouth of Yahweh.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Just as Yahweh had commanded

According to what Yahweh had said

21:3b

the Israelites gave the Levites these cities and their pasturelands out of their own inheritance:

- They gave the following towns and the grasslands around them to the clan of Levi. They gave them from the land that they had been given.
- the people of Israel gave some of the towns and pasturelands that they had received to the Levi people. This is a list of those towns.

the Israelites gave the Levites these cities and their pasturelands out of their own inheritance: The phrase their own inheritance refers to the towns and lands that the people of Israel received when Joshua and Eleazar the priest threw lots for them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Israel people gave these towns and the lands around them to the clan of Levi from the land that they had been given

The people of Israel gave to the Levi people some of the towns and pasturelands that they had received

Joshua 21:4

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:4a

The first lot came out for the Kohathite clans.

- ¶ The first lot was for the descendants of Kohath.
- ¶ The families who descended from Kohath received their towns by lot first.

The first lot came out: The clause The first lot came out is the same Hebrew expression as in 16:1 where it BSB translates it as “The allotment for.” It means that Eleazar the priest threw the lot to show which clan would receive their towns first.

for the Kohathite clans: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as clans refers to groups of families or sub-clans. This word was used in 15:1b.

Kohathite: The term Kohathite refers to the descendants of Kohath. Kohath was one of Levi’s three sons. (See Genesis 46:11.)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The first lot was for the descendants of Kohath.

The families of the descendants of Kohath received their towns first by lot.

21:4b

The Levites who were descendants of Aaron the priest

- The Levi people who were descended from Aaron the priest
- The men of the Levi clan who were descendants of Aaron the chief priest

There is a Hebrew conjunction here, which the BSB leaves untranslated, that indicates the next event in the narrative. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

The Levites who were descendants of Aaron the priest:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Levites who were descendants of Aaron the priest is more literally “the sons of Aaron the priest from the Levites.” This refers to the male descendants of Aaron.

Aaron the priest: Aaron was a grandson of Kohath, one of the three sons of Levi. Aaron was the first chief priest of Israel. The male descendants of Aaron had the responsibility to serve Yahweh as priests (Exodus 29).

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Levi people who were descended from Aaron the first chief priest

The male descendants of Aaron the priest, who was of the clan of Levi

21:4c

received thirteen cities by lot from the tribes of Judah, Simeon, and Benjamin.

- received thirteen towns when the lot was thrown. These towns were from the descendants of Judah, Simeon and Benjamin.
- were given thirteen towns by lot. The towns they received came from the clan of Judah, the clan of Simeon, and the clan of Benjamin.

received thirteen cities by lot from the tribes of Judah, Simeon, and Benjamin: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

received thirteen towns when the lot was thrown. These towns belonged to the clans of Judah, Simeon, and Benjamin.

were given thirteen towns by lot. The towns they received came from the clan of Judah, the clan of Simeon, and the clan of Benjamin.

Joshua 21:5

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:5a

The remaining descendants of Kohath received ten cities by lot from the tribes of Ephraim,

- The remaining people who were descended from Kohath received their towns from the families of the clan of Ephraim,
- The other Kohath people were given towns by lot from the descendants of Ephraim,

The remaining descendants of Kohath: The phrase remaining descendants of Kohath refers to the clans of Kohath who were not descended from Aaron.

received ten cities by lot from the tribes of Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The other families who were descended from Kohath received their towns from the families of the clan of Ephraim

The other families of Kohath were given towns by lot from the clan of Ephraim

21:5b

Dan, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.

- the clan of Dan, and from half of the clan of Manasseh. They received by lot ten towns in all.
- and from the descendants of Dan, and from the half of the descendants of Manasseh who live west of the Jordan River. They received ten towns by lot.

Dan, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

from the clan of Dan, and from half of the clan of Manasseh. They received ten towns in all by lot.

from the clan of Dan, and from the half of the Manasseh clan that lived west of the Jordan River. They received ten towns.

General Comment on verse 21:5

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

The other families who were descendants of Kohath received ten towns by lot. These towns came from the clan of Ephraim, from the clan of Dan, and from half the clan of Manasseh.

Joshua 21:6

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:6a

The descendants of Gershon received thirteen cities by lot from the tribes of Issachar,

- The descendants of Gershon received towns by lot from the families of the clan of Issachar,
- When the lot was thrown, the people who were descended from Gershon received towns from the descendants of Issachar,

The descendants of Gershon: Gershon was one of Levi's three sons.

received thirteen cities by lot from the tribes of Issachar: This clause is like the clause in verse 21:5a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The descendants of Gershon received towns by lot from the families of the clan of Issachar,

When the lot was thrown, the people who were descended from Gershon received towns from the clan of Issachar,

21:6b

Asher, Naphtali, and the half-tribe of Manasseh in Bashan.

- the clan of Asher, the clan of Naphtali, and from the part of the clan of Manasseh who live in Bashan east of the Jordan River. They received thirteen towns.
- and from the descendants of Asher, and from the descendants of Naphtali, and from the half of the descendants of Manasseh who live in Bashan east of the Jordan. They received thirteen towns.

Asher, Naphtali, and the half-tribe of Manasseh in Bashan: This part of the verse is like verse 21:5b. The phrase the half-tribe of Manasseh in Bashan refers to the part of the Manasseh clan that lived on the east side of the Jordan River. Bashan was an area northeast of the Sea of Galilee.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

from the clan of Asher, from the clan of Naphtali, and from the part of the clan of Manasseh who live in Bashan, east of the Jordan River. They received thirteen towns.

and from the clan of Asher, and the clan of Naphtali, and from the half of the clan of Manasseh who live in Bashan, east of the Jordan. They received thirteen towns.

General Comment on 21:6

It may be more natural in some languages to rearrange the parts of this verse. For example:

The descendants of Gershon received thirteen towns by lot. These towns came from the families of the clan of Issachar, the clan of Naphtali, and half of the clan of Manasseh.

Joshua 21:7

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:7a

And the descendants of Merari

- The descendants of Merari by their families
- The families that were descended from Merari

And the descendants of Merari: Merari was one of the three sons of Levi.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The descendants of Merari, by their families

The families that were descended from Merari

21:7b

received twelve cities from the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun.

- received twelve towns from the clans of Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun.
- were given twelve towns from the descendants of Reuben, and the descendants of Gad, and the descendants of Zebulun.

received twelve cities from the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun: This verse is similar to 21:4c although it does not have the phrase “by lot.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

received twelve towns from the clans of Reuben, Gad, and Zebulun

were given twelve towns in all from the clan of Reuben, the clan of Gad, and the clan of Zebulun

Joshua 21:8

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:8a

So the Israelites allotted to the Levites these cities, together with their pasturelands,

- ¶ The people of Israel gave these towns and the grasslands around them to the clan of Levi by throwing lots,
- ¶ The Israel people gave the towns listed here and the lands around them for grazing livestock to the Levi people by throwing lots.

So the Israelites allotted to the Levites these cities, together with their pasturelands: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

the Israelites gave these towns and their grasslands to the clan of Levi by throwing lots

21:8b

as the LORD had commanded through Moses.

- just as Yahweh had commanded Moses to tell them to do.
- Yahweh had told Moses that they must do this.

as the LORD had commanded through Moses: This part of the verse is similar to verse 21:2b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

just as Yahweh had commanded Moses to tell them to do

Yahweh had told Moses that they must do this

General Comment on 21:8

Verse 8 is a summary statement of verses 4–7. It restates the information that was first said in verse 3.

Joshua 21:9

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:9a

From the tribes of Judah and Simeon,

- ¶ From the clans of Judah and Simeon,
- ¶ From the land that belonged to the descendants of Judah and to the descendants of Simeon

From the tribes of Judah and Simeon: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the clans of Judah and Simeon

From the land that belonged to the clan of Judah, and the clan of Simeon

21:9b

they designated these cities by name

- the Israelites gave these towns which they called by name.
- the people of Israel named the following towns.

they designated these cities by name: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as they designated these cities by name is more literally “they gave them these towns which they called them by name.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the Israelites gave these cities which they called by name

the Israelites named the following towns

General Comment on 21:9

It may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example,

The Israelites gave these towns from the clans of Judah and Simeon and told their names.

Joshua 21:10

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:10a

to the descendants of Aaron from the Kohathite clans of the Levites,

- They gave these towns to the descendants of Aaron, who belonged to the Kohath family in the clan of Levi,
- They gave these towns to the descendants of Aaron. The descendants of Aaron were one of the families of the Kohath people, from the clan of Levi.

to the descendants of Aaron from the Kohathite clans of the Levites: The Hebrew text begins a new sentence here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

These towns belonged to the descendants of Aaron, who were one of the families of the Kohath people, from the clan of Levi.

These towns were given to the descendants of Aaron, who belonged to the Kohath family in the clan of Levi.

21:10b
because the first lot fell to them:

- because they received the first lot.
- They got their land first because the first lot pointed to them.

because the first lot fell to them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because the first lot pointed to them

because they received the first lot

Joshua 21:11

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:11a
They gave them Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron),

- The people of Israel gave to them the town of Kiriath-arba, which is now called Hebron.
- The Israelites gave them the town of Kiriath-arba. That town has another name, which is Hebron.

They gave them Kiriath-arba (that is, Hebron): The town of Kiriath-arba is mentioned in 14:15. The word “Kiriath” means “town” in Hebrew. Arba was the name of one of the Anak people.

21:11b
with its surrounding pasturelands, in the hill country of Judah. (Arba was the father of Anak.)

- Kiriath-arba is in the mountain region that belonged to the clan of Judah. They also gave them the grasslands around it. Arba was the father of Anak.
- They also gave them land around the town for their animals. Kiriath-arba is in the mountain country of the descendants of Judah. Arba was the father of Anak.

with its surrounding pasturelands, in the hill country of Judah: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It was in the mountain region that belonged to the clan of Judah. They also gave them the grasslands around it.

They gave them lands around the town for their animals. Hebron was in the mountains of the clan of Judah.

Arba was the father of Anak: The clause that the BSB translates as Arba was the father of Anak is background information. In some languages it may be more natural to place this background information at some other point in the verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse

The Israelites gave them the town of Kiriath-arba, which is now called Hebron. Arba was the father of Anak.

The people of Israel gave them Kiriath-arba town. Arba was the father of Anak. That town had another name, Hebron.

General Comment on verse 21:11

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

The Israelites gave them Kiriath-arba, together with the grasslands around it, in the hill country of Judah. That town was named after Arba, who was the father of Anak. It is also called Hebron.

Joshua 21:12

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:12

But they had given the fields and villages around the city to Caleb son of Jephunneh as his possession.

- But the fields and villages that were around the town had already been given to Caleb the son of Jephunneh as his own property.
- However, Caleb the son of Jephunneh had already received the fields and villages that surrounded the town as his own.

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast.

they had given the fields and villages around the city to Caleb son of Jephunneh as his possession:

The Hebrew sentence places the object first to emphasize it. Use the order that is natural in your language.

the fields: The phrase the fields refers to the land around the town that was good for growing crops.

villages around the city: The phrase villages around the city refers to small settlements near the town that did not have a wall around them.

had given...to Caleb: The story of how Caleb received the town of Hebron was told in 14:6–15.

as his possession: The phrase as his possession can also be translated “as his property.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But the fields and villages that were around the town had already been given to Caleb, the son of Jephunneh, as his own property.

However, Caleb the son of Jephunneh had already received the fields and villages that surrounded the town as his own.

Joshua 21:13

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:13a

So to the descendants of Aaron the priest they gave these cities, together with their pasturelands: Hebron, a city of refuge for the manslayer,

- The Israel people gave the descendants of Aaron the priest the town of Hebron and its grazing lands. It was a town where people could run to escape when they had killed someone by accident.
- The people of Israel gave Hebron town with its pasturelands to the descendants of Aaron the priest. Hebron was a town of safety for those who had killed by mistake.

So: This verse repeats information which was stated in verse 21:10–11. Some English versions translate this Hebrew conjunction as So, as “thus” or “and.” Use the connecting word that is natural in your language.

to the descendants of Aaron the priest they gave these cities, together with their pasturelands: Hebron, a city of refuge for the manslayer: In this verse Aaron is given the title of Aaron the priest, which is slightly different from verse 21:10. The Hebrew sentence puts the object of the sentence first to emphasize it. Use the sentence order that is natural in your language.

together with their pasturelands: The phrase together with their pasturelands refers to the land around Hebron where livestock could eat grass.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

So the people of Israel gave Hebron town with its pasturelands to the descendants of Aaron the priest. Hebron was a town of safety for those who had killed someone by mistake.

a city of refuge for the manslayer: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as manslayer is the same Hebrew word that occurred in 20:3. In that verse the BSB translated it as “anyone who kills another.” It is recommended that you translate this term the same way as you did in verse 20:3.

21:13b Libnah,

- They also gave them Libnah town and the grazing lands around it,
- They also gave them Libnah town and its grasslands,

Libnah: The town of Libnah was southwest of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p.243.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also gave them Libnah and the grazing lands around it,

Libnah town and the grasslands around it,

Joshua 21:14

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:14

Jattir, Eshtemoa,

- Jattir town and the grazing lands around it, Eshtemoa town and the grazing lands around it,
- and Jattir town with its grasslands, and Eshtemoa town with its grasslands,

Jattir: The town of Jattir was mentioned in 15:48. It was southwest of Hebron, in the hill country of Judah. Rasmussen p. 240.

Eshtemoa: The town of Eshtemoa was mentioned in 15:50. It was also southwest of Hebron in the hill country of Judah. Rasmussen p. 2234.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Jattir town and the grazing lands around it and Eshtemoa town with the grazing lands around it

and Jattir town with its grasslands and Eshtemoa town with its grasslands

Joshua 21:15

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:15

Holon, Debir,

- Holon town and the grazing lands around it, Debir town with the grazing lands around it,
- and Holon town with its grasslands, and Debir town with its grasslands,

Holon: The town of Holon was mentioned in 15:51. It was in the south hill country of the clan of Judah.

Debir: The town of Debir was mentioned in 15:15. It was southwest of Hebron. Rasmussen p. 232.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Holon and the grazing lands around it and Debir with the grazing lands around it.

and the town of Holon with its grasslands and the town of Debir with its grasslands

Joshua 21:16

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:16

Ain, Juttah, and Beth-shemesh—nine cities from these two tribes, together with their pasturelands.

- Ain town and the grazing lands around it, Juttah town and the grazing lands around it, and Beth-shemesh town with the grazing lands around it. Nine towns in all were given from these two clans.
- and Ain town with its grasslands, and Juttah town with its grasslands, and Beth-shemesh town with its grasslands. The descendants of Judah and Simeon gave nine towns to the descendants of Aaron.

Ain: The town of Ain was mentioned in 15:32. It was allotted to both the clan of Judah and the clan of Simeon. It was in the south part of the land that was given to these clans.

Juttah: The town of Juttah was mentioned in 15:55. It was south of Hebron. Rasmussen p. 241.

Beth-shemesh: The town of Beth-shemesh was mentioned in chapter 15:10. It was on the north boundary of the land that belonged to the clan of Judah, to the west of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p. 230.

nine cities from these two tribes: The phrase nine cities from these two tribes indicates that the descendants of Aaron were given a total of nine towns from the clans of Judah and Simeon.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Ain and the grazing lands around it, Juttah and the grazing lands around it, and Beth-shemesh with the grazing lands around it. Nine towns in all were given from these two clans.

and the town of Ain with its grasslands, the town of Juttah with its grasslands, and the town of Beth-shemesh with its grasslands. The clans of Judah and Simeon gave nine towns to the descendants of Aaron.

Joshua 21:17

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:17

And from the tribe of Benjamin they gave them Gibeon, Geba,

- The clan of Benjamin gave them these towns: Gibeon town and the grazing lands around it, Geba town and the grazing lands around it,
- The following towns were given by the descendants of Benjamin: Gibeon town and its grasslands, and Geba town and its grasslands,

And from the tribe of Benjamin: This indicates that the clan of Benjamin gave the Levi people towns from their land for them to live in.

they gave them Gibeon: The town of Gibeon was mentioned in 18:25. It was northwest of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p. 236.

Geba: The town of Geba was mentioned in chapter 18:24. It was northeast of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p. 235.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The clan of Benjamin gave these towns: Gibeon and the grazing lands around it, Geba and the grazing lands around it,

The following towns were given from the clan of Benjamin: the town of Gibeon and its grasslands, the town of Geba and its grasslands,

Joshua 21:18

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:18

Anathoth, and Almon—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- Anathoth town and the grazing lands around it, and Almon town and the grazing lands around it. These four towns were given by the clan of Benjamin.
- and Anathoth town and its grasslands, and Almon town and its grasslands. The descendants of Benjamin gave them these four towns.

Anathoth: The town of Anathoth has not been mentioned previously. It was northeast of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p. 226.

and Almon: The town of Almon has not been mentioned previously. It was northeast of Anathoth. Woudstra p. 309.

four cities: The phrase four cities indicates that there were four towns in all that were given to the descendants of Aaron from the clan of Benjamin.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Anathoth and the grazing lands around it, and Almon and the grazing lands around it. These four towns were given from the clan of Benjamin.

Anathoth and its grasslands, and Almon and its grasslands. The clan of Benjamin gave four towns to the descendants of Aaron.

Joshua 21:19

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:19

In all, thirteen cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the priests, the descendants of Aaron.

- A total of thirteen towns and the grazing lands around them were given to the priests, the descendants of Aaron.
- The priests were all descendants of Aaron. They received thirteen towns in all and the grasslands that surrounded them.

In all, thirteen cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the priests, the descendants of Aaron: This verse is a concluding statement of the paragraph.

In all, thirteen cities, together with their pasturelands: The total number of towns that the descendants of Aaron received was thirteen towns and the lands around them for their livestock to graze.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

These thirteen towns and the grazing lands around them were given to the priests, the descendants of Aaron.

The priests, who were all descended from Aaron, received thirteen towns in all and the grasslands that surrounded them.

the priests, the descendants of Aaron: In Joshua 21:13 it referred to Aaron the priest. This verse refers to the priests, who were all the descendants of Aaron.

Joshua 21:20

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:20a

The remaining Kohathite clans of the Levites

- ¶ The remaining Levi people who belonged to the Kohath families of the Levi clan
- ¶ The descendants of Levi who belonged to the families of Kohath

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated can also be translated “and.” Many English versions leave this conjunction untranslated. Use the form that is natural in your language.

remaining Kohathite clans of the Levites: Exodus 6:16 says that Kohath had four sons. The eldest son was Amram who was the father of Moses and Aaron. The three other sons had sons who became the families that are spoken of here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The remaining Levi people who belonged to the Kohath families of the Levi clan

The Levi people who belonged to the other families of Kohath

21:20b

were allotted these cities: From the tribe of Ephraim

- received their towns by lot from the clan of Ephraim.
- were given towns from the descendants of Ephraim, by lot.

were allotted these cities: From the tribe of Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

received their towns by lot from the clan of Ephraim

were given towns from the clan of Ephraim by lot

Joshua 21:21

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:21a

they were given Shechem in the hill country of Ephraim

- The people of Israel gave them the town of Shechem. Shechem and the grazing lands around it were in the mountain country of the clan of Ephraim.

- They received Shechem town. Shechem and the grasslands around it were in the mountains of Ephraim.

they were given Shechem: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as they were given Shechem is more literally “they gave them Shechem.”

in the hill country of Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in the mountain country of the clan of Ephraim

in the mountains of Ephraim

21:21b

(a city of refuge for the manslayer),

- It was a town where people could run to escape when they had killed someone by accident.
- It was a town of safety for those who had killed by mistake.

a city of refuge for the manslayer: This phrase is the same Hebrew phrase as was found in verse 21:13. You should translate this phrase in the same way as you did in that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It was a town where people could run to escape if they had killed someone by accident.

which was a town of safety for anyone who had killed somebody by mistake

21:21c

Gezer,

- They also received Gezer town and the grazing lands around it,
- They also received the town of Gezer and the grasslands around it,

Gezer: The town of Gezer was mentioned in Joshua 10:33. It was southeast of Joppa.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received Gezer and the grazing lands around it

They received the town of Gezer and the grasslands around it

General Comment on verse 21:21

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

They received the town of Shechem and the pasturelands around it, in the hill country of Ephraim. It was a town of safety where anyone who killed somebody accidentally could escape. They also received the town of Gezer and the pasturelands around it.

Joshua 21:22

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:22

Kibzaim, and Beth-horon—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- Kibza-im town with the grazing lands around it, and Beth-horon town with the grazing lands around it. They received four towns from the clan of Ephraim.
- and Kibza-im town with its grasslands, and Beth-horon town with its grasslands. In all there were four towns.

Kibzaim: The town of Kibzaim has not been mentioned previously. The location of this town is uncertain.

Beth-horon: The town of Beth-horon was mentioned in Joshua 10:10–11. It was northwest of Jerusalem.

four cities: The phrase four cities refers to the four towns that the Kohath families received from the clan of Ephraim.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Kibza-im town with the grazing lands around it, and Beth-horon town with the grazing lands around it. They received four towns from the clan of Ephraim.

and the town of Kibza-im with its grasslands and the town of Beth-horon with its grasslands. In all there were four towns.

Joshua 21:23

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:23

From the tribe of Dan they were given Elteke, Gibbethon,

- From the clan of Dan they received the town of Elteke with the grazing lands around it, the town of Gibbethon with the grazing lands around it,
- They received these towns from the descendants of Dan: Elteke and its grasslands, and Gibbethon and its grasslands,

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated is often translated as “and.” It indicates the next event in the story. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence and to omit this conjunction.

From the tribe of Dan they were given: The phrase that the BSB translates as From the tribe of Dan can also be translated as “from the clan of Dan.”

Elteke: The town of Elteke was mentioned in 19:44. Its location is uncertain.

Gibbethon: The town of Gibbethon was also mentioned in Joshua 19:44. It was south of Joppa and west of Gezer. Rasmussen p. 236.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

From the clan of Dan they received the town of Elteke with the grazing lands around it, and the town of Gibbethon with the grazing lands around it.

They received these towns from the clan of Dan: Elteke and its grasslands, Gibbethon and its grasslands,

Joshua 21:24

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:24

Aijalon, and Gath-rimmon—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- Aijalon town with the grazing lands around it, and Gath-rimmon town and the grazing lands around it. The descendants of Dan gave them four towns.
- and Aijalon town and its grasslands, and Gath-rimmon town and its grasslands. In all there were four towns.

Aijalon: The town of Aijalon was mentioned in 19:42. It was northwest of Jerusalem. Rasmussen p.225.

Gath-rimmon: The town of Gath-rimmon was mentioned in 19:45. It was probably northeast of Joppa. Rasmussen p. 235.

four cities, together with their pasturelands: The phrase four cities refers to the four towns that the Kohath families received from the clan of Dan.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

They also received the town of Aijalon and the grazing lands around it, and the town of Gath-rimmon and the grazing lands around it.

Aijalon and its grasslands, Gath-rimmon and its grasslands.

Joshua 21:25

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:25

And from the half-tribe of Manasseh they were given Taanach and Gath-rimmon—two cities, together with their pasturelands.

- From the half of the clan of Manasseh who live west of the Jordan River they received Taanach town and the grazing lands around it, and Jibleam town and the grazing lands around it. The total was two towns.
- The part of the Manasseh people who live west of the Jordan River gave them Taanach town and its grasslands, and Jibleam town and its grasslands. They received two towns from the Manasseh people.

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the story. It may be more natural in some languages to omit this conjunction.

from the half-tribe of Manasseh: The half-tribe of Manasseh refers to the part of the clan of Manasseh that lived west of the Jordan River.

Taanach: The town of Taanach was mentioned in 12:21. It was on the border of the lands that belonged to the clans of Issachar and Manasseh. Rasmussen p.252.

Gath-rimmon: There is a textual issue with the name of this town:

1. The name of the town is Jibleam. NJB, CEV
2. The name of the town is Gath-rimmon. BSB, RSV, ESV, NIV, NET, NASB, GW, REB, NJPS, NABRE, GNT, NLT, KJV

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This is not the word in the Hebrew text, but it is supported by one ancient Greek manuscript and by the parallel passage in I Chronicles 6:70. This is the recommendation of most commentaries. See, for example, Butler p. 222, Boling and Wright p. 490, Dallaire p. 1019, and Hess p. 311. and also of the Hebrew Old Testament Text Project (HOTTP). These commentaries think we should not translate it as “Gath-rimmon,” because the town of Gath-rimmon was assigned to the clan of Dan in verse 21:24.

two cities: The phrase two cities refers to the towns that the half-clan of Manasseh gave to the Kohath families.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the half of the clan of Manasseh that lived west of the Jordan River they received Taanach and the grazing lands around it, and Jibleam and the grazing lands around it. The total was two towns.

The part of the Manasseh clan that lived west of the Jordan River gave them Taanach town and its grasslands and Jibleam town and its grasslands. They received two towns from that clan.

Joshua 21:26

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:26

In all, ten cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the rest of the Kohathite clans.

- The remaining families of Kohath received ten towns in all with the grazing lands that were around them.
- The other families that were descended from Kohath were given ten towns and their grasslands.

In all, ten cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the rest of the Kohathite clans: This verse is like verse 21:19. It is a concluding statement for the paragraph about the towns that the other Kohath families received.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The rest of the families of Kohath received ten towns in all with the grazing lands that were around them.

The other families that were descended from Kohath were given ten towns and their grasslands.

Joshua 21:27

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:27a

This is what the Levite clans of the Gershonites were given:

- ¶ The families that descended from Gershon, who was one of the sons of Levi,
- ¶ The families that descended from Gershon also belonged to the clan of Levi.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated indicates the next event in the story. It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence and to omit this conjunction.

the Levite clans of the Gershonites: The Hebrew phrase which the BSB translates as Gershonites is more literally “the descendants of Gershon.” Gershon was one of the three sons of Levi, and the Gershonites were his descendants.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The families that descended from Gershon, who was one of the sons of Levi

The family groups that descended from Gershon also belonged to the clan of Levi

21:27b

From the half-tribe of Manasseh they were given Golan in Bashan, a city of refuge for the manslayer,

- received the town of Golan in Bashan with its grazing lands from the half clan of Manasseh who live east of the Jordan River. It was a town where anyone could run to escape when they had killed someone by accident.
- They were given Golan town in Bashan region and the grasslands around it. The half of the Manasseh people who live east of the Jordan River gave it to them. It was a town of safety for those who had killed by mistake.

From the half-tribe of Manasseh they were given:

The phrase the half-tribe of Manasseh refers to the part of the Manasseh clan that lived on the east side of the Jordan River.

Golan in Bashan: The town of Golan was mentioned in 20:8. It was east of the Sea of Galilee, in the region of Bashan. Rasmussen p. 237.

a city of refuge for the manslayer: This is the same Hebrew phrase as in verse 21:13 and 21. You should translate it as you did in those verses.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

received the town of Golan in Bashan with its grazing lands from the half-clan of Manasseh that lived east of the Jordan River. It was a town where anyone who had killed someone by mistake could run and escape.

21:27c Rasmussen p. 232.

and Beeshterah—two cities, together with their pasturelands.

- They also received the town of Be-eshterah with its grazing lands. They received two towns in all.
- They were also given Be-eshterah town and the grasslands around it. In total there were two towns.

and Beeshterah—two cities, together with their pasturelands:

The town of Beeshterah is called Ashtaroth in I Chronicles 6:71. It was in the region of Bashan, east of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received the town of Beeshterah with its grazing lands. They received two towns from this clan.

They were also given Beeshterah and the grasslands around it. The total was two towns.

Joshua 21:28

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:28

From the tribe of Issachar they were given Kishion, Daberath,

- From the clan of Issachar the Kohath families received the town of Kishion and the grazing lands around it, the town of Daberath and the grazing lands around it,
- The descendants of Issachar gave them Kishion town with its grasslands, and Daberath town with its grasslands,

From the tribe of Issachar they were given Kishion:

The town of Kishion was mentioned in 19:20. It was the southeast of Nazareth. Rasmussen p. 242.

Daberath: The town of Daberath was mentioned in 19:12. It was east of Nazareth

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the clan of Issachar the Kohath families received the town of Kishion and the grazing lands around it and the town of Daberath with the grazing lands around it.

The clan of Issachar gave them the town of Kishion with the grasslands around it and the town of Daberath with the grasslands around it.

Joshua 21:29

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:29

Jarmuth, and En-gannim—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- the town of Jarmuth with the grazing lands around it, and the town of En-gannim with the grazing lands around it.
- and Jarmuth town with its grasslands, and En-gannim town with its grasslands.

Jarmuth: The town of Jarmuth was south of Kishion. Rasmussen p. 102.

and En-gannim: The town of En-gannim was mentioned in 19:21. It was southwest of the Sea of Galilee.

four cities: The clan of Issachar gave four cities in all to the Kohath families of the Levi people.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Jarmuth with the grazing lands around it and the town of En-gannim with the grazing lands around it. They gave four towns in all.

Jarmuth town with its grasslands and En-gannim town with its grasslands. The total was four towns.

Joshua 21:30

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:30

From the tribe of Asher they were given Mishal, Abdon,

- From the clan of Asher, they received the town of Mishal with the grazing lands around it, the town of Abdon with the grazing lands around it,
- The descendants of Asher gave the Kohath people Mishal town with its grasslands, and Abdon town with its grasslands,

From the tribe of Asher they were given Mishal: The town of Mishal was mentioned in 19:26. Its location is uncertain.

Abdon: The town of Abdon was mentioned in 1 Chronicles 6:74. It was northeast of Acco. Rasmussen p. 224.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the clan of Asher they received the town of Mishal with the grazing lands around it and the town of Abdon with the grazing lands around it,

The clan of Asher gave the Kohath families Mishal town with its grasslands and Abdon town with its grasslands,

Joshua 21:31

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:31

Helkath, and Rehob—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- the town of Helkath and the grazing lands around it, and the town of Rehob and the grazing lands around it. They gave four towns in all.
- and Helkath town and its grasslands, and Rehob town and its grasslands. The descendants of Asher gave a total of four towns.

Helkath: The town of Helkath was mentioned in 19:25. Its location is uncertain.

and Rehob: The town of Rehob was mentioned in 19:28. Its location is uncertain. Rasmussen p. 249.

four cities: The total number of towns that the clan of Asher gave to the Kohath clans was four cities.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Helkath and the grazing lands around it and the town of Rehob and the grazing lands around it. They gave four towns in all.

Helkath town and its grasslands, and Rehob town and its grasslands. The total was four towns.

Joshua 21:32

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:32a

And from the tribe of Naphtali they were given Kedesh in Galilee (a city of refuge for the manslayer),

- From the clan of Naphtali they received the town of Kedesh in the region of Galilee with its grasslands. It was a town where anyone could run to escape when they had killed someone by accident.
- The descendants of Naphtali gave them Kedesh town in Galilee region and the grasslands around it. It was a town of safety for those who had killed by mistake.

And from the tribe of Naphtali: The phrase from the tribe of Naphtali can also be translated “from the clan of Naphtali.”

they were given Kedesh in Galilee: The town of Kedesh in Galilee was mentioned in 12:22. It was northwest of the Sea of Galilee. Rasmussen p. 241.

a city of refuge for the manslayer: This is the same Hebrew phrase as in verse 21:13, 21:21, and 21:27. You should translate it as you did in those verses.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the clan of Naphtali they received the town of Kedesh in the region of Galilee, with its grasslands. It was a town where anyone who had killed someone by mistake could run and escape.

The clan of Naphtali gave them Kedesh in Galilee region and the grazing lands around it. It was a town of safety for anyone who had killed someone accidentally.

21:32b

Hammoth-dor, and Kartan—three cities, together with their pasturelands.

- They also received the town of Hammoth-dor and the grazing lands around it, and the town of Kartan and the grazing lands around it. They received three towns in all.
- They also gave the Gershon families the town of Hammoth-dor with its grasslands, and the town of Kartan with its grasslands. The total was three towns.

Hammoth-dor: The town of Hammoth-dor is called “Hammath” in Joshua 19:35. Woudstra p. 313.

and Kartan: The location of the town of Kartan is uncertain.

three cities, together with their pasturelands: The phrase three cities indicates that the clan of Naphtali gave a total of three towns to the Gershon families.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They also received Hammoth-dor and the grazing lands around it and Kartan and the grazing lands around it. They received three towns in all.

They also gave the Gershon clans the town of Hammoth-dor with its grasslands and the town of Kartan with its grasslands. The total was three towns.

Joshua 21:33

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:33

In all, thirteen cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the Gershonite clans.

- The Gershon families received a total of thirteen towns and the grazing lands around them.
- The families of the Gershon people were given thirteen towns and their grasslands.

In all, thirteen cities, together with their pasturelands, were given to the Gershonite clans: This verse is like verses 21:19 and 21:26. It is a concluding statement for this paragraph.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

The Gershon families received a total of thirteen towns and the grazing lands around them.

The family groups of the Gershon people were given thirteen towns and their grasslands.

Joshua 21:34

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:34a

This is what the Merarite clan (the rest of the Levites) were given:

- ¶ The remaining Levi people belonged to the families descended from Merari.
- ¶ The other Levi people were families who descended from Merari.

the Merarite clan: The phrase the Merarite clan refers to the families who were descended from Merari. All the Levites who were not yet named were from the Merari families.

the rest of the Levites: The phrase the rest of the Levites refers to all the descendants of Levi who had not been named previously.

21:34b

From the tribe of Zebulun they were given Jokneam, Kartah,

- From the clan of Zebulun they were given the town of Jokne-am with the grazing lands around it, the town of Kartah with the grazing lands around it,
- The descendants of Zebulun gave them Jokne-am town with its grasslands, and Kartah town with its grasslands,

From the tribe of Zebulun they were given: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Levites that remained belonged to the families descended from Merari. From the clan of Zebulun they were given...

The other Levi people were descended from Merari. The clan of Zebulun gave them...

Jokneam: The town of Jokneam is mentioned in 12:22. It was northwest of Meggido at the foot of Mount Carmel. Rasmussen p. 241.

Kartah: The location of the town of Kartah is unknown.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The town of Jokne-am with the grazing lands around it, the town of Kartah with the grazing lands around it,

Jokne-am town with its grasslands, Kartah town with its grasslands

Joshua 21:35

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:35

Dimnah, and Nahalal—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- the town of Dimnah with the grazing lands around it, and the town of Nahalal with the grazing lands around it. The total number was four towns.
- and Dimnah town with its grasslands, and Nahalal town with its grasslands. They received four towns from the descendants of Zebulun.

Dimnah: The town of Dimnah was probably the same town as was called “Rimmon” in 19:13. Butler p. 233.

and Nahalal: The town of Nahalal was mentioned in 19:15. Its location is unknown.

four cities: The phrase four cities indicates that the families of Merari received four towns in all from the clan of Zebulun.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

the town of Dimnah with the grazing lands around it and the town of Nahalal with the grazing lands around it. The families of Merari received four towns from the clan of Zebulun.

Dimnah with its grasslands and Nahalal with its grasslands. In all they received four towns.

Joshua 21:36

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:36

From the tribe of Reuben they were given Bezer, Jahaz,

- From the clan of Reuben, they received the town of Bezer with the grazing lands around it, the town of Jahaz with the grazing lands around it,
- The descendants of Reuben gave the Merari families the town of Bezer and its grasslands, and the town of Jahaz and its grasslands,

From the tribe of Reuben they were given Bezer:

The town of Bezer was mentioned in 20:8. It was east of the Jordan River.

Jahaz: The town of Jahaz was mentioned in 13:18. It was probably east of the Dead Sea, southeast of Medeba. Rasmussen p. 240.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

From the clan of Reuben, they received the town of Bezer with its grazing lands and the town of Jahaz with its grazing lands,

The clan of Reuben gave from their lands the Merari families the town of Bezer and the grasslands around it and the town of Jahaz and the grasslands around it,

Joshua 21:37

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:37

Kedemoth, and Mephaath—four cities, together with their pasturelands.

- the town of Kedemoth with the grazing lands around it, and the town of Mepha-ath with the grazing lands around it. The total was four towns.
- and the town of Kedemoth with its grasslands, and the town of Mepha-ath with its grasslands. The clan of Reuben gave the families of Merari four towns in all.

Kedemoth: The town of Kedemoth was mentioned in 13:18. It was possibly east of the Dead Sea and north of the Arnon River. Rasmussen p. 241.

and Mephaath: The town of Mephaath was mentioned in 13:18. Possibly it was south of the town of Amman in what is now the country of Jordan. Rasmussen p. 244.

four cities, together with their pasturelands: The phrase four cities indicates that the clan of Reuben gave the Merari families four towns in all.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

the town of Kedemoth and the grasslands around it, and the town of Mephaath and the grasslands around it. The total was four towns.

the town of Kedemoth with its grazing lands and the town of Mephaath with its grazing lands. The

clan of Reuben gave the families of Merari four towns in all.

Joshua 21:38

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:38a

And from the tribe of Gad they were given Ramoth in Gilead, a city of refuge for the manslayer,

- From the clan of Gad they received the town of Ramoth in the region of Gilead with the grazing lands around it. It was a town where anyone could run to escape when they had killed someone by accident.
- The descendants of Gad gave them Ramoth in Gilead region and its grasslands. It was a town of safety for those who had killed by mistake.

And from the tribe of Gad they were given Ramoth in Gilead:

The town of Ramoth in Gilead was mentioned in chapter 20:8. It was north of the town of Amman in what is now the country of Jordan. Rasmussen, p. 249.

a city of refuge for the manslayer: This Hebrew phrase was found in verses 21:13, 21:21, 21:27, and 21:32. You should translate it as you did in those verses:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

From the clan of Gad they received the town of Ramoth in the region of Gilead, with its grasslands. It was a town where anyone who had killed someone by mistake could run and escape.

The clan of Gad gave them Ramoth in Gilead region and the grazing lands around it. It was a town of safety for anyone who had killed someone accidentally.

21:38b

Mahanaim,

- They also received the town of Mahanaim with its grazing lands,
- They also gave them the town of Mahanaim and its grasslands,

Mahanaim: The town of Mahanaim was mentioned in 13:26. It was on the border of the lands that belonged to the clans of Gad and Manasseh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the town of Mahanaim with its grazing lands

the town of Mahanaim and the grasslands around it

Joshua 21:39

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:39

Heshbon, and Jazer—four cities in all, together with their pasturelands.

- the town of Heshbon with its grazing lands, and the town of Jazer with its grazing lands. The total was four towns.
- and the town of Heshbon with its grasslands, and the town of Jazer with its grasslands. The descendants of Gad gave the families of Merari four towns in all.

Heshbon: The town of Heshbon was mentioned in 9:10. It was southwest of the city of Amman in what is now the country of Jordan. Rasmussen p. 238.

Jazer: The town of Jazer was mentioned in 13:25. It was probably west of the present city of Amman in what is now the country of Jordan. Rasmussen, p. 240.

four cities in all, together with their pasturelands: The phrase four cities in all indicates that the clan of Gad gave four of their towns for the Merari families to live in.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

the town of Heshbon and the grasslands around it, and the town of Jazer and the grasslands around it. The total was four towns.

the town of Heshbon with its grazing lands and the town of Jazer with its grazing lands. The clan of Gad gave the families of Merari four towns in all.

Joshua 21:40

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:40a

In all, twelve cities were allotted to the clans of Merari,

- The descendants of Merari received twelve towns by lot,

- The families of the Merari people were given twelve towns in all.

twelve cities were allotted to the clans of Merari: This verse is like verse 21:19. It is a concluding statement for the paragraph about the towns that the families of Merari received.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The towns that the descendants of Merari, according to their families

The towns of the family groups of the Merari people

The Hebrew clause twelve cities were allotted to is more literally “their lot was twelve cities.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

the clans of Merari received twelve towns by lot

Their share of the clans of Merari was twelve towns.

21:40b

the remaining Levite clans.

- who were the remaining families of the Levi people.
- They were the last families to receive towns.

the remaining Levite clans: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as the remaining Levite clans is more literally “the remaining ones from the clans of the Levites.” This indicates that the Merari families were the last Levite families to receive towns.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

who were the remaining clans of the Levites

those family groups of the Levites who had not yet received towns

Joshua 21:41

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:41

For the Levites, then, there were forty-eight cities in all, together with their pasturelands, within the territory of the Israelites.

- ¶ All the towns that the clan of Levi received in the land of the people of Israel numbered forty-eight towns with the grazing lands around them.
- ¶ The total number of towns that the descendants of Levi were given inside the land that belonged to Israel was forty-eight towns and their grasslands.

For the Levites, then, there were forty-eight cities in all: This is the concluding paragraph of this chapter about the clans of Levi. The phrase For the Levites... forty-eight cities refers to all the towns named in the previous verses. They were all given to the clan of Levi to live in.

together with their pasturelands: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

with the grazing lands around them

and their grasslands

within the territory of the Israelites: The phrase within the territory of the Israelites indicates that these towns were scattered among all the lands that belonged to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The towns that the clan of Levi received within the land of the people of Israel

The total number of towns that the Levi clan were given in the land that belonged to the Israel people

Joshua 21:42

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:42

Each of these cities had its own surrounding pasturelands; this was true for all the cities.

- Each one of these towns had its own grazing lands around it.

- All of these towns had grasslands surrounding them.

Each of these cities had its own surrounding pasturelands: This information has been stated in verse 21:41. It is repeated here to emphasize that the Levites received pasture lands for their use.

this was true for all the cities: The clause this was true for all the cities further emphasizes that each town had pasturelands around it for the Levites to use.

If it is not natural in your language to repeat this information it may be possible to combine verse 41 and 42. For example:

From the land that the people of Israel possessed, a total of forty-eight cities, with the pasture lands around them, was given to the Levites (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Each one of these towns had its own grasslands around it.

All of these towns had grazing lands surrounding them. They were the same in this way.

Joshua 21:43

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:43a

Thus the LORD gave Israel all the land He had sworn to give their fathers,

- ¶ So Yahweh gave to the Israel people all the land that he had promised to give to their ancestors.
- ¶ In this way, Yahweh gave the people of Israel all the land. He had promised their ancestors that he would do that.

Thus: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Thus introduces the conclusion to the account of how the land was assigned to all the clans of Israel. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language in this context. In some languages it may be more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated.

Here are some other ways to translate this conjunction:

In this way

So

the LORD gave Israel all the land He had sworn to give their fathers: At the beginning of the book of Joshua, in 1:1, Yahweh repeated his promise to give the land of Canaan to the Israelites. He promised the land of Canaan to Abraham and his descendants in Genesis 13:1.

had sworn: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as had sworn was also used in chapter 1:6. You should translate it in the same way as in that verse.

their fathers: The phrase their fathers refers to the ancestors of the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So Yahweh gave to the Israel people all the land which he had promised to give to their ancestors.

In this way Yahweh gave the people of Israel all the land. He had promised their ancestors that he would do that.

21:43b
and they took possession of it and settled in it.

- They conquered the land and they lived in it.
- They took that land and made it their home.

and they took possession of it: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as took possession of was used in 1:11. You should translate this verb in the same way as in that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate the verb “took possession:”

captured

conquered

took

and settled in it: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as settled can also be translated as “lived.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They conquered that land and they lived in it.

They took that land and made it their home.

Joshua 21:44

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:44a

And the LORD gave them rest on every side, just as He had sworn to their fathers.

- Yahweh caused them to have peace all around them, just as he had promised their ancestors that he would do.
- Yahweh kept the promise that he had made to their ancestors and gave them rest from war all through their land.

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the story. It may be more natural in some languages to omit this conjunction.

the LORD gave them rest on every side: The clause the LORD gave them rest on every side indicates that Yahweh caused the Israelites to have peace throughout their land. The phrase on every side can also be translated “all around them.”

just as He had sworn to their fathers: The clause He had sworn to their fathers indicates that Yahweh had made this promise to the ancestors of the Israelites. The promise to give rest to their ancestors was given in Deuteronomy 12:10. It was repeated in Joshua 1:13.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh caused them to have peace all around them, just as he had promised their ancestors that he would do.

Yahweh kept the promise that he had made to their ancestors and gave them rest from war all through their land.

21:44b

None of their enemies could stand against them,

- Not even one of Israel’s enemies was able to defeat them
- None of their enemies could fight against them and win.

None of their enemies could stand against them: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as None of their enemies could stand against them is more literally “A man from all their enemies did not stand before them.” This indicates that none of their enemies had been able to fight against them and win.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Not a single one of Israel's enemies was able to defeat them

None of their enemies could fight against them and win.

21:44c
for the LORD delivered all their enemies into their hand.

- because Yahweh had given all their enemies over to them.
- Yahweh had caused them to win over all their enemies.

for: There is no Hebrew word which corresponds to the word for in the BSB. The BSB added the word for because this clause indicates the reason that Israel's enemies could not defeat them.

the LORD delivered all their enemies into their hand: The clause the LORD delivered all their enemies into their hand indicates that Yahweh had enabled the Israelites to defeat their enemies.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because Yahweh had handed all Israel's enemies over to them

Yahweh had caused Israel to win over all their enemies.

Joshua 21:45

Section 21:1–45 The clan of Levi received towns to live in

21:45a
Not one of all the LORD's good promises to the house of Israel had failed;

- None of the good words which Yahweh had spoken to Israel were left undone.
- There was no promise which Yahweh had made to the people of Israel which he did not keep.

Not one of all the LORD's good promises to the house of Israel had failed: This clause is more literally, "Not a word fell from all the good words that Yahweh spoke to the house of Israel."

the house of Israel: The phrase the house of Israel refers to all the people of Israel.

had failed: The verb had failed indicates that there was no promise that Yahweh had not kept.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

None of the good words which Yahweh had spoken to Israel were unfulfilled.

There was no promise which Yahweh had made to the people of Israel which he did not keep.

21:45b
everything was fulfilled.

- Everything happened just as he had said.
- Every one of his promises came true.

everything was fulfilled: The clause everything was fulfilled indicates that everything happened that Yahweh had said would happen.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Everything happened just as he had said.

Every one of his promises came true.

Joshua 22:1

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God's help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:1
Then Joshua summoned the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ Later, Joshua called together the people of the Reuben clan, the Gad clan, and half of the Manasseh clan.
- ¶ On another day, Joshua called the Reuben people, the Gad people and half of the Manasseh people to meet with him.

Then: The Hebrew adverb that the BSB translates as Then starts a new time setting. Butler, p. 241. We do not know how much time passed between the events of chapter 21 and the events of chapter 22. If the word Then in your language suggests that these events happened immediately after the events of chapter 22, it may be better to add a phrase such as:

some time later

on another day

Joshua summoned: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as summoned can also be translated as “called” or “called together.” Joshua called all these people to come together and listen to what he had to say.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: The phrase the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh refers to the people of the Reuben clan, the Gad clan, and half the people of the clan of Manasseh. These clans were mentioned in 1:12.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Later, Joshua called together the people of the Reuben clan, the Gad clan, and half of the Manasseh clan

On another day, Joshua called the Reuben people, the Gad people, and half of the Manasseh people to meet with him

Joshua 22:2

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God’s help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:2a and told them,

- He said to them,
- He told them,

and told them: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He said to them (GNT)

He told them (NLT)

22:2b

“You have done all that Moses the servant of the LORD commanded you,

- “You^(plur) have done everything that Moses, the servant of Yahweh, commanded you to do.
- “You have obeyed all the commands that Moses gave you. Moses was Yahweh’s servant.

You have done all that Moses the servant of the LORD commanded you:

In Numbers 32:16–32 Moses had told the people of these clans to help their fellow Israelites conquer the land that was west of the Jordan River. In this verse Joshua says that they have done what they were told.

The verb You have done can also be translated “you have obeyed” or “you have kept.”

Moses the servant of the LORD: This phrase first occurred in 1:1. You should translate it as you did there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You^(plur) have done everything that Moses, the servant of Yahweh, commanded you to do.

Moses was Yahweh’s servant. You have obeyed all the commands that Moses gave you.

22:2c

and you have obeyed my voice in all that I commanded you.

- You have also done everything that I commanded you to do.
- You have also obeyed all the commands that I gave you.

and you have obeyed my voice in all that I commanded you: in 1:17 the people of these clans promised to obey Joshua, as they had obeyed Moses.

obeyed my voice: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as obeyed my voice is more literally “listened to my voice.” This is a Hebrew idiom that means “to obey.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You have done everything that I commanded you to do

You have obeyed all the commands that I gave you to do

Joshua 22:3

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God's help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:3a

All this time you have not deserted your brothers, up to this very day,

- You have not deserted your brother Israelites all this long time, up to today.
- During these years you have not left your relatives and gone home. You have helped them until this day.

All this time you have not deserted your brothers:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as deserted means to leave someone without intending to return to them. In some languages it may be more natural to state this in a positive sense. For example,

For a long time you have supported your fellow Israelites. (NCV)

It's taken a long time, but you have stayed and helped your relatives. (CEV)

All this time: The phrase All this time refers to the time that the Israelites were fighting to conquer the land of Canaan. This was probably a period of several years.

brothers: The word brothers refers to the people of the other Israelite clans.

up to this very day: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as up to this very day can also be translated "until this day," or "down to this day."

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You have not deserted your brother Israelites all this long time, up to today.

During these years you have not left your relatives. You have helped them until this day.

22:3b

but have kept the charge given you by the LORD your God.

- You have faithfully observed the commands of Yahweh your God.
- You have carefully kept the commands of Yahweh our^(incl) God.

but: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates a contrast. However, in this context it is not strongly contrastive. Some versions, such as NET, do not translate this conjunction. Begin this sentence in a way that is natural in your language.

have kept the charge given you by the LORD your God:

The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the charge is more literally "the obligation of the commandment." These three clans were required to obey God's command, and they did obey it.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

have completed the task given to you by the Lord your God (NET)

have carried out the mission the Lord your God gave you (NIV)

Joshua 22:4

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God's help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:4a

And now that the LORD your God has given your brothers rest as He promised them,

- Now Yahweh your God has given peace to the other Israel clans, just as he promised.
- Now Yahweh our God has given your fellow Israelites a place to settle and live in peace. That was what he promised to do.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the story. Many English versions leave this conjunction untranslated.

now that: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as now indicates a contrast between the time when all the Israelites were fighting to conquer the land of Canaan, and the present time, when they were able to settle down in it.

the LORD your God: In some languages it may be more natural to translate this phrase as “Yahweh our God.” Yahweh was the God of Joshua as well as the God of the Israel people.

has given your brothers rest: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as has given...rest comes from the same verbal root as was used in 1:13. It indicates that Yahweh gave the Israelites a place to settle and live in peace.

as He promised them: Here, the pronoun them refers to the other Israelite people.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Now Yahweh your God has given peace to the other Israel clans, as he promised.

Now Yahweh our God has given your fellow Israel people a place to settle and live in peace. He promised to do that.

22:4b

you may return to your homes in the land

- So now return to your homes in the land that you own.
- Now return to your own place in the land that you possess

The Hebrew words that the BSB leaves untranslated are the same words that were translated “and now” in verse 22:4. They are repeated here for emphasis. Choose a natural way in your language to connect this sentence with the previous sentence in the first part of the verse.

you may return to your homes: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as your homes is more literally

“your tents.” It indicates the place where their wives and children were living.

in the land that: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So return to your homes in the land that you own

Now return to your own place in the land that you possess

22:4c

that Moses the servant of the LORD gave you across the Jordan.

- Moses, who was Yahweh’s servant, gave you that land on the east side of the Jordan River.
- east of the Jordan River. Moses gave that land to you.

that Moses the servant of the LORD gave you across the Jordan: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here.

across the Jordan: The across the Jordan refers to the east side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Moses, who was Yahweh’s servant, gave you that land on the east side of the Jordan River.

east of the Jordan River. Moses gave that land to you.

Joshua 22:5

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God’s help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:5a

But be very careful to observe the commandment and the law that Moses the servant of the LORD gave you:

- Be very careful to obey all the commands and teachings of Moses, who was Yahweh’s servant.

- But be sure to follow all the commandments that Moses gave you. He was Yahweh's servant.

But be very careful to observe: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as be very careful to observe can also be translated "be careful to do."

the commandment and the law that Moses the servant of the LORD gave you: The phrase the commandment and the law is a reference to the commandments and teachings of the covenant that Yahweh made with the Israelites. The two nouns express one idea. For this reason, some English versions use only one noun to translate this phrase. For example:

Make sure you obey the law that Moses commanded you (GNT)

So be very careful to do everything Moses commanded (CEV)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Be careful to obey all the commands and teachings of Moses, who was Yahweh's servant.

But be sure to follow the entire law that Moses gave you. He was Yahweh's servant.

22:5b

to love the LORD your God, to walk in all His ways,

- You must love Yahweh your God and live according to his teachings.
- Love Yahweh your God and follow everything he has told you to do.

to love the LORD your God: It may be more natural in some languages to begin a new sentence here. For example,

You must love Yahweh your God

to walk in all His ways: The phrase walk in all His ways is an idiom. It means that a person will obey the commands and teachings of Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do his will (GNT)

live according to his teachings

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must love Yahweh your God and live according to his teachings.

Love Yahweh your God and follow everything he has told you to do.

22:5c

to keep His commandments, to hold fast to Him,

- You must keep all his commandments and hold onto him.
- Obey all his commands and be faithful to him.

to keep His commandments: This clause repeats information from verse 5a. This is a way to emphasize the importance of doing everything that Yahweh commanded the Israelites. If it is too repetitive to have the word "commands" again, it may be better to choose to use the word "law" in verse 5a and to use the word "commands" in this part of the verse.

to hold fast to Him: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as hold fast may also be translated "hold onto," "cling to," "cleave to," or "stick to" someone. This is a Hebrew idiom that implies being loyal and faithful to somebody.

Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

hold onto him

stay close to him

be faithful to him

be loyal to him

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You must keep all his commandments and hold onto him.

Obey all his commands and be faithful to him.

22:5d

and to serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul."

- You must serve him with your whole life and being."

- Serve him in the very best way that you can.”

and to serve Him with all your heart and with all your soul: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as all your heart and with all your soul is an idiom that refers to the whole person.

Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

Serve him by everything that you think and everything that you do (T4T)

You must serve him with your whole life and being.

Joshua 22:6

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God’s help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:6

So Joshua blessed them and sent them on their way, and they went to their homes.

- Then Joshua blessed them. He sent them on their way and they returned to their homes.
- Then Joshua blessed the men of those clans and told them they could go. They left to go home.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates the next event in the narrative. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua blessed them: It was customary in ancient Israel to bless people as part of saying goodbye to them. Butler, p. 245.

and sent them on their way, and they went to their homes: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as they went to their homes is more literally “they went to their tents.” It is the same phrase as was used 22:4.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua blessed them and said goodbye to them. He sent them on their way and they returned to their homes.

Then Joshua blessed these men and told them they could go. They left to go home.

Then Joshua said goodbye to them and they left and went home. (ERV)

Joshua 22:7

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God’s help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:7a

(To the half-tribe of Manasseh Moses had given land in Bashan,

- Moses had given land to the half-clan of Manasseh in the region of Bashan east of the Jordan River.
- One half of the clan of Manasseh had received land from Moses. That land was in the region of Bashan on the east side of the Jordan River.

The information in verse 22:7a–c is background information. The Hebrew conjunction that begins this sentence is usually translated “and.” Some translations translate it as “now” because this is a way to introduce background information in English. Some English versions including the BSB indicate this by putting the sentence in parentheses. Translate this Hebrew conjunction in a way that is natural in your language and shows that what follows is background information.

To the half-tribe of Manasseh Moses had given land in Bashan:

The author reminds the reader of information from chapter 1:12–15 and chapter 17:1–13. Moses had given land to half of the clan of Manasseh on the east side of the Jordan River, but the other half of the people of the Manasseh clan received land on the west side of the river.

To the half-tribe of Manasseh: The phrase To the half-tribe of Manasseh is put at the beginning of the sentence in Hebrew to emphasize it. Use a word order that is natural in your language.

had given land: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as had given land is more literally “Moses had given.” The BSB has supplied the word land to make the meaning clear in English.

in Bashan: Bashan was a region that was east of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Moses had given land to the half-clan of Manasseh in the region of Bashan east of the Jordan River

One half of the clan of Manasseh had received land from Moses. That land was in the region of Bashan on the east side of the Jordan River

22:7b

and to the other half Joshua gave land on the west side of the Jordan among their brothers.)

- But Joshua had given land to the other half of the clan of Manasseh on the west side of the Jordan River, next to the land the other clans received.
- But the other half of the clan of Manasseh received land from Joshua on the west side of the Jordan River, along with their other relatives.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and indicates a contrast. It is a contrast between the two locations of land that the clan of Manasseh received.

and to the other half: The phrase the other half refers to the other half of the clan of Manasseh.

Joshua gave land: The Hebrew clause is more literally “Joshua had given.” The BSB has added the word land to make the meaning clear in English.

on the west side of the Jordan among their brothers: The phrase among their brothers indicates that half of the Manasseh clan’s land was next to the land that the other clans received on the west side of the Jordan River. The word brothers refers to the other Israelite clans.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But Joshua had given land to the other half of the clan of Manasseh. That land was on the west side of the Jordan River, next to the land the other clans had received.

But the other half of the clan of Manasseh received land from Joshua on the west side of the Jordan River, along with their relatives.

22:7c

When Joshua sent them to their homes he blessed them,

- As Joshua sent them on their way home, he blessed them,
- When Joshua told them to go home, he blessed them

When Joshua sent them to their homes he blessed them: This part of the verse restates the information found in 22:6.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As Joshua sent them on their way home he blessed them

When Joshua told them to go home he blessed them

Joshua 22:8

Section 22:1–8 Joshua sent the eastern clans back to their homes

Joshua had told the men of the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh that they must help their fellow Israelites to conquer the land on the west side of the Jordan River (see Joshua 1:12–18). Now they had conquered it with God’s help. They had fulfilled their obligation and so Joshua sent them home to where their families were living on the east side of the Jordan.

22:8a saying,

- saying to them:
- and said to them:

saying: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

saying to them,

and said to them,

22:8b

“Return to your homes with your great wealth, with immense herds of livestock,

- “Return home with all your riches. Take your many herds and flocks,

- “Go back home and take your many possessions with you that you took from your enemies. Take all your animals,

Return to your homes with your great wealth: The phrase great wealth refers to the things that the men of the two and a half clans took from their enemies in the battles they fought. This is made clear in 22:8d. It may be clearer to include this information in this part of the verse.

Verse 22:8b-c explains what the wealth consists of. Some English versions use dashes to indicate that the following items are a list of the things that the Israelites were taking home with them. Use punctuation or grammar that is natural in your language to indicate a list of items.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Return home with many valuable things

Go back home and take all your many possessions with you

with immense herds of livestock: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as herds of livestock and can refer to sheep and goats as well as cattle.

22:8c

with silver, gold, bronze, iron, and very many clothes.

- your silver, gold, bronze and iron and all your many clothes.
- your silver and your gold and your bronze and iron items and your many clothing items.

with silver, gold, bronze, iron, and very many clothes: Here are some other ways to translate 8b-c:

Take your many cows and sheep and goats, your silver, gold, bronze, and iron and all your many clothes

Take all your animals, your silver and your gold and your bronze and iron items and your many clothing items

iron: This was at the very beginning of the iron age. Since iron was a new material that was stronger than bronze, items made of iron would have been very valuable.

22:8d

Divide with your brothers the spoil of your enemies.”

- Share the things you have gotten from your enemies with your relatives.”
- Divide the things you have captured from your enemies with the other people of your clans.”

Divide with your brothers the spoil of your enemies: The phrase the spoil of your enemies refers to the things that the Israelites took from their enemies in battle.

with your brothers: The word brothers in this context refers to the people of the two and a half clans who have stayed home.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Share the things you have gotten from your enemies with your relatives.

Divide the things you have captured from your enemies with the other people of your clans.

General Comment on 22:8

It may be clearer in some languages to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

Go back home and take all the things you have captured from your enemies: your many herds and flocks, your items of silver, gold, bronze, iron, and many pieces of clothing. Share these things with your fellow Israelites.

Joshua 22:9

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:9a

So the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh went home.
- ¶ So the people of Reuben, Gad, and half the Manasseh people left

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces a new section. Use a connecting word that is natural to begin a new section in your language.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh went home

The people of Reuben, the people of Gad, and half the people of Manasseh left

22:9b **left the Israelites at Shiloh in the land of Canaan**

- They left the other Israelites at the town of Shiloh, which was in the land of Canaan.
- the other Israel clans at Shiloh town in the land of Canaan.

left the Israelites at Shiloh in the land of Canaan: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the Israelites is more literally “sons of Israel.”

Shiloh: The town of Shiloh was last mentioned in 21:2. Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they left the other Israelites at the town of Shiloh that was in the land of Canaan

they parted from the other Israelite clans at Shiloh town in the land of Canaan

22:9c **to return to their own land of Gilead,**

- They went back to their own land, the region of Gilead.
- They started to go back to the region of Gilead, which was their own land.

to return to their own land of Gilead: The region of Gilead was on the east side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they started to go back to their own land, the region of Gilead

They went back to the region of Gilead, which was their own land

22:9d **which they had acquired according to the command of the LORD through Moses.**

- They had taken possession of that land as Yahweh had commanded through Moses.
- Yahweh told Moses that they should have that land, and they had captured it.

which they had acquired according to the command of the LORD through Moses: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

They had taken possession of that land as Yahweh had commanded through Moses

Joshua 22:10

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:10a **And when they came to Geliloth near the Jordan in the land of Canaan,**

- ¶ They went as far as the region near the Jordan River, in the land of Canaan.
- ¶ They came to the Jordan River in the land of Canaan. Before they crossed the river

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the storyline.

when: The Hebrew text does not have the word when. The BSB has added it to make the meaning clear in English. It may be natural in your language to omit the word when.

they came to Geliloth near the Jordan: There is an interpretation issue concerning the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Geliloth:

1. This word means region. (ESV, NASB, RSV, NABRE, CEV, GW, NJPS, KJV)
 2. This word is Geliloth, the name of a place. (BSB, NIV, NET, GNT, NLT, NCV, REB)
 3. This word means circle of stones. (NJB)
- It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with Hebrew lexicons HOL, BDB. and many English versions.

in the land of Canaan: The land of Canaan refers to the west side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

that is in the land of Canaan

in the land of Canaan on the west side of the river

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they came to the district near the Jordan River, in the land of Canaan

they came to the region that was near the Jordan River in the land of Canaan

22:10b

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh built an imposing altar there by the Jordan.

- Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh built an altar by the side of the river. It was large and impressive to look at.
- they built an altar there next to the river. The altar was very large and grand.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: In some languages it may be more natural to use the proper names of the clans in 22:10a of this verse and use a pronoun reference in this part of the verse. For example:

Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh came to the region of the Jordan that was still in Canaan. They built an altar by the Jordan River. (GW)

built an imposing altar there by the Jordan: The clans of Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh built an altar by the side of the Jordan River.

an imposing altar: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as an imposing altar is more literally “an altar great of appearance.” The altar was large, and it was grand and impressive to look at.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh built an altar by the side of the Jordan River. It was large and impressive to look at.

and built an altar near the Jordan River. The altar was large and grand.

Joshua 22:11

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:11a

Then the Israelites received the report:

- Somebody told the other Israelite clans this news:
- Then the people of Israel heard that

Then the Israelites received the report: The clause the Israelites received the report indicates that the other Israel people who were still at Shiloh, heard a report from somebody about the altar.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The other Israelite clans heard this news

Somebody told the rest of the Israel people

22:11b

“Behold, the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- “Listen! The people of Reuben and Gad and the half-clan of Manasseh
- the eastern clans

Behold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Behold draws attention to what follows.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Listen!

Look!

Several English versions do not use a separate word or expression here. Languages have a wide variety of ways to direct the listener's attention to the next statement. Use a way that is natural in your language.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Listen! The people of Reuben and Gad and the half-tribe of Manasseh

Look! Those people

22:11c

have built an altar on the border of the land of Canaan,

- have built an altar at the border of the land of Canaan
- had built an altar at the edge of the land of Canaan

have built an altar on the border of the land of Canaan: The Hebrew phrase the border of the land of Canaan is more literally “the front of the land of Canaan.” It refers to the frontier of the land, or the edge of the land.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

have built an altar at the border of the land of Canaan

have built an altar at the edge of the land of Canaan

22:11d

at Geliloth near the Jordan on the Israelite side.”

- by the Jordan River, on the side that belongs to Israel.”
- near the Jordan River, on the Israel side.

at Geliloth near the Jordan: The phrase Geliloth near the Jordan is the same as in verse 22:10. You should translate it the same way as you did there.

on the Israelite side: The phrase on the Israelite side indicates that the altar was on the west side of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in the district that is by the Jordan River, on the side that belongs to we^(incl) Israelites

in the region near the Jordan River, on the Israel side

Joshua 22:12

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:12a

And when they heard this,

- When the people of Israel heard this,
- When they heard about it

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And indicates the next event in the storyline.

when: The Hebrew text does not have a word that is equivalent to when. The BSB has added the word when to make the meaning clear in English.

they heard this: The Hebrew text does not have the word this. The BSB has added this to make the meaning clear in English.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse.

The rest of the people of Israel heard about this

When the other Israelite clans heard of that

22:12b**the whole congregation of Israel assembled at Shiloh**

- they all gathered together at the town of Shiloh
- they all came together at Shiloh town

the whole congregation of Israel: This phrase refers to the clans of Israel who had received their land on the west side of the Jordan River. It may be clearer in some languages to translate this phrase as “the people of the western clans.”

assembled at Shiloh: Verse 9 stated that the two and a half clans had left the other Israelites at Shiloh to return to their land east of the Jordan River. Now the other clans came together at Shiloh to discuss the report that they heard.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

all the men of the western clans came together
at Shiloh town

All the Israel people on the west side of the river
gathered together at the town of Shiloh

22:12c**to go to war against them.**

- to make war against them.
- and prepared to attack the eastern clans.

to go to war against them: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as to go to war against them is more literally “to go up against them for war.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

to make war against them

to get ready to attack them

Joshua 22:13**Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River**

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the

east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:13a**The Israelites sent Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest**

- ¶ Before they went to war, the people of Israel sent Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest, with a group of people
- ¶ But first, they sent Phinehas, the son of Eleazar the priest, and some people to talk

There is a Hebrew conjunction at the beginning of this verse that the BSB leaves implicit. This conjunction is often translated as “and.” It introduces the next event in the storyline. Translate this in a natural way in your language. It may be clearer to include some implied information. For example:

Before they went to war

The first thing they did was to send a group of people...

The Israelites: The phrase The Israelites refer to the clans of Israel who lived on the west side of the Jordan River.

sent Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest: This is the first time that Phinehas has been mentioned in the book of Joshua. He was mentioned in Numbers 25:7.

sent Phinehas: The people of the western clans sent some of their leaders along with Phinehas to talk to the people of the eastern clans. It may be clearer to state this explicitly, for example:

Then the people of Israel sent Phinehas son of
Eleazar the priest with a group of people to talk

22:13b**to the land of Gilead, to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh.**

- to the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh in the land of Gilead.
- with the clans of Reuben, Gad, and the half-clan of Manasseh in the region of Gilead.

to the land of Gilead: The phrase the land of Gilead refers to a region on the east side of the Jordan River. The eastern clans built their altar on the west side of the river. Then they crossed the river to join their

families on the east side. Phinehas also had to cross the river when he went to talk to them.

General Comment on Joshua 22:13

It may be more natural in some languages to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

First, the people of Israel sent Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest to the land of Gilead, to talk with the clans of Reuben, Gad and the half clan of Manasseh

Joshua 22:14

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:14a

With him they sent ten chiefs—one family leader from each tribe of Israel,

- and ten leading men, one from each of the ten western clans of Israel.
- and ten leaders with him. There was one leader from each of the ten western clans of Israel.

With him they sent ten chiefs—one family leader from each tribe of Israel: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates chiefs can also be translated “leaders” or “leading men.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Ten leaders came with him, one from each of the ten clans of Israel

and ten leaders came with him. There was one leader from each of the ten western clans of Israel

22:14b

each the head of a family among the clans of Israel.

- Each of them was the head of a family within the clans of Israel.

- Every one of them was the leader of his family among the clans of Israel.

each the head of a family among the clans of Israel:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Each one of them was the head of a family within the clans of Israel

Every one of them was the leader of his family among the clans of Israel

Joshua 22:15

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:15a

They went to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ When they reached the people of Reuben, Gad and the half-clan of Manasseh
- ¶ Those people crossed the Jordan River and went to speak with the western clans

They went to the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh in the land of Gilead: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So they went to the land of Gilead to speak to the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh.

When they reached the two and a half clans in the region of Gilead

When they arrived, these leaders said to the people of Gilead, (GW)

22:15b

in the land of Gilead and said to them,

- in the region of Gilead, they said to them,

- in the land of Gilead. They told them,

and said to them: In some languages it may be more natural to reorder parts a and b of this verse. For example:

They went to the region of Gilead and said to the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half of the clan of Manasseh,

Joshua 22:16

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:16a

“This is what the whole congregation of the LORD says:

- “The whole community of Yahweh says to you:
- “This is what the entire assembly of Yahweh says:

This is what the whole congregation of the LORD says: The phrase the whole congregation of the LORD refers to all the Israelite clans who lived on the west side of the Jordan River. They refer to themselves as representing the whole of Israel.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the entire community of Yahweh

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The whole community of Yahweh says to you

This is what the entire assembly of Yahweh says:

22:16b–d

What is this breach of faith you have committed today against the God of Israel by turning away from the LORD and building for yourselves an altar, that you might rebel against the LORD this day?: This is a long rhetorical question. It functions as a

rebuke. The western clans rebuked the eastern clans for building the altar.

The BSB has translated this question as one long sentence. It may be more natural in some languages to translate it as two or more sentences. For example:

Why have you done this evil thing against the God of Israel? You have rebelled against the Lord by building this altar for yourselves! You are no longer following him! (GNT)

22:16b

‘What is this breach of faith you have committed today against the God of Israel

- ‘Why have you^(plur) done this very wicked act against the God of Israel?
- ‘You have acted disloyally against the God of Israel.

What is this breach of faith you have committed today against the God of Israel: This is a rhetorical question that functions as a rebuke. The western clans rebuked the eastern clans for building the altar.

There are two ways to translate this question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

How could you break faith with the God of Israel like this? (NIV)

- As a statement. For example:

You have acted disloyally and sinned against the God of Israel.

You have turned against the God of Israel.

The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as breach of faith comes from the same root as the word that describes the sin of Achan in 7:1. It means to act unfaithfully or disloyally.

22:16c

by turning away from the LORD

- Today you have stopped being faithful to Yahweh.
- You have turned back from following Yahweh today.

by turning away from the LORD: The Hebrew clause is more literally “turn back from after Yahweh.” This is a Hebrew idiom. It indicates that the western clans thought the eastern clans had stopped being faithful to Yahweh. Some languages may have a different idiom to express this meaning.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

you have turned your back on the Lord (CEV)

Today you have stopped being faithful to Yahweh

You have turned back from following Yahweh today

22:16d

and building for yourselves an altar, that you might rebel against the LORD this day?

- Today you have built an altar for yourselves and rebelled against Yahweh.
- You have disobeyed Yahweh's command and built an altar for yourselves.

and building for yourselves an altar, that you might rebel against the LORD this day: The Israelite leaders thought the clans of Reuben, Gad and the half-clan of Manasseh had rebelled against Yahweh, because they had built an altar other than the one that was in the tent of meeting at Shiloh. This violated the command of Yahweh found in Leviticus 17:8–9. They had acted against God's Law and disobeyed him.

this day: The phrase this day means "today."

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Today you have built an altar for yourselves and rebelled against Yahweh.

How could you turn away from the Lord and build yourselves an altar in rebellion against him now? (NIV)

You have acted against Yahweh's command and built an altar for yourselves.

Joshua 22:17

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the

east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:17–18a

Was not the sin of Peor enough for us, from which we have not cleansed ourselves to this day? It even brought a plague upon the congregation of the LORD. And now, would you turn away from the LORD?: This is a long rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- As a rhetorical question. For example:

Was not the sin of Peor enough for us? Up to this very day we have not cleansed ourselves from that sin, even though a plague fell on the community of the Lord! And are you now turning away from the Lord? (NIV)

- As a statement. For example:

The sin we committed at Peor was bad enough. To this very day we have not purified ourselves; it even brought a plague on the community of the Lord. Now today you dare to turn back from following the Lord! (NET)

The BSB translates this rhetorical question as one long sentence. Many English versions translate it as two or three sentences. See the example of the NIV and the NET above. Translate this rhetorical question in the way that makes the meaning most clear in your language.

22:17a

Was not the sin of Peor enough for us,

- Is the sin that the people of Israel committed at Peor a small thing to you?
- We^(incl) Israel people sinned very wickedly at Peor,

Was not the sin of Peor enough for us: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as Was not the sin of Peor enough for us is more literally "Was it (the sin of Peor) too little for us?"

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Is the sin that Israel committed at Peor a small thing to you?

The Israelites sinned at Peor and that was very bad.

the sin of Peor enough for us: The phrase the sin of Peor refers to the time when the people of Israel sacrificed to other gods and worshiped them. This event is recorded in Numbers 25:1–9. The Israel men committed sexual acts with Moab women while they were camped at Shittim. These women invited them to sacrifice to their god, the Baal of Peor. Deuteronomy 4:3 says this happened at Baal Peor.

22:17b
from which we have not cleansed ourselves to this day?

- Even now we^(incl) have not completely purified ourselves from that sin.
- and we still suffer from that sin up to the present day.

from which we have not cleansed ourselves to this day: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

cleansed ourselves: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as cleansed ourselves can also be translated “purified ourselves.” The people of Israel still felt ashamed when they thought of that sin. It may also mean that there were still some Israel people who wanted to worship Baal. Keil and Delitsch, v. 2 p.160. Joshua alludes to this in 24:14–23.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We^(incl) have still not completely purified ourselves from this sin

We still suffer from that sin up to the present day

22:17c
It even brought a plague upon the congregation of the LORD.

- Because of it, there was a plague in the community of Yahweh.
- A deadly disease struck the people of Yahweh because of it.

It even brought a plague upon the congregation of the LORD: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

plague: A plague is a disease that spreads quickly and kills many people. A plague came and killed many

Israel people when they sinned by worshiping the Baal god at Peor.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

there was a plague in the community of Yahweh

a deadly disease struck the people of Yahweh

a terrible disease fell upon the people of Yahweh

In some languages it may be helpful to repeat information to make the connection between the clauses clear. For example:

because of it, there was a plague in the community of Yahweh

a deadly disease struck the people of Yahweh because of it

Joshua 22:18

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:18a

And now, would you turn away from the LORD?

- And you^(plur) also are turning back today from following Yahweh.
- Yet today you are not being faithful to Yahweh.

And now, would you turn away from the LORD?:

This expression was used in verse 22:16. You should translate it the same way as you did in that verse.

The plural pronoun you is emphatic. Some ways to show this emphasis are:

and you^(plur) also are turning back today from following Yahweh

Yet today you too are not being faithful to Yahweh

22:18b**If you rebel today against the LORD,**

- Today you^(plur) are rebelling against Yahweh!
- If you disobey Yahweh's command today,

If you rebel today against the LORD: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as If you rebel today against the LORD is more literally “and it will be, today you, you are rebelling against Yahweh.” The plural pronoun you is repeated to make it emphatic. It contrasts with “the whole congregation” in the next part of the verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Today it is you who are rebelling against Yahweh

If you act against Yahweh's command today,

22:18c**tomorrow He will be angry with the whole congregation of Israel.**

- That will cause him to be angry with the whole community of Israel tomorrow.
- he will be angry with all of us^(incl) tomorrow.

tomorrow He will be angry with the whole congregation of Israel: The leaders of the other Israelite clans remembered what had happened when Achan sinned. Many other people also died because of his sin. This event is recorded in Joshua chapter 7.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

That will cause him to be angry with the whole assembly of Israel tomorrow.

he will be angry with all the people of Israel tomorrow

Joshua 22:19**Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River**

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar,

the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:19a**If indeed the land of your inheritance is unclean,**

- But if your^(plur) land is not pure,
- If your land is not a suitable place for worship,

If indeed the land of your inheritance is unclean:

The people of the western clans implied that the land east of the Jordan was not pure because it was not Yahweh's land. They thought Yahweh lived on their side of the river, where the Tent of Meeting was set up at Shiloh. Butler, p. 247.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But if your land is ritually impure

However, if your land is not a suitable place for worship

22:19b**then cross over to the land of the LORD's possession, where the LORD's tabernacle stands,**

- cross over into the land that belongs to Yahweh, where his holy tent is located.
- bring your families back to Yahweh's land. This is where his dwelling place is.

then cross over to the land of the LORD's possession:

The clause cross over to the land of the LORD's possession indicates that the people from the west side of the Jordan River were inviting the people on the east side to go and live with them.

the land of the LORD's possession: The people of the western clans declared that the land on the west side of the Jordan River belonged to Yahweh because the Tent of Meeting was set up there, at Shiloh.

where the LORD's tabernacle stands: The tabernacle was a tent, and the place where Yahweh lived. In 18:1 this place was referred to as “the Tent of Meeting.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Cross over into the land that belongs to Yahweh, where his tent is.

Come back to Yahweh's land. That is where his dwelling place is.

22:19c**and take possession of it among us.**

- Find a place to live among us^(excl).
- We^(excl) will share some of our land with you.

and take possession of it among us: It may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Take some land for yourselves in our land

We will share some of our land with you.

22:19d**But do not rebel against the LORD**

- But do not rebel against Yahweh
- But don't turn against Yahweh

But do not rebel against the LORD: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But do not rebel against Yahweh.

But don't turn against Yahweh

22:19e**or against us by building for yourselves an altar other than the altar of the LORD our God.**

- and do not rebel against us. Do not build a different altar for yourselves besides the altar of Yahweh our God.
- or against us by building another altar. We already have the altar of Yahweh our God at the tent of meeting.

or against us: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse concerning the clause that the BSB translates "rebel...against us."

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text reads "do not rebel against us." (BSB, NASB, NET, NIV, NRSV, GW, NJPS, NLT, CEV, KJV)
2. Some translators change the vowels of the Hebrew verb so that it means "do not make us rebels." (RSV, ESV, NABRE, REB, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This follows the Hebrew text and is followed by many English versions.

by building for yourselves an altar other than the altar of the LORD our God: The phrase the altar of the

LORD our God refers to the altar that was in the tent of meeting at Shiloh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Do not rebel against us and build another altar for yourselves besides the altar of Yahweh our God that is in Shiloh

or against us by building another altar. We already have the altar of the Lord our God at the Meeting Tent. (ERV)

Joshua 22:20**Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River**

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:20a**Was not Achan son of Zerah unfaithful regarding what was set apart for destruction,**

- Remember how Achan the son of Zerah disobeyed the command about the things that belonged to Yahweh.
- When Achan the son of Zerah rebelled against Yahweh and did not destroy the things that must be destroyed,

Was not Achan son of Zerah unfaithful regarding what was set apart for destruction: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a warning. There are two ways to translate this question:

- As a question. For example:

Achan son of Zerah acted unfaithfully concerning the things that belonged to Yahweh, didn't he?

- As a statement. For example:

Remember how Achan son of Zerah refused to obey the command about things that must be destroyed. (ERV)

Achan son of Zerah: This person was first mentioned in 7:1.

unfaithful: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as unfaithful are the same words that occurred in verse 22:16 that the BSB translated as “breach of faith.” It means to act disloyally or unfaithfully. Achan did not keep the promise he made to Yahweh to obey his commands.

regarding what was set apart for destruction: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as what was set apart was first used in 6:17-18. Yahweh said that these things belonged to him. The Israelites must not keep them. In 7:1 Achan stole some of these things and hid them. He and his family died because of that sin. It is recommended that you translate this Hebrew word in a similar way to how it was translated in 6:17 and 7:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Did not Achan the son of Zerah disobey the command concerning the things that belonged to Yahweh?

Achan the son of Zerah acted disloyally toward Yahweh regarding the things that must be destroyed

22:20b
bringing wrath upon the whole congregation of Israel?

- Yahweh was angry with all the people of Israel because of what he did.
- Yahweh was angry with the entire community of Israel.

bringing wrath upon the whole congregation of Israel: The clause bringing wrath upon the whole congregation of Israel indicates that Yahweh was angry with all the Israelite people.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh was angry with all the people of Israel because of what Achan did

Yahweh became angry with the entire community of Israel

22:20c

Yet it was not only Achan who perished because of his sin!”

- He was not the only person who died because of his sin.”
- Other people also died because he had sinned.”

Yet it was not only Achan who perished because of his sin: The clause not only Achan who perished because of his sin indicates that Achan was not the only person who died because of what he had done. His whole family also died. The Israel people were concerned that they would die because of the sin of the eastern clans.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He was not the only person who died because of his sin.

Other people also died because he had sinned.

Joshua 22:21

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:21a

Then the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh

- ¶ Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and the half-clan of Manasseh
- ¶ Then the people of Reuben, Gad, and the half-clan of Manasseh

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the storyline.

the Reubenites, the Gadites, and the half-tribe of Manasseh: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then the clans of Reuben, Gad, and half the clan of Manasseh

22:21b**answered the leaders of the clans of Israel:**

- answered the leaders of the families of Israel,
- said to the heads of the Israel clans,

answered the leaders of the clans of Israel: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the leaders of the clans of Israel is like the phrase in 22:14. It can also be translated “the heads of the families of Israel.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

answered the leaders of the families of Israel

said to the heads of the Israel clans,

Joshua 22:22**Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River**

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:22a**“The LORD, the Mighty One, is God! The LORD, the Mighty One, is God!”**

- “The powerful one, God, Yahweh. The powerful one, God, Yahweh.
- “Yahweh is the Mighty One. He is God. Yahweh is the Mighty one. He is God.
- “Our God is Yahweh, the mighty God. Our God is Yahweh, the mighty God.

The LORD, the Mighty One, is God! The LORD, the Mighty One, is God:

The clans of Reuben, Gad and Manasseh answered by declaring firmly that they believe that Yahweh is the only true God.

There is an interpretation issue with the three Hebrew words that the BSB translates as The LORD, the Mighty One, is God.

1. The three terms are three separate names for God. (BSB, RSV, ESV, NET, NIV, NASB, NLT, GNT)
2. The second and third terms should be combined as a phrase: “God of Gods.” This is another way of

saying that God is the mightiest God. (NRSV, NABRE, REB, NJB, NJPS, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) along with many English versions and several commentaries. Butler, p. 247–248, Woudstra, p. 327. The people said three different names for God. Then they repeated them to indicate that they were faithful and loyal in following Yahweh.

The LORD: The term that the BSB translates as The LORD is the name Yahweh.

the Mighty One: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as the Mighty One is a Hebrew term for God that is most often used in combinations with other words. In Joshua 3:10 it is used in the phrase “the living God.” It is often used in Genesis with the Hebrew term that means mighty, as in Genesis 17:1.

is God: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as God is the usual Hebrew word for God.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We follow the mighty one, God, Yahweh.

God is the powerful one, he is God, he is Yahweh.

22:22b**He knows, and may Israel also know.**

- God knows why we^(excl) did this, and we want the people of Israel to know also.
- God knows what we have done. Now let the people of Israel know it too.

He knows, and may Israel also know: It may be helpful to add some implicit information:

God knows why we did this, and we want the people of Israel to know also

God knows the reason that we built this altar. Now let the people of Israel also know it.

22:22c**If this was in rebellion or breach of faith against the LORD, do not spare us today.**

- If we^(excl) have rebelled and disobeyed Yahweh, then don’t rescue us today.
- If we have rebelled against Yahweh and acted disloyally towards him, you can kill us today.

If this was in rebellion or breach of faith against the LORD: In some languages it may be more natural to use verbs rather than noun phrases. The Hebrew noun that the BSB translates as breach of faith is the same term that was used in verses 16 and 20. It indicates that the people acted unfaithfully, or disloyally, toward Yahweh. They did not obey him.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

If we have rebelled and disobeyed Yahweh

If we have rebelled against Yahweh and have not been loyal to him

do not spare us today: Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

do not save us today

do not let us live any longer (GNT)

you can kill us today

Joshua 22:23

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:23a

If we have built for ourselves an altar to turn away from Him

- If we^(excl) have built an altar for ourselves to turn against Yahweh,
- If we built the altar in order to disobey Yahweh

If we have built for ourselves an altar to turn away from Him: It may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

If we built an altar to turn away from the Lord (NJPS)

to turn away from Him: This is the same phrase that was used in 22:16. See how you translated it there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

If we have built ourselves an altar so that we could turn against Yahweh

If we built the altar in order to disobey Yahweh

22:23b

and to offer burnt offerings and grain offerings on it, or to sacrifice fellowship offerings on it,

- and offer burnt offerings, grain offerings, and peace offerings on it,
- by offering on it burnt offerings, grain offerings and fellowship offerings,

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as and can also be translated as “or.”

to offer burnt offerings: The phrase burnt offerings was used in 8:31. You should translate this term the same way as in that verse. It refers to animals that were totally burned as an atonement for sins. See Letiticus 1:1–17 for more information about burnt offerings.

and grain offerings: The term grain offerings refers to offerings of wheat. For more information on grain offerings, see Letiticus 2:1–16.

or to sacrifice fellowship offerings on it: The phrase fellowship offerings refers to sacrifices in which part of the animal was burned, and the rest of the animal was eaten by the worshipers. Many English versions refer to these offerings as “peace offerings.” The people who ate the animal had fellowship with Yahweh. See Letiticus 3:1–17 for more information about peace/fellowship offerings.

The Hebrew word translated here as fellowship offerings was used in 8:31. See the note in 8:31a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

or to offer burnt offerings, grain offerings, and peace offerings on it,

And if we built an altar to offer burnt offerings, grain offerings, or fellowship offerings on it,

22:23c

may the LORD Himself hold us accountable.

- may Yahweh himself demand an accounting from us.
- let Yahweh himself punish us.

may the LORD Himself hold us accountable: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as may the LORD Himself hold us accountable is more literally “May Yahweh himself demand.” This is an oath formula. They are asking Yahweh to punish them if they have sinned against him.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

may Yahweh himself demand an accounting from us

let Yahweh himself punish us

Joshua 22:24**Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River**

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:24a

But in fact we have done this for fear that in the future your descendants might say to ours,

- No. We^(excl) did it because we were anxious about what your descendants might say some day to our descendants.
- But this is why we built this altar. We built it because we were concerned about what your descendants might tell ours in the future.

But in fact: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as But in fact can also be translated as “surely” or “truly.” It is used as a strong affirmation in an oath formula. Boling, p. 515, Woudstra, p. 327.

we have done this for fear: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as fear can also be translated as “concern” or “anxiety.”

that in the future: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in the future is more literally “tomorrow.” In this context it refers to some indefinite time in the future.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

some day

in time to come

your descendants might say to ours: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as descendants can also mean children. The people of the eastern clans were concerned about what the descendants of the other clans might tell their own descendants. They were not only concerned about their own sons and daughters but about their grandchildren, and their great-grandchildren.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Truly we did it because we are worried about what your descendants might say to our descendants someday.

Surely, we built this altar because we were concerned about what your descendants would tell our descendants in the future.

22:24b

‘What have you to do with the LORD, the God of Israel?

- They might say, ‘What relationship do you have with Yahweh, the God of Israel?’
- They might say, ‘You have no right to worship Yahweh, the God of Israel.’

What have you to do with the LORD, the God of Israel?: This is a rhetorical question. It functions as a rebuke. It indicates that future generations of the western Israelite clans might think that the eastern clans are not part of the people of Yahweh. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- As a question. For example:

What right do you have to worship the Lord, the God of Israel? (NLT)

- As a statement. For example:

You have no relationship with Yahweh, the God of Israel.

The question What have you to do with the LORD, the God of Israel? is a question that they imagine future generations asking. Future descendants of the western clans might ask this question to the eastern clans.

This is part of an embedded quotation. English shows this kind of quotation with a single quotation mark. Think about how to make this clear in your language. Some languages have grammatical markers or other ways to make clear to whom each group of people is speaking.

Joshua 22:25

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:25a

For the LORD has made the Jordan a border between us and you Reubenites and Gadites.

- Yahweh made the Jordan River to be a border between us^(excl) and you, the people of Reuben and Gad.
- Yahweh put the Jordan River as a boundary between us, the people of Israel, and you, the people of Reuben and Gad.

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For can also be translated as “and.” Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

the LORD has made the Jordan a border between us and you Reubenites and Gadites: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh has put the Jordan River as a boundary between us, the people of Israel, and you, the people of Reuben and Gad.

22:25b

You have no share in the LORD!

- You have no part in the people of Yahweh.’

- You are not really Israel people any more, and you have no right to worship Yahweh.’

You have no share in the LORD: The sentence You have no share in the LORD indicates that the people of Reuben and Gad do not belong to Yahweh. They would have no right to participate in worshiping him.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You have no part in the people of Yahweh.

You have no right to worship Yahweh.

22:25c

So your descendants could cause ours to stop fearing the LORD.

- Then your descendants might make our^(excl) descendants stop worshiping Yahweh.
- If your descendants said that, it might make our descendants stop worshiping Yahweh.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So can also be translated as “and.”

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

In this way (NET)

Then (GNT)

your descendants could cause ours to stop fearing the LORD: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates literally as fearing is sometimes translated as “worship.” To fear Yahweh includes honoring him, worshiping him, and obeying him.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then your descendants might make our descendants stop worshiping Yahweh.

If your descendants said that, they might stop our descendants from obeying Yahweh.

Joshua 22:26

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river

on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:26

That is why we said, ‘Let us take action and build an altar for ourselves, but not for burnt offerings or sacrifices.

- So we^(excl) said to each other, ‘Let’s build an altar. We will not offer burnt offerings or other sacrifices on it.
- That is why we decided to build an altar. It was not to make burnt offerings or other sacrifices.

That is why: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as That is why introduces a conclusion. Because of what might happen, the eastern people took this action. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

we said: The clause we said refers to the discussion that the eastern clans had with each other before they built the altar. It may be helpful to include the implicit information “to each other.”

Let us take action and build an altar for ourselves, but not for burnt offerings or sacrifices: This statement is in the form of a quotation. It may be more natural to rephrase it without a quotation. In that case the clause “we said” would be left untranslated. For example:

So we decided to build this altar, not for burnt offerings and sacrifices (NET)

burnt offerings: This is the same term used in verse 23b.

sacrifices: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sacrifices refers to offerings of animals that were burnt. It is a more general word for sacrifices than the word that is translated as “burnt offerings.”

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

So we said to each other, ‘Let’s build an altar. We will not offer burnt offerings or other sacrifices on it,

That is why we decided to build an altar. It was not for offering burnt offerings or other sacrifices.

Joshua 22:27

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:27a

Rather, let it be a witness between us and you and the generations to come,

- On the contrary, it will remind us^(excl) and you, and all of our descendants in the future
- But instead it will be a sign for you and for us, and for all the generations who are born after us

Rather: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Rather shows a contrast. The altar was not for offerings, rather it was to be a witness. Use a word that is natural to show this contrast in your language.

Here are some other ways to show contrast in English:

On the contrary (NIV)

But instead (GNT)

let it be a witness between us and you: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as witness indicates that the altar was to be a proof or evidence. It was a sign that the eastern clans were still worshiping Yahweh. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the word witness as a verb rather than a noun.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

we built the altar to remind us and you (CEV)

as a sign for our people and yours (GNT)

it will help us all, our descendants and your descendants, to remember (EASY)

and the generations to come: This refers to their descendants who will be born in the future.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

On the contrary, it will remind us and you, and all of our descendants who are born in the future

But instead it will be a sign for you and for us, and for all the generations who are born after us

22:27b **that we will worship the LORD in His presence**

- that we worship in the presence of Yahweh.
- that we worship Yahweh where he dwells at the tent of meeting in Shiloh.

that we will worship the LORD: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as that we will worship the LORD is more literally “to serve the service of Yahweh.” This phrase refers to the outward acts of worshipping Yahweh. Woudstra, p. 328.

in His presence: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as in His presence is more literally “before his face.” Yahweh’s presence was at the tabernacle in Shiloh. In some languages it may be clearer to make this information explicit.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

that we worship Yahweh in his presence

that we worship Yahweh where he is at the tent of meeting in Shiloh

22:27c **with our burnt offerings, sacrifices, and peace offerings.’**

- We will bring our burnt offerings, and sacrifices, and fellowship offerings to him.
- We will give our burnt offerings, sacrifices and peace offerings to Yahweh there.

with our burnt offerings: The term burnt offerings occurred in verse 22:23b. Translate it the same way as you did in that verse.

sacrifices: The same Hebrew word that the BSB translates as sacrifices occurred in verse 22:26. Translate it the same way as you did in that verse.

and peace offerings: The term peace offerings occurred in verse 22:23b where the BSB translated it as “fellowship offerings.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

with our burnt offerings, sacrifices and fellowship offerings

We will give our burnt offerings, and sacrifices, and peace offerings to Yahweh there.

22:27d **Then in the future, your descendants cannot say to ours,**

- Then your^(plur) descendants will not say to our^(excl) descendants some day,
- We did this so that your descendants will not tell our descendants in the future

Then in the future, your descendants cannot say to ours: This part of the verse is like verse 22:24a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then your descendants will not say to our descendants someday,

We did this so that your descendants will not say to our descendants in the future,

22:27e **‘You have no share in the LORD!’**

- ‘You have no part in Yahweh.’
- that we have no right to worship Yahweh.

You have no share in the LORD: This part of the verse is the same as verse 22:25b. Translate this part of the verse the same as you did there. This is a direct quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech. For example:

This was to keep your descendants from saying that ours have nothing to do with the Lord. (GNT)

Joshua 22:28

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being

unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:28a

Therefore we said, ‘If they ever say this to us or to our descendants,

- So we^(excl) thought, If they speak like that to us or to our descendants some day,
- So, if they say that to us or to our descendants in the future,

Therefore we said: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So we said to each other,

So we thought,

If they ever say this to us or to our descendants:

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If they speak like this to us or to our descendants someday

If they say this to us or to our descendants in the future

22:28b

we will answer: Look at the replica of the altar of the LORD that our fathers made,

- then we^(excl) will say, ‘Look at the copy of the altar of Yahweh.
- we will answer them, ‘We have here a model of Yahweh’s altar,

we will answer: Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

then we will say

we will answer them

Look at the replica of the altar of the LORD: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as Look at the replica of the altar of the LORD is more literally “look at the copy of the altar of Yahweh.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then we will say, “Look at the copy of the altar of Yahweh,

We will answer them, “Look. We have here a copy of Yahweh’s altar.

22:28c

not for burnt offerings or sacrifices,

- Our^(excl) ancestors made it, but they did not make it to offer burnt offerings or sacrifices on it.
- which our ancestors made. They did not make it to offer burnt offerings or sacrifices.

that our fathers made, not for burnt offerings or sacrifices: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

that our ancestors made. But it was not for the purpose of offering burnt offerings or sacrifices.

Our ancestors made it, but they did not make it to offer burnt offerings or sacrifices on it.

22:28d

but as a witness between us and you.’

- On the contrary, they made it to remind us^(excl) and you^(plur) that we^(excl) are loyal to Yahweh.’
- Instead, they made it to be a sign that we^(excl) worship Yahweh.’

but as a witness between us and you: This clause is the same in Hebrew as the first part of verse 22:27. You should translate these words as much as possible in the same way as you did the words in that verse.

Joshua 22:29

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:29a

Far be it from us to rebel against the LORD

- May it never happen that we^(excl) rebel against Yahweh
- We most certainly will not disobey Yahweh

Far be it from us to rebel against the LORD: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Far be it from us is an emphatic statement. It is a firm rejection of the idea that follows it. It indicates that the eastern clans will certainly never rebel against Yahweh. They will certainly not disobey him by offering sacrifices on another altar. If there is an idiomatic way to make an emphatic negative statement in your language, you may want to use it here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We will certainly never rebel against Yahweh

May it never happen that we rebel against Yahweh

22:29b and turn away from Him today

- or turn back from Yahweh and disobey him.
- or stop being faithful to Yahweh today.

and turn away from Him today: The clause turn away from Him was used in verses 16c and 18a. Translate it the same way as you did in those verses. For example:

or stop being faithful to Yahweh today

we will not turn back from following Yahweh today

22:29c by building an altar for burnt offerings, grain offerings, or sacrifices,

- May we never build an altar to offer burnt offerings, grain offerings, or other sacrifices,
- We will not build an altar for burnt offerings, grain offering, or other sacrifices.

by building an altar for burnt offerings, grain offerings, or sacrifices: This part of the verse is like verses 23a and 23b. The term burnt offerings and the term grain offerings were used in verse 23b. The term sacrifices was used in verses 26 and 28c.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and build an altar to offer burnt offerings, grain offerings, or other sacrifices on it,

We will not build an altar for burnt offerings, grain offerings, or other sacrifices

22:29d other than the altar of the LORD our God, which stands before His tabernacle.”

- besides the altar of Yahweh our God, which is in front of his holy tent.”
- We will only use the altar of Yahweh our God that is before the tent of meeting in Shiloh.”

other than the altar of the LORD our God: The phrase other than the altar of the LORD our God occurred in verse 19e. See how you translated it there.

which stands before His tabernacle: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as tabernacle refers to the holy tent that was in Shiloh. This word occurred in 22:19b.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

besides the altar of Yahweh our God that is in front of his holy tent in Shiloh

We will only use the altar of Yahweh our God. It is before the tent of meeting in Shiloh.

Joshua 22:30

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:30a When Phinehas the priest and the chiefs of the congregation—the heads of Israel’s clans who were with him—

- ¶ When Phinehas the priest and the leaders of the community of Israel, who were the heads of the Israel clans who were with him

- ¶ Phinehas the priest and the leaders of Israel who were with him

When Phinehas the priest and the chiefs of the congregation—the heads of Israel’s clans who were with him: The group of men who are referred to in this part of the verse are the same group of men as in verse 14.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When Phinehas the priest and the leaders of the community of Israel, the heads of the Israelite families who were with him,

Phinehas the priest and the leaders of Israel who were with him

22:30b

heard what the descendants of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh had to say,

- heard what the people of Reuben, Gad and Manasseh said,
- listened to what the people from the Reuben clan, the Gad clan, and the Manasseh clan said.

heard what the descendants of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh had to say: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

heard what the people of Reuben, Gad and the clan of Manasseh said

listened to what the people from the Reuben clan, the Gad clan and the Manasseh clan said

they were satisfied: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as they were satisfied is more literally “it was good in their eyes.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

they were pleased

they approved of their words

22:30d

they were satisfied.

- they were pleased.
- They approved of their words.

Joshua 22:31

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:31a

Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest said to the descendants of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh,

- Then Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest said to the clans of Reuben, Gad and Manasseh:
- And Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest answered them,

Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest: In verse 30a Phinehas was identified as a priest. In this verse he is identified as son of Eleazar the priest. Phinehas and his father Eleazar were both priests.

said to the descendants of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest said to the clans of Reuben, Gad and Manasseh

Then Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest answered them

22:31b

“Today we know that the LORD is among us,

- “Today we^(incl) know that Yahweh is with us^(incl),
- “Today we know that Yahweh is with all of us people of Israel.

Today we know that the LORD is among us: The pronouns we and us in this verse are inclusive. Phinehas is including all the clans of Israel, on the western and eastern sides of the Jordan River.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Today we^(incl) know that Yahweh is with us^(incl)

Today we^(incl) know that Yahweh lives among us^(incl)

22:31c

because you have not committed this breach of faith against Him.

- because you^(plur) have not acted disloyally against Yahweh.
- We know this because you have not disobeyed Yahweh in this matter.

because you have not committed this breach of faith against Him: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as not committed this breach of faith uses the negative form of the same Hebrew verb phrase as occurred in verse 22:16b. Translate this phrase in a similar way.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because you have not acted disloyally against Yahweh

because you have not disobeyed Yahweh in this matter

22:31d

Consequently, you have delivered the Israelites from the hand of the LORD.”

- Instead, you have saved the people of Israel and Yahweh will not punish us^(incl).”
- You have kept the Israel people from Yahweh’s anger.”

Consequently: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Consequently introduces an emphatic phrase. HOL p. 26.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

So (GNT)

Instead (NLT)

As a result (CSB)

you have delivered the Israelites from the hand of the LORD: The phrase the hand of the LORD is a Hebrew idiom that refers to the power of Yahweh. Yahweh has the power to punish the people of Israel, but he will not do so.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Instead, you have saved the people of Israel and Yahweh will not punish them

So you have kept the Israel people from Yahweh’s anger

Joshua 22:32

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:32a

Then Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest, together with the other leaders,

- Then Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest and the leaders
- So Phinehas and the leaders

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates the next event in the storyline.

Phinehas son of Eleazar the priest, together with the other leaders: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then Phinehas the son of Eleazar the priest and the leaders of Israel

22:32b

returned to the Israelites in the land of Canaan

- left the people of Reuben and Gad in the region of Gilead and returned to the land of Canaan.
- went back to the land of Canaan from the region of Gilead. They left the people of the clans of Reuben and Gad there.

returned to the Israelites in the land of Canaan: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

left the people of Reuben and Gad in the region of Gilead and returned to the land of Canaan

went back to the land of Canaan from the region of Gilead. They left the people of the clans of Reuben and Gad.

22:32c

and brought back a report regarding the Reubenites and Gadites in the land of Gilead.

- When they reached the people of Israel, they told them what the people of Reuben and Gad had said.
- They returned to the people of Israel, and made a report about what had happened.

and brought back a report regarding the Reubenites and Gadites in the land of Gilead: In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

They returned to the people of Israel and told them what had happened.

brought back a report: The clause brought back a report indicates that the leaders gave a report to the assembled people of Israel. They were probably still at Shiloh, but this is not certain.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When they reached the people of Israel, they told them what the people of Reuben and Gad had said.

They made a report to the people of Israel about what had happened.

Joshua 22:33

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:33a

The Israelites were satisfied with the report,

- The people of Israel were satisfied
- The Israelites were happy with what they heard,

The Israelites were satisfied with the report: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as The Israelites were satisfied with the report is more literally “the matter was good in the eyes of the people of Israel.” This same expression was used in verse 22:30d.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Israel were pleased with the report,

The Israelites were glad to hear the report

22:33b

and they blessed God and spoke no more about going to war against them

- and they praised God. They didn’t talk any more about starting a war against the other clans,
- and they thanked God for it. They said nothing more about going to war

and they blessed God: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as blessed God can also be translated “praised God.”

and spoke no more about going to war against them: There was no more discussion about fighting against the clans of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and they praised God. They didn’t talk any more about starting a war against the other clans,

and they thanked God for it. They said nothing more about going to war with them,

22:33c

to destroy the land where the Reubenites and Gadites lived.

- to destroy the land where the people of Reuben and Gad lived.
- so that they could ruin the land where the clans of Reuben and Gad lived.

to destroy the land where the Reubenites and Gadites lived: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

in order to ruin the land where the clans of Reuben and Gad lived

so that they could destroy the land where the people of Reuben and Gad lived

Joshua 22:34

Section 22:9–34 The eastern clans built an altar beside the Jordan River

Before the clans of Reuben, Gad and half the clan of Manasseh returned to their homes on the east side of the Jordan River, they built an altar beside the river on the west side. This made the clans on the west side of the river angry. They thought the clans from the east side were rebelling against Yahweh and being unfaithful to the covenant. When the clans from the east side explained their reason for building the altar, the other Israelites were pleased and stopped being angry.

22:34a

So the Reubenites and Gadites named the altar Witness,

- The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the altar,
- The Reuben clan and the Gad clan gave a name to the altar:

So the Reubenites and Gadites named the altar Witness: There is a textual issue in this part of the verse.

1. The Hebrew Masoretic text reads: “The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the altar.” (NET, NIV, GW, NABRE, NCV, CEV)
2. Some Hebrew manuscripts have an additional word: “The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the altar ‘witness.’” (BSB, RSV, ESV, REB, NLT, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option 1). This is the reading of the Masoretic text. It is recommended by HOTTP, and is followed by many English versions and some commentaries. Woudstra p. 326, 330, Dallaire, p. 1031.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the altar.

The Reuben clan and the Gad clan gave a name to the altar.

22:34b

for they said, “It is a witness between us that the LORD is God.”

- “A sign between us^(incl) that Yahweh is God.”
- They named it, “A reminder for us that Yahweh is God.”

for they said, “It is a witness between us that the LORD is God.”: The translation of this part of the verse depends on the Hebrew text that one follows in the first part of the verse. If one follows the Masoretic text,

“The people of Reuben and the people of Gad named the altar,” then the sentence that follows is the name of the altar. The name was “A witness between us that Yahweh is God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They named it “A sign between us that Yahweh is God.”

This was its name: “It reminds us that Yahweh is God.”

Joshua 23:1

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:1a

A long time after

- ¶ It was a long time
- ¶ Many years went by

A long time after: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as A long time after is more literally “from many days.” There is an interpretation issue with this phrase.

1. It means that a long time passed after Israel was at peace. For example:

A long time passed after the Lord made Israel secure from all their enemies (NET) (NET, REB, NCV, CEV, KJV)

1. It means that a long time passed, and then Israel was at peace. For example:

Much later the Lord gave Israel security from their enemies around them (GNT) (BSB, GNT, RSV, ESV, NASB, NIV, GW, NJPS, NABRE)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and Bible commentaries. Woudstra, p.332, Butler p. 251.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

A long time went by

Many years later

23:1b

the LORD had given Israel rest from all the enemies around them,

- after Yahweh had given peace to the people of Israel,
- after Yahweh had made the Israelites secure from their enemies.

the LORD had given Israel rest from all the enemies around them: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

after Yahweh had given peace to the Israelites

after Yahweh had made the Israelites secure from their enemies

23:1c

when Joshua was old and well along in years,

- and Joshua was an old man.
- Joshua had grown old.

when Joshua was old and well along in years: This Hebrew idiom is more literally “Joshua was old and had come in days.” The same Hebrew idiom was used in 13:1. If you have an idiom in your language for old age you could use it here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua was an old man.

Joshua had grown old

Joshua 23:2

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:2a

he summoned all Israel, including its elders, leaders, judges, and officers.

- Joshua called all the Israelites together. He called the elders, the heads of families, the judges and the officials.
- Then Joshua gathered all the people of Israel together. He gathered their tribal leaders, their family leaders, their judges and their officials.

he summoned all Israel: This can also be translated:

Joshua called all the Israelites together

including its elders, leaders, judges, and officers:

The terms in this list are similar to the list in 8:33. Look to see how you translated these terms there.

elders: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as elders refers to the heads of families who represented their clan on special occasions. Woudstra, p. 139. This Hebrew term occurred in 8:33.

leaders: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as leaders was used in chapter 22, verses 14 and 30. It refers to the heads of families.

judges: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as judges refers to people who judged disputes between Israelites. See Exodus 18:17–26 where Moses first appointed judges. This term was used in 8:33.

officers: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as officers refers to people who had both military and administrative responsibilities. Woudstra, p. 64 footnote 1. This term occurred in 1:10 and in 8:33.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua called all the Israelites together. He called the elders, the heads of families, the judges and the officers.

So Joshua gathered all the Israelite people together: their tribal leaders, their family leaders, their judges and their officials.

23:2b

“I am old and well along in years,” he said,

- He said to them, “I am now very old.
- He told them, “I am an old man.

“I am old and well along in years,” he said: The sentence that the BSB translates as “I am now old and well advanced in years,” uses almost the same Hebrew words as in verse 23:1c.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and said to them, “I am an old man now

Then Joshua told them, “I am very old

Joshua 23:3

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:3a

“and you have seen everything that the LORD your God has done to all these nations for your sake,

- You^(plur) have seen for yourselves everything that Yahweh your God has done to help you against all these nations.
- You yourselves have seen all that Yahweh our God has done for us. He helped us defeat all these enemy people.

and you have seen: The people of Israel had seen with their own eyes how God had defeated their enemies. The pronoun you is emphatic in Hebrew.

everything that the LORD your God has done to all these nations: This phrase indicates that Yahweh had defeated all the nations.

for your sake: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as for your sake is more literally, “from in front of you.” It means that Yahweh did everything in order to help the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

on your behalf

to help you

It may be clearer to change the pronoun reference to include Joshua:

on our behalf

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You have seen for yourselves everything that Yahweh your God has done to all these nations on your/our behalf.

You yourselves have seen how Yahweh your God has done for us. He has defeated the enemy nations.

23:3b

because it was the LORD your God who fought for you.

- Yahweh your God was the one fighting for you.
- Yahweh our God fought for us.

because it was the LORD your God who fought for you: This clause is similar to the statement in 10:14. It indicates that the Israelites were only able to defeat their enemies because of what Yahweh did for them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh your God was the one fighting on your behalf

Yahweh your God enabled you to defeat your enemies

Joshua 23:4

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:4a

See, I have allotted as an inheritance to your tribes these remaining nations,

- Look, I have divided out to each clan the lands of the nations which you^(plur) still have not conquered. You will have them to be yours.
- Remember, I, Joshua, have assigned to each clan your own land as your inheritance. Many of those lands have not been defeated yet.

See: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as See calls attention to what is coming next. Some languages may have grammatical particles or markers that fulfill this function. Some English versions do not translate this word.

Here are some other ways to translate it in English:

Look

Remember

I have allotted as an inheritance to your tribes these remaining nations: The person who is speaking is Joshua. In chapters 14–21 he named the lands that each clan should inherit. This included many lands that they had not yet conquered.

your: The pronoun your is plural in Hebrew.

these remaining nations: The phrase these remaining nations refers to the lands of the people that Israel has not yet conquered.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Look, I have given the clans of Israel the lands of the nations that still have not been conquered yet. They will be your inheritance.

Remember, I, Joshua, have also divided out to each clan your own land as your inheritance. Many of those lands have not been defeated yet.

23:4b

including all the nations I have already cut off,

- You will have them as well as the lands of all the nations that I have already conquered.
- I have also assigned to you the lands of all those peoples that we have already defeated.

including: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as including is more literally “and.”

all the nations I have already cut off: The phrase nations I have already cut off refers to the nations that were already controlled by Israel. Joshua says “I have cut them off” because he was the leader of the Israelites when they defeated these nations.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

as well as the lands of all the nations that I have already defeated

and I have given you the lands of all those peoples that we already conquered

23:4c

from the Jordan westward to the Great Sea.

- Those lands go from the Jordan River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.
- Those lands reach from the Jordan River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

from the Jordan westward to the Great Sea: The lands that Yahweh gave to Israel reached from the Jordan River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

Great Sea: The Great Sea is another name for the Mediterranean Sea.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Those lands stretch from the Jordan River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

General Comment on 23:4

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

I, Joshua, have divided up all the land from the Jordan River in the east to the Mediterranean Sea in the west and given it to your clans as an inheritance. This includes the lands I defeated, and those lands that we have not yet defeated.

Joshua 23:5

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:5a

The LORD your God will push them out of your way

- Yahweh your^(plur) God will drive them out in front of you.
- Yahweh our^(incl) God, he will chase these people out ahead of us.

The LORD your God will push them out of your way:

The Hebrew text has an emphatic pronoun “he” after the phrase the LORD your God.

Here are some other ways to indicate this emphasis:

Yahweh your God himself will push...

Yahweh your God, he will push...

push them out: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as push them out can also be translated “force them to leave” or “drive them out.”

of your way: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as of your way is more literally “from your face.” It can also be translated “in front of you” or “ahead of you.” This indicates that Yahweh will cause the other nations to retreat as the Israelites move into their territory.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh your God himself will force them to leave in front of you

Yahweh your God, he will chase them out ahead of you

23:5b

and drive them out before you, so that you can take possession of their land,

- He will drive them away in front of you, and you will own their land,
- He will take the land away from them and we will live in it.

and drive them out before you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as drive them out can also be translated “dispossess.” This means that Yahweh will take the land away from the other nations and give it to the Israelites.

before you: The Hebrew prepositional phrase that the BSB translates as before you is more literally “from your face.” It is like the phrase that was used in verse 23:5a.

so that you can take possession of their land:

Yahweh promised to take away the land from the other nations so that it could belong to the Israelites instead.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He will drive them away in front of you, and you will own their land.

He will take the land away from them and you will live in it.

23:5c

as the LORD your God promised you.

- just as Yahweh your God said to you.
- Yahweh our^(incl) God promised us that he would do this.

as the LORD your God promised you: In some languages it may be clearer to translate the phrase your God as “our^(incl) God” to show that Yahweh was Joshua's God also.

promised: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as promised is more literally “spoke” or “said.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

as Yahweh your God said to you

as Yahweh our^(incl) God promised you he would do

Joshua 23:6

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:6a

Be very strong, then, so that you can keep and obey

- ¶ So be very determined to keep and obey
- ¶ Be very firm and careful to obey

Be very strong, then: The conjunction that the BSB translates as then is the Hebrew conjunction which connects sentences. It is translated in different ways depending upon the context. Translate this connecting word in a way that is natural in your language.

Be very strong: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as strong could also be translated as “steadfast” or “brave” or “determined.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So be very determined to keep and obey

Be very firm and careful to do

23:6b

all that is written in the Book of the Law of Moses,

- everything that you^(plur) read in the book of the law of Moses.
- every command that Moses wrote in the book of the law.

all that is written in the Book of the Law of Moses:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

everything that Moses wrote in the book of the law

every command that is in the law book that Moses wrote

23:6c

not turning aside from it to the right or to the left.

- You must obey it completely.
- Do not turn away from any part of that law.

not turning aside from it to the right or to the left:

The Hebrew idiom not turning aside from it to the right or to the left means that a person must obey God completely. He must not disobey any part of God’s law. The Hebrew construction is a negative word followed by an infinitive verb form. It functions as a command. See Williams, p. 69.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

you must obey all of it completely

Do not turn away from any part of that law.

Joshua 23:7

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:7a

So you are not to associate with these nations that remain among you.

- Do not have anything to do with the nations who still live among you.
- Do not make friends with the other peoples who still remain around you.

So you are not to associate with these nations that remain among you: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as not to associate with is more literally “not enter into.” This indicates that the Israelites should not have anything to do with the non-Israelites who still lived in the lands they had conquered.

these nations that remain among you: This indicates that there were non-Israelite people who still lived in the land of Canaan because the Israelites had not yet conquered them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Do not have anything to do with the nations who still live among you.

Do not make friends with the other peoples who still remain around you.

23:7b

You must not call on the names of their gods or swear by them, and you must not serve them or bow down to them.

- Do not call on the names of their gods or take oaths in their name. Do not serve them or bow down to them.
- You must not speak the names of their gods in prayer. You must not make promises in their names. You must not worship them or bow down in front of them.

You must not call on the names of their gods or swear by them, and you must not serve them or bow down to them: The four verbs that are used in this part of the verse all refer to different acts of worship. Woudstra, p. 335.

You must not call on the names of their gods: This clause indicates that the Israelites should not speak the names of foreign gods. They should not call on them to pray to them.

or swear by them: The phrase swear by them indicates that the Israelites should not take an oath or a vow using the name of a foreign god.

you must not serve them: The phrase serve them indicates that the Israelites should not worship foreign gods.

or bow down to them: The phrase bow down to them indicates that the Israelites should not bow down to foreign gods as part of their worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Do not call on the names of their gods or take oaths in their names. Do not serve them or bow down to them.

You must not speak the names of their gods in prayer. You must not make promises in their names. You must not worship them or bow down in front of them.

Joshua 23:8

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:8

Instead, you shall hold fast to the LORD your God, as you have done to this day.

- But rather, be loyal to Yahweh your God, just as you^(plur) have done to the present day.
- Instead, you must be faithful to Yahweh our God, as you have been doing until now.

Instead: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead indicates a strong contrast. They should not worship other gods, but they should be loyal to Yahweh.

you shall hold fast to the LORD your God: The verb that the BSB translates as hold fast can also be translated as “cling to” or “hold tightly to.” This is a metaphor which indicates that the Israelites must remain completely loyal to Yahweh.

as you have done to this day: The clause as you have done to this day indicates that the Israelites had been loyal to Yahweh up to that time.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

But rather, you must be loyal to Yahweh your God, as you have done to the present day.

Instead, be faithful to Yahweh our God, as you have been doing up till now.

Joshua 23:9

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:9a

The LORD has driven out great and powerful nations before you,

- ¶ Yahweh has made great and powerful nations leave as you moved ahead.
- ¶ Yahweh has taken away the land from large, strong peoples in front of you.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “For” is the conjunction that joins sentences and can be translated as “and.” Many English versions do not translate this conjunction. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

The LORD has driven out great and powerful nations before you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as driven out was used in verse 23:5b. See how you translated it there.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yahweh has made great and powerful nations leave as you conquered the land.

Yahweh has taken away the land from large, strong peoples in front of you.

23:9b

and to this day no one can stand against you.

- As for you, no one has defeated you up to this present day.
- But you, none of your enemies has won against you up until this time.

and: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB as and is literally “and you.” The plural pronoun “you” is emphatic. Some English translations add the words “as for” as a way to show emphasis in English. Other English versions, such as the BSB, do not make this emphasis explicit. Show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

no one can stand against you: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as no one can stand against you is more literally “no man has stood before you until this day.” It indicates that none of their enemies had been able to defeat them. The Israelites had defeated all of them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

As for you, no one has defeated you up to this present day.

But you, none of your enemies has won against you yet.

Joshua 23:10

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:10a

One of you can put a thousand to flight,

- One of you^(plur) is able to chase away one thousand of the enemy.
- One of your soldiers makes a thousand enemy soldiers run away.

One of you can put a thousand to flight: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as One of you can put a thousand to flight is more literally “One man of you chases a thousand.” This indicates that one Israelite soldier can make a thousand enemy soldiers run away.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

One of you is able to chase away one thousand of the enemy.

One of you will make a thousand of them run away

23:10b

because the LORD your God fights for you, just as He promised.

- Yahweh your God is the one fighting on your behalf, just as he said to you.
- Yahweh your God enables you to defeat them. He promised you that he would do this.

because: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as because can also be translated “since.” It introduces the reason why one Israelite soldier was able to make one thousand enemy soldiers run away.

the LORD your God fights for you: This clause uses the same words as verse 23:3b. The BSB translated the Hebrew participle “the one who fights” in the past tense in that verse (23:3) because the context referred to what had already happened. It is translated in the present tense here because it refers to the pattern of how God operates. Use the tense or aspect that is natural in your language.

just as He promised: This clause uses similar words as verse 23:5c.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because Yahweh your God is the one fighting on your behalf, as he told you he would do

because Yahweh your God helps you to defeat your enemies. He promised that he would do this for you

Joshua 23:11

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:11

Therefore watch yourselves carefully, that you love the LORD your God.

- So be very careful to love Yahweh your God.
- Be sure that you do not stop loving Yahweh our God.

Therefore: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Therefore is the Hebrew conjunction that occurs at the beginning of clauses to connect them.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So

Some English versions leave this conjunction untranslated. Use the connecting word that is natural in your language.

watch yourselves carefully: The Hebrew verb phrase that the BSB translates as watch yourselves carefully can also be translated “Be on your guard,” or “Be attentive.”

that you love the LORD your God: In some languages it may be more natural to translate “Yahweh our God” because Yahweh is also the God of Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

So be careful to love Yahweh your God

Be sure to love Yahweh our God.

Joshua 23:12

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:12a

For if you turn away and cling to the rest of these nations that remain among you,

- If you^(plur) ever stop following him, and become friends with the nations that are left here among you, they will cause trouble for you.
- Do not be unfaithful to him. Do not have anything to do with the peoples who are still left among you in the land.

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as For can also be translated as “because” or “but.” Use a connecting word that fits this context in your language.

if: The word if introduces a condition that is explained in verse 12. The result is explained in verse 13. If the Israelites associate with the other nations around them, then God will not drive those nations out.

you turn away: The Hebrew verb construction that the BSB translates as turn away indicates emphasis. Some English versions represent this emphasis. For example:

But if you ever turn away (NET)

If indeed you do go back (NKJV)

turn away: The expression turn away is an idiom that means to be disloyal or unfaithful.

Here are some other ways to translate this:

For if you ever turn away from following him

Because if you are at all disloyal to him

Do not be unfaithful to him in any way

and cling to the rest of these nations that remain among you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates literally as cling to is the same verb that the BSB translated as “hold fast to” in verse 23:8. It indicates that the Israelites should not have anything to do with the nations that still live in the land in which the Israelites settled. Instead, they should be faithful to Yahweh.

the rest of these nations that remain among you: This phrase is like the phrase in verse 23:7, but one more word is added at the beginning. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as rest can also be translated “what is left” or “what remains.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Because if you ever stop following Yahweh, and become friends with the nations who are left here among you,

Do not be unfaithful to Yahweh in any way. Do not have anything to do with the peoples who are still left among you in the land,

23:12b

and if you intermarry and associate with them,

- If you marry with them and you associate with them,
- Do not marry with them. Do not make friends with them.

if you intermarry: The Israelite people were not to marry the people of other nations.

and associate with them: There is an interpretation issue in this part of the verse. The Hebrew words are more literally “you go in them and they in you.”

1. The clause “you go in them and they in you” indicates association or friendship of people with each other. For example:

and you associate with them (NIV) (BSB, NIV, ESV, NABRE, NET, GW, REB, NJPS, CEV, NASB)

1. The clause “you go in them and they in you” indicates sexual intercourse and is another way to refer to marriage. For example:

and intermarry with them (GNT) (GNT, RSV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is supported by many English versions and Bible commentaries. Boling and Wright, p. 525, Woudstra, p. 337, footnote 6.

Here are some ways to translate verses 12b–c:

and if you marry with them and you associate with them

Do not marry with them. Do not make friends with them.

Joshua 23:13

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua

was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:13a

know for sure that the LORD your God will no longer drive out these nations before you.

- then know for certain that Yahweh your God will stop making these nations leave ahead of you.
- If you make friends with them, you can be sure that Yahweh your God will no longer take away the land from those peoples as you go forward.

know for sure that the LORD your God will no longer drive out these nations before you: Verse 12 started with the word “if” to indicate a condition. Verse 13 shows the result that will follow if the Israelites associate with the other nations around them. The Hebrew does not use the word “then” in verse 13. In some languages it may help to say “then” to make it clear that this is a result.

know for sure: The Hebrew verb structure that the BSB translates as know for sure indicates emphasis. Look for a way to mark this emphasis if it is possible in your language.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

know assuredly (RSV)

then you can be sure

the LORD your God will no longer drive out these nations before you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as drive out was used in verse 23:5b and 23:9a.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then know for certain that Yahweh your God will stop making these nations leave ahead of you

If you do those things, then Yahweh your God will definitely no longer take away the land from these peoples as you go forward.

23:13b

Instead, they will become for you a snare and a trap, a scourge in your sides and thorns in your eyes,

- Instead, they will be a net and a trap to catch you. They will be a whip on your sides and thorns in your eyes.
- Instead, they will be like traps that catch you. They will be like a whip that beats your sides and like thorns that stick into your eyes.

Instead: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead indicates a contrast. In some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here.

they will become for you a snare and a trap, a scourge in your sides and thorns in your eyes: This is a series of metaphors that describe how dangerous the enemy nations will become to the Israelites.

a snare and a trap: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as snare refers to a net for catching birds. The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as trap may refer to a wooden trap to catch birds, or it may refer to the bait inside the net which would lure the bird in. If you do not have two different words for bird traps you could say simply “a bird trap.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

a net and a trap

a bird trap

a trap

a scourge: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as scourge can also be translated “whip.”

thorns in your eyes: The phrase thorns in your eyes indicates that the enemy nations would damage the Israelites just as thorns damage the eyes.

In some languages it may be more natural to translate these metaphors as similes.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Rather, they will be a net or a trap for you, a whip on your side and thorns in your eyes.

Instead, they will be like traps that catch you like a bird, like a whip that stings your sides and like thorns that stick in your eyes.

they will be as dangerous for you as a trap. They will hurt you as much as a whip on your sides or thorns that stick into your eyes.

23:13c

until you perish from this good land that the LORD your God has given you.

- They will torment you until you have all died. Then you will be gone from the good land that Yahweh your God has given you.
- Then none of you will be left in this good land which Yahweh your God has given you.

until you perish from this good land that the LORD your God has given you: This indicates that the enemy nations would inflict all those injuries on the Israelites until all of them had died.

perish: The English word perish is an older word that means “die.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until you have all died and no longer live in the good land that Yahweh your God has given you

In the end, none of you will be left in this good land that Yahweh your God has given you.

General Comment on 23:12–13

Verses 12 and 13 are a condition and a result.

¹² If the Israelites associate with the other nations around them, ¹³ then God will not drive those nations out.

This could also be expressed as a command with a warning.

¹² Do not associate with the other nations around you, ¹³ otherwise God will not drive those nations out.

Joshua 23:14

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua's farewell speech to the Israelites

23:14a

Now behold, today I am going the way of all the earth,

- ¶ Look, I will soon die, just like everyone does.
- ¶ Pay attention. I will not live much longer.

Now: The connector that the BSB translates as Now is the Hebrew conjunction that joins sentences. Many English versions do not translate this connecting word. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

behold: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as behold calls attention to the next statement. Some languages may have grammatical markers that fulfill this function.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Look

Pay attention (GW)

I am going the way of all the earth: This is a Hebrew idiom which means that Joshua will soon die.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

I will soon die, like everyone else does

I will not live much longer

23:14b

and you know with all your heart and soul

- You^(plur) know in your hearts
- Each one of you truly knows this:

and you know with all your heart and soul: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as you know is plural. It refers to all the Israelites.

your heart and soul: The phrase your heart and soul is a Hebrew idiom that refers to the entire being of a person. In this context it emphasizes the completeness of their knowledge.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You^(plur) know in your hearts and in your souls

You^(plur) know with all your being

Each one of you truly knows this:

23:14c

that not one of the good promises the LORD your God made to you has failed.

- that none of the good words that Yahweh your God promised you has failed to happen.
- not one of the promises that Yahweh your God gave to you has failed to come true.

that not one of the good promises the LORD your God made to you has failed: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as not one of the good promises the LORD your God made to you has failed is more literally “not one thing has fallen.” In some languages it may be more natural to express this in a positive statement. For example, “Everything has happened.”

not one of the good promises the LORD your God made to you: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

none of the good words that Yahweh your God has spoken concerning you has failed to happen

Every one of the promises that Yahweh your God gave to you has happened

23:14d

Everything was fulfilled for you; not one promise has failed.

- All his words have been fulfilled. None have failed to happen.
- Every single one of the promises that he gave to you has come true.

Everything was fulfilled for you: This means that every word or promise that Yahweh has spoken to them has happened.

not one promise has failed: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as not one promise has failed is more literally “not one word has fallen from them.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

All his promises have been fulfilled. None have failed to happen.

Every single one of the words he spoke to you has come true.

General Comment on 23:14c–d

The negative and positive statements in 14c and 14d mean the same thing. The repetition functions to emphasize that nothing that Yahweh has promised has failed to happen. Every promise he made has come true. Use a natural way in your language to indicate this emphasis.

Joshua 23:15

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:15a

But just as every good thing the LORD your God promised you has come to pass,

- But, just as all the good things that he promised you^(plur) have happened,
- All the good promises that Yahweh your God spoke to you have come true. But if you do not obey him

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. God has blessed them, but if they disobey him, he will curse them. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

just as: The Hebrew prepositional phrase that the BSB translates as just as introduces a comparison. It connects with the word “likewise” in 15b.

- ^{15a} Just as God has given good things to them,
^{15b} likewise he will give evil things to them if they break their covenant with him.

every good thing the LORD your God promised you: This clause uses almost the same Hebrew words as the clause in 23:14c.

has come to pass: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as has come to pass is more literally “have come upon you.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But, in the same way that all the promises Yahweh your God made to you have happened...

All the good promises that Yahweh your God spoke to you have come true. In the same way...

23:15b
likewise the LORD will bring upon you the calamity He has threatened,

- so he will cause every evil thing to happen to you.
- he will make every judgment that he warned you about come true as well.

likewise: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as likewise introduces the second part of the comparison.

the LORD will bring upon you the calamity He has threatened: Here are some other ways to translate the word calamity:

judgments (NET)

threat (GNT)

warnings (NASB)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

so also Yahweh will cause every evil thing to happen

in the same way, he will make all the judgments which he spoke come true

23:15c
until He has destroyed you from this good land He has given you.

- He will destroy you, and you will no longer live in this good land that he has given to you.
- That will happen until he has destroyed you and none of you is left in this good land which he had given you.

until He has destroyed you from this good land He has given you: This part of the verse is like verse 23:13c. In that verse the Hebrew verb that means “die” is used. In this verse the Hebrew verb that means “destroy” is used. Some English versions such as GNT do not translate this clause because the information was already stated in that verse.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until he has destroyed you. Then you will no longer live in this good land that Yahweh your God has given to you.

That will happen until he has destroyed you and none of you is left in this good land that he has given you.

Joshua 23:16

Section 23:1–16: Joshua warned the Israelites to continue to obey Yahweh

Joshua gave this farewell speech to the Israelites when he was near the end of his life. This section connects back to Joshua 13:1 which says that Joshua was very old, and to Joshua 21:44 which says that God had given the Israelites rest. Butler, p. 254. The text does not say where Joshua gave this farewell speech, but it may have taken place at Shiloh. Woudstra, p. 332.

Here is another possible section heading:

Joshua’s farewell speech to the Israelites

23:16a
If you transgress the covenant of the LORD your God, which He commanded you,

- If you^(plur) do not obey the covenant of Yahweh your God that he commanded you to follow,

- Yahweh your God commanded you to obey the laws of the agreement he made with you. If you do not obey them,

Some English versions continue the sentence from verse 23:15a. It is a very long sentence. You may find that it is more natural to begin a new sentence here like the BSB.

If you transgress the covenant of the LORD your God: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as transgress the covenant indicates that someone has not obeyed the covenant. The term covenant was first mentioned in the book of Joshua in 3:3. Look to see how you translated this term in that verse.

which He commanded you: Yahweh had commanded the Israelites to obey the covenant that he had made with them. It may be more natural to include implicit information:

which he commanded you to obey

In some languages it may be more natural to have two sentences. For example,

Yahweh your God commanded you to obey his covenant. If you disobey it,

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This will happen if you do not obey the covenant of Yahweh your God, which he commanded you to follow,

Yahweh your God commanded you to obey the laws of the agreement he made with you. If you do not,

23:16b

and go and serve other gods and bow down to them,

- but you serve and bow down to worship other gods,
- but you honor and worship other gods,

and go and serve other gods: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as serve indicates that the Israelites might worship other gods and honor them.

and bow down to them: This indicates that someone is bowing down in worship.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and you serve and bow down in worship to other gods,

and you honor and worship other gods,

23:16c

then the anger of the LORD will burn against you,

- then Yahweh will become angry with you.
- he will be angry with you.

then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as then is the Hebrew conjunction that connects sentences. In this context it indicates the result. This is what will happen if the Israelites follow other gods instead of Yahweh. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language to indicate a result.

the anger of the LORD will burn against you: This is more literally “the anger of Yahweh will burn in you.” It is a Hebrew idiom which indicates that Yahweh will be angry with the Israelites.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

then Yahweh will be angry with you

23:16d

and you will quickly perish from this good land He has given you.”

- You will all die quickly and will no longer live in the good land that he has given you.”
- Then none of you will be left in this good land that he has given you. Very soon you will all be dead.”

and you will quickly perish from this good land He has given you: This is the same phrase as verse 23:13c, except that the word quickly is added. It may be helpful to add implicit information here. The Israelites would die quickly because Yahweh would punish them. For example:

then in his anger he will punish you, and soon none of you will be left in this good land that he has given you (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

until you have all quickly died and you no longer live in the good land that Yahweh your God has given you

Then none of you will be left in this good land that Yahweh your God has given you. You will all soon be dead.

General Comment on 23:16

Although some English versions begin a sentence at verse 16c, the BSB and many English versions start the sentence at the beginning of verse 16. For example:

If you violate the covenant of the Lord your God, which he commanded you, and go and serve other gods and bow down to them, the Lord's anger will burn against you, and you will quickly perish from the good land he has given you. (NIV)

Joshua 24:1

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:1a

Then Joshua assembled all the tribes of Israel at Shechem.

- ¶ Sometime later Joshua called all the clans of Israel to come together at Shechem town.
- ¶ After that, Joshua sent for all the clans of Israel to gather at Shechem town.

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. It is not certain how much time had passed between chapter 23 and chapter 24. It is recommended that you use an indefinite marker of time. Some English versions do not use a time marker here.

Here are some other ways to introduce this paragraph:

Afterwards

Sometime later

Joshua assembled all the tribes of Israel at Shechem: The clause Joshua assembled all the tribes of Israel indicates that Joshua sent a message to all the people of Israel asking them to come and meet together.

the tribes of Israel: The tribes of Israel refers to all the people who were descended from the twelve sons of Jacob. They all shared a common culture and language. Choose a translation of the word “tribe” that reflects this kind of relationship.

Shechem: The town of Shechem was mentioned in 17:7.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Later Joshua called all the clans of Israel to come together at Shechem town

Afterwards, Joshua sent for all the clans of Israel to gather at Shechem town.

24:1b

He summoned the elders, leaders, judges, and officers of Israel,

- He called the leaders, the heads of families, the judges, and the officers.
- He sent for their clan leaders, their family leaders, their judges, and their officials.

The Hebrew begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “and.” However, in some languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here like the BSB.

He summoned the elders, leaders, judges, and officers of Israel: This list of terms is like the list in 23:2a. Translate these terms the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He called the elders, the heads of families, the judges, and the officers to come together.

He sent for their clan leaders, and their family leaders, and their judges, and their officials.

24:1c

and they presented themselves before God.

- They came and stood before God.
- They came and stood in the presence of God.

and they presented themselves before God: The clause they presented themselves before God indicates that the leaders came and stood in the presence of God. This may mean that they stood before the covenant chest of God, but that is not certain. Woudstra, p. 342.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They came and stood before God.

They came and stood in the presence of God.

Joshua 24:2

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:2a

And Joshua said to all the people,

- Then Joshua told all the people,
- Then Joshua said to everyone,

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

Joshua said to all the people: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua told all the people

Then Joshua said to everyone

24:2b

“This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says:

- “This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel, says.
- “Yahweh, the God of all the Israelites, says this:

This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: This part of the verse indicates that what Joshua was going to tell them was a message that had God’s authority.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This is what Yahweh, the God of Israel says:

Yahweh, the God of Israel, says this:

24:2c

‘Long ago your fathers, including Terah the father of Abraham and Nahor, lived beyond the Euphrates and worshiped other gods.

- ‘Long ago your^(plur) ancestors lived on the east side of the Euphrates River. This included Terah, the father of Abraham and Nahor. They worshiped other gods.
- ‘A long time ago your ancestors lived way over there on the other side of the Euphrates River. This included Terah, who was the father of Abraham and Nahor. They worshiped gods other than Yahweh.

your fathers: The phrase your fathers refers to the ancestors of the Israelite people.

Terah the father of Abraham and Nahor: Terah was an important ancestor of the Israelite people. He was the father of Abraham, whom God called to leave his country and form a new nation.

lived beyond the Euphrates: The word lived indicates that these people lived a long time ago.

beyond the Euphrates: Their ancestors lived on the east side of the Euphrates River. Joshua and the people were now far away from the Euphrates River on its west side.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Long ago your ancestors lived on the east side of the Euphrates River.

A long time ago your ancestors lived way over there on the other side of the Euphrates River.

and worshiped other gods: The clause and worshiped other gods indicates that Terah as well as other ancestors of the Israelites did not worship Yahweh. They worshiped other, different, gods.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

This included Terah, who was the father of Abraham and Nahor. They worshiped other gods.

including Terah who was the father of Abraham and Nahor. They worshiped foreign gods.

General Comment on 24:2

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

Then Joshua told everyone to listen to this message from the Lord, the God of Israel: Long ago your ancestors lived on the other side of the Euphrates River, and they worshiped other gods. This continued until the time of your ancestor Terah and his two sons, Abraham and Nahor. (CEV)

Joshua 24:3

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:3a

But I took your father Abraham from beyond the Euphrates

- ¶ Then I brought Abraham, your^(plur) ancestor, from beyond the Euphrates River.
- ¶ But I led your ancestor Abraham away from that land,

But: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as But introduces the next event in the storyline. Translate this word with a natural connector in your language.

I took your father Abraham from beyond the Euphrates: Yahweh led Abraham away from his former country, which was on the east side of the Euphrates River. This place was mentioned in verse 2.

I: God is speaking here. The person who said I is God, not Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then I brought Abraham your ancestor from the east side of the Euphrates River

But I led your ancestor Abraham away from that land

24:3b

and led him through all the land of Canaan, and I multiplied his descendants.

- I led him through the entire land of Canaan and multiplied his descendants.
- and brought him into all the land of Canaan and gave him many descendants.

and led him through all the land of Canaan: It may be more natural in many languages to begin a new sentence here.

and I multiplied his descendants: The clause I multiplied his descendants indicates that Yahweh enabled Abraham to have many descendants.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I led him through the entire land of Canaan and multiplied his descendants

I brought him into all the land of Canaan and gave him many children and grandchildren

24:3c

I gave him Isaac,

- I gave him his son Isaac.
- I gave to Abraham his son Isaac,

I gave him Isaac: The clause I gave him Isaac indicates that Yahweh was the one who enabled Abraham to become the father of Isaac.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

I gave Abraham his son Isaac

Joshua 24:4

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:4a

and to Isaac I gave Jacob and Esau.

- To Isaac I gave two sons: Jacob and Esau.
- and I gave to Isaac his sons Jacob and Esau.

and to Isaac I gave Jacob and Esau: The BSB has placed the indirect object, Isaac, first in the sentence in order to emphasize it. The Hebrew text has normal Hebrew word order: “I gave to Isaac Jacob and Esau.” Translate this sentence using the word order that is natural in your language.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

I gave Isaac two sons: Jacob and Esau.

24:4b

I gave Esau Mount Seir to possess,

- I gave his son Esau the mountain country of Seir to live in.
- I gave Esau the hilly region of Edom for his own,

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but other English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline.

I gave Esau Mount Seir to possess: The Mount Seir refers to the land that Esau and his descendants lived in. It was south of the Dead Sea. This land is often called “Edom,” and you may wish to translate it that way. See how you translated the term Seir in Joshua 11:17.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I gave his son Esau the mountain country of Seir to live in

I gave Esau the hilly country of Edom to be his own land

24:4c

but Jacob and his sons went down to Egypt.

- But Jacob and his children went to live in Egypt.
- but Jacob and his family went to the land of Egypt.

but Jacob and his sons went down to Egypt: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as went down indicates descending to a lower elevation. If the gram-

mar of your language does not keep track of elevation, it may be more natural to translate it as “went.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

but Jacob and his children went downhill to live in Egypt

But Jacob and his family went to the land of Egypt

Joshua 24:5

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:5a

Then I sent Moses and Aaron,

- Later I sent Moses and Aaron to help the Israelites.
- Many years after that I sent Moses and his brother Aaron to Egypt.

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

I sent Moses and Aaron: Many years passed between the time that Jacob and his family went to Egypt, and the time that Yahweh sent Moses and Aaron to meet the king of Egypt. It may be helpful to add this implicit information at the beginning of the verse. For example,

Later I sent Moses and Aaron (GNT)

Many years after that, I sent Moses and Aaron

The clause I sent Moses and Aaron does not state where Yahweh sent them or what Yahweh sent them to do. In some languages it may be helpful to include some of this implicit information. For example:

I sent Moses and Aaron to help the Israelites

I sent Moses and his brother Aaron to Egypt

24:5b

and I afflicted the Egyptians by what I did there,

- I struck the people of Egypt with the disasters that I caused there.
- I made terrible things happen to the Egyptian people.

and I afflicted the Egyptians by what I did there:

The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as afflicted is more literally “hit.” In this context it refers to the disasters that God caused the Egyptians to suffer. The disasters that God brought upon the Egyptians are recorded in Exodus 7–11.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I struck the people of Egypt with the disasters that I caused there

I made terrible things happen to the Egyptian people

24:5c

and afterward I brought you out.

- After that, I brought you^(plur) out of Egypt.
- Then I led you out of Egypt.

and afterward I brought you out: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After that, I brought you^(plur) out of Egypt

Then I led you all out from Egypt

Joshua 24:6

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:6a

When I brought your fathers out of Egypt

- When I brought your^(plur) ancestors out of the land of Egypt
- After I led your ancestors out from the land of Egypt

When I brought your fathers out of Egypt: The information in this part of the verse is the same as the information in 24:5. The phrase your fathers refers to the ancestors of the Israelites to whom Joshua was speaking. It may be more natural to include the information out of Egypt in verse 5c and leave that information implicit here.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When I brought your forefathers out of Egypt

When I led your ancestors out

24:6b

and you reached the Red Sea,

- you reached the Red Sea.
- then you arrived at the Red Sea.

and you reached the Red Sea: In verses 6 and 7 Joshua sometimes used the term “your fathers” and sometimes used the pronoun you, speaking to the Israelites. In some languages it may not be natural to alternate in this way. In that case, you may choose to refer only to the Israelite ancestors, using the pronoun “they.” For example:

I brought your ancestors out of Egypt, and the Egyptians pursued them with chariots and cavalry. But when your ancestors got to the Red Sea they cried out to me for help, and I put darkness between them and the Egyptians. I made the sea come rolling over the Egyptians and drown them. You know what I did to Egypt. (GNT)

the Red Sea: In the Hebrew this was more literally “the sea.” It may be more natural in your language to identify it here as the Red Sea as the BSB did.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

you arrived at the Red Sea

you came to the sea. (RSV)

24:6c
the Egyptians pursued them with chariots and horsemen as far as the Red Sea.

- The Egyptians pursued your^(plur) ancestors as far as the Red Sea. Their men on chariots and their men on horses pursued you.
- The Egyptian army chased after your ancestors with their horse-drawn war carts and men who rode horses. They chased you up to the Red Sea.

the Egyptians pursued them with chariots and horsemen as far as the Red Sea: The term chariots refers to small horse-drawn carts with two wheels. Soldiers of ancient times rode in these carts to go to war. The term horsemen refers to soldiers who were riding on horses.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Egyptians pursued your ancestors to the Red Sea with men driving in chariots and men riding on horses

The Egyptian army chased after your ancestors with their war carts and horse riders up to the Red Sea.

Joshua 24:7

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:7a
So your fathers cried out to the LORD,

- When they called out to Yahweh to help them
- Your ancestors pleaded with me to help them.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the next event in the storyline. Many English versions do not translate this conjunction here.

your fathers cried out to the LORD: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as cried can also be translated “shouted” or “called out.” It implies that they called to Yahweh to help them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

When they called out to Yahweh to help them

They pleaded with Yahweh to help them

24:7b
and He put darkness between you and the Egyptians,

- he placed a dark cloud between you^(plur) and the Egyptians.
- Then I made the area between them and the Egyptian army become dark.

He put darkness between you and the Egyptians: The darkness refers to the dark cloud that Yahweh placed between the Israelite people and the Egyptian army when the Israelites were camped by the Red Sea. This event is described in Exodus 14:19–20.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

he placed a dark cloud between you^(plur) and the Egyptians

Then Yahweh put an area of darkness between you and the Egyptian soldiers

24:7c
over whom He brought the sea and engulfed them.

- Then he made the sea cover the Egyptians so that they drowned.
- I made the Egyptian soldiers drown in the Red Sea.

over whom He brought the sea and engulfed them: This indicates that Yahweh made the sea roll over the Egyptian soldiers, and they all drowned.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and made the sea cover them so that they drowned

Then he caused the Egyptian army to drown in the Red Sea.

24:7d

Your very eyes saw what I did to the Egyptians. Then you lived in the wilderness for a long time.

- You^(plur) saw what I did to the Egyptians there. Then you lived in the wilderness for a long time.
- You watched what I did to the Egyptians. After that you lived in the wilderness for many years.

Your very eyes saw what I did to the Egyptians:

The sentence **Your very eyes saw what I did to the Egyptians** indicates that the Israelites watched while Yahweh caused the sea to cover the Egyptians. The phrase **Your very eyes** refers to all the Israelites, both those who were young when they crossed the Red Sea with their parents, and the others who were standing there listening to Joshua.

Then you lived in the wilderness for a long time: It may be more natural to include a phrase here such as “after that happened.” For example:

You watched what I did to the Egyptians. After that you lived in the wilderness for many years

General Comment on 24:7

This verse contains an implicit event. Before Yahweh made the Egyptians drown in the Red Sea, he had made the sea stand up like a wall. Then the Israelites were able to walk on a dry path through the sea to the other side. Some English versions add this implicit information so that the sequence of events is clear to the readers. For example:

Your people cried to me for help, so I put a dark cloud between them and the Egyptians. Then I opened up the sea and let your people walk across on dry ground. But when the Egyptians tried to follow, I commanded the sea to swallow them, and they drowned while you watched. (CEV)

Joshua 24:8**Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh**

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:8a

Later, I brought you to the land of the Amorites who lived beyond the Jordan.

- ¶ Then I brought you^(plur) into the land of the Amorites, who lived on the other side of the Jordan River.
- ¶ Then I led you into the land of the Amor people, who lived on the east side of the Jordan River.

Later: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as **Later** introduces the next event in the storyline.

I brought you to the land of the Amorites: The Amorites were mentioned in 3:10. Look to see how you translated it there. The events that Joshua described in this verse are first told in Numbers 21:21–35.

who lived beyond the Jordan: The phrase **beyond the Jordan** refers to the east side of the Jordan River. Joshua and the people are now on the west side.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then I led you^(plur) into the land of the Amorites who lived on the other side of the Jordan River.

24:8b

They fought against you, but I delivered them into your hand,

- They fought against you, but I handed them over to you.
- When they attacked you, I helped you to defeat them.

They fought against you, but I delivered them into your hand: The sentence **I delivered them into your hand** indicates that when the Amorites attacked the Israelites, Yahweh helped the Israelites to defeat them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They fought against you but I handed them over to you.

When they attacked you, I helped you to defeat them.

24:8c

that you should possess their land when I destroyed them before you.

- I destroyed them in front of you^(plur) and you took their land for your own.
- I helped you to destroy them and you occupied their land.

that you should possess their land when I destroyed them before you: It may be more natural to reorder the parts of this sentence so that it follows a chronological order. For example:

I destroyed them in front of you and you took their land for your own.

I helped you to destroy them and you occupied their land.

Joshua 24:9

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:9a

Then Balak son of Zippor, the king of Moab, set out to fight against Israel.

- Then Balak, who was the king of Moab and the son of Zippor, got ready to fight against the Israelites.
- Then King Balak the king of the Moabites prepared to fight against Israel. He was the son of Zippor.

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline.

Balak son of Zippor, the king of Moab: The story of King Balak is told in Numbers 22–24. He was the king of the Moabites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Balak, who was the king of Moab and the son of Zippor, got ready to fight against the Israelites.

King Balak was the son of Zippor and the king of the Moabites. He prepared to fight Israel.

set out to fight against Israel: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as set out indicates preparation for an action. TWOT p. 793. It can also be translated “he got ready to make war.” Woudstra p. 348 fn 13.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

prepared to fight (NIV)

24:9b

He sent for Balaam son of Beor to curse you,

- He sent messengers to tell Balaam the son of Beor to put a curse on you.
- He sent word to Balaam the son of Beor and asked him to put a curse on the Israelites.

He sent for Balaam son of Beor to curse you: King Balak sent messengers to Balaam to ask him to put a curse on Israel.

Balaam son of Beor: Balaam is first mentioned in Numbers 22:5.

curse you: The phrase curse you indicates that Balaam would call on gods to make something terrible happen to the Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He sent messengers to tell Balaam the son of Beor to put a curse on you.

So King Balak sent word to Balaam the son of Beor and asked him to put a curse on you.

Joshua 24:10

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:10a

but I would not listen to Balaam. So he blessed you again and again,

- But I would not permit Balaam to curse you, so instead he blessed you again and again.
- But I was not willing to say yes to Balaam's request to curse you. Instead, he blessed you, and he kept on blessing you many times.

but: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* indicates a contrast between King Balak's action and God's action. Introduce this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

I would not listen to Balaam: The Hebrew sentence that the BSB translates as *I would not listen to Balaam* is more literally "I was not willing to listen to Balaam." When Balaam told God about King Balak's request, God told Balaam not to curse the Israelites.

So: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* is used to join clauses. Use a connecting word that is natural in your language.

he blessed you again and again: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as *he blessed you again and again* is more literally "he blessed to bless you." It indicates that Balaam blessed the Israelites many times. In Numbers 23–24 it says that he blessed the Israelites four times.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But I did not permit Balaam to curse you^(plur), so instead he blessed you again and again.

But I was not willing to say yes to Balaam's request to curse you. Instead he kept blessing you.

24:10b

and I delivered you from his hand.

- In that way I saved you^(plur) from the power of Balaam's curse.
- Thus, I rescued you from Balaam and from King Balak.

and: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* introduces the next event in the storyline. Translate this connecting word in a way that is natural in your language.

I delivered you from his hand: The clause *I delivered you from his hand* indicates that Yahweh rescued the Israelites from the power of Balaam's curse. In that

way Yahweh saved them from King Balak and the Moabites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

In that way I saved you^(plur) from the power of Balaam's curse.

Thus I rescued you from Balaam and from King Balak.

Joshua 24:11**Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh**

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:11a

After this, you crossed the Jordan and came to Jericho.

- Then you^(plur) crossed the Jordan River and arrived at Jericho town,
- When you crossed the Jordan River and came to the town of Jericho,

After this: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as *After this* introduces the next event in the storyline.

you crossed the Jordan and came to Jericho: The sentence *you crossed the Jordan and came to Jericho* indicates that the Israelites crossed the Jordan River. This event is recorded in Joshua chapters 3 and 4. After they had crossed the river they arrived at the town of Jericho.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then you^(plur) crossed the Jordan River and arrived at Jericho

When you crossed the Jordan River and came to the town of Jericho,

24:11b

The people of Jericho fought against you,

- and the leaders of Jericho fought with you.
- the rulers of Jericho fought against you.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline.

The people of Jericho fought against you: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as the people of Jericho is more literally “the lords/owners of Jericho.” It refers to the group of citizens of Jericho who made decisions for the town. Walton p. 83.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the citizens of Jericho (NRSV, NIV, NJPS, NASB, GW)

The rulers of Jericho (CEV)

The leaders of Jericho (NET, ESV)

24:11c

as did the Amorites, Perizzites, Canaanites, Hittites, Girgashites, Hivites, and Jebusites,

- You^(plur) also fought with the Amorites, the Perizzites, the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Girgashites, the Hivites, and the Jebusites.
- These people also fought against you: the Amor people, and the Periz people, and the Canaan people, and the Hitti people, and the Girgash people, and the Hiw people, and the Yabus people.

as did the Amorites, Perizzites, Canaanites, Hittites, Girgashites, Hivites, and Jebusites: The groups of people who are listed here were also listed in 3:10, although the order is not the same. Translate these names the same way in both places.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then the Amor people, the Periz people, the Canaan people, the Heth people, the Hiv people, the Girgash people and the Yabus people also fought against you

24:11d

and I delivered them into your hand.

- I helped you^(plur) to defeat them all.
- I gave you victory over all those people.

and I delivered them into your hand: The clause I delivered them into your hand indicates that Yahweh helped the Israelites to defeat these groups of people.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I helped you to defeat them.

I gave you victory over all these people.

Joshua 24:12

Section 24:1-33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:12a

I sent the hornet ahead of you, and it drove out the two Amorite kings before you,

- I sent terror ahead of you^(plur) and it made the two kings of the Amorites flee ahead of you.
- I caused your enemies to panic as you advanced, and the two kings of the Amor people and their armies all ran away.

I sent the hornet ahead of you: The meaning of the Hebrew word that the BSB translates as hornet is uncertain. There are two ways to interpret it.

1. It means terror or panic. For example:

I sent terror ahead of you (NET)

As you advanced, I threw them into panic. (GNT)
(NET, GNT, REB, CEV, NLT, NJPS, NCV)

1. It means hornet. For example:

I sent the hornet before you (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NASB, NIV, GW, NABRE, NJB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation recommended by most Bible commentaries. See for example Walton p. 83–84, and Dallaire p. 1038. and the one taken by many English versions.

and it drove out the two Amorite kings before you:

The clause drove out the two Amorite kings before you indicates that the enemies of Israel ran away as the Israelites went into their lands. They did this because they were afraid of the Israelites.

the two Amorite kings: There is an interpretation issue here. It is not certain to whom the Hebrew pronoun “them” that the BSB translates as the two Amorite kings refers.

1. It refers to the two kings of the Amorites. For example:

I sent terror ahead of you to drive out before you the two Amorite kings (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, NRSV, ESV, REB, NASB, NCV, NLT, NJPS, NJB, GNT, GW)

1. It refers to the peoples mentioned in verse 11 as well as the Amorite kings. For example:

I made your enemies panic and run away, as I had done with the two Amorite kings east of the River Jordan. (CEV) (CEV, NIV, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by most English versions and Bible commentaries.

The two Amorite kings were King Sihon and King Og, who lived east of the Jordan River. The battle between the Israelites and these kings was mentioned in chapter 24:8.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I sent terror ahead of you^(plur) and it made the two Amor kings flee ahead of you.

I caused your enemies to panic as you advanced, so that the two kings of the Amor people and their armies all ran away.

24:12b

but not by your own sword or bow.

- It was not your^(plur) skill with swords and bows that caused you to defeat them.
- You did not defeat them by the strength of your own swords and bows, but because I helped you.

but not by your own sword or bow: This indicates that Israel did not defeat their enemies with their own weapons or by their own power, but because God helped them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You did not defeat these enemies by the strength of your own swords and bows

It was not your skill with swords and bows that caused you to defeat them. I defeated them for you.

Joshua 24:13

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:13a

So I gave you a land on which you did not toil

- I gave you^(plur) a land where you had not planted the crops. They had already been planted.
- I gave you land where the crops had already been planted.

I gave you a land on which you did not toil: The phrase a land on which you did not toil indicates that God gave the Israelites a land where the crops were already planted.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I gave you^(plur) a land where you had not planted the crops

I gave you land where the crops had already been planted

24:13b
and cities that you did not build, and now you live in them

- I gave you towns that you had not built for yourselves, and now you live in them.
- I gave you towns that had already been built. You are living in them.

and cities that you did not build: The clause cities that you did not build indicates that the Israelites took over the towns that the previous owners had built.

and now you live in them: The clause now you live in them indicates that the Israelites were living in those towns at the time that Joshua was speaking to them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

I gave you towns that you had not built for yourselves, and now you live in them.

I gave you towns that other people had built. You are living in them now.

24:13c
and eat from vineyards and olive groves that you did not plant.’

- You^(plur) are eating grapes from vines that you did not plant and olives from trees that you did not plant.’
- You eat grapes and olives from vines and trees that you did not plant.’

and eat from vineyards and olive groves that you did not plant: The term vineyards refers to a place where grapes grow. The term olive groves refers to a place where olive trees grow.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

You are eating grapes from vines that you did not plant and olives from trees that you did not plant.

Joshua 24:14

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:14a
Now, therefore, fear the LORD and serve Him in sincerity and truth;

- ¶ So now worship Yahweh and obey him completely and sincerely.
- ¶ That is what Yahweh said. Now, I, Joshua, say that you must honor Yahweh and worship him and be true and faithful to him.

Now, therefore: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now, therefore is used to draw a conclusion from the previous paragraphs. BDB p. 774. In those paragraphs Yahweh spoke to the Israelites through Joshua. Now, in the coming paragraphs, Joshua will exhort the Israelites himself to honor Yahweh.

Make it clear in your translation that God finished speaking at the end of verse 13, and that Joshua is speaking in verse 14.

Here are some other ways to translate this Hebrew conjunction:

So now

Therefore

Because of all that Yahweh has done for you (T4T)

fear the LORD: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as fear includes honoring Yahweh and worshipping him.

and serve Him in sincerity and truth: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as in sincerity can also be translated “completely” or “without fault.” The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as truth indicates honesty. Together these two words indicate that the Israelites should worship and obey Yahweh completely, with their whole hearts. They must be totally loyal to him.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So now worship Yahweh and obey him completely and sincerely.

Therefore you^(plur) must honor and worship Yahweh and be true and faithful to him.

24:14b

cast aside the gods your fathers served beyond the Euphrates and in Egypt,

- Remove the gods which your ancestors worshiped while they lived on the east side of the Euphrates River and later in Egypt.
- Throw away the idols which your ancestors used to worship. They worshiped them when they lived on the east side of the Euphrates River and also when they lived in Egypt.

cast aside the gods your fathers served: Joshua said that the Israelites must throw away any images of gods that they still had.

beyond the Euphrates: The phrase beyond the Euphrates refers to the east side of the Euphrates River. In the time of Abraham's parents, the ancestors of the Israelites lived on the east side of the Euphrates River and worshiped other gods. Some of them still worshiped these gods.

and in Egypt: The Israelites worshiped other gods during the time that they lived in Egypt. This is mentioned in Ezekiel 20:7.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Destroy the gods that your ancestors worshiped while they lived on the east side of the Euphrates River, and in Egypt.

Throw away the gods that your ancestors used to worship when they lived on the east side of the Euphrates River, and also in Egypt

24:14c

and serve the LORD.

- Worship Yahweh only.
- Obey Yahweh.

and serve the LORD: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as serve means to worship and obey him.

Joshua 24:15

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would

bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:15a

But if it is unpleasing in your sight to serve the LORD,

- But if you^(plur) do not want to serve Yahweh,
- If it doesn't seem good to you to obey Yahweh,

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast with the previous sentence. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Choose a connecting word that indicates a contrast in your language.

if it is unpleasing in your sight to serve the LORD:

The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as if it is unpleasing in your sight to serve the LORD is more literally "but if it is bad in your eyes to serve Yahweh."

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But if you^(plur) do not want to serve Yahweh

But if it doesn't seem good to you to obey Yahweh

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause as an independent sentence. For example:

But you may not want to worship Yahweh.

24:15b

then choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve,

- then choose for yourselves whom you will serve.
- then choose for yourselves the gods that you want to obey.

then choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve: Joshua indicated that the Israelites had a choice to make about whom they would worship and obey.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then choose for yourselves the gods that you want to worship and obey

24:15c

whether the gods your fathers served beyond the Euphrates,

- Serve the gods whom your ancestors served when they lived in the land beyond the Euphrates River.
- You can worship the gods whom your ancestors worshiped when they lived on the other side of the Euphrates River.

whether the gods your fathers served beyond the Euphrates: This refers to the gods that the ancestors of the Israelites worshiped when they lived in Mesopotamia, on the east side of the Euphrates River. Some English versions make this reference clear. For example:

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Serve the gods whom your ancestors served when they lived in the land beyond the Euphrates River

You can decide to worship the gods whom your ancestors worshiped when they lived on the other side of the Euphrates River.

the gods your ancestors worshiped in Mesopotamia (GNT)

24:15d

or the gods of the Amorites in whose land you are living.

- Or serve the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you are living.
- Or you can worship the gods of the Amor people. You are living in their land.

or the gods of the Amorites in whose land you are living: The term Amorites refers here to all the people who lived in the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

or serve the gods of the Amorites, in whose land you are living

You can decide to worship the gods of the Amor people. You are living in their land.

24:15e

As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD!"

- But I myself and my family, we^(excl) will obey Yahweh."
- But for myself and my household, we will worship Yahweh."

As for me and my house: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as As for me is more literally "but I." The pronoun "I" is emphatic in Hebrew. Joshua contrasted himself with the other Israelites. The BSB shows this emphasis in English with the words As for me. Choose a natural way to show this emphasis in your language.

my house: The term my house refers to Joshua's family and the other people who live with him.

we will serve the LORD: The clause we will serve the LORD indicates that Joshua and everyone in his household would honor and obey Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

But I myself and my family will obey Yahweh

But for myself and my household, we^(excl) will worship Yahweh.

Joshua 24:16

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:16a

The people replied,

- ¶ Then the people said to Joshua,
- ¶ Then all the people answered,

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as "and" introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce

this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

The people replied: The people refers to the Israelites who were gathered with Joshua.

Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

Then the people said to Joshua,

The people replied to him,

24:16b

“Far be it from us to forsake the LORD to serve other gods!

- “We^(excl) will certainly never leave Yahweh and worship other gods.
- “May that never happen! We will never abandon Yahweh. We will never obey other gods.

Far be it from us: The Hebrew phrase that the BSB translates as Far be it from us is more literally “to that which is profane.” This is a Hebrew idiom which indicates an emphatic rejection of something. It indicates that the people would certainly not forsake Yahweh.

Translate this Hebrew idiom with a word or phrase that indicates an emphatic decision to take a certain path.

to forsake the LORD to serve other gods: The Israelites made a strong statement that they would not turn from Yahweh to worship other gods.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We^(excl) will never leave Yahweh and worship other gods.

Absolutely not! We will never abandon Yahweh.
We will never worship other gods.

Joshua 24:17

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:17a

For the LORD our God brought us and our fathers out of the land of Egypt,

- Yahweh our God is the one who brought us and our fathers up from the land of Egypt.
- All these things have come to us because of Yahweh our God. He led us and our parents and grandparents out of the land of Egypt.

For: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates For introduces a reason. Here the people explained the reason why they would be faithful to Yahweh.

the LORD our God brought us and our fathers out of the land of Egypt: The Hebrew construction puts emphasis on the words “Yahweh our God.” This emphasizes the role of Yahweh as the one who saved them.

brought us and our fathers out: The word fathers refers to the parents and grandparents of the people who were standing there with Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Because Yahweh our God is the one who brought us^(incl) and our fathers up from the land of Egypt.

This is because of Yahweh our God. He himself led us and our parents and grandparents out of the land of Egypt.

24:17b

out of the house of slavery, and performed these great signs before our eyes.

- He took us from the place where we were slaves and did great miracles for us to see.
- We were slaves there, but he rescued us and did great things before our eyes.

out of the house of slavery: The term house of slavery is a Hebrew idiom. It refers to the time when the Israelites were slaves in Egypt.

Here are some other ways to translate this idiom:

from that land of slavery (NIV)

from where we were slaves in Egypt

and performed these great signs before our eyes:

This indicates that the people saw the miracles that Yahweh did for them. Most of the people standing there were not yet born when the Israelites left Egypt. But the whole group identified with what God had done by bringing them out of Egypt.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He took us from the place where we^(incl) were slaves and he did great miracles before our eyes.

We were slaves there, but he rescued us and did great things for us to see.

24:17c**He also protected us throughout our journey**

- He watched over us wherever we went.
- On that whole journey he protected us

He also protected us: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as protected can also be translated “he protected us” or “he watched over us.”

throughout our journey: The phrase throughout our journey indicates that Yahweh took care of them all the time they were walking from Egypt to Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He watched over us wherever we went.

He protected us through our whole journey,

24:17d**and among all the nations through which we traveled.**

- He guarded us while we traveled through the lands of other nations.
- from all the nations that we walked through.

and among all the nations through which we traveled: Yahweh protected them as they walked through the territory of other nations.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He guarded us while we traveled through the lands of other nations

through all the nations that we passed through

Joshua 24:18**Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh**

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:18a**And the LORD drove out before us all the nations, including the Amorites who lived in the land.**

- Then Yahweh forced all the people living in this land to leave. Those people were the Amor people.
- Then Yahweh helped us to defeat all the people living in the land. Those were the Amor people.

And: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

the LORD drove out before us all the nations, including the Amorites who lived in the land: There is an interpretation issue concerning the phrase all the nations, including the Amorites

1. It refers to the Amorites. The entire phrase refers to the same group of people. For example:

the Lord drove out all the Amorites who lived here (GNT) (GNT, RSV, ESV, NASB, NJPS, NCV, KJV)

1. It refers to other nations as well as to the Amorites. For example:

And the Lord drove out before us all the nations, including the Amorites, who lived in the land. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, GW, REB, NABRE, NJB, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This is supported by several Bible commentaries as well as many English versions.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Yahweh forced all the Amor people who were living in this land to leave.

Then Yahweh helped us to defeat the Amor people. They were living in this land.

24:18b

We too will serve the LORD, because He is our God!”

- We^(excl) too will honor and obey Yahweh, because he is our God.”
- Yahweh is our God, so along with you, we also will worship him.”

We too will serve the LORD: In verse 15 Joshua said that he and his family would serve Yahweh. Here the Israel people said that they also would serve Yahweh.

because He is our God: The clause He is our God states the reason why the people chose to worship Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

We^(excl) too will honor and obey Yahweh because he is our God.

Yahweh is our God, so we also will worship him with you.

Joshua 24:19

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:19a

But Joshua said to the people,

- ¶ Then Joshua told the people,
- ¶ But Joshua warned them,

But: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as But introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

Joshua said to the people: The term the people refers to the Israelites who were listening to Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua told the people

Joshua warned them

24:19b

“You are not able to serve the LORD,

- “I think that you^(plur) will not be able to serve Yahweh,
- “It is not easy to worship and obey Yahweh,

You are not able to serve the LORD: The Hebrew clause that the BSB translates as You are not able to serve the LORD is more literally “you will not be able to serve Yahweh.” Joshua warned the people to think carefully about what it meant to serve Yahweh. It would not be easy to obey and worship him.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

You^(plur) cannot serve Yahweh

It is not easy to worship and obey Yahweh

24:19c

for He is a holy God; He is a jealous God;

- because he is a holy God. He will not allow you to worship other gods.
- because he is a holy God. He is God, and he wants you to serve him only.

for He is a holy God: The clause He is a holy God states the first reason why it would be difficult to serve Yahweh. He is a completely pure God who is set apart from all others. This is the first time in the book of Joshua that the term holy is used regarding God. Consider the way you translated the word holy when you said “Holy Spirit” in the New Testament.

He is a jealous God: This is the second reason why it would be difficult to serve Yahweh. The clause He is a jealous God indicates that God demands that the Israelites worship only him.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He hates his people worshiping other gods (ERV)

He will not allow you to worship other gods

He is God, and he wants you to serve him only

24:19d

He will not forgive your rebellion or your sins.

- He will not forgive you if you rebel and sin against him.
- He will not forgive you when you turn away from him and do wrong.

He will not forgive your rebellion or your sins: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as rebellion and sins both refer to breaking the commands of God. Some languages may have only one word for this. In that case it may be more natural to translate using one word only. For example:

he...will not forgive your sins (GNT)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He will not forgive you if you rebel and sin against him.

He will not forgive you if you turn away from him and sin.

Joshua 24:20

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:20a

If you forsake the LORD and serve foreign gods,

- If you^(plur) abandon Yahweh and worship gods of other nations

- If you turn away from Yahweh to obey other gods

If you forsake the LORD and serve foreign gods:

These words are similar to the words in verse 24:16. In that verse the phrase “other gods” is used. Here the phrase foreign gods is used. Both these phrases refer to gods other than Yahweh.

You may be able to translate this clause in a similar way in both places.

24:20b

He will turn and bring disaster on you and consume you,

- then he will turn against you. He will harm you, and bring an end to you,
- then he will become your enemy. He will bring disaster on you, and destroy you,

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “then” introduces the consequences of the previous clause.

He will turn: The clause He will turn indicates that Yahweh would turn against the Israelites. He would no longer help them.

bring disaster on you and consume you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as consume can also be translated “bring to an end” or “destroy.” This part of the verse is similar to verse 23:15.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

then he will turn against you and harm you and bring an end to you

then he will become your enemy, and bring disaster on you and destroy you

24:20c

even after He has been good to you.”

- even though previously he treated you well.”
- although he has been good to you in the past.”

even after He has been good to you: Yahweh had previously done many good things for the Israelites. He had helped them.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

although he has been good to you in the past

even though previously he treated you well

Joshua 24:21

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:21

“No!” replied the people. “We will serve the LORD!”

- ¶ Then the people answered Joshua, “No, we^(excl) will not serve other gods. It is Yahweh whom we will serve.”
- ¶ But the people told Joshua, “We will never serve other gods. We will honor and obey only Yahweh.”

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

“No!” replied the people: The people answered “No, we will not serve other gods.” They were accepting Joshua’s advice. They were not rejecting it. You may need to add some words to make the meaning clear.

We will serve the LORD!: The Hebrew words that the BSB translates as We will serve the LORD are more literally “but Yahweh we will serve.” The Hebrew sentence puts the word “Yahweh” at the front to indicate emphasis. Use a natural way in your language to mark this emphasis.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

No, we will not serve other gods. It is Yahweh whom we will worship and obey.

We will never honor other gods . We will honor and obey only Yahweh.

Joshua 24:22

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:22a

Then Joshua told them, “You are witnesses against yourselves that you have chosen to serve the LORD.”

- Then Joshua said to the people, “You^(plur) will give evidence against yourselves that you have chosen to serve Yahweh.”
- Then Joshua answered them, “Do you agree to give evidence against yourselves, and condemn yourselves, if you do not worship and obey Yahweh?”

Then: The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

You are witnesses against yourselves: There is an interpretation issue with the Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as against.

1. It means against. This indicates that the Israelites will be asked in the future to testify whether they have kept their covenant with Yahweh. If they have not kept the covenant, they will have to testify that they are wrong. For example:

Do you agree to be witnesses against yourselves that you have chosen to worship the Lord? (NET) (BSB, NET, RSV, ESV, NIV, NABRE, NASB, REB, NJPS, KJV)

1. It means for or about. This indicates that the Israelites are affirming that they have said that they will serve Yahweh. It does not imply any consequences for the future. For example:

You have testified that you have chosen to serve the Lord. (GW) (GW, GNT, NLT, NCV, NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is followed by many English versions and Bible commentaries.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

You^(plur) will give evidence against yourselves

You are witnesses who may have to condemn yourselves

that you have chosen to serve the LORD: Here are some other ways to translate this:

that you have chosen to serve Yahweh

that you chose to worship and obey Yahweh

24:22b

“We are witnesses!” they said.

- They answered, “Yes, we^(excl) are our own witnesses.”
- They replied, “Yes, we agree to testify against ourselves.”

“We are witnesses!” they said: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They answered, “Yes, we^(excl) agree to be our own witnesses.”

They said, “Yes, we will testify against ourselves.”

Joshua 24:23

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:23a

“Now, therefore,” he said, “get rid of the foreign gods among you

- He said, “Then throw away all the gods that you^(plur) still have,
- Joshua told them, “Destroy any foreign gods that you still have with you.

“Now, therefore,” he said: The Hebrew text does not have the words he said. The BSB had supplied these words to indicate that Joshua was speaking again. In your translation, make it clear that Joshua is speaking.

The Hebrew conjunction that the BSB translates as Now, therefore introduces a conclusion from the previous paragraphs. Because of their commitment, the people must put away their other gods. Introduce this conclusion in a way that is natural in your language.

get rid of the foreign gods among you: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as get rid of was translated as “cast aside” in verse 24:14.

foreign gods: The phrase foreign gods refers to all gods besides Yahweh. They were the gods of other foreign nations.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Joshua told them, “Destroy any foreign god that you have

Then Joshua said, “Throw away all the other gods that you still have

24:23b

and incline your hearts to the LORD, the God of Israel.”

- and turn your hearts to Yahweh, the God of Israel.”
- Dedicate yourselves to serve only Yahweh, the God of all the Israelites.”

and incline your hearts to the LORD, the God of Israel: The clause incline your hearts is an idiom. It means “be completely committed” to Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and turn your hearts to Yahweh, the God of Israel

Commit yourselves to Yahweh, the God of the Israelite nation.

Dedicate yourself to serve only Yahweh, the God of Israel.

Joshua 24:24

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:24a

So the people said to Joshua,

- Then the people answered Joshua,
- The Israelites answered him,

So: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as *So* introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

the people said to Joshua: The phrase the people refers to the Israelite people who were present there with Joshua.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then the people answered Joshua,

The Israelites answered him,

24:24b

“We will serve the LORD our God and obey His voice.”

- “Yes, we^(excl) will serve Yahweh. We will obey only him.”
- “It is Yahweh whom we will serve. When he speaks to us, we will obey him.”

We will serve the LORD our God and obey His voice: Some English versions follow the Hebrew by putting the object at the beginning of each clause. This emphasizes their commitment to the LORD and to obeying his voice. Use a natural way to show this emphasis in your language.

obey His voice: This is a Hebrew idiom. It means that they will obey Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Yes, we^(excl) will serve Yahweh. We will obey only him.

We will worship only Yahweh. We will obey him alone.

It is Yahweh whom we will serve. When he speaks to us, we will obey him.

Joshua 24:25

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:25a

On that day Joshua made a covenant for the people,

- ¶ On that day Joshua made an agreement for the people with Yahweh,
- ¶ That same day Joshua established a treaty between the people and Yahweh.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “so” introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

Joshua made a covenant for the people: The term *covenant* was first mentioned in the book of Joshua in 3:3. It was also used in 23:16. You will probably be able to translate it the same way in all three places.

for the people: The Hebrew preposition that the BSB translates as *for* can also be translated “with.” Joshua did not make an agreement between the people and himself. Instead, he acted as Yahweh’s representative. He established a covenant between the people and Yahweh.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

That day Joshua drew up an agreement for the people (NET)

Joshua helped Israel make an agreement with the Lord that day (CEV)

That day, Joshua established an agreement between the people and Yahweh (T4T)

24:25b

and there at Shechem he established for them a statute and ordinance.

- and he set up laws and commands for them to follow at Shechem town.
- At the town of Shechem he established laws and regulations for them.

and there at Shechem he established for them a statute and ordinance: The words statute and ordinance refer to all the laws that Yahweh specified should be part of the covenant. Some languages may not have two terms that refer to laws. In this case, only one term may be used.

Shechem: The town of Shechem was mentioned in verse 24:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

At Shechem, he set up rules and commands for them to follow

He established laws and regulations for them at the town of Shechem

at Shechem...Joshua made laws for Israel (CEV)

Joshua 24:26

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:26a

Joshua recorded these things in the Book of the Law of God.

- Then Joshua wrote down these words in the book that contained God's laws.
- Then Joshua wrote these things in the book of God's teachings for them.

Joshua recorded these things: The phrase these things refers to the statutes and ordinances that are mentioned in the previous verse.

in the Book of the Law of God: The Book of the Law of God refers to the book, or scroll, in which Joshua wrote down the laws that he received from God for them. Woudstra p. 357–358. The people of that time wrote things on scrolls rather than in books. Some English versions use the word scroll. For example:

Joshua wrote these words in the Law Scroll of God (NET)

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Then Joshua wrote down all these words in the book that contained God's laws.

Then Joshua wrote these things in the book of God's teachings for them.

24:26b

Then he took a large stone and set it up there under the oak that was near the sanctuary of the LORD.

- He took a large stone and set it up under the oak tree near the holy place of Yahweh.
- He set a large stone on its end under the oak tree near the place that was set apart to worship Yahweh.

Then he took a large stone and set it up there under the oak: In many languages it may be more natural to begin a new sentence here. The clause set it up indicates that Joshua stood the large stone up on its end.

He erected a big stone

He stood a big stone on its end

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

oak: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as oak is found only in this verse. It refers to a kind of tree, but scholars do not agree on what kind of tree it was. Some English versions translate this word as “terebinth,” which is a tree in the cashew family.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

oak (BSB, RSV, NET, NASB, NIV, GW, NJPS, GNT, CEV, NCV, NJB, KJV)

terebinth (ESV, NABRE, NLT, REB)

near the sanctuary of the LORD: This sanctuary was a place where Yahweh was worshiped. The tree was probably close to this place.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

He took a large stone and set it up under the oak tree near the holy place of Yahweh.

He set a large stone on its end under the oak tree, near the place that was set apart to worship Yahweh.

Joshua 24:27

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:27a

And Joshua said to all the people,

- ¶ Then Joshua said to all the people,
- ¶ Joshua told all the Israelites,

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the storyline. Intro-

duce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

24:27b

“You see this stone. It will be a witness against us,

- “Look. This stone will be a witness against us^(incl),
- “Look at this stone. If it could speak it would give evidence against us.

You see: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as You see calls attention to the next statement. Some languages may have grammatical markers that fulfill this function.

Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Look

Look at this stone

this stone. It will be a witness against us: In verse 24:22 Joshua told the Israelites that they would be witnesses against themselves in the future. In this verse he told them that the stone he had set up would also be a witness. He said it was a witness against us because he was including himself with the other Israelites.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Look. This stone will be a witness against us^(incl)

Look at this stone. It will give evidence against us.

Look at this stone. If it could speak it would testify against us.

24:27c

for it has heard all the words the LORD has spoken to us,

- because it has heard all the words that Yahweh spoke to us.
- It is as though it has heard all the words that Yahweh has spoken to us.

for it has heard all the words the LORD has spoken to us: Yahweh had spoken to the people of Israel through Joshua, and the stone had been a witness to all the words he said.

This does not mean that the stone had magical powers, or that there were spirits who lived in the stone.

If it sounds strange in your language to have a stone be able to hear, you could use a simile.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

because it has heard all the words that Yahweh spoke to us

It is as though it has heard all the words that Yahweh has spoken to us.

24:27d

and it will be a witness against you if you ever deny your God.”

- It will be a witness against you^(plur) if you are not faithful to your God.”
- So, it could give evidence against you if you betray God.”

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and connects sentences. Many English versions do not translate this word here. Use a connecting word if there is a natural one in your language.

it will be a witness against you: This sentence uses almost the same words as in part b of this verse. Joshua repeated his statement to emphasize it. However, in this part of the verse he used the pronoun you instead of “us.”

if you ever deny your God: The Hebrew verb that the BSB translates as deny can also be translated “betray” or “be unfaithful.”

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

So it will be a witness against you^(plur), if you are not faithful to your God.

It could give evidence against you if you betray God.

Joshua 24:28

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:28

Then Joshua sent the people away, each to his own inheritance.

- Then Joshua told all the people to leave and return to their own property.
- Then Joshua told all the people to go to their homes.

Then: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a natural way in your language.

Joshua sent the people away, each to his own inheritance: The phrase each to his own inheritance indicates that each person returned to the land that Joshua gave him when land was divided among the clans of Israel.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Then Joshua told all the people to leave and return to their own property.

Then Joshua told all the people to go to their homes.

Joshua 24:29

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:29a

Some time later, Joshua son of Nun, the servant of the LORD, died

- ¶ After these events had happened, Joshua the son of Nun, the servant of Yahweh, died
- ¶ Sometime after that, Joshua died. He was the son of Nun, and he was Yahweh’s servant.

Some time later, Joshua son of Nun, the servant of the LORD, died: The phrase Some time later refers to an indefinite period of time. It does not mean that Joshua died right after the ceremony of Shechem.

servant of the LORD: The phrase servant of the LORD is the same title that Moses received. Translate this title in the same way as you did in Joshua 1:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

After these events had happened, Joshua the son of Nun, the servant of Yahweh, died.

Sometime after that, Joshua died. He was the son of Nun and he was Yahweh's servant.

24:29b at the age of 110.

- at the age of one hundred and ten.
- He was one hundred and ten years old when he died.

at the age of 110: Here is another way to translate this part of the verse:

He was one hundred and ten years old when he died.

Joshua 24:30

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:30a

And they buried him in the land of his inheritance, at Timnath-serah

- They buried him on his own land in the town of Timnath-serah,
- The Israelites buried him in the land that he had received, which was the town of Timnath-serah.

And: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the story line.

they buried him in the land of his inheritance: The Israelites buried Joshua in the land that they had given him. The story of how they gave him this land is in Joshua 19:49.

at Timnath-serah: The town of Timnath-serah was southwest of the town of Shechem. It is mentioned in Joshua 19:50.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

They buried him in the land that he had received, which was the town of Timnath-serah.

The Israelites buried him in his own land at the town of Timnath-serah.

24:30b in the hill country of Ephraim, north of Mount Gaash.

- which was north of Gaash Mountain in the hilly region of the clan of Ephraim.
- It was in the mountain region of the clan of Ephraim, north of the mountain of Gaash.

in the hill country of Ephraim, north of Mount Gaash: Mount Gaash is not mentioned anywhere else in the Bible.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It was in the mountain region of the clan of Ephraim, north of the mountain of Gaash.

which was north of Gaash Mountain in the hilly region of the clan of Ephraim

Joshua 24:31

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:31a

Israel had served the LORD throughout the days of Joshua

- The people of Israel served Yahweh during Joshua's lifetime,
- As long as Joshua lived, the people of Israel worshiped Yahweh.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as “and” introduces the next event in the storyline.

Israel served the LORD throughout the days of Joshua: The phrase throughout the days of Joshua indicates all the time that Joshua lived.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Israel served Yahweh during Joshua's lifetime.

As long as Joshua lived, the people of Israel worshiped Yahweh.

24:31b

and of the elders who outlived him

- and during the lifetimes of the elders who lived longer than Joshua did.
- They continued to worship Yahweh during the lifetimes of the leaders who still lived after Joshua had died.

and of the elders who outlived him: The term elders also occurs in Joshua 24:1. You should translate it the same way in both places.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

and during the lifetimes of the elders who lived longer than Joshua did

They continued to worship Yahweh during the lifetimes of the leaders who still lived after Joshua had died.

24:31c

and who had experienced all the works that the LORD had done for Israel.

- Those elders had seen all the mighty acts that Yahweh had done for the people of Israel.
- The leaders had experienced all the things that Yahweh had done to help the Israelites.

and who had experienced all the works that the LORD had done for Israel: The elders had seen how Yahweh helped Israel to leave Egypt and conquer the land of Canaan.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Those elders had seen all the mighty acts that Yahweh had done for the people of Israel.

The leaders had experienced all the things that Yahweh had done to help the Israelites.

Joshua 24:32

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:32a

And the bones of Joseph, which the Israelites had brought up out of Egypt, were buried at Shechem

- The people of Israel had brought Joseph's bones with them when they left Egypt. They buried them at Shechem.
- The Israelites buried Joseph's bones at Shechem town. They had brought the bones with them when they came out of Egypt.

And the bones of Joseph, which the Israelites had brought up out of Egypt, were buried at Shechem:

In Genesis 50:25 Joseph had made the Israelites promise to bring his bones with them when they left Egypt.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The people of Israel had brought Joseph's bones with them when they left Egypt. They buried them at the town of Shechem.

The Israelites buried Joseph's bones at Shechem town. They had brought the bones with them when they came out of Egypt.

24:32b

in the plot of land that Jacob had purchased from the sons of Hamor, Shechem's father, for a hundred pieces of silver.

- Jacob had bought a plot of land there from the sons of Hamor, who was Shechem's father. He had paid one hundred pieces of money for it.
- They buried them in the plot of land that Jacob had bought for one hundred silver pieces from the sons of Hamor, the father of Shechem.

in the plot of land that Jacob had purchased from the sons of Hamor, Shechem's father, for a hundred pieces of silver: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as pieces of silver is found in only two other places in the Old Testament: Genesis 33:19 and Job 42:11. It was an ancient weight, but it is not certain how heavy it was.

Avoid using the word "coins." Coins had not been invented at this time. They used pieces of silver in a wedge shape with a standard weight.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Jacob had bought a plot of land there from the sons of Hamor, who was Shechem's father. Jacob had paid one hundred pieces of silver for it.

They buried them in the plot of land that Jacob had bought for one hundred silver pieces from the sons of Hamor, the father of Shechem.

24:32c

So it became an inheritance for Joseph's descendants.

- That land was in the area that belonged to the descendants of Joseph.
- Joseph's descendants now owned that land.

So it became an inheritance for Joseph's descendants: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

That land was in the area that belonged to the descendants of Joseph.

Joseph's descendants now own that land.

General Comment on verse 24:32

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse so that they are in chronological order. For example:

Many years ago Jacob had bought a piece of land from the sons of Hamor, the father of Shechem for one hundred pieces of silver. When the Israelites left Egypt they carried Joseph's bones with them. Now, years later, they buried his bones in that piece of land that Jacob had bought in Shechem.

Joshua 24:33

Section 24:1–33: Israel renewed their covenant with Yahweh

In this section Joshua called the people of Israel together to affirm that they would worship and obey only Yahweh. He warned them that Yahweh would bring disaster on them if they worshiped other gods. Then Joshua died and was buried.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Renewing the covenant at Shechem

The Israelites promise to worship only Yahweh

24:33a

Eleazar son of Aaron also died,

- Later, Eleazar the priest, the son of Aaron, died.
- Some time after that, Eleazar died. He was the son of Aaron.

The Hebrew word that the BSB leaves untranslated but some English versions translate as "and" introduces the next event in the storyline. Introduce the next event in a way that is natural in your language.

Eleazar son of Aaron also died: Eleazar was a priest. He was last mentioned in Joshua 21:1.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

Later, Eleazar the priest the son of Aaron died.

Some time later, Eleazar died. He was a son of Aaron.

24:33b

and they buried him at Gibeah,

- The Israelites buried him at Gibe-ah, which belonged to his son Phinehas.
- The people of Israel buried Eleazar in the town of Gibe-ah. That town had been given to his son Phinehas

and: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as and introduces the next event in the storyline.

they buried him at Gibeah: The Hebrew word that the BSB translates as Gibeah is the name of a town, and is also a noun meaning “hill.” The English versions do not agree on how to translate it in this context.

1. It is the name of a town. For example:

and they buried him at Gibeah, the town of Phinehas his son (ESV) (BSB, ESV, RSV, NET, NASB, NIV, GNT, NLT, NCV, NJB)

1. It is a noun that means “hill.” For example:

and they buried him on the hill of his son Phinehas (NJPS, NABRE, GW, REB, CEV, KJV)

It is recommended that you choose interpretation (1). This is the interpretation taken by many English versions.

The location of Gibeah is uncertain, except that it was in the hill country of Ephraim. It belonged to Phinehas.

Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

The Israelites buried him at Gibeah, which belonged to his son Phinehas.

The people of Israel buried Eleazar in the town of Gibeah. That town had been given to his son Phinehas.

24:33c

which had been given to his son Phinehas in the hill country of Ephraim.

- It was in the mountain country that belonged to the clan of Ephraim.
- and was in the hilly region of the clan of Ephraim.

which had been given to his son Phinehas in the hill country of Ephraim: Here are some other ways to translate this part of the verse:

It was in the mountain country that belonged to the clan of Ephraim.

And it was in the hilly region of the clan of Ephraim.